Dragon Raja II

The Mourner's Eyes

Jiang Nan

English Translation Working Draft

This working draft contains the prologue and Acts One through Fifteen. The remainder of this volume is in progress.

Translated from the supplied Chinese text. American English. Updated November 4, 2026.

Prologue Darkness in the Torrent of Rain

Act One Birthday Cake Is the Grave of Youth

Act Two None of Our Young Classmates Are Losers

Act Three Reward

Act Four Dance of the Flame Demon Blade

Act Five Dandelion

Act Six Beware of Fire, Thieves, and Your Senior

Act Seven The Feast of Dragons

Act Eight A Sigh on the River Cam

Act Nine The Fall of Midgard

Act Ten The Night Watcher

Act Eleven The Engagement

Act Twelve The Dragonbone Cross

Act Thirteen The Bloodline Covenant

Act Fourteen Crime and Punishment

Act Fifteen The Man Behind the Scenes

Prologue

Darkness in the Torrent of Rain

A Dark Rainy Night

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

Chu Zihang stood at the window in a daze.

Rain rattled against the glass. The playing field was a blur of white.

The afternoon had been bright and sunny, but as the dismissal bell rang, leaden clouds swept in from the southeast and the sky darkened within minutes. Then thunder exploded, and millions upon millions of tons of water fell on the earth as though a reservoir in the sky had opened its gates.

Tire tracks crisscrossed the soccer field, its turf churned to pieces. Private cars were normally forbidden on campus, but in such terrible weather the parents worried about their children getting wet. Several forced the iron gates open, and all the cars swarmed inside. Half an hour ago the field had been as crowded as a market: cars parked every which way, hazard lights flashing a confusion of yellow, everyone leaning on their horns and shouting their children's names. In the downpour, students unable to find their families' cars wandered around like headless flies.

Now everyone had been collected. The classrooms and playing field were empty, and the sky-blue flag of Shilan High School fluttered wildly in the storm.

Like the dispersal of a crowd when the music ends.

He was alone in the classroom, beneath pale lights, while outside was as dark as midnight. On a day like this, people should go home early.

He took out his phone, dialed, switched on the speaker, and set it on the desk, watching it in silence.

After several rings, the call connected. "Zihang, it's raining where you are too, isn't it? Oh, Mom's shopping at Jiuguang Department Store with her friends. It's pouring here, and we can't get a cab. We're having coffee and waiting for the rain to let up. Get yourself a taxi home, or call your dad and ask him to send a car. Be good, Zihang. Mommy sends you a kiss." A crisp kissing sound came through the phone, and she hung up.

Chu Zihang put away his phone. He hadn't said a single word, nor had he planned to. He had called only to let his mother know he was all right, so she wouldn't worry and could keep enjoying herself.

Adults could be foolish sometimes. When a child reached out to comfort one, she thought he was asking for food.

There were no taxis outside. In rain this heavy, drivers didn't want the business and had gone home early. If there were no cars at Jiuguang, it was the same at school, but his mother wouldn't think of that. His grandmother said his mother was an innocent little girl, without a care in the world. Chu Zihang

didn't want to call "Dad" either. "Dad" was a very busy man who wouldn't remember the small matter of sending a car for his stepson on a rainy day. But if reminded, he would certainly send a driver. "Dad" was a fine, responsible, well-mannered man who loved his beautiful wife, a former dancer, and treated her son well for her sake. He often said, "Zihang, if you need anything, just say so. I'm your father, and I'll fulfill my responsibilities to you."

Having a wealthy "Dad" who wanted to fulfill his responsibilities sounded rather good.

But Chu Zihang didn't think he needed it.

The classroom door stood open. Cold wind and fine rain blew in, chilling him to the bone. Chu Zihang pulled his jacket tighter, stuck his hands in his pockets, and resumed staring into space.

"Chu Zihang? Let's go together. The rain won't stop—the forecast says it's a typhoon, and the weather bureau issued a warning!" A girl peeked in. Her long hair fell clean and straight, with a silver Hello Kitty clip at the end. Her delicate face was slightly flushed, and she lowered her eyes, too shy to meet his gaze.

"You don't know me? I'm Liu Miaomiao..." Receiving no answer, her voice grew softer and softer, like a mosquito's hum.

Actually, Chu Zihang did know Liu Miaomiao. A year below him, she was famous at Shilan High. She had passed the tenth-grade piano examination in her second year of middle school and played a solo at every annual celebration. Several boys in his class competed for her attention in secret; he could hardly have avoided knowing who she was.

"I'm on cleaning duty today. I'll leave in a while." Chu Zihang nodded politely.

"Oh... then I'll go first." Liu Miaomiao spoke softly and withdrew her head.

Through the window, Chu Zihang watched her family's driver open an enormous black umbrella over her. She took off her strappy sandals, and the driver crouched to help her into rain boots. Sheltering under the umbrella, she picked her way toward a black BMW whose "angel eye" headlights shone through the rain.

"Hey! Liu Miaomiao! Give me a ride!" a younger boy shouted from under the eaves.

"Walk, Lu Mingfei! My house isn't in the same direction as yours!" Liu Miaomiao didn't turn around.

Actually, Chu Zihang's home wasn't in the same direction as Liu Miaomiao's either. His was in Peacock Residence in the east of the city, hers in California Sunshine in the west, opposite directions altogether. Yet she had offered him a ride.

The younger boy squatted under the eaves and watched the BMW glide silently into the rain. Its taillights flashed, its engine roared, and it was gone. He stood, head drooping to one side, and walked slowly along the eaves. Watching his retreating figure, Chu Zihang suddenly thought he might give him a ride. But the boy ducked his head, wrapped his coat over it, and darted into the rain like a stray dog. He ran so fast that before Chu Zihang could call out, he had splashed away into the distance.

Zigzag lightning flickered in the clouds, and thunder burst overhead. The rain grew heavier. Liu Miaomiao was right: this was no ordinary rain, but a typhoon. Suddenly Chu Zihang very much wanted someone to pick him up. Otherwise he would have to splash through the cold rain like that younger boy. He took out his phone and typed: "It's raining hard. Can you come pick me up?" He read it over silently, made sure the tone was right, and sent it.

For the next several dozen seconds he counted his heartbeats. Thump-thump... thump-thump... thump-thump...

"Sure, sure, no problem! Wait at school. I'll be there in a bit!" The reply came. That person always sounded so cheerful.

Chu Zihang deleted both messages; it would be awkward if "Dad" saw them. He picked up the bucket at his feet and threw all the water onto the blackboard. Water streamed down as he seized an eraser and scrubbed hard.

On his third pass, a low horn sounded outside. He turned. Through the rain, xenon headlights cast two dazzling beams that made him squint.

It was a pure black sedan. In a triangular frame on its hood, two overlapping M's formed a mountain. A Maybach 62.

Maybach was Mercedes-Benz's top marque, apparently several times more expensive than "Dad's" Mercedes S500. Chu Zihang wasn't much interested in cars. The man inside had boasted all this to him.

The wipers swung back and forth like a deranged metronome, clearing layer after layer of rain from the windshield. The middle-aged man inside waved to Chu Zihang, his face blooming with a smile. Chu Zihang couldn't understand why he always looked so happy, as if nothing ever troubled him. Shouldering the Hermès bag "Dad" had bought him in London, Chu Zihang locked the classroom, checked the door, and walked to the edge of the eaves. He hesitated a moment before the downpour. The man hurried out, opened a huge black umbrella, and came to meet him, as attentive as Liu Miaomiao's driver. Chu Zihang didn't look at him. He pushed the umbrella aside, walked through the rain to the car, opened the rear door himself, and climbed in.

His attempt at ingratiation unanswered, the man paused, then climbed back into the driver's seat. He closed the umbrella and passed it to Chu Zihang in the back. "Stick it in the door. There's a hole just for umbrellas."

"I know. You told me." Chu Zihang put it away and turned to the window. "Let's go."

"Your clothes are wet, right? Want me to turn on the rear-seat heating? Once you try it, you'll know—comfortable as hell!" The man began boasting about his car again.

"No need. I'll change at home."

"Oh, okay." The man cleared his throat and spoke to the center console. "Start!"

The screen lit up, a cold blue light flashed across the dashboard, and the savage 5.5-liter turbocharged V12 began its self-check. Not a vibration could be felt inside; even the engine's deep growl was shut out.

"A nine-million-yuan car, no key. Only three voices in the world can start it: mine, my boss's, and guess whose?" The man looked immensely pleased.

"Not interested." Chu Zihang's face was expressionless.

Again the man's warmth met a cold shoulder, but he wasn't discouraged. He shifted and accelerated briskly. The Maybach roared forward, sweeping in a great arc across the field and cutting through the rain like a blade as it drove through Shilan High's gate. The guard stood ramrod straight in his booth, chest and belly thrust out in respect for the luxury car and the wealth it represented.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what there was to respect. On a rainy day like this, all you needed was a car to pick you up and someone who remembered to come. Whether it was a Maybach, a Mercedes S500, or a QQ made no difference.

"Such heavy rain, and your mother didn't think to pick you up."

"Lucky I didn't get the car washed this morning. An eighty-yuan touchless wash would have been money down the drain."

"That guard at your school wouldn't let me drive in. I told him I was picking up my son, and he'd get soaked in rain like this if I couldn't go in. Took no end of arguing. Finally I told him this car cost nine million, and nobody stops me driving into city hall, so why should Shilan High be so damned strict? He backed down right away. Ha ha!"

The man chattered on as he handled the wheel with a flourish.

Chu Zihang hadn't answered him once since getting in. He turned on the radio; the announcer's voice gave him more peace than the man's.

"We now bring you an emergency typhoon warning and traffic update. According to the municipal weather station, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407 this year, made landfall on the city's southeastern coast this afternoon. Heavy rain and force-ten winds are expected. All organizations should take precautions. Due to the intense rainfall, provincial and national highways through the city will close in two hours. Winds are high on the elevated roads and visibility is below thirty meters. Drivers still on the road should take alternative routes."

He looked out. Visibility really was terrible: beyond fifty meters everything dissolved into a white haze. The raindrops were so dense they seemed to smash one another apart in the air, falling as a spray of foam. The sky was black as ink; occasional bolts of lightning struck straight down. Few cars remained, all creeping carefully with headlights on. When two met, their drivers sounded their horns hard, like beasts encountering each other in a forest, baring their teeth and growling a warning.

Traffic slowed to a crawl, one car feeling its way behind another. Horns shrilled ahead like boiling kettles, and countless red brake lights pierced the rain. There seemed to be a jam.

"You want my V12 to crawl like a turtle?" the man muttered. He swung the wheel and forced his way into the emergency lane.

It was a beautiful cut, like a sharp blade slicing through water, severing the stream of traffic behind them. The driver of an Audi braked hard, locked wheels skidding across the road. Without braking, the Audi would have hit the Maybach from behind, and the Audi driver would have been entirely responsible. Repairing the Maybach would cost as much as an Audi. The braking opened a one-second gap in the traffic, and the man squeezed into it.

"Do you know how to fucking drive? Rushing to a funeral?"

The man winked proudly at Chu Zihang, ignoring the Audi driver's shouted curses. The luxury car, more than six meters long, was like an iron catfish in his hands, flicking its tail at just the right moment and swimming freely through traffic. Who knew how many drivers rolled down their windows and cursed after he overtook them? A chorus of sharp horns followed. But there was little they could do: the car overtaking them was an ultraluxury vehicle with sports-car performance, and its driver was clearly skilled.

The man grinned broadly.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what he was so happy about. Would it kill him to follow the traffic slowly? He simply had to show off his car and his tricks. He was a professional driver; of course he should be good at driving.

"Damn it, we're really stuck!" the man swore.

Two cars had scraped each other ahead. Their drivers stood under umbrellas, spitting as they shouted. In weather like this, traffic police couldn't arrive quickly, and each blamed the other. Dozens of cars were blocked. Several drivers got out and told the arguing men to move their vehicles, only for another argument to break out, with pushing and shoving. Everyone else pressed their horns impatiently.

Chu Zihang wanted to cover his ears. What a mess. The whole world was a mess.

"Are they idiots? What's there to argue about over two lousy little cars? Insurance pays anyway," the man grumbled. "I've got things to do after I drop off my son..."

He craned his neck and looked around, his gaze settling on a branch road in the rain. An entrance to the elevated highway, just a step away; its sign was hidden among a willow's wildly thrashing branches. It was odd. The trapped cars should have poured onto an empty road, yet not a soul was there. Something stirred in Chu Zihang, a strange feeling that only they could see the road, or else everyone else knew it was impassable. His biology teacher had said animals had an instinct for finding their way: wild camels in the desert knew which paths were wrong and had no springs, and wouldn't take them even if driven.

"That road should lead up to the elevated highway, though it's probably closed now," the man said, even as he pointed the car straight toward it.

Closer up, the sign read "Elevated Highway Entrance..." followed by its number. Chu Zihang looked, but a sheet of rain burst against the windshield at that moment, and he couldn't make it out.

The Maybach climbed the ramp. The elevated road stretched ahead like a gray rainbow, disappearing into the white rain.

"What if it really is closed and we can't get down?" Chu Zihang asked.

"If we can get up, we can get down." The man wasn't worried. "At worst I'll offer the cop at the exit a cigarette."

"The radio said the wind's strong and visibility's poor up here. It told drivers to take another route." Chu Zihang was uneasy. He didn't know how fast the wind outside was blowing, but it shrieked like a whistle.

"It's fine." The man patted the wheel. "What's a little wind? Tiny cars have to worry about that. Know how much a Maybach 62 weighs? Two point seven tons! Even a force-twelve wind can't budge it! Your dad's driving and this car together are rock solid. Relax!"

The Maybach sped along the empty elevated road, throwing up sprays of water as tall as a person. The man turned on the stereo without asking and played "Daily Growing" by the Irish band Altan:

The trees they grow high, the leaves they do grow green,

Many is the time my true love I've seen,

Many an hour I have watched him all alone,

He's young but he's daily growing.

Father, dear father, you've done me great wrong,

You have married me to a boy who is too young,

I am twice twelve and he is but fourteen,

He's young but he's daily growing.

"Good, isn't it? Everyone said it was a great disc, so I bought it. It's about a father's love!" the man said.

Chu Zihang didn't know whether to laugh or cry. "Can't you hear? It's a conversation between a girl and her father, not a boy. It's not appropriate for me."

"Boy or girl, what's the difference? It's a father's love either way." The man waved it off. "You understand it? I hear your English is top-notch at school, that you won a competition... But your mother never told me. What's the song about?"

"A father marries his twenty-four-year-old daughter to a rich fourteen-year-old boy. She doesn't want to; she worries she'll be old by the time her husband grows up. But her father says his arrangement is right. He's married her to a wealthy young man, so she'll have someone to rely on when he's old," Chu Zihang said. "Later the boy dies before he grows up. The girl grieves terribly and weaves him a flannel shroud in a green graveyard."

"What the hell kind of song is that? No fun at all. The girl's husband dies before he even does anything?" The man really was not a sensitive creature. Chu Zihang had known since childhood that his biological father was as rough as they came.

"Let's just have a chat, father and son." The man turned off the stereo. "Did I tell you about our company's new building? The boss put in a steam room and gym, free for us to use. Everything in there is so damn fancy..."

The man had failed in life because he talked too much... yet if he hadn't talked so much, he might have failed even worse, Chu Zihang thought.

His gift of gab was how he had charmed Mom until she married beneath her. Everyone at Shilan High agreed Chu Zihang was handsome enough to live off his looks, thanks to his mother's genes. In her youth she had been the star of the city dance troupe, dancing Silk Road Flower Rain like a flying apsara from a mural, with suitors as numerous as fish crossing a river. Somehow this man had fought his way through the field. Every day he drove to the troupe's gate to pick her up after work, using nothing but his mouth to weave a beautiful future and charm her senseless. On a drive to Hangzhou she had absentmindedly agreed to marry beneath her, and on that same trip had conceived Chu Zihang. Only after pressing her fingerprints onto the marriage certificate did she learn the car wasn't his: he was a driver for his work unit.

His politics teacher was right: the economic base determines the superstructure. A man like that couldn't support the superstructure of a beautiful wife. His mother had always been absentminded and wasn't greedy; the man was simply too hopeless.

And so, snap, it fell apart.

At the divorce, the man thumped his chest and promised his former wife he would earn money every month to support her and their son, show her he could make something of himself, and come back to propose once he had succeeded. Full of grand ambition, he promptly quit his stable job at the state enterprise to find more profitable work. After hanging around the labor market for three or four

months without a single offer, he finally realized all he knew was driving. Shamefaced, he found a driving job at a private company. The boss of the Black Prince Group liked his gift of gab and put him behind the wheel of the Maybach. A driver needed to talk smoothly, so the boss could leave him to boast about things the boss couldn't conveniently boast about himself.

The car was better than before, but his pay had hardly changed. After his own expenses, he couldn't even support a cat.

Fortunately, Chu Zihang's beautiful mother finally did something for herself. She had no intention of waiting for him. After several tearful days, she left Chu Zihang at his grandmother's, bought new cosmetics, put on alluring makeup, and went barhopping with her friends. In less than a month, she brought Chu Zihang a new dad. Having learned from experience, she chose carefully this time: a man one in a thousand. "Dad" owned three companies, was divorced once, and had no children. When he proposed, he swore he would never have children of his own and would raise Chu Zihang as his son.

With a rich dad and beautiful mom, talented and capable himself, Chu Zihang seemed exceptionally fortunate to his classmates. They had no idea his private life was far more exceptional than they imagined. But he couldn't take credit for it; his biological parents were the exceptional ones.

"Want to watch a DVD? I've got Shrek 2, though it's a bootleg filmed in a theater." The man stopped chattering, perhaps embarrassed at getting no response.

"No." Chu Zihang hesitated. "The three of us are going to see it this weekend."

The three meant Chu Zihang and his rich dad and beautiful mom. The man had nothing to do with it.

That was "Dad's" rule. Busy with work, "Dad" gave his clients every meal from breakfast to late-night snacks. But after one divorce, he had recognized the importance of family, so he permanently marked one weekend day on his schedule for them. Their usual activities were shopping, a movie, and a lavish dinner, followed by a discussion of Chu Zihang's studies. "Dad" followed his schedule strictly: never one day less or one day more of family time, just as he appeared in the company's main conference room at nine every Monday, rain or shine, for the weekly meeting with senior executives.

How did a stepson with a face that rarely smiled deserve the same treatment as executives earning a million a year? It was all thanks to Mom.

"Is the air warm enough in back?" the man asked again.

"Enough. Stop talking like a chauffeur!" Chu Zihang was irritated.

You're my father! Do you understand? he wanted to ask the man. Do you?

Under the visitation agreement you only get one day a month, and even then you're often too busy. Even when you come, what can you say to me while you sit in someone else's house? Actually, of course, you can talk plenty: you sit on the horsehair sofa "Dad" bought for 170,000 yuan and praise how fancy it is! Why did I ask you to pick me up? Because no one else would? Because if you picked me up, we could talk! If you can't say anything profound, just ask plainly, casually, how I've been, whether I'm happy... Don't hold an umbrella over me, so attentive. I don't care about that. Do you want to kneel and change my rain boots like Liu Miaomiao's driver? I don't need a chauffeur. We already have one at home... You're my father. Do you understand?

"What's shameful about being my son's chauffeur?" The man shrugged. His skin was as thick as a city wall, or his nerves slower than a turtle's. "When you were little, you rode me like a horse."

Something in Chu Zihang's heart twitched, as though it had cracked and released bitter water. He was tired and didn't want to speak. He leaned back against the leather seat and stared out the window.

He always said things that hurt so calmly... Couldn't he stop bringing them up?

Many years ago... in that shabby little room of barely a dozen square meters, the man crawled around while a boy rode on his shoulders shouting "Giddyap!" and a beautiful woman fussed over the gas stove... The images flickered in his mind like a film played by a battered hand-cranked projector.

The sky slowly darkened and the streetlights came on. Through the layers of rain, their light was as faint as fireflies.

"How's your mother lately?" the man asked, breaking the silence.

"Same as before. She gets up in the morning and plays with the cat, shops in the afternoon, and goes drinking with her friends at night. When they're having fun they come back together and talk until late, then sleep until noon. Anyway..." Chu Zihang hesitated. "Dad is always out entertaining clients and has no time for her. He thinks it's good that she amuses herself."

The words were a little hurtful. A down-on-his-luck man asked after the woman he had once loved, and she was happy, having forgotten him altogether.

Grandma said Mom had been a carefree girl since childhood, but being carefree and beautiful meant she could live well. Mom had long since put her unhappiness behind her. She regarded "Dad" as her first husband: married happily in their youth, with an outstanding son like Chu Zihang. In Chinese, perfect; in English, perfect.

People had to accept reality. The man's image had been erased from the limited memory in Mom's head.

Calling another man "Dad" in front of him was not easy for Chu Zihang either. A moment ago he had tactfully said "the three of us." But once the word was out, it wasn't so awkward. He had promised "Dad" to call him Dad, not Uncle, Four-Eyes, or Side Parting... even though in Chu Zihang's mind "Dad" was a four-eyed fellow with a side part, or a side-parted fellow with glasses. But Chu Zihang was stubborn about keeping promises, whether people were watching or not.

After all these years, surely the man was used to it. He hadn't tried hard to win custody of his son back then, anyway.

"Take good care of your mother," the man said.

In the rearview mirror, his still handsome but somewhat aging face showed little expression.

"Mm. Like you said, I make sure she drinks milk before bed. If she's talking with her friends, I warm it and bring it to her."

It was the only thing the man had asked Chu Zihang to do. Strange: he had lost the woman, yet still remembered a cup of milk. Since childhood Mom had needed a glass of warm milk with half a spoonful of sugar every night, so she wouldn't wake repeatedly. By now she had probably forgotten that years ago the man had warmed it for her. Before him, Grandma had done it; after him, her son did.

A fortunate woman always had someone to warm her milk.

"Shilan High is damn impressive! Seventeen students got into Tsinghua and Peking University this year. Work hard, son! Don't disgrace me!" The man made a show of concern for Chu Zihang's studies.

"Dad says I'm not taking the domestic entrance exam. I'm going abroad for college. I'm taking the TOEFL next month," Chu Zihang replied coldly.

Disgrace him? When had he ever really cared? He only ever talked.

Last year a coproduced movie had filmed locally, and Chu Zihang had been chosen as an extra. Hearing about it, the man had sworn he would visit the set.

"My son's making a movie! I'll bring tea and water. If I drive this car there, I'll look spectacular, won't I?" He patted the wheel, beaming.

So during breaks Chu Zihang kept looking, consciously or not, toward the parking lot. The spectacular Maybach never appeared. But "Dad's" Mercedes S500 was always there, with the driver, Old Shun, wearing huge dark glasses and a neck thicker than a man's head, looking every bit a bodyguard. He called Chu Zihang "young master" in front of everyone and behind their backs, making people stare.

And then there was that disastrous middle-school entrance ceremony. It fell on "Dad" and Mom's wedding anniversary, when they were going on vacation to northern Europe. After much thought, Chu Zihang called the man and asked him to come. The man was happy but hesitant: what about your mother and stepfather? After a long silence Chu Zihang said, just say you're my uncle. The man didn't feel slighted at all. He chuckled and said, then remember to call me Uncle; don't let it slip... In the end Chu Zihang was the only student with no parent standing behind him at the ceremony. He stood in the most prominent place, first in line, as the principal awarded him the new-student scholarship. He ranked first among Shilan's incoming class and had wanted to surprise the man.

"Oh, I really didn't forget, but that day the boss suddenly said an important client was coming and wanted a bath, so I had to drive them there. Who knew they'd bathe until the next morning..." Later the man scratched his head and mumbled his explanation.

Chu Zihang had a vague idea what sort of person the man's "boss" was, and what sort of place he meant by "a bath."

A classmate had told Chu Zihang, "I saw your Maybach parked outside a bathhouse last time," then lowered his voice. "Isn't that a place where people do bad things?"

Obviously. At the entrance, decorated like a Roman palace, seven or eight heavily made-up hostesses wore skirts almost short enough to reach their waists and necklines nearly low enough to fall below their breasts. Men of every kind climbed out of luxury cars and marched in, bellies thrust forward. Chu Zihang had passed once and glanced from a distance, imagining the man's boss and clients reveling inside at night while the man leaned against his beloved Maybach, smoking, the smoke spreading into the dark.

Chu Zihang didn't blame him much. The man was simply who he was and lived the life he lived, very far removed from Chu Zihang's.

"Going abroad isn't good," the man mumbled. "It's not fashionable anymore. China's developing so fast; opportunities are everywhere. If you ask me, go to college here, study finance, and have your stepdad use his connections to find you a job..."

It was as though a needle pierced Chu Zihang's chest. He shuddered with pain. "Have your stepdad use his connections"... Couldn't a person have some dignity? Did he have to be so shameless?

"Shut up!" Chu Zihang growled.

"What?" The man hadn't heard clearly.

"Shut up." Chu Zihang was like a young lion with its fur on end.

"What a rude child. I'm doing this for your own good." The man stared. "You should listen to adults..."

"Is listening to you any use? If I listen to you, will I find a girl and marry her without getting divorced? Will I make it to my son's graduation on time? Will I pick him up and drop him off at school on time? If I listen to you, all I'll do is ask my stepfather to use his connections!" Chu Zihang stared into the man's eyes in the rearview mirror, hoping to see disappointment or anger.

Every word struck at the heart.

Many people thought Chu Zihang couldn't even swear, much less speak with cutting bitterness. Even when fouled on the basketball court he never lost his temper, only raised a hand for the referee. But who couldn't say cruel things, when anger lay buried like needles in the heart? Now he was furious and wanted to stab the man hard with those needles. The words came out without thought.

"You're still young. Family matters... you'll understand when you're older." The man was clearly at a loss. He reached out as if to pat Chu Zihang in the back seat, but didn't dare; he drew his hand back and scratched his head.

It was always the same answer: "You'll understand later," "You're too young," "It's not what you think." Bullshit! When those two fools divorced, Chu Zihang had been small. He had cried as though the world were ending, and the man comforted him with "It's not what you think," "Mom and Dad just won't live together," "I'll still take you out on Sundays." Chu Zihang believed him; he believed home was still the three of them. Then he followed Mom into their new house and saw a gentleman with side-parted hair, a bathrobe, and two hairy legs politely open the door. Not knowing who this stranger was, Chu Zihang was so shocked that he shoved his ice cream into the man's face.

All these years later, the little kid had grown up, and they were still lying? To hell with that!

"Enough! Just drive, and stay out of my business! When we get home, don't come in. 'Dad' might be unhappy!" Chu Zihang clenched his teeth and turned away.

"What kind of thing is that to say? I'm your real father. If he's unhappy, let him be unhappy. Who the hell is he..." At last the man sounded wounded in his pride.

"He isn't my real father, but he comes to parent-teacher meetings. He takes me to amusement parks on weekends. He knows my final grades. At least he buys me a schoolbag for my birthday!" Chu Zihang slammed the Hermès bag against the seat. "Do you even remember my birthday?"

"Of course I remember!" the man protested, red-faced. "You're my son. Your mom and I made you together... As soon as we heard she was pregnant, we counted the days, when you were conceived and when you were due, waiting eagerly. You little rascal wouldn't come out; you stayed two months extra! How could I forget? Haven't you had health class? Men deserve credit for making babies too. Aren't you smart because I made you well?"

Chu Zihang was so angry he nearly laughed. How could any man be so shameless?

"Was it hard? Marrying a beautiful woman and having her give birth... was that such an achievement?" His voice shook. "I've had health class! The woman carries the baby for ten difficult months. What does the man do? What was hard for you?"

The man wilted, his voice sinking. "I'm not discussing health class with my son..."

"Was it hard after I was born? Did you ever look after me? Why exactly are you my 'real father'? Just because you and Mom 'made me together'? As though you manufactured some product? Tell me what 'real father' actually means." Chu Zihang's mood was as bad as it could get, and the anger he had suppressed flared again.

"A real father means... you... carry my blood." The man chose his words carefully. "You're my legacy in this world, don't you understand? You're half of me... I know I haven't looked after you much these years, and I'm sorry, but what father doesn't care about his child? Our blood connects us, we..."

"Live and prosper together, too!" Chu Zihang sneered.

The man fell silent, and so did Chu Zihang. Only thousands upon thousands of raindrops drummed heavily on the roof. The air inside seemed to grow much colder all at once, beyond the reach of the heater.

After a long time the man sighed slowly, sounding like he was repeating an old saying. "That's why I say you're young. You don't understand. When you have a child of your own, you'll see. Having a child is like giving half of yourself to that child. It's as if you can sense where he is, like telepathy. You'll always care about him and think about him. It comes naturally, for no reason at all. Besides, everyone dies. When I die, everyone else will forget me, but you'll still be in this world, and half of you is me. It's as though I've left something behind."

"You only know how to make a child, not raise one. If someone else raises him, he'll grow less and less like you!"

"I... I wanted to raise you too," the man said haltingly.

A low laugh came from the stereo. Chu Zihang started, unsure whether it was static or the CD player accidentally turning on. The laughter was deep, immense and solemn, as though echoing inside an ancient bronze bell. He had been watching the man's face in the rearview mirror. Suddenly it changed: blue veins sprang up at the corners of his eyes like restless little snakes. His usually slack face tightened, like red-hot iron quenched in ice water.

Chu Zihang had never seen that expression on him. He was a different person altogether, his abruptly narrowed pupils betraying immense terror.

Someone tapped softly on the car door.

"In rain this heavy, who's outside?" Chu Zihang turned and saw a black shadow cast on the window. Had the elevated road been closed, and traffic police come to check? He reached to lower the window.

"Sit back!" the man barked.

A vast terror suddenly engulfed Chu Zihang. He glanced at the speedometer: 120 kilometers an hour. Who could run after the Maybach on the elevated road and reach out to knock at the same time?

The knocking grew urgent. There was not one figure but three, five, more and more gathering outside, staring down at Chu Zihang through the rain-streaked windows. A dazzling mercury-colored light shone from outside, turning both their faces deathly pale. The man turned to Chu Zihang and struggled to keep his voice from shaking. "Don't be afraid... son!"

The knocking became the piercing scrape of sharp things across steel and glass. Chu Zihang thought they must be the shadows' nails.

"Where are we?" he screamed.

The man reached back, seized his wrist, hauled him bodily from the back seat, and threw him into the passenger seat.

"Buckle up!" he said quietly. All fear had vanished from his face, which was hard as cast iron.

He floored the accelerator. The Maybach shuddered and surged forward. Within seconds it reached 180 kilometers an hour and continued accelerating, because they had failed to shake the shadows. Mercury-colored light came from every direction, revealing countless dark figures surrounding the car... standing silently... like a crowd of death gods around a dying person's bed. They opened their eyes together, golden pupils blazing like torches. Chu Zihang curled up, clutching his head in pain.

Pain tore through the depths of his brain. Tangled blue-violet lines twisted like countless snakes, like hieroglyphs on an ancient tablet come alive and dancing like spirits. Images he would never have dared imagine in his worst nightmares flashed before him: a young man with a golden eye split open in his forehead lay on a black stone throne, a long bone sword in his chest; girls writhed on a carved stone altar, screaming in pain as if labor were beginning; black wings rose against the sunset, blotting out half the sky; a woman bound to a bronze pillar slowly opened her eyes, white hair flying as two streams of foul blood ran down her face...

It was like watching snakes dance in the primeval darkness, telling him a lost history in a strange language.

"It's spirit vision. Your bloodline is being awakened. Such a strong reaction—I don't know whether it's your luck... or your misfortune." The man gripped Chu Zihang's hand. "I always hoped this day... would come later."

After an unknown time, Chu Zihang slowly lifted his head, as if waking from a nightmare as long as a lifetime. The feeling was hard to describe: like a nearsighted man putting on glasses after years without them, the world suddenly became extraordinarily clear. Sight, hearing, even smell awoke. He looked blankly at the man, who gently stroked his head, in a gesture that might have been care or sorrow.

"What's happening? Are we going to die?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Son, welcome to"—the man drew a deep breath—"the real world."

"The real... world?"

"Don't tell anyone what you just saw, or whatever you see next. No one will believe you; they'll think you're crazy," the man said. "I think living in an unreal world is happier, so I always wanted you to learn all this later. I kept trying to stay away from you so I wouldn't drag you into it. But when I got your text today... I couldn't stop myself from picking you up... Well, it's no big deal. If a father wants to make an impression on his son, he has to act like a man. I never had the chance before." He licked his lips. "Are these guys giving me a stage to show off? Not bad!"

Chu Zihang didn't understand. He thought the man must have been scared out of his wits. Why was he talking nonsense?

The Maybach had reached its top speed, 275 kilometers an hour, the tachometer needle jumping into the dangerous red zone. The man floored the accelerator, gripped the wheel, and stared ahead. There was only mercury-colored light; nothing was visible, as though they were racing toward a silver

sea. Pale handprints without palm lines struck the windshield with loud bangs. Shadows pounded the windows on every side, hard enough to break blast-resistant glass.

The man pulled the black umbrella from the door.

Was he going to get out and talk to the shadows with an umbrella at a time like this? Chu Zihang stared, then saw clearly: it wasn't an umbrella but a sword, a slender Japanese blade in a black sheath, with no guard. It was a devotional sword. Chu Zihang had read a book called Knowledge of Japanese Swords: in Japan, swordsmiths omitted the guard only on two kinds of sword, those carried by poor ronin and ceremonial swords dedicated to the gods. Sacred swords were never used for cutting, so a guard was unnecessary. The sword's elegant, antique-style sharkskin sheath showed it was a decorative craft object.

The blade slipped from the sheath, its gleam clear as water.

Chu Zihang was dumbfounded. What was happening? Wasn't the man a driver, a loser who should be carefully ferrying his boss around? Yet now he held the sword, eager to act, radiating an edge sharp as a spear... with a decorative sword?

"Sacred sword Murasame, the cursed blade destined to kill the Tokugawa family. Heard of it?" The man laid it across the steering wheel. "The original was destroyed long ago. They recast it in regenerated metal and enshrined it at Gion Shrine for ten years."

Veins bulged on the man's wrist. Reversing his grip, he thrust straight into the left door. The long blade pierced the cast-aluminum door and lodged there, half its length exposed outside. He slammed on the brakes. The speedometer plunged, the wheels skidding on the verge of losing control. Foul blood trailed a black ribbon a dozen meters long in the wind, then the rain washed it away. The shadows couldn't slow in time; those on the left were cut through by the exposed blade before they could even cry out. Simple, pure killing, as though they had struck its sharp edge at 250 kilometers an hour. Black blood splashed across every window on the left and even seeped through the cracks. Chu Zihang held his head and trembled uncontrollably.

Sacred sword Murasame—was it a decorative replica? It had been forged to kill! Its tough blade could cut through the bones of more than a dozen people without breaking. This way of killing... this man, and the whole world... had they all gone mad?

The man immediately floored the accelerator. Tires shrieked against the road: wheelspin, the power exceeding their grip. Even through the air filter came the smell of burning rubber. He jerked the wheel and the Maybach spun out, its heavy 2.7-ton body sweeping the shadows away and into the roadside barrier, which cracked under the impacts.

Black blood coated all the windows, only to be washed away by the rain.

It was hell.

As the car spun violently, the man pressed a warm palm to Chu Zihang's head. Chu Zihang suddenly remembered childhood, when the man, the woman, and he were still a family, and the man took him to ride a carousel, holding his head just as gently.

The car stopped, facing the opposite direction. The man floored it again, and the Maybach charged back the way they had come like an enraged stallion. A chilling sound came from under the wheels, like bones being crushed... The car kept shuddering as one shadow after another flew away. The man held the accelerator down, his face expressionless. In his hands the car had become a killing machine.

Chu Zihang couldn't believe such a useless man had suddenly become a demon who killed without blinking.

"Don't be afraid. Things like Deadpool... don't have civil rights," the man said hoarsely. "They aren't human, so the law doesn't protect them!"

One shadow wasn't thrown aside. Taller than the others, he was built like a giant. He braced both hands against the hood and was driven rapidly backward by the Maybach, his feet scraping shrilly against the road. In the rain his golden eyes seemed to burn. The scene belonged in a Superman or Spider-Man movie. For an ordinary person, such enormous friction would dislocate joints and break leg bones.

"Die!" the man growled. The Maybach drove the shadow into the barrier. He shifted into reverse, then forward, accelerated, and struck again, then a third and fourth time, until the barrier broke. Only then did the gold in the shadow's eyes dim like a lamp out of oil. Even so, he made no sound.

The man turned the car and accelerated away. Trembling, Chu Zihang looked through the rear window. The fallen shadows slowly rose, their golden eyes flickering as they silently watched the car recede.

"Those... who are they? Call... call 110!" Chu Zihang looked fearfully at the man.

"No use. Your phone probably has no signal," the man said softly.

"As for who they are... that would take some explaining," he added after a moment.

"Don't be afraid, son. A dad for one day is a dad for life. Your dad's still your dad, not a monster." One glance at Chu Zihang told him what the terror in his son's eyes meant.

"Don't worry, don't worry. Your dad is actually very capable. I just don't look the part..."

Apparently he was still the same man; at least he was just as talkative. But Chu Zihang could see he was far from relaxed. Sweat covered his face, his hands trembled slightly on the wheel, and he hunched like a shrimp, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Sure enough, the phone had no signal. Chu Zihang turned on the radio; only static came through. GPS couldn't find a satellite signal either. Everything was beyond his understanding. How could so many strange people be on an elevated highway? It was covered in surveillance cameras, yet no road police came after such a serious accident. They seemed to have entered a space cut off from the world, containing only the elevated road, the storm, the shadows, and the Maybach.

"To put it simply, your bloodline is a little different from other people's." After a long silence, the man offered this rather unconvincing explanation.

"Don't look like it's the end of the world. A different bloodline is nothing to be ashamed of. Mine's different too. If you hadn't inherited it from me, you'd be perfectly normal."

He scratched his head. "Forget it. Let's not talk about it now. I'll explain properly when there's time... Actually, going abroad isn't bad. But remember, don't apply to a college called Cassell. It's full of lunatics."

"Say, will your stepdad leave you his fortune? Keep an eye on him. Don't let him take a mistress... or there'll be someone competing with you for the inheritance," the man said seriously.

"Have you seen Indiana Jones? The professor and his son are great! My lifelong dream is just like that: Dad driving in front, son behind him firing a machine gun!"

What went on inside this man's head? Even now he could chatter and grow animated.

They raced on for more than ten minutes. At their speed they had covered over forty kilometers. The shadows hadn't caught up, and the mercury light had vanished. Chu Zihang's pounding heart slowly returned to normal. Surely nothing in the world could run as fast as a Maybach at top speed. They should have left the shadows forty kilometers behind.

"Where are we going now?" he asked.

"I don't know. They're still here... they haven't gone... because the rain hasn't stopped. We have to find the exit." The man kept the accelerator floored. Chu Zihang could see he was no less tense.

The rain hadn't stopped? What did that mean? What did rain have to do with the shadows? His head was splitting.

A speed-reduction sign flashed past, announcing a toll station one kilometer ahead. Bright white lights emerged from the darkness. The man let out a long breath of relief.

"We should be back in a normal area. Get out after the toll station and see if a passing car can take you home. Your dad can give them some money." The man took out several banknotes for the toll, then pulled the sword from the car door.

"Where are you going?" Chu Zihang asked.

"They'll follow me. Don't worry, your dad really is capable, and this car—a nine-million-yuan Maybach—is no joke. I can outrun them."

At a time like this, he was still boasting about his car? Chu Zihang looked at him speechlessly.

"I was joking. Don't take it seriously." The man smiled. "But I really will be fine. I still have to attend your parent-teacher meetings. Don't worry... son."

The Maybach didn't slow. The toll station drew closer, its brilliant white light warm as an inn's lamp seen beneath the eaves by a traveler lost in night fog, making him quicken his steps, knowing he could lay down his worries once he arrived. Both Chu Zihang and the man gazed eagerly ahead.

The car abruptly slowed, brake pads squealing.

"No... something's wrong!" the man said hoarsely.

Chu Zihang sensed it too. The light ahead conveyed not only warmth but solemnity and grandeur, like... pilgrims approaching a temple.

Yes! That longing to draw near wasn't like seeing a lighthouse at sea. It was the reverent desire to worship a god, to approach the radiance of divinity.

But Chu Zihang believed in no god, none at all... until he saw that light.

They had stopped, but the light came toward them, threads of white radiating through darkness and rain.

Chu Zihang heard a horse neigh. He thought it must be an illusion. It sounded very much like a horse, but if it really was, what an immense creature it must be! Its deep roar was like thunder held in its mouth, lightning shooting from its nostrils.

"Listen to your dad. Don't get too far away from me, but don't get too close either." The man looked at him. "Like when I took you to fly a kite."

A kite never strays far from the person flying it, because a string connects them. When it does fly away, the string has broken.

Chu Zihang nodded.

"Buckle your seat belt!" The man pressed the accelerator with all his strength.

The Maybach surged forward at maximum acceleration, charging straight into the white light. The mist parted, and Chu Zihang suddenly saw what stood in the radiance...

His worldview collapsed. Everything he had believed was shattered. The world was nothing like he had imagined!

In the white light stood a horse as mighty as a mountain, draped in heavy armor inlaid with metal patterns, its white coat glowing like crystal. Eight powerful legs resembled the outriggers that steady a wheeled crane. Dark-gold horseshoes tore one wound after another in the hard road. A mask covered its face, and after each thunderous neigh, sparks of lightning sprayed from its metal nostrils.

A huge black figure sat astride it, encased in heavy dark-gold armor that glimmered under the rain. He carried a curved spear, its shaft arcing like a meteor across the sky. Behind his iron mask, a single golden eye lit the surroundings like a great lamp.

Odin, chief god of the Norse Aesir!

Chu Zihang had read his story in a book. Now he had come, just as in legend: riding the eight-legged Sleipnir, carrying Gungnir, a spear made from a branch of the World Tree, clad in dark-gold armor and a dark-blue cloak, one-eyed!

He should have existed only in words and murals!

The Maybach crashed into him. Sleipnir screamed, four front hooves rearing into the air. Rain from every direction gathered before Odin and struck the front of the Maybach. Chu Zihang could see nothing; it was as though a waterfall rushed toward them. The car's immense momentum dissolved within a few meters. Alarms sounded and airbags deployed, saving Chu Zihang's neck from snapping instantly.

The torrent pushed the Maybach back. Sleipnir slowly sank to its eight knees and stopped. Odin drove Gungnir into the wet asphalt, his divine horse his throne. Crowds of black figures emerged behind him like priests preparing for Mass. They surrounded the car on every side, all in identical black clothes, with identical pale faces and identical hollow eyes shining gold. The Maybach was completely surrounded. Apparently the gods' tactics resembled those of humans.

"Get out," the man said softly.

Chu Zihang moved mechanically, following him out. They stood side by side in the brilliant headlights, the man holding the long sword in one hand and drawing Chu Zihang close with the other.

"Don't be afraid... although I was terrified the first time I saw it too... But fear won't help. I didn't want you to see this, but since you have, don't miss the chance. Open your eyes wide!"

Chu Zihang gripped his hand. He had never felt the man so tall, as immovable as a mountain. Rain filled heaven and earth; beyond it lay limitless darkness. Beneath them stretched the broad elevated road, surrounded by transparent curtains of water, as though all the world's rain had gathered in this space, streams pressed together without gaps.

"You dare crash into the throne of a god!" Odin's deep voice came through the rain.

"I'm a driver. When you drive too much, your hand inevitably slips." The man spoke calmly. "I know what you want. Fine, I can give it to you."

He patted Chu Zihang's head. "Get the case from the trunk. Black, with a silver emblem."

There was indeed a black case in the trunk, its special leather rough and tough, with a silver plate engraved with a flourishing World Tree.

Chu Zihang handed it to the man, who weighed it, gave it back, and looked at Odin. "I'm ready."

"Then, human! Approach!"

"You've disobeyed me many times, but this time you must listen," the man whispered in Chu Zihang's ear. "Remember, don't leave me, but don't get too close. When I say 'run,' run toward the car. Don't look back, whatever you do. Don't look back!"

"Mm!" Chu Zihang trembled.

The shadows closed around them and carried them forward, whispering to one another in an ancient tongue, like singing and weeping. Chu Zihang couldn't understand a word, but the snakelike lines in his mind were waking, shifting endlessly. Suddenly he understood those eager voices of the dead:

"Human..."

"Humans again..."

"The child's bloodline..."

"Such mouthwatering fresh meat..."

"Thirsty..."

Chu Zihang covered his ears and looked around in terror. The shadows' faces were all alike, all expressionless, yet each bore too many stories of the past.

"I hear what you hear. Don't be afraid. Dad is beside you," the man whispered.

The man stopped about a hundred meters from Odin and a hundred from the Maybach behind them, exactly halfway between. Rain washed continuously over the sword in his hand.

"Even if I give you the thing, I don't think you'll let us go," he said.

He planted his feet wide, soaked trousers flapping in the cold wind, looking as swaggering as a street thug. But showing a thug's swagger before something like a god?

"I will promise you life," Odin said. "A god never lies to mortals."

"Life like these dead men?" The man pointed his thumb at the shadows.

"No. Your bloodlines are far superior to theirs. You will be much stronger."

"No room to bargain?"

"All who have been to this realm can return to it. Therefore everyone who comes here must be a servant of god."

"Son, they say you're a center on the city team, good at breaking through defenses?" the man murmured in Chu Zihang's ear.

Chu Zihang nodded nervously.

"Negotiations have broken down," the man said. "Give me the case."

He took it and gently stroked Chu Zihang's head. "Remember everything I told you. Every word." He suddenly slapped Chu Zihang on the rear and roared, "Run!"

Without thinking, Chu Zihang turned and ran madly toward the car. For a long time he had no longer believed the man's words, but on this rainy night, holding his warm hand, he had suddenly become a child dependent on his father again.

The man hurled the case toward Odin, like fresh meat thrown to draw wolves. Half the shadows rushed after it, half intercepted the man and Chu Zihang. Their forms distorted with speed, like long snakes springing from the ground. The man ran after Chu Zihang, but perhaps because he was middle-aged, he wasn't as fast; the distance between them widened. Watching his son's back recede, a smile touched his mouth. "Fast little rascal."

He spun, his sword carving a blinding arc and sending rain splashing outward in a circle.

Chu Zihang heard terrible sounds pursuing him: blood pouring from wounds, bones breaking beneath a blade, mingled with the storm.

He actually heard the shadows wailing: "It hurts," "It hurts so much," "It burns with pain"... desperate cries, as if from hell.

Thick, foul blood without warmth spattered his back, and even the rain could not wash it away. The man remained behind him. Chu Zihang gathered his courage and looked back. Like a lion the man swung his sword, and shadow after shadow split in its gleam.

A transparent curtain of air opened in the rain. A high cry burst from deep in the man's throat, as ancient as the shadows' whispers.

Where the curtain spread, time slowed. Wind and rain seemed to thicken, and the shadows slowed too, everything like a film in slow motion. Only the man was unaffected. He turned and swung his sword, stepping and sliding, water slowly splashing underfoot and the shadows' foul black blood slowly flowing out, all suspended for a moment in the air like ink drifting through water. Amid the ink, his flashing blade was a silver swallow in flight.

Chu Zihang had never imagined a man could look so magnificent, and this man was his father.

At last he threw himself into the car and shouted into the rain, "Dad!"

Suddenly he had a strange feeling... the kite string had broken.

It was the string between him and the man. For a very long time he had seen him only at long intervals, but there had always been a string between them. Now it had broken.

The man had not run back with him. After shaking off the shadows, he had turned and raced toward Odin!

The shadows with the case had counterattacked, and the man's domain expanded to cover them all. But Odin did not slow. He drew Gungnir and struck, lightning darting. Countless thrusts in an instant: each stroke of the legendary spear that always found its mark carried a dark-gold gleam. Arcs of light surrounded the man, attacking vital points from different directions like a dense meteor shower.

The man ignored the shadows. He dodged among the meteors, spinning with his sword, stepping on a shadow to leap high, and struck downward—at Odin, at the god's head!

Blood suddenly poured from his back. He fell among the shadows. The "meteors" he had dodged curved around like fireflies and struck him from behind. Odin withdrew Gungnir, and the shadows closed on the man step by step.

"Son! Drive away!" He turned sharply and roared at Chu Zihang, thick blood-red mist rising from his body.

Chu Zihang understood. The man wanted to draw every shadow surrounding them to himself. He was using himself as bait.

"Listen to me! Remember what you promised." The man's blood-red eyes stayed fixed on Odin, but he spoke to Chu Zihang. "If I die, you're all I leave in this world. If you die too, I'll have nothing left here."

"Son, trust your dad. If you live, we'll have a chance to meet again." He flexed his bleeding arm. "With you here, there are some of my big moves I can't use."

"That car's wonderful. It cost nine million! Something that damn expensive can't be stopped even by a god!"

Chu Zihang looked at the keyless console. He understood what the man had boasted about: three people could awaken the engine, and he was the third.

"Start," he said.

The engine roared.

"Well done, son!" The man raised his sword, his voice like thunder.

Chu Zihang reversed, the car flying backward. The man had secretly taught him to drive in this very Maybach; they had once sped along a country dirt road in spring with the sunroof open.

The Maybach struck a barely visible curtain of rain. Whirling wind battered its body, walls of water pressed in from every side. The twelve-cylinder engine roared at full power, but could not move the car out of that place.

"Hey! God! Open sesame!" the man roared, hurling his sword at the eight-legged horse's head. Gungnir struck again. The man leaped, surrounded by countless golden meteors.

The water wall's force weakened for an instant. The Maybach roared through it and plunged into the deep night.

Chu Zihang's mind was blank. He drove mechanically through the rain. At some point the stereo had come on again, and daughter and father were singing to each other:

Daughter, dear daughter, the match I made was right,

I married you to a wealthy family's son,

When I grow old, he will be the man you can rely on,

He is young, but he is growing.

Suddenly he understood the song.

Those were the words the man wanted to leave him. Whether he was a son or daughter didn't matter: the man had sent him into a wealthy family because he had no certainty about his own life. He wanted his child to live well and have someone to rely on.

This was a man who always lived a double life. Only rarely was he fierce and formidable; in most people's eyes he was a man of little ability. Yet he dared not show that fierce side to his son, so he could appear only as a driver, snatching time to collect him from school. That was all he could do. Many times he had waited outside the school in the Maybach, only to see the Mercedes S500 arrive and retreat with his head lowered. Believing his "daughter" had someone to rely on, he fled far away.

"You'll understand when you're older."

Now Chu Zihang understood. And the man... the man might already be dead.

What was death?

It was the end, a final parting, something irretrievable: a hand you could never hold again, warmth you could never feel, and "I'm sorry" you could never say.

Chu Zihang slammed on the brakes. Tires shrieked; the car stopped sideways on the empty elevated road in the rain. He opened the sunroof and leaned back, gasping like an asthmatic, looking up. It seemed all the world's rain poured through the opening, hard and cold against his face, but he felt neither cold nor pain. Only the man's voice and the song played back in his ears.

"Start! Start!" he suddenly shouted at the console.

The engine gave a low, feeble sound. The car had reached its limit and could not move again.

Chu Zihang flung open the door and ran into the wind and rain. At that instant he understood that he was truly about to lose the man. What the man would leave in the world, what he had promised him—all of it was forgotten. He had gone mad. He feared neither the shadows nor Odin nor Gungnir. He had to find the man.

In the downpour, a small figure sat on the Maybach's roof and watched him go, eyes faintly golden, humming the Irish folk song.

On July 3, 2004, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407, made landfall in the city, bringing torrential rain and force-ten winds. The city was given three days off.

For the people of this coastal city, typhoons were ordinary, so no one panicked. Instead they happily enjoyed three unexpected days at home. Unable to go out, families sat together watching variety shows on television, and parents took the opportunity to make up for the time they usually couldn't spend with their children.

Naturally the typhoon caused trouble. Although the elevated road had been closed promptly, some drivers had still gone up. Eventually the wind grew too strong for them to drive, and police cars couldn't reach them. Officers phoned and told them to park against the barrier, close their windows tightly, and endure the night in the storm. Thanks to this, no cars were overturned, though their paint was scraped against the barrier and water got into their engines. In the morning the wind subsided and tow trucks went up to bring them out one by one. Every rescued person was overjoyed. A damaged car was nothing; insurance would pay. Having escaped death, everything was wonderful. At the exit they embraced waiting relatives, young people kissed, and older men and women wept. What a moving scene.

At last the families waiting at the exit left one by one, until only a boy remained. Without an umbrella, soaked through, he stood behind the crowd watching every car towed down. He seemed frozen, lips purple, trembling slightly, yet he did not move. Finally, when all the tow trucks had assembled and were about to leave, he approached the officer in charge. "Are there no more?"

"No more," the officer said. "Haven't found your family? Don't worry, we rescued everyone on the elevated road. Nobody was hurt. If you didn't see them, you must have missed each other. Go home and check."

Something faint in the boy's eyes seemed finally to go out. After a long silence he slowly crouched, both hands on the ground, saying nothing.

The officer couldn't see his face and thought he was crying. He wanted to pat his shoulder and comfort him. A boy didn't need to cry just because something had gone wrong; when in trouble, ask the police...

But he suddenly stopped. He did not dare approach. He could clearly see the boy's ten fingers, braced against the ground and curled into claws, digging deep into the asphalt. He had no time to wonder how a middle-school boy possessed such terrifying strength. He simply sensed, instinctively, the overwhelming waves of... sorrow erupting from that slender body.

On the night of July 12, 2010, rain fell on the city again, a fine, steady drizzle.

The World Cup final in South Africa: Spain against the Netherlands. The streets were empty, traffic lights changing lonely colors. All over the city, people gathered before televisions, drinking beer and shouting at good plays and bad.

Chu Zihang lay on his back in the dark, hands folded on his chest, staring at the enameled chandelier. Mom and her friends screamed in the next room; someone must have scored. They had already finished a case of beer. If they kept drinking, those beautiful, eccentric aunties would run into the garden in low-cut silk nightgowns, holding hands and acting crazy. But never mind; let them. A little madness once in a while was fine.

Mom had already drunk her milk tonight.

Chu Zihang was reciting his diary. It was written neither on paper nor in an electronic file, but in his mind. It contained many images, passing frame by frame: riding on the man's shoulders shouting "Giddyap!"; the only expensive toy the man had bought him, a model train set; and the scene the man himself would have considered the most spectacular of his life, standing with legs apart and holding a sword for worshiping—or killing—a god... Every night before sleep, Chu Zihang recalled them, every detail, until he was sure he had forgotten nothing.

Masashi Toyama, who taught Introduction to Brain Science, said human memory was unreliable, like a worn-out hard drive easily demagnetized. The past was like a picture drawn in sand. As time passed, wind blew the sand away, memory blurred, and finally everything became an indistinguishable haze. Toyama said this was a form of self-protection: imagine remembering every detail of the past forever. The saddest, most painful, most sorrowful images of your life would torment you constantly, and you could never escape the bad times behind you.

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

"Dad, it's raining again." Having recalled the final image, Chu Zihang spoke softly.

Rain rattled against the window. He slowly closed his eyes and fell asleep.

Act One

Birthday Cake Is the Grave of Youth

Birthday Cake is the Grave of Youth

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

He woke to cicadas shrieking their hearts out. The sunshine was almost poisonous, and the stuffy room felt like the steamer in Journey to the West in which demons cooked a fat monk.

Lu Mingfei waved a paper fan inscribed I COME BY MOONLIGHT—words that made him feel like a lecherous thief—and typed www.i-cassell-you.com into his laptop.

He entered the username Ricardo.M.Lu, a password that changed with the date, and authentication from a security USB drive. A tap on Enter refreshed the screen to the Cassell College Vacation Daily Report Form: a dark-green interface with clean, thin borders and more buttons than he could take in at a glance. Lu Mingfei fished a wrinkled little notebook from the pocket of his baggy shorts and began following its instructions item by item.

"Have you detected any unidentified dragons?"

Lu Mingfei checked No. Under a clear blue sky in broad daylight, where would dragons be running around? Coming home for summer vacation meant returning to the real world and severing all contact with reptiles.

"Have you used a Yanling?"

Another No. After the battle at the Three Gorges Reservoir, all his Yanling abilities had vanished again. He had risked a quarter of his life for them, only to get a single use and no after-sales service. Lu Mingze was a crooked businessman.

"Have you experienced any physical abnormalities?"

"Have you discovered any suspected alchemical equipment?"

No, no, no, no, no... This was Lu Mingfei's summer vacation after freshman year. He was doing his daily report.

The daily report was a Cassell College rule. During winter and summer breaks, students had to report online every day. Professors graded the reports: good ones raised a student's GPA, while lying counted as cheating on an exam. In a sense this was their vacation homework, that turd teachers left to spoil your happy days off and remind you they existed. It was like finally getting dessert after a meal, only for someone to sprinkle mustard oil over it. But at Cassell College the daily report was absolutely necessary, because its students were absolutely exceptional.

Cassell College was a private, elite institution for the privileged in the Great Lakes region of Illinois. None of those adjectives quite captured it. It was a paradise for monsters and lunatics.

A college for dragon hybrids.

The professors firmly believed that dragons had once ruled the world as an intelligent race. This rewrote evolution: humanity was no longer the sole pinnacle of the evolutionary tree. Before mammals produced humans, reptiles had given rise to a supreme intelligent species, the dragons. That history had been buried after humanity rose, surviving only in scraps and fragments of ancient myths. But the decline of the dragons did not mean their extinction. The Dragon Kings, bearers of the most sacred bloodlines, merely slept, and would one day awaken. They were unlikely to join the United Nations and build a better home with humanity. They intended to restore the theocratic age of reptiles.

They could do it, too. They were nothing like the monsters of knightly romances, clumsily flying about and stupidly breathing fire. They possessed a mysterious art called alchemy and the sacred power of words known as Yanling, which could even alter the laws of physics.

Most humans believed dragons were only myths because a certain group had long erased evidence of their existence: the dragon hybrids. Born of humans and dragons, they had human hearts and draconic powers. They kept the dragons' secret and bore the duty of guardians. Cassell trained the finest hybrids and sent them around the world to prevent the Dragon Kings' awakening and, when necessary, devise plans to slay them and send those unrepentant monarchs back to their long sleep.

Lu Mingfei had grown up under the red flag and in the sunshine, educated in materialism with all the proper beliefs. Though he sometimes indulged in wild fantasies, he had never imagined supernatural nonsense like dragons could have anything to do with him.

Yet Cassell College had come all that way to recruit him, singing the praises of his bloodline.

The courses were outrageous, and the textbooks even more absurd—more absurd than Japan's new history textbooks. There it was in black and white: humans had not struggled against nature for a million years before learning to use tools and fire; dragons had taught those skills to their servants. Attila the Hun was a dragon, which was why he was so powerful that no one could stop him as he fought his way to Rome. Chinese emperors had not been boasting when they called themselves descendants of dragons, because as far back as the Three Sovereigns and Five Emperors, every enlightened person fit to lead had indeed been a dragon hybrid...

After taking classes there, Lu Mingfei figured every historical event probably had something to do with dragons. Maybe, just as in Stephen Chow's version of The Deer and the Cauldron, the Qing dynasty had really fallen because the Red Flower Society severed its dragon vein.

Since everyone was a human-dragon hybrid, geniuses were everywhere and elites were a dime a dozen. Every genius and elite had a shocking side, and without strict discipline and management the consequences of letting them run wild were unthinkable. Compared with these hybrids, even Ultraman, Pikachu, and the Transformers might be nothing special. During summer break these people lived among ordinary crowds. If one of them accidentally unleashed a Yanling...

They had indeed learned painful lessons in that regard.

Fortunately, the college leadership were not elegant but useless intellectuals. Before the college was founded, the dragon slayers' organization had been called the Dragon Blood Secret Party. Anyone daring to call themselves a party had to be a scheming customer, no pushover; without an iron hand,

how could they command obedience? Principal Anjou therefore played his trump card: the daily report. Students complained, but it worked, reducing accidents that required the college to clean up afterward by as much as eighty percent. Of course, eliminating them entirely was impossible. Last year a student with a heroic streak had secretly taken alchemical equipment from campus to excavate a hidden dragon tomb in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, awakening a dragon about to emerge from its cocoon. He missed his return date and pursued it across thousands of miles, taking Star Alliance flights from Cairo to Istanbul, then New York and Cape Town. Finally, when he fired an alchemical missile at the dragon's seaplane, he shot down a new stealth drone the Pentagon was test-flying. The American stealth-aircraft industry interpreted the incident as proof that an adversary had mastered every technique needed to detect their aircraft and was making an unmistakable demonstration. They abandoned their existing research and threw themselves into a space-shuttle project for attacks from outer space.

The Board of Trustees punished the student severely, but Lu Mingfei had to admit that was how students at Cassell thought: anything went in the pursuit of dragon slaying. The plane had only itself to blame for crossing the senior student's missile trajectory at exactly the wrong moment.

"Mingfei! Don't get up and start playing on the computer first thing! Go downstairs and buy a bag of Cantonese sausage and a bunch of scallions, and check the front desk for any new packages while you're at it!" His aunt's voice carried so well it came through a twenty-centimeter load-bearing wall and left Lu Mingfei reeling. A demonic sound straight through the brain.

"Okay, okay! Just a second!" Lu Mingfei hurried to his feet.

His parents had gone abroad for work when he was little and never returned, leaving him in storage with his uncle and aunt. Only after enrolling at Cassell did he learn they were both distinguished alumni, traveling the world for the cause of dragon slaying and far too busy to look after their troublesome kid. Fortunately, that meant the college viewed him differently and classified his bloodline as S-rank. He was its only S-rank student, with an exclusive scholarship worth tens of thousands of dollars. Admittedly, nobody had seen anything extraordinary about him yet—in other words, everyone else at the college had a Yanling and he did not—but perhaps that could be explained by a modest, understated personality...

After years of swallowing insults in his uncle and aunt's house, he could finally hold his head high. Summer vacation was the perfect time to return home in glory!

He was no longer that troublesome kid. In his first semester's practical course, he had stabbed the King of Bronze and Fire, one of the Four Monarchs of the dragons, to death at the Three Gorges Reservoir... though one might suspect a little cheating.

By comparison, a student ID that doubled as a credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit was nothing. Once you had saved the world, why discuss something as vulgar as money?

He even owned a car now. He had won a Bugatti Veyron in a bet... though he had smashed it up on his first drive and still couldn't afford repairs.

He had a boss, too. He had joined the Student Council under President Caesar Gattuso. Brother Caesar had very few virtues, only three. First, he could fight: with two modified Desert Eagles and Yanling: Kamaitachi, he had actually wounded the Dragon King Constantine. Second, he was rich; Lu Mingfei had won his Bugatti from him. Third, he was generous and grand, spending lavishly every birthday on a swimsuit-and-champagne party by the pool. Few people in the world caught Caesar's eye,

yet in front of every Student Council officer he had clapped Lu Mingfei on the shoulder and said, "Recruiting Lu Mingfei is our greatest achievement this year!" His next words were, "Even if he's good for nothing, I won't let our only S-rank fall into Chu Zihang's Lionheart Society!"

What an honor! How could Lu Mingfei not be proud? With that background and status, he had no weaknesses at all!

As the plane crossed the Bering Strait on its way home, Lu Mingfei practiced smiling. No matter how his uncle and aunt praised him, he must smile calmly, not grin and show his gums. That was the aristocratic Cassell style. The passenger beside him watched the boy smile faintly, compose himself, smile faintly again, then compose himself again, over and over as if practicing a secret martial art, and spent the entire journey in terror.

But when he stepped through his uncle's door, he was greeted not by flowers but by a heap of radish strips on the dining table. His uncle and aunt were sweating over a lively operation to pickle dried radish.

"Mingfei, you're back? Perfect timing! Go buy me half a jin of coarse salt!" His aunt was delighted to see him.

"Okay, okay." From habit, Lu Mingfei put down his luggage, took the two and a half yuan in change, and headed downstairs.

Only outside did it hit him. Damn it! He was practically a successful man now. Did he really have to buy salt himself? Shouldn't his precious hands be reserved for saving the world?

He returned with the salt and helped his aunt cut radishes. Just as he was preparing to describe his year in America with suitable restraint, she spoke first. "Mingfei, let me ask you something..."

He had not yet realized this was the prelude to Cheng Yaojin's three axe blows.

"You've been in America a year. Have you saved any of your scholarship?"

The first blow turned him to stone. She had struck his weak point. On paper he was rich, but the college had strict rules: to collect his scholarship he had to pass every test, submit papers on time, and earn excellent grades. Apart from his practical course, his results were miserable. In twelve months he had received only four months' scholarship money, and his credit card was now thousands in the red. Some of his swagger deflated, and he unconsciously put more effort into cutting the radishes.

"People say American girls are very open. Have you found a girlfriend?" The second blow followed hard on the first.

Lu Mingfei's head dropped. That question really hurt. How could he put it? The figure that kept appearing and disappearing in his heart was... He couldn't very well confess, "I think my boss's girlfriend Nono is great, and she's been good to me, but I'm rather like a toad gazing up at a swan, and I'm still single."

"Did you see your parents?" The ultimate finishing move.

Lu Mingfei had almost forgotten what they looked like. In a whole year he had received only two letters from his mother, Qiao Weini. Even on the emergency-contact form when he enrolled, he could only put his uncle and aunt. His impressive parents, his dashing parents, his busy parents, the parents who supposedly loved Lu Mingfei so deeply, were occupied with some great enterprise to fight dragons and save the world. They had no time to come back and see him.

In his heart they were as distant as a myth.

You couldn't always ask someone else to say "I love you" for you, could you? Even if you wrote it a thousand times in letters, one day you still had to say it yourself. Lu Mingfei wanted his parents to prove their sincerity one day, with something dramatic: suddenly appearing before him, travel-worn, suitcases in hand, standing amid steam from a train or the rush of air behind a plane, gazing silently at their troublesome son and saying in trembling voices, "You've... grown so much?"

Right? That would be moving! Then he could resist the urge to crouch on the ground and bawl, and say casually, "You're back."

Come on, heroes! Prove to the unlucky kid you brought into this world that you would cross mountains and oceans just to see him and say a sentimental "I love you"!

But so far, to Lu Mingfei, his parents were merely signatures at the ends of letters, definitions in a figure of speech, and two splendid names in an alumni directory: Lu Lincheng and Qiao Weini.

Lu Mingfei fell silent. His knife struck hollowly against the chopping board.

His aunt understood at once. With a contemptuous smile she said she'd known his parents were unreliable. She had hoped they might recommend Mingze, but fortunately she'd had the foresight not to wait. If she had relied on them, would Mingze ever have gotten into Austin University?

His cousin Lu Mingze had just received his acceptance from Austin University, and the whole family had celebrated. After spending a year in the shadow of "even a loser like Lu Mingfei got into an American university," his aunt could finally hold her head high. Her back straightened, her legs stopped aching when she walked, and she could speak without running out of breath. An American university acceptance letter worked like a calcium supplement for her.

"Don't cut the strips so thick! The salt won't get in!" his aunt barked.

"Mm-hmm." Lu Mingfei was sweating buckets.

"Apply to our Austin University. It's a famous school, everyone's very friendly, and the professors are especially nice..." Lu Mingze's voice came from the inner room. Wearing a headset, he was chatting on QQ voice with his feet on the desk and the air conditioning turned up high. Cool air bathed him, and a girl's soft admiration at the other end sent him floating, lending his voice ever more dramatic rises and falls. He was 160 centimeters tall and weighed 160 jin, but when it came to chasing girls he was far more reliable than his cousin. He had heard his cousin was still single; if he got a girlfriend first, he would be what his mother called a winner in life.

Actually Lu Mingze had no real need to look down on Lu Mingfei. With Austin University behind him, he felt superior to his cousin from head to toe in every possible way. But since he was so outstanding, he might as well show off without shame.

To the clatter of the keyboard, Lu Mingfei packed the radish strips into a pickle jar, rubbed coarse salt over each layer, and sealed it. Salt seeped into his skin, leaving it dry and rough.

"Carry the jar out to the balcony! Look how clumsy you are. You didn't learn to cook in America either, did you?" His aunt pointed.

Among the most invincible creatures in the world were middle-aged women: sturdy, practical, and sharp-eyed. With only three questions they could reduce a swaggering brat to his true form. To a middle-aged woman, if you had no parents, girlfriend, or money, what were you showing off for? However capable you were, however many dragons you'd killed, it meant nothing. Even if you were

great enough to master Star Platinum, you still needed a reason to throw a punch, didn't you? You had nothing, not even a reason to throw a punch... Were you supposed to fight for eternal justice?

What nonsense.

"Hurry up! How long have I been calling you? Lazy and poor go together, ever heard that? If you're lazy, you'll be poor!" His aunt grew sharper still.

Lu Mingfei hastily clicked Send and rushed out. His aunt's demonic voice boring through his brain... even a hero like his uncle, who had practiced the Golden Bell Shield for twenty years, couldn't withstand it.

"Ricardo.M.Lu, you have one unread message." A window suddenly appeared on the screen.

Ricardo:

According to your enrollment information, you were born on July 17, 1991, and turn nineteen today.

On this important day, on behalf of Principal Hilbert Jean Anjou and all the professors of the academic board, I wish you a happy birthday.

Thank you for attending Cassell College and sharing these wonderful times with us. It is an honor to grow together.

Yours sincerely, Norma.

PS. Under college rules, a student celebrating a birthday may collect one birthday cake from the cafeteria. Since you are currently on summer vacation in China, your complimentary birthday cake has been canceled. Furthermore, the summer term begins July 20, 2010. Your transcript shows D grades in two courses last semester, meaning you did not pass. I regret to inform you that you must attend remedial classes and retake the examinations during the summer term. I have booked your flight back to campus. Please be ready to depart at any time.

"Birthday?" Lu Mingfei stared. Since coming home, he had spent his days serving at his aunt's command and his evenings playing StarCraft. The days had blurred together, and he had completely forgotten.

He was nineteen, just like that? Time really flew. Think of what heroes had accomplished at nineteen... Zhou Yu and his sworn brother Sun Ce had already established a base in Jiangdong and married the Qiao sisters, with territory and women to call their own... And this was how his own nineteenth birthday arrived?

"What the hell? What kind of congratulatory email is this? It's just telling me my free cake is canceled and I failed classes!" After reading the PS twice, Lu Mingfei finally caught on.

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

His phone chimed. A text had arrived.

"Happy birthday. Chu Zihang." As concise as that senior student's expressionless face.

Someone actually remembered his birthday, and that someone was Chu Zihang.

Chu Zihang was president of Cassell's Lionheart Society, the Student Council's sworn enemy, while Lu Mingfei was a new Council member. It was like Lu Su waking on his birthday to a card from Cao Cao: bewildering and full of conflicting feelings. Lu Mingfei had no idea how Chu Zihang had gotten his number. He certainly hadn't saved Chu Zihang's, and the senior had spoken fewer than a hundred sentences to him altogether. Was this an attempt to win him over? But would the stone-faced senior, who would cut down anyone who stood in his path, really resort to such tactics?

While Lu Mingfei was speculating, another text arrived.

"Lu Mingfei, is this your number? I'm Chen Wenwen. The Literature Club is having lunch at Sophie Lad Pizza at 11:30 today. Come along if you get this."

His heart rippled... No, a colossal meteorite had struck the middle of the Pacific, raising towering waves!

The sudden message was like Chen Wenwen's invitation to join the Literature Club years ago: casual, unexpected, and delightful. That had been a summer too. Cicadas screamed their hearts out, the sunlight outside was blinding, and the shadow of the eaves lay sharp as a blade across the ground. He had leaned against the windowsill, bored out of his mind, while Chen Wenwen, in a blue-and-white cloth dress and low-heeled sandals, moved lightly past as though walking on tiptoe along a road at night.

"Are you Lu Mingfei? Do you like reading?" Chen Wenwen had stopped abruptly.

He had looked up in surprise. Her eyes were like water, rippling faintly as they reflected the sun.

"Pathetic," Lu Mingfei muttered. Chen Wenwen had a boyfriend now, and the whole affair had left him miserable... Yet remembering that instant when he looked up still stirred him.

"Sure," he replied.

"Mingfei, you haven't left yet?" His aunt burst in.

"I'm going, I'm going!" Startled, Lu Mingfei snapped to attention.

"Good thing you haven't." She waved what she was holding: a cracked toilet seat. "Your uncle cracked it sitting on it. Go to the building-supply market and buy a new one, beechwood, something decent. Your uncle and I are taking Mingze to buy a suit for going abroad, to wear at the graduation ceremony! Don't dawdle. Buy the seat and have the property management people install it. We'll be back at four thirty this afternoon. Steam the sausage, clean the scallions, and cut some radish for soup!"

Having issued her orders, his aunt turned and left. The outer door slammed, and a few minutes later his uncle's little BMW drove away downstairs.

Lu Mingfei's head ached. What a busy birthday: the Literature Club gathering, his aunt's many errands, and a family dinner that evening to celebrate Lu Mingze's departure for study in America.

Eleven time zones away, at Cassell College in Illinois.

Late at night the central control room on the library's second floor was ablaze with light. Manstein stood before a giant 3D projection: a virtual globe five meters high floated before him, spinning rapidly to whatever location he wanted with a light wave of his hand. It felt like a god manipulating his creation, a thrilling sense of command and power. If politicians knew such an advanced projection system existed, they would scramble to buy one and indulge their urge to direct the world: cosplay Hitler if they liked, Genghis Khan if they preferred, like the old teacher in From the Herbal Garden to

the Three Flavor Study reciting of an iron scepter wielded in splendid command and golden cups emptied without drunkenness.

But Manstein was not enjoying himself at all. Manstein wanted to die.

Seven or eight red lights flashed at once on the ghostly blue globe, alarms rising and falling. The control room was filled with rapid keyboard clatter, printers hissing, and mechanical cipher machines clicking as they translated coded messages. His head was ready to explode. Day or night, the atmosphere was always like this; tonight Manstein was the unlucky professor on duty.

As many as seventy experts and interns worked there, each facing several terminals at once. The college secretary, or rather the supercomputer named Norma, gathered information relevant to the college from across the world, but people still had to analyze it and make decisions. The central control room was the college's think tank.

"Executive Department agents intercepted a smuggling plane over Peru. We found priceless Egyptian alchemical equipment dating from 700 BC in the cabin! They have the situation completely under control," an intelligence officer shouted hoarsely through his headset. "But they shot the plane down... They're making an emergency landing and requesting rescue!"

"Please sign this reimbursement form. Our agents in Greece are waiting for the funds!" A female secretary hurried up in clicking high heels and handed Manstein a bill.

"Seventy thousand dollars?" His eyes bulged. "For a sum this large they need to submit a formal report!"

"There's no time... They're dealing with the mob."

"We're a college! We're educators! What are we doing dealing with the mob?" Manstein exploded.

"Several recent serial murders are suspected to involve a death servitor. The mob knows something, and our agents in Greece believe it must be captured before the police get involved." The secretary caught her breath. "It's urgent. They called directly for money. Both sides reportedly have their fingers on their triggers while they wait. If the money doesn't arrive... the other side may think they're being cheated and open fire!"

Manstein was about to say more when an anxious financial expert rushed over.

"OPEC announced an increase in crude oil prices five minutes ago!"

"What the hell do crude oil prices have to do with me?" Manstein glared. "I didn't buy oil futures."

"But the college did... a huge position, using over 1.2 billion in reserves. If we don't sell in time, we'll suffer enormous losses."

"How enormous?" Manstein covered his face.

"Conservatively, possibly two hundred million..." The expert wiped cold sweat from his face.

Manstein felt one breath away from spraying blood all the way to the ceiling. He signed the secretary's bill with a flourish, turned to the financial expert, and ordered, "Sell! Sell everything!"

He couldn't be bothered about Greece's seventy thousand dollars. Tonight a word from him moved hundreds of millions; was there any point getting angry over a mere seventy thousand? What a wretched night, and he alone had to hold it together. Normally three professors shared a shift: tonight it was his turn with Guderian and Schneider, director of the Executive Department. The scatterbrained Guderian was plainly unreliable, so when he said he was used to going to bed early and didn't want

overtime, Manstein agreed to cover for an old friend. But Schneider, famed as an iron-willed enforcer, had let him down too, saying he had an important academic paper to revise and asking Manstein to cover. Manstein knew that although Schneider was a butcher—he regarded everyone in the Executive Department as butchers, crude people who knew only knives and guns—he had always wanted more publications so he wouldn't fall behind the other professors academically. So he agreed.

But the whole world was unsettled tonight, and not one piece of good news had arrived to lift his spirits.

"The Equipment Department has achieved tremendous success testing a new alchemical weapon in the Sahara!" An intern sprang from his chair and raised his arms in triumph.

His wild delight caught on. Everyone knew the department was preparing a secret weapons test deep in the Sahara: a superweapon that might tip the balance between humans and dragons. It had succeeded! Everyone raised their arms and cheered, as if NASA had just announced a successful moon landing.

Manstein perked up and started toward the intern's terminal. Then a piercing alarm swept through the control room. It was a high-level warning. He turned to see a rapidly flashing red light expanding in the heart of the Sahara on the globe, threatening to engulf the entire earth!

"What happened? Didn't you say it was a tremendous success?" he roared at the intern.

"A minor problem... The Pentagon's spy satellite Tungusta happened to be passing over the Sahara and observed our test. It mistook it for... a nuclear explosion. According to our inside source, the CIA has reported it to the president. Since the test site was in Libya, the ambassador there will probably issue a stern diplomatic note very soon... accusing Libya of conducting a secret nuclear test..."

Manstein slapped himself hard. I knew it, he thought. When has that bunch of lunatics in the Equipment Department ever brought good news? But did they have to make it this outrageous?

"What alchemical weapon could possibly be mistaken for a nuclear explosion?" the duty professor cried in anguish, his voice echoing through the library's marble corridors.

"A tactical missile fitted with an alchemically refined silver warhead... Combined with refined mercury, niter extracted from Vesuvius's volcanic ash, and the blood of a holy infant, the explosion can lethally poison dragons in its central zone."

"What use is that? How many dragons will wait in the middle of the desert for you to bomb them? What if one is in New York? Kill thousands of people along with one dragon? Those ingredients can kill humans as well!" Manstein collapsed into his chair. "I need to make some calls to deal with this... I need a little time..." Then he sprang up again, slamming both palms on the desk. "Executive Department, send people immediately! People! Fly them to the Sahara and clean up the site before the Pentagon gets there!"

A tremendous roar drowned him out. The floor shook violently and the lights went out, then came back on. Manstein fell, rolled to his feet, and rushed to the window. A column of dark-blue flame shot into the night sky from the direction of the Ice Cellar, the storehouse for alchemical equipment. The things kept there could destroy the earth several times over!

"Something's happened!" He lunged for the central console and grabbed a hammer to smash the glass covering the red lever for the campus-wide alarm.

Then the red telephone on the console rang. He hesitated, but answered it first. The line went directly to the Ice Cellar; he wanted to find out what was happening. Intruders? An accidental explosion?

"Hello? Who's on duty tonight?" asked a casual voice.

"Manstein, head of the Discipline Committee! What's going on?" The tone infuriated him. He recognized the Equipment Department's spokesperson. The weapon-obsessed lunatics rarely appeared in person and entrusted their communications to this unreliable representative.

"Just a routine experiment, a tiny bit of open flame. Everything is under our control," the spokesperson said calmly. "No need to make a fuss. We're calling to notify you that the Equipment Department has an experiment in the Ice Cellar tonight."

Manstein's eyes blazed. "Under control? Your Sahara experiment..."

"All departments in position! Hydrogen flame ready. Let's do it again..." someone called through the receiver.

"Again? You lunatics won't stop until somebody gets killed, will you?" Manstein roared, but only a busy signal answered. The spokesperson had already hung up with brisk efficiency.

He slowly replaced the receiver and sank weakly into his chair. What could he do? Some departments at the college could not be offended, and Equipment was one of them. Even knowing their reckless experiments might bring the sky down... no one wanted their new equipment to explode for no reason on the next assignment.

Quick, sharp footsteps approached and the control-room door was shoved open. Schneider was dragging Guderian along. These two disloyal fellows had left Manstein to take the blame alone; ordinarily they would hardly return out of kindness. Guderian had apparently been dragged from his nest and was still wearing a Pikachu nightcap. Entirely in keeping with his taste.

"What is it?" Manstein snatched off Guderian's cap and tossed it aside, but addressed Schneider. Guderian looked sleepy, with an expression that said this had nothing to do with him and he wanted to go back to bed.

"We lost some information in China." Schneider's voice was low and hoarse, always enough to make a listener's skin crawl.

"Tsk!" Manstein scoffed. What was one lost document in China? One of them had gone to sleep in a Pikachu cap, the other had used a paper as an excuse, and he had been left alone for twelve hours. In that time he had cleaned up after seven Executive Department teams around the world, authorized as much as $120,000 in expenses, prevented a gunfight, and was dealing with an imaginary nuclear crisis... And now they rushed in to tell him some information was lost?

Schneider slapped a file onto the desk. The dark-red stamp on its cover brought Manstein's overtime-muddled brain awake as if someone had poured cold water over it. It showed a great serpent holding its tail in its mouth to form a circle, its scales distinct, with two bold black letters in the center: SS.

"Top classification..." Manstein said softly.

Cassell missions, like bloodlines, were divided into grades. In descending priority they were A, B, C, D, E, and F. Special missions beyond those grades were designated S-rank. S-rank missions were rare; Operation Bronze against the Dragon King Norton at the Three Gorges Reservoir had been one.

SS was an exception among exceptions, not necessarily more important than S but extraordinarily special. Such missions came directly from the Board of Trustees, bypassing Principal Anjou.

The nuclear crisis had just been classified A-rank and had already reached the diplomatic level, yet the mission involving this information was SS. What could be so deadly important that even the trustees hidden behind the scenes couldn't sit still? Some scandal involving the trustees?

"Yes. Something the board wants." Schneider nodded slowly.

Manstein nodded and clapped his hands. "Ladies and gentlemen, give us the room."

Everyone else stood and filed out. As the financial expert passed Manstein, he asked quietly, "Sell in stages?"

"That's not important now. Decide for yourself." Manstein waved him away, leaving the 1.2-billion-dollar transaction to the expert. Only one thing mattered now: an SS-rank mission. Once one appeared, everything else gave way.

"You can't leave!" He caught Guderian trying to slip out at the back of the line and pulled him back.

"You said you wanted to talk alone," Guderian said, scratching his head. "I don't understand those things you're discussing anyway."

"But you're a professor on duty." Manstein sighed. "None of us can decide an SS-rank mission alone. With the principal away, the duty professors decide together. You have to be here."

Only the three of them remained in the vast control room. The doors closed tightly. No one dared eavesdrop on a secret mission from the trustees; the college might have a free atmosphere, but its rules were strict.

"What is it?" Manstein asked.

"You're better off not asking," Schneider said. "You weren't supposed to know anything about it. It was handled directly by the Executive Department. We only had to tell you because something went wrong."

"With a mission classified this highly, the Executive Department should have given it everything. How could there be a problem?"

"We did give it everything. We made detailed plans, obtained the information, and sent our best man to escort it back to campus personally. But it was lost on the way." Schneider gestured. The projection changed to a building with a turtle-shell-shaped glass dome, like an airport waiting hall, except it had been completely deformed. Its high-strength aluminum-alloy beams were twisted like pretzels. A simulation showed the disaster: as the ground shook, every beam twisted inexplicably, as if turned by giant hands, and thousands upon thousands of glass panes broke loose and fell straight down.

"I've seen that hall. It's the South Railway Station!" Guderian said suddenly.

"Yes. You saw it in Lu Mingfei's hometown. It was still under construction when you went for the interview, and began trial operations this summer. Its glass dome consisted of 3,200 high-strength panes, and its aluminum frame was designed to withstand a magnitude-eight earthquake, using the most advanced building technology. But this morning, Beijing time, it was destroyed in a magnitude-three quake. All 3,200 panes fell vertically, like 3,200 blades cutting at once." Schneider paused. "And our man was waiting for a train there with the information."

"He died?" Manstein asked.

"Cut to pieces," Schneider said quietly. "It was Raymond."

They had deployed Agent B007, Raymond, which showed how careful the Executive Department had been. A 2006 graduate of Cassell's mechanical engineering department, B-rank, Raymond possessed Yanling number 28, Blazing Sun, radiating light up to 4,000 lumens within his domain. The light could not kill, but his domain was a giant incandescent bulb fifty meters across. Anyone approaching him effectively entered the bulb and couldn't open their eyes. Though not a high-level Yanling, it was considered absurdly powerful, a game-breaking ability. Yet Raymond had died, and Blazing Sun had been useless, because his opponents had no eyes: 3,200 panes of glass falling from the sky.

"The casualties must have been terrible," Manstein said.

"Besides Raymond, only three people were injured. The station was still in its trial period, with few departures and few passengers waiting."

"Was he attacked by one of our kind? A building designed to withstand a magnitude-eight quake collapsing in a magnitude-three one is impossible to explain," Manstein said.

"I know. In China they call that tofu-dreg construction," Guderian interjected.

"If you don't understand, stop squawking!" Manstein snapped. "A magnitude-three quake wouldn't even bring down a condemned building!"

"We don't know. I've never heard of a Yanling like that," Schneider said. "What Yanling could destroy an aluminum-alloy hall large enough for thousands of passengers? That kind of force is almost comparable to Rhine."

"We don't have time to send an investigation team, do we?" Manstein said.

"No investigation team. Send someone to recover the information directly. The board's deadline is seven tonight, local time." Schneider checked his watch. "About eight hours."

"Who can we send? Who's nearby? Dispatch someone local."

"People in other cities can't make it. Railways and airports are closed until nine tonight against aftershocks," Schneider said. "The campus maintenance staff could drive there; they have a group vacationing in China."

Manstein pictured those men with steel-hard arms and stone-slab chests and shook his head. "Maintenance can assist, but the agent should have a bloodline advantage."

"Then we can only call on students: A-rank Chu Zihang and S-rank Lu Mingfei. Both have an unquestionable bloodline advantage," Schneider said. "Their homes are local, and they're on summer break."

Even in this serious, tense moment that admitted no levity, Manstein gave a rueful smile at Lu Mingfei's name. A bloodline advantage? He had one, certainly; S-rank marked the highest bloodline. But...

"That's right! With Mingfei there's no problem! He's S-rank!" Guderian looked as though he'd found treasure in a garbage heap. As Lu Mingfei's adviser, he had always had confidence in his student.

"I really don't know where your confidence comes from. Your S failed two courses last semester; the transcript has already gone to the academic board." Manstein shook his head. "An S-rank who can't even use a Yanling. Without a Yanling he has no innate ability. As a hybrid he's useless."

"Send Chu Zihang," Schneider said. "He has successfully completed many missions."

"As head of the Discipline Committee, I'm responsible for student discipline, and there are things I remember very clearly. Your student Chu Zihang is a confirmed devotee of violence. His record contains twelve disciplinary citations for violent tendencies during missions!" Manstein shook his head again. "Put an ungraduated violent offender in charge of an SS-rank mission?"

"The Executive Department is itself an organization of violence!" Schneider was just as protective of his own student.

"I know you're the chief thug," Manstein said. "But no. Chu Zihang can't be in charge alone."

"We have no choice," Schneider said. "I know my student. Chu Zihang is suited to working alone."

"He doesn't have to go alone. Mingfei will support him!" Guderian seized the opportunity.

Manstein looked straight into Schneider's iron-gray eyes. "A top-level mission needs a top-level team. Chu Zihang does have a bloodline advantage, but he isn't good enough to carry out a mission of this level by himself. At most he can be one member of a team!"

"I head the Executive Department. This is its mission, and Chu Zihang is my student. Do you understand?" Schneider was just as forceful.

"There's Mingfei..." Guderian watched their gazes strike sparks.

After several seconds, Schneider and Manstein both realized neither could overwhelm the other. They turned simultaneously and paced apart in agitation.

"Mingfei..." Guderian looked from one to the other.

"Chu Zihang as agent! Lu Mingfei assisting!" Schneider and Manstein turned and spoke at once. At last they had compromised. They had no choice: time was running out, and no one could afford to offend the trustees.

"Norma, inform the board of the team roster," Schneider said, thrusting his fingers into the projection and moving them rapidly to summon information. "We're drawing up an operational plan and will report to them promptly."

"Understood." An elegant female voice came from speakers on all sides.

"The board has replied. The team is to be adjusted: S-rank Lu Mingfei is appointed agent for this mission, with A-rank Chu Zihang assisting him. Chu Zihang is to follow Lu Mingfei's direction." Several minutes later, Norma's voice came again from overhead.

All three duty professors froze. For a long time the control room was silent.

"My God! The board really does recognize Mingfei's talent!" Guderian pressed both hands to his chest in delight.

Manstein and Schneider both raised hands to their foreheads, perhaps checking for fever and wondering whether they were hallucinating. They knew exactly what the college's only S-rank Lu Mingfei was: a "gifted student" struggling on the verge of remedial exams; a loser who would have been demoted without the principal's unconditional protection; an unpredictable wild card who lost his nerve when needed and stunned everyone when he wasn't supposed to appear. Put someone like that in charge? Let him command the elite of the elite, Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, who had completed twelve missions without a single failure? How was that different from asking Cassell's number-one loser Fingel to solve the Sahara nuclear crisis? Were they trying to destroy the earth?

Morning sunlight poured through the skylight onto the empty basketball court. A ball struck a bright patch with a soothing thump, thump. Chu Zihang was alone, dribbling, crouching, breathing deeply.

An electronic whistle sounded across the court. Chu Zihang moved, driving forward with the ball, leaping like a hurricane, and dunking! His body blurred with speed, and the ball struck the floor so rapidly it sounded like automatic gunfire.

The ball never reached the floor. Chu Zihang landed first and caught it, then immediately turned, drove toward the other basket, and dunked again! The hoop gave a tremendous crack, as though it might break.

He repeated the cycle, the electronic scoreboard rolling upward. It was a basketball game with one player, but both sides' scores rose in turn.

The final whistle sounded, and the scoreboard reached 50–50. His shoes hissed sharply against the floor as he slid into the center circle and slowly straightened. Only then did the ball land with a thump at one side of the court.

Until that moment he had not shed a drop of sweat. A few seconds later it poured out as though a sluice had opened, soaking his jersey.

This was the basketball court in Chu Zihang's home; he was doing his morning exercise. In middle school he had played center on the city's youth team, but after his bloodline awakened, most human competitive sports became dull. Greater muscular strength, superior agility, and bones able to bend beyond ordinary angles meant playing basketball against normal people was now like golf: pure recreation. Few people at Cassell liked basketball. Even the girls could leap and dunk easily, making the game uninteresting. Intellectual contests such as go and sports such as downhill skiing, which tested agility and courage, were popular. No one wanted to play games won simply by brute strength.

So he could only play against himself, turning an enjoyable sport into monotonous morning exercise. Caesar always mocked his taste in sports. Caesar naturally preferred Cassell's classic pastime of sailing: noble and carefree, well-shaped arms drawing substantial ropes, cold water splashing against a bare chest as the boat sped across great lakes and oceans.

Chu Zihang kept playing basketball. He had never been an interesting person anyway.

That man had been the first to teach him basketball. That alone was enough reason to keep playing for life.

Chu Zihang jumped out of his red jersey and went into the shower. Even showering followed a procedure: exactly three minutes, one minute hot, one cold, one warm. The hot water drove out the remaining sweat; the cold tightened muscles and skin; the warm rinsed him clean before he left. While Caesar and the Student Council officers soaked in a petal-strewn whirlpool bath drinking beer, they often joked that if they were living in decadent ancient Rome, Chu Zihang was a medieval ascetic.

Caesar was not quite right. Chu Zihang did not enjoy hardship; he simply wanted to remain as precise as a machine.

Cold water flowed over his raised muscles like streams through mountain rocks. Muscles and tendons overheated by exercise slowly returned to normal. He breathed in and out rhythmically, slowing his heartbeat and blood flow. His physical training specialty was tai chi.

Then his phone, sealed in a waterproof bag, rang. He never let it leave his side, even in the shower.

"I have a mission for you." His adviser Schneider always spoke in commands, blunt as a club descending on one's head.

"I'm listening." Chu Zihang quickly dried himself.

"Urgent mission, SS-rank. Recover important information before seven tonight. Norma has emailed you the detailed instructions." Schneider paused and lowered his voice. "Exercise restraint... Don't make the scene too big. Avoid casualties as far as possible. Don't be like those lunatics in Equipment..." A faint explosion came through the receiver, and Schneider's voice filled with anger. "They're dismantling the campus!"

"SS?" Chu Zihang was uninterested in the Equipment Department's lunatics. It was the mission's classification that surprised him. The highest he had previously taken part in was A-rank.

"You heard correctly. You were originally scheduled to return to campus today, weren't you? Norma has booked you and Lu Mingfei on tonight's UA836 nonstop to Chicago."

"Lu Mingfei?" Chu Zihang was taken aback.

Schneider paused. Even a man as hard and blunt as he found this arrangement difficult to announce and had to choose his words. "The agent in charge is S-rank Lu Mingfei. Your job is to assist him. You are to follow his instructions."

Chu Zihang was confused. What did that mean? An emperor summons his great general and says he wants him to go north against the barbarians with Chief Palace Eunuch Lu. The general naturally knows Eunuch Lu is there as an overseer: the general does the fighting, the eunuch takes the credit, and the general can only thank the emperor and obey. That would be normal. What was abnormal was the emperor saying, I'll give Eunuch Lu armor, a sword, and a fine horse so he can charge in front, while you run logistics behind him... Wasn't that a plan to get Eunuch Lu killed?

"Understood." Chu Zihang's tone remained calm. He was not one to argue.

After hanging up, he opened his wardrobe. A long black tennis bag lay in the corner. He unzipped it to reveal a sword hilt wrapped in black rayskin, pressed against a racket. He took the hilt and drew the blade an inch. Iron-blue light flashed, and a chill ran swiftly up his wrist.

The sacred sword Murasame, the demon blade said to produce spring rain after killing, washing away the blood. Someone had cast this nonexistent sword from regenerated metal and enshrined it for ten years to cultivate its murderous aura.

"Did you get your Birkin? I've been on the waiting list for two years. Do you think they only sell them to VIPs?"

"I did. Last time I went to Europe, I bought tens of thousands of yuan worth of little things at Hermès, and the clerk quietly told me they had one in stock. I grabbed it without thinking. But it's alligator skin, and the pattern isn't very pronounced."

"Show-off! You're lucky to get one. When are you going to lend it to me?"

"Give me a kiss, pretty lady, and I'll reward you."

"Drop dead!" A woman curled up on the sofa kicked at the woman opposite with bare feet, which the other caught.

Four women of auntie age giggled, their hair disheveled, makeup smeared, rolling around on the sofa in silk nightgowns and drinking black tea to recover from their hangovers. Last night's three

bottles of cognac had been powerful enough to knock them all out, and they had slept in this state at Chu Zihang's home until the sun was high.

"It's nearly noon. What are we eating?" Someone suddenly felt hungry.

The door opened silently and a tall, slender boy walked in, glancing at the cans scattered across the floor and the four women who had been famous throughout the city for their beauty when young. He frowned. "What a mess. Couldn't you ask Auntie Tong to help clean up?"

"Oh, Zihang, you're so handsome! Come sit with Auntie a while," Auntie Shanshan said happily.

Chu Zihang wore faded blue jeans and a white T-shirt, simply dressed, with the black tennis bag across his body and the scent of freshly washed sandalwood in his hair.

He was no longer a little boy, but a genuine male. The beautiful aunties had no notion of being modest around him: graceful legs sprawled as before, slim waists twisted as before. They had watched him grow up. His mother had been the first of their circle to have a child, and the aunties adored this toy fallen from heaven. His early memories were traumatic: at two or three, enveloped in perfume and powder, scarlet lips all around, aunties competing to carry him and long elegant hands pinching his little bottom...

"I can't stay. I ordered food for you: two eel rice bowls and two teriyaki beef rice bowls," Chu Zihang said. "They'll be here soon."

"How thoughtful!" The aunties' eyes sparkled. Chu Zihang remembered what each of them liked to eat.

He looked at his mother, curled on the sofa under a thin blanket, and shook his head. "The air conditioning's too high. It's down to twenty degrees in here." He picked up the remote and adjusted it. "Air-conditioned rooms are dry. Drink plenty of water."

He went to the window and drew the curtains. "The public walkway is outside. People can see you dressed like that."

The nightgown sisterhood felt a little embarrassed. They nodded and tugged their gowns down over their thighs to show they accepted the correction.

"Going to play tennis?" his mother asked.

"Yes. I may be back late. I'm meeting some high-school classmates," he said. "I brewed your herbal medicine. It's in the refrigerator. Don't stop taking it once you've started, or the little bumps will come back on your face."

"Yes, yes! I remember, good boy. You're getting more and more naggy." His beautiful thirty-nine-year-old mother bounced up, mussed his hair with both hands, and planted a hard kiss on his cheek.

Naggy? Perhaps that came from the man's genes, Chu Zihang thought.

"As long as you remember." He turned and went out.

Later he understood why the man had always fretted about something as small as drinking milk. Perhaps he knew what had been lost could never be recovered and dared not ask for it, and only wanted to do something to show the past had not been an illusion, that he still had a connection to it.

It was a long thread leading back to the past. So long as it remained unbroken, perhaps there was still no despair, and he need not give up hope.

"I just can't resist a boy like your son, so poised and never smiling! My eyes are blinded by his radiance!" Auntie Shanshan announced.

"I can't help fangirling... He's too adorable! If I were twenty years younger, I'd carry him right out of your house!" Auntie Annie clutched her chest.

"As if you'd get a turn before me! Yingying, let Zihang be my godson!" Auntie EB shrieked.

"Dream on! How could my son be carried off by old women like you?" His mother's smug voice suddenly turned to giggles. "Oh, stop tickling, stop tickling! I was kidding, kidding! Shanshan, you can be my son's second mom from today, all right? Oh, I shouldn't have told you where I'm ticklish..."

Chu Zihang closed the door behind him, shutting out the women's clamor.

In the garage, beside the Mercedes S500, stood a new car, dark blue, long and low like a sleeping leopard: a Porsche Panamera, his "dad's" new toy. Dad had generously said Chu Zihang could use it whenever he liked. For one thing, Chu Zihang was a good driver, unlikely to damage it; for another, Dad was happy for his stepson to show their wealth and taste to classmates in his busy absence.

Chu Zihang sat in the driver's seat, lowered the sun visor, and studied his face in the mirror: clear lines, a broad forehead, straight nose, strong brows, and gentle black eyes, the face of a good student. He had been born looking like this. Even on a wanted poster, people would mistake his picture for an outstanding-student certificate.

He looked down and removed two soft black films from his eyes: Johnson & Johnson daily disposable cosmetic contacts, the popular Butterfly Black loved by fashionable girls. He closed his eyes, concentrated, and slowly opened them. Light flared in them like torches dropped into an ancient well!

He brushed back his hair and slowly, deliberately worked his facial muscles. The mirror now held another person: a face hard as a glacier, a flickering golden gleam deep in the pupils like will-o'-the-wisps. No one would willingly meet his eyes now. A savage, spear-sharp presence spread soundlessly; looking into those eyes was like having a gun with its safety off pressed between your brows.

Sometimes even Chu Zihang could not tell which was his real self.

He put on black sunglasses. "Start!"

The 4.8-liter V8 roared, the gears of the seven-speed PDK dual-clutch transmission meshing smoothly and delivering power evenly to all four wheels. The broad tires gripped the ground like a beast's claws curled before a pounce.

The roller door rose slowly. Sunlight poured over the windshield like a waterfall. Chu Zihang released the brake and floored the accelerator. The engine sang, and the Panamera pierced the brilliant curtain of light like a freshly sharpened sword.

Act Two

None of Our Young Classmates Are Losers

Every Junior Has A Good Time

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... At Shilan High School, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

At Sophie Lad Pizza, Lu Mingfei sat alone in a private room... carrying a toilet seat.

Damn it! Was this how you showed up to a Literature Club lunch? He looked like a foreign monk from the Western Regions arriving to wreck the place with some exotic weapon!

He had originally been in high spirits, but a courteous waiter stopped him at the door and knocked him senseless with one blow: "Out! Our restrooms all have squat toilets. We don't buy your toilet seats."

Lu Mingfei knew it looked bad, but what could he do? His aunt's orders outranked heaven. Even his uncle had to kneel on a keyboard if he disobeyed; who was Lu Mingfei to defy the decree? The building-supply market was some distance from his uncle's house, and after calculating every way, he had realized that buying the seat would leave no time to go home before lunch. He had to come straight here. Even then he had jogged all the way with the seat around his neck, feeling as if he wore the breastplate of a sacred suit of armor... and still he was the only one on time.

"Can't these people be more reliable?" The thought made him increasingly angry.

Apart from that, he was nervous. He hadn't seen a certain person in a long time and didn't know what expression to wear. People young and ignorant about love usually showed two symptoms: picking the least unfortunate-looking girl in class as their dream lover and even contemplating marrying her; and believing they could act convincingly before her, trying to produce a smile that would dazzle her without considering that nature had given them a bitter-melon face poorly suited to smiling.

Fortunately Lu Mingfei did not have a bitter-melon face. If he had to be compared to a vegetable, he was more like celery left too long in the sun...

The door opened, and in came someone short and plump, with a round belly no belt could contain.

"What's with that? Carrying a toilet?" The newcomer was startled by Lu Mingfei's appearance.

"Xu Yanyan?" He recognized him.

He was one of the twins in their class. At the Literature Club farewell, Zhao Menghua had declared his love to Chen Wenwen with an illuminated I love you display. Lu Mingfei had played the lowercase i; the Xu brothers had played the o. After a year apart they looked more like o's than ever.

Xu Yanyan looked him up and down. "Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine." Lu Mingfei was a little wooden, still rehearsing his long-awaited reunion smile in his head.

Nervous, Xu Yanyan perched on the edge of a chair and watched him from the corner of his eye.

Lu Mingfei was a legend at Shilan High.

As the city's foremost elite school, Shilan had no shortage of legends. Grade-ten pianists, grade-eight pipa players, and students who had passed College English Test Band Six were as plentiful as fish crossing a river. Each graduating class sent four or five scholarship students to America or Europe, and the school had supplied athletes to the national swim team and produced nationally ranked martial artists. One such fellow looked like a wandering hero, specialized in twin sabers, cut a dashing figure, and came from a wealthy family that chauffeured him in a Lexus. Whenever people saw him seated bolt upright in the rear of a luxury sedan, legs planted as though in a horse stance, two practice blades on his back and red tassels streaming over his shoulders... it was hard not to become a legend.

But once Lu Mingfei rose at Shilan High, every other legend paled.

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... Naturally his grades were miserable, and he had a loose tongue; you never knew what nonsense would come out next. In class he either smiled dreamily out the window or sneaked naps in the back row, drooling all over his desk. No one attended parent-teacher meetings for him; presumably even his uncle and aunt couldn't bear the embarrassment.

At Shilan High, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

His only talent was StarCraft. He made it work, mooching countless hours of internet access and drinks at cafés under the pretext of "teaching matches." Anyone wanting a few pointers only had to say, "Lu Mingfei, let's go to the internet café after school. I'll pay for your time and buy you a Nutritional Express drink," and he would sidle right up, shameless and ingratiating, without a shred of a teacher's dignity.

But legends are often made by a sudden, mysterious rise, blazing across the sky like a meteor!

Before his graduation, at the Literature Club farewell, everyone cheered when golden boy Zhao Menghua and beauty-ranked Chen Wenwen finally confessed and joined hands, while laughing at the legendary Lu for having once entertained improper hopes about someone...

An angel descended, bearing a sword!

A breathtaking young woman in the legendary Lu's service pushed open the doors, her beauty outshining the moon, bringing a whole company of pretty girls and an assortment of handsome clothes for him. She was all demure obedience before Lu Mingfei, and finally took his arm and whisked him away in a Ferrari.

Everyone talked about her beauty and presence: alluring and fierce, flowers and swords flying together. Shilan's boys were astonished and jealous; the girls felt that even all of them together could not match the grace of a single glance from her!

After that, Lu Mingfei shed his loser destiny and his life changed utterly. Soon news came that he had received the largest scholarship in Shilan's history to attend Cassell College, a private elite American university. Its admissions were so strict that all Shilan's top students had been rejected at interview, yet it seemed to beg Lu Mingfei to enroll. Later its principal sent Shilan's principal an enthusiastic letter thanking him for educating such a fine student. Comparing the letter's lavish praise with Lu Mingfei's transcript, which had crawled and struggled along the passing line, the principal felt his entire life had been an illusion.

Xu Yanyan secretly examined Lu Mingfei. After a year apart the legendary figure dressed just as before: a big white T-shirt, baggy shorts, and a pair of very unconvincing imitation Nikes.

As hopelessly uncool as ever.

Xu Yanyan decided to be cautious. With his stunning girl, Ferrari, and immense scholarship, Lu Mingfei had shattered countless people's confidence and risen to number one on Shilan's "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list, an enemy every boy was entitled to kill. People could not bear seeing someone once beneath them rise to a height they had to look up at. But Xu Yanyan couldn't read him and dared not leap out and strike at once to rid the boys of this menace...

Xu Yanyan and Lu Mingfei had actually gotten along reasonably well before, but when someone in the group chat said Lu Mingfei was coming today, Xu's heart still skipped. Lu had been someone nobody respected, and Xu Yanyan had treated him coldly a few times. Now Lu Mingfei was a big shot, looking lost in another world and too indifferent to pay him attention. Who knew whether he held a grudge?

Lu Mingfei had not noticed Xu Yanyan watching. He was practicing his smile again, the corners of his mouth twitching stiffly. To Xu Yanyan it was a smile overflowing with indescribable murderous intent.

"Are you... fixing a toilet?" Xu Yanyan asked cautiously.

"No... I brought my own seat. It's more comfortable." Lu Mingfei didn't understand the question, but nonsense came naturally to his lips.

"Good for you." Xu Yanyan felt even less certain. A man with tens of thousands a year in scholarship money, a wealthy young master fixing toilets? Successful yet humble: a formidable rival indeed!

Another person entered, looking as though cast from the same mold as Xu Yanyan. He glanced at Lu Mingfei and also started. "Lu Mingfei? Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine, I'm fine." Lu Mingfei didn't understand why everyone asked.

The private room fell strangely quiet. Brothers Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao spoke in low voices, stealing occasional glances at the legend opposite them. His gaze was vacant, he smiled from time to time, and he held a toilet seat. Though they couldn't read him, his murderous aura was unmistakable.

Fifteen minutes later people arrived in twos and threes. Every time the door opened a familiar face appeared, startled into asking if Lu Mingfei was all right, until he began to feel a little crazy himself and scratched his head with an embarrassed smile. Finally even Liu Miaomiao, the pretty pianist who rarely took part in Literature Club activities, arrived. The gathering had become a small class reunion. The room grew lively as everyone exchanged news, and fewer people paid attention to Lu Mingfei.

"What's on special?" Xu Yanyan studied the menu.

"Who cares? Zhao Menghua said he's paying for everything today. A fully loaded surf-and-turf pizza each and unlimited cola refills!" Xu Miaomiao announced.

"Country bumpkin! If Young Master Zhao's paying, why pizza? I'll have black-truffle meat-sauce pasta with Caspian caviar!" someone said.

"Keep pretending! Caspian caviar? Do you even know where the Caspian is?" Xu Miaomiao jeered. "That stuff won't fill you up. What's the point?"

"I saw it was the most expensive... I'm sharpening my knife to fleece Zhao Menghua. Haven't you heard? His family's company is going public. It'd be a waste not to!"

"Young Master Zhao's more of a class enemy every day! He's about to overtake..." Xu Miaomiao glanced at Lu Mingfei. "...and become number one on the 'This Villain Must Be Eliminated' list!"

"The boss has always been the class enemy among class enemies," one of Zhao Menghua's followers chimed in.

Only Liu Miaomiao was quiet, sitting obediently with her hands on her knees and smiling with pursed lips. She had always been a pretty girl who spoke softly and seemed a little delicate, looking a year or two younger than the others, with long fair hands, grade-ten piano skills, and sweet, well-behaved eyes. The boys in Lu Mingfei's class had split into three camps: one supporting the "Little Celestial Princess" Su Xiaoqiang, another declaring Liu Miaomiao much prettier than Su, and the rest under Chen Wenwen's banner.

Lu Mingfei let his thoughts wander through his school days. Chen Wenwen had still not arrived.

"You're at Fudan?" he tried, making conversation with Liu Miaomiao.

He had once been a stalwart champion in Chen Wenwen's camp, dismissing Liu Miaomiao as a little kid. In truth he admitted to himself that she was pretty, but he couldn't stand seeing boys flock around her like male attendants to a little goddess. He had even heard two of her admirers confide in each other: "I guess I won't get to marry Liu Miaomiao in this life. I'll let you have her!" The other had thumped his chest and said, "Don't worry. I'll treat her well!"

What kind of brotherly loyalty was that?

But Liu Miaomiao had been nice enough to Lu Mingfei, willing to talk to him. Once, bored, he asked how she practiced piano. She said it was hard work and you had to train finger strength from childhood. Then she played several measures powerfully with one hand against the window, making the glass tremble. Lu Mingfei couldn't produce that effect. He remembered the beautiful patterns of light and shadow her long, slender fingers left on the glass, and never called her a little kid again.

"Mm." Liu Miaomiao nodded.

She wore a Dai-style tube skirt dyed with blue silk-tree blossoms and a white camisole, her hair in a high ponytail. She even had light makeup on. In less than a year the little kid had blossomed; sleazy middle-aged men would probably turn to look if she walked down the street now. A year had passed and everyone seemed to have changed a little. None of their young classmates were losers.

Lu Mingfei glanced at the mirror. The fellow in it looked unlucky, his messy head like a clump of chicken feathers. He wanted to cover his face. Who would have thought Cassell's elite education could produce something like this? He had once read in Zhiyin that whether a person could become an aristocrat depended on their surroundings before age thirteen. Sure enough, a bumpkin was a bumpkin

for life. Even if he drove his Bugatti Veyron here, he wouldn't have Caesar's aura of a crown prince arriving.

Head drooping, he stood to escape the noisy room and wander outside. He pushed the door open. Bang.

Outside was an enormous face with a red mark down the middle, struck by the edge of the glass door.

Zhao Menghua, today's host and benefactor, stared at him as though he'd seen a ghost, unable to understand how Lu Mingfei could remain so calm after hitting him. In the past Zhao had paid for drinks and internet access while Lu flattered him; they had worked together beautifully. Now Lu Mingfei's eyes were vacant, as though he saw no one or his mind was far away.

"I'm fine, I'm fine," Lu Mingfei said hastily, coming to himself. Habit had taken over: those had been his first words to every classmate today.

"I... I'm not!" Zhao Menghua clutched his head.

In the past Zhao would have exploded, but for the moment he didn't dare. He couldn't read Lu Mingfei.

Zhao Menghua had been the city's top scorer in their year's college entrance exams and entered Peking University's Guanghua School of Management. His family had connections, and a place as a Yale exchange student in his junior or senior year was already arranged. Everything was wonderful; he should have been a legend himself. But their year had produced Lu Mingfei, a dark horse as black as a lump of coal, who stole all his glory. Shilan's old principal had no idea what Cassell College was, but when he calculated Lu Mingfei's scholarship at roughly 300,000 yuan a year, he was astounded. When the entrance-exam results were posted, Lu Mingfei's name appeared above top scorer Zhao Menghua, on a line of its own, truly outshining everyone! Zhao gazed up at the huge red notice while the crowd discussed the legendary Lu Mingfei. Him? That lowercase i? Zhao was so depressed he nearly spat blood.

Lu Mingfei went out, Zhao Menghua came in, and the door closed between them. Inside, a chorus called, "Boss!"

In the long corridor, fierce sunlight came from the right, erasing darkness layer by layer. Long shadows of windows and a person lay across the floor. The figure's long hair and skirt hem shifted gently in the breeze. Lu Mingfei slowly turned his head right and saw a white cotton dress and a book held in hands folded over it.

The corridor was long, but unfortunately it was empty. Nothing could obstruct their view of each other.

Silence.

"It's not like I'm meeting my first girlfriend. Why am I such a coward?" All the smiles he had prepared came to nothing. Seeing her again, he still didn't know what expression to wear.

"Chen Wenwen: Lu Mingfei's first unrequited crush, three years long, ended without result; she fell to Zhao Menghua."

If Lu Mingfei had a life file and reread it in old age, that would be all it said about Chen Wenwen. They had never held hands, seen a movie, or traveled together; he had never had the slightest chance. An unremarkable unrequited love. In the gradually fading memories, what sometimes flashed past was

the hem of a white dress on a bench on the first day of school and the light and shadow across the girl's face.

"Hi, Lu Mingfei," Chen Wenwen said.

"Oh, I'm going to the restroom," he said.

They passed each other.

Lu Mingfei wandered around the restroom and returned to find the pizza already served, everyone eating with enthusiasm. The splendid toilet seat lay on his chair, with Chen Wenwen seated beside it. He hesitated, but that was the only seat left. He sat down gingerly and forked a piece of pizza onto his plate. Chen Wenwen smiled and nodded; perhaps she hadn't slept well, for her complexion was poor. After two bites he looked up and realized Zhao Menghua sat opposite them.

"What the hell?" he muttered inwardly.

Chen Wenwen was Zhao Menghua's girlfriend. Naturally she should sit with him.

He worried they were playing another trick on him; it wouldn't be the first. Looking around, he suddenly realized they were seated this way because of him. No one had chosen the seat beside Lu Mingfei, and Chen Wenwen had arrived last, leaving her only that place.

"Should I swap seats with someone?" he asked Chen Wenwen awkwardly.

Chen Wenwen shook her head, busy texting. When she finished she placed her phone face down on the table and began drinking cream-of-mushroom soup. The bowl hid her face; Lu Mingfei couldn't even steal a glance.

Across the room Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. He read the new message, sent a brief reply, and also laid his phone face down.

"Boss, you've really made it!" A follower reached for Zhao's hand.

"Only just noticed?" Zhao shook it, a little uncomfortable. "Why are you shaking my hand? What's this about?"

"Who wants to hold a man's hand? I wanted to see your watch." The follower seized his wrist, revealing a heavy watch whose face shimmered faintly gold and blue. "Rolex?"

"Wow, a Yacht-Master! Caliber 4016! Boss, you're wearing a gold watch!" Some classmates knew their watches.

Everyone put down their pizza and gathered around Zhao's watch. The other side of the table grew lively; here only Chen Wenwen and Lu Mingfei remained among half-eaten slices.

Lu Mingfei wanted to look too. A good watch was always cool to a boy. Though he knew little about watches, he understood their great significance: like monkeys on South Pacific islands stuffing fruit into their cheeks to create a powerful jawline and attract females. Expensive male adornment. Caesar often wore a Patek Philippe, occasionally switching to a Zenith or Glashütte.

But Lu Mingfei didn't move, because Chen Wenwen hadn't. If he joined the crowd, she would be left alone. She was still texting.

The conversation grew livelier. Several boys wore watches and showed them off, also discussing how so-and-so had bought a Jeep to drive around campus, how another had failed three courses because he took golf lessons, and how another never lived in a dorm but rented a serviced apartment for twelve thousand a month. These subjects were far removed from poor Lu Mingfei. Those people

were distant too. The closest person to him now was Chen Wenwen, right before his eyes and as far away as the horizon.

She did not spare him even a glance, texting on and on.

How awkward. Suddenly he missed Fingel. If his useless senior were here, he clearly wouldn't be embarrassed... He'd seize the opportunity to drag the lobster pizza over to himself! Lu Mingfei felt a sudden delight and quietly pulled the whole freshly served lobster pizza close. Smelling the melted cheese, he felt better and laughed without thinking.

The laugh sounded so lewd and sleazy that everyone turned at once. The room suddenly fell quiet.

Lu Mingfei ducked his head.

Chen Wenwen pressed Send.

Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. "You have a new message."

Lu Mingfei knew whom she was texting. Suddenly it all became clear, a startling discovery: so this was the great advantage of having a girlfriend! Even if you didn't sit together at dinner you could text, talking slowly in a noisy crowd... whether to go out this weekend... whether yesterday's beef-noodle shop was good... a great comic you'd read lately... the flower you'd planted in the botanical garden last year had sprouted... Beep, back and forth.

However noisy the surroundings, the two of you still had a world of your own, quiet enough to hear a flower seed lost in the shade beneath a window last spring begin to sprout.

How literary. Literary enough to make a person sad.

Lu Mingfei's battle-tested eyes were blinded by envy, jealousy, and resentment. Why hadn't he noticed before? Oh, so that was it. He never knew how close other people were in private... He was always an idiot. His thoughts ran wild, and he grinned silently. Sometimes when he didn't know what expression to wear, he smiled like a fool.

Zhao Menghua retrieved his Rolex and put it on. "Eat, everyone, eat."

Liu Miaomiao sat nearby silently looking at her phone. Everyone else returned to their seats, chewing pizza and cursing some professor for being such a maniac.

The atmosphere was strangely stifling.

"I'm going to the restroom." Lu Mingfei stood.

At the waiter's "squat toilet," Lu Mingfei held a wad of paper and assumed the standard squatting position, but he was actually thinking. Suddenly many things tumbled through his mind.

On Nono's birthday, her official boyfriend Caesar had been leading the Student Council's lovely girls in white lace dresses around campus with submachine guns to slay a dragon, while Lu Mingfei and Nono watched the stars by the cold spring on the hill. Nono had placed her phone on a rock, waiting for someone's birthday wishes. He had sat beside her, kicking the icy water, feeling in tune with the red-haired little witch. Later he had given her a sky full of fireworks. His heart had stirred with foolish hopes.

One afternoon he and Chen Wenwen had classroom-cleaning duty. She sat on the teacher's platform with a faint smile, head bowed over her phone. He happily waved his mop and ran around, because in a world the size of the classroom only he and Chen Wenwen existed. He felt incredibly close to her, as if even holding hands wasn't impossible. Foolish hopes stirred.

At the Literature Club graduation gathering, he and Chen Wenwen returned from booking movie tickets and walked beside the river. She texted with her head down, her sleeve brushing his shoulder. A little deer bounded in his heart... No! Hundreds of two-and-a-half-meter stags with huge antlers crashed exuberantly around his chest, making his nose threaten to bleed and his face glow. He felt the moment belonged to him and Chen Wenwen and wished the road could stretch to the edge of the sky... Foolish hopes stirred...

Damn it! Was "foolish hopes stirring" all worth writing in the history of his love life?

Every time his hopes stirred, the other person had been sending or awaiting a text. A young hero and heroine ride one horse across a vast grassland, sky wide, clouds low, a lone goose calling in the west wind; he in white, she in red, and he wishes the moment could last forever. Meanwhile the heroine's lips move as she uses a long-distance voice technique to exchange love songs with her boyfriend far to the south. What kind of crap plot was that? What garbage writer would create such a pathetic male lead?

But if Lu Mingfei lived in a book... the book had been written by a garbage writer... and he was that utterly pathetic male lead.

No, not the lead. Just passerby A, B, C, or D.

Sometimes he thought Nono and Caesar didn't talk much and didn't seem particularly close... and foolish hopes stirred. But they were boyfriend and girlfriend, for heaven's sake. When Nono and Caesar were alone together... did they hold hands? Hug? Kiss? Damn it, Boss Caesar looked every inch a handsome, debauched, sex-starved devil!

The saddest thing in the world was secretly loving a girl while she happily shared her life with someone else. While you walked alone in moonlight, thinking of her in literary sorrow, under that same moon she held someone's hand, leaned into someone's arm, and kissed someone's lips... The air was full of the hormones of mutual desire...

Lu Mingfei picked at a crack in the floor tiles in grief and indignation, convinced no one in the vast world was sadder than he. Then he remembered he was in a restroom, and that crack in the tiles... A wave of nausea abruptly halted the melancholy literary mood in his head.

A text chimed. With the finger that had picked the tile crack held up delicately, Lu Mingfei extracted his phone and opened it.

"Happy birthday, wishing you a happy birthday, happiness every day of your life, never mind how you spend your birthday... I've learned Zheng Zhihua's 'Happy Birthday.' It's the first Chinese song I can sing. The attachment is my recording, your birthday present. As you know, your senior is dirt poor, so let's skip gifts that cost money." Sender: Useless Senior.

That was his roommate Fingel. Lu Mingfei had given him that name in his contacts as revenge: Fingel listed Lu Mingfei as Idiot Junior.

Lu Mingfei was touched. It was rare for anything in his useless senior's shaggy head to remember his birthday. The emotion didn't last long... because he couldn't resist opening the attachment. Fingel sang in German-accented Mandarin, wildly off-key being a perfect description, but he put force into every word and had clearly made an effort. Only... wasn't this "Happy Birthday" that song by the old-school literary singer from the 1980s?

"Your birthday reminds me of a friend from long ago. It was a cold winter, and he wandered the streets. I thought he wanted to beg for something, but he always shook his head..." Fingel sang on with extravagant feeling.

Was a song this miserable really a birthday greeting? It sounded more like something to play at his grave. Lu Mingfei covered his face and sighed deeply.

He closed the attachment, pulled up his baggy shorts, and stood. Looking up, he saw a line of neat writing on the partition: "I'm very boyish... seeking a lesbian... phone 138XXXXXXXX."

"Someone looking for a lesbian in the men's room?" He stared.

Wait!

His head buzzed. Something was wrong! Seeking a lesbian in the men's room plainly defied ordinary logic, but with a different way of thinking... everything made sense!

Damn it! Depressed when he came in, he hadn't checked the sign on the door!

Holding up his shorts, half squatting, legs weak, he couldn't stand up. No way. The wrong room again? Once was an accident, twice was natural absentmindedness, three times... that was a hobby!

He rapidly considered countermeasures. There was no time for hesitation. Only a few meters separated the stall from the door; if no one noticed, he could sprint out in three to five seconds. He tried combing his hair forward to hide his face. The look might barely pass for... a tomboy?

He pricked up his ears. It was quiet outside; apparently still safe. Relieved, he fastened his shorts and loosened his ankles as though preparing for a hundred-meter sprint.

"Did you tell her or not?" A girl's voice came from the corridor outside.

"It has nothing to do with her. Why should I?" a boy answered impatiently.

"If you don't tell her she'll find out sooner or later. Can you avoid seeing each other forever?"

"You know what she's like. She's exhausting, moping all day. What good would telling her do? She'd cling to me as though I owed her something."

"Don't talk about her like that... When you were together, didn't you say she was pretty nice?" The girl's voice grew quieter.

"How was I supposed to know what she was like at first? Oversensitive for no reason, playing gloomy one moment, pitiful the next, then unbearably bossy, as if the world had to revolve around her. Whoever wants to cater to her can do it. I'm done!"

"If we broke up someday... you wouldn't talk about me like that too, would you?"

"Come on, you're different from her. I'd never say that about you. I tell everyone how great you are... Damn, wrong answer. That day will never come. We won't break up! I'd have to hit my head to break up with you." The boy laughed ingratiatingly.

"Stop it! Why are you all over me?"

"Pretty skirt... Did you buy it in Yunnan?"

The jumbled sounds of kissing, fabric rubbing, footsteps, and soft murmurs faded away. Lu Mingfei turned to stone, his head buzzing.

Zhao Menghua and Liu Miaomiao had just passed along the corridor outside.

"Kissing and groping right there. Did they think I didn't exist?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

Of their three class beauties, Chen Wenwen, Liu Miaomiao, and Su Xiaoqiang, Zhao Menghua had hooked two: when the class flowers bloomed, he was the one smiling among them... A real winner in life. Once Lu Mingfei understood, righteous indignation filled him! Not just for himself, but for all the boys in class. There were already more boys than girls, and Zhao was taking more than his share! What was this? A waste of resources!

He was also a little dazed. The world changed so quickly. It was as though you looked up and everyone had gone far ahead, leaving you, a little kid, standing where you were.

He pushed open the stall door and walked out, then abruptly stopped.

In the mirror above the sinks he saw Sadako: white dress, black hair hanging over her face. Both hands were beneath the faucet, but the water wasn't running. She stood frozen in the posture of washing them.

At that moment he would rather it had really been Sadako, slowly crawling out of the mirror. At worst he could have screamed, "A ghost!"

But it was Chen Wenwen.

"I-I... came into the wrong restroom..." he explained. Only after speaking did he realize how irrelevant that was.

As though she hadn't seen him, Chen Wenwen turned on the faucet, wet her hands, and patted water onto her face. Her phone lay on the sink. When she reached for it, she fumbled; it clattered to the floor and slid across the tiles toward Lu Mingfei.

He slowly bent to pick it up, looked at her expression, and carefully offered it back. His curiosity was too strong. His eyes darted to the messages on the screen. Chen Wenwen used an iPhone too; its messaging system displayed all the texts with one person like a chat log, stringing scattered memories together.

"You're not wearing the bracelet I gave you last birthday..."

"Did you get my text just now? The one about the bracelet..."

"Got it. I'm not wearing it today. Too hot."

"Yes, it's too hot. I couldn't sleep last night, kept thinking about the past. I could only sleep an hour or two at a time. Did you sleep well?"

"All right. Drink a glass of milk before bed and you'll sleep."

"Do you still think about me?"

"Don't overthink it. We're still classmates."

"Last night I dreamed I was rowing down a river. I texted to ask where you were, and you said you were waiting on the bridge ahead. I rowed forward, but there was fog everywhere and I rowed a long time without seeing a bridge. I texted again and you said you were still waiting on the bridge. I wondered if it was behind me and rowed hard back, but the current was too fast, so I kept going forward... Then I woke up."

"Don't overthink it. Calm your mind and you won't dream."

"Do you understand what the dream means?"

"Yes, but I don't want to hear it. There's no point. Saying less is better for both of us."

"You don't want to hear me anymore. Do you have a new girlfriend?"

"Stop asking! We're at a gathering today. Let me eat in peace! You keep texting, and Lu Mingfei beside you can see!"

"Don't be angry. If you've found a new girlfriend, I'll wish..."

That final text was unfinished. Now there was no need to send it.

Want to wish them well? Easy: go out at once, buy flowers, rush in, and give them to Liu Miaomiao, saying, Little sister, you're wonderful; I can rest easy knowing Zhao Menghua is with you... But was that really what she wanted to say? Bless them? Bullshit. Even Lu Mingfei, whose romantic experience was a blank canvas fit for the most beautiful picture, wouldn't fall for it!

His face twitched. He didn't know what expression to wear.

Actually he had reason to smile smugly. The girl you once liked gave you a polite rejection and threw herself into the arms of a glamorous young prince, and now he'd dumped her. If the petty heart inside you didn't laugh a little, who would believe it? Karma never failed! Ha ha ha! Shouldn't you kick her while she was down, saying, "You thought I was a loser, but my feelings were sincere and dependable. What did that playboy have apart from money and looks?" Or you could be more gentlemanly and say considerately, "It'll pass. Who hasn't had their heart broken?" while secretly exulting, That's for kicking me aside!

But Lu Mingfei only scratched his head and sighed.

He was too timid, so timid he scarcely had a vengeful thought. In a dream Lu Mingze had asked, "Don't you want revenge on the world?" Lu Mingfei had never really thought about it. Not only that, he constantly handed out sympathy, even to Chen Wenwen, who had given him the polite rejection.

Reading the messages, he felt that Chen Wenwen was exhausted and had used all her strength. Her face was wet and pale, so tired it hurt to see.

"Don't look," she said softly, taking the phone from his hand and switching off the screen. "It's all right."

"Oh, okay." He nodded quickly.

Chen Wenwen lifted her long white skirt to wipe her face, arranged her hair, took a deep breath, and straightened her chest. A resentful woman? Not at all. She looked more like Joan of Arc going into battle.

"Don't say anything. Promise." She looked at Lu Mingfei in the mirror.

She had always spoken to him like that. In the Literature Club, when she assigned him something such as arranging the venue, she would say, "Make sure it's arranged. Promise," as if his promise could really guarantee anything.

"Mm. I promise." As before, he raised his hand.

They returned to the room, where a fresh round of pizza had arrived. Everyone was cheerful. It seemed the party was livelier without the two of them.

Lu Mingfei ate absently, watching the people around him. They all seemed different now. He noticed details: Zhao Menghua took two slices and tore one off for Liu Miaomiao; she absentmindedly drank his cola; the boys who used to praise her beauty no longer stole glances at the slender legs beneath her skirt; Zhao and Liu sat close together and far from the others.

Suddenly he understood. When it came to feelings he was a complete idiot. He had never understood other people's looks. Everything he thought he knew was wrong.

Zhao Menghua glanced at Chen Wenwen opposite him, a strange light flashing in his eyes. He cleared his throat and reached into his pocket like a leader about to make a speech. Liu Miaomiao hurriedly pulled at him under the table, but he shook her off.

Lu Mingfei suddenly felt uneasy. He didn't know what Zhao intended, but instinct told him it would be idiotic, stupid, and had to be stopped, even if that meant pouring a glass of cola over his head.

Damn it, why was his glass always empty at moments like this?

Zhao stood with a blue velvet jewelry box in hand and looked around the table. "Since everyone's here today, I'll announce something..." He glanced down at Liu Miaomiao, who instinctively avoided his eyes, cheeks flushed as though she had drunk a great deal.

He opened the box. Inside was a Tiffany platinum wire ring. "Nobody's allowed to pursue Liu Miaomiao anymore. Anyone who does answers to me... We're getting engaged. This is the engagement ring."

Everyone fell silent. Though they knew about Zhao and Liu, engagement... in freshman year? What grand family still played the engagement game?

"Boss, your family actually lets you get engaged?" a follower asked.

"Hell, my mom kept saying if I thought she was right, I should make it official. Mom bought the ring herself. What? Got a problem? I'm telling you so nobody tries to pursue her without knowing and runs into a wall." Zhao grinned and surveyed the table, his eyes not pausing on Chen Wenwen.

"Of course it's fine! So that's why we're having lunch. If I'd known, I'd have bought a present," the follower said quickly.

"Zhao Menghua, you're ruthless. Engaged as soon as you win her over, leaving us brothers no hope at all," someone congratulated him with a mournful face.

"Then we should order a few beers."

"Bumpkin! For something this big it has to be champagne. You think Zhao Menghua can't afford it? If we don't fleece him now, when will we?"

"Come on, put the ring on her! Pictures! Can we post them in the alumni group?"

"Happy now? I've told everyone." Zhao grinned at Liu Miaomiao. "Now you're tied to me for good... marry a carrying pole and you have to carry it around..."

"Stop it..." She lowered her head and pinched his waist.

"Ow, look, she's hitting me..." Zhao laughed and teased his girlfriend—no, now his fiancée.

While the room buzzed with celebration, outside everyone's gaze, a person silently crumbled, as though consumed by fire until only ashes remained.

"Hey, man, you..." Someone stood, the corner of his eye twitching, and stared at Zhao Menghua. "Have you no decency?"

The room fell dead silent. Everyone looked at Lu Mingfei as though they had seen Godzilla.

Lu Mingfei understood why Zhao had done it. He had to give his current girlfriend an assurance. Anyone who landed Liu Miaomiao would be so happy he'd parade around campus banging a lunch basin and blowing snot bubbles, wishing everyone knew he had claimed that flower. Zhao had been

fairly careful today, holding back because Chen Wenwen didn't know yet. But Liu had a knot in her heart, and Zhao had to make a gesture. By evening news of the engagement would spread across the school; everyone would know what a devoted boyfriend he was, and from then on Zhao and Liu would be bound together openly and properly.

But Lu Mingfei had something to say. He wanted to say... She already knows, she's been struggling to hold herself together and can't much longer, she won't text you anymore or nag you... What are you showing off for with your arm around your new girlfriend? We all know how cool and handsome you are, big brother! Of course you won't lack girlfriends! Your life must be wonderfully happy, with a girlfriend to eat late-night snacks with, unlike a loser like me... Oh, right, nothing to do with me... In short, all those thousands of words came down to one sentence:

"You're already happy... just leave her a way to live!"

Lu Mingfei delivered his bold, powerful speech in his head, but not one word escaped his mouth.

He glanced at Chen Wenwen, who was close to falling apart, and sighed. He knew her personality: if he said those things, she would suffer most.

So he could only puff out his cheeks and glare at Zhao Menghua with eyes that were neither quite timid nor quite arrogant, so much white showing around the irises. In high school his homeroom teacher had once said before the whole class, "Lu Mingfei, are you really that useless? Are you a dead weight? You alone dragged our class average down half a point. You're unbelievable." Lu had answered with the same stare, impossible to tell whether it was stupidity or defiance, and made the teacher's heart race.

Lu Mingfei was confident that stare was still quite lethal... Apart from that he didn't have much killing power.

Actually, playing the brave young defender was not for him; this was the situation he handled worst. He instinctively feared awkward scenes. Watching Tom Hanks in Cast Away, for example, Hanks lived like a savage on an island for years after a plane crash, yearning to return to his wife and child. After endless hardship he finally got home, emotions surging at the door—Hanks didn't yet know his wife had remarried, but Lu Mingfei watching did. So he would urgently change channels to avoid embarrassment that had nothing to do with him. He couldn't bear the door opening and Hanks seeing his wife approach in tears on a strange man's arm. Even a movie scene was unbearable.

But this time his brain had overheated and he had run right into the scene himself, playing a passerby with a sense of justice. Really, what the hell did any of it have to do with him?

Zhao Menghua's face twisted, his brow knotted as though the god Erlang's third eye lay hidden there, ready to open and stare the damned monkey before him to death.

"None of your damn business!" He spat the words like a deadly dart from an outlaw's mouth.

"You're right," Lu Mingfei said.

Zhao froze. He had prepared several more concise and vicious replies for when Lu finished talking tough. But Lu Mingfei had readily admitted it.

Yet Lu didn't move away, still holding that wide-eyed stare.

"What do you want?" Zhao stepped forward.

"Nothing." It was true. Lu hadn't had time to think. Given a minute to consider, he might well have retreated.

Zhao nearly broke down, veins jumping in his neck, but several friends held him back. "We're classmates... Forget it, forget it."

Zhao took a deep breath, glared at Lu, and forced out through his teeth, "Pay the bill! We're leaving! What are we eating for? I've lost my appetite! I'll take you all somewhere else for Italian tonight!"

Lu Mingfei breathed easier. Good. Let it end here, leaving room to retreat. Hybrids were supposed to have exceptional physical abilities; Caesar's beautiful Student Council combat squad could take on 200-pound wrestlers in high heels and evening gowns. But that advantage had never appeared in Lu Mingfei, and he had yet to take a fighting class. If it came to blows, two of him would be no match for Zhao. He glanced at Chen Wenwen. She stared blankly into a corner, as though the scene had nothing to do with her.

"The emperor isn't worried, but the eunuch is..." Lu Mingfei muttered inwardly.

The bill came. Zhao pulled several notes from his wallet and tossed them onto the tray, then thought better of it, took one back, and pointed at Lu. "This one pays for himself! Nothing to do with me!"

"Fine, I'll pay for myself." Lu wasn't afraid of that; instead, his spirits rose.

A Cassell student ID was also an American Express credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit! Though he was penniless, he could borrow from an American bank by swiping it! Without thinking he took out his student card. Nicknamed the black card, it had a matte-black surface stamped in pure silver with the college emblem, the half-rotten World Tree. With the gesture of an emperor handing out a tip, he held it between two fingers and passed it to the server.

"We don't take library cards..." The young waitress spoke timidly.

Dark lines covered Lu Mingfei's face. "Get the card machine... I'll show you..."

Someone drew a sharp breath. The back of the card bore both the Citi Bank and American Express logos. Shilan students considered themselves worldly and knew what an American Express black card meant. The highest black card had no spending limit and was called the Centurion; only a very small number of credit cards were permitted to be pure black.

The waitress quickly brought the terminal. Lu entered his PIN with an air of surveying all beneath him, spinning the pen in his palm as he waited for the slip to sign.

"Fake. Declined," the waitress said in her local accent, the words sounding like "tragedy."

It really was a tragedy. The terminal displayed PAYMENT DECLINED.

Sweating coldly, Lu swiped the black card he carried everywhere, the symbol of his incomparable S-rank status, again and again. It was refused each time, as though the mighty organization in North America had abandoned him.

Someone laughed, and sneers rose around the room.

"Pay cash," someone said mildly.

The door opened and air stirred, like breaking the clay seal on a jar to let in a cool breeze. The young man entering placed several large notes in the black billfold and returned it to the waitress. "Keep the change."

Only a class enemy could utter such punchable words; normally anyone hearing them ought to give him the finger. But this boy spoke with natural detachment, without a trace of showiness. No one

noticed how he had suddenly entered, without a sound. He wore faded jeans and a white T-shirt, enormous sunglasses, and no expression on the half of his face visible.

Such a figure looked ordinary enough to be found on any street, nothing remarkable. But Liu Miaomiao suddenly stood, staring at him, tense.

Lu Mingfei also sprang up, tense. But his tension was different from hers. His instinct was that something had happened; why else would these human-dragon hybrids come looking for him during summer break? And he knew exactly why this fellow carried a tennis bag. Whenever he appeared with any long object, you had to be careful: repeated experience showed he would inevitably draw a blade from it.

"How much longer until lunch ends? The college has something for us to do. I'm here to assist you," the boy told Lu. "Waiting for you to start, boss."

Boss? This fellow called him boss? Lu thought he was hearing things. Don't joke! Since when was he this man's boss? Boss Caesar had wanted to take over the Lionheart Society for years, only to be repelled head-on by this harmless-looking fellow.

Yet it didn't seem to be a joke. This man supposedly had no sense of humor whatsoever.

"Chu Zihang. We're all alumni." The boy briefly removed his sunglasses, then put them back on.

This time everyone turned to stone.

For Shilan students three years above or below him, "Chu Zihang" was a symbol, always far out of reach.

You knew his name and had seen him, but couldn't quite remember his face, because you rarely had a chance to get close.

At graduation he spoke for the student body in a sea-blue uniform, head lowered over his notes and bangs hiding his face. On the basketball court he played center, devastating opponents and leaping to dunk; by the time the ball landed he was already turning back toward midcourt, not even high-fiving teammates. At the Spring Festival show he played a cello solo of the theme from Schindler's List. While the audience remained immersed in the music, thinking his talent belonged on the national gala, Chu Zihang had already packed his cello, bowed, and left the stage, leaving only a slender back.

In Liu Miaomiao's memory, every time she saw Chu Zihang it was raining.

Beyond the eaves rain fell in curtains, mist drifting between the strands. Chu Zihang stood under the roof in a brown denim overshirt, a scarf tied at the collar, hands in his pockets. A bag hung from one shoulder, bulging with what was obviously a basketball. He bent slightly like bamboo in the wind, its joints firm. Faint daylight haloed his dark silhouette.

Liu Miaomiao walked forward surrounded by girls from her class. It felt as though hundreds of little frogs had been stuffed into her heart, jumping furiously. She talked and laughed with the girls as they approached that figure. Each step closer seemed long, so long that time nearly stopped. At last she stood behind him. Chu Zihang politely shifted aside and nodded. She noticed his bangs were wet from the rain, hanging over his eyes.

Time resumed its normal pace. Chu Zihang and Liu Miaomiao passed each other.

After walking a long way, she suddenly turned her head and asked, "Can you see if I have a pimple?" Her classmates leaned close and said no. She said good, it had felt itchy, and quietly withdrew her backward glance.

Through layers of rain Chu Zihang still stood there. Liu Miaomiao had always thought he liked rainy days. Whenever it rained, he seemed so absorbed that she wanted to brush his soaked bangs aside and see his eyes.

Chu Zihang had used his life to define one word: awesome.

So awesome that even a meteoric force like Lu Mingfei could only prostrate himself beneath Brother Chu's slim-fit jeans. The true hidden number one on the "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list would always be Chu Zihang.

For Liu Miaomiao and many girls at Shilan, Chu Zihang taught them the meaning of an unrequited crush. But he seemed unaware of his mastery in this field, and people misunderstood him. His face was simply expressionless, yet many thought he was pretending to be cool. He didn't like rainy days at all; he stared into space when it rained because he wondered whether that Maybach might come to pick him up again...

Chu Zihang attracted countless admirers but was dense to an extraordinary degree. He was like one of the Easter Island stone statues gazing out to sea; blossoms falling on him were utterly wasted.

Why must he be eliminated? If the many Shilan boys dating girls in their class discovered the same man's shadow had already invaded their girlfriends' hearts, it would be strange if they didn't want to destroy him!

"Thanks, thanks. You're a real friend, senior." Whatever the circumstances, Lu Mingfei was grateful for Chu Zihang's sudden appearance. "I'll pay you back when we get home."

"It's nothing. You're the boss today; you make the calls," Chu Zihang said calmly.

Lu stared. The act was getting more convincing. Who was he to deserve this? It would be an honor to polish the president's shoes, and he dared call himself boss in public? But Chu looked as if to say this was a fact not worth discussing, so he could only keep quiet.

The crowd murmured in amazement. They had known Boss Lu was astonishing, but not that he was so modest, displaying only two parts of his twelve-part greatness. Even Chu Zihang called him boss; surely he had built a vast empire in his year in America. How gracious of him to condescend to eat pizza with his old classmates. That also explained his lack of cash: underlings always paid, so why would the boss settle the bill himself?

"The car's waiting outside." Chu held the door and gestured for him to go first.

Chu's icy expression made Lu uncertain what was happening. The courtesy lay somewhere between a bodyguard addressing his boss and the CIA addressing a terrorist with nowhere left to run. He realized refusal wasn't an option and walked out with his head down.

Chu followed without missing a step, their footsteps echoing down the hall. Lu thought of the people watching him from behind, eyes full of envy and resentment, but he didn't feel honored at all.

Damn, what rotten luck. It wasn't his business, so why had he stepped in? And once he did, even his credit card had proved as useless as he was. The president had rescued him, but what did that amount to? Every scrap of face Lu Mingfei had ever enjoyed had been provided by his seniors. Not once had he stood up and been impressive on his own. He was like a little kid beaten up in a fight, face covered in snot, who went home to fetch his big brother. Others feared you a little, but never respected you, because even with a fierce, stone-faced fighting brother and a gorgeous, long-legged sister, you were still a little kid with snot on your face.

You are incapable. You are useless.

Chu Zihang opened the Panamera's door. Pure white leather racing seats welcomed the honored guest.

Suddenly Lu Mingfei stopped, turned, and ran back!

The people talking at the door to the private room backed away in alarm and made a path. Lu had returned at a hundred-meter sprint, bristling with murderous intent.

He walked up to Chen Wenwen and reached out... seized the toilet seat leaning against his chair... and dashed out of the door.

Chen Wenwen said nothing, gently brushing her long bangs aside.

"Headquarters has assigned a mission. You're the agent and I'm assisting, so you're the boss today. It's not a joke." Chu handed Lu an iPad and skillfully steered one-handed as the Panamera joined the stream of traffic.

Lu Mingfei could hardly believe his ears. A mission with him in charge? What task could he excel at enough to have Chu Zihang assist him? Unless they were going as a team to challenge the Deyun Society at comic dialogue, with Lu as the funny man and Chu as his straight man...

But the iPad ran a Cassell-developed interface directly connected to Norma, and his name was plainly listed under AGENT. After reading the details, Lu Mingfei felt lost in a fog. Was this a criminal investigation? But Field Investigation seemed to be a junior-year elective. He was a complete novice in that area... apart from watching Detective Conan movies.

The air conditioning raised goosebumps on his skin. He glanced timidly at Chu Zihang; the hard profile was expressionless and showed no intention of explaining to the person in charge what to do.

His courage failed. He sank into the seat and stared blankly out the window. He was in a bad mood. When Chen Wenwen had brushed back her hair, he had seen her dreadful face. Ugly—she had never looked so ugly, tears clinging to pale skin, eyes swollen... like a little goldfish. Where was the girl of his dreams? Once she had sat at one end of a bench in a white cotton dress reading Duras's The Lover, her spotless fairy aura seeming to banish sunlight and dust alike. Every fairy, apparently, would one day fall for an idiot and knit him sweaters, loving and resentful, and from then on her life was a downhill road of no return. At such a time a toad like Lu Mingfei, who had never tasted swan flesh, ought to clap in delight, but for some reason his heart clenched and he suddenly grew irritable.

"I listened outside the room for two minutes."

Lu Mingfei nearly jumped out of his skin. Chu had spoken without warning. The flat statement sounded like a threat: I know what you did last summer.

Would the president take an interest in his useless junior's petty gossip and silently listen for two minutes? For a man with Chu Zihang's rigorously organized schedule, what could possibly be important enough to stop him for two minutes?

"You should inform your card issuer of your travel plans. Otherwise, if they see the card used in another place, they'll suspect theft and temporarily freeze the account," Chu said. "I know you liked Chen Wenwen at school."

Lu Mingfei's heart lost its rhythm and his face flushed purple. Even when Fingel exposed his feelings for Nono, he hadn't reacted so strongly.

Nono's beauty was dazzling and sharp, an angel bearing a sword, sometimes madly loyal to her friends. Any man ought to like Nono; Lu suspected Fingel liked her too. He had never imagined Nono dumping Caesar and falling into his arms... All right, given their relative strength, Nono would take him into hers. It was pure admiration: a lovely lady, a worthy gentleman's desire, and a loser's desire too. Nothing to be ashamed of, as long as Boss Caesar didn't know.

But Chen Wenwen was different. Chen Wenwen was a secret. When he had been innocent and still capable of embarrassment, he had thought marrying her would be the happiness of his life. He never tired of sitting beside her on a bench reading all afternoon, running Literature Club errands at her heels like an eager little dog. Back then he had never liked anyone else, wasn't thick-skinned, and had experienced nothing momentous. He was an uncool boy weaving a future with this girl in his heart. If she had nodded, he would have impatiently placed his whole life in her hands for her to command... But she hadn't chosen him.

He always wanted to find a hollow tree and bury that story in it, because it was embarrassing, or... because the feeling of loving someone like that was so tender that if people knew, they might touch it and break it.

"You... you..."

"Probably the whole school knew," Chu added.

"Senior, don't make it sound so scary. The whole school? Our high school banned dating!" Lu felt as if struck by five thunderbolts. "If everyone really knew, wouldn't the dean have dragged me off to confess my wrongdoing?"

"He didn't because he knew you had no chance. He didn't need to concern himself with your fantasies."

"But surely not the whole school?"

"Someone else liked Chen Wenwen and told people you liked her as a joke. So the whole school knew."

Lu stared. "Zhao Menghua?"

Chu did not answer.

Lu sat stunned for a long time, suddenly very tired. Nono had said everyone had played him at the Literature Club farewell. But he hadn't wanted to believe it. He thought he had hidden his feelings well; a few people making fun of him wouldn't matter as long as Chen Wenwen wasn't one of them. He would rather she had never known he liked her and therefore chosen Zhao. But if even Chu Zihang could recount his romantic history in detail...

He was that i, lowercase, a very small "I"... but with no love and no you.

"I don't mind you standing on the seat, but at this speed it's unsafe," Chu said.

Only then did Lu realize he had somehow crouched on the luxurious leather seat, arms around his knees, chin resting on them—a posture somewhere between an elderly northern Shaanxi farmer on a field ridge and a stray dog taking a rest. He hurriedly jumped down, wiped at his shoeprints, and smiled awkwardly.

"It's all right. You weren't saying anything, so I was finding a topic to talk about," Chu said coldly.

Lu was dumbfounded. Huh? What did that mean? Was this merely the president's icebreaker, like the table-tennis diplomacy that opened relations between China and America? He hadn't had time to

wonder why Chu had turned to Chen Wenwen instead of discussing the mission. Was this heart-souring subject merely the stone-faced senior's friendly small talk to break the silence between them? Damn! Table tennis would have been better!

"I'm not Conan..." Lu tried to discuss business.

"Chen Wenwen knew you liked her but pretended she didn't. She wasn't good to you and treated you as a follower. Yet you still stood up for her?" Chu cut off his topic like a blade.

Lu was unaccustomed to such forceful questioning and froze.

"Because she's vulnerable now and you pity her?" Chu shot him a cold glance.

"She was never bad to me. I liked her; that had nothing to do with her." Lu grew anxious.

"Zhao Menghua was unhappy because Chen Wenwen was his girlfriend. She still loves him, and psychologically he still feels possessive toward her. He can discard her, but he doesn't want anyone else standing up for her." Chu raised an eyebrow. "Why did you?"

The cold, pressing tone was like a knife digging into his heart. Lu suddenly grew angry. He didn't want to discuss this, but Chu insisted. What did Chu Zihang want? He was only a senior, only president of the Lionheart Society. Lu Mingfei was an underling of Student Council President Caesar, with no connection to the society. Why must he report his romantic history to its president? They were only doing a mission together; afterward they would go their separate ways! What was Chu trying to ask? Did he only want Lu to admit he was an idiot? That girl had set him up and embarrassed him publicly, yet now he insisted on standing up for her?

"All right, I know what you're going to say. I'm an idiot. I'm useless and still try to play the hero, but I... I can't stand seeing someone treated unfairly." Lu turned hard toward the window, raising his voice. "Anyway, senior, you'd never be treated unfairly! You've been outstanding all your life. You don't understand!"

The Panamera braked suddenly, tires screeching against the road, and stopped dead in the middle of the street.

"Get out," Chu said.

"What?" Lu was bewildered. The sudden stop had almost given him a concussion. What had he said wrong to be thrown out? Could it be... the president had secretly loved Chen Wenwen for years too, and hearing his rival pour out his heart had made him sulk?

"Get out and wait for me. I have something to do. I'll be right back." Chu was expressionless.

Sitting in someone else's luxury sports car, arguing was pointless. Lu obediently got out and stood by the road. Chu shifted into reverse and floored the accelerator. The Panamera accelerated backward into traffic with smoke rising from all four wheels, retracing their route.

Lu stared. He had never seen anyone drive so outrageously. He didn't know this was a driving style inherited in certain families.

Sunlight stung the skin, hot air rising in wisps from the asphalt. Chen Wenwen trailed far behind the group. Through the heat the boy's back ahead of her looked distorted.

Everything was distorted.

"Hey, sister-in-law, do you eat foie gras?" someone called.

"No, it's too salty. I'll have a salad. You eat what you like," Liu Miaomiao answered absently.

"Boss, it's burning up. Why are we wandering outside? Let's get ice cream at Cold Stone," another said.

"Save room for dinner." Zhao Menghua's voice came faintly.

The conversation was distant, yet seemed close to her ear.

Sometimes people couldn't help listening closely to words that pierced the heart. Perhaps their brains had short-circuited...

Chen Wenwen looked down at her white sandals. Again and again, her slender fair feet emerged beneath her skirt as she shuffled forward.

When she was still with Zhao, he had come to school to see her and they had walked under the lights after dinner. She had walked with her head down then too. Students passed on their way back from evening study, and whenever someone called, "Chen Wenwen, is this your boyfriend?" her face burned, as if it were embarrassing, yet she felt so happy. Zhao would throw an arm firmly around her shoulders and grin as he greeted them.

Now she still couldn't lift her head. Not from embarrassment, but because it felt so heavy it might break her neck.

Zhao Menghua was annoyed. Since leaving Sophie Lad Pizza, Chen Wenwen had followed them, inexplicably refusing to leave.

What was the point of clinging now? It was over, and she was acting like a resentful wife. Zhao didn't think he had wronged her. It was just a breakup, wasn't it? Before splitting up they had had a terrible fight. Zhao had gritted his teeth and said they should break up, and Chen Wenwen had actually bitten her lip and agreed. Startled, he had said, "If you dare agree, don't regret it!" and stormed out. A few days later he happened to sit beside Liu Miaomiao at a gathering and suddenly felt glad he had broken up. He muted his phone throughout because Chen Wenwen kept texting him, dozens of messages in a day.

He wanted to turn and tell her, Aren't you annoying? I told you not to regret it if you dared agree! Playing the tragic victim afterward is pointless.

But Liu Miaomiao was beside him. Being too harsh to an ex would make his new girlfriend think him ungallant, so Zhao endured it. He liked Liu: she was pretty, agreeable, and from a good family; unlike Chen Wenwen, she didn't argue with him and made him look good before his friends. Conveniently, their fathers were golfing partners. On hearing that her son had a new girlfriend, his mother had clapped delightedly and said, "Good breakup! You and Chen Wenwen weren't suited!"

Zhao agreed. Watching Chen from afar, he had always seen her reading quietly, untouched by dust, eyes lowered, utterly lovely. Only after winning her had he learned the more literary they were, the more annoying, oversensitive about everything.

Chen Wenwen also thought she and Zhao Menghua weren't suited.

They had not seen each other for nearly two months. He didn't answer her calls, and emails sank without a trace. Late at night she stared at his QQ status. One weekend he'd gone rafting, the next to an amusement park, the next hiking on Fragrant Hill... Every weekend he had something to do. With whom? She didn't know.

She sat by the library's floor-to-ceiling window. Outside the light was dim and wind stirred the dense green leaves. She remembered The Lover and Marguerite Duras, imagining the girl on the Mekong River slowly turning gray.

Suddenly she burst into sobs, frightening the elderly librarian so badly his chronic leg pain flared up.

Actually the story of The Lover was nothing like hers.

The only thing they shared was being unsuited. The white girl and wealthy Chinese young master in The Lover had parted forever because they were unsuited too.

She had come today to see Zhao. That hope had overcome her heavy hesitation. She had put on light makeup so she would look healthier and he wouldn't worry. She had invited Lu Mingfei because everyone else at the gathering was one of Zhao's friends, which frightened her a little. She hadn't imagined getting back together with Zhao; she only wanted to see him casually.

Then why had she burst into tears?

Why was she still following them?

She knew doing so wouldn't make Zhao look back. She knew his character better than anyone... But if she left like this, perhaps she would never see him again, and all those memories would be gone. In memory they walked side by side beneath streetlights along the school river road; now the lights had gone out. In memory they got meals together in the cafeteria; now the food had spoiled. In memory she had bought a Hello Kitty charm and insisted on hanging it on Zhao's phone. By now, she thought, it must have been torn off. The little pink furry cat lay in a garbage heap somewhere in the world beneath all kinds of filth, but it couldn't even cry, because it had no mouth...

She regretted it. She should never have bought that Hello Kitty. If she hadn't, the kitten would still be lying obediently in the display case waiting for someone to take it home.

Why make that innocent little cat so miserable because of a relationship that wasn't right?

That poor... little cat...

At last tears spilled from her eyes, falling onto the scorching concrete tiles and rising as a faint wisp of steam.

"Hey! Hey!" Xu Yanyan nudged Zhao in the waist with his elbow. Out of the corner of his eye he had seen Chen Wenwen stop, tears streaming, and felt a little pity.

"Will you stop bothering me?" Zhao forcefully knocked his arm away.

He wished he could strike Chen Wenwen instead. She was too annoying! He couldn't bear it. What did she want? If she hadn't come today and they met alone another time, he would have patted her shoulder and comforted her. But she insisted on coming; if she came, she shouldn't cause trouble, and she'd even brought Lu Mingfei. That boy was really stubbornly devoted to her. Now she had made everyone part on bad terms. What more did she want? His new girlfriend Liu Miaomiao was beside him, and he had to take his friends out for Italian that night to recover his standing. He hadn't invited Chen Wenwen. Who did she think she was, following along?

Suddenly a deep, powerful engine sounded. Before Zhao could look up, hot wind cut past as though it might slice his hair. A dark-blue shape flashed beside him; brakes screamed, and the Panamera stopped sharply beside Chen Wenwen.

The lunatic was driving backward!

The window lowered. Chu Zihang's face, half hidden by dark glasses, was icy enough to play a killer utterly loyal to his boss in any Hong Kong film. He said, "Lu Mingfei says he'd like to take you to dinner tonight."

"Yes, you." He nodded to the bewildered Chen Wenwen. His handsome, thoroughly masculine face seemed to say, It's that simple. I've delivered the boss's message.

His seriousness, commanding presence, coldness, and nosiness combined perfectly. This was probably an invitation no one could refuse. Imagine someone admired you and invited you to an intimate, elegant dinner for two, but delivered the invitation so forcefully that you felt if you said no, the messenger would pull a Desert Eagle from the glove compartment and shoot you between the eyes...

"He reserved a table at Aspasia tonight." Chu drew a business card from the compartment and handed it to Chen. "The address is on here. Seven thirty."

She stared at the black card. Aspasia. She had vaguely heard of this fashionable Italian restaurant, luxurious to an almost unimaginable degree. Could this really be the timid boy's doing? Such unmistakable commanding presence... Boss Lu stood tall and firm!

Nearby the Shilan boys stared, jaws nearly hitting the ground. Given the temperature of the pavement, one might soon smell roasted jaws. Zhao clenched his fists. He had a premonition that an opponent he had never respected was about to crush him again...

"Are you refusing?" Chu frowned.

Could anyone refuse that tone? He was plainly growing impatient. Surely his Desert Eagle was itching to come out of the glove compartment. Even Zhao felt refusing would be courting death.

Chen lowered her head, smoothed the fine hair by her ear, and sniffed. "All right."

The window rose and the Panamera sped away, arriving and departing in a rush. Its four exhaust pipes again left Zhao's ears ringing.

Act Three

Reward

Reward

Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

The Panamera turned onto the elevated road. Its two occupants once again had nothing to say.

"You're really good at driving, senior," Lu Mingfei said awkwardly, trying to break the uncomfortable silence.

Five minutes after leaving him by the roadside, Chu Zihang had returned to pick him up. Since then he hadn't mentioned Chen Wenwen, as if that conversation had never happened. Lu Mingfei thought he must have misunderstood him and regretted his earlier impatience. To complete this mission, wouldn't he need the president's help as his "assistant"? If Chu Zihang angrily abandoned him, Commissioner Lu's assignment would be a total disaster.

Chu Zihang hadn't said a word about the mission details, as though he were simply a chauffeur. But he drove well, using manual mode, shifting gears with swift, decisive movements. There was beauty in the way he held everything under control, as if a flock of butterflies might fly from between his fingers.

"My dad taught me." Chu Zihang seemed surprised Lu Mingfei had brought it up. After a pause he added, "Happy birthday."

"Oh, oh." Lu Mingfei hurriedly nodded and bowed. "Your text moved me so much I practically bubbled over."

"You're replacing a toilet seat on your birthday instead of going out to eat?" Chu Zihang glanced at the thing on his lap.

"My aunt didn't give birth to me. It's normal for her not to remember." Lu Mingfei wasn't complaining; he really thought so. He apparently had never celebrated a birthday. You couldn't blame the government for a hard life. Who told him to have unreliable parents?

This topic was a hundred times better than the previous one, and the two seemed to get along a little more easily. "How do you usually celebrate your birthday, senior?" Lu Mingfei asked.

Chu Zihang thought. "House party, cake, presents, a garden party, photos, dinner, travel... About the same every year."

Lu Mingfei stuck out his tongue. What more could you want, brother? Launch a spacecraft to the moon for your birthday and write HAPPY BIRTHDAY, MASTER CHU ZIHANG on its surface?

"Do you like Italian food?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Never tried it." Lu Mingfei shook his head.

"Cheese, pizza, fried chicken, steak, pasta, that sort of thing. Italian food was the predecessor of French cuisine. It emphasizes natural flavors, and uses olive oil, black olives, dried cheese, tomatoes, spices, and Marsala wine for seasoning. Its air-dried meats and sausages are excellent."

Lu Mingfei didn't know what this had to do with anything, so he nodded. "I like meat."

"Mm." Chu Zihang nodded and connected the car's Bluetooth. "Aspasia restaurant? I'd like to reserve a table for two tonight..."

"I'm very sorry, sir. The restaurant has been booked for a private event tonight." The female manager's voice was gentle but firm.

"Fully booked?" Chu Zihang frowned. "Can you add a table?"

"I'm very sorry. The Black Prince Group is holding a wedding banquet tonight for Mr. Chen's son. We can't accommodate individual guests." The manager left no room for negotiation. "I'm terribly sorry. Please try another restaurant."

Chu Zihang held the phone in silence. The Black Prince Group was a major local taxpayer and a government-supported company. Its boss was a prominent figure whose portrait often appeared on the evening paper's front page, someone even the new mayor sought out. Naturally, none of that intimidated someone with Chu Zihang's elite Cassell education, a man whose face radiated authority once he took off his dark glasses. The problem was that Boss Black—as Chu Zihang always called the group's owner for short—was a major client of his father's, and the families visited from time to time. If this got back to his parents... Chu Zihang scratched his eyebrow, a little intimidated. Everyone had a weak point, and he was no exception.

"Senior, why insist on hanging yourself from this one crooked tree?" Lu Mingfei suggested quietly. "Can't we pick another restaurant?"

"I'm booking for a friend. It's already arranged, so it would be awkward to change." Chu Zihang thought for a while.

A figure sprang to mind. He wasn't the only person at Cassell who radiated authority, nor the most lawless. To suppress a local strongman, you needed an unreasonable dragon from out of town!

He dialed another number. "Fingel, are you at your computer? Post a reward on the Night Watcher forum for me. Yes, using the ID Murasame. I'll text you the details..."

The Night Watcher forum had originally been Cassell College's internal message board, a place for students to gossip, ask about class schedules, and rate the pretty girls in the current class. Gradually it grew popular, becoming a self-service guide to life at Cassell. Early in the morning a tarot master posted fortunes for the day; in the morning someone asked for lecture notes; at noon someone cursed the cafeteria's increasingly awful pork knuckles; in the afternoon someone who had just woken up organized that night's party; and after dark the anonymous boards filled with proud young men and women pouring out their love stories behind masks. Then the News Department was formally established. Its head, Fingel, was the undisputed king of campus paparazzi, claiming the righteous principles of a journalist: anything reasonable ought to be exposed to sunlight. Thus professors' scandals, unofficial histories of the Dragon Blood Secret Party, even Principal Anjou's large travel-expense bills could all be found there, provided you were willing to dig through the posts.

By then every Cassell graduate kept their old ID and remained a regular. Some had joined archaeological teams digging up dragon ruins in the middle of nowhere, others the Executive Department on secret missions in Europe. But whenever they had a free moment and internet access, they connected to the Night Watcher forum first, to feel the warmth of home and... the spirit of gossip.

It was late at night in America, peak traffic. More than ten thousand people were posting across the boards, white instant messages bouncing up the dark interface one after another.

Suddenly an inconspicuous white message turned red! This was rare: ordinary users couldn't do it; only an administrator working behind the scenes could. Then the red message rose above all the others and was pinned to the top!

A stream of data burst from Norma, the intelligent core at North American headquarters, crossed the undersea cables of the Pacific, and rushed to tens of thousands of clients worldwide. For a moment, people before more than ten thousand screens held their breath. What kind of news warranted this? Previously, only gossip on the level of an actual photograph of the department head's first girlfriend seemed to have received such treatment.

"REWARD: A table for two at Aspasia restaurant tonight at 7:30 p.m. (coordinates: 119.28439° E, 26.08774° N), reservation under Lu Mingfei. The person posting this reward offers one promise in exchange."

The posting ID was Murasame.

That ID appeared on the Night Watcher forum about as often as a South China tiger. But everyone knew whose it was. Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, was openly posting a reward to the Dragon Blood Secret Party worldwide.

Seven time zones away: Portofino, Italy.

At seven in the morning, sunlight covered the Gulf of Genoa, surrounded by mountains. Seagulls gathered and flew low, waiting for little fish to leap among the waves. On a clear morning, the sea was their abundant table.

Among the gulls was a black-and-white hobby falcon. Unlike them, it had not fixed its sights on little fish; it soared and waited for a cod or eel to surface.

A blurred shadow grew clearer. Something was rising from the seabed, and it was certainly big. The predatory bird's blood heated. It folded its wings, extended its talons, and plunged toward the water like a dive-bomber.

The surface broke. The prey leaped half a meter out of the water and caught the falcon's talons in a tenth of a second. The bird beat its wings in terror, unable to escape. It had judged wrongly: this was neither eel nor cod. It had no business being in the depths of the Gulf of Genoa. How could a human reach the seabed without diving equipment?

"Shh." The young man smiled coldly and laid a finger against his lips. He was actually speaking to the falcon.

A faint gold flashed in his eyes, like reflected sunlight. The falcon stopped struggling and perched quietly on the back of his hand. One instant of eye contact, and it was tamed.

"From now on you're my falcon. I'll call you Antony, after an ancient Roman general. It goes rather well with my name," the young man said. "Oh, I'm Caesar Gattuso."

He waved. Antony obeyed, beating its wings and circling overhead. Caesar swam backstroke toward shore like an arrow cleaving the water. On the empty beach stood a tiny motorcycle, only a little over half a meter tall. Though short, it looked every inch a proud Harley cruiser; the rising tide had covered its wheels. Caesar swung aboard and turned the throttle. It roared cheerfully, kicked up a person-high spray, and charged onto the road. The road climbed around the mountain. Plain houses with pink and yellow walls and deep green woods flashed past. Looking back, he saw yachts gathered in the bay below, white wind pennants streaming from their masts.

Caesar held a white bath towel high overhead. Antony understood at once, descending to follow the motorcycle, wings beating as it soared now above and now below the towel, like a warrior following his master's warhorse.

Caesar put on sunglasses against the increasingly fierce sun, a faint smile on his handsome face.

This was his summer vacation, utterly different from the life of the S-rank loser Lu Mingfei. He spent the hottest weeks in Portofino, in a permanently rented suite at the hilltop Splendid Hotel. The little town attracted wealthy Italians and luxury goods, yet remained simple and natural. It was also a superb diving harbor, with red coral and ancient shipwrecks beneath the water and schools of fish swimming leisurely above them. He knew it as well as his own garden.

The Splendid had once been an old monastery. Its pool and restaurant lay among ancient trees, like a garden suspended in the air when seen from below. Caesar entered the lobby bare-chested, and his secretary handed him a phone.

"Your classmate is calling. He seems to be an officer of the Student Council."

"What is it?" Caesar asked casually, holding the phone between neck and shoulder. During the vacation he had left several capable officers on campus, so any news would reach him promptly. Caesar wasn't used to losing control of a situation.

"Big news! Lu Mingfei is taking someone out for authentic Italian food tonight. He can't get a table and is looking for help."

"Who is this?" Caesar paused. The voice was familiar, but not one of those he'd left behind.

"Your loyal lackey Fingel!" The voice was exceedingly ingratiating.

"What does that have to do with me?" Caesar frowned.

Fingel was indeed in the Student Council, but unless he surfaced on his own, Caesar would never remember he had such a subordinate. The fellow had repeated so many years that his original file couldn't be found, and he hadn't reported for duty once since Caesar took office. He was a thoroughgoing drifter.

"But Chu Zihang posted a reward!"

"Chu Zihang?" Caesar's face grew serious.

"Chu Zihang says whoever helps Lu Mingfei get a table at Aspasia tonight can ask him to do one thing within his ability, as long as it doesn't violate morality. Basically, they get a promise from him and can come to him when they have a problem."

"A considerable reward." Caesar pondered for a moment.

The game of posting "rewards" was common at Cassell: helping one another in an exchange of equal value. Caesar had posted one himself when courting Nono, asking people to send her postcards from their hometowns over vacation. Each said, "My hometown is a beautiful place. I hope one day

you'll visit it with Caesar Gattuso." The postcards piled up on Nono's desk like a little mountain, and Caesar sent each sender a new-model PSP as promised.

Compared with Chu Zihang's present reward, however, a few hundred PSPs were nothing. A promise from the Lionheart Society's president could be worth very little or an outrageous amount. You could ask Chu Zihang to bark like a dog, or to give up the presidency. Caesar believed Chu Zihang kept his word. Only such a man was worthy of being Caesar Gattuso's enemy. He was beginning to find this interesting. Lu Mingfei's reservation had nothing to do with him, but... everything involving Chu Zihang did!

"Trying to win people over on campus?" Caesar raised an eyebrow. "Ridiculous! Lu Mingfei is a Student Council member. He's mine. If he needs anything, he should come to me, and I'll help him!" He smiled coldly, radiating authority. "Tonight I'll have Lu Mingfei dining at the best table in the best Italian restaurant he can reach, served by the finest chef and the finest waiters. Everything must be perfect!"

"Brilliant, boss!" Fingel praised him. "But Chu Zihang named Aspasia, and there aren't any tables left."

"That three-Michelin-star restaurant?" Caesar frowned. "I've eaten at its Rome branch many times and never once had to wait."

"Apparently it's booked out for a wedding banquet."

"It's not as if China has no other good restaurants. They can simply get married somewhere else." To Caesar the matter was simple. It was trivial to him; his precious brainpower needn't be wasted considering the bride and groom.

"It's tricky. The people who booked it have considerable influence."

Caesar frowned. "Considerable influence? Politicians?"

"No, a local listed company. Their son got a girl pregnant..."

Caesar lost interest. "Only a business owner. I understand. Someone will take care of it; they're professionals... You're surprisingly eager to help your roommate. You owe Lu Mingfei a lot of money, don't you?"

Fingel sounded sheepish. "I've eaten a lot of his late-night snacks without paying..."

"Then I'll repay the favor for you." Caesar hung up.

He handed the phone to the butler beside him. "Call the Mint Club for me. Once it's arranged, text my classmate. His name is Lu Mingfei." He thought. "The message is: 'Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso.'"

"Using Mint? The cost won't be small. Isn't that rather elaborate for a classmate?" the secretary advised tactfully.

"Do you know Zhou Enlai?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. He was a very famous diplomat."

"I just read his biography. Some of it is quite interesting. Chinese people care a great deal about details. Mr. Zhou could clearly remember all sorts of information about someone he'd met once, and greet them the next time, making them feel deeply honored. He even bought a shirt for a cleaner whose clothes his car had dirtied. It's a leader's philosophy: attend to details concerning your subordinates."

Caesar dried his wet blond hair, voice firm. "It strengthens a team's cohesion. That's an important lesson I've learned these past few days."

Had Lu Mingfei been there, he probably would have reminded him that this important lesson came from material fit for a middle-school textbook.

"But... all this seems like a roundabout way to ask for your help." The secretary smiled. "Like a little trick."

Caesar raised an eyebrow, looked at the secretary intently, and smiled too. "Yes, Chu Zihang's little trick. I saw it, but it's one I have to fall for because," he said slowly, "Chu Zihang has put himself on the line. I don't need his promise, but I don't want someone else to get it and make some bizarre demand that turns our competition into a mess."

"I understand. I'll arrange it." The secretary bowed slightly. "Young master, it's almost time. Please get ready. The trustees are on their way."

"The main courses haven't been served yet. Why should a side dish like me hurry? I'd still like another swim."

"In your uncle's eyes, you're the main course at today's meeting."

Caesar turned to the young secretary with a subtle smile. "Parsi, don't say that to me again. First, I'm not a dish for a chef to decide about. Even if I were, neither you nor Uncle should expect to be my cook."

"Sorry, young master. I'll be more careful." The secretary withdrew submissively.

Chu Zihang's and Lu Mingfei's phones rang at the same time. Both had received texts. Chu Zihang glanced at his and silently closed it; Lu Mingfei stared in astonishment.

"Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso."

The second birthday greeting on his nineteenth birthday came from Caesar Gattuso. Lu Mingfei was dizzy. What had he done to deserve birthday wishes from the presidents of the Lionheart Society and the Student Council? Zhou Yu and Cao Cao had fought each other to the death on the Yangtze, yet both wished the same person a happy birthday. Who could earn such an honor? Probably... Jiang Gan.

The world was strange. Some people saw him as a lump of crap; others saw him as a treasure.

"Where are we going now?" Lu Mingfei leaned back and looked out the window.

"You're in charge of the mission. You decide."

"Senior, don't mess with me, okay? We'll go wherever you say. Once we get there, you do your thing... I'll... help dust your car." Lu Mingfei looked miserable.

"Then the ruins of South Railway Station. We don't know who took the documents, so we'll look at the scene first," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei looked out. The collapsed, tortoise-shell-shaped aluminum-alloy dome of South Railway Station came into view. This branch of the elevated road led straight there. So from the beginning they hadn't needed him, the nominal person in charge, to do anything at all, right? The car had been heading straight for the station. Thinking that made him feel pretty useless... but since it was true, he didn't mind admitting it. Senior Chu Zihang certainly had his measure.

"How long will it take? I'm afraid I'll get home too late... and the toilet seat won't get installed." Lu Mingfei was worried.

He imagined his aunt rushing home sweaty and hot, making for the bathroom, and finding no toilet seat, so she had to squat on the rim. Her rage would turn into a sonic boom and kill him, wouldn't it?

"I've arranged it. You're the commissioner; just complete the mission. I'm responsible for assisting, and I'll take care of your toilet seat," Chu Zihang said mildly.

"You'll call the maintenance guy who fixes the drains in our building?" Lu Mingfei thought that sounded sensible.

Chu Zihang froze. Evidently it hadn't occurred to him that a call to the building management would fix the toilet. Young Master Chu was hardworking at home too, but he'd never repaired a toilet. His family had plenty of housekeepers and drivers.

"Don't worry. I've arranged for professionals," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei relaxed. Chu Zihang was clearly an extreme perfectionist. If he said professionals, they had to be professionals, capable of going to heaven or underground, let alone fixing a toilet.

The car stopped five hundred meters from South Railway Station, where yellow tape blocked the way. Under the blazing sun, the once beautiful building looked like a work of postmodern art: only a vast, twisted aluminum-alloy frame remained, desolate in the extreme. Cicadas screamed, and crows perched on the frame croaking hoarsely. The municipal government's press conference explaining the "shoddy construction" was being held that afternoon at the city hall auditorium. Reporters had all rushed there, leaving discarded sheets of notes scattered on the ground. Police and security guards sheltered in the shade, fanning themselves with their caps.

"Whoa... Was the earthquake that strong? I didn't feel a thing!" Lu Mingfei exclaimed. Only standing before the ruins could you truly understand the immense force that had destroyed the building, and in turn feel how small you were.

Like two ants arriving before the shell of a sea turtle that had died thousands of years ago.

"It's hard to imagine. Its mechanical structure was very stable, designed to withstand an earthquake of magnitude eight. The aluminum frame was heat-treated to eliminate internal stresses. This morning's small quake was magnitude three; theoretically, it shouldn't even have been damaged. Yet it collapsed, and not a single pane of glass remained intact." Chu Zihang spoke quietly. "I imagine Raymond felt as if the sky was falling."

"Follow me. Don't say anything careless." He opened the car door.

A security guard was already shouting. "Move the car! Move the car! It's closed ahead!"

"Damn, the sky really did fall." Lu Mingfei sucked in a breath.

Chu Zihang gave the guard two packs of cigarettes and said they were seismology students who wanted photographs for a graduation thesis. The guard let them in. Now Lu Mingfei stood among shattered glass, looking up at the sky. The twisted aluminum beams possessed an extraordinary beauty.

Chu Zihang crouched and gently wobbled the shards embedded in a wooden bench. They had sunk deep; anyone standing in that rain of glass could hardly have met a good end.

"Blood." Chu Zihang pointed to a patch of ground. "Raymond was standing here."

"Senior, what can you possibly see in all this broken glass?" Lu Mingfei followed him like a little attendant.

"You can't see it, and neither can I," Chu Zihang said. "But someone can. It's an ability to reconstruct what happened through observation. You know the person who has it."

He put on a baseball cap with a high-resolution camera fixed to the brim and connected to his phone, then started a 3G video call.

"Nono? I need your help," Chu Zihang said.

"Norma has already assigned the task, so I understand. I need you to walk Raymond's route again. I'll try to reconstruct the scene." Chu Zihang switched on the speaker, and Lu Mingfei heard Nono clearly.

Lu Mingfei was wondering whether to greet the little witch when she said, "Who's on your left?"

He started. He hadn't appeared in front of the camera at all.

"Lu Mingfei. He's the commissioner on this operation; I'm assisting him," Chu Zihang said. "How did you know he was here?"

"I saw his reflection in the broken glass in front of you, though his image was small," Nono said. "Tell him to move farther away. He'll interfere with my judgment standing there."

Lu Mingfei had to retreat to a distant corner. The little witch's ability to catch details while profiling was extraordinary. He'd seen it before and didn't mind, but she hadn't shown the slightest intention of wishing him a happy birthday, treating everything as business. It was a little depressing.

Chu Zihang walked through the enormous space, every detail captured by the camera transmitted to Nono. At this moment he was Raymond, entering South Railway Station before its collapse, carrying important documents, surrounded by danger and unsure where the enemy was hiding.

"Stop. He should have paused here," Nono said. "He'd just entered the station. He wasn't familiar with the new building, so he would have stopped to read the signs."

Chu Zihang turned his head slowly, scanning the entire station.

"Good. Raymond's Yanling wasn't visual, so a sweep would probably take three or four seconds. He was noticed at this point," Nono said confidently.

"Now forward. Stop. Turn your head. Raymond would have looked back here to check his surroundings. It was his habit and also followed the college's reconnaissance procedure."

Chu Zihang turned and looked around as instructed. Watching the little witch and Chu Zihang play this crime-scene game from his corner, Lu Mingfei felt a little envious. Chu Zihang was a great player, expressionless and calm, doing whatever she told him. Somehow that even made him a little cute. In Lu Mingfei's place he'd be pulling complicated faces and saying "Really?" and "No way," which wouldn't look cool at all. But he couldn't imitate Chu Zihang's bearing, so all he could do was envy him.

"Raymond found nothing suspicious at the observation point and continued fifteen meters to the ticket gates. Here he discovered that the station was about to collapse," Nono said.

"Are you sure this is the spot?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Yes. He couldn't have been where he died when he realized it was collapsing. He died close to the benches, and with his training he'd certainly have hidden beneath one, but he didn't. That means he saw the danger where he couldn't take cover, then ran toward the benches, trying to escape it, but was too late. The most reasonable nearby position is where you're standing now," Nono said.

"Good." Chu Zihang nodded.

"The conclusion is clear. No one could have snatched the documents from Raymond in so short a time. They were lost after his death, within the next few minutes."

"Why within a few minutes?"

"Someone stepped in Raymond's blood. Your camera caught the footprint just now. It's blurred, which means it was made when the blood had only just flowed. There are lots of footprints at the scene, but only this one approaches Raymond. He was an experienced commissioner and wouldn't have dropped the documents even while seeking cover. So this person stole them from beside him within minutes of the collapse," Nono said. "And judging from the footprint, this was a human with an unsteady step. A pure human would be nervous in a place like this, so they'd have to flee by the nearest exit. C2, right beside you. We should find more information there."

"Understood."

"Now imitate that person's actions. Run to exit C2, but don't use your top speed; he couldn't run as fast as you," Nono said.

Chu Zihang started running at a moderate speed. Fully immersed in the situation, he naturally glanced left and right as he ran, like a nervous little thief who had stolen something.

Was the college's SS-rank mission really only because a petty thief had stolen the documents?

He stopped abruptly in front of exit C2. Outside was the parking lot, and the camera revealed two deep black tire marks. You could imagine how panicked the driver had been: a tremendously powerful car, its tires softened by heat, and the person who stole the documents pressing hard on the gas in their nervousness. Only that would leave marks like these.

"You boys all know cars, so you don't need me for the rest." Nono giggled through the phone. "You've worked hard, Mr. President. I'm taking your girl into the mountains to play."

Chu Zihang paused and nodded slightly. "Thank you."

"Oh, one more feeling, though it isn't very reliable. Just for reference," Nono said. "There was a third person there, standing right where you are now, without moving. They watched from Raymond's death through the theft, and the little thief evidently saw them too. The thief had blood on his feet, and the trail of footprints bent here, which means he saw something that surprised him. It should have been a person."

"What kind of person?"

"I don't know. They left very few traces, so that's why I say it isn't reliable. Looking at all the images you've sent, I just have a feeling that a blurred shadow was watching it all."

Chu Zihang was silent for a moment. "Understood."

"Let's go." Chu Zihang approached Lu Mingfei. "That's about it. I think we can solve this tonight."

"Good, good!" Lu Mingfei nodded.

"There's still some time. Aren't you meeting your cousin, uncle, and aunt tonight? Go back first. I have something to do, so I won't take you for now."

Lu Mingfei thought there weren't any taxis to be had here, but couldn't very well say it. He just kept nodding. "Then I'll meet up with you tonight."

"Let's meet after the mission. I'll arrange a car to pick you up. We'll work in two different places. I have a little more experience, so may I temporarily handle the operational details for you, Commissioner?"

"Sure, sure! The capable should do more!" Lu Mingfei thumped his chest. "With you handling it, I'm not worried!"

Cassell College headquarters, central control room. It was midnight, the easiest time to get sleepy. Guderian was sprawled on the table, fast asleep. Manstein and Schneider, eyes red, leafed through a thick stack of lists and crossed off names one by one.

Manstein glanced at his sleeping friend, frowned, and rolled up a tissue to put beneath his open mouth so his drool wouldn't wet the lists.

"Found it," Schneider said quietly, pushing the list across the table to Manstein.

"The tire marks Chu Zihang found were made by a large-displacement SUV, twenty-two-inch oversized wheels and 285-millimeter-wide Bridgestone tires," Schneider said. "Only modified Hummers or Escalades use those tires. This is the most suspicious name on the owners' list."

Manstein glanced at it. "I know that name."

The Escalade Schneider had underlined belonged to Millennium Labor Services, registered at Runde Building.

"Right. Those people are hunters," Schneider said. "The group calls itself the Three Young Masters. The leader is Tang Wei."

"Some inexplicable things are getting mixed up in this," Manstein said. "A real nuisance."

At Cassell, carrying a gun into the mountains to shoot pheasants didn't make you a "hunter." The word referred to a particular group: a loose organization hired to solve problems. Its members included desperadoes, artists, avant-garde young creatives, and gangsters, a complicated mixture. Their jobs weren't to rescue an elderly neighbor's kitten from a tree, of course, but work on the border between legal and illegal. Usually they weren't hired to murder or commit arson, but they stole, robbed graves, and looted artifacts. A substantial number of these jobs involved dragons, such as stealing alchemical implements from tombs.

They came from everywhere to enter this dangerous and disreputable line of work for one real reason: the "call of blood." Most had some dragon ancestry.

The college had noticed this hybrid organization twenty years earlier, but had never fully understood it. Nor did it want to recruit the scattered bands, as their bloodlines were usually not very pure. It still kept watch, however. Executive Department members stationed around the world registered every hunter they found, and the files already contained several thousand.

Serious research into the organization had begun only last year. Before awakening as the Dragon King, the elder of the King of Bronze and Fire's brothers had been a hunter operating in New York, essentially a petty hoodlum.

Even so, the college had avoided direct contact with hunters, whose minor activities rarely infringed on its interests.

This time was different. Apparently some ruthless figure had emerged among these half-skilled hybrids of low blood purity, capable of bringing down Executive Department commissioner Raymond and trying to take the documents wanted by the Board of Trustees.

"Only four hours remain until the trustees' deadline," Schneider said. "No time for an indirect approach. Act directly."

"Use force?" Manstein frowned. "China is a country governed by law..."

"Human laws don't fully apply to us, do they?" Schneider said. "Both sides are hybrids. Just warn Chu Zihang not to hurt anyone uninvolved."

"You should know your student isn't a precision sniper rifle, skilled at picking off individual targets. He's practically... a shotgun that fires as soon as it lands! I'll say it again: his mission record is poor. He's already caused the college a lot of trouble." Manstein lowered his voice. "If we hadn't kept a lid on it, the trustees would have heard long ago!"

"What's wrong with it? He has a hundred-percent success rate. His methods are just a little too forceful sometimes."

Manstein sighed. "Listen, Schneider, I know you value Chu Zihang, but don't let personal feelings affect your judgment. What's that saying? Impulse is the devil! Remember the bronze city mission? If we'd known Ye Sheng and Aki were a couple, we wouldn't have put them on the same team. We might have saved at least one."

"Right! Good point! Mingfei and Nono have no feelings for each other, so their mission was a great success!" Guderian woke at precisely the right moment, found an opportunity to boast about his student, and immediately brightened.

"The whole campus knows who Lu Mingfei has a crush on," Schneider said coldly. "Except perhaps Caesar."

"Stop! We don't have time for gossip!" Manstein grew angry. "And don't drag my student into this too!"

"Sorry, I forgot Nono is your student now," Schneider said.

The three stared at one another. The central control room fell deathly quiet except for the ticking of the old wall clock. Time passed, second by second.

After a long hesitation, Manstein handed Schneider a list. "To tell you the truth, I've already contacted the trustees directly. They seem to have begun doubting Chu Zihang's abilities. Besides appointing Lu Mingfei commissioner, they immediately dispatched the people on this list to assist them. They're driving to meet Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang now. They're elite veterans with many years of experience. The recovery plan must also be approved by the trustees and directed remotely from here."

Schneider scanned the list and started. "Why send these people? They're far too conspicuous!"

"The trustees understand that, so they ordered them to dress in plain clothes and keep a low profile."

Schneider was silent for a long time. He gave a long sigh, rose, and walked toward the door.

"Hey, Schneider, don't be so stubborn." Manstein stood and raised his voice. "Not everything depends on an excellent bloodline, right? Don't assume only your own student is the best."

"Once the trustees have decided, the Executive Department can't overturn it. Do as they say. Those politicians only know how to issue orders; they don't understand operations at all. Those people can't help Chu Zihang." Schneider looked back from the door. "Worse, Chu Zihang can't work with other people at all! Every mission he's undertaken, he's actually completed alone!"

On the twenty-first floor of Runde Building, heavy velvet curtains covered every window, shutting out the light. At the center of an enormous conference table stood a red tea-light holder containing a lavender-scented candle. That little light couldn't illuminate the huge, luxurious conference room or the client opposite. He sat between light and shadow, looking thin, with tousled red hair, a deathly pale face, a red-and-white striped shirt, and a yellow vest.

"Whiskey on the rocks? Camus XO? Or... would you like a Chicken McNuggets meal?" Tang Wei turned a glass of Yamazaki whiskey in his hand, unable to resist a joke.

Because the client opposite was Ronald McDonald.

Tang Wei had faced all kinds of clients: burly men with blue dragons tattooed on their backs and Chairman Mao quotations on both arms; obvious success stories with fat bellies and glamorous women in black stockings and miniskirts on their arms; even someone who came in, poked two holes in the conference table with two fingers, and said, "I've trained in the two-finger technique, brother. I advise you not to pull any tricks!" Tang Wei had thought he'd seen enough not to be shaken by anything, but the sight of Ronald McDonald as a client still filled him with respect.

Tang Wei had grown up poor. As a child he'd stared up at McDonald's big sign, swallowing hard.

"Camus XO, on the rocks," the client said in a deep voice.

Sipping the expensive Camus, the client opened the case he'd brought. Inside were neatly stacked high-denomination U.S. bills. The case held exactly $2.5 million.

"The goods," the client said simply.

Tang Wei lifted the case at his feet onto the table and opened it. Inside was a sealed paper bag, its seal printed with an emblem: a great, half-decayed tree. Tang Wei was about to cut it open with scissors when the client said, "That's enough. Don't."

He pushed the heavy case toward Tang Wei and raised his eyes. The moment Tang Wei met them, he nearly jumped to his feet.

Damn, he doesn't have severe hepatitis, does he? That was the first thought to surge into Tang Wei's mind. Otherwise, why were his eyes so yellow? And shining gold...

In each golden eye seemed to be an unfamiliar symbol, slowly rotating backward. The symbols drew Tang Wei into staring hard, even as he realized he shouldn't. The sight made him dizzy, like looking into a kaleidoscope.

"What the hell!" Tang Wei shouted inwardly. When he recovered from the momentary fright, he was drenched in cold sweat. The client still sat quietly across the table, with his rightful fee in front of him: $2.5 million in cash.

"The Three Young Masters are very efficient. I'm pleased." The client picked up the tea-light holder and blew the candle flame into his glass of Camus. The strong grape brandy began to burn quietly, a dark blue flame floating above the ice-filled liquor. He swirled the glass and swallowed liquor, ice, and flame in one gulp. Nodding with satisfaction, he rose to leave.

"Hey, you forgot the goods!" Tang Wei said.

"A courier will come at seven tonight. FedEx. Just give it to him." The client left without looking back.

Tang Wei drank his whiskey in a daze and failed to notice that the wall clock seemed to have gained a few minutes.

"Boss, got the money?" As soon as the client left, Tang Wei's underling darted in.

Tang Wei patted the case proudly. He'd checked the bills: the full amount, all genuine. He'd never expected to get the money so easily. It was almost too comfortable.

"Wow, now I've seen everything! A job from Ronald McDonald!" The underling was full of curiosity.

"What the hell do you know?" Tang Wei rolled his eyes. "He didn't want to show his face. If he'd come dressed as Zorro, security would have grabbed him on the first floor."

He couldn't help admiring the client's ingenuity. Disguised as Ronald McDonald making a promotional visit, he'd come all the way to the office without anyone suspecting him. One brainless young woman at the company had even followed him, asking whether he'd brought a delivery.

"So we get a bonus this month?" The underling gazed at the case full of dollars, delighted.

"Get lost! Don't be so uncultured. In our line of work, we stay cool!" Tang Wei chased him out. "Have the brothers keep a good watch tonight! Someone's picking up the goods. Put extra men on every floor. We'll enjoy dividing the money once we've handed them over!"

On the surface Tang Wei ran a major labor-placement business and drove an imposing Cadillac Escalade SUV. In fact, he considered himself a blue-collar worker. He was a hunter.

He knew there were many others like him around the world, taking jobs for substantial rewards on a website called the Hunter Market. Clients from all over uploaded assignments and solicited capable hunters. Registered members confident they could do a job could reply through the site's mail system, attaching a résumé. This was called "bidding," and the client chose among the hunters who applied.

Tang Wei knew these jobs usually involved strange and supernatural things; crawling in and out of ancient tombs was routine. But you couldn't make money without hardship. He had a talent for this line of work. His company was a hunters' company, and his men all had skills. For each job, the underlings and the company split the proceeds fifty-fifty.

The work was thrilling, dangerous, and profitable. The only problem was that Tang Wei didn't know whether he belonged to the underworld or the legitimate world, and he had little confidence in the Hunter Market site that had made him rich.

No one could say what the site really was. It didn't even have moderators, only an administrator named Nido who rarely appeared. Break the rules and you'd receive a warning email from him, that was all. Tang Wei's ID was 3rd_young_master: Third Young Master.

The always-dark site was like the ruined tombs they often had to "visit" for jobs, with clients and hunters drifting and trading like midnight ghosts. You didn't know what was hidden deep in a tomb, but wandering those boards you felt that someone in their depths was watching your every move. Each extra word you typed, each extra minute online, let someone—or something—in the depths of the tomb learn a little more about you.

By comparison, a client who came to pay in person dressed as Ronald McDonald was almost amusing.

This job had earned Tang Wei more easily than any he'd ever done. He'd originally planned to send his men to seize the packet by force, but an underling had returned delighted. "We got there just in time for the earthquake! South Railway Station collapsed! The falling glass really sliced that guy up. I

risked my life to grab the case and run... It was dangerous, but all it cost was gas there and back! Boss, you need to give me a bigger bonus this time!"

Such damn good luck, and $2.5 million just like that? It was enough to make him wonder if he was dreaming.

Tang Wei touched the bills, took out his phone, and dialed. "Hey, Dad, it's Tang Wei. Wait for me to come home for dinner tonight... Mm... Did your passport application come through? Damn it, call and hurry them up. The lawyer's waiting to file the immigration papers!"

He was planning to take his father and run. He'd applied for Canadian investor immigration. In a few months he would close the company; this was actually his last job. He intended to settle his father in Canada first, hire a few housekeepers to look after the old man, and then travel the world. First stop: Vietnam. His brothers said years of war had left the sexes out of balance, and beautiful Saigon girls by the handful had trouble finding husbands, all wearing those fitted Vietnamese dresses, áo dài, slit high up the sides. A wonderful country full of beautiful legs. On reflection, though, the Sino-Vietnamese battle of Laoshan had been in 1984. However war-torn and unbalanced the sexes had once been, girls unable to find husbands since 1984 would now be middle-aged women with wrinkles and yellow teeth...

Whether or not that dream country of beautiful legs existed, Tang Wei would close his Hunter Market account and stay away from supernatural affairs from then on.

He glanced at the wall clock. Two and a half hours until seven thirty. Two and a half hours until he washed his hands of the business for good.

Chu Zihang stood below Runde Building in a FedEx uniform. The sun sank gradually westward, stretching his shadow long.

His sunglasses reflected the Escalade parked before the main entrance, with its enormous twenty-two-inch chrome wheels.

A BMW 320, loaded down with shopping, drove through the sunset.

"Mingze, once you're abroad, don't rush to find a girlfriend. Your parents won't be there, so don't spend all your time playing," Aunt lectured Lu Mingze in the back seat.

"I know, I know. Will you stop nagging?" Lu Mingze texted without looking up.

"He's grown up and sensible." Aunt was pleased.

"You believe him? Your son might bring home a foreign girl." Uncle looked forward to his son bringing glory to the nation in romance.

"No foreign woman is coming through our door! All you do is watch Hollywood movies and think American women are pretty. Let me tell you, their skin is rough. Close up it's all pores, and their blond body hair is an inch long..." Aunt spoke as though she'd inspected a foreign girl's thighs with a magnifying glass. "Once Mingze gets his Harvard doctorate, plenty of female classmates will want him. Whatever happens, he'll do better than your brother's boy! Just look at that timid Lu Mingfei. He's got an American scholarship, but he didn't even know to buy me a gift when he came home..."

"Didn't he bring you deep-sea fish oil?" Uncle tried to say a few words for Lu Mingfei. He was one of the Lu family, after all.

"What's that worth?" Aunt snorted. "He gets so much American money every year!"

Aunt had always resented Lu Mingfei's damn good luck. At first she'd hoped he would open a path abroad for Lu Mingze, but after swallowing her pride and calling him several times to "find Mingze some connections and help out," Lu Mingfei had only vaguely agreed, with no good news following. It wasn't that he hadn't tried. Cassell was essentially a research center for abnormal humans, but Lu Mingze was too normal.

Aunt had finally called Professor Guderian herself. He'd told her bluntly there was no chance. "Although your son's grades really are better than Mingfei's, ma'am, you must understand: Mingfei is a genius! Do you know what a genius is? An incomparable, irreplaceable, outstanding individual born among us only by chance and opportunity! Edison said genius is ninety-nine percent perspiration and one percent inspiration..."

Aunt suppressed her anger. "I know you Americans emphasize hard work! Our Mingze works hard. More than ninety-nine percent perspiration: he puts a hundred percent perspiration into studying! Definitely more sweat than Mingfei sheds."

Lu Mingze really did sweat more than Lu Mingfei. Aunt wasn't making that up. Mingfei weighed 130 jin at 178 centimeters, Mingze 160 jin at 160 centimeters. If they slept in the same room and Mingfei sweated more, it could only be a feverish night sweat from physical weakness.

"But Edison hadn't finished. He also said that one percent inspiration is more important than all ninety-nine percent perspiration!" Guderian was animated on the phone. "If Mingze is already a hundred percent perspiration, where is the one percent inspiration supposed to go?"

"So Mingfei has inspiration?" Aunt raged.

"Mingfei is inspiration from head to toe!" Professor Guderian said excitedly. "I'm counting on him to help me become a full professor..."

Aunt slammed down the phone. For several nights she tossed and turned, unable to understand how Lu Mingze, whom she'd borne with immense effort, could be inferior to listless Lu Mingfei. Thinking about it brought tears. She shook Uncle awake and told him how hard life had been since she married into the Lu family. Everyone said Lu Mingfei's mother, Qiao Weini, was learned and well brought up, and that she and her husband got along so well. It was as if Qiao Weini were a swan and Aunt a toad... no, an ugly duckling... In any case, they were bullying her to death!

Resolving to turn her pain into action, Aunt rose early and stayed up late for a year, driving Lu Mingze to study like a donkey. At last the acceptance letter arrived from overseas. Her day to lord it over everyone... no, to hold her head high had come. She immediately picked up the phone to call Lu Mingfei's parents. Only then did she discover they had no telephone number for them. All these years they'd kept in touch only through letters written in fountain pen on white paper, and not one had ever had a return address!

The pain of wanting to show off with no one to see was like eating abalone alone, with no audience!

The family of three squeezed into the elevator with bags and bundles. Aunt had even bought Lu Mingze toilet paper.

"I'm exhausted," Uncle groaned. "What's for dinner?"

"I told Mingfei to slice the radish, steam some sausage, chop scallions, and soak the rice noodles. Doesn't Mingze like crossing-the-bridge rice noodles? Tonight it's pork ribs stewed with radish, rice

noodles in the rib broth, Cantonese sausage, and I bought salmon to slice into sashimi for our son." Aunt stroked her son's round face lovingly.

"Don't always make Mingfei run errands for you. Isn't he going back to school tomorrow? He needs time to pack too," Uncle said.

"So what? Going to college means he can't do a few things for me?" Aunt rolled her eyes. "Never mind all the years I raised him."

The aging elevator creaked up from the underground garage to the first floor and stopped. As the doors opened, a sweat-soaked fellow rushed in and frantically pressed a floor button.

"No manners!" Aunt snorted, looking elsewhere so the fellow could hear her but couldn't accuse her of insulting him.

The fellow snapped to attention.

"Lu Mingfei?" Aunt recognized him and flared up. "Where have you been playing? I told you to steam the sausage and buy and install a toilet seat. Didn't you hear? All you know is play! Just like your parents! Where's the seat? You didn't buy it? You go out and all you do is play with classmates? You're so grown up and still don't appreciate how hard adults work!"

Lu Mingfei immediately wilted. Aunt had guessed correctly. He'd just returned. Chu Zihang had dropped him at an intersection not far from the complex, and he'd run all the way, hoping to get home before his aunt and uncle. He hadn't expected to meet them face-to-face in the elevator.

All his life he'd been afraid of Aunt. He hadn't been that frightened even before Norton. What was a Dragon King compared with her? Even if that Yanling: Torch Dragon went off, at worst he'd be blown to ash holding a nuclear bomb. He wasn't Caesar, with a fortune and a beautiful girlfriend to make him reluctant to leave the world. But Aunt was different: waves of brain-piercing demon sound rose higher and higher, and her middle-aged, plump face wore an expression of pity for his misfortune and anger at his lack of ambition. It made life worse than death.

"Fixed, fixed! The toilet's fixed!" Lu Mingfei remained at attention.

He could only gamble on Chu Zihang. He'd said he'd send professionals to take care of it. The Lionheart Society's leader was no ordinary man, and his word carried weight at the college. A little follower like Lu Mingfei had to trust the bosses' power.

"Then why are you running, like you desperately need to take a dump?" Aunt was still displeased.

"I, I, I..." Lu Mingfei kept sweating.

He didn't really know why he was so timid. Even if Aunt threw him out, it wouldn't be a disaster. At worst he wouldn't come back for summer vacation, and could hang out with Fingel.

Perhaps he was simply used to cowering.

The elevator opened. Lu Mingfei carried the bags and followed Aunt carefully, praying everything would be done as Chu Zihang had said when they opened the door. Today was important: dinner was the "family celebration of Lu Mingze going abroad to study." He'd bought his cousin a gift too, a universal power strip with a transformer. A useful little thing; Aunt probably wouldn't have thought the voltage in America differed from China's. Last year Lu Mingfei had suffered in the waiting hall of Chicago's train station, unable even to charge his MP3 player. With this, Lu Mingze wouldn't have to go through that.

"Did you slice the radish?" Aunt felt for her key.

"S-sliced it." Lu Mingfei stammered. He had told Chu Zihang he still had to slice radish, steam sausage, and chop scallions, but had emphasized the toilet seat. He wasn't sure the young master had paid attention.

The door opened... The house was full of white radish slices, neatly stacked, each one centimeter thick. The knife work was exquisite, like a Japanese chef slicing raw fish, with bright green chopped scallions sprinkled on top. The dining table, coffee table, refrigerator—every flat surface in the living room was covered with radish and scallions. All the lights were on, making the slices shine translucently. Aunt was so careful about the electricity bill that she never allowed two lights on in one room.

The steady, forceful chopping from the kitchen suggested dozens of knives rising and falling together, as though a class of chefs were practicing knife skills inside.

A deafening hammer drill sounded from the bathroom. Tiles broke, cement cracked, and the entire wall shook.

The family was stunned. Lu Mingze had been exchanging affectionate texts with a younger schoolmate; in his distraction he dropped his phone, and the battery flew out.

An imposing figure emerged from the kitchen: 190 centimeters tall, shoulders fifty centimeters wide, more than two hundred pounds, his gaze sharp as lightning behind dark glasses. The burly man surveyed them with authority. His left hand held a bucket full of radish slices; his right carried a U.S. military standard M9 bayonet. The gray titanium blade had blood grooves on both sides, a genuine deadly weapon, now decorated with a few delicate pieces of scallion.

"Robbers!" Facing the thug, Aunt lost her breath and nearly fainted.

"There's money in the desk drawer. Take it yourselves!" Uncle raised both hands.

A second thug appeared in the kitchen doorway, wearing only a tank top that exposed bulging muscles, a black military cap, and holding a U.S. military standard Ontario cavalry saber.

"Commissioner Lu?" The thug removed his cap, revealing a splendid bald head with a terrifying skull tattoo on its scalp.

Lu Mingfei didn't answer. He only wanted to cover his face and say he didn't know the man. But he did... These people had once belonged to the Navy SEALs, throat-cutting thugs, but they were retired now and simply maintenance workers at the college.

Cassell College, Maintenance Department!

A burly man carrying the hammer drill came out of the bathroom, his military boots leaving clear prints on the solid wood floor Aunt had carefully polished. He approached Lu Mingfei, removed a large cigar from the corner of his mouth, and smiled with pure manly pride on a square face like RoboCop's. He extended a hand. "Hello, Commissioner Lu! Following your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, we've installed the toilet seat. Please inspect it!" He gestured toward the bathroom. "Quality guaranteed! Repairs are our specialty!"

"'Professionals,' all right..." Lu Mingfei pressed a hand to his forehead.

A club boss really was dependable! He'd sent first-rate people, with PROFESSIONAL written all over their faces! But... what was their profession? Killing? Holding terrorists overhead and snapping them in two? Charging through a hail of bullets with a submachine gun in each hand? This was China. Why had these thuggish maintenance men appeared here?

"We took annual leave over the summer and came to China as tourists. We'd planned to visit Guanyin on Mount Putuo tomorrow, but came immediately when we got the call." The leader seemed to read Lu Mingfei's mind.

"Won't you try sitting on it? We bought a top-quality teak seat." The man was puzzled by the commissioner's complicated expression.

"No need..." Lu Mingfei waved weakly.

"We also steamed the sausage and sliced the radish and scallions," the man added.

"But you didn't have to... slaughter all the radishes, did you? And the scallions... Were you making chili sauce, chopping that many?"

The man looked surprised. "The assignment didn't mention chili sauce. To be honest, cooking isn't among our specialties. This is our first time handling this kind of work, so it's a little unfamiliar. Please point out anything we did badly, Commissioner. During reconnaissance and search... I mean, after entering the apartment we looked around and found big bags of radishes and bundles of scallions on the balcony. We guessed it was time-consuming work requiring several people, so we called in the Maintenance Department. Everything else was fine, but the knives weren't handy. Fortunately we all carried our own." He felt he should mention another achievement. "We also cleared the drain while we were at it."

"Look what you've done, Lu Mingfei! You resent me giving you orders, don't you? Showing off for me, are you? How dare you... how dare you turn my home upside down!" Aunt finally understood. Her shrill demon voice could split clouds and stone.

"I... I didn't mean to..." Lu Mingfei murmured like a mosquito.

Disturbed neighbors poked their heads through the door, trembling as they peeked at the room full of thug-like men. They heard they were "friends" of the child the Lu family had taken in.

The burly man immediately grew alert and raised the hammer drill as though it were a loaded Desert Eagle.

"No, no!" Lu Mingfei hurriedly held them back. Their Chinese wasn't very good, and they couldn't understand the neighbors' chatter. They only felt the situation was out of control. They stood shoulder to shoulder, knives in hand, eyes cold, shielding Lu Mingfei in their midst.

The commissioner was the highest authority on an operation and had to be protected first.

"You look down on Mingze! You can't stand me giving you orders! You're so important now, bringing a whole gang to make trouble. Well done! Your family has walked all over me for a lifetime! Go ahead and bully me! I'm not as well educated and gentle as your mother, and Mingze doesn't have your grand style, your American professor backing him... I... I raised you for nothing!" Aunt no longer cared about losing face before the neighbors. Hair disheveled, she cursed him.

Lu Mingfei lowered his head and looked at the floor, feeling incomprehensible gazes on him from every direction. Though the workers didn't know what they'd done wrong, they roughly understood what he meant. They stood in a row behind him, lowered their heads together, and accepted Aunt's scolding alongside him.

Lu Mingfei felt dazed, yet suddenly things seemed clear. So... he and Aunt had never lived in the same world at all. In the world Aunt imagined, he was ruthless and scheming, looked down on Lu Mingze, had an American professor backing him, and possessed status and influence... Apparently he'd

always stood above her. Perhaps he'd been too timid before and should just have stayed that way, never lifting his head. Only keeping his head down and silently slipping along the wall was the life meant for Lu Mingfei.

He suddenly remembered it was his birthday! For the first time in his life people had texted him happy birthday, and someone wanted to dedicate an ill-timed birthday song to him.

Lu Mingfei suddenly laughed aloud. It was clearly inappropriate, but he couldn't control himself.

Uncle and Aunt looked up at him angrily, took Lu Mingze by the hand, and went into the inner room. The door slammed. Through it Lu Mingfei heard a shout: "Get out!"

Head lowered, Lu Mingfei was silent for a long time. Then he patted the Maintenance Department leader's shoulder. "Wait for me."

He returned to his bedroom and packed. Finally he put the multifunction adapter he'd bought for forty yuan on the old IBM laptop he and Lu Mingze had shared, on which he'd wasted so much time.

Lu Mingfei led the Maintenance Department's large contingent through the living room. On the floor were the groceries Aunt had bought, the bags for Lu Mingze's trip abroad, and a cake. He'd never had a birthday cake of his own. Though he was born in the summer heat, when cake wasn't appetizing, he still wanted a cake with his own name on it, even if only to smash it.

"Commissioner Lu, did we do something wrong?" a maintenance worker asked.

"No," Lu Mingfei said. "I know your toilet-repair skills. First-rate."

There was no right or wrong. Whatever he did, this family would never like him. Like a girl who didn't love you, so whatever you did was wrong.

Without love, everything was wrong.

A top-of-the-line black BMW stood at the entrance to the building. A uniformed driver in white gloves respectfully opened its door for him. "A table for two has been reserved at Aspasia. Dinner for you and Miss Chen Wenwen begins at seven."

Lu Mingfei stared. "Aren't we going on a mission tonight? What dinner? I don't know anything about that."

"According to your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, you're responsible for the most important part of the mission tonight: dining with Miss Chen Wenwen at Aspasia," the Maintenance Department leader explained. "He'll lead the support team."

"What support work?"

The leader smiled. "Probably leading a team into Runde Building to recover our lost documents."

"Oh, he thinks I'd be too much of a burden, right?" Lu Mingfei understood.

He looked up at the window that had once been his. A solitary light shone there. He suddenly understood why he cowered before Aunt: that three-bedroom apartment in an ordinary complex was like a home. He was different from the others at Cassell. He didn't want to be lonely; the impressive, sorrowful condition called blood sorrow had nothing to do with him. He wanted a home to return to, like an ordinary person.

But he should have understood long ago. Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

What you must pay... is only that little bit of warmth and softness in your heart, hardened into iron from now on.

The black BMW glided silently into the night. Lu Mingfei sat in the back seat, his back perfectly straight.

Act Four

Dance of the Flame Demon Blade

Sword Devil with Flaming Rage

Chu Zihang paused briefly and looked around, holding the sword across his left arm, its point sloping down as ink-dark drops fell slowly from it. More black shapes stepped out of the mist. He had no time to distinguish reality from illusion, just as on that night in the typhoon. Then he had been a frail boy; now he had set his dragon blood alight. Without hesitation, without asking why, he sent a storm of blades cutting through the fog once more.

What were his enemies? He needed only to cut them down!

Cassell College headquarters, central control room.

"Our opponents are hunters. Some may have dragon blood. Since this recovery operation is on Chinese soil and we don't want trouble with the police, we need to strike fast and finish quickly, so we're deploying a nine-person team. The Board of Trustees has approved the plan. We'll direct it remotely from here." Manstein glanced at his watch. "Forty-five minutes until the operation begins."

A three-dimensional model of the Runde Building hung projected in the air. Schneider walked slowly around it.

"Where's Mingfei?" Guderian flipped through the plan. "I don't see what Mingfei is responsible for."

"Coordinating command. A very important job," Manstein said. He had left Lu Mingfei out of the plan because his coursework showed so little training that he was incapable of taking on any assignment.

Guderian nodded in understanding.

"Our central objective is the twenty-first floor of Tower A, the headquarters of Millennium. The documents should be there," Manstein said. "The Runde Building has twin towers. The company owns the entire twenty-first floor of Tower A."

"It's only an office building. Isn't a nine-person team a little extravagant?" Guderian said. "You look as if you're planning to take the Pentagon!"

"If we were taking the Pentagon, we'd need seven more people," Schneider said expressionlessly. "Security at the Runde Building is tight. The developer contracted it out to these hunters, so their people are all over the building. They know their business can't stand public scrutiny, so this is how they protect themselves." He waved, and the model changed to a cross section. Every route was marked in red: stairs, elevators, fire escapes, even ventilation ducts. "Security controls every route. To reach Tang Wei on the twenty-first floor by elevator, you have to transfer once and pass four checkpoints. Worst of all, the bottom five floors are retail, and the crowds will slow us down. If the operation takes more than five minutes, the police will arrive, and the hunters will have time to move the documents."

"Five minutes?" Guderian asked, puzzled. "The elevator might not even get there in five minutes."

"We aren't taking the elevator," Manstein said. "We're taking a direct route!"

At 18:15, as the sun sank westward, Chu Zihang looked up at the building's glass curtain wall, where advancing clouds of dusk were reflected. Static crackled in his earpiece as campus headquarters reconnected with him across the Pacific.

"Have you read the operation plan?" Schneider's hoarse voice came through the earpiece.

"It's a low-difficulty operation. If the opposition has no one with a high concentration of dragon blood, I can do it alone. I don't need that support," Chu Zihang said. "The Maintenance Department people are too conspicuous."

"Obey orders," Schneider said. "We've told them to wear civilian clothes and keep a low profile. They'll meet you in thirty minutes. Another team has, as you requested..." Schneider paused. "Gone to Lu Mingfei's home."

"Understood."

"This is China. Don't mistake it for an unpoliced stretch of the West African desert and make too much noise!" Schneider lowered his voice. "There are problems in your past record. You know that yourself. Don't draw the college's scrutiny."

"Understood," Chu Zihang said. "But you are the college, Professor."

Schneider was momentarily at a loss. "All right! That's enough! This is a discreet operation: no helmets, guns, blades, tactical flashlights, and certainly none of the alchemical equipment supplied by those lunatics in the Equipment Department. To the police it shouldn't look like an organized break-in..."

"But a bank robbery," Chu Zihang said suddenly.

Schneider blinked. "Yes... it does look a little like one..."

At 18:30, Tang Wei was playing Plants vs. Zombies while waiting for the courier who was to collect the package. His nagging father was waiting for him to come home for dinner, and he was getting anxious. Tang Wei had once been a street thug, the sort of bully who would lift the skirts of girls passing him in summer just to look. But when his father got angry and came after him waving a spatula, he never dared fight back; he covered his head and ran. His underlings asked, Boss, what are you scared of? You're so tough, and you're a head and a half taller than your dad. Tang Wei smacked one of them on the forehead. "A dad's valuable because he's rare! You only get one. Break him and there's no replacement!"

Tang Wei picked up the phone. "Front desk? Has anyone come to collect the package?"

"No, Mr. Tang. It looks like rain. I doubt they'll come today," the receptionist said in a beguiling voice.

"It was sunny all afternoon. How can it suddenly be raining?" Tang Wei looked out the window. Clouds were slowly pressing over the city, black with the promise of a storm.

The sudden change in weather made him uneasy, as though something were about to happen. He logged in to the Hunter Market for one last look.

He entered his ID, "3rd_young_master," and password. When he pressed Enter, the page refreshed from top to bottom: black background, dark green lines, deep red type, like a door opening before him onto another world. Bored, he clicked through the sections, reviewed his mission history, and

considered posting a farewell in the chat area. His friends would probably send messages wishing the Third Young Master well in a lovely land full of beautiful legs and so on. So touching.

A notice flashed at the upper right: "You have one unread message."

The message contained a single word: "Byebye."

Someone had guessed he was retiring? Who was clever enough to read his mind? Tang Wei looked at the sender field... It was blank.

There was no sender.

At that instant, thunder shook the windows. They flashed deathly white as a vertical bolt illuminated the Runde Building. Tens of thousands of volts of static electricity made every lit window flicker. At last the rain came down.

Tang Wei began to tremble. He had the worst feeling imaginable: the message came from his client on this job, that very manly Ronald McDonald. And "Byebye" wasn't wishing him a pleasant boat ride down a Vietnamese river, admiring beauties.

The word could also mean farewell forever.

At 18:40, a black BMW glided along a quiet, tree-lined road. Rain poured down. Looking out the window, Lu Mingfei saw an old red-brick house by the lake, appearing and disappearing in the curtain of rain at the end of the road.

The old mansion was called Number One Lake Garden because it was the only numbered address on the entire road. Its heavy black wrought-iron gates stood open. The car drove straight through and stopped before the house.

The house was completely dark. Through the huge floor-to-ceiling windows he could see empty tables covered in checked cloths, but no one inside. The door was closed, and the only light burned above it. A waiter in white stood in the rain beneath an umbrella.

"Come on, they got it wrong, didn't they? The place is closed," Lu Mingfei muttered to himself. The driver had already opened his door.

"Aspasia has been reserved for a private party tonight, sir," the waiter said politely.

"Oh, great!" Already nervous and awkward, Lu Mingfei felt reprieved and turned to escape. But the waiter slowly pushed open the locked door. "Mr. Ricardo M. Lu, you are our only honored guest tonight."

Lu Mingfei's head buzzed. Only then did he realize the club leaders had even more clout than he had imagined: they had reserved the whole of Aspasia for him!

Soft music began. The waiter in white walked into the dark center of the old house and struck a match to light the floating candles on the table. In the warm glow sat Chen Wenwen, dressed in white, a white butterfly clip in her black hair.

Time seemed to race backward. Lu Mingfei returned to the afternoon four years ago when they had first met.

At 18:45, on the street outside the Runde Building, people ran in every direction through the downpour, holding all sorts of things over their heads, and the street suddenly emptied. Chu Zihang stood beneath an umbrella in the gloom, holding a long box marked "Flower Delivery." Head bowed, he watched huge drops strike the ground and shatter into transparent flowers.

A van marked "FedEx" pierced the curtain of rain and stopped in front of him with a shriek of brakes. The formidable support team headquarters had assigned to him jumped out one after another, moving as if cast from the same mold. Clearly they were well-trained elites.

"Civilian clothes and a low profile, just as promised. Refreshing," Chu Zihang remarked mildly.

The brawny maintenance men stood shoulder to shoulder as if awaiting inspection, though their clothes were somewhat unconventional. One wore an Adiwang pullover, another wide-legged Korean-style pants, and another oversized Double Star skate shoes. Their leader wore the green uniform of Beijing Guoan, apparently a devoted fan.

"Not appropriate?" The leader looked himself over. "I thought this was how Chinese people dressed."

"But our chest muscles don't look as if they're about to burst out of our shirts." Chu Zihang surveyed their bodybuilding-champion physiques.

"We can't exactly hide our muscles in our pockets..." The leader looked troubled.

"Never mind. It won't affect anything, except that tomorrow you'll make the evening paper's front page: 'Adiwang's American Muscle Men Brazenly Rob Office Building.' You should have read the plan. You have five minutes to prepare. Professor Schneider will send orders directly to your earpieces." Chu Zihang waved, carried the box toward the Runde Building, and smiled at the guards. "Hello. Courier service. Flower delivery."

At 18:50, Chu Zihang was in the high-speed elevator to the top floor, the numbers flying past.

At 18:52, Lu Mingfei gazed into Chen Wenwen's eyes across the candlelight as the waiter poured them rose-colored aperitifs.

At 18:53, Tang Wei hurriedly packed up his office. He didn't want to wait anymore. He could leave the delivery to an underling. On this damned rainy day, he wanted to get home early.

At 18:54, guards on every floor of the Runde Building received a call: post extra personnel in the rain and make sure the building was secure. All surveillance systems were switched on.

Manstein looked down at his carefully synchronized watch, headset on, all channels to China open. The second hand ticked forward.

At 18:55 Beijing time, Manstein said, "Operation commence," and started the stopwatch on his watch.

He knew the order would set a precision machine in motion: the nine-person team at the Runde Building. Each was a gear with a different function, yet each worked with the others. Every plan was different, every assignment decided in advance. If they followed the procedure, they would have the objective in five minutes.

The man in the Adiwang sportswear crossed the rain toward the building's front entrance. His very "localized" civilian clothes did nothing to hide the aggression of those enormous muscles. The guards stepped back and reached for their batons. Wherever these men went, they looked like a gang of thugs.

Adiwang spread his arms, blocking the guards' blows with his hard forearms, then grabbed two by the collars and hoisted them into the air. Alarms rang, startling the entire shopping area. Customers sheltering from the rain and doing a little shopping had packed the ground floor; now they all looked toward the entrance. Adiwang was already tangled up with a dozen guards. He sprinted between the luxury shops on the first floor, nothing able to obstruct him. A burst of speed carried him over a five-

foot display sign like a hurdler. The stunned guards could only weave around the crowd. Whenever he found he'd left them too far behind, he stopped, looked back, and gave them an idiotic grin.

The shoppers were baffled. Had a bodybuilding coach gone crazy? Was this a parkour show put on to entertain customers? Whatever it was, watching the fools chase one another was rather fun.

But soon they sensed something was wrong. Guards poured out of different exits and raced down the escalators. A burly man in a pullover and Double Star shoes ran up an escalator moving downward, taking several steps at a stride. Like a cannonball, he struck the guards and pinned them in the middle. The escalator went down, but the people stayed where they were.

The man in the green Beijing Guoan jersey took the emergency stairs to the second floor, kicked in the surveillance-room door, and shattered the control panel with one punch. He pulled out two wires and touched them together; the excess current burned the equipment out completely.

A professional robbery gang could hardly have done better.

"Everybody down! Hands on your heads!" Adiwang roared in less than perfect Chinese.

He had plunged into the crowd, with guards converging from every direction. He didn't want to fight them; in hand-to-hand combat, one shoulder throw would break their backs. The words came out instinctively. When he had served in the SEALs on counterterrorism missions, he had always shouted that at hostages before emptying his submachine gun into the terrorists.

The customers screamed, crouched, and put their hands on their heads.

"They're awfully cooperative, aren't they?" Adiwang was pleased by the Chinese public's counterterrorism awareness. On past missions in Europe, he had often encountered hostages whose legs went weak and who shook too hard to cooperate.

His satisfaction lasted only a second. He suddenly saw the pretty girl in front of him crouch and hold up the wallet she had taken from her bag as though presenting a treasure.

Damn it! They really thought it was a robbery!

The retail floors were in chaos. All the guards converged there, scattered in every direction by the huge men acting like a pack of fools. The ropes holding a wall of balloons on the first floor were untied, and the balloons rose slowly. From the second floor someone poured down paper-cut dandelions meant for the Qixi celebration, filling the air with little spinning parachutes. Someone hurled handfuls of glow sticks from a nearby display into the crowd. A giant ball of flowers was pulled from the center of the dome and burst in the air, thousands of silk flowers floating like a sea of blossoms.

The Maintenance Department elites were having a good time. This was a simple assignment: draw the guards into the shops and blind the surveillance system, leaving the rest to the man among them with the strongest bloodline. They only had to play with the guards for five minutes.

They didn't notice the van they had left in the rain shudder to life and roll slowly toward the front entrance. Its wipers were off, and rain on the windshield hid the driver.

On the roof, Chu Zihang stood in the pouring rain, holding the "Flower Delivery" box. The Runde Building was forty-six stories and 210 meters tall. Looking down from the edge of the roof, everything seemed so small that he felt far removed from the whole world.

Lonely. Vast and open.

Chu Zihang let his body tip forward and plunged straight down!

In complete weightlessness, he drew the sword from the box. Shreds of flowers flew, and the sacred sword Murasame shrieked as it cut the air.

On the twenty-first floor of Tower A, guards had blocked every entrance, from the stairwells to the elevators. At Tang Wei's order, they had all mobilized. Millennium was nominally a security company, and they were professionals: its eighty or ninety men were no pushovers. The building had called the police, so even armed opponents shouldn't necessarily have been able to fight their way up. The guards couldn't understand why Tang Wei was so nervous. Besides, the banks were all downstairs; on this floor there was only their security company, full of big men and the smell of sweat and cigarettes. Bank robbers shouldn't make it their first stop.

"Hey, hey! Someone's jumping!" one guard said, pointing out the window.

Most saw a figure flash downward. Then came the sharp twang of a steel cable tightening and the creak of turning gears. An enormous dark shape rose outside the window. A courier in sunglasses stood in the rain, carrying a long sheathed sword. He unfastened the rappelling clip at his waist and threw the bare flower stems into the wind.

This was his direct route. He had fallen wearing a rappelling clip, while the Maintenance Department had activated the suspended platform used to wash the glass curtain wall. As the platform rose and Chu Zihang descended, he used the clip to slow himself and landed safely.

It looked elaborate, but was actually simple and practical: the optimal route Norma had devised after analyzing the entire building. The disturbance in the shops concealed the purpose of the operation, allowed control of the platform, and kept the mass of guards downstairs occupied.

Four minutes and forty seconds remained. Chu Zihang only had to clear the floor and retrieve the documents within that time. In the underground garage, the Panamera was already running, a maintenance man at the wheel. The garage entrance had been blocked, causing traffic to jam on the western road in a sea of red lights. The eastern road had been cleared. Once Chu Zihang reached the ground, he could leave immediately by car.

The timing was entirely under control. The plan was flawless, every piece meshing with the next.

The guards stared as the courier pressed a device resembling a stun gun against the tempered glass. Current flashed, the whole pane began to vibrate at high frequency, and then it shattered.

Chu Zihang entered the twenty-first floor. The guards had no time to think; they drew their electric batons and surrounded him. The two in front stepped forward together and struck at his head. By the standards of a martial-arts school, they were excellent students, each capable of fighting three or five men. But that was against people, and their opponent now... could hardly be called truly "human."

Chu Zihang suddenly accelerated. Before the raised batons could fall, he was chest to chest with the two guards. He pressed his hands against their chests, paused an instant, and released his power. He had chosen tai chi as his martial-arts elective; its soft, yielding force sent two men weighing over 150 jin reeling into the walls on either side. He caught the next two by the neck and spun seemingly lightly. The rotation flung them away, each knocking down two more guards. The others were stunned. There had been ten of them; six were down in an instant, and their opponent had clearly not even begun to fight in earnest. His sword was still in its sheath.

An entire squad of guards crowded into the corridor. Their comrades, unaware of what had happened, had come as reinforcements, full of energy. What kind of petty thief was this? Robbing a

bank branch and frightening pretty girls was one thing, but invading a security company was asking for death.

Chu Zihang frowned slightly. This squad would cost him more time. Then he heard a distant chant, like the chanting of ancient monks. A domain unfolded without a sound. The skin of every guard present flushed red as though blood were seeping through it. Their hearts pounded, sending blood surging through their bodies, and in an instant their physical abilities multiplied. They didn't even notice the change, but threw themselves at Chu Zihang with all their strength.

Yanling: King's Attendants, sequence number twenty-eight. It strengthened the bodies of living creatures within its domain. In ancient times, dragons had used it to inspire the humans and even beasts loyal to them, strengthening them into an army.

The intelligence had been slightly off. Norma had not mentioned a hybrid like this in the security company. Twenty-eight was not a high sequence number, but this Yanling strengthened companions, and a whole floor of companions surrounded its user.

Hidden from everyone's view in the shadows at the far end of the corridor, a slender figure chanted softly, faint gold flowing in their eyes.

The storm raged behind him; crowds of guards filled the passage ahead. Trapped in the narrow space, Chu Zihang did not retreat. Surging forward, the guards leaped, driven by a dose of adrenaline that had instantly doubled in their bloodstreams. High-voltage batons crisscrossed the air, static breaking through it in fine purple filaments that linked one baton to another.

Their display was intimidating, but still not enough to threaten Chu Zihang. There was a fundamental difference between hybrids and ordinary humans, however much the latter were strengthened.

Chu Zihang sprang back to avoid the blows. He leaped through the floor-to-ceiling window into the storm, where one last foothold remained: the suspended platform. It bought him a few brief seconds to find a reasonable answer to this surprise. Against physically enhanced opponents, he would have to strike harder, but that would inevitably injure them, and when the enhancement faded, the injuries would remain in full.

Chu Zihang rubbed his fingers together. They were unusually damp. He had overlooked something strange: the humidity on the twenty-first floor was extraordinarily high. More precisely, the air was oversaturated with moisture, faintly white like thick fog. The dense vapor had turned the air into a conductor, allowing the batons to spark between one another. But even during a storm, the humidity inside a centrally air-conditioned building should not have been so high.

The guards did not pursue him. Instead, they stopped together and formed a human wall in front of him. For an instant their faces all looked identical.

Chu Zihang shivered. The scene felt familiar: surrounded by a crowd of identical, expressionless faces.

Then he caught a familiar scent: the scent of a cold rainstorm, unique, one he had smelled only once before, on that elevated road shrouded in sheets of water!

A car horn sounded below. Chu Zihang looked down. On the deserted street to the east, a rust-spotted Maybach, headlights on, was driving slowly toward Tower A of the Runde Building.

Terror exploded in his heart. The Maybach's engine roared as it drove straight into a load-bearing pillar on the side of the building. Its heavy body struck at over a hundred miles an hour; the pillar tore its front end in two, and the entire building shook. The suspended platform jolted. Its cables slipped off the gears, caught between the bearings, and were twisted apart. Chu Zihang lost his balance as the entire platform fell!

He understood at once why the guards hadn't pursued him. They had merely wanted to force him into a death trap. They had succeeded.

Portofino, Italy.

Amid whirling leaves, a silver Rolls-Royce climbed the winding mountain road into the Splendid Hotel and stopped beside a white building close to the cliff.

The detached building had walls of hard white marble and narrow little windows, like a tiny fortress. Its private parking lot was nearly full: a Lamborghini, a vintage Jaguar, an AMG-modified Mercedes. Surprisingly, an orange mountain bike occupied an entire space alongside the luxury cars.

The driver bent to open the door, shielding its upper edge with his hand so the honored guest wouldn't bump her head. A golden high heel touched the ground, followed by a slender, breathtakingly beautiful leg. Unlike the aristocratic lady the shoe suggested, the passenger was a young woman with features as exquisite as a sculpture by a Greek master. She looked twenty, but her eyes belonged to someone in her thirties. She wore the makeup of a European grande dame, a black veil, an expensive fitted skirt suit, and a fur stole. Her slender heels gave her a swaying grace as she walked, but her cold face carried the imperious air of a queen.

"The sixth trustee, and the last. Elizabeth Laurent, twenty-two. Her family owns one of Europe's largest syndicates, with interests in mining and finance. After her father died in a plane crash, she had to interrupt her studies at the Royal Academy of Arts to inherit the business." Not far from the white building, behind the blinds of a hotel suite, a secretary named Parsi explained patiently.

"A woman who thinks she's very beautiful." Caesar lifted a slat and peered out.

"Indeed. Her family was once famous among hybrids for producing beautiful descendants." Parsi smiled.

"Hello, Liza, my child! Welcome, welcome. Right on time." An old man strode out to meet her, arms open. "You've grown again. I still remember you in your Eton uniform."

"Thank you, Anjou." She embraced him and exchanged cheek kisses. "You haven't seen me in eight years, then. You look just the same. Time seems to have stopped for you."

"For an old man, the god of time takes pity and lets the clock run a little more slowly." The old man offered her his arm like a gentleman.

She took it and climbed the stairs with him, like a beautiful daughter entering society for the first time with her elderly but still handsome father.

Principal Anjou of Cassell College.

"There should be one more trustee," Caesar said.

"I've never seen him attend, and I don't know his name," Parsi said.

"He spends enormous sums on the college every year but never comes to exercise the power he's entitled to. Magnificent."

"The trustees don't invest in Cassell College for money. They are," Parsi said softly, "the secret party of dragon-slaying families!"

A secret organization that had endured for thousands of years, an elite legion of hybrids that had trained countless brave fighters under an iron code—the Dragon Blood Secret Party had, in the modern world, taken the form of a college board of trustees.

"They're also this generation's council of elders, aren't they?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. The board and the council of elders are one and the same. The trustees are the highest class among hybrids, the true holders of power. Principal Anjou is only the executive they chose."

"All I can do is wait here until they call me in?" Caesar sipped the strong liquor in his glass.

"They're looking forward to meeting you. They'll certainly summon you." Parsi bowed slightly. "That's why your uncle arranged this year's annual board meeting at the Splendid: so you could make your formal appearance somewhere familiar and meet the people who hold power among hybrids."

"People who hold power?" Caesar savored the words.

The building's doors slowly closed from within. Four heavy ancient locks clicked shut together, sealing it completely.

"Everyone is here, so I declare this year's annual board meeting open." Seated at the end of the long table, Anjou shook a small brass bell.

The place had once been used by ancient monks for austere religious practice, so it was unusually dark. Though it was daytime, a row of candlesticks stood on the table, illuminating the trustees' faces.

There were six in all, four men and two women. On either side of Anjou sat two men so old their ages could no longer be guessed. Both wore crisp black suits with dark red handkerchiefs in their breast pockets. One leaned on a cane; the other fingered a string of rosewood beads and muttered under his breath, looking somewhat out of place. Another man, perhaps in his thirties or forties, wore a bright yellow tracksuit, with a bicycle helmet beside his right hand. A trustee of an elite school like Cassell College had actually ridden a bicycle to the meeting. The trustee beside Liza was startlingly young, a girl of sixteen or seventeen. Her long pale-gold hair was piled on her head, and her still baby-fat face was serious as an exquisite doll's. A butler in white gloves stood erect behind her, head high and chest out.

"The same people are here as last year. The one who never attends is absent as usual, and the Gattuso family has again sent Frost Gattuso, my old friend, in his brother's place." Anjou indicated the old man with the cane beside him.

Frost Gattuso picked up the bell in front of him and rang it. "Is the Bronze Report ready? I'm eager to know the conclusion." Ringing before speaking was a board tradition meant to prevent interruptions.

"It's the stack of papers in front of each of you," Anjou said.

As one, the trustees flipped through the elaborate report to the last page. The conclusion read: "The Monarch of Fire & Bronze was terminated."

Though the college taught Chinese, the report was in English for the trustees from different language backgrounds. It meant: the King of Bronze and Fire had been killed.

The trustees were silent for a moment before this definitive conclusion. It was an epoch-making event, and the final report had taken half a year to prepare so there would be no mistake. Though they

had all anticipated the conclusion, seeing the words with their own eyes still required a moment of quiet acceptance.

Frost rang again. "No Dragon King in history has ever been confirmed dead. Anjou, you need to produce evidence."

Without a word, Anjou took out a prismatic crystal and slid it along the table. The trustees exchanged glances. At last the old man with the beads picked it up and squinted at it against the light. It was artificial quartz, bearing the logo of an optical-products company in Texas. Its slightly convex surface acted as a magnifying glass. At its center was a dark-red line as fine as a hair, like a thread of congealed blood. The old man's pupils contracted. His hand trembled as he passed the crystal on.

"The Philosopher's Stone," he said softly, ringing his bell. "A newly made Philosopher's Stone, indeed."

"The crystallized 'fifth element' of alchemy: the Philosopher's Stone, said to turn any metal into gold, also a medicine that grants eternal life, the most sacred thing in alchemy." Anjou nodded. "As you all know, we have lost the method of producing it. The last alchemist in history to succeed was Nicolas Flamel, at five in the evening on April 25, 1382. No one has succeeded in the six hundred years since. Our existing reserves all came from ancient tombs. But what you hold is a brand-new stone, however small. It was refined from the bones of a Dragon King. His name was Constantine."

"Constantine is my name. I have been to the mountaintop of flames, where I melted a sea of bronze and forged the name of a god." The girl softly recited the ancient scripture.

"Now he is dead, and the name of bronze can be written only on his gravestone." Anjou's voice was cold and stern. "A dead god is nothing but a pile of old bones!"

After a long silence, Liza rose and applauded. The other trustees rose and joined her. Anjou stood slowly to accept their praise. Bracing both hands on the table, he looked at the candles and spoke in a low voice. "This is an epoch-making breakthrough, but before we reached this glory, tens of thousands of our comrades died along the way. I propose a moment of silence for the fallen. Their sacrifice bought us this."

The trustees bowed their heads. The meeting room was utterly silent; faintly, waves could be heard rolling below the cliff.

When the silence ended and the trustees sat again, Frost rang his bell. "The King of Bronze and Fire produced a Philosopher's Stone only that big? And to kill him, you consumed a 2.75-gram stone ground into a bullet."

"We used only one finger joint from the Dragon King's remains to refine it. If we destroyed all the bones, the yield would be much greater, but we aren't willing to do that yet," Anjou said. "The stone's purpose is simply to prove that what we obtained was true dragon bone, not an empty shell. If Constantine had left an egg in a 'burial place' and could awaken again, we certainly couldn't have refined the stone."

"'A first-generation dragon cannot be killed' was an iron rule we believed," Liza said, ringing her bell. "Why has it now been broken?"

Anjou shrugged. "It wasn't an iron rule, only dogma. The dogma was that they were 'immortal'; they simply had never been killed. It's really very simple. Making an egg takes time. We don't know

how a Dragon King makes one for himself, but clearly it doesn't arise naturally. Kill him before he makes one, and his spirit can't transfer into it. Then he dies."

"A Dragon King can't be unaware of that weakness," the girl said, ringing her bell. "The first thing they do after awakening should be to make an egg."

"Exactly. Like an alchemist who can make an elixir of immortality, each time he rises from death he should first make another dose and keep it close," Anjou said. "But there are exceptions. First, when a Dragon King awakens, his power is incomplete at first, and he may not even have his memories. Like a hybrid, he needs time to discover his bloodline. Second, in a rage, a Dragon King will put revenge first. We used the death of the younger brother Constantine to enrage the elder, Norton. So although we haven't found Norton's bones, we have reason to believe he died too."

"Both twins of the 'fire' line among the Four Monarchs were killed," the old man with the prayer beads said thoughtfully, ringing his bell. "Are all Four Monarchs twins?"

"Possibly, but we still don't know whether twins have a special religious or genetic significance to dragons," Anjou said.

Frost rang. "Where are Constantine's remains kept now?"

Anjou raised an eyebrow and was silent for several seconds. "Somewhere safe."

"Somewhere you consider safe, or somewhere we all consider safe?" Frost's question seemed to lower the temperature in the room.

Anjou seemed too bored to answer. He shifted to a more comfortable position in his chair. "Only two people in the whole world can enter. It's safer than the World Bank's vault."

"Which two?"

"One is me," Anjou said mildly. "The other built the vault."

"There are seven trustees, and none of us knows how to build vaults." Frost looked straight into Anjou's eyes. "In other words, you're the only one among us who can reach the Dragon King's remains. Is that right, Principal?"

"Mm." Anjou answered absently, taking a Havana No. 1 cigar from a cedar box. He slowly smelled it, snipped the end, warmed the body with a long match, lit it, and took a blissful puff.

Anyone could see he wanted to end the subject. The room seemed colder still. Frost Gattuso, the family representative, wore an icy expression. He was an important man who managed the whole family's business in his brother's place. His importance rested chiefly on the Gattusos' donations: they gave the college more each year than any other family, with Liza's Laurents second.

"Anjou, we greatly admire your courage and achievements in the cause of dragon slaying. But you must understand that Cassell College does not belong to you, and neither do the Dragon King's remains. You are the man we selected to manage that enterprise. In other words, you are our professional manager," Frost said slowly.

"I think I've managed it rather well. If I'm a CEO, I've just submitted a splendid annual report: two Dragon Kings killed." Anjou exhaled bluish smoke. "Trustee, this hardly seems the best time to question my management authority."

Liza rang her bell. "I agree with Anjou. This is an era of outstanding achievement, and he has shown more than enough leadership."

Frost picked up a printed document and slid it down the table to her. "Being an expert dragon slayer and being a good manager are two different things. These are the facts we've collected. Over the past ten years, the college's administrative costs have climbed steadily, with vast sums wasted in strange places. Every year, for example, Principal Anjou announces a carnival called Freedom Day, when students may do as they please on campus so long as nobody is injured. It has become an armed showdown between the college's two major clubs, consuming huge quantities of alchemical ammunition and leaving enormous repair bills every year."

"In return the students agree to obey the rules the rest of the time and not fight with Yanling on or off campus. Youthful hormones need an outlet." Anjou shrugged. "It's a small part of the college's enormous expenses."

"Then your chartered flights around the world for vacations, also charged to the college, must be an even smaller part," Frost said coldly.

Anjou scratched his graying hair. "To be honest, that costs quite a bit more than Freedom Day..."

"Principal Anjou is very popular at the college. He even has a fan club whose members call themselves Team Anjou. To them, it doesn't matter whether the board exists; with a spiritual leader like Principal Anjou, exterminating the dragons is no problem."

"That's excessive praise." The old fellow held his cigar between his teeth, apparently modest but positively glowing with delight.

"The Executive Department's methods have grown increasingly outrageous—or you may call them brave. They look like thugs willing to sacrifice all humanity for the great cause of dragon slaying. Our brave young people tour the world waving weapons modified by the Equipment Department like mounted Western cowboys righting wrongs. They don't hesitate to start fights in the heart of major cities. Cleaning up after them costs tens of millions of dollars every year."

"It's all for our great cause."

"And every year the college holds a beauty contest called Campus Star, with Principal Anjou personally judging and dancing with the beautiful young freshmen. Every evening there are parties of all kinds. Students fill basements with soap bubbles, jump in wearing swimsuits, and dance Latin dances. The campus network has such a free atmosphere... someone even dug up gossip about a department chair's first girlfriend." Frost raised an eyebrow. "Is that also for our great cause?"

Everyone fell silent. The trustees passed the document around. It was detailed and well substantiated; under the principal's leadership, the college did indeed appear free and uninhibited... or rather, a carnival of demons.

It seemed hard to find words to defend him.

"You aren't thinking of firing me, are you?" Anjou asked leisurely.

Liza rang. "I think we can end this discussion. Compared with the great cause of dragon slaying, these are trifles! We needn't waste time on them. The board isn't a place for quarrels. Can you imagine the elders arguing over a few extra tens of thousands of gold coins a year back when we were still called the Secret Party?"

Frost rang. "We haven't said anything about firing anyone. My point is, Anjou, do your job, but don't assume the whole college should be under your control. It's time to hand the Dragon King's remains over to the board for safekeeping!"

"That's a fortune," Anjou said, continuing to smoke. "We don't yet know what those bones, still carrying a dragon's soul, can do, but at the very least they can produce the Philosopher's Stone. What does the board intend to do with them? Or... what does the Gattuso family intend?"

Frost tapped the table. "Watch your words, Anjou. I'm speaking for the board, not the Gattuso family!"

"You can fire me as the board," the old man said with a shrug, "but I won't hand the remains over to you. There's nothing to discuss."

The trustees were shocked. In their experience, Anjou might be excessively unconventional at times, but he was still a model old-fashioned gentleman. Hearing such blunt defiance from the principal made them wonder whether he'd lost his mind.

The old man fingering his beads frowned and rang. "Anjou, you've exceeded your authority!"

Liza rang. "Can we stop discussing this? Custody of the dragon bones isn't on today's agenda!"

The girl glanced back at her butler and rang. "I think Principal Anjou should be reminded that the Secret Party's wealth must be entrusted to the council of elders. Only the board has the authority to dispose of the bones!"

The middle-aged man, silent until now, looked from side to side and rang. "Let's not spoil the harmony..."

Frost rang. "This is no longer a question of harmony! Exceeding his authority! That's what it is!"

The air around the table grew so heated it seemed ready to ignite. Everyone tried to speak; everyone rang a bell. The clear sounds merged into a deafening, uneasy uproar. The trustees rose as one and split into two arguing camps. Liza clearly supported Anjou; the two old men looked stern; after each glance at her butler, the girl hurled forceful words at Anjou; and the middle-aged man kept chattering, "Stay calm"...

Suddenly a more furious ringing drowned out every voice, full of impatience and ferocity.

All eyes turned to the man ringing: Anjou. The old fellow had seized several bells around him and was shaking them furiously over his head, cigar clenched between his teeth as clouds of smoke poured out. He looked rather like some villain wielding a soul-shaking bell in The Investiture of the Gods...

Anjou threw the bells onto the table, leaned back, and exhaled at length. "All right. This subject won't reach a conclusion, so we can end it. You won't fire me for now, because you can't find anyone to replace me."

After a long silence, the trustees resumed their seats. Anjou had named the problem closest to their hearts. Supporters and opponents alike admitted that in Cassell's hundred-plus years, no one had appeared who could replace him. Behind Anjou stood the department heads, powerful supporters and elites among hybrids.

"Next item: the candidate for the Nibelungen Project." Anjou clapped his hands. "Allow me to introduce our A-rank student, an elite beyond question: Caesar Gattuso."

The door opened. Brilliant gold hair, sea-blue eyes, a pure-white dinner suit, and a violet silk handkerchief in his breast pocket: Caesar Gattuso appeared before the trustees in unapologetically flamboyant attire.

"So handsome!" the girl blurted out involuntarily.

The butler promptly put a hand on her shoulder. "Miss, composure."

Embarrassed, she resumed the solemn face of a trustee, her little face stiff with the effort.

Caesar nodded slightly to everyone and sat casually in the empty seat at the end of the table.

"No student has ever been invited to a board meeting in all these years. You're the first." Anjou glanced at Caesar, then turned to the trustees. "A brief introduction: he has just been reelected Student Council president unanimously, unprecedented in college history, though that has something to do with his turning the council into his personal fan club. His GPA is 2.7, rather poor, the same as former President George W. Bush's at Yale. Numerous tardies, two failed courses... Oh, he's one of the leaders in the armed battles on Freedom Day. He also received a warning for filling the swimming pool with beer in winter and holding a lavish beer-swimming competition, which cracked the frozen pool."

"I wanted champagne, but buying that much of the same brand at once was a little difficult." Caesar didn't mind the awful introduction; he merely supplemented the last point.

"The one main reason he can sit here as a candidate is that he killed the Dragon King Norton," Anjou said.

After a moment's silence, the trustees applauded politely. This single merit erased all the preceding shortcomings. Someone who could kill a Dragon King deserved a hero's respect and a seat among the trustees.

"Unfortunately, Caesar, I can't reveal the trustees' names to you," Anjou said. "Except one, of course: your uncle. Won't you say hello?"

Caesar seemed not to hear. From the moment he entered the room, he had not looked at Frost Gattuso, his own uncle. Nor had he ever told anyone that he belonged to a trustee's family.

"You didn't summon me here because the Gattusos sit on the board, did you?" Caesar looked at Anjou. "When I entered Cassell, I said it was my personal choice, nothing to do with the family."

"No. It's because of a project: the Nibelungen Project," Frost Gattuso said.

"Nibelungen?" Caesar repeated the name.

He knew it as the land of the dead in Norse mythology. In Wagner's famous opera The Ring of the Nibelung, the ring of that name represented power: whoever possessed it would possess the world. A family music teacher had taught him to appreciate opera since childhood, and he liked heroic themes.

"Before we disclose the project, we have a few questions," Liza said. "What do you think of dragon slaying?"

"Enormous fun." Caesar's answer was nonsensical.

The butler whispered to the girl. She nodded, fixing her dark-green, catlike eyes on Caesar. "Why slay dragons? Without following Cassell's path, you could still enjoy an aristocrat's life."

"Isn't human existence a matter of proving oneself again and again?" His ice-blue eyes met hers without flinching. "I haven't found a better way to prove myself."

"Good," Anjou said. "What is your goal for the future?"

"Wait for the next Dragon King to awaken and kill him." Caesar spread his hands. "I only hope he won't wait until I've died of old age."

"I like that lawless tone. Frost, you see, your nephew is actually more like me than you..." Anjou smiled. "Caesar, you faced Norton directly. Did you feel his overwhelming power?"

Caesar grew grave. After a pause he nodded. "Overwhelming power, an aura like the tide. Suffocating!"

"Yes. Nothing trains a dragon slayer better than experiencing a battlefield and smelling blood. You felt a Dragon King's power: absolute strength that numbers alone cannot oppose. We all have dragon blood; dragons are half our ancestry. Our bloodline makes us instinctively want to submit to them. Only the strongest will and finest blood can preserve dignity before a Dragon King and kill him! So Cassell must train not a crowd, but the elite of the elite, heroes among heroes, incomparable like Meinhard Cassell, the first president of the Lionheart Society." Anjou looked into Caesar's eyes, his voice low. "Because the worst time... is almost upon us."

"The worst time?"

"The Dragon Kings on the other three thrones of the Four Monarchs will all awaken. Myth foretold a collective awakening, and Norton's awakening proves the prophecy. You wanted to know when the next Dragon King would wake? Perhaps... today!"

"A collective awakening...?" Caesar drew a deep breath.

"So we can no longer wait. We must choose the finest bloodline among outstanding candidates and devote everything to training that person. He will be the Dragon Kings' mortal enemy." Anjou paused. "The world's savior."

"Me?" Caesar pointed at himself.

"Possibly you," Liza said.

"If devoting everything to my training means more classes and drills, forget it. I'm not good at that. My GPA's only 2.7, as bad as the former president's at Yale, as the principal already said." Caesar shrugged.

"No. What we intend to strengthen is your bloodline," Frost said slowly.

"Strengthen my bloodline?"

"Did you know someone can possess more than one Yanling?"

"No."

"Did you know some hybrids can attain the power of purebloods while remaining hybrids?"

"No."

"Have you heard of a 'hybrid monarch'?"

"Comparable to the Four Monarchs?"

"Perhaps even surpassing a Dragon King!" Frost enunciated every word. "That is the Nibelungen Project: strengthen the bloodline, break through the hybrid's limits and the theories in textbooks. Caesar, this is no fantasy. The Secret Party's council of elders can do it. It is a tremendous gift, and we are choosing one person to receive it. Acceptance means power, but also enormous sacrifice. You will face every danger and may even die. Are you willing?"

For once Caesar looked directly at his uncle. Frost's solemn face resembled a preaching pastor's. The room was dead silent; everyone watched Caesar.

Caesar licked his lips. "Why does this feel a little like... wedding vows?"

"Caesar!" Frost was furious.

Anjou laughed aloud.

"Great sacrifice, every danger, risking my life: none of that's much. If giving up those little things would put someone at the top of the hybrids, plenty at the college would accept." Caesar raised an eyebrow. "I'm only curious why you chose me."

"Because you're good enough," Anjou said.

"Why not Chu Zihang?"

"He lacks experience killing a Dragon King directly. In that respect he falls short of you."

"Why not Lu Mingfei?"

Anjou smiled. "Mingfei's still new. Many people think giving him S-rank was my mistake."

"But you value him. He shot a Dragon King and gravely wounded the target. When we faced Constantine, you used Yanling: Time Zero and handed him the sniper rifle. Without doubt you expected him to deliver the final shot, though he missed." Caesar's voice was cold. "You might casually give someone S-rank, but I don't believe you'd entrust your life to a useless nobody while fighting a Dragon King at close quarters."

"And your uncle insisted you were the best," Anjou said. "He said ability means not just bloodline, but organization and leadership. We need a leader people will follow as well as a genius. You're a brilliant leader among the new generation; not even Chu Zihang can match you there. Under you the Student Council has grown into a club able to rival the Lionheart Society. So we made you the Nibelungen Project's first candidate."

Frost had mastered his anger. His low voice was gentle. "Caesar, do you understand now? The family has always loved you selflessly... and placed its hopes in you!"

From Frost Gattuso, this was naked praise and support, a declaration of his determination to put Caesar on a throne. Yet the trustees were silent; no one objected. The candidates had been rigorously selected in advance, and Caesar truly was the best choice. Everyone acknowledged it.

Caesar kept his head down, playing with his fingers as he listened to his uncle finish.

"Uncle, have you ever lost the most important person in your life?" He slowly raised his head and asked the strange question.

"Oh, I forgot. A man like you doesn't have anyone important in his life. So you don't know that people who've experienced that often become particularly stubborn and resistant to certain things. Psychologists say"—Caesar smiled and pointed to his heart—"it's a mental illness."

"I refuse." Caesar rose and bowed. "If there's nothing else, excuse me."

Leaning against an ivy-covered marble column, Caesar leisurely drank an iced gin and watched the luxury cars leave the hotel gates one by one. Last came the mountain bike. Seeing its rider wiggle his rear as he pedaled hard, Caesar couldn't help laughing.

"Is it fun challenging the authority of the family and the trustees?" Frost Gattuso had silently appeared at his side.

"At Cassell I'm only a student. Trustees are exalted people we can't afford to offend. But I said 'I refuse' and made them end their meeting without a result, made you important people come for nothing, and made one of you wiggle his rear on the way home. I thought that was amusing," Caesar said coldly.

"Your childishness is truly intolerable to the family."

Caesar laughed softly. "You know, Uncle, I guessed why you wanted me when I went in. Though the 'hybrid monarch' surprised me, I was right that you meant to promote me. I've been holding it in and playing a game with you, wondering what expression you'd make when I said, 'I refuse.'"

Frost wasn't angry. He sighed quietly. "What put such a cruel streak in your heart? You're a genius the family rarely sees in centuries, first-rate in blood and talent. You want to be a leader too, and you've always worked hard. The family loves you and wants to help. Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei may obstruct your path; we don't want that. You're the best; no one should be ranked above you. The family is promoting the Nibelungen Project to secure your future position."

"My bloodline? Uncle, you've forgotten something. I inherited only half of the Gattusos' noble blood. The other half came from a lowly name, lowly..." Caesar's smile vanished. "Gullveig."

"Still dwelling on your mother's death?" Frost shook his head. "It seems the misunderstanding between us runs deep. To the family, Gullveig's bloodline was indeed not noble. Her marriage to your father wasn't blessed by the family. But you're different. The entire family recognizes you as its descendant with the finest blood. Your talent has proved it."

"A lowborn woman marries a husband of noble blood, bears a child, and dies. His family despises her blood but accepts the child mixed with it." Caesar looked down and laughed. "It's like a story where nobody likes pigs because they're dirty, but when one dies, people cut off the tenderest pork chop. A chef carefully fries it with matsutake and morels, lays it on a spotless china plate, and serves it on a silver tray."

"Caesar, trust the family. Your mother's death had nothing to do with us. Her funeral was held at Westminster Cathedral, the pope himself presided, and the entire family attended. Her soul is at rest."

"Don't be ridiculous. We're a family descended from dragons; we don't believe in religion. A funeral conducted by the pope counts as compensation?"

"It was an honor in mourning. The family honored her in return for her contribution." Frost was deeply earnest. "Caesar, you are her contribution. Think: the only thing she left from her life was you. If her spirit lives, wouldn't she want to see you achieve a man's great work? The Nibelungen Project is the family's love for you, a gift without equal. Refusing it would hurt your mother too. She's watching you from heaven."

"No. She can't see." Caesar slowly lifted his head. His expression had changed. Few had seen the face he kept hidden: a cold, thin smile, ice in his eyes.

"When she died, she couldn't see or hear anymore. That was the price she paid to give birth to me." Caesar looked at his hand. "All I could do then was hold her hand." He slowly clenched his fist; his knuckles cracked softly. "I didn't dare let go, because I thought how terrible it must be... She couldn't see or hear. If no one held her hand, she'd feel that no one in the world wanted her anymore. She knew nothing of the honors the family gave her. The only connection between her and the world was the warmth passing from my palm." Caesar laughed hoarsely. "Uncle, I'll repeat what I told you: I'm Gullveig's descendant. I'm not that close to you Gattusos."

Frost watched him, seeming to see the sorrowful, surging force pouring from his body. After a long time, he sighed again.

"Caesar, look at the sea. The wind's rising. It's going to rain," Frost said suddenly.

Caesar followed his gaze to the rolling Gulf of Genoa. Dark clouds were gathering, heavy as lead.

"Before you came in, the family had a disagreement with Anjou," Frost said softly. "We have just killed the King of Bronze and Fire. In the face of such an epoch-making miracle, why argue? Because the waves are rising. A new era is coming."

"A new era?"

"Hybrids can kill Dragon Kings now. At last we see hope of ending the dragons' history. Afterward, hybrids will be the world's finest people, far superior to ordinary humans. With dragons gone, no one can stand against us. The world's order will be rewritten, as in the Age of Exploration, as in the Industrial Revolution. That will be the age of hybrids, and you will be their leader." Frost sounded like a poet singing of a glorious future. "The family is putting all its strength behind you now. Isn't that enough proof of our love? You will be the new era's... emperor!"

His voice held a faint temptation, like the serpent in Eden telling Adam and Eve, "Eat the fruit of that tree, and you will stand beside God."

Caesar turned his glass in his hand and said nothing.

"Think again, Caesar. If you're willing, the family will raise the Nibelungen Project at the next board meeting, with you as the sole candidate. Many people dream of this opportunity. Now the family offers it to you; please accept." Frost coaxed him patiently. "Don't miss the best moment. Understand that the family cannot absolutely control the board. Sooner or later the project must begin to oppose the Dragon Kings' collective awakening. If you give it up, Chu Zihang or Lu Mingfei will take your place. Opportunity won't wait forever for one person."

"Yes, I long to prove myself. I long for glory and power." Caesar lifted his head.

"Good. That's what we hoped to hear."

"But I'm different from you." Caesar turned and looked at Frost coldly. "I'll seize my own future with my own hands. Chu Zihang, Lu Mingfei, anyone else who might threaten me—I'll compete with them face to face! One day I'll have everything I want, not as head of the Gattuso family, but as Caesar. Just Caesar, like the man my Dictator was named for. Take back your gift. It's a little dirty."

A cold sea wind blew between uncle and nephew as they met each other's eyes, neither willing to show weakness.

At last Frost looked away. He sighed. "Hatred takes only an instant to build, but love takes many years. Caesar, you're still too young. One day you'll understand the family's love." He drew an envelope from his coat, the Gattuso crest stamped in red sealing wax. "I brought a letter from your father. I meant to give it to you at the celebration launching the Nibelungen Project... The family knows whom you love. Regrettably, her blood, like your mother Gullveig's, isn't noble enough. By rights, bloodline is the absolute standard when the family chooses a bride. But we don't want your mother's tragedy repeated, and we're willing to change the rules for you."

"If you're willing to accept the Nibelungen Project's gift," Frost said, looking into Caesar's eyes, "the family will make an exception and approve your engagement to Chen Motong. Your union will have the family's blessing."

Caesar stared. Slowly he finished his drink. "How generous..."

"You should understand how enormous the family's blessing on your engagement is. Do you still doubt us? The family blesses only its future head's marriage. You are that future head. Surely you don't want your future wife Chen Motong denied our blessing? How pitiable she would be!"

With a loud crash, Caesar's glass shattered on the ground, scattering pale pink shards.

"My engagement has nothing to do with the family. Now take your generosity and"—Caesar bit the tip of his tongue and spat one savage word with the force of someone hawking up phlegm—"get lost!"

A startling rage burst from his eyes. They even glimmered faintly gold, a sign that in a hybrid appeared only at extremes of emotion.

His dragon blood boiled fiercely!

In the distance, Anjou also drank gin, watching uncle and nephew with a faintly mischievous smile. Without Kamaitachi's hearing he couldn't make out their words, but their changing expressions were enough to make the drama entertaining.

At last Frost turned away in anger, leaving Caesar alone looking at the sea. His lowered eyes were shadowed, no longer pure ice blue but dark and deep like the sea under cirrus clouds.

"A family melodrama," Anjou said with a shrug. His phone rang. He answered, then frowned a few seconds later. "Chu Zihang's in trouble again?"

Runde Building, 18:57.

The headlights of the van marked "FedEx" suddenly came on. As their beams pierced the rain, its old engine made a dreadful noise, like an old man drawing a great breath into withered lungs, preparing to drive his stiff, aged muscles at any cost. The van burst through the glass curtain wall in a storm of shards and struck a wedge-shaped load-bearing pillar. The pillar stopped it and split its front end in two, like a sharp blade cutting into an enemy's skull.

Sparks flew from the engine, the radiator burst, and white steam filled the air. The entire building shook, but not as violently as the maintenance men's hearts. The windshield had broken. The cab was empty.

This was the van they had driven here. The key was still in one man's pocket, and they had left nobody inside. Yet while they threw the shopping floors into chaos, the driverless van had been silently circling the building, like a beast circling prey, seeking an opening.

Was this utterly lifeless van... trying to hunt humans?

Supernatural events were hardly unusual to maintenance men with dragon blood, and they immediately escalated their response. One drew a flare gun, knelt, and fired. A dazzling red signal flare shot through the glassless window into the van.

To these men a flare gun could hardly be called a weapon; they had once slaughtered enemies with submachine guns in both hands. This one was an exception. Its enormous recoil knocked a former SEAL who could bench-press 250 pounds flat on his back. The "flare" screamed through the entire vehicle, flew out of the building, and melted a twenty-centimeter hole in an aluminum-alloy sculpture in the center of the square.

"Can that... still be called a flare?" The maintenance man felt as if he had fired a miniature rocket.

But he ought to be used to it: this was the Equipment Department's style, perverse modifications, immense power, and... vague instructions. When the launcher was issued, the armorer had casually insisted that it be fired vertically to avoid "unpredictable" consequences. Now the man understood that it really was sound advice. Firing a rocket at any target would have "unpredictable" consequences.

Still, it had been fired. Surely not even a ghost could withstand a weapon from the Equipment Department? The men exchanged glances.

Everything seemed normal again. The van that had suddenly moved by itself had caused no trouble... Then a piercing metallic scrape reached their ears, like a steel cable... breaking.

Seconds later, a tremendous crash sounded outside the glass wall. The suspended platform, weighing hundreds of kilograms, smashed into the asphalt.

The maintenance men stared in shock. According to the schedule, Chu Zihang... had been on that platform!

Chu Zihang floated in the rain. The instant the platform fell, he had jumped with all his strength, head tilted back toward the sky. The whole sky was reflected in his pupils; from this angle every raindrop seemed to fall from one point at its center, all of them destined for his eyes.

Like a god observing the world from the air, he saw it with extraordinary clarity.

In an instant he underwent a transformation as though reborn. Blood rushed through his veins like a great river thawing from ice; every cell breathed recklessly and with all its strength, like a spring bud. Endless power passed silently along muscle and sinew.

He had used blood amplification.

This technique instantaneously increased bloodline purity through mental means. Before the industrial age it had been the deepest secret of certain families, allowing a hybrid body to gain power close to a pureblood dragon's. But it was also regarded as black magic and subjected to many restrictions. After the persecution of heretics in the dark Middle Ages, the secret ceased to be passed down. Not until the early twentieth century did the Secret Party's rising Lionheart Society rediscover it, quickly surpassing the older generation to establish itself as the new generation's leader.

And Chu Zihang was the current Lionheart Society president.

The records preserved by the society said a lion lay hidden in one's bloodline. If you were willing to untie the ropes binding it, you could gain its strength. And what bound that strength was yourself.

The Lionheart Society's original meaning was "the society that releases the lion's heart."

With a motion no human could possibly perform, Chu Zihang stepped against the glass curtain wall and used a moment's friction to check his fall. He threw away the scabbard and drove Murasame through the glass. The force of his descent left a smooth cut down its surface!

He exerted force with one hand and leaped back onto the twenty-first floor. Confronted by his sudden return, the guards showed no panic, as though they saw nothing astonishing in defying gravity. They tightened their grips on their batons; some unfastened iron chains from their waists. Chu Zihang looked around, eyes unfocused. He wasn't looking at the eager guards at all; those antlike things did not exist in his sight.

If a god looked down on the world, would he gaze at every passerby? It was like a child crouching beside a tree root, watching ants busily going in and out and poking a stick into their nest, without truly looking at any individual ant.

Once you possessed the power to reduce an individual to ashes with ease, you would no longer notice its existence.

His sunglasses had fallen during the descent. Blazing golden eyes lit the mist. The guards began to retreat; the majesty of those pupils opposed the Yanling controlling them. It was a gaze from on high, as though a hand gripped each heart and would crush it if the owner resisted and failed to answer.

The faint, dreamlike song suddenly rose, piercing the air like a blade, and the domain expanded at once. Bright beads of blood seeped from the guards' skin. Their bodies had been strengthened to the limit; their blood pressure was so high that capillaries burst. The Yanling overcame the authority of the golden eyes, extinguishing their fear. They leaped again, electric batons high overhead, spiderweb filaments of static entwining them. An attack without a blind spot closed in from every direction at once.

Yanling: Sovereign Flame opened its domain.

Enormous heat filled the confined space. In a few hundredths of a second, the temperature approached eighty degrees Celsius. The heat drove the fog away at once. In a spherical space two meters across, centered on Chu Zihang, the air became completely clear; outside the domain the fog remained, the boundary plainly visible. Guards fell on either side of him before a single baton could touch him. The sudden heat gave their bodies no time to react; their temperatures shot above forty degrees and their brains immediately shut down.

Metal clacked in the fog ahead: a gun being chambered. A guard raised an illegal imitation Black Star pistol and aimed at Chu Zihang's head. Chu Zihang's eyelid twitched. Suddenly he was before the guard, gripping his wrist. He squeezed silently, breaking both wrist bones. He threw the unconscious guard aside. His own hand had entirely changed shape: bones protruded, fine iron-blue scales covered its back, and sharp claws sheathed his nails. Several guards swept iron chains low along the floor, trying to break his shins. He didn't evade, allowing the chains to coil around his legs. They pulled in opposite directions to bring him down. Chu Zihang crouched, seized all the chains, and slowly dragged the guards back toward him. Their muscles bulged, their strength now comparable to bulls, yet he pulled those maddened bulls back by sheer force.

The chains suddenly became searing hot. The guards screamed and let go, but the skin of their palms had burned onto the metal. Sovereign Flame heated the chains until they glowed faintly red. Chu Zihang swung them like red snakes across the guards' backs, leaving black marks; faintly came the sound of bones breaking.

Seconds ago the place had been crowded; now everyone lay on the floor. The smell of burning and a faint scent of blood filled the air. Fog was everywhere, a white expanse hiding the end of the corridor.

The King's Attendants domain that had enveloped the guards suddenly collapsed. They awoke as if from a dream, their bodies completely unable to resist their injuries. Some howled; others fainted from the pain.

Dragging the red-hot chains among the wounded, Chu Zihang seemed like a flame demon emerging from an opened hell.

The guards crawled backward in terror. Chu Zihang still held an utterly aggressive stance, but everyone capable of opposing him had fallen. How could he attack further?

To swing those chains again could only mean slaughter!

He walked past them, chains scraping shrilly. His eyes held none of the howling men; he simply advanced down the vapor-filled corridor, still in a fully attacking posture. The guards stared, wondering whether he had gone mad. Ahead was only an empty doorway; nobody remained inside.

With a hiss, a cold curtain of water fell from above. The fire-safety system had begun spraying, alerted by Sovereign Flame's heat.

An empty corridor, bodies covering the floor, thick fog, water falling from the sky... Chu Zihang wiped his face. It felt like standing alone in a rainy night.

He advanced step by step. A red "Exit" sign flashed in the mist at the corridor's end. Thuds came from the door, as though someone were pounding madly to get out; at some point the pounding became deafening. He kicked the door open. Denser white vapor poured out. Under deathly pale fluorescent light stood those strangely familiar shadows whose faces one could never remember, silently greeting him with expressionless faces and whispered murmurs, exactly like the reception six years ago.

The guards couldn't see them, but to him they were exceptionally real. The twenty-first floor was full of people, walking slowly out of the fog toward Chu Zihang, their faces blank.

He removed the earpiece from behind his ear, threw it down, and crushed it underfoot, severing contact with everyone else.

What followed really could only be slaughter. That man had once said there was no need for mercy toward these things, because they could not even be called living people.

"Abort the operation! Withdraw personnel!" Manstein seized the microphone and shouted. "The police are almost here! No one can fall into their hands! Where is Chu Zihang? Where is Chu Zihang?"

On the globe projection, a red dot in East Asia flashed rapidly, alarms sweeping through the central control room. The operation there was sliding out of control. Manstein didn't know what had happened; an elaborately designed operation had been thrown completely off rhythm by a ghostly driverless van. They had lost contact with Chu Zihang, and no one knew what was happening on the twenty-first floor. The terrible cracking before communications failed was chilling.

"Continue the operation." Schneider suddenly reached over and seized the microphone, stopping him. "I know where Chu Zihang is."

Schneider brought up a login screen and entered a password. A cross section of the Runde Building appeared, with a rapidly blinking red dot on the twenty-first floor.

"That's Chu Zihang," Schneider said quietly. "He's all right, moving on the twenty-first floor."

"Thank goodness." Guderian held his chest and breathed out deeply.

Manstein stared. "What's he doing?"

"I don't know..." Schneider said.

At that moment in China, eighteen thousand kilometers away, Murasame, trailing flickering firelight, cut through the fog again and again, leaving transparent slashes in the air that crossed like a calligraphy practice sheet written with fierce strokes. Ink-black shadows rushed at him one after another, only to be swept into splashes of thick darkness by the blade, shattering in the mist into countless threads of ink. When black blood coated Murasame's edge, clear drops condensed on it and washed the darkness away. Chu Zihang paused briefly and looked around, holding the sword across his left arm, its point sloping down as ink-dark drops fell slowly from it. More black shapes stepped out of the mist. He had no time to distinguish reality from illusion, just as on that night in the typhoon. Then he had been a frail boy; now he had set his dragon blood alight. Without hesitation, without asking why, he sent a storm of blades cutting through the fog once more.

What were his enemies? He needed only to cut them down!

The ground-floor shopping area had completely changed. Some maintenance men helped guards evacuate frightened crowds; others fought a fire. A shop selling ZIPPO lighters had collapsed in the shaking, and lighter fuel had caught fire. Faced with a stranger disaster, the guards had no time for the American muscle men, who seemed merely a little crazy and out for amusement.

"Who's still on the twenty-first floor?" the Maintenance Department leader demanded in fluent Chinese, rushing up to a guard.

"No one! Everyone's evacuated to the twentieth!" the guard shouted. "We've checked every identity."

An inexplicable chill ran through the leader. If the twenty-first floor was empty, who was holding Chu Zihang up there? His suddenly quickened breathing before communications failed had given them a bad feeling.

"But he's never disappointed me. He'll bring back what we need." Schneider checked the clock. "He has more than two minutes. There's still time."

"Two minutes? According to plan he should already be in the descending elevator with the documents! Still time? The entire operation is out of rhythm! Call your student back!" Manstein was shocked and furious; Schneider's firmness and indifference were completely unexpected. He was violating Executive Department procedures, although the procedures existed to be violated. Manstein couldn't understand his confidence, as though everything were still under control.

"I can't call him back. I can't reach him either. The schedule is broken, so it's broken. He's already left your plan," Schneider said coldly.

"Left the plan?"

"He's still operating, but not along your planned track. He'll retrieve the documents independently. I told you sending him alone was enough. The team is an obstacle to him, not support."

"He... alone?" Manstein could hardly believe his ears. This was an SS-rank mission. Norma had repeatedly simulated the plan and excluded risks in advance before settling on a nine-person team. Each person had a duty; together they were nine components of a precisely coordinated machine running at high speed. Now one component had broken away and was trying to perform the entire machine's function independently. More ridiculous still, the man who had made that component firmly believed it could succeed. It was as absurd as a racing tire preparing to run an entire rally in place of the car, while its designer applauded the brave tire!

"It's not hard for him. I only hope he doesn't make too much of a mess." Schneider handed Manstein a stack of documents he had prepared.

Manstein opened them in confusion. After the first few paragraphs his expression changed; his pupils widened and glimmered faintly gold.

"His previous mission reports. The real versions. The ones you found in Norma were polished by me," Schneider said mildly.

After half a page Manstein closed the folder. Silent for several seconds, he drew a deep breath. "Schneider... do you know what your student is?"

"No, but he's very useful. He's still an intern, but he's the Executive Department's ace commissioner."

"But you don't trust him." Manstein stared into his eyes. "So you planted a transmitter on him. Does he know?"

Schneider looked out the window. "He doesn't. It isn't a question of trust. If you have a sharp knife, you always want to know where it is, so it doesn't accidentally cut someone."

"Where is the transmitter?"

"He had a tooth filled in the college infirmary. It was implanted in a molar then, covered by a titanium-alloy crown. Even X-rays won't show it."

"Even someone with that fine a bloodline gets cavities?" Guderian said.

"I was oddly relieved when I learned he did," Schneider said quietly. "It makes him seem human. Humans are supposed to be a flawed species: they get sick, feel pain, and grow afraid. They aren't perfect, but they're more real."

"What do we do now? Just wait? Three professors on duty are responsible for an operation, and all we can do is wait more than ten thousand kilometers away for your prized student to turn in a satisfactory answer?" Manstein frowned tightly.

"Ninety-five seconds left. He'll hand it in. He's always punctual," Schneider said.

"Dad, listen. I have... Do you have paper and a pen? If not, get them! Quickly!" Curled under his desk, Tang Wei clutched the landline. Only this heavy huanghuali-wood furniture could make him feel safe now; with his back against its thick panel, his heart was beating just slowly enough to avoid a heart attack.

"I have three bank cards, Bank of Communications, China Merchants, and ICBC. I wrote the numbers inside the blue photo album at home. The password is your birthday backward... Dad, don't interrupt. Let me finish. I'm busy and have to hang up soon." Tang Wei panted, fighting to keep his voice from shaking and giving himself away. "The deeds to our properties are at Auntie's. Six apartments and one shop, seven deeds in all, don't count wrong. I bought a three-million trust in your name; it matures in a year and a half. Don't forget your commercial insurance either, another three million... Oh, right, my watches and jade are valuable too, worth two million together. Don't throw them away." He wiped his face, but tears kept betraying him. "I'm fine, don't worry. Aren't we applying for visas? I'm telling you how much money we have so you can answer the visa officer... I'm really fine! Why don't you believe me? Can you stop fucking arguing with me? You've fussed over me since I was little. Do you have to do it now too...?"

"I have a visitor. I won't be home for dinner tonight." He hung up and pulled out the phone cord.

The office was dark. Sprinklers sprayed like mad; rain fell outside and inside the entire building, bitterly cold. The air-conditioning had stopped, the power had failed, and the building was paralyzed. Tang Wei was trapped in this office. A private elevator requiring a VIP card had once come directly here, but now it wouldn't respond no matter how often he swiped. This top-floor office was his real one, known only to a few trusted brothers. He had built a safe into the wall for cash, ledgers, and important things, including the paper envelope of documents. When bored in his twenty-first-floor office, he occasionally took the VIP elevator up to play games, so he kept many personal belongings here too.

Now Tang Wei thought he would die in this office.

He had sensed trouble from the moment that fearsome gang of American muscle men entered the shops. Then came the strange site message and someone breaking into the twenty-first floor, where dozens of his men were stationed—a heavily defended position, in military terms. But when he called down only half a minute later, no one answered. Tang Wei wanted to run, but it was too late.

He had always known a hunter's money wasn't easy. As the saying went, "Live by the underworld, and sooner or later you pay." He had done so many shady things over the years, digging up dozens of ancestral graves alone, that he wouldn't believe in no retribution himself. He wanted to go to Vietnam because perhaps it was far enough away that retribution, having no sense of direction, couldn't find him. He had earned enough and was supposed to retire tonight. Damn it, in a risky trade like this, "retire" was a taboo word. Countless masters died the night before retiring: Qu Yang and Liu Zhengfeng, the two old men who understood one another in The Smiling, Proud Wanderer, or Xu Wenqiang in The Bund, preparing to go to France to recover the girl he had lost...

Now retribution had come in overwhelming force. He had already called the police, hoping they'd hurry over and take him to prison for a good reeducation. At least he wouldn't die there.

He should have known the two and a half million dollars had come too easily. Money that easy burned your hands.

Fortunately he had laundered his earnings again and again and transferred them under various names to his father. If he really died, the old man would suddenly discover he was rich. A single old bachelor with tens of millions, perhaps a hundred million—who knew how many scheming women would try to seduce him for the inheritance? The thought saddened Tang Wei. When he was little, his mother had left father and son to go south and make money, never to return. His father was a worker who supported him through school on his small factory wage and night work guarding warehouses. Later he retired early to give Tang Wei his job, continuing to guard warehouses himself. Dad never remarried, though life was hard without a woman. It wasn't that he still loved the vanished mother too deeply; he'd told Tang Wei he liked women with fuller chests... But such women all demanded that Tang Wei be sent to Grandma's to be raised. Dad refused. My son can't be raised that way, he'd said. My son's a hooligan! They can't keep him in line; he has to stay with me!

So no woman would live with Dad. Tang Wei thought he should have tricked one into coming to cook and wash for them first; Tang Wei could have stayed with Grandma for a few months and then come back. Dad was such an idiot, determined to keep him close no matter what.

Because Dad was an idiot, Tang Wei had to be tough. There were only two men in the family; one of them had to be tough, or wouldn't everyone bully them to death? When Tang Wei made his first windfall as a hunter, he withdrew every cent in cash, stacked it before his father, and said, "Hey! How about that? Your son's made something of himself, hasn't he? Spend as much as you like! Take it!" Dad said tearfully, "Son, robbing banks gets you executed! Run, quickly, take all the money. I'll stay and hold off the police."

The memory brought tears streaming down Tang Wei's face. If only he'd found Dad a companion before he died; then he could go in peace. Unfortunately, none of the women Dad saw regularly met his standards: one had bags under her eyes, another skin too dark. Tang Wei would lose face among his friends with any of them as a stepmother.

After crying for a while, he remembered something. Even if his enemies knew about this office, the VIP elevator was out, cutting off the shortcut. They shouldn't be able to reach him before the police arrived.

He crawled out from under the desk, locked the office door, and shoved the desk against it. Feeling hidden in a relatively safe fortress, he breathed a little easier.

He turned his head, and his heart nearly jumped out of his throat...

A pitch-black figure clung to the enormous floor-to-ceiling window!

It was nearly two hundred meters above the ground. Who could climb a two-hundred-meter skyscraper in minutes? Superman or Spider-Man? Rain hammered the figure outside, spray surrounding him like a faint glow. He seemed to wear a suit of iron-blue scales.

Tang Wei screamed and lunged for the crossbow on the wall. He had brought it from America, supposedly for shooting fish, though it was really a weapon. Its compound bolts could pass through three meters of water and pierce a large fish; in air they could easily penetrate sheet metal. He pulled the string back with all his strength. He no longer cared about human life; the silhouette alone terrified him! He hoped the top floor's sturdy double-reinforced glass would hold the figure for a moment. He needed a few seconds more.

But the glass... began to melt! Dark-red currents appeared around the shadow, along with a transparent boundary that instantly turned the rain to white steam. Where glass met the boundary, it was like wax meeting fire. The shadow entered the office. Everything near him burned silently, dark-red currents snaking along the transparent edge. Firelight revealed his hideous face, bones jutting sharply at his temples and cheeks.

He was a demon burning with black fire! Tang Wei had robbed countless ancestral graves and encountered evil things more than once, but none was so terrifying. Beside this one, they were innocent, gentle little girls compared with a demon god.

At last Tang Wei cocked the bow and fired, opening his eyes as wide as he could. His pupils burned like a lizard's or snake's, or golden gas lamps. This was his greatest secret, the reason he could make a living as a hunter. When he concentrated fully, his pupils changed color. Until now, every uncanny thing had fled before those golden eyes.

The bolt tore through the air like silk being cut. At this distance, such a powerful shot could not possibly be dodged.

The other man didn't dodge. He raised a hand and waved it lightly; the bolt split in two.

He slowly raised his head. Gold ten times brighter than Tang Wei's shot from his pupils, dimming even the firelight. Tang Wei felt immense force thrust his gaze back. He fell to his knees involuntarily, trembling. The other's eyes were gold too, but possessed an overwhelming advantage in power. Tang Wei no longer dared meet them, and understood why some hunters trembled before his own golden eyes. It was like facing a demon god: radiating golden cracks formed intricate patterns in the pupils, seemingly able to rob a person of his mind.

A huge force slammed Tang Wei against the wall, feet off the ground. A hand like an iron clamp gripped his neck, his cervical bones on the verge of cracking. His whole body convulsed, but he had no room to struggle. The clamp tightened slowly; blood failed to reach his brain, his thoughts grew confused, his sight blurred. Though the other seemed surrounded by flame, Tang Wei felt no heat from

the hand. Those golden eyes filled his vision, slowly opening and closing. They could never be human eyes: not a trace of mercy. He observed the dying Tang Wei with indifferent curiosity, like a child poking an ant to death with a twig.

His neck bones made a strange cracking sound. Tang Wei had never imagined how terrifying it would be to hear his own neck break. He knew he was really going to die. Now he wished the other would be quick.

Because facing those eyes was more terrifying than death!

The other suddenly released him, letting him fall flat on his face. Tang Wei had barely recovered a little awareness and hadn't decided whether to be relieved when the man turned and picked up a heavy steel fire extinguisher.

"Is he going to smash me to death?" Tang Wei's heart clenched. He couldn't really say whether being strangled or smashed was better, but was it so hard to make it quick?

The other pressed the nozzle and sprayed Tang Wei vigorously, extinguishing the flames on him. Only then did Tang Wei notice that his clothes had somehow caught fire.

The man dropped the extinguisher and slowly backed away, each step leaving a black footprint on the carpet. The black-red currents around him gradually faded, and the hazy boundary vanished. The iron-blue scales on his skin retracted beneath it like insects withdrawing after poking out their heads. He was no demon god or monster, but a handsome young man, scarcely more than a boy. Soaked through in a FedEx uniform, he looked like a delivery boy collecting a package in the rain, except for the deadly blade in his right hand. Tang Wei stared stupidly for a long moment, then clutched his throat and coughed violently.

The boy sat on the couch, hands resting on the long sword, slowly regulating his breathing.

Tang Wei didn't understand what had happened. He stared at the boy, whose eyes were lowered. He had suddenly changed from a monster back into a boy, yet also seemed to have suddenly grown old.

"Is that your father?" He pointed to a photograph on the wall and asked softly. His voice was unexpectedly gentle, even courteous.

It was an old photograph enlarged to thirty-six inches and set in a rosewood frame. Tang Wei wore a black gown and mortarboard, arm around his father in bright sunshine. Dad's wrinkled face seemed ready to burst into flowers. It was Tang Wei's graduation picture. His university wasn't much, but after so many hard years Dad had raised him to graduation and was immensely proud, telling everyone at the factory and buying a suit especially for the ceremony. Tang Wei hadn't cared much about graduating, but Dad had rented academic dress, forced him to put it on, and paid for the picture. Red words on it read: "July 1994. My son Tang Wei graduates from university. From Father."

"Mm-hm!" Tang Wei nodded hard. "My dad. Looks like me, doesn't he? Big nose."

He realized the photograph was precisely why he had survived. But his father wasn't some powerful official like Li Gang, only an ordinary worker with few abilities. What power could he possibly have to make this killer hesitate? Could this be his long-lost twin? But were there twins more than ten years apart in age? Dad's illegitimate son? Could Dad have produced such a handsome illegitimate son? Tang Wei examined the boy while little dramas played out in his head.

"You do look alike." The boy nodded and checked his watch. "No more talk. My time is limited. You took something you shouldn't have."

Without a word Tang Wei opened the safe, took out the paper envelope, and offered it carefully with both hands.

"You haven't opened it?" The boy glanced at the intact seal.

"No, no. It's the client's property; how would we dare peek? It was supposed to be sent tonight, and then you came." Tang Wei bowed and scraped.

"Sorry for the financial loss." Carrying the envelope, the boy walked to the window.

He leaped out and vanished into the vast curtain of rain.

Tang Wei stood stunned for several seconds, then collapsed limply onto the floor. With shaking hands he took out his phone and called Dad. As soon as the call connected, Dad shouted and cursed in alarm and anger: Tang Wei had spouted all that ominous nonsense and hung up, then wouldn't answer when called back. He had frightened Dad nearly into a heart attack.

"What the fuck are you yelling about? The guest has gone. I'm coming home for dinner, so save me something hot." Tang Wei hung up impatiently. He leaned wearily against the bookcase and began wondering again whether Dad had secretly cheated behind his back.

The grandfather clock boomed, its chimes echoing around the office walls. Tang Wei shuddered, remembering the courier supposed to collect the mail at seven. The courier his employer mentioned was this boy, and in the intended ending he would be dead by now, except for that photograph.

At Cassell headquarters, the central control-room clock changed to 19:00. On the globe projection, the red dot in East Asia vanished at once. Schneider raised his head and slowly exhaled.

"Mission complete," Manstein said quietly. "Schneider, you were right. He's perfectly capable of doing it alone. He can't work with anyone... His bloodline is too strong."

"For a student who pursues 'the strongest,' only 'the strongest' earns a passing grade. Everything else fails." Schneider showed no relief. "That's also his greatest flaw."

"I don't want to congratulate you on such a fine student." Manstein was grave. "He's had another problem. One minute and fifty seconds after the operation began, he completely abandoned our plan. Though he retrieved the documents, we don't know what he did during those three minutes and ten seconds. And the many injuries he caused... Cleaning up won't be easy. I'm worried the bill will be enormous, but you know that's not the greatest trouble..."

Schneider nodded. "The mission report. He may have been on the edge of losing control this time."

"I can pretend not to know, but you must find a way to deal with it. You know the harm a dangerous bloodline can do us," Manstein said. "Don't let personal feelings cloud your judgment."

"Yes. Sometimes I'd rather he were like Lu Mingfei, with no particular ability," Schneider said softly.

"What nonsense!" Guderian protested. "Mingfei is inspiration from head to toe!"

"Ridiculous. What part did your star pupil play in this operation? He's having dinner with a girl!" Schneider and Manstein said together.

Act Five

Dandelion

Dandelion

He pushed open the door and looked up at the rain pouring from the sky. Pulling his collar over his head, he grabbed his suitcase and ran. The Panamera's door swung open and he dove into the passenger seat before looking back. Across the curtain of rain, on the other side of the floor-to-ceiling windows, the air-conditioning scattered the last tiny parachutes. Chen Wenwen stood amid the drifting dandelion seeds, as though she might float away with those soft white things. Looking toward him, she breathed a small patch of mist onto the glass and drew a smiling face in three strokes.

"Mingfei, is it hard, being abroad all by yourself?" Chen Wenwen asked softly, looking down at her plate rather than at him.

"It's all right, really. I have a senior roommate named Fingel, and a boss named Caesar. They're both great to me." Lu Mingfei's voice echoed through every corner of Aspasia.

Before the revolution the building had been a French merchant's house. Aspasia had renovated it after buying it, preserving the old elm floors but knocking out all four walls and replacing them with floor-to-ceiling windows. The rooms had been opened into one another and the upper floors removed, leaving an eight-meter-high vaulted ceiling. An enormous chandelier hung from wooden beams nearly a century old. The chandelier was dark now; the only light in the vast space came from the candles on Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen's table. Theirs was the only occupied table, too.

Boss Caesar—or rather, the Mint Club—had made a flamboyant gesture and booked the whole place!

Chen Wenwen wore the white dress Lu Mingfei knew so well, white lace-trimmed socks, and flat black leather shoes. Candlelight brushed her with a faint warmth.

Lu Mingfei wore formal black, with a Florentine-style shirt and mother-of-pearl buttons. The outfit had been waiting in the BMW's back seat, thoughtfully arranged by the Mint Club in keeping with Mr. Caesar Gattuso's usual standards of dress.

To their left stood an enormous antique ship, planted upright with its bow nearly touching the roof. It was a Ming dynasty wreck that Aspasia had salvaged and ingeniously turned into a wine cabinet.

On the right was a huge window, with a tree-lined road beyond it and a river beyond the road. Rain rattled against the glass.

Lu Mingfei had never eaten a meal so formally in his life. He sat bolt upright as though someone had shoved a rolling pin down his back, elbows raised, fork in his left hand and knife in his right, cutting his lamb chops with painstaking precision. He was afraid he'd have to pay for the clothes if he wrinkled them. There had been no ordering: their likes and dietary restrictions were already on file. The waiter said that after receiving the request, the executive chef had personally selected the finest ingredients. The cheese had aged five years in an Italian cave, the chops were guaranteed to come from

six-month-old Italian goats, and the fish had arrived fresh from Yokohama. Every dish was impressive. Lu Mingfei couldn't understand the strange names, but he got the idea.

Each course came with a different wine. Lu Mingfei had little interest in the sour, astringent stuff, but this was no time to embarrass himself; he wasn't eating with Fingel! Every bite and sip... was it food? No, it was sophistication! He ate with an air of refinement, feeling tremendously cool.

"At first I thought you were joking." Chen Wenwen took a sip of wine. "I looked up this restaurant online. They're applying for three Michelin stars, and the prices are frightening."

Lu Mingfei nodded with a flourish. "Authentic Italian food, a bit of a niche taste. It's normal for it to cost more."

His knowledge of Italian food actually began and ended with pizza. But with a boy and girl facing each other by flickering candlelight, whispering together, who would mention pizza? Wasn't it basically a meat-stuffed flatbread? He had to talk about respectable things like foie gras, white truffles, lobster, and Black Sea caviar.

"The wine is wonderful," Chen Wenwen said. "Mingfei, did you learn to drink red wine in America?"

"Oh... some are fuller-bodied, and some have a stronger fruit flavor. Drink enough and you learn to tell." Lu Mingfei licked his lips. They were drinking a 1997 Margaux.

Everything he knew about wine came from Fingel, who occasionally ordered a bottle of red to whet his appetite during late-night meals. But Fingel always chose table wine as sour as aged vinegar, with a standing in its French region much like cheap bulk liquor sold by weight at a rural Chinese supply cooperative. Lafite, Latour, Margaux, the great Bordeaux estates—Fingel never even looked at them. He couldn't afford them.

"I've never seen you in a suit. It fits you rather well." Chen Wenwen glanced at him.

Lu Mingfei's back stiffened a little more of its own accord. He had worn a Korean-style suit to the Literature Club's graduation party, playing the lowercase i for Zhao Menghua, but Chen Wenwen had forgotten. Of course, that suit couldn't compare with this one. This was Caesar's standard. Nono said Caesar was outrageously picky about clothes: he never wore anything ready-made, always ordering from a little tailor that kept paper patterns of his measurements for every age from five to eighteen. A phone call was enough to order a suit. It was practically the Gattuso family's own imperial workshop.

"If I'd known it was this sort of occasion, I'd have dressed more formally," Chen Wenwen added.

"You look great like that." Gathering his courage, Lu Mingfei surveyed her from the tips of her hair to her toes, delighted.

How could she not? In his memory, Chen Wenwen always wore this dress, so white it was almost translucent, sitting on a bench in the sun with a book. Without it she hardly seemed like Chen Wenwen at all.

Throughout high school, even when he managed to get very close to her, he had still felt as if he were watching from a distance. Boys of every kind had always surrounded her, all more accomplished than Lu Mingfei, making him ashamed to squeeze in. Now she wore the same white dress, a warm glow flowing over her skin, only fifty—perhaps forty—centimeters away. He could lift his eyes to meet her gentle gaze and smell the soft fragrance of her hair. He could study her freely, without restraint, like dissecting a little frog in biology class when the teacher made them examine it millimeter

by millimeter... And where were all those boys who used to surround Chen Wenwen? Ha! Not one could come between them. Tonight, at Aspasia... he'd booked the whole place!

Music drifted almost imperceptibly through the room. Lu Mingfei could barely contain himself.

"This song is nice." He began putting on airs as an art connoisseur.

"It's Dalida's 'I Found My Love in Portofino.' You like it too?" Chen Wenwen's eyes lit up with delighted surprise. "Lu Mingfei... you've changed."

He blinked and couldn't help looking down at his reflection in a sterling-silver spoon. Had he changed? Become suave? Was he no longer that shabby little loser? Could he now eat Italian food and appreciate Dalida too?

At last the great day had come: the turtle had turned over!

He had always hated the rich kids in class, showing off their family vacations abroad, their new houses, casually displaying the logos on their designer clothes, climbing into their family's fine cars on rainy days and waving goodbye to classmates miserably waiting under the eaves for the rain to stop... How vulgar! Yet the girls had no restraint; those young masters' airs always left them dazzled, eyes sparkling. But now that it was his turn to show off, he suddenly found it wonderfully comfortable, enough to make him float with bliss!

Lu Mingfei leaned over the table, bringing his face a little closer to Chen Wenwen's, so restless with excitement he was almost ready to take flight.

Chu Zihang reached out with a trembling hand and switched off the Panamera's engine. The headlights went out, leaving the garage in darkness.

He breathed deeply and silently, gathering strength. Only when he felt able to move again did he turn on the overhead reading light, remove his sunglasses, and put his black contacts back in. He got out, stripped off his FedEx uniform, and changed into tennis clothes, rubbing a little dust onto his chest. His head was covered in cold sweat, his hair soaked; that needed no disguise. In the mirror he did look as though he had come back exhausted from the tennis court.

As he crossed the lawn, concealed sprinklers rose from the ground and rotated, spraying him. The cold water made him feel weak; his vision blurred in waves. He had little strength left, perhaps enough to walk a few hundred meters, and had to use it carefully. It would be best if neither parent were home, so no one would stop him in the living room for a conversation.

Chu Zihang pushed the door open cautiously and paused. His mother was curled up asleep on the sofa. At this hour she was usually out at a bar, laughing and talking loudly over whiskey or brandy with her friends. For some reason tonight was an exception.

She slept terribly. Once asleep, the woman was utterly careless. Who knew how many times she'd rolled around? Besides boldly exposing an entire thigh, she'd wrinkled her silk nightdress until it looked like a rag. She held a thin blanket to her chest like a child sleeping with a doll. The air conditioner was still set to the temperature Chu Zihang had chosen before leaving, but that had been a sunlit morning, and now a storm had broken on the evening. He didn't know what expression to give a mother like this. Passing the sofa, he smelled a strong odor of alcohol. He tugged the blanket over her and went upstairs straight to the bathroom.

He bolted the door and checked the lock to make sure no one would burst in. Leaning against it, he breathed in short, silent gasps, pressing one hand to his waist while pulling off his tennis shirt with the

other. It was soaked with cold sweat. In the mere few dozen meters from the garage, the wound beneath the layers of tissue pressed to his lower right abdomen had begun to scab, only to split open again when he moved. A thin stream of blood ran down his body. He took the medicine box from a wall cabinet and found tetanus vaccine, iodine, and bandages.

He peeled away the blood-soaked tissues to reveal a crudely dressed wound. The dressing was so rough it was alarming. Chu Zihang had used clear packing tape—the kind used to seal cardboard boxes, complete with a company logo printed on it. It was all he could find at the time, so he had sealed himself up like a broken carton, as long as the blood didn't leak out where the Maintenance Department could see.

Gritting his teeth, Chu Zihang tore off the tape. Blood welled out. He blotted it with toilet paper and felt something inside the wound.

A sharp shard of glass, roughly an inch long, buried all the way in. When the suspended platform fell, his abdomen had struck the shattered glass curtain wall. Because he had undergone blood amplification in time, his dragon bloodline had made his body exceptionally resilient, and the rush of adrenaline had kept him from feeling pain. But when the effect wore off, the pain returned with vengeful force. His body was still human, after all.

Even through the tissue, touching the glass made him convulse. It seemed to have grown into his body, become one of his bones; pulling it out was like tearing out a bone of his own. He bit down on a rolled towel, took several deep breaths, and pulled hard... Tiny drops of blood spattered half the mirror.

The instant of agony nearly drained his strength, and darkness filled his vision. Half a minute passed before he could see again. He looked at the bloody shard and laid it gently on the edge of the sink.

After blotting the blood, he inserted a disposable syringe into the deltoid of his upper arm and injected the tetanus vaccine. Then he wiped the wound directly with an alcohol-soaked cotton ball. It was like cutting the wound open again, but there was no better disinfectant in the household kit. By the time all the cotton balls were red, the bleeding had stopped. He spread Yunnan Baiyao ointment on a piece of gauze, pressed it to the wound, and wound a bandage around his waist. He changed into a white shirt and tucked it into his jeans, concealing the bandage completely.

He studied himself in the mirror. Nothing looked unusual except that his face was a little paler.

He put all the bloody cotton, tissues, syringe, and glass into his tennis bag, wiped the blood from the floor, and checked every corner of the bathroom to be sure he had left no trace. He would never leave a trace. The Chu Zihang who lived in this house was someone else, unconnected to Cassell College: a good student, obedient, fond of basketball and books, with no bad habits or violent tendencies, whose favorite celebrity was even a wholesome role model, Wang Leehom. Sometimes Chu Zihang himself thought such a person was as pale and lifeless as a paper figure, but his parents were proud of their paper-perfect son.

If they saw these bloodstained things, they probably wouldn't be proud. They would think they had raised a monster.

No one liked monsters, and Chu Zihang didn't blame them, so he put on that pale, pleasing face. He wanted his parents to be happy; whether the person they saw was real didn't matter.

A packed suitcase and a laptop bag were always waiting in his bedroom, ready for departure at any time. Chu Zihang checked that his passport was valid, picked up his luggage, and went downstairs.

His mother was still asleep on the sofa, clutching the blanket tightly.

Chu Zihang took a cushion, tugged the blanket free, and slipped the cushion into her arms. She held it and slept on, breathing softly through her nose. He tucked the blanket around her on all four sides and sat watching her face. Apparently she hadn't gone out today and hadn't put on makeup. Without it she looked a little older, with fine lines at the corners of her eyes. A woman who had been too beautiful in her youth, showing her age after drinking, made a desolate sight.

It was hard to accept that such a woman was his mother. The most reliable thing he remembered her doing for him was giving birth to him. According to that man, she'd wanted to give up even then, saying childbirth would hurt and perhaps she should have an abortion. Unfortunately for her, she was eight months pregnant when she changed her mind, and the doctor warned her that an abortion then would be suicide. Thus Chu Zihang had survived. From the time he could understand speech, the woman had held him and said, Mommy suffered so much giving birth to you, so grow up quickly and take care of Mommy; Mommy works so hard, so grow up quickly and earn money to support Mommy; there are so many bad people in the world, so grow up quickly and protect Mommy... Mommy was so fragile, so tired, had suffered so much... Because Mommy had such a hard time, she missed parents' meetings, nobody packed his lunch for school outings, nobody picked him up in the rain. When he had a high fever... Mommy did stay with him, but she had no idea how to care for a feverish child, so she gave him neither medicine nor water. Instead she touched his little forehead and said, "Are you dizzy? Mommy will sing Zihang a lovely song!"

No one had ever promised to protect Chu Zihang, yet from childhood he had felt he must take care of many people.

Rain whispered against the windows. His mother turned over and kicked at him unconsciously; he tucked the blanket around her again. He probably wouldn't have a chance to say goodbye before leaving. That was his mother, careless and oblivious: once asleep, she slept like the dead, and waking her would only make her angry.

Aunt Tong, the housekeeper, came in, wiping her hands on her apron. "Zihang, are you going out?" She had seen his suitcase.

"Yes. The school moved up the start of the short term and told us to report back." He nodded. "I'm taking a night flight."

"Oh! Why didn't you tell your parents? The whole family could have dinner together and have the driver take you."

"I told them yesterday. 'Dad' has a business dinner tonight."

"Your 'dad' is dining with people from the land bureau tonight," Aunt Tong said. She meant that he had important clients to see and couldn't help missing the chance to see him off.

"It's fine," Chu Zihang said.

He had no doubt that if "Dad" had time, he would arrange to take him out to dinner. Dad was so successful in business because he handled every social obligation well. He handled Chu Zihang well too, never missing a gift or a courtesy, leaving no fault to find. But Chu Zihang didn't need to be

treated as an obligation, so he had deliberately announced his departure only the day before, when "Dad's" dinner with the land bureau could no longer be rescheduled.

"Don't let Mom sleep in the living room again. She'll catch cold," he said.

"No, no, she only just fell asleep," Aunt Tong said quickly. "She was in the kitchen cooking something and sent me to the supermarket for vinegar. When I got back, she was asleep."

"Cooking?" Chu Zihang stared. How strange. The saying "she wouldn't even right an overturned oil bottle" might have been invented for his mother.

"Oh no! She doesn't know how to use the stove. Something might happen in the kitchen!"

They hurried in and were hit by a burnt smell. Smoke filled the kitchen; the range hood wasn't even on. A little more and the smoke alarm would have sounded. Chu Zihang shut off the gas and opened every window. Once some smoke had cleared, Aunt Tong took a blackened pot off the stove. It was imported German stainless steel, polished daily until it could serve as a mirror.

"What is that?" Chu Zihang covered his nose. Everything in the pot had burned to charcoal; he couldn't tell what it had been.

He guessed Aunt Annie had taken his mother to another fashionable cooking class and inspired her to try her hand. Those classes were fun: a group of ladies carrying LV, Chanel, and Gucci bags were taught by a chef who played the master, making dishes like king crab with coconut and egg white paired with the Trimbach family's Alsatian Pinot Gris, or pork and green plums with tiger-paw mushrooms paired with a royal dry red from the Gigondas estate. His mother would come home and practice on Chu Zihang. Each time he faced an indistinct heap on a bone-china plate, he would try a little and suggest, "Mom, would you like to taste it too?" She would taste it and pull a long face. "What I made in class was clearly nothing like this!" Chu Zihang understood why. In class the ingredients were prepared for her and a chef stood behind her giving instructions in real time. Cook that way, and even an old man selling Shaanxi meat sandwiches could make authentic French food.

"It won't come clean. Throw the pot away too," he said.

"I understand! Your mother was boiling dumplings!" Aunt Tong slapped her thigh.

Chu Zihang blinked. Dumplings? Did she mean Italian pasta? "Matsutake pasta in broth with Riesling"? That had failed last time, and afterward his mother had sworn never to make it again.

"Dumplings before a journey, noodles on return. Your mother was making dumplings for you," Aunt Tong said. "She's from Shaanxi."

Chu Zihang touched his chest without thinking. Something deep inside twitched faintly. Flour lay scattered across the stainless-steel kitchen island, with a thick rolling pin lying across it... No wonder his mother had sent Aunt Tong to buy vinegar: it was for dumplings. Dumplings before departure, noodles on return; before a journey, you always ate a bowl of dumplings. No fashionable cooking-class chef would have taught her this. She could only have learned it from Grandma: handmade celery-and-pork dumplings paired with a selected 2010 Zhenjiang aromatic vinegar.

No wonder she hadn't gone out. He had thought it was because of the rain.

He fished a piece of wrapper out of the pot and put it in his mouth. The flavor was truly something. His nostrils filled with burnt smoke, as though someone had used him for a chimney.

"It's inedible. Better throw it out," he said, swallowing it anyway.

Washing his hands at the sink, he thought of that man again. His life had always seemed absurd: a complete loser, boasting about irrelevant things, smiling apologetically as he drove people around, watching his wife take their son and leave. Only at the end had he revealed his terrifying bloodline. With that man's blood, so much should have been within easy reach.

A dragon bloodline that stood above ordinary people and could kill as easily as cutting down straw dogs.

If he was that powerful, why hide his blood, humble himself to serve his wife and make her happy, and live a "normal" life?

What was a hybrid? A different kind of being, between human and dragon. Even if what you did concerned humanity's survival, you were not truly human yourself; when your blood burned, your pupils turned gold like a dragon's. Through golden dragon eyes the world looked entirely different. Dragons killed and judged decisively, strength determining rank. If their world had a ranking system like Blizzard's ladder, blood and death would constantly wash the board clean.

A king was always killed by a new king.

And yet did he still want somewhere to return to, even a doghouse? Did he want... a home?

"Aunt Tong, remember to remind Mom to drink milk every day." Chu Zihang opened the refrigerator and showed her a carton. "Buy this Sanyuan low-fat milk. She won't drink any other kind. Add a sugar cube, microwave it on low for five minutes, and make sure she drinks it before bed every night."

"I know, I know, same as always." Aunt Tong didn't quite understand this habit. Before every trip abroad he repeated the whole procedure as though entrusting her with some momentous responsibility.

"I'll leave the car in the airport parking lot, with the key and parking card in the glove compartment. Have the driver take the spare key and bring it back." Chu Zihang said. "I'm going."

"Zihang, aren't you going to say goodbye to your mother?"

"I'm not used to saying goodbye... Whenever she sees me off... she kisses me like crazy..." He picked up his suitcase and disappeared into the rain.

"Sir, would you like to come over and select a dessert wine?" The sommelier materialized behind Lu Mingfei like a ghost.

Lu Mingfei thought, Honestly... why appear like a ghost now and poke your nose in? But perhaps it was an Italian dining custom. He nodded politely to Chen Wenwen. "I'll be right back."

The sommelier led him into the shadow of the antique ship wine cabinet, pointing out little golden bottles of dessert wine while lowering his voice. "Booking the whole restaurant is quite a gesture. Is this a special occasion? Would you like to surprise the lady when dessert is served?"

"A surprise? Extra whipped cream?" Lu Mingfei didn't understand.

"Have you seen Spider-Man 2?" the sommelier patiently explained. "Spider-Man proposes to his girlfriend over dinner and has the waiter put the diamond ring in her champagne..."

"Soga!" Enlightenment struck Lu Mingfei like a revelation.

A sophisticated, romantic setting like this, a rainy night separating two people from the world, a fine Italian meal and a little wine, Dalida singing softly in the air, candlelight spilling over the girl's white dress—shouldn't he be itching to... no, shouldn't he let his feelings move him to say something

important? This was a stage made for a confession! The girl was watching him, eyes lowered, cheeks flushed. The spotlight was already on him, the microphone in his hand, the audience waiting to cheer. If he didn't say something earth-shaking, it would be a crime against heaven!

"I don't have a ring... And we're not at the proposal stage yet, are we?" He scratched his head.

"No problem, we're here to help! For example, we could decorate the cheesecake with the most important words from the time you met and came to know each other." The sommelier gave an emphatic thumbs-up. "Our service is first-rate!"

"Oh! That's a real bargain!" Lu Mingfei beamed, rubbing his hands, eager to try.

"Then what were the words that laid the foundation of your relationship?"

Lu Mingfei looked up at the ceiling. Candlelight illuminated his eyes, faint flames stirring in them, his face blooming with romance.

Pen and paper in hand, the sommelier held his breath and waited.

"There weren't any," Lu Mingfei sighed.

The sommelier pressed a hand to his forehead. Was this distinguished guest inarticulate, or simply too shy?

"Then put the Olympic rings on it!" Lu Mingfei suddenly said.

"Oh, yes." The sommelier nodded blankly.

Lu Mingfei returned to the table. Chen Wenwen was playing with the floating candle; she gave him a sweet smile and said little. He smiled back, finishing the last pieces of lamb while waiting for his Olympic cheesecake. What could the sommelier know about the twists of his thoughts? He was remembering the high-school sports meet in his second year. His event had been the five-thousand-meter run. Nobody had forced him to sign up. Chen Wenwen was running it too, and since boys and girls ran together and he fancied his endurance, he could show off in front of her. But who could have guessed? Chen Wenwen looked delicate, yet she had been on the track team in elementary school. At the starting gun she had shot away, running right behind Xu Yanyan and using him to block the wind. On the final lap she made her move and took second place among the girls. Lu Mingfei, meanwhile, was still a whole lap behind, shuffling along with groans. He had been knocked down at the start, scraped his knee on the track, and fallen into last place. The five thousand meters was the final event; only he remained on the track, and everyone else had slipped away after watching the race. Just as he was wondering whether to change direction and run straight for the exit, Chen Wenwen crossed the field and ran beside him. "Come on, come on! Nobody in our Literature Club can be left behind!" she had said. She'd worn a white T-shirt with the Olympic rings on her chest, so lovely he wanted to lean against her or something.

What a memorable event! He could count it as the beginning of their romance!

He slipped into a mood of predestined love, convinced that he and Chen Wenwen, not Zhao Menghua, had been exchanging meaningful glances all along. Every great lover had that potential: see a pretty girl and imagine fate had already bound you together, like Jia Baoyu's famous "I've seen this girl before." In short, he was lovestruck.

"Lu Mingfei, didn't that senior who picked you up last time come back with you?" Chen Wenwen asked suddenly.

It was like a bucket of cold water over his head. His lovestruck haze faded, and an image of the little red-haired witch rose in his mind, her silver four-leaf-clover earrings swinging beside her ears.

"She's probably on vacation with her boyfriend," he said quietly.

The little witch's image kept bouncing like a spring-loaded puppet. Oh, stop bouncing. This isn't your scene to be the heroine; Caesar is your leading man... Lu Mingfei's thoughts were a mess.

Could a person like two girls at once? He'd read a psychology article saying no: a man like Duan Zhengchun could not exist. If someone claimed to like two girls at the same time, he liked neither. So between Nono and Chen Wenwen he could only like one; the other was merely adolescent male hormones stirring. Which one, which one?

Lu Mingfei was nineteen and had been single all nineteen years. He wanted very much to like a girl seriously.

Yes, yes, Nono was wonderful. She drove a flaming-red Ferrari and wore a flaming-red bikini. Her rare A-rank bloodline made her exceptional even among hybrids. She was only twenty, but in high heels she could command a room like a little queen, drawing every eye. At twenty-five, who knew how magnificent she'd be? And her mind twisted and turned, a book you could never finish or fully understand but always wanted to read. If you were with her, you'd have something to do for the rest of your life: study her. You wouldn't have to worry about making a living in later years either. The little witch seemed to come from a distinguished family and was very dependable.

In short, everything about Nono was wonderful; beside her, Chen Wenwen was only an ordinary girl. But Nono was too far away. He was her little sidekick, always at her beck and call, and only Caesar was worthy of her.

Would you choose a goddess at the edge of the sky, or the girl right in front of you?

Chen Wenwen is looking at you! She's probably waiting for you to say something!

Stop thinking, brother! There's no future following the little witch! At best it's a toad's rhapsody about coveting a swan! How did the old saying go? A bird in the hand is worth ten in the bush! A little crow on the branch beats a golden phoenix in the sky! Think about it: say the words now and you might finally leave the ranks of the single! You'd have a girlfriend! You've never even put your arm around a girl's waist in your life! Never had a Valentine's chocolate of your own! Don't you want something this wonderful? Just say the words! Only a word from you! A natural eight-hearts-and-eight-arrows diamond necklace can be yours for 998 yuan! Limited quantities, hurry! Pick up the phone and order...

Something strange seemed to have crept into his thoughts... Back on track... Don't you want something this wonderful? Just say the words! You'd never again have to spend Valentine's Day watching Brokeback Mountain with Fingel! You might even get a first kiss as a bonus! Look at Chen Wenwen's lips, soft as petals in the candlelight, and dare say you aren't tempted!

Ten million little devils danced in Lu Mingfei's heart.

Damn it! It was settled! Youth was wasted if you didn't chase girls! What the hell was he waiting for? Wait any longer and the daylilies would go cold! Forget the decorated cheesecake. A confession needed only a mouth!

He jerked his head up and looked across the table. "I actually like..."

"Calm down. Don't spit food in my face." Across the table, Lu Mingze calmly cut a slice of tuna belly.

Not Lu Mingfei's plump, round cousin, but the devilish Lu Mingze who had bargained for his life. The little fellow's hair was meticulously combed. His formal black suit, stand-collar shirt, bow tie, and lace-edged handkerchief in his breast pocket matched the establishment perfectly, as though he belonged here for dinner and Chen Wenwen in her plain white dress was the one out of place.

Speak of the devil and the devil appears!

"I wasn't going to spit in your face," Lu Mingfei began, then suddenly raised his plate. "I was going to smash this over your head!"

"You struggled with yourself so long I got bored waiting, so I summoned you for a chat. Oh, and happy birthday, Brother." Lu Mingze raised his glass, took a sip, and suddenly frowned.

"Of the five great Bordeaux estates, Margaux is my least favorite. It's a Bordeaux vineyard, but its wine tastes a little like Burgundy." He sniffed the wine and shook his head. "The tuna belly is perfectly seared, though if I'd made it I'd season it with matsutake rather than truffle. Let me taste your lamb..."

Lu Mingfei shoved him away with a palm to the forehead and swallowed the remaining lamb in a few bites.

"So stingy. I only wanted a piece of lamb," Lu Mingze said.

"Just letting you have something go wrong for once, so you won't always be leading me around by the nose," Lu Mingfei grumbled.

"How could that be? You're my most important customer. Until you've used your three remaining summons, I'll serve you faithfully." Lu Mingze smiled. "But don't worry, we never force a sale. You didn't summon me this time. This is a voluntary customer follow-up."

"If there's nothing else, disappear! I'm having dinner with my first..." Lu Mingfei stopped. Chen Wenwen wasn't his "first girlfriend."

"The first girl you secretly loved," Lu Mingze supplied the correct definition.

"Get lost! Anyway, I'm eating with a beautiful girl. Could you please send me back to the real world? How can I have an appetite looking at you?"

"I like the atmosphere here." Ignoring him, Lu Mingze looked around. "The old ship harmonizes with the aged elm floor, but the designer has divided the space in a very modern way with marble and resin panels. Old and new fit together beautifully; it's private yet open. No wonder they charge so much."

"What are you going on about? What's it to you? If there's nothing else, please get lost."

"I especially like this table. It seems ordinary, but anyone sitting here can see in every direction, as though commanding the whole space." Lu Mingze pushed aside his plate and glass, rested his elbows on the table, and folded his hands under his chin, looking into Lu Mingfei's eyes. "This is a position of power and authority."

"Here we go again..." Lu Mingfei covered his face.

"You don't like it? But you've already felt the pleasure power brings, haven't you?" Lu Mingze smiled.

"What pleasure of power? It's the pleasure of chasing a girl. Has your brain overheated?"

"You've never felt this kind of control before, have you? That certainty of victory, holding something firmly in your hand without fear it will escape." Lu Mingze lifted his glass. "A bottle of the finest red wine and an ordinary one are made much the same way: grapes are grown, fermented in oak barrels, filtered, bottled, and sold. Yet the first costs thousands of times more. Many people can't tell the difference in taste without drinking them side by side, but still claim to love the art of wine and eagerly collect the most expensive bottles. Do you know why?"

"To show off their money."

"No, not just that. Tasting the most expensive wine makes them feel they possess power. So much invisible value attaches to an expensive bottle: the winemaker's care, the taster's praise, the fashionable crowd's acclaim. The bottle costs eight thousand yuan not because the wine itself is worth that, but because of those invisible values spreading out like a spiderweb. They are worth far more than the wine." Lu Mingze spoke softly. "When humans taste it, it's like sipping the essence of power, bright red, the color of blood."

"Could you please break the habit of never saying anything plainly?" Lu Mingfei was sick of the boy's mystical tone.

"You were happy just now. I could feel it," Lu Mingze said.

"All right, you're the roundworm in my belly. No objection. Next time I'll strain hard and pull you out..." Lu Mingfei said fiercely.

"You were happy because you used to look up to Chen Wenwen. If you were on classroom duty together and she smiled at you, it became a precious memory. But now it's different. You're in the seat of honor at Aspasia, drinking wine that costs eight thousand a bottle, eating food the executive chef spent the afternoon preparing. A luxury car is outside waiting to take you to the airport, and the waiter in the corner awaits your slightest signal, a snap of the fingers, for instance!" Lu Mingze held up a hand and snapped crisply. "A hot Earl Grey, please."

The waiter came silently to the table and poured amber tea into a glass, apparently unaware that the guest had changed.

Without looking at him, Lu Mingze waved him away coldly. The waiter bowed and vanished into the unlit darkness.

"That is power. It's the smallest kind, yet it still has power's intoxicating scent." Lu Mingze smelled his fingertips and glanced at Lu Mingfei. "You've caught the scent already, haven't you? Right now Chen Wenwen is prey within your grasp. You have power and no longer need to look up to her. Instead you compare her with Nono. There's nothing she does better than Nono; she's just an ordinary girl. But Nono is too far away, beyond your reach. The power you hold isn't enough, so you still have to look up to Nono, but not to Chen Wenwen. You could even bend down..." He paused. A tissue rose from the table without a breeze and drifted to the floor.

Lu Mingze bent slowly, picked it up, and tossed it before Lu Mingfei. "Pick her up. Forgive her for everything she's done to you."

Lu Mingfei looked at the tissue. His heart clenched. Blood soaked it, a vivid red heart so bright it seemed ready to drip onto the table.

"Do you... still want her?" Lu Mingze asked softly.

"Take that damn thing away!" Lu Mingfei burst out.

"It's ketchup... I got it on there by accident." Lu Mingze shrugged. "A joke... just a joke."

"Damn it!" Lu Mingfei touched his chest, breathing hard.

"Without power, anyone feels inferior, like a stag without antlers that has no place in the herd." Lu Mingze played with the sterling-silver knife, watching its light turn in his hand. "But for someone who holds power, the girl once beyond his reach becomes a clay doll in the dust, and the enemy who towered above him kneels and begs for mercy. That's power and authority. You can call it the devil, but everyone rejoices to obtain it. Once they've tasted it, they fall in love and long to hold more and more. Have you imagined that one day, just as you face Chen Wenwen today, you might consider bending down to pick up Nono? To the you of that day, she too would be only a clay doll in the dust. She could no longer tease you, no longer wear that proud expression. Even if she cried and begged, you wouldn't be moved. That kind of power... is within your reach, if you only want it."

Lu Mingfei shuddered violently, unable to control it, as if a cold snake had slithered across his chest. Though Lu Mingze was certainly mischievous, most of the time Lu Mingfei regarded him as being on his side, and deep down half doubted the contract that traded away his life. But as Lu Mingze spoke, uncanny golden light danced in his deep pupils, and a sneering demon hid beneath his mild tone.

Mocking the whole world, every person in it.

Could that day really come? Even if Nono cried and begged him, he wouldn't be moved? Impossible, right? With the little witch's stubborn nature, if she cried, the sun would rise in the west, the Happy Prince would damn well break his heart, and monks would return to worldly life. Could his own steadfast heart remain unmoved? Ridiculous! Even if he practiced some secret art of perfect detachment, could he become that cold? No, no, impossible, absolutely impossible!

"Pah, pah!" Lu Mingfei spat twice into his palm and held it out. "Come on! I've spat in my hand. Give me that power."

Lu Mingze paused, then smiled. "I can. You just have to beg me."

"Please, little brother, give me power. I really want to see what Nono looks like begging me." Lu Mingfei shamelessly put on a pleading face.

At last Lu Mingze was at a loss. He shook his head with a rueful smile. "Brother, you aren't truly begging."

"If you can't do it, why talk so big? Acting all impressive, having fun pretending to be grown-up?" Lu Mingfei rallied at once. "Pfft!"

He didn't want to take Lu Mingze seriously. The more seriously he considered the boy's words, the more frightening they became; only by dismissing him as a little brat could he feel at ease.

"But one day you will sincerely beg me, and then I will give you everything I promised... I'll go now. Brother, you're nineteen; please patronize my business as often as possible. A pleasure working with you." Lu Mingze hopped down from the chair. He was the size of an eight- or nine-year-old; seated, his feet couldn't even reach the floor.

"Hey, let me ask you. Who do you think is better... Chen Wenwen or Nono?" Lu Mingfei caught his arm.

"Nono," Lu Mingze said without thinking.

"Why?"

"I prefer a good figure to the literary type." Lu Mingze looked utterly serious.

Everything went black before Lu Mingfei's eyes.

"Oh, crap!" His heart went cold.

In the instant of darkness, the person opposite had turned back into Chen Wenwen. His mouth was wide open, looking as though he were about to lean in for a French kiss. She showed no intention of dodging, watching his eyes intently.

Damn it, what power did that little devil use? Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum, which could stop time? He always chose such devious moments to pause it.

This time resumed the instant after Lu Mingfei said, "I actually like..."

The next words stuck in his throat. Lu Mingze's voice buzzed in his mind over and over. Every muscle in his body tensed, his face stiffened, as if he were about to launch a missile and discovered it was aimed at the wrong target, and wanted to swallow it back. But it was too late: "I actually like" was already out, Chen Wenwen had heard it... and that damned blush was spreading across her face!

"I actually... liked you," Lu Mingfei forced out with all his strength.

At last, at last he overcame the rhythm of the sentence and shoved in the past tense. He felt utterly drained. It had been a battle between heaven and man: in that single second, Lu Mingfei had beaten back the little soul wriggling inside him. One step forward was a pretty girl; one step back meant continuing his miserable single life in the autumn wind. The eager little soul shouted, I refuse, I refuse, I refuse... and was suppressed deep in his heart again.

In a setting like this, "I like you" was easy to say. Everything had been arranged for that sentence. He had drunk two glasses of wine, desire stirred in his heart, and a bold declaration would have been perfectly natural; even if Chen Wenwen refused, it wouldn't be too awkward. The wine and feast weren't innocent, and if she dared come alone she should have been prepared like Guan Yunchang attending the enemy's banquet armed with a single blade!

"I used to like you" was difficult. Why bring up something already over when everything was so pleasant? Did he want to put a period at the end of it all?

"I know. You don't have to say it." The blush faded from Chen Wenwen's face. She lowered her head and spoke softly.

Lu Mingfei coughed violently. That dangerous change of breath had nearly killed him.

He didn't know whether this counted as a victory over Lu Mingze. He didn't like what Lu Mingze said about power. Chen Wenwen was his classmate; he had liked her very much, and even now was willing to stand up for her. However he changed, he would never bend down and pick her up like a tissue. To Lu Mingfei, Chen Wenwen was Chen Wenwen. If she sent him for a Coke now as she once had, he would still jump up and run.

Some things... would never change!

Lu Mingfei gritted his teeth as though defying someone.

"Actually, I knew before too, but I pretended I didn't... I'm sorry I disappointed you," Chen Wenwen said quietly.

"It's all right, I don't blame you, really. Believe me." Lu Mingfei took a deep breath, arranging his words with care. "Before I met you, I didn't know what it was like to like a girl. Knowing you taught

me. Actually... high school was miserable for me. If I hadn't spent every day mooning over you... it would have been even worse, wouldn't it? I'm grateful you were there. Even though I missed my chance—no, there was never a chance—you can't regret it, can you? If you like someone for that long, they become tied to your past. If you regret having liked them, aren't you denying all the time you lived before?"

He had nothing more to say. He licked his lips and swallowed, embarrassed. "That was too literary. Bear with me."

"It's all right." Chen Wenwen lowered her head. "It was beautiful, like poetry."

"Like poetry?" Lu Mingfei wiped his sweat with a tissue. No one had ever praised him like that before, and he was a little lost.

But there was nothing left to say... Deadlock, absolute deadlock! Everything was on the table now, plain to see. Anything more would be superfluous. It was like the Japanese art of iaido: a sword was alive in its sheath, but once drawn, it was dead.

Should they continue talking about their old classmates? Would Chen Wenwen suddenly stand, burst into tears, and run away? Or would they clasp all four hands and say, ha ha ha, our old misunderstanding is settled, let's drink till we drop tonight? If Chen Wenwen could accept that last possibility... Lu Mingfei would be quite happy to oblige...

The door creaked open. A furtive figure poked his head in and edged inside, peering toward the only lit table, carrying something in his hand.

"What the hell! Brother, are you dropping in for a meal or a room at an inn?" Before a waiter could stop him, Lu Mingfei slapped the table. "Come over here!"

"An... interview." The man, who had REPORTER written all over his face, clutched a recorder, sweating at the opulent surroundings. He pointed to the camera operator behind him. "This is my younger sister... she does the filming... We're from a TV food show. We heard a gourmet had booked Aspasia tonight and the executive chef was cooking personally, so we came through the rain for an interview. Sorry to disturb you... I'll... I'll leave right away."

"You came all this way. Why leave? Sit down and eat with us!" Lu Mingfei quickly grabbed his sleeve. Brother, save me! Don't go! If you leave, we'll run out of things to say again.

"Oh, that's too kind. It's awfully expensive." The reporter was astonished to find the wealthy gourmet so young and hospitable. He rubbed his hands. "I couldn't impose on you for a meal, but could you say a few words to our viewers?"

"No need to stand on ceremony!" Young Master Lu warmly pulled the reporter into a seat, fetched a chair for the camera girl, and called to the waiter. "Chopsticks... no, two more place settings. The menu, the menu! We're ordering more!"

"Well, then... it'd be rude to refuse." The reporter was delighted. "Brother, how's the food here?"

Lu Mingfei recalled Lu Mingze's expression and smacked his lips. "The tuna is perfectly seared, but if I'd made it, I'd season it with matsutake rather than truffle."

"And does the wine suit your palate?"

"Of the five great Bordeaux estates, Margaux is my least favorite. It's a Bordeaux vineyard, but its wine tastes a little like Burgundy." Lu Mingfei pointed at the bottle and frowned.

"And the atmosphere?"

Lu Mingfei nodded slightly, showing his approval. "Mm... the antique ship harmonizes with the aged elm floor, but the designer has divided the space in a very modern way with marble and resin panels. Old and new fit together beautifully; it's private yet open."

"That's what I said!" The reporter slapped his thigh. "An expert is an expert! We've finally found someone who really knows food."

Wine was poured, dishes added, and everyone enjoyed themselves. Lu Mingfei and the reporter slapped each other's shoulders and called each other brother. Then he turned and saw Chen Wenwen smiling silently, her expression hard to read: calm, perhaps, or sad.

Brilliant lights flashed across the rain-spattered glass. The dark-blue Panamera stopped beneath a tree outside. Its window lowered and rose again; Chu Zihang nodded expressionlessly to Lu Mingfei.

"Oh, I have to go. Take your time, brother." Lu Mingfei wiped his mouth with a napkin, stood, and slung his backpack over one shoulder.

"Mm, I'll see you out." Chen Wenwen stood too.

When the door opened, cold wind rushed in. Rain filled the night, and a handmade black iron lantern cast a warm halo through it.

"You're a really good person," Chen Wenwen said softly behind him.

Lu Mingfei's heart jumped. He turned and nearly collided with her; she had followed closely, head lowered, as if too tired to do anything but rest it against his back. The warm scent of her hair filled his nose. That restless little soul inside him began muttering again: Idiot, idiot, you've said it now, and there's no chance left.

Lu Mingfei gave a crooked, bitter smile. "Don't hand me the good-guy rejection card whenever you feel like it... We're just classmates having dinner tonight..."

"Thank you. I know you don't like me anymore." Chen Wenwen shook her head. "But thank you anyway... I don't like you that way either... It's not that I don't like you, just not that kind of liking."

"Mm-hm." Lu Mingfei nodded, thoroughly confused.

"When I said you'd changed, I didn't mean money or taste or anything. I meant... well, you've grown up." She smoothed the hair beside her ear and raised her head, her eyes clear.

"You sound like my big sister..."

"It's wonderful." Chen Wenwen sighed very, very softly.

"That BMW will take you home." Lu Mingfei stuck out his tongue. "Don't stand on ceremony with them; it's paid for... To be honest, I'm flat broke in America. Chu Zihang was showing off. He arranged the restaurant, the fancy car, these clothes, all of it. I was fooling the reporter. The food and wine here are good, but they're really not to my taste."

"I guessed." Chen Wenwen smiled. "You weren't paying attention to what you ate."

"Mm... This is the only thing I prepared. It's for you." He hesitated, then pulled a handful of crumpled plants from his bag and laid them on the table. "Dandelions... I picked them on the way. But at this time of year the little parachutes have all flown away; I couldn't find any whole ones. It doesn't mean anything special, just a keepsake. I wanted to give you dandelions at graduation, so this makes up for it... I remember you picked a lot and put them in a paper bag of bellflowers. When you blew on them, it looked like snow."

Chen Wenwen looked down, holding the withered bouquet without speaking, and gently stroked its empty stems.

"Goodbye," she said.

"Goodbye," Lu Mingfei said.

He pushed open the door and looked up at the rain pouring from the sky. Pulling his collar over his head, he grabbed his suitcase and ran. The Panamera's door swung open and he dove into the passenger seat before looking back. Across the curtain of rain, on the other side of the floor-to-ceiling windows, the air-conditioning scattered the last tiny parachutes. Chen Wenwen stood amid the drifting dandelion seeds, as though she might float away with those soft white things. Looking toward him, she breathed a small patch of mist onto the glass and drew a smiling face in three strokes.

The Panamera raced along the airport expressway. Rain struck the windshield head-on and broke into sprays of water.

"Mission complete." Steering with one hand, Chu Zihang reached back and patted the sealed aluminum case on the rear seat, then handed Lu Mingfei an iPad. "I've finished the report. Just add your electronic signature at the bottom."

Too lazy to read it, Lu Mingfei scrawled something in the reporter field and handed the iPad back. "Senior, you never planned to take me on the mission, did you?"

Chu Zihang was silent for a moment. "You're not ready. I don't know why you were appointed commissioner, but you haven't had the necessary training and aren't capable of carrying out an operation."

Lu Mingfei leaned back, watching the rain pour outside, and sighed. "Hey... I know I'm useless, but you could at least spare my feelings... Just saying I'm not ready like that..."

Some lilting Irish music played on the stereo. Chu Zihang didn't reply, and Lu Mingfei couldn't think of anything to say either. They sat through the silence.

"About tonight... I won't tell Nono," Chu Zihang said suddenly.

"Thanks." Lu Mingfei scratched his head. "But senior, get this straight: Nono is Caesar's girlfriend. I'm single, and I'm free to eat with anyone I want. You make it sound like I've done something wrong..."

"But you don't want her to know." Chu Zihang's answer was as hard and cold as stone.

Lu Mingfei felt he really had nothing to discuss with the president. His way of speaking was like using a knife: the fewest words struck straight at the heart of the matter, hard and accurately, and then the blade was withdrawn. He couldn't be bothered with an extra word.

Chu Zihang was right. Lu Mingfei didn't want Nono to know he'd made a grand show of dining with Chen Wenwen, although he knew Nono wouldn't be angry even if told; at most she'd tease him.

"But Caesar made your reservation. I can't guarantee he won't tell Nono," Chu Zihang added.

Lu Mingfei nearly choked, just short of rolling his eyes. Hey, boss! You're messing with me, aren't you? Caesar is Nono's boyfriend. What wouldn't he tell her? Please, use some sense! All right, you've been single so long you probably don't know what boyfriends and girlfriends are like...

"The restaurant had a wedding banquet tonight and wasn't taking individual guests, but I'd already told Chen Wenwen and couldn't easily change it. It was no problem for Caesar. He's a Mint Club member, and that club can do almost anything."

"Caesar helped you?" Lu Mingfei was curious.

"I posted a reward on the Night Watcher forum. Anyone who could reserve a table for you would be owed a favor by me." Chu Zihang's voice was as level as the asphalt beneath the wheels. "Caesar would see it too, of course. He's the noble young master of the Gattuso family and wouldn't let anyone court his subordinates from a position above him. So he'd rush to take care of it first. Caesar is very possessive, not only of his subordinates but also of his enemies. He wouldn't let anyone else claim my reward and interfere in our competition. He considers me his enemy, so he wants to defeat me himself."

"So you tricked Boss? Senior, you're devious!"

"People who speak little are often devious." Chu Zihang's tone was mild. "Actually, I'm sure Caesar understood exactly what I was thinking, but he was willing to play along."

Lu Mingfei grinned. Worrying was useless now; he'd just have to wait for Nono to find out and tease him. Even if Chu Zihang had played him, he had been irresolute himself, unable to move when he saw Chen Wenwen. Then again, he had no reason to be resolute in the first place.

"Senior, you really have influence. Chen Wenwen actually agreed to dinner."

"I used your name, gave her the restaurant's card, and asked whether she would refuse. She said yes. That was it." Chu Zihang said, "I'm not good at invitations."

"Is that how you've always invited girls to dinner?" Lu Mingfei was speechless. "Like you're challenging them on their own turf."

Chu Zihang nodded.

"That works?"

Chu Zihang thought about it. "I don't remember anyone refusing."

Lu Mingfei sighed. "All right, you win... You don't know how ridiculous tonight was. A reporter from a food show came to interview me, and I fed him a whole load of nonsense."

"I called their show and said someone had booked Aspasia tonight for a dinner for two, with the executive chef cooking personally. They were curious and said they'd send a reporter. When the interview airs, Zhao Menghua will see it too. A man like him probably thinks, 'Even if I don't want it, no one else may touch it.' Imagine his face when he sees the show. Wouldn't that be fun?" Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at him in surprise. With that cold, hard face, he didn't even smile while saying something so quietly malicious; there wasn't the slightest hint he thought it fun.

"Vicious! I'm impressed!" Lu Mingfei said.

The Panamera abruptly slowed. Chu Zihang wrenched the wheel and braked sharply at the side of the airport expressway.

"Hey, hey! I was only talking nonsense! It's raining outside, senior! I'll catch cold if you make me stand in it!" Lu Mingfei hurriedly said. Last time he'd been inexplicably kicked out of the car to bake in the sun for several minutes.

Chu Zihang waved a hand. "Wait in the car for me."

Lu Mingfei stared, his gaze falling on Chu Zihang's waist. "Holy crap... Senior, you're bleeding!"

A striking red stain spread across Chu Zihang's white shirt. Only now did Lu Mingfei notice that his face was pale as if dusted with powder—not because he was posing, but because he'd lost so much blood.

"It's nothing. The wound reopened," Chu Zihang said lightly.

He opened the door and got out into the pouring rain. He unbuttoned his shirt and tossed it into the car, then unwound the layers of gauze from his waist. Bare-chested, head lowered, he stood in the downpour and let it wash over him. His abdomen was streaked with blood, and the wound looked alarming.

"Huh? What's the point of a shirtless wet-body show now? We're on the expressway!" Lu Mingfei was shocked. "If you really want to look cool and outrageous... Senior, you could take your pants off too..."

But he soon understood. As the rain washed away the blood, faint white steam rose, like concentrated sulfuric acid mixed with water, or as if Chu Zihang's blood were burning oil. Water mixed with blood splashed onto the ground, leaving white spots. Lu Mingfei stared, reminded of the monster in Alien whose blood was strong acid. He had just been chatting with such a monster and riding in his car; he didn't know whether to be proud or scream.

Only when the blood had washed away did Chu Zihang return to the car. He dried himself quickly and took fresh clothes from his suitcase.

"Don't tell anyone. Consider it repayment for my favor," he said quietly.

"No problem, no problem!" Lu Mingfei nodded vigorously.

"Thank you." Chu Zihang started the Panamera. "May I ask a question? Do you like Nono more, or Chen Wenwen?"

"Senior, could you not be so nosy when you're asking someone to keep a secret?" Lu Mingfei made a miserable face.

"Oh, sorry," Chu Zihang said mildly.

The Panamera returned to the road. "I once read a book called Shanghai Fortress. It said there are twenty thousand people in the world you'll fall in love with at first sight, but you might never meet a single one in your whole life," Lu Mingfei said suddenly.

Chu Zihang blinked. "I didn't expect there to be so many..."

"I really liked Chen Wenwen in high school. If she'd liked me back, I probably wouldn't have come to Cassell to slay dragons, and I wouldn't have met Nono. Shameless as it sounds, I like Nono now, but I think I'm just mooning over her, like I did with Chen Wenwen." Lu Mingfei hung his head. "Who I like doesn't matter, does it? The question is who will like me."

"You're the only S-rank among us. You shouldn't think like that," Chu Zihang said.

"You all make S-rank sound impressive, but I can't feel it. You don't even bother taking me on operations," Lu Mingfei muttered.

"That's because you don't have enough experience yet. This world is ours, and yours too, but one day it will all be yours," Chu Zihang said softly. "That day you'll take the places of Caesar and me on the battlefield."

Lu Mingfei immediately imagined himself taking Chu Zihang's place before the three-nothings girl. She waved a hand and rolling flames swept over the three realms like a blazing red lotus, a furious tide of light surging toward him. He, an S-rank, waved a hand too... nothing. He could only say, "Hello, have you eaten?" Then the fire passed, leaving him standing in the ruins as a blackened human shape with only two pitiful eyes blinking... Though it was rather cute, when he pictured it.

"Senior, do you really think my bloodline is S-rank?"

"I don't know. You haven't shown a bloodline advantage yet." Chu Zihang was blunt.

Lu Mingfei sighed. "It's not that I don't want to be impressive. I used to show off in my fantasies. I'd daydream in class about how cool I'd be one day: the teacher is explaining English grammar when a beautiful girl comes in and says in perfect American English, 'Sorry to interrupt, but Sir Lu Mingfei, an urgent transoceanic call from headquarters. If you don't answer, North America will sink...' Then, in front of the whole class, I take the phone and rattle away in flawless French. From then on the teacher never dares punish me by making me copy vocabulary." He smiled self-mockingly. "But that wouldn't be me at all. It'd be somebody else with nothing to do with me."

Chu Zihang glanced at him. "What kind of person do you think you are?"

"Probably... the kind who sleeps in, plays games, spaces out and thinks about random things, reads magazines for free at the newsstand, and likes someone for three years without daring to confess... I know that kind of person isn't interesting. But that's who I am." Lu Mingfei hesitated. "Senior, do you know? When I first walked into Aspasia, I was bursting with happiness, imagining what I'd say if Chen Wenwen liked me because I rescued her and treated her to such an expensive meal, thinking I was incredibly cool."

"She watched you through the glass the whole time you left. I saw it in the rearview mirror," Chu Zihang said. "She did like you a little, didn't she? But you ran away."

"Yeah." Lu Mingfei nodded seriously. "Because then it wouldn't be me she liked. I didn't even know what Aspasia was. I don't have Boss's taste, much less a Mint Club membership. I can't afford to treat her to a meal that expensive; my credit card is still in debt. Boss was really the one buying her Italian food. Boss is wonderful, of course; any girl would like him, right? If I treated her, I could only afford ramen at a street stall... But the me who can only afford ramen still hopes someone will like him..." He scratched his head, suddenly embarrassed. "I'm making a mess of this... Senior, do you understand?"

The corner of Chu Zihang's eye twitched almost imperceptibly, and he fell silent. After a long time he reached out and patted Lu Mingfei's shoulder. "I understand... There used to be someone who could only drive a car, and hoped people would like the him who could only drive."

Lu Mingfei sensed his senior was showing him a little closeness, but didn't understand the deeper meaning, so he could only grin in response.

"What a person can accomplish doesn't depend entirely on bloodline, but on what he wants to accomplish. When I say you're not ready, I don't mean your blood or your ability. I mean you have no goal," Chu Zihang said. "There's no goal that would make you put everything on the line and use all your strength. Someone who can't do that is useless, even if his bloodline is stronger than all of ours."

"Who would I put everything on the line for..." Lu Mingfei muttered. He remembered seeing the sharp tail spike pierce Nono's chest underwater at the Three Gorges, her hair floating like thick

seaweed in a cloud of her own blood. His fingers had grown hot and he'd wanted desperately to draw that blade. The feeling had been wonderful. He too wanted another chance to throw everything away for someone in a flash of passion... but what right did he have to risk himself for anyone?

"Everyone has reasons to risk their life. You keep your life... to wait for the day you'll put it on the line," Chu Zihang said softly.

Only after speaking did he realize how sentimental it sounded. He and Lu Mingfei weren't close enough to bare their hearts; they were merely partners on one operation. He said no more, pressed the accelerator hard, and the engine revved. The Panamera became a dark-blue streak of lightning on the expressway.

The night sky was deep blue, and the glacier below it was black. It was nearly midnight. The moon had just risen over the glacier, turning ice accumulated over tens of thousands of years a luminous blue. Wolves howled from some unknown direction, startling sleeping birds into flight from the dark forest. The Hailuogou hot-spring resort lay in a hollow beneath the glacier.

Nono and Susie soaked in a square hot-spring pool. Under the lights, the water was a soft baby blue, fine wisps of steam rising from its surface. Nono lifted a long leg from the water, waving a razor in her hand.

"Please, you hardly have any leg hair." Susie took a cold can of Coke from a little wooden boat floating in front of her.

"I'm imitating Marilyn Monroe's pose." Nono ducked under the water and popped up beside Susie like a little fish. "Tell me, what's sexy about shaving your legs?"

"I'm not a man. Ask Caesar." Susie sounded languid.

"Caesar thinks a troupe of girls in white lace dresses is the sexiest thing. He's already recruited a whole group into the Student Council." Nono narrowed her eyes and smiled. "Do you think Chu Zihang would like it? Maybe I should make a show of shaving for him one day?"

"You should do it for Lu Mingfei. The recoil from his nosebleed would send him to the moon." Susie pinched her friend's nose. "You remember, don't you? It's Lu Mingfei's birthday. He's your only little junior. Did you text him?"

"I remember, I remember, but I'm hesitating a little." Nono put a white towel soaked in cold water on her forehead and looked up at the sky.

"Don't tell me you don't know he likes you?"

"Do I look that stupid?" Nono made a face. "I've been dating since kindergarten!"

"Kindergarten?"

"I'm the queen of all big sisters. I once stood at the front of my kindergarten class and pointed at all the little boys, announcing that from that day on they were all my boyfriends and had to obey me, and anyone who didn't would be kicked out!" Nono smiled, showing her lovely teeth, her sterling-silver four-leaf clover earrings swaying.

"What's it like, having a junior secretly in love with you?"

"Like an older man in kindergarten telling you what a pretty little girl you are."

"What do you mean?"

"The man says you're pretty, and the junior likes you, but neither of them really knows you. Next time the man sees another little girl he'll tell her she's pretty too, and the junior will end up with a younger girl." Nono shrugged and climbed onto a step beside the pool. Though she wore a swimsuit, much of her chest was exposed, and when the water ran off, a recently healed scar was visible. She had received it during the Three Gorges Reservoir operation, but no longer remembered what had caused it. The doctor had marveled that whatever huge, deadly weapon had made it, her survival was a miracle.

"Plenty of people have crushes on you, don't they? Does Caesar know? Isn't he worried?"

"Caesar is actually very perceptive. He can sense who likes me." Nono tilted her head, combing through her dark-red hair. "But he isn't worried, much less jealous. He thinks only he deserves me. Of course, if the one who liked me were Chu Zihang..." Nono's eyes curved like crescent moons. "Then Caesar might get serious about dealing with him. Thinking about it makes me want to seduce your Chu Zihang!"

"Chu Zihang can't be seduced. Even if you ran toward him naked through the snow, he'd think you had a fever and needed cooling down," Susie said mildly.

"Hey, I'm joking. Don't be possessive. I won't touch your Chu Zihang." Nono cautiously nudged Susie's shoulder.

"He isn't mine. You don't think he's my boyfriend too, do you? He's just a good friend. He's willing to do things for me only because he thinks I've helped him. That's how he is: anyone who helps him, he makes sure to repay. You helped him with your profiling today; maybe he'll take you to dinner when school starts." Susie smiled.

Nono sighed and patted her head. "That makes me angry enough to cry. What a jerk. When I get back to college, I'll teach him a lesson for you."

"He just doesn't have many feelings." Susie fell silent for a while, then, not wanting to continue the subject, turned and tapped Nono's nose. "Seriously, you've been dating Caesar almost two years. Are you going to marry him?"

Nono rested her chin on her hand and thought for a long time, then shook her head. "I haven't decided... I mean it. It's not that there's anything wrong with Caesar. He's very, very good to me, but I don't know why I should marry him!"

"I asked my mom that," Susie said. "Her answer was... because only after you're married can you register the children in the household records!"

Nono covered her face. "Your mom is amazing!"

"Maybe you don't need a reason. Keep it simple: you like someone, he's good to you, you want to stay with him forever, so you marry him and make him yours," Susie said.

"You like Chu Zihang. How long will you like him?" Nono asked softly, gazing at the night sky.

Susie looked up. Moonlight reflected in Nono's clear pupils, and her face was uncharacteristically blank. Knowing she had something on her mind, Susie grew serious too. "I don't know. Maybe once I find a boyfriend, I won't like him anymore."

"If Chu Zihang suddenly proposed and you married him, you wouldn't have another boyfriend. Would you go on liking him all your life?"

Susie thought for a while and shook her head. "I don't know. I've never liked anyone for a lifetime."

"You don't really know Chu Zihang, do you? Even though you remember perfectly whether he likes his eggs fried on one side or both."

Susie lowered her head. "He hasn't given me a chance to know him."

"Exactly." Nono looked down into Susie's eyes, very serious. "When you first begin to like someone, that's when you know them least. Take Chu Zihang: a handsome, cool guy with an expressionless face, but you have no idea when he's happy or sad. He's a book whose cover hasn't even opened for you. Yet you keep thinking about him, longing to open that book and read what's inside. Maybe one day you'll be together and you'll open it. It's so wonderful that you forget to eat and sleep, and want to take it even to the bathroom... But after one year, two years, five, ten, you've finished it and memorized every line and word. Will you still read it over and over? Or will you put it back in its cover and set it on a shelf? Books on shelves are rarely opened again."

Susie was silent for a long time, then reached out and touched Nono's cheek affectionately. "Doesn't it tire you, having so much on your mind all day? Caesar is already the ultimate boyfriend. What kind of person do you want to marry?"

"I've thought about it!" Nono's eyes shone. "The man I marry will make me believe he'll always be with me. As long as I want him there, he'll stay with me always and always. When I'm afraid, even if I can't find anyone else, I'll always find him. When I'm trapped in a nightmare, his name will be the one I call without thinking."

"Mm." Susie looked solemn. "In that case, a dog would do... You could name it 'Oh, how scary,' and when you have a nightmare you'd call, 'Oh, how scary!'"

"How dare you tease me, little lady?" Nono plunged into the spring and pushed Susie in too.

Steam hung thick as a curtain. The girls' laughter answered the distant howls of wolves. Nearby, a man selling cold beer, wrapped in an old sheepskin coat, glimpsed lovely curves flashing through the vapor and silently suffered a nosebleed.

Beep, beep. Nono's phone, sealed in a waterproof plastic bag, lit up with a text.

She emerged from the spring, shook the water from her hair, and opened it.

"Dear: This may seem sudden to you, but I've planned it for a long time. Please read this message patiently to the end..."

It was from Caesar Gattuso. Nono's eyes widened in surprise, and she exchanged a glance with Susie, who had leaned over to look.

Portofino, Italy. The Splendid Hotel.

Caesar leaned against a marble column, holding a glass of gin on ice. A single lamp above cast its light straight down around him. Night had fallen and a storm swept across the Gulf of Genoa. The hotel had brought its umbrellas and outdoor café seating inside, leaving him alone in the courtyard. Lights blazed behind him, an indoor band playing gentle blues, while wind and rain darkened the world ahead. From where he stood the pale-gray sea rolled as though an enormous sea beast were about to break the surface. Waves several meters high battered the cliffs below, while a distant lighthouse beam swept monotonously over the water.

Caesar made a call. "Caesar Gattuso. I'd like to know whether my account has been frozen."

His private banking adviser sounded alarmed. "How could that happen, Mr. Gattuso? You've always been among our highest-tier clients. Who would dare freeze your account? I just checked again and confirmed everything is perfectly normal..."

Caesar silently hung up, unwilling to listen further. Of course there were people in the world who dared freeze his account. His enormous spending came from family funds, and his father or uncle could suspend or permanently close it. He had defied his uncle so fiercely today, and the old man's face had been full of anger when he left, yet he still hadn't thought to freeze Caesar's account. For years Caesar had tested his uncle's limits, and however furious Frost Gattuso became, he had never punished his nephew. Seen from that angle alone, the family's love for Caesar was as vast as the Gulf of Genoa.

Caesar smiled silently. In truth, while spending the family's money freely, he was always prepared for the account to be closed. He knew the conflict between him and the family could not be reconciled. Ever since he'd announced he was considering changing his surname to "Gullveig," all his elders had flown into a rage. "How could you have such an absurd idea?" "That's a lowly surname!" "You may rebel against anything, but not your blood!" Caesar had looked at those angry old faces and found it fascinating.

If one day he lost that endlessly replenished account, he would say goodbye to his present life: luxury sports cars, top hotels, high society in its perfumes and fine clothes, even the light and warmth behind him. He would walk into the storm alone.

"I can't say I don't care at all." He stretched out his hand and let the rain fall into his palm.

There was still no reply. He dried his hand and reread the message he had just sent.

"...I once imagined that on the day I proposed, I would pretend to invite you on vacation to an uninhabited island. I'd have my friends wait on the beach across the water with thousands of fireworks. When you and I walked hand in hand to the shore, I would suddenly kneel and bring out the ring I'd prepared, while streaks of light flew across the night sky and reflected in the sea. But when the day suddenly came, I hadn't had time to arrange fireworks. I could buy a ring at once, but I couldn't get it to China. The Mint Club people say the earliest they can deliver it to you is tomorrow morning. But I don't want to wait. I want to say it tonight: Nono, I want to announce our engagement to everyone, in a grand ceremony or a simple one..."

"Wow! Speak of the wolf and it really comes! A proposal text! My face is burning!" Susie covered her cheeks and cried out.

"Hey... he isn't proposing to you..." Nono glanced at her. "Keep reading. I don't know why he's suddenly gone crazy tonight."

"A man who suddenly goes crazy is the most romantic kind! He must be an absolute Cancer!"

"No, he's a perfectionist Libra!"

Caesar tipped the last of his drink and its ice into his mouth.

"...But it's very likely our engagement won't have my family's blessing. The Gattuso family's chosen heir has his engagement decided by the family, not by himself. But I won't let them decide my future. My future will be brilliant, and I will share it with the brilliant girl I love. Her surname isn't special; her hair is dark red; she wears silver four-leaf-clover earrings; when she's angry she's as prickly and unapproachable as a hedgehog... But I want to live with her for decades more, perhaps a

hundred years. I truly have to thank my bloodline: it gives me more time in the life I have left to spend with her..."

Reading that far, Caesar smiled silently. He was beginning to admire his own literary talent. All that idle practice writing fiction online hadn't gone to waste.

"...It's such a lonely night. It's raining in Portofino, and Portofino is beautiful in the rain. I've always wanted to bring you here, but you haven't accepted my invitation yet. Much happened today; I'll tell you everything later. Right now I only want to say that tonight, more than ever, I wish you were beside me. Even if you merely sat silently watching me, or pulled a contemptuous face and mocked my weakness at this moment, I would still want to feel your warmth..."

He set his glass beneath the grapevines and walked into the rain, which instantly soaked him through. He mounted the little motorcycle and rode out through the heavy black iron gates.

"Wow, underneath it all he's a sensitive, proud little boy!" Susie shook a clenched fist. "'I'm happy even when you bully me' and all that!"

"Absolutely not." Nono stuck out her tongue, a blush rising to her cheeks. "Something probably upset him today. Most of the time he's still an overbearing, conceited guy."

"You're blushing, you're blushing!" Susie leaned over Nono's smooth back and pinched her cheeks.

"Hey, it's a love letter. Isn't it normal to blush reading one?" Nono reached back and pinched her nose. "If you're peeking at somebody else's love letter, be quiet!"

"All right, all right, I'll shut up. Look how ridiculously happy you are." Susie put her arms around her neck.

"...I have many, many friends, and know many, many girls. Ever since I was little I've wondered what kind of girl I would spend my life with. What a terrifying thing: only one chance to choose, and I must swear before everyone to love and protect her and never leave her. I thought I was already brave, but not brave enough to tell a girl in public that I would love her for life. Then I met you, and you gave me that courage. Yes, Nono, I love you, and I hope for the chance to love you all my life..."

The little motorcycle cut through the storm. Caesar's wet blond hair streamed into the wind like a battle flag, and Anthony the gyrfalcon flew beside him.

"...I know many people think I'm a spoiled playboy or a young emperor or something, but whether he's a playboy or a young emperor, when a man faces the girl he loves, he's only a boy. The boy who loves you is named Caesar, not Caesar Gattuso, just Caesar. There are things I can't tell you yet, but my family doesn't want you and me to become engaged. If I have to choose, however, I will take off the glittering coat called 'Gattuso' without hesitation. Would you accept that Caesar? Still Caesar, only apparently naked..."

The motorcycle stopped on the beach. Caesar ran into the cold surf, his powerful chest breaking wave after wave of the rising tide. He threw off his little white dinner jacket, kicked away his expensive crocodile-skin shoes, tied his hair back with the violet scarf, and dove into the water, swimming against the waves toward the deep sea.

"...Come, we will seize happiness and glory together. My life will be a great ship, and I want you standing with me at its prow. When that ship enters port we will astonish the world together. I will take your hand as we come ashore and say, 'This is Caesar's bride!'"

His arms stroked powerfully, fighting the cold waves again and again. Caesar felt like an arrow gliding through the water. Nothing could stop him: waves, family, even his father! Because he was sharp enough!

Caesar burst out of the water and looked back. He could no longer see the cliffs through the storm; he was nearing the edge of the harbor. Around him were only black, heaving waves. The lighthouse's white beam swept past, and a falcon's cry tore through the wind and rain.

"Anthony! Fly! Fly to..." Caesar raised his arm and shouted at the sky with all his strength. "The highest place!"

In the black sky torn by lightning, the falcon soared.

Thousands of kilometers away, at Hailuogou in China's Sichuan Province, snowflakes settled on the girls' bare arms and quickly melted into drops of water.

"It's snowing." Susie sank into the hot spring, watching the fine drifting flakes. "So beautiful. I never expected snow this time of year. It must be a blessing for you, though the proposal reads a little like a declaration of war..."

"Come conquer the world with me, woman!" Nono sank into the spring too, curling up with her mouth beneath the surface, only her blinking eyes showing, like a child.

"But it's really moving, as though he put all his strength into every word," Susie said softly. "If Lu Mingfei wrote it, it'd probably be something like, 'I don't mean anything special, I just thought if we have children it'll be easier to register them,' that sort of nonsense."

"Hey... where did that strange idea come from?" Nono said quietly.

"Dizzy with happiness, girl?" Susie said. "Say yes. Get engaged first, then after graduation you can have a grand wedding. I reserve the bridesmaid's job!"

"Oh, come on, I have to play hard to get a little! And look how sudden it is. I haven't even brushed my teeth... How can I accept a proposal like this?"

"Look at you, tail in the air!" Susie laughed and pushed her head under the water.

Caught off guard, Nono choked on a mouthful of water. Everything suddenly went black.

"Oh no!" She was still conscious.

Since the Three Gorges operation she had kept having dreams. The doctor said it was a minor aftereffect of prolonged oxygen deprivation underwater and would gradually heal. But Nono hated this "minor" aftereffect, because it was always the same dream.

In the dream all was a blue so dark it was nearly black. Light came down through the water overhead, its ripples reflected across her face. She floated amid endless waves, unable even to hear her own heartbeat. Figures seemed to move above the surface. She tried to rise but had no strength, unable to move a finger. They seemed to bend over her with grief-stricken faces. She felt as though she lay in a coffin, saying goodbye to loved ones through glass.

What a nightmare, how she hated it! Time didn't flow in the dream. It was so cold; she wanted fearfully to curl up but lacked the strength. It was so quiet; she wanted to talk to someone but couldn't speak. It was so hopeless. So this was what death was like.

Every time she woke she was cold all over. She didn't remember what had happened underwater at the Three Gorges, but she understood the dream was about death.

The moment she choked on the water she saw that almost-black blue again. She floated in endless waves, unable to move. The damned lack of oxygen had dragged her bodily into the dream!

She felt she was going to die...

Everything suddenly tore apart! Water, light, the almost-black blue, everything was ripped open by claws! As if the vault of heaven had split, an enormous face appeared in the gap, with golden eyes bright as day! That twisted, ferocious... child's face...

"Don't die!" he roared.

"Ricar...do." Nono called out the name.

More water flooded her throat. She kicked hard several times, found her footing in the spring, and gasped, her eyes filled with terror.

"Oh, sorry, sorry!" Susie hurried to help her.

Susie hadn't expected such an accomplished swimmer to come to grief in this little pool. Nono had clearly swallowed several mouthfuls, not just the first one; she'd swallowed more while struggling and calling out underwater. Susie hadn't heard what she said, but through the surface had seen the terror on her face. In all the time they'd known each other, she had never seen the little red-haired witch so shaken.

"I'm fine, I'm fine." Nono waved a hand and turned, forcing a smile for Susie. "I'm a little dizzy. I'll sit in the sauna."

Susie watched her white-swimsuited back disappear into the darkness, suddenly feeling as though she had become another person.

Nono was alone in the sauna. She ladled cool water over the red-hot stones; dense steam spread and blurred her vision.

The phone screen was the only thing she could see clearly through the steam. It displayed a multimedia message she had already prepared. She had hesitated to send it, thought it inappropriate, then couldn't quite bear to cancel it. So the message remained in her drafts, its fate dependent on her mood.

The message was a song: "Happy birthday to you, Ri-Ricardo, happy birthday to you, Ri-Ricardo..."

On the way to Hailuogou, the tune had suddenly occurred to her. She had recorded it for fun, thinking she'd send it to Lu Mingfei on his birthday and he'd surely grin like an idiot.

But... did it suggest something, however faintly? She rarely hesitated; she generally did whatever came to mind. And was there any need to hesitate? She couldn't possibly like Lu Mingfei. At most she pitied him a little. When they first met he was a genuine beaten dog, and the image of him crouching alone in a corner, gasping for breath, felt familiar. She had already been quite good to him; having a pretty senior looking out for him would make college easier. She hated seeing anyone helpless. As for his liking her, surely it would pass? Wasn't a junior supposed to learn how girls thought from his senior, then use that knowledge to charm girls younger than himself?

Just as the older men who praised her in kindergarten belonged with women their own age, a junior belonged with a younger girl.

She should have been happily bouncing around today, getting thoroughly drunk with Susie tonight. It was the first proposal of her life... So why had that childish face suddenly appeared? She'd never

seen him so frantic, furious, and ferocious. That wasn't an expression he should wear. Suddenly all her joy had faded, leaving her very, very tired.

She sat silently in the steam. Today was Lu Mingfei's birthday; in half an hour it would be over.

Lu Mingfei took out his phone and checked the time: 11:30 p.m. Rain streamed past the airplane window, and the city's scattered lights could be seen in the distance.

Chu Zihang handed him a small packet. "This route crosses the Arctic Circle. Ten hours; sleep and you'll be in Chicago." Then he briskly put in earplugs, covered his eyes with a mask, fitted an inflatable neck pillow, pulled up a blanket, and fell asleep.

Lu Mingfei opened the packet. Inside was an identical set. Chu Zihang had long since planned to spend the ten-hour flight resting; the man's life was precise as a machine.

"United Airlines Flight UA836 to Chicago is preparing for departure. Please switch off your mobile communication devices." A sweet female voice echoed through the cabin.

No new messages came. Lu Mingfei pressed the power button until the screen went black. What was the person he was thinking of doing at this moment? Better not wonder about what he couldn't know. Perhaps she was nestled beside someone, fishing on the sunlit Red Sea, while he thought of her on a dark rainy night. It made him seem so humble, wrapped in a gloomy, unpleasant haze, didn't it? Lu Mingfei put in his earplugs and eye mask. Darkness filled his vision, and the enormous roar of the engines was shut out; all he could feel was the acceleration and vibration of his seat. The Boeing 747 pierced the curtain of rain and climbed diagonally into the sky, skimming over the sleeping city.

"Good night," Lu Mingfei said softly, not knowing to whom.

Act Six

Beware of Fire, Thieves, and Your Senior

Beware of Your Senior

What a wonderful morning. Sunlight poured through the skylight onto Xia Mi. The slender, supple girl stood on one leg with the grace of a ballerina, reaching out to steal two cups of Coke for them. Lu Mingfei watched her long leg lifted into the sunlight, every line youthful and fluid, every inch of skin smooth as jade. For the first time he understood what the ancients meant by a perfect balance of flesh and bone.

"TRY A WEEK WITHOUT RAILWAY!!!" proclaimed a huge white banner hanging in the empty waiting hall of Chicago's train station.

Lu Mingfei lifted his face to the ceiling and sighed, his heart sinking.

They had flown halfway around the world to Chicago and hurried eagerly to the station, only to find a waiting hall littered with scraps of paper, placards, and drink cans. A few hours before they landed at Chicago International Airport, the entire Chicago railway workforce had finished marching in protest and gone home. They would not be back for a week.

They were on strike.

Lu Mingfei had grown up under the red flag of socialism and had always been generous with his praise of strikes. When his high-school politics teacher put a question about the strike movement on the final exam, he had even quoted Comrade Lenin with feeling: "How profound is the influence of a strike! Every strike powerfully turns the workers' thoughts toward socialism, toward the struggle the whole working class must wage to free itself from the oppression of capital!"

But supporting the Chicago railway workers out of his own wallet hurt. Cassell operated the CC1000 branch express itself, but without switch operators or a dispatch center, every train had to stop. They would certainly miss registration. Since the delay was beyond their control, their GPA would not be penalized, but the college would not pay for a week in Chicago.

"Then we'll stay in Chicago for a week," Chu Zihang said calmly. "If that's a problem for you, share a room with me. I'll pay."

A sneaky little thrill ran through Lu Mingfei. He had known his expressionless senior never quibbled over money. He had been waiting for exactly those words!

He hoisted his luggage. "Come on! Let's go get a room!"

A soft giggle came from overhead. "What do two grown men need a room for?"

Lu Mingfei jumped. He and Chu Zihang were clearly the only people in the hall. Could Lu Mingze have grown restless again? He looked up for the voice and saw the enormous white banner, ten meters wide and ten meters long, trembling slightly, as if someone were hiding behind it. A human shape moved left along the beam. A hand emerged from behind the cloth and unfastened the hook on the left. Then the figure moved right, and the hand reached out again for the other hook.

"Careful!" Chu Zihang said suddenly.

He saw the beam wobble. The person behind the banner lost their balance and pulled the whole sheet down. Just then a gust swept through the waiting hall, and the white cloth fell like a cloud. Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei both lunged to catch the person: a fall from five or six meters up would break an ordinary person's bones. Lu Mingfei had barely taken two steps when the cloth came down over his head. He panicked, tripped, and fell flat on his face like a fallen angel. Chu Zihang was half a step slower, but he could see the figure wrapped in the cloth, and caught them securely.

The person was startlingly light.

"Who? Who are you? Are you trying to get yourself killed? You made me fall too!" Lu Mingfei scrambled up, rubbing his back and complaining without pause.

A head poked out of the white cloth and looked around. For a moment both Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang fell silent. Chu Zihang gently set the person down and stepped back.

It was respect for a woman, and awe before beauty. A tomb robber crawling into Tutankhamun's burial chamber, confronted by that exquisite golden mask as if time itself had been sealed inside it, might likewise fall silent in wonder and hesitate to lift it, afraid of disturbing sleeping beauty, afraid she would grow old the moment she woke.

The girl regarded them curiously. In her clear eyes, both boys saw their own awkward, self-conscious reflections.

As a shut-in, Lu Mingfei kept a mental ranking of beautiful girls. Nono and Su Xiaoqiang tied for first. The little witch needed no explanation, and Su Xiaoqiang's nickname, the Little Celestial Princess, was well earned. Her mother was Portuguese, giving her the defined features of a European and the gentle beauty of an Eastern girl. Zero ranked second: Her Ice Queen Majesty's beauty hovered between girl and little girl, proud as snow and ice, though she was always so cold-faced that she seemed to think the whole world owed her millions of rubles. Liu Miaomiao came third, while Chen Wenwen was only fourth, even allowing for the likelihood that judge Lu Mingfei had awarded her extra points for personal preference.

Yet none of them could quite be called flawless. "Flawless" was not really a good word; every living thing had defects. A truly flawless face probably existed only beneath a sculptor's chisel.

But looking at this girl, you felt as though the sculpture had opened its eyes and come to life.

"Hi there, monster!" Lu Mingfei murmured.

He meant that only a monster could be that beautiful. His expressionless senior and the beauty herself could hardly be expected to understand a joke with such depth.

Chu Zihang nudged him with an elbow. "She's a fellow student."

The girl bared her teeth. "Not a monster. I'm a sweet, gentle girl!"

Lu Mingfei was delighted. Someone did understand his joke after all. Only then did he notice the black ticket held between her teeth: a special ticket for the CC1000 branch express.

"Chu Zihang, mechanical engineering." Chu Zihang reached out to help her up.

The girl emerged from the white cloth. She wore a plain white spaghetti-strap top with batik orchids, very short shorts, ankle socks, and sneakers. Her outfit was simple, with sunglasses perched on her head.

"Senior!" The girl sprang up. "I'm a freshman, Xia Mi."

"Hey, hey, don't block me." Lu Mingfei shouldered Chu Zihang aside. "I'm a senior too! Lu Mingfei, history."

"Oh, a humanities guy?" Xia Mi widened her eyes and looked him up and down.

For no reason Lu Mingfei felt inferior to Chu Zihang. Strictly speaking, Chu Zihang's department was called Alchemical Mechanical Engineering and specialized in alchemical equipment. Lu Mingfei's history department was really Dragon Genealogy, where he would study dragon family trees and dig deep into the dark side of their history. But none of that was easy to explain to this junior, still as blank as a sheet of paper. The mystery would be revealed at freshman orientation.

"What were you doing up there?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Taking down this sheet. We'd have to stay in a hotel for a week, and I'm out of money. I still have to save up for a lens for my camera. Nobody needs this thing anyway, so I can use it to pitch a tent near Central Park and sleep there for a week." Xia Mi plopped down amid the cloth and folded the huge sheet. Her hands moved quickly. Soon she had rolled it into an enormous bundle and slung it over her shoulder. "I'll be going, then. See you at college!"

"Can you pitch a tent in the park?" Chu Zihang asked.

"I'll tell them I'm demonstrating on behalf of the Chicago railway workers!" Xia Mi clenched her fist, earnest and blazing with civic spirit. "If our railway brothers aren't going back to work, I'll share their hardship!"

"Brilliant! I can go with you!" Lu Mingfei was delighted by her ingenuity.

Chu Zihang hesitated. "You don't have a Social Security card yet. It could be awkward if the police questioned you. If you don't mind, you could stay with us. We're going to..."

"Get a room?" Xia Mi spun around and stared at him.

Chu Zihang froze, taken aback by the fierce look in her eyes. He realized the invitation was inappropriate. They might be fellow students, but they hardly knew one another. Two boys inviting a girl to share a room, a Chinese girl at that—her parents would probably throw gas cylinders at them if they found out.

"A rich guy! I'm so happy! Please keep me!" The next moment Xia Mi was pretending to collapse against Chu Zihang's chest.

Chu Zihang stood there silently, wondering whether he had met a female Fingel or a female Lu Mingfei. Well, there was not much difference between the two species.

"Come on, come on, let's get a room! I'm starving." Lu Mingfei picked up Xia Mi's luggage. Compared with other students arriving in America, she had brought very little: one standard suitcase and a tote bag.

"Wait, wait, let me get another Coke," Xia Mi said.

"Buy one after we get to the hotel," Chu Zihang said.

"All you ever say is buy, buy, buy!" Xia Mi made a face. "I never said I was going to pay."

She fished a used paper Coke cup out of her bag and trotted to the entrance of a closed Subway. Standing on tiptoe, she squeezed half her body between the metal bars. With the cup in her hand she

could just reach the soda dispenser. A wonderfully refreshing sound of flowing liquid followed: the Subway staff had forgotten to unplug the machine when they closed.

Xia Mi sipped her Coke, looking pleased with herself. "I didn't arrive two hours before you for nothing. I've already scouted the whole place!"

"Wow! Doesn't that mean endless free Coke?" Lu Mingfei was overjoyed. "I'll get one too."

"You boys won't fit through. I'll get some for you." Xia Mi produced two more paper cups.

What a wonderful morning. Sunlight poured through the skylight onto Xia Mi. The slender, supple girl stood on one leg with the grace of a ballerina, reaching out to steal two cups of Coke for them. Lu Mingfei watched her long leg lifted into the sunlight, every line youthful and fluid, every inch of skin smooth as jade. For the first time he understood what the ancients meant by a perfect balance of flesh and bone. Watching her was simply an appreciation of beauty; he felt neither lust nor unbearable longing. He only wished the cups were bigger so she would take longer to fill them, and at the same time wanted to pull out his phone and preserve the moment.

It was as wonderful as the first time the guys had sneaked into a dance academy and watched the pretty girls practice through the glass, a sight to lift the heart.

Pretty little female thieves were truly one of the cutest species in the world!

"Drink the Coke I stole and you'll owe me a favor. You'll have to help me out later," Xia Mi said as the three of them dragged their luggage toward the exit.

"Of course! Your senior's got your back!" Lu Mingfei drank his Coke and thumped his chest.

Only a fool would fail to look after a junior like this. Here was that legendary, wondrous species, the junior girl! She was electricity, she was light, she was an awesome myth! She had come to rescue suffering seniors from their sea of misery! In every story about junior girls, they admired the knowledgeable, cultured seniors who knew all the rules for surviving campus life. Wasn't this how generations of seniors studying in America had got by? Drive a battered car to the airport to meet a junior, enthusiastically help her find a place to live, generously drive her to the supermarket, take her to an amusement park to expose the decadence of capitalism, and confess your love before she had fully learned her way around America and discovered you were just a loser! Generation after generation, the seniors had taken the juniors' share, leaving the younger boys to wait silently until they became seniors themselves and a new crop of junior girls descended from heaven.

Junior girls were like chives: every crop was fresher than the last!

"You're so kind, senior." Xia Mi smiled a smile that could win anyone's heart and make flowers bloom. Then her voice suddenly dropped, like an older sister offering a confidence. "Xia Mi, be careful he doesn't pick you up. Stay alert! Beware of fire, thieves, and your senior!"

In a guest room at the Hyatt Regency Chicago, Lu Mingfei lounged on the sofa watching television.

The famous hotel stood beside the Chicago River. Outside, white tour boats glided slowly past, a plump Black guide at the bow enthusiastically recounting the golden years of the city's founding to a group of foreign tourists.

"Senior, isn't this a little inappropriate? I absolutely support you paying for our junior's room," Lu Mingfei said, "but two guys and a girl in one room? Won't the Disciplinary Committee come after us?"

"The Disciplinary Committee doesn't care about that. Professor Manstein is probably arranging defenses for this year's Freedom Day," Chu Zihang said mildly. "I don't think it's quite appropriate

either, but she said if I paid for a separate room, she'd owe me too much, and she'd rather pitch a tent in the park."

He stood with his back against the wall, leafing through an old annotated edition of the Emerald Tablet, a reference work for Alchemical Chemistry III. The Emerald Tablet was an ancient text from 1900 BC, engraved on an emerald slab and discovered in a hidden chamber beneath a pyramid. Considered the foundational book of alchemy, it claimed as its author Hermes, the three-in-one god of Egyptian mythology. It contained only thirteen sentences, yet held all the truths of alchemy.

Water splashed in the next room. Xia Mi was bathing in the bathroom.

"It rises from earth to heaven and descends again from heaven to earth, receiving the power of the higher and the lower. Thus you shall gain the glory of the world and be free of darkness and ignorance," Chu Zihang murmured. This was Newton's translation of the Emerald Tablet. The scientist himself was also a well-known mystic, deeply interested in alchemy and the occult. In the Middle Ages theology and science were not so clearly separated, and alchemy counted as a science too.

Lu Mingfei was truly in awe of him. They had finally found a girl among the freshmen beautiful enough to be the campus belle, and they were even sharing a room. They ought to drink a few beers and get to know one another. Imagine it: their pretty junior bathing next door. Ah, "warm spring waters caressed her creamy skin." Back in class, the more the teacher explained the Song of Everlasting Sorrow, the more irritated he had become. Now, wiping away his drool as he imagined water dancing over his junior's lovely skin, he felt enlightened at last and understood classmate Bai Letian's poetic vision. Come to think of it, wasn't that line downright indecent? Recite it to yourself a few times and you could feel a nosebleed coming on... Yet Chu Zihang looked utterly unmoved, having wrestled with that dry reference book for nearly half an hour. Such meditative powers would be wasted on anyone but a monk.

"Senior, I know you're studying, but couldn't you find somewhere to sit?" Lu Mingfei could not understand why Chu Zihang kept standing against the wall.

"I'm practicing my standing posture at the same time. I stand for half an hour every night. It's very good for the spine. I suggest you try it," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at him. "Forget it. Fingel would die laughing if he saw." Such dull, strenuous self-discipline, with its faint air of aristocratic refinement, struck him as a little silly, though it suited Chu Zihang rather well.

"Newton's original says, 'It ascends from ye earth to ye heaven & again it descends to ye earth and receives ye force of things superior & inferior. By this means you shall have ye glory of ye whole world & thereby all obscurity shall fly from you.' It can also be translated, 'The One rises from earth to heaven, then descends again to earth, absorbing the powers of the upper and lower realms. Thus you shall possess the glory of the whole world and be free of ignorance.'" The bathroom door opened. Wrapped in a bathrobe, Xia Mi emerged, drying her long hair, and went to the wall opposite Chu Zihang. She too stood with her back against it. "The key to understanding the passage is what that 'it' refers to."

"It could mean the material used in alchemy: metal or another substance being scorched by flame," Chu Zihang said.

"It could also mean the spirit," Xia Mi said.

"There hasn't been much progress on the spirit interpretation since 1972."

"But a new paper on it came out just last year."

The two people standing against the walls exchanged questions and answers with easy fluency, while Lu Mingfei stared wide-eyed. He was like a toad listening to a sermon before the Buddha: he could hear profound truths but understood not a word, and wished someone would translate the mysteries into ribbits.

"Wait, wait, what are you talking about? Junior, why are you standing against the wall too?" Lu Mingfei could not take it anymore.

"The Emerald Tablet. Senior Lu, didn't you take Alchemical Chemistry? It's a surviving fragment of a draconic classic. It's just so obscure that no one's ever given it a definitive interpretation," Xia Mi said. "I'm waiting for my hair to dry and practicing my posture at the same time."

"What did you say?" Lu Mingfei was stunned.

What was going on? This junior had not even been through orientation. Wasn't she supposed to be a blank sheet on which the most beautiful picture could be painted? On hearing that a miraculous reptilian dynasty really existed in the world, she ought to scream in terror! Back then, Senior Lu Mingfei himself had screamed and practically wet his pants!

"Dragons, dragons, dragons," Xia Mi said three times.

"She was in the preparatory program. Prep students take the 3E exam early, so the existence of dragons isn't a secret to her. Her bloodline is A-rank, exceptionally good," Chu Zihang explained to Lu Mingfei.

"Preparatory? What program?"

"The college's secret branch in China. It selects high-school students with bloodlines from across the country for preparatory classes. The college gives them the 3E exam early. If their bloodlines are good enough, they go straight to the main campus after graduation. If they don't pass, the Gate to Cassell begins its closing sequence. They're treated as ordinary students and take the national college entrance exam when they graduate." Chu Zihang continued, "Xia Mi, born October 30, 1993, in Beijing, China. Female. Before the preparatory program she attended the high school affiliated with Peking University. Registered in Beijing. Family consists of her parents and an older brother."

"Hey!" Xia Mi glared. "Are you checking my household registration?"

"Norma sent the information from the main campus. We need to know who you are." Chu Zihang picked up his iPad from a little table. "Lu Mingfei, hand this to Xia Mi for me."

"Why am I the errand boy?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

"I haven't finished my exercise." Chu Zihang was still standing perfectly straight, now balancing a hardcover book on his head.

Four or five meters away, Xia Mi also balanced a hardcover on her head and held out her hand, waiting for Lu Mingfei to bring her the iPad.

"Are you two kidding me?" Lu Mingfei snatched the iPad from Chu Zihang and ran it over to Xia Mi, looking every inch an obedient little lackey.

The iPad held Xia Mi's file, thorough and clear down to the smallest detail. Cassell College's Intelligence Department was responsible for student records. Famous for CIA-like rigor, its people

made everyone's file read like a catalog of embarrassing secrets. Xia Mi's photograph brightened the document, a casual close-up taken with some small camera. Her hair was dyed dark coffee brown, she wore dark cosmetic contact lenses, and she was looking back against a sunset, a yellow bow in her hair flying in the breeze.

"You're so alternative!" Lu Mingfei commented offhandedly.

"You're the pig, and your whole family's a bunch of pigs." Xia Mi took the iPad and glanced at it. "I was cosplaying Haruhi Suzumiya at the anime club."

"They picked you to cosplay Haruhi Suzumiya?"

"I wanted to cosplay Asahina originally," Xia Mi said.

"Asahina?" Lu Mingfei grinned, delighted.

Asahina was the big-busted beauty in The Melancholy of Haruhi Suzumiya, always forced to dress as a bunny girl, a maid, or even a sexy frog. Imagining Xia Mi in the role, he felt another nosebleed threatening.

Xia Mi sighed and looked down at her chest. After a moment's silence, she said, "But they all disagreed. They said I didn't qualify..."

"I hate girls with big breasts the most!" Xia Mi suddenly looked up and shouted. "They bully people!"

The words came straight from the heart and rang with conviction. The room went quiet. No... it fell deathly silent.

"Well... my condolences." Lu Mingfei handed his discouraged junior an orange and patted the book on her head, like a compassionate monk comforting a young seeker short on natural gifts.

Then he burst out laughing, threw himself onto the bed, buried his head under the covers, and pounded the mattress. He could not hold it in any longer; bottling it up would have caused internal injuries. Suddenly the strike seemed wonderful, and the coming week stranded in Chicago would be even better, all because he had met this pretty, mischievous, delightfully goofy junior. She was both Lin Zhiling and a stand-up comedian!

"Laugh... laugh at your own sister." Xia Mi glanced at Lu Mingfei and curled her lip.

"If 'the One' means the spirit, then do the upper and lower realms refer to the different spiritual worlds of dragons and humans?"

"You can interpret it that way. It describes the process of a human evolving into a dragon and thereby reaching self-completion."

"Can humans evolve into dragons?"

"Some medieval scholars of the Emerald Tablet believed it was a work falsely attributed to a god, but that its author had 'approached infinitely close to godhood' and 'stolen the laws of the gods.' Fearing ordinary people would discover those laws, the author used secret language."

"The hieratic script of ancient Egypt?"

"Yes. Only priests knew hieratic script. Arabic replaced Egyptian as the common language of Egypt in the seventh century, so hieratic is hard to decipher. The Newton translation you're using could be full of errors..."

"The translation you just used says, 'The One rises from earth to heaven, then descends again to earth, absorbing the powers of the upper and lower realms. Thus you shall possess the glory of the whole world and be free of ignorance.' By your interpretation, if a human can evolve into a dragon, there would be no need to return to the human world. Since the author wanted to leave ignorance behind..." Chu Zihang pondered.

"Why leave cute girls behind?" Lu Mingfei interrupted, bored out of his mind.

It was a beautiful day: a luxurious five-star hotel, a comfortable big sofa, a complimentary fruit platter, a rich expressionless senior paying the bill, and a pretty junior he had just met. Yet the two of them stood against the walls to either side of Lu Mingfei, each balancing a book on their head like a pair of door gods. Worse still, after reading separately for a while, the two door gods had started arguing over how to interpret that Emerald Tablet. Both were damn academics, and Lu Mingfei did not understand a word, hearing only mystical phrases like "from heaven to earth" and "from earth to heaven."

"Then why must he 'descend again to earth'? Isn't 'from earth to heaven' the ultimate goal of all alchemy?" Chu Zihang had no intention of paying Lu Mingfei any attention; his mind was entirely occupied with the subject he was discussing with Xia Mi.

"From earth to heaven, from heaven to earth, how marvelous are all the things in the world, how marvelous..." Lu Mingfei suddenly remembered a children's song from a CCTV program he had watched as a child and sang it offhandedly.

Chu Zihang and Xia Mi stared at him speechlessly, apparently unable to understand his inner world at all.

"Between heaven and earth there hangs a scale, and the common people are its weight..." Just as Lu Mingfei realized he had gone off the rails again, Xia Mi suddenly began singing the theme from Prime Minister Liu Luoguo in the style of Beijing drum singing.

"Hey, what's going on? Weren't you having an academic discussion? How did we suddenly turn it into a medley of old songs?" Lu Mingfei said.

"I was playing along with you," Xia Mi said. "Do you know the theme from Barbapapa?"

"I think I remember it..." Chu Zihang tried humming the tune.

Later, remembering that warm, sunlit afternoon, Lu Mingfei felt that they had done nothing meaningful at all. Tour boats came and went on the Chicago River, The Simpsons played in reruns on television, and he sat on the sofa with a handsome boy and a beautiful girl standing straight on either side, hardcovers balanced on their heads. Sometimes they discussed scholarship, sometimes they sang back and forth. Sometimes Xia Mi told silly jokes, and sometimes Lu Mingfei explained the college's factions to her. An afternoon like that sounded like a waste of life.

And yet you always wished such afternoons could be longer, more frequent, and never end...

"Are you asleep?" Lu Mingfei asked softly, looking at the ceiling.

The person beside him was also looking at the ceiling, the blanket pulled up to the shoulders, both hands neatly tucked beneath it. "Not yet. I'm thinking."

"Sorry, sorry. Was I too loud turning over?"

"No. I'm just not used to sleeping with someone else. I'll fall asleep when I get tired. It's all right."

"You have an iPhone too, and there's Wi-Fi here. Since neither of us can sleep... how about a game of tile matching online?" Lu Mingfei suggested after a long silence.

"I don't know how to play tile matching, but we could play chess."

"You've never even played tile matching? Senior, your life is a tragedy..." Lu Mingfei turned his head and sighed at the handsome face and neat eyelashes beside him.

"Sorry," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei remembered the time during high-school military training when the boys had eavesdropped on the girls' late-night conversation. The subject had been: "What would I do if I landed Chu Zihang?" The aggressive faction insisted they would push him down. The literary faction wanted to hear him tell bedtime stories. The devoted-wife-and-mother faction wanted to feed their darling Chu Zihang baby until he was plump and healthy. The career-minded faction scoffed: "I'd let him follow me and live the life he wants! I'll support him!" In the end the sentimental faction won out when a girl said softly, "I just want to count his eyelashes one by one while he sleeps..." The boys listening at the wall all went weak at the knees.

Time had passed and things had changed. The girls from that conversation probably all had boyfriends now, while one of the eavesdroppers was sharing a bed and pillow with young master Chu.

"Damn it," Lu Mingfei muttered inwardly. "A whole week in bed with this young master? What have I done to deserve it? Hey, girls, jealous of me? Hey, girls, jealous?"

He muttered himself to sleep.

Chu Zihang turned his head. Xia Mi was already fast asleep. The curtains were open, and moonlight fell across her soft bangs. The blanket was wrapped all the way up to the back of her head, leaving only her small, delicate face exposed. Her long eyelashes cast two shadows on her cheeks. Something stirred in Chu Zihang's heart. Each lash could be counted distinctly, as though marking the passage of time.

At the college's main campus, in the central control room, an aluminum security case sat on the long table with a courier label from China attached. The last CC1000 express before the strike had brought it there.

Schneider shone a dark-purple flashlight along the edge of the case. Under the ultraviolet light a reflective security label appeared, like the marks used to authenticate banknotes. He nodded. "The seal is intact. The case wasn't opened on the way. What's inside is safe."

"This didn't need to come to the college. It could have gone straight to the Board of Trustees," Manstein said, frowning. "Now we have to wait for them to send someone to collect it."

"I told Chu Zihang to send it to us," Schneider said. "I'm still not entirely reassured. We'd better open it and have a look." He acted as soon as he spoke, picking up handheld hydraulic cutters and snipping off the lock with a snap.

"Hey!" Manstein shouted, trying to stop him, but it was too late.

"You work like a burglar breaking down a door. Don't you have a key?" Manstein said. "Leave it alone. It isn't what we're after. We've recovered it as the Board of Trustees ordered, so let them have it. Don't touch it. You'll only make trouble for yourself."

"It's simpler this way," Schneider said mildly. Sometimes Manstein had to wonder whether Chu Zihang had learned certain habits from his violence-prone teacher.

Inside the aluminum case was a sealed paper envelope with its seal intact. Schneider tore it open and emptied it onto the table. The envelope contained photocopied documents printed on transparent film. Schneider flipped through them at astonishing speed. His hands suddenly became extraordinarily nimble, nothing like an old man's. The sheets slid rapidly between his fingers as his eyes swept over them like a scanner, his iron-gray pupils contracted to pinpoints. Manstein had rarely seen him so intent.

"Hey, you! Are you crazy?" Manstein finally understood and shouted.

Schneider was not checking whether the material was intact at all. He meant to scan it before it was taken away, stealing a look at the Board of Trustees' top-secret SS-rank files.

"Do you know what this is?" Schneider's face was expressionless, and he showed no sign of stopping. "These are confidential Chinese police files from the past five years on 'unknown types of crime.' That means supernatural crime. This archive is like the US Air Force's Project Blue Book on UFOs. Of course, most cases simply involved methods too ingenious to solve, but some are connected to dragons."

"The Chinese police know dragons exist?" Guderian was shocked.

"No, but they know these events are beyond ordinary human understanding. Take this one." Schneider laid a sheet of film on the table. "On July 3, 2004, Typhoon Dandelion made landfall on China's southeastern coast, bringing three days of storms. During that storm there was an incident that was never explained. A Maybach sedan was abandoned on an elevated road, its body covered with inexplicable damage, as if it had been repeatedly stamped by machinery and then cut with a laser welding torch. The driver was not in the car. No one ever saw him again; he vanished from the world." Schneider spoke slowly. "That driver was Chu Zihang's biological father."

"No wonder the Board of Trustees didn't make Chu Zihang the commissioner..." Manstein understood at last. They had had no choice but to use Chu Zihang, yet they could not trust him.

Manstein turned and backed away step by step from the long table. "Schneider, I can't stop you from protecting your student, but I have nothing to do with this! You'll be punished under college regulations... no, under the Party's rules!"

He chaired the Disciplinary Committee and oversaw college discipline, but above college rules stood the rules of the Secret Party. Those rules derived from an ancient alchemical scroll, the Abraham Bloodline Covenant, a harsh code handed down from the Middle Ages. Schneider had violated the Council of Elders' secrets, an offense approaching treason in its gravity.

"No, this concerns you." Without looking up, Schneider handed Manstein an envelope he had prepared in advance. "See for yourself."

Manstein opened the envelope. Inside were student dossiers, each bearing a special red wax seal. The words on the seals read: "Nibelungen Project."

"Nibelungen?" Manstein had heard of this mythical "realm of the dead," but he did not see what it had to do with him.

Then his face changed. Turning through several dossiers, he saw the name Chen Motong.

"Why are you flipping through so fast? I saw Lu Mingfei..." Guderian craned his neck to look too.

"What does this mean?" Manstein asked quietly.

"The Nibelungen Project is a bloodline screening program led by the Board of Trustees. Officially, they select elites from students of A-rank or higher for special training. In fact, they have another purpose: to purge suspicious bloodlines among us. These students are all considered to have questionable bloodlines, including your student Chen Motong." Schneider pointed at Guderian. "And your student Lu Mingfei. Now, my old friends, do you still say this has nothing to do with you?"

"That can't be right. If we're talking about suspicious bloodlines, isn't your student Chu Zihang the most questionable of all? But Chu Zihang isn't in here?" Guderian said.

"Easy to understand," Manstein said quietly. "He's Chu Zihang's adviser. Even if Chu Zihang is under suspicion, his dossier wouldn't be sent to him. The people he's asked to investigate must have no connection to him." He already believed Schneider.

"What could be wrong with them? Aren't they all good students, excellent in conduct and academics?" Guderian was bewildered.

"Did you investigate them?" Manstein asked.

"The Board's orders must be carried out. I've already submitted my report. I gathered a little information and wrote something up. I said there was nothing suspicious about their bloodlines, but my conclusion may not be accepted," Schneider said calmly. "The two most unusual are Lu Mingfei and Chen Motong. They resonate with Draconic, but have no Yanling. Lu Mingfei in particular is the only S-rank student. In other words, his rank is as high as a trustee's, yet he has no Yanling. Anyone could easily grow suspicious of him."

"What exactly defines a suspicious bloodline?" Manstein asked.

"An excessive proportion of dragon blood. Generally, we believe that if a hybrid's dragon blood exceeds their human blood, they are closer to a dragon than a human. They are no longer one of us. But dragon blood can also be genetically recessive, and those recessive genes may awaken slowly. That can cause a hybrid to become progressively more dragonlike. Once they cross the fifty-percent threshold, they become the enemy," Schneider said. "The Dragon King Norton is a classic example. He was a pureblood dragon, but before his awakening he believed himself to be a human orphan."

"Is there any laboratory method now for measuring the genetic proportions?"

"No. We have to rely on analyzing their behavior. So you understand why the Board paid such a high price to steal this archive, and why the recovery operation was assigned such a high priority. Among the students investigated under the Nibelungen Project, Lu Mingfei, Chen Motong, and very likely Chu Zihang all come from China."

"They're looking into their family histories," Manstein said quietly.

"Mingfei... can't be a problem. How could he be dangerous? He's a complete coward!" Guderian stammered.

"Haven't you always said your student is inspiration from head to toe?" Manstein pushed him aside and looked at Schneider. "If the Board considers their bloodlines dangerous... what happens?"

"You know how the Board operates as well as I do." Schneider stopped what he was doing and looked up at Manstein, his iron-gray eyes filled with a bone-deep chill.

Manstein took a deep breath. "The iron-fist rule... purge them!"

"Kill... kill them?" Guderian's voice trembled. "Surely that isn't necessary... Couldn't we buy a little island in the Pacific, build a villa, send them there, and deliver supplies regularly?"

"A lifelong vacation in Hawaii? With treatment that good, I'd want a dangerous bloodline too," Manstein said with a bitter smile. "But do you think the Board is a group of philanthropists?"

"They wouldn't kill them, but historically they used lobotomy to purge people whose bloodlines were dangerous," Schneider said.

"What does that mean? I haven't studied brain science." Guderian stared.

Schneider hesitated. He did not want to bring up this history, but the Secret Party had endured for thousands of years, from the ancient age of blood sacrifice through the dark Middle Ages and the radical industrial era into modern society. Its history could not possibly conform entirely to today's moral standards.

"It's a form of brain surgery invented by António Egas Moniz, a Portuguese physician. Studying ancient Egyptian skulls, he found holes drilled into them and concluded the Egyptians had used brain surgery to treat epilepsy. He developed his theory and believed that removing white matter from the brain's lobes could treat all kinds of mental illness, including such unwelcome states as depression, agitation, anxiety, and paranoia. From 1930 to 1950, tens of thousands of these operations were performed worldwide. The patients really did become more docile and easier to control afterward, but often they sat in one place all day muttering to themselves like fools. He won the Nobel Prize in Medicine for it," Manstein said. "It's one of the most absurd Nobel Prizes in history, because the doctor completely misunderstood why the Egyptians performed the operation. In the age of the pharaohs, it was used to control hybrids. Removing the lobes also severed the 'spiritual resonance' most essential to their dragon blood."

"The Council of Elders knew what the operation did, so they sent suspected hybrids to psychiatric hospitals..." Schneider said. "They also paid to promote its supposed benefits around the world."

"Damn..." Guderian murmured.

"By now you should both understand. Some people at the college are suspected of being dangerous, and we are their advisers. If something happens to them, we'll have to bear some of the consequences too, so we need to take action." Schneider struck a match and set fire to the sheet about Chu Zihang. Amid choking smoke, the film slowly melted in the ashtray.

"Let me borrow a match," Guderian said.

"Don't bother. There's nothing in the film about Lu Mingfei. The Executive Department investigated his past; it was utterly ordinary. His first eighteen years were so normal they seemed like a failure. You might even suspect he had no bloodline at all and was admitted by mistake." Schneider shrugged.

"A genius must have something that sets him apart!" Guderian breathed a sigh of relief.

Another match struck. Both men turned to see Manstein expressionlessly lighting a different sheet of film.

"Mr. Chairman of the Disciplinary Committee, that's not your usual style," Schneider said with a cold smile. "Aren't you the one who values college rules and the Board's orders above all else?"

Manstein did not answer. He watched impassively as the sheet turned to ash in the tray.

Guderian saw the light. "Is it because of her mother? You were secretly in love with her mother back then, weren't you? You're an extraordinary man of loyalty and feeling." He was delighted, as if he had discovered a new continent, and used a new expression he had recently learned.

"Damn it! Nothing of the sort!" Manstein wanted to smash the ashtray into his face.

Schneider deftly gathered the remaining film, stuffed it back into the aluminum case, and clicked on a new lock he had prepared earlier. He let out a long breath and looked at Guderian and Manstein. "There. It's done. We're accomplices now. We should have a drink together."

"Wait! You destroyed the paper envelope with the Board's seal. That's too obvious!" Manstein said sharply.

"Simple. The hunters stole these documents, so they must have taken some of the contents." Schneider was confident. "That's what happened. Entirely reasonable."

"Some hunters with low-purity bloodlines—why would they meddle in our affairs? If someone hired them in secret, why would they open the documents? They're only people taking commissions to earn a little money." Manstein frowned. "They had no reason to do that."

"They're bad people." Schneider shrugged. "Bad people can do anything. They don't need a reason."

"Your logic is just like the Executive Department's methods... crude and direct..." Manstein murmured.

A gentle knock sounded at the door. The three exchanged quick glances. Schneider sprang up, grabbed the ashtray, dumped it into the wastebasket, and poured in a can of Coke. Guderian threw a thick dictionary on top, smothering the wisps of smoke. Manstein quickly rearranged his face into the stern integrity expected of the chairman of the Disciplinary Committee. He went to the door and opened it. Outside stood a smiling young man, his long golden hair covering half his remarkably delicate face.

He held out his hand. "Hello, Professor Manstein? I'm Parsi, secretary to the Board of Trustees. I've been sent to collect a case."

He looked into the central control room. An aluminum case sat on the long table. The imposing, cold-faced Professor Schneider of the Executive Department and Professor Guderian, whistling in apparent boredom, both seemed delighted to see him and waved. "Hi!"

"Damn it! Does he really have to whistle to show he has nothing to hide?" Manstein cursed inwardly.

Act Seven

The Feast of Dragons

Dragons'Feast

He slowly raised the lid, his voice full of mysterious enticement. "A weapon out of legend... a set of alchemical blades!"

A sharp, dark-golden light flowed through the widening gap. Lu Mingfei froze. Suddenly he felt that the thing inside the case was alive; he could hear a familiar breathing sound coming from within.

The lid opened. Alchemical blades? The Seven Deadly Sins! It was like meeting an old friend again.

Lu Mingfei opened his sleepy eyes. The room was silent. He turned his head. The sheet where Chu Zihang had slept was perfectly smooth, without so much as a depression, while Xia Mi's blanket was neatly folded, as though it had never been opened.

"Some friends," he muttered.

Had those two gone out to have fun first thing in the morning without even telling him? He stared at the ceiling for a while, then wondered whether Xia Mi might have a thing for Chu Zihang. Come to think of it, the beautiful freshman and the expressionless senior admired by everyone yet always single did make a good match. They even had common ground academically, which was to say neither of them spoke like a normal human being. Still, it wouldn't have hurt to take him along. He might always be a third wheel, but he was a considerate one: a good light bulb that didn't flash at random, just cast a warm glow on the couple beside him.

It was so quiet, as though he were the only person left in the world.

Lu Mingfei suddenly felt strange, uncertain where he was. There was no evidence that he was still dreaming or had woken up. On a morning like this, waking alone in an unfamiliar place was itself like a dream, wasn't it?

He had always had a weak presence, but never felt so unmoored. Lying on the soft bed, he seemed to float in the air. Aunt must really be angry this time. Would he go back to Uncle's next summer? If he did, Aunt would glare at him again. But if he didn't, where could he go? Stay on an empty campus? Everyone else would go home for summer vacation, leaving him all alone. Without Chu Zihang, Caesar, Nono, Xia Mi, and Fingel, he really was on his own. Was this what they called blood sorrow? Or the loneliness the devil version of Lu Mingze spoke about?

Thinking of Lu Mingze, he paused. Then he understood.

"Breakfast!" He clapped imperiously.

The door opened, and Lu Mingze pushed in a gleaming silver food cart. He was not much taller than the cart, but wore a proper white chef's uniform and a tall French chef's hat.

"I've just woken up and I'm terribly tired. His Majesty will dine in bed. Bring it over." Lu Mingfei put on a grand air, reclining against his pillows like a French noblewoman awakened from a springtime nap.

"Caviar with freshly toasted whole-wheat bread, raisin Danish pastry, chicken breast sautéed with lemon juice, and grilled Munich white sausage." Lu Mingze spoke with the exacting attentiveness of a butler. "To drink, would you prefer coffee, milk and cereal, or kiwi juice?"

"That's all? His Majesty's favorites are fried dough sticks and soft tofu pudding!"

"No problem." Lu Mingze lifted the silver cloche to reveal a set of white Chinese porcelain, four perfectly fried dough sticks, two bowls of silky soft tofu pudding, and several side dishes: Gaoyou salted duck eggs, Jinhua ham, Hangzhou vegetarian chicken, and Wangzhihe fermented tofu in chili oil.

As for the caviar, Danish pastry, chicken breast, and grilled sausage he had just mentioned, there was no sign of any of them.

"Are you messing with me? Four fried dough sticks and two bowls of tofu pudding, and you pretend to be a French chef?" That was what Lu Mingfei said, but he was happy. Once he returned to Cassell College he would have nothing but German food: endless sausages, sauerkraut, and pork knuckles.

"Our customer service is first-rate. A magic breakfast: if French breakfast had been what you wanted, that's exactly what you'd have found under the cover." Lu Mingze sat on the edge of the bed. "You only get two dough sticks and one bowl of tofu pudding. The other half is mine."

Lu Mingfei hesitated. "Am I eating in a dream? In reality, am I chewing on toads and drinking foot-washing water? It happens in Journey to the West: the White Bone Demon turns into a village girl bringing food, but the food is really toads, clods of dirt, and broken roof tiles."

"Of course not. You're a customer, and customers are the greatest. We devils always treat our customers well. We're businesspeople! Hard work brings prosperity!" Lu Mingze lifted a bowl of tofu pudding, blew on it, and took a sip. "Satisfied?"

"Satisfied, my foot! You've got too many tricks. I can't beat you, so I give up!" Unable to resist the fragrance of the fried dough, Lu Mingfei grabbed a stick and took a bite. It was superb, crisp and rich with oil. Even if it turned out to be a toad in the real world, he would accept it.

"Get to the point. I didn't summon you this time, so don't put it on my account," Lu Mingfei mumbled. A big spoonful of tofu pudding brought a hint of heat, and it tasted exactly like the breakfast stall outside his uncle's home.

Tofu pudding like this was reason enough to keep muddling through this lonely world!

"Of course. That was settled when we made the contract." Lu Mingze sounded magnanimous. "Something's going to happen today. I came especially to let you know, so you don't make a mistake."

"Something's going to happen?" Lu Mingfei frowned and picked up a piece of vegetarian chicken with his chopsticks.

"You have an important event coming up that will require money. I know you're a poor dog, so I'm going to lend you some."

"No!" Lu Mingfei refused without hesitation.

"No?" Lu Mingze was surprised.

"Borrow money from you? That means asking you for help, doesn't it? Asking you costs me part of my life. No deal! I don't need money for anything. If kidnappers came after me, I'd be better off summoning you to knock them all down. That would cost the same quarter of my life."

"It's a complimentary gift for a customer. No charge."

"You? So kind?" Lu Mingfei eyed Lu Mingze sideways.

"Me." Lu Mingze smiled. On the little devil's face, the innocent smile was like green leaves in the morning light. Even knowing how full of wicked schemes he was, you couldn't hate him when he smiled like that.

"In this whole world, I'm the only one who's always of one mind with you. Because... you're my brother." He actually reached out and gently touched Lu Mingfei's forehead.

"What are you touching me for? You've smeared chili oil on my face!" Lu Mingfei shouted.

But the instant Lu Mingze's hand touched his forehead, he felt an indescribable warmth. It was not merely the warmth of a hand that had held a bowl of tofu pudding; a tangible current of warmth flowed from Lu Mingze's palm into his body. The simple, natural touch felt as though it had happened thousands, tens of thousands of times in dreams: a hand touching his forehead, saying... Brother.

Looking back, this sneaky big boy had never harmed him once. Whenever he was at the end of his rope, with no answer from heaven or earth, and Caesar, Nono, and Chu Zihang could do nothing to help, only this devil version of Lu Mingze had stayed by his side. As long as he was willing to make a deal, Lu Mingze would help him, like the person closest to him in the whole world.

"This time's temporary Yanling is 'show me the money.' In StarCraft, entering that cheat code gives you ten thousand minerals and gas. This Yanling adds ten thousand US dollars to your assets, and you can use it repeatedly." Lu Mingze withdrew his hand.

"I reward my customers so often. Couldn't you summon me for something important once in a while?" He jumped off the bed and walked softly to the door, then turned back. "But I expect you will soon. Danger isn't far away. Stay alert and keep that phone with you at all times. Text me if anything happens. Oh, and someone left a note for you at the front desk. I brought it up on my way. It's on the cart."

He closed the door behind him.

The lock clicked shut. Lu Mingfei gave a start, and everything returned to normal.

It was still the same hotel room, with the same warm morning light coming through the sheer white curtains, but the details had changed. A depression where Chu Zihang had slept appeared beside Lu Mingfei; the blanket on Xia Mi's bed was a mess, not folded at all. Orange peels lay scattered on the table. Xia Mi's white cotton pajamas hung over the back of a chair, with a yellow sticky note attached: "Senior Mingfei, we had to go out on an errand. We ordered you a Chinese breakfast: fried dough sticks and tofu pudding." A cat's head was drawn in place of a signature. Xia Mi actually signed with a cat's head.

With those subtle changes, the dreamlike feeling, the sense of being a stranger to the world, vanished.

The food cart was still there. Soft, white tofu pudding remained in the bowl, sprinkled with fragrant chili-sesame oil, shreds of preserved mustard greens, shrimp, sesame, and dark vinegar. Half a fried dough stick lay on the plate, still steaming. This time Lu Mingze really hadn't tricked him.

Suddenly he felt like crying, though he didn't know why... and he also wanted to sneeze...

Lu Mingfei drew a deep breath and let out an earth-shaking sneeze, tears streaming down his face. If the tears had come from grief, his sorrow must have been as vast as the sea. But they didn't. They came from a streak of red sauce spread on the dough stick.

Blazingly hot bird's-eye chili sauce!

"Damn you! Who eats fried dough sticks with bird's-eye chili sauce? Lu Mingze, you're vicious!" Lu Mingfei wiped away his tears and imagined he could hear the sly little devil laughing triumphantly after going out the door.

"If I ever trust him again, I'm his son!" Lu Mingfei swore inwardly as he came out of the bathroom, wiping his mouth. Lu Mingze had spread the chili sauce as thickly as peanut butter. He had spent ten minutes frantically rinsing his mouth with cold water.

"If breakfast was a prank... then the money-making Yanling probably can't be trusted either, right?" Lu Mingfei thought. Besides, how was he supposed to use it? Shout "show me the money" into the air and have a courier deliver a package of cash? It could supposedly be used repeatedly. If he shouted it a hundred times, that would be a million dollars. Would an armored truck pull up outside the hotel?

A pale-yellow envelope lay on the food cart. In beautiful script it was addressed to "Ricardo M. Lu."

"Dear Ricardo:

This is a mission notice. Please go downstairs immediately upon receiving it. A black Maserati sedan will be waiting outside the hotel, with Illinois license plate 'CAS001.' The person in the car will explain the details of the mission."

The letter was printed on Hyatt stationery. If not for the seal at the bottom, Lu Mingfei would have assumed it was another of Lu Mingze's pranks. The security emblem was used exclusively by Cassell College; the last time he had seen one was on his disastrous transcript.

Lu Mingfei ran out of the hotel and immediately spotted the black Maserati parked at the curb.

It was a prestigious car sold alongside Ferraris. The long hood curved sharply, like a shark leaping from the water, while privacy glass blocked any view inside. Definitely a stylish toy. Lu Mingfei craned his neck, trying to see who was in it. He had heard the Executive Department paid very well, but who could be wealthy enough to drive a Maserati on a mission?

A tailored black suit? Gleaming Italian leather shoes? Hair so heavily oiled it could serve as a mirror? Dragons must be a terribly conceited race, if even their hybrid descendants loved showing off so much. Nine out of ten men and women at the college put on aristocratic airs. Even Chu Zihang drove a Panamera on official business. Or was it a beautiful woman? A qipao slit all the way to the top of the thigh, slender high heels, long waves of hair? No, that outfit belonged exclusively to female Nationalist spies... Lu Mingfei's imagination ran wild.

The car door popped open automatically and nearly hit him in the head. He ducked inside.

A tailored black suit, gleaming Italian leather shoes, hair oiled to a mirror shine, and a vivid red rose on the chest. If the man hadn't had a head of silver hair, he'd have looked like a thoroughgoing lecher! Add the silver hair and he was... an old lecher!

"P-Pr... Principal!" Lu Mingfei stammered.

"Hello, Mingfei. Let's work together wholeheartedly on this mission." Anjou smiled and raised his glass. The old man clearly knew how to enjoy life. A lilting aria played on the stereo; the slot that

should have held a Coke contained a bottle of ice wine instead. The sunroof stood open overhead, and delicate curls of cigar smoke drifted upward.

"You... got stranded in Chicago by the strike too?" Lu Mingfei felt a small, involuntary thrill. He wasn't the only unlucky one.

"You could say that, although I planned to stay here for two days anyway to attend an auction." Anjou handed him a beautifully printed brochure. "Sotheby's, one of the world's finest auction houses, is an important marketplace for art."

Lu Mingfei was bewildered. An auction? That was something rich young masters like Caesar played at. What did it have to do with him? The college's mission... could they be going to rob the auction house? Possible! The Executive Department was hardly made up of saints; they seemed to have broken plenty of laws and rules. Maybe the sports car was for a fast getaway. But if they really were robbing an auction house, shouldn't they send someone tough like Chu Zihang? Instead they were sending a man who was actually over a hundred years old with a novice? Granted, the old man's Yanling and fighting skills seemed no worse than a young man's, but what if a stray bullet happened to take out the principal...

He leafed through the brochure. China really had prospered: it was printed in Chinese too. A Qing Qianlong doucai tripod dish in the form of a mallow flower with floral motifs... a Song blue-and-white, underglaze-red high-necked vase with a low-relief design of the Music of the Prince of Qin Breaking the Battle Formation... a great Nanyang Dushan jade vessel depicting Vairocana Buddha with lowered hands... The elaborate names bloomed one after another, with startling prices beneath them.

"The items in the brochure aren't what interest us." Anjou waved his cigar. "This is a restricted auction: an auction of objects that the law permits to circulate only within certain limits, so only clients of particular standing are invited. But objects offered at such auctions often have obscure origins, and even major auction houses don't dare publicize them. They invite only discreet, trustworthy clients. In 2003 Sotheby's tried to auction six pottery figures from the tomb of Empress Dou of the Western Han. They were stolen relics, and it caused quite a stir. Since then, certain interesting objects haven't been printed in promotional materials. You have to attend in person to see what's revealed."

"So... we really are going there to bid?" Lu Mingfei relaxed. Watching Anjou wave his cigar, he had kept imagining the old man pulling a loaded Colt pistol out of the glove compartment, tossing it to him, and saying, "Today's job is up to the two of us!"

"Of course." Anjou looked surprised. "One goes to an auction to bid on things."

"Good, good. Please go on, Principal." Lu Mingfei nodded vigorously.

"Restricted auctions are where the college hunts for treasures. We often find obscure pieces. For example, we once paid less than four hundred thousand dollars for a brass blowtorch of unknown age. Do you know the kind?" Anjou gestured with both hands. "An alcohol blowtorch like chemists used in the century before last."

"I've seen one. Only the teacher was allowed to use it in high-school lab. It's like a little flamethrower."

"Quite right. Now imagine turning the blowtorch sideways..."

"Then... it's a flamethrower!" Lu Mingfei understood.

"Exactly! It wasn't an alcohol blowtorch at all, but a weapon made by a nineteenth-century alchemical technician. They usually called such things 'dragon's breath.' The fuel wasn't alcohol, but refined mercury-bearing nitroglycerin."

"Nitroglycerin... isn't that an explosive?"

"Correct. An explosive. It could project a cone of flame twenty meters long, with an explosive effect, while releasing enormous quantities of mercury vapor. A powerful weapon against dragons." Anjou nodded. "That's why I say it's a place to find treasures."

"And I'm going because..."

"You'll play a buyer new to the trade. There's an item we want you to bid on for us." Anjou handed him a wireless earpiece. "It's simple. Just follow my instructions. But remember, at the auction you and I don't know each other."

"I don't think I'm suitable... I don't know anything about auctions..." Lu Mingfei lost his nerve.

"That doesn't matter. The college will create all kinds of opportunities for you to learn." Anjou drew deeply on his cigar and was silent for several seconds. "You're the only S-rank student at the college now. You have a great deal to learn. While the Night Watcher and I can still protect this school, you must learn as quickly as you can... There's not much time."

"Not... much time?" Lu Mingfei heard a deep loneliness in the old man's words.

"At my age, how much longer do you think I can live?" Anjou shrugged. "I was among the earliest members of the Lionheart Society. Of course, if you'd lived through the entire twentieth century, you wouldn't care much about whether you died either."

"And yet... you smoke so much..." Lu Mingfei stammered. He had never imagined that someone as formidable as the principal could die. To any Cassell student, the principal and the Night Watcher were the foundations of the school. An old man who had lived 130 years and could still leap like a tiger with a folding knife and stab a Dragon King through the head was practically an ancient monster! And weren't ancient monsters supposed to live for a thousand years? Hearing one speak about a subject as serious as death was both funny and sad.

"The advantage of dragon genes is that most of us will never get cancer. Many fatal diseases leave us alone. If I die one day, it will be because every part of me has worn out... or because a Dragon King's Yanling blows my head apart." The old man casually flicked the cigar butt through the sunroof, gripped the wheel with one hand, and floored the accelerator.

The dangerous shark roared away, ignoring the changing traffic light and plunging into the stream of cars. Several vehicles behind it braked in panic, blocking the entire intersection at crooked angles.

"Hey, hey, hey!" Lu Mingfei hadn't even had time to fasten his seat belt and could only cling desperately to the handhold. The acceleration that car magazines praised so highly was torture now, like an immense force pinning him to the seat.

These Cassell College lunatics! No wonder the old saying went that when the upper beam was crooked, the lower ones would lean too. Compared with this, Chu Zihang merely reversed at sixty kilometers an hour. What a law-abiding driver!

Anjou drained his glass of ice wine with pleasure and kept accelerating. Evidently the old man drove fast as a matter of course.

Ice wine? Wait, no. Ice wine had no business here, did it? They were already going 120 kilometers an hour, and the old man driving had a stemmed glass in his hand? This was too much excitement. Lu Mingfei's head buzzed.

"Principal... driving after drinking, in China..." Lu Mingfei swallowed hard. "They revoke your license for that!"

"Same in America." Anjou shrugged. "But do you think they'd renew a license for a 130-year-old man? When I learned to drive, there was no such thing as a driver's license. That was 1899... yes, 1899. Cars had only been invented in 1885, a new toy that couldn't outrun a carriage yet. No Ford, no General Motors, no traffic rules at all!"

"Principal, you've... been driving without a license for over a hundred years?" Lu Mingfei's heart nearly leaped into his throat. A moment ago, passing another car, he'd been sure they would crash; the gap was so narrow it was like two Japanese swordsmen crossing blades, their quick swords flashing past each other in midair. "Principal, I'm still young! I want to live a good long life!"

"That's right." Anjou smiled. "You're still young. But remember what I just told you? I don't know how much time I have left..."

"Hey, please! Could you stop accelerating when you change the subject?"

"I haven't changed it. I mean... as an old man with one foot in the grave who loves driving fast, what do I have left to lose?" Anjou switched the gear setting to that damned super-sport mode and let out a whoop that would have sent a teenage girl's hormones racing.

The Maserati slowed and stopped at the curb.

"Ready? The mission is about to begin. Remember your identity? You're Lu Mingfei, an art enthusiast from China..." Anjou handed him a cigar sealed in an aluminum tube.

"I've memorized it. I'm Lu Mingfei, a nouveau riche bumpkin who's fallen for a girl at art school and wants to cultivate some artistic taste... Damn it, I've finally made it to an amazing auction, and I'm going to pick up some good stuff for my mansion with the water feature! I don't know how to smoke fancy things like cigars. I don't smoke cigarettes either." The mission plan had included his cover story, which Lu Mingfei now knew backward. He imagined himself an actor, trying hard to get into character.

"You don't have to know how. Just hold it in your mouth and draw. You're attending an auction; you need an expensive habit or two to show your worth. This is a Cuban cigar, fifty dollars apiece!"

"Very nouveau riche." Lu Mingfei held the cigar in his mouth like a grilled sausage.

"That's why I chose you instead of Chu Zihang or Caesar. You're better at playing a nouveau riche upstart."

"True. I'm a bumpkin."

Anjou handed him an envelope. "Your invitation is inside. Keep it safe. You need a two-million-dollar deposit in your account. Norma opened an account for you at a bank in Zurich and deposited two million."

"Wow! Two million!" Lu Mingfei imagined that if he looked in a mirror, dollar signs would be rolling across his wide-open eyes.

"It's mission funding. It will be withdrawn from your account afterward."

"I don't care if it lasts forever; I only care that I have it today." The ridiculous line rolled out of Lu Mingfei's mouth without passing through his brain. "But Principal, you're such a tasteful man, and clearly rich. Why not bid for it yourself?"

"An auction is a psychological game. Especially with rarities seldom seen on the market: no one can assess their value at once, and psychology becomes particularly important. An artwork's price depends on how many people want it. The more bidders, the higher the price rises. If an experienced buyer bids aggressively, many will follow, driving it up. And I am an experienced buyer. Almost everyone there knows me."

"So if you raise your paddle, it tells them the thing is valuable?" Lu Mingfei nodded. "In plain language, I'm a plant."

Anjou gave him a thumbs-up. "Exactly, you're a plant! I'll bid on a few small things for appearances, but I won't raise my paddle for the real target. I want it to seem an obscure item no one cares about. You will bid, and everyone will think that new rich upstart is spending his money on something useless, while you get it cheaply."

"Understood!" Lu Mingfei said. "By the way, Principal, do you know where Chu Zihang went? We also met a freshman named Xia Mi yesterday. We shared a room last night, and when I woke up they were both gone."

"Norma arranged another assignment for Chu Zihang. He's showing Xia Mi around Chicago and giving her pre-enrollment orientation at the same time. Usually a professor would do it, but since we have an extra seven days, we should make good use of them." Anjou thought for a moment. "I believe they went to Six Flags, the roller-coaster park."

"No way! I've never been to Six Flags either... I want to take a pretty junior on a roller coaster too!" Lu Mingfei failed to stop himself; his true feelings spilled out.

Anjou stared for a moment, then said awkwardly, "I'm the principal. I'm more important than a pretty junior... Students would firmly turn down a date just to have afternoon tea with me..."

"At your age, why are you competing with a girl for attention?" Lu Mingfei shrugged.

"Get out!"

"Hey... is this about a man's pride? Isn't that a bit much?" Lu Mingfei stared wide-eyed.

"You're a plant. Naturally you can't appear with me. Someone will pick you up here shortly. Remember to change: a full Armani outfit, the brand all wealthy Chinese bumpkins love. Walk with your chest out. You're a man coming here to spend two million dollars; look down on everything. Don't overestimate those well-dressed Sotheby's auctioneers. They're just people earning a commission." Anjou clapped him hard on the shoulder. "You failed two courses last semester..."

"Hey, Principal, that's unfair. Don't bring up a sore subject... How am I supposed to act arrogant when you remind me of that?" Lu Mingfei made a miserable face, and the cigar fell from his mouth onto the seat.

"I mean that as principal I have the authority to give you extra credit. If you perform this assignment beautifully, I'll give you passing grades." Anjou held out his hand. "Deal?"

"You can do that? Deal!" Lu Mingfei's fighting spirit blazed at once, and he seized Anjou's hand.

"I told you hanging around the principal had a brighter future than hanging around a pretty junior..."

"...You're not still bothered by what I said, are you?"

"Of course not. I'm always magnanimous..." Anjou took out a jet lighter and lit the thick cigar for Lu Mingfei. "Now smoke your Cohiba, wear your Armani suit, and go do battle in the arena of wealth, our young Chinese millionaire!"

The car door flew open. The principal lifted a foot and kicked the stunned Lu Mingfei out. The Maserati sped away in a cloud of dust.

"Hey! So violent? You really were embarrassed and angry, weren't you?" The young upstart Lu Mingfei pounded the pavement and shouted after the disappearing car.

His stomach gave an unhelpful rumble, wiping away his anger. Only then did he remember he'd eaten just half his breakfast. He got up helplessly, dusted himself off, and rolled his eyes toward the sky. It was clear and freshly washed, and a white-winged gull that had strayed from Lake Michigan into the human city glided among the skyscrapers.

Pennsylvania Avenue was a small road hidden in the busy downtown district, with the towering gray walls of skyscrapers on either side. The buildings dated from Chicago's most luxurious metropolitan era, the 1950s. Over the years their limestone surfaces had flaked away, giving them the forlorn air of fallen nobility. The tall buildings blocked out all sunlight, leaving a chill in the long, narrow street. At the end stood a massive square building, its high walls windowless except for a row of large ventilation fans turning slowly near the top.

The Chicago Civic Opera House.

It had once been a gathering place for celebrities. Sixty years ago, every night brought luxury cars and fashionable women. Courteous gentlemen escorted young companions to enjoy refined music, while attendants called out the names of distinguished guests.

But its glory had faded. Young people now went on dates to movie theaters or shopping centers downtown. The opera house belonged to the splendor of another age.

Today it had awakened again. A succession of luxury cars stopped at the entrance, red taillights flashing one after another. Heavy doors opened, and men in black tailcoats or evening suits stepped out, all wearing white embroidered shirts and metropolitan side parts slicked with enough oil to shine like mirrors. Hands in long white velvet gloves emerged from the cars, silver watches worn outside the gloves. The men took those hands and lightly helped out fashionable women wrapped in mink and veils, slender heels touching the pavement, calves drawn into graceful curves. White steam rose from sewer grates, and the men and women walking arm in arm toward the opera house formed a picture of Chicago in the golden age of 1950.

Outside the Civic Opera House that day, time seemed to have flowed backward sixty years.

A black Lincoln sedan drew slowly to the entrance. Its old-fashioned grandeur caught an attendant's eye, and he hurried down the steps. The window lowered, and a young, long-fingered hand with prominent joints held out a dark-red invitation.

"Mr. Ricardo M. Lu!" the attendant called the unfamiliar name as though welcoming a well-known count.

The driver got out, his back perfectly straight, dressed in black with gold-plated buttons. He respectfully opened the rear door. A young man with pale-gold hair emerged and swept a cool gaze over the passing guests. His upright figure stood in the wind like a spear planted in the ground. He put

on black sunglasses, hiding his handsome face, and pulled back his striped shirt cuff to glance at a fine IWC watch.

"This way, Mr. Lu. The auction is about to begin." The attendant bowed to the young guest of honor.

The guest waved him away coolly, turned, and went to a silver extended Bentley behind the Lincoln. Bending slightly, he opened its door. "This way, Mr. Lu."

The flamboyant display shocked every passing guest. So this imposing young man was... the one who opened the car door!

This time the first thing to appear was a thick Cohiba cigar, then an expensive custom Armani suit, then a snow-white lace cravat, then polished Ferragamo shoes. Surprise spread over every face as the honored guest finally emerged in full. He drew a breath, thrust out his chest, and looked down on the assembled company, a brown Burberry trench coat draped over his shoulders. He took a deep drag on the cigar...

Then erupted in violent coughing. The blond young man hurried over to pat his back. Around them came a ripple of snickers of uncertain meaning.

"Damn it!" Lu Mingfei cursed inwardly. There was nothing wrong with this outfit. What were they laughing at? He'd only choked on the cigar! Besides, hadn't his entrance imitating Mark Gor been impressive?

"They're laughing because you've put on every fashionable designer label at once. Your taste is too mixed. Ignore them. That's your assigned role." Anjou's low voice sounded in his ear. In his nervousness, Lu Mingfei had almost forgotten the wireless earpiece.

"What kind of lousy role is this..." A tiny microphone was hidden beside Lu Mingfei's jaw.

"Whatever you see, don't show surprise. Just follow along." Anjou was hidden somewhere out of sight.

Lu Mingfei followed the attendant through a dim passage, perfume drifting faintly in the air. The glints came from silver powder on the fashionable women's bare shoulders. The luxurious, unreal surroundings made him a little dizzy. Then the space ahead brightened.

Suddenly he emerged into a vast open space, as if golden light were shining from every direction.

The opera house spread out before him, a wave of splendor washing over him. Towering columns all around resembled the ruins of the Parthenon on the Acropolis, but painted a magnificent dark red. Beneath the domed ceiling, enormous crystal chandeliers banished every shadow. The dome and walls, golden in the light, were painted with the battles of Ragnarök. A wool carpet bore green mandala designs; brass plates marked the numbers on red velvet seats. A scarlet curtain hung over the stage, as though drawing it back would reveal a tragedy by some ancient Greek master.

He didn't have enough eyes to take it all in and didn't know where to look. Amid the endless crowd, he felt lost.

He found his seat, but not Anjou. Guests settled into the surrounding seats, exchanging brief greetings as though they all knew one another. The opera house was not very large, but all several hundred seats were occupied.

The lights went out one by one until only the huge branching chandelier in the center of the dome remained lit. As if a performance were about to begin, white-clad attendants passed through the aisles

ringing a string of bells, and the guests' conversations died down. The curtain trembled, and a man in a black tailcoat stepped out.

"Ladies and gentlemen, Sotheby's restricted auction, the 2010 Summer Chicago Cultural Journey sale, will begin in five minutes. I am your auctioneer. Please keep hold of your paddles and don't miss the things you desire, because every item we're about to offer is unique." He paused. "Now, night has fallen. Please close your eyes."

What was this? Lu Mingfei stared. Were they playing a murder game? Did they have to close their eyes at night and open them at dawn? The guests all closed their eyes and lowered their heads slightly.

"Day has broken. Please open your eyes!"

Everyone opened their eyes at once. For an instant it was as though the opera house had lit up again, but this time it was not crystal chandeliers illuminating the hall. It was hundreds of pairs of golden eyes!

Lu Mingfei felt his heart stop.

"Don't move or say anything. Don't look around," Anjou's voice sounded in his ear.

"But that's... that's... that's..." Lu Mingfei almost groaned.

"Yes, genuine golden eyes, every one. This isn't a masquerade. They're revealing their golden eyes to show their bloodlines. Everyone attending this auction is a hybrid, like you and me. This is..." Anjou paused. "A feast of dragons!"

Lu Mingfei was thankful there was still a chair beneath him. Otherwise he would have collapsed like an overcooked noodle and wet himself.

What kind of place was this? The hall was full of distinguished guests, every one a human-dragon hybrid! Gold cards, platinum cards, and black cards didn't signify status here. Everyone displayed golden eyes as proof of bloodline. But he... he was staring in terror, eyes almost popping out, red as a little white rabbit's.

A feast of dragons? A grand name for a bunch of half-dragons throwing a party in a dragon's den, right? There had to be a main course. Were these people vegetarians? He was the only little white rabbit here!

"May I get past?" a low, cool voice said beside him.

Lu Mingfei turned and sucked in a breath. A pair of golden eyes shone beside him like lamps. They belonged to a young man in his twenties who had arrived late. Before Lu Mingfei could look away, their eyes met. We're doomed! I've been exposed, he thought. If he'd known what kind of gathering this was, he should have brought gold cosmetic contacts. In this sea of golden eyes, he was like a green-eyed foreigner sitting in a Chang'an tavern at the height of the Tang dynasty. How could anyone fail to see he was different?

Sure enough, the man paused, and the light in his pupils grew fiercer, as if golden blades were gathering in his eyes.

Lu Mingfei went rigid. That piercing gaze! In an anime, it would surely come just before a devastating special attack!

"Very understated," the man said suddenly with an appreciative click of his tongue. The gold in his pupils dimmed slightly, and he held out a hand in friendship. "Romario Townsend. Call me Roma."

Understated, my ass! It's just that I can't make my eyes turn gold, brother! Lu Mingfei shook his hand nervously.

"Ever since auctions like this began, people have lit their golden eyes to show off the purity of their bloodlines and put pressure on others when they meet their gaze," Townsend said, sitting beside Lu Mingfei and lowering his voice. "Eventually everyone started doing it, and it turned into a masquerade. But it's hard not to follow the crowd. Bloodline is what matters here, as if without golden eyes yours won't even be recognized." Townsend scoffed. "I think your way is better: natural, relaxed. We're here for things we like, after all. Spending money should be fun. Keeping golden eyes lit for hours always leaves you exhausted afterward."

"Roma... you don't suspect I'm human?" Lu Mingfei ventured, thinking, Damn it, I am human, but please don't suspect it.

"How could you be?" Townsend dismissed the idea. "The screening here is strict. I haven't seen you before. New to the trade?"

"Oh, yes. My family's in building materials in China, and because I like..." Lu Mingfei hurriedly retrieved his cover story.

"The building materials business is very profitable in China!" Townsend exclaimed again. "My family's always been in construction too, but the golden age of North American construction is past. We can't possibly compete with Chinese real-estate developers."

"Oh, come on, you imperialist countries..."

"But I hear in China you can even withhold workers' wages. How can we compete with that?" Townsend spread his hands.

Damn it! Lu Mingfei cursed inwardly. Word about migrant workers' unpaid wages had reached Lake Michigan. What a disgrace to the nation!

"Don't say too much. The more you say, the more likely you are to make a mistake." Anjou's voice sounded in his ear. "Now it's time for a lesson from the principal himself."

"You've always thought Cassell College was the only place where hybrids gather? Let me correct that. It's only one of them. You come from China, Caesar from Italy, Chu Zihang from China, Zero from Russia... Hybrids are spread across different parts of the world. Through marriage, dragon blood has traveled to every corner. We don't know how many hybrids exist worldwide. Those selected for Cassell College are only a tiny fraction. The others have their own ways of life, but because of their bloodlines they are drawn to one another and form a hidden sub-society within human society. What you're seeing now is hybrid society. It has its own rules.

"Cassell College grew out of the Dragon Blood Secret Party, whose aim is to destroy all pureblood dragons. But not every hybrid shares that ideal. More of them remain outside the war. They hate dragons, but don't consider themselves on humanity's side either. They believe their bloodlines are superior to humans', and call themselves a 'third race' between humans and dragons. Because of their blood, they age more slowly than ordinary people, and their aesthetic tastes lag behind too. Some of these people may already have been active in the middle of the last century. The flamboyant style of old Chicago is still fashionable among them.

"Some of their families have lasted for thousands of years, accumulating astonishing wealth and power. But because their positions differ, they won't necessarily support us. In any case, this is hybrid

society: all kinds of people with all kinds of ideas, who need to communicate with one another. Auctions are one way they socialize. Do you remember what dragons' greatest obsession is said to be?"

"Stealing princesses?" How should I know, Lu Mingfei thought. Maybe you just like playing the villainous boss, kidnapping princesses in fairy tales and getting speared to death by knights.

"No. According to legend, dragons love collecting precious metals and gems, and sleep sprawled on gold," Anjou said. "There's a basis for that. Dragons developed alchemy, and alchemy is the pinnacle of craftsmanship. Dragons are often obsessed with art. Attila, king of the Huns, for instance, was buried sealed in three coffins of gold, silver, and iron, each elaborately carved and set with gems. Hybrids inherited this obsession. Half the top collectors are hybrids, though you won't find their names in collecting magazines."

"So they're artists too." Lu Mingfei calmed down a little. He was already in the dragon's pool and tiger's den, but he at least understood the words accept your fate.

"The paddle in your hand is number seventeen, your birthday. All you have to do is raise it and bid in the most leisurely way possible. Ordinarily the increments don't need to be high, but a powerful buyer can intimidate others through sheer presence. When you think you need to win in one stroke, don't be afraid to make a large jump bid. It shows you're determined to have the item. Anyone bidding against you may hesitate: if they continue, the price could be driven too high, and they won't want to pay it. And if you're a plant for the auction house or another seller, they'll have fallen for it."

"Presence is such an elusive thing..." Lu Mingfei whispered.

"Actually, in the way you young people put it..." Anjou chuckled. "Just act like a pompous badass."

"Our next lot is a Qing Qianlong yangcai gourd vase with brocade-ground decoration and a longevity-and-ruyi motif. This porcelain from the Qianlong reign of the Qing dynasty represents the height of the ceramic art of its time, made for the imperial household by the Imperial Workshops. It left China after the Boxer War of 1900. A similar piece sold in Hong Kong for 17.3 million dollars a few months ago." The auctioneer surveyed the room. "The opening bid is nine million dollars. Bids, please."

This was the sixth lot of the day, and the opening price had risen from two hundred thousand to nine million. Lu Mingfei had not raised his paddle once, because Anjou had not given the order. Anjou himself, however, had bid on and won the great Nanyang Dushan jade vessel depicting Vairocana Buddha with lowered hands. Seated in the VIP section up front, he bid while whispering to the graceful young married woman beside him, looking perfectly content.

Now that was a pompous badass: bleeding money by the bucket while acting as if cash meant nothing, as if he'd come only for the love of art and to flirt with women! Lu Mingfei was impressed.

As opening prices climbed, the circle of competition narrowed to the VIP section. The earlier little pieces had been appetizers; this gourd vase was the main course, and several parties were fighting fiercely for it.

Anjou bid a few times, but he seemed merely bored and interested in driving up the price for others. Once it passed twenty million he withdrew and began telling jokes that made the young woman smile behind pursed lips.

Lu Mingfei grew bored. There was nothing special about this auction except that the participants were all hybrids. Everyone followed the rules, and so far no one had lost a bid, flown into a rage, and

started blasting the others with Yanling. The game had gone beyond what he could play anyway: his mission budget was only two million.

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going once!"

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going twice! Last chance, please bid now."

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going three times! Sold!" The auctioneer brought down the hammer.

Polite applause filled the hall. The sale made a fine ending: the vase had been listed last in the catalog, the day's grand finale.

"Now for today's special segment, as always: 'An Unexpected Encounter.'" The auctioneer smiled.

Lu Mingfei looked up in surprise and saw Townsend's eyes brighten.

"What encounter?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"An Unexpected Encounter is a fun part of the evening." Townsend had taken a liking to him and explained patiently. "After the main auction ends, they offer some unconventional lots for amusement. Usually they're little things, but occasionally a superb piece fetches an astronomical price, or you can acquire something promising very cheaply. Recently someone bought an old Renaissance painting there. The brushwork was rather immature, the condition poor, and the signature belonged to one of Leonardo da Vinci's students. Insiders considered it an entry-level piece, so the hammer price was low. But when the buyer examined it under ultraviolet light, he found another painting beneath it: a genuine da Vinci, signature and all."

"He hit the jackpot!" Lu Mingfei said.

"Exactly. Once the top layer of paint was removed, the price increased fivefold! Oil painters in those days reused canvases, painting over old pictures, but who would have expected a student to cover up his teacher's work?"

"What incredible luck!" Lu Mingfei exclaimed.

"Your assignment today is a lot in An Unexpected Encounter. According to certain information, it's extremely important to us." Anjou's voice sounded in his ear. "Get it, whatever the cost."

Lu Mingfei started and came alert. Was it his turn to take the stage?

The auctioneer's assistant wheeled out a huge black hard-shell case. The auctioneer rested a white-gloved hand on the lid and smiled around the room without hurrying to open it. It was rather like an old street salesman hawking strength pills: before smashing a stone on his chest, he had to boast and build suspense.

"This is an extraordinary lot. Every auctioneer who saw it was astonished. It is exceptionally beautiful, the pinnacle of craftsmanship, but regrettably we know nothing of its provenance, not even its age, so we cannot set an appropriate opening price. With the seller's permission, this will be one of our rare zero-reserve auctions. Each increment may be as little as one dollar." The auctioneer raised one finger. "An opportunity not to be missed. Only... one dollar!"

A stir ran through the room. This was new and had aroused everyone's curiosity. The auctioneer was pleased with the atmosphere: the first step of his sales pitch had succeeded.

He slowly lifted the lid, his voice full of mysterious temptation. "Weapons out of myth... a set of alchemical blades!"

Sharp, dark-golden light flowed through the widening gap. Lu Mingfei froze. Suddenly he felt that the object in the case was alive; he could hear familiar breathing inside.

The lid opened. Alchemical blades? The Seven Deadly Sins! It was like meeting an old acquaintance again.

Lu Mingfei had used one of them to stab the Dragon King Norton to death, yet Norton himself had forged the weapons to slaughter dragons. Lu Mingfei had lost them in the Three Gorges Reservoir and never expected to see them again.

Someone was willing to sell a treasure on the level of a divine artifact? And it had fallen to an auction with a zero opening price? It was like an emperor getting so carried away selling offices that he began auctioning his own throne! Lu Mingfei was stunned.

"Familiar, isn't it? The Seven Deadly Sins. Both your report and Nono's said you'd found the set but lost it during the ascent." Anjou spoke with quiet admiration. "An alchemical creation beyond its age, of incalculable value!"

Lu Mingfei shivered silently. He knew its value. He had drawn only the shortest blade, yet the metal's roar had sounded like a dragon. Holding it meant holding the power over life and death. But he didn't like the set, and hadn't much regretted losing it, because of a shadow in his heart... Once these blades were grasped, killing would begin, and even the person holding them would have no choice.

Lu Mingfei had never been able to say whether the one he'd stabbed underwater was the Dragon King Norton or his friend Old Tang, who had taught him interview techniques.

Yet here it was again, like a restless ghost returning to haunt him.

"Superb workmanship, perfectly preserved, edges as sharp as new. Their forms imitate Chinese horse-chopping sabers, Tang sabers, Japanese swords, wakizashi, Damascus blades, and so on. They're housed in a single box opened by a concealed catch..." The auctioneer spoke eloquently.

Meanwhile assistants demonstrated quick cucumber slicing, cutting rolled bamboo mats, severing iron nails and metal sheets... Apparently the auction house had no way to explain the set's origins and could only demonstrate its sharpness. Lu Mingfei knew the style: Chinese TV shopping channels used the same enthusiasm to sell whitening or waist-slimming products.

"Replicas, surely? However well preserved, they couldn't be completely flawless," someone in the VIP seats objected. "They look like Swiss Army knives made this year!"

"As I said, we can't confirm their age or provenance, so the price depends entirely on your interest. In any case they're a fine set of blades; at the very least you can use them in the kitchen." The auctioneer shrugged and deflected the question with a joke.

"All right, one dollar!" Someone raised a paddle.

"Two dollars!" another followed immediately. The guests smiled indulgently.

"Three dollars!"

"Four dollars!"

The auctioneer looked embarrassed. The guests were teasing him. "Ladies and gentlemen, even a set of Damascus-steel kitchen knives costs hundreds of dollars. Might we have some competitive bids?" He spread his hands with a helpless smile.

"Certainly. Two hundred thousand."

The moment the voice came from the box on the right, every eye turned toward it. Besides the startling jump in price, there was that remarkable voice: no one could explain why such a casual woman's voice should be so enchanting. Behind a deep-red velvet curtain sat a young woman in an embroidered Islamic robe, holding paddle 88. A golden veil covered her entire face; only her lovely eyes were exposed, a trace of crimson at their corners. A bright red cord tied her high-styled hair.

She sat with her eyes lowered, yet looked like a queen presiding over the gathering.

"Two hundred and five thousand." After a few seconds, someone raised the bid.

This was no longer a joke. Someone clearly thought the set worth more.

"Two hundred and ten thousand!" Lu Mingfei raised his paddle. The principal had said they must have it, so this was unquestionably the time to act. It wasn't his money anyway.

"Three hundred thousand." Without hesitation, the veiled young woman raised her paddle again.

What magnificent bidding! Every raise was a leap, every leap measured in hundreds of thousands of dollars. Number 88 was clearly even more determined than Lu Mingfei.

"Three hundred thousand to the lady with eighty-eight, going once!" The auctioneer happily raised his hammer.

"Three hundred and fifty thousand." This bidder was seated among the VIPs.

"Four hundred thousand!" Someone followed. The VIP's bid had stirred the room.

"Damn, it's heating up. They're driving up the price." Anjou's voice remained calm. "But don't hurry, and don't leave the field. Keep bidding, without making the jumps too obvious. It isn't time to exert ourselves yet."

"Four hundred and ten thousand." Lu Mingfei raised his paddle. Though he wasn't fond of the set, completing the assignment would excuse him from two makeup exams, so he was willing to try.

"One million." Number 88 again.

The veiled girl's momentum was irresistible. Anjou didn't need to remind Lu Mingfei: however hard he tried, his biggest jumps were not even half hers.

"One million?" Even the auctioneer questioned the figure.

"One and a half million." Number 88's voice was icy.

"One moment, madam. No one has bid against you since your last offer. Is your bid one million or one and a half?" the auctioneer asked carefully.

"What it was doesn't matter. Now it's one and a half million."

The room erupted. This was madness: Number 88 was driving up the price of the blades by bidding against herself.

"One point six million." Before the astonished murmurs had died away, a fresh price came from the VIP seats.

"Someone is paying close attention now," Anjou murmured, raising his own paddle. "One point seven million."

"Principal, didn't you say you weren't bidding?" Lu Mingfei was bewildered.

In the blink of an eye, one of their own had driven the price up another hundred thousand. Did these people have any idea what a hundred thousand dollars could do? In Lu Mingfei's hometown, fifty

thousand would buy a small house, and the other fifty thousand could buy enough pirated game discs to fill it!

"Someone paying close attention means they've realized this might be extraordinary. They know me; with my temperament, I'd certainly try for something unusual, or I wouldn't be myself," Anjou said quietly. "But you're still our trump card."

"Two million." Number 88's queenly presence surged again.

"Keep bidding," Anjou ordered.

"Two... million and ten thousand!" Lu Mingfei gritted his teeth and raised his paddle. His smallholder instincts said a thousand-dollar raise was still a raise, so why not save money? But in this situation he felt he couldn't embarrass himself too badly.

"Two point one million." Number 72 raised a paddle, apparently an ambusher who had kept hidden until now.

"Two point one million, the gentleman with seventy-two!" The auctioneer's face flushed with excitement. Apparently the auction house had struck lucky. They hadn't expected much from this unusual lot, yet the competition was now as fierce as for the gourd-shaped vase that had closed the main sale.

"Continue," Anjou murmured.

"But I only have two million," Lu Mingfei reminded him quietly.

"Don't worry. Once you've successfully bought it, the college will transfer the money. The two million was only your deposit to get a seat here."

"Two point two million!" Lu Mingfei threw caution aside.

"Three." Number 88 spoke lightly, not even bothering to say "million."

The price rose back and forth, the air growing hot. Bidding gentlemen loosened their ties to breathe. Lu Mingfei gasped, the hand holding his cigar trembling slightly. He was caught in a torrent of money and couldn't stop. A few seconds after his bid of 5.2 million, someone raised it again. Hybrids truly were passionate lovers of fine craftsmanship: once their blood was hot, cost no longer mattered.

But Number 88 remained the focus. She held everyone down so firmly that, however they struggled, they seemed only to make her eventual victory more glorious.

What did it mean to be determined to win? This! It took both resources and nerve. A mongrel like Lu Mingfei could never summon the aura of a queen arriving. He felt he was losing, unable to hold on.

"Ten million." Number 88 spoke casually, this time adding an entire digit.

Should he just give up? At worst he could work harder for the makeup exams next semester. This sort of assignment had never suited him. The principal must have read the mission report Chu Zihang had written for him and thought he'd been heroic in China. In truth his expressionless senior had protected him... while Senior was bleeding, Lu Mingfei had only been mooning over Chen Wenwen. Thoughts flashed through his mind.

"Ten million, going once, number eighty-eight." The auctioneer's voice filled the room.

Yet he couldn't quite accept defeat. The old principal really did seem good to him, saying such poignant things, promising to give him a chance to learn. But please: a circus gorilla might sometimes

appear to do addition, but it would never learn calculus, just as Lu Mingfei would never become Chu Zihang. He wrestled with himself.

"Ten million, going twice. Ladies and gentlemen, seize your last chance."

Why didn't he dare fight? The principal had beaten his chest and promised to back him. Yet the enormous numbers seemed to crush him, leaving him breathless, hands and feet cold. He really couldn't do it... He'd tried hard to hold on until now... Perhaps he should let it go... Though he hated to lose.

"Mingfei, I believe in you. You must believe in yourself too. You are the one I chose; wherever you go, you will shine." Anjou's voice seemed both near and far. "Giving up? You'll regret it, won't you?"

Lu Mingfei shuddered, as though an electric current had passed through him.

Yes, he hated to lose. Though he wanted desperately to give up, he couldn't suppress that little spark of unwillingness deep in his heart, a flame that not all the rain in the world could extinguish.

So he still had that inside him...

"Twenty million!" Number 17 raised his paddle.

Lu Mingfei's voice filled the hall, and everyone fell silent. Could it get any crazier? This young, nouveau-riche-looking big kid still trembled slightly as he raised his paddle, yet he had jumped ten million!

The auctioneer hesitated; it was the second time that day he'd wondered whether he'd heard correctly. An assistant hurried onstage and whispered to him. The auctioneer nodded slightly, his face grave. "Ladies and gentlemen, thank you for your interest in this lot. The intensity of the bidding has greatly exceeded our expectations. We must prevent false bids that result in a successful sale without payment, so we must ask Mr. Lu, number seventeen, to accompany us to the finance office. The auction will be suspended in the meantime."

Lu Mingfei's face changed at once.

In the finance office the auctioneer's assistant and the finance manager gathered around Lu Mingfei. They were perfectly courteous, but to him they seemed full of murderous intent.

"We're very sorry, but the manner of your bidding was truly extraordinary. To safeguard the auction, we had to ask you here." The manager patted a black briefcase. "You gave us only a Zurich bank account containing two million dollars as a deposit. Ordinarily that would be persuasive, but your bid this round is twenty million, ten times your deposit. This is your first visit, and you haven't established sufficient credit. Unless you can demonstrate that you really can pay, we must revoke your bidding privileges."

"How could that be? Is that all?" Sweat poured down Lu Mingfei's face, but he forced himself to bluster. "Two million is just what I spend on a new Bugatti!"

The manager seemed to see through the boy's bravado and smiled discreetly. "Please cooperate and temporarily remove your earpiece and microphone. Your financial security and our reputation are at stake, so our conversation must remain confidential."

Lu Mingfei had no choice but to remove them. Now he was fighting alone.

"In the past, malicious clients have placed newcomers in the room to drive up prices. They had no ability to pay, but affected the fairness of the auction." The manager spoke patiently. "You only need to demonstrate your ability to pay, for example by providing us with another account."

"Two million is only my account balance." Lu Mingfei did his best to avoid the man's gaze.

The manager smiled and opened the briefcase. Unfolded, it became an electronic device with a red LCD screen and black keyboard, like an enormous calculator.

"Please enter the password for your Zurich bank account." He pushed the case toward Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingfei couldn't refuse. With stiff fingers he pressed the keys; Anjou had given him the password. A few seconds later the screen displayed "$2,000,000.00." He stared blankly at the number that had once seemed a vast fortune, but heard quiet, derisive laughter. At this feast of dragons, the sum was insignificant.

"We have considerable access at the Zurich bank and can check your balance. It really is only two million dollars." The manager smiled.

Laugh, laugh. These people had been laughing at him ever since he got out of the car, until he no longer knew what to do with his hands and feet. Lu Mingfei lowered his head like a suspect being questioned.

In the opera-house hall, guests murmured to one another, voices rising and falling.

Someone cleared her throat in the box on the right. Even that sound was seductive, and everyone looked up together.

"When the auction resumes, my next bid will be fifty million." Every word from Number 88 was as heavy as a gold bar.

The auctioneer was dumbfounded. Was this a declaration of war? Was the veiled girl's fighting spirit so fierce she wouldn't even wait for the auction to resume before bidding? She was no longer a queen; she was an army at the gates!

"Number eighty-eight says she'll raise it to fifty million!" Another assistant hurried into the finance office and whispered to the manager.

"Did you hear right? Fifty million?" The manager stared, lowering his own voice. "There's nobody left bidding against her!"

"Who says there isn't?" Lu Mingfei slowly raised his head.

The manager frowned. "Sir, unless you can provide a new account with funds to prove yourself..."

Lu Mingfei looked at the balding man. Did hybrids go bald too? He looked like a washed-up middle-aged loser. A man who admitted defeat... would become a useless middle-aged uncle like that!

That little fire in his heart was so annoying... burning slowly.

"I really hate the way you look at me. It's like my high-school teacher reading my grades aloud to the whole class," Lu Mingfei said. "And I hate the way you all laugh. Let me enter the password again."

The strange characters shone in his mind. "Show me the money": that cheat code would bring him ten thousand dollars, but he needed more, far more. He had no way out. If he retreated, he'd lose, and he couldn't bear it. As if possessed, he added "×10000" after the code. Ten thousand times: he would borrow a hundred million!

He tapped the confirmation key and pushed the remote device connected directly to the Zurich bank back to the manager. Crossing his legs, he smoked the Cohiba cigar, which had looked like a ridiculous grilled sausage between his fingers moments ago.

"What?" The manager smiled. "Still two million..."

He stopped suddenly, the tail of his words twisting. The number had begun to change, leaping rapidly like ultraviolet readings from the sky during a solar flare. Every digit rolled—no, flashed! Had the device used old-fashioned numerical wheels instead of an LCD, their furious rotation would have thrown sparks.

The manager involuntarily reached out to slap the device. Either it had gone mad or his eyes were wrong. A vast flood of money was pouring into this unknown boy's account.

At last the number settled at "$10,200,000.00." In ten seconds, a hundred million dollars had poured into the account!

Lu Mingfei tilted his head back and drew a deep breath, as though he would take all the air in the world into his lungs. Then he exhaled softly. "One hundred million."

"Yes... your account... has increased by a hundred million." The manager stammered.

"I can see that. What I mean is, when the auction resumes, I'll bid a hundred million dollars. I like to show my hand," Lu Mingfei said evenly. "Competitive bidding is too tedious; it wastes everyone's time. I think this set is worth a hundred million, so that's what I'll offer. There's no need to economize on something I want. If anyone bids higher, I'll let it go."

"All right, I'm going to the restroom. Take care of this. You have my authorization; this paddle is now worth a hundred million." Lu Mingfei tossed number 17 in front of the manager, stood, and went out.

The auctioneer was back onstage, his voice trembling, eyes bright. "The auction is now resumed. We have received authorization from the lady with number eighty-eight to bid fifty million, and authorization from Mr. Lu, number seventeen, to bid... one hundred million."

Silence filled the hall. Everyone watched the box on the right, waiting for Number 88. The price had become utterly insane; nobody else wanted to join this contest between madmen. Whether Number 88 would fight back was the only uncertainty.

"One hundred million dollars, going once." The auctioneer raised his hammer.

"One hundred million dollars, going twice..."

The veiled girl stood, turned without a word, and left. Suddenly she discarded the set as though it were worthless.

"Sold for one hundred million dollars!" As she walked out of the hall, the auctioneer brought down the hammer as if driving a nail hard into wood.

In the lounge outside the opera-house hall, Lu Mingfei paced in circles, thinking. The once-magnificent cigar had become a grilled sausage again between his limp fingers, seemingly a little wilted itself.

He tried to recall what had happened. For an instant an exhilarating force had surged through him, like a martial-arts master unleashing power from his dantian, or someone who had just eaten a bowl of hot, spicy tofu pudding. He had stopped caring about anything, overflowing with heroic passion and grand words. As he tossed out the paddle and that hundred million, he had been full of thoughts like, What's a hundred million to a magnificent fellow like me? I'm the man who will shatter heaven! Like a Hong Kong comic hero bursting with power and shouting, "You useless fool, don't think your Hell King's World-Splitting Fist lets you rule the world! Dare you face my hundred-thousand-horsepower Star-Shattering Divine Sword?"

Only when he happily relieved himself in the restroom did that domineering spirit flow away with his urine. He suddenly came to his senses, and his entire body went cold.

A hundred million... Holy crap, he'd actually spent a hundred million without the principal's authorization. He had thrown away a hundred million for something as insubstantial as a surge of bravado?

Had he gone mad, or just awakened from a dream? His memory tangled for a moment as he stood blankly before the urinal.

"Hey, friend, you're already finished..." a man beside him reminded him kindly.

"Can't I savor the moment?" Lu Mingfei snapped.

But after leaving the restroom he didn't dare enter the hall. He only hoped everything had been an illusion, that nothing had happened, that he hadn't spent a hundred million, that he had merely stepped out to use the restroom and after a short rest everything would return to normal.

High heels clicked crisply against the floor.

"Mr. Lu," someone said behind him.

He spun around. The veiled Number 88 stood only a foot behind him, her eyes cold, the alluring crimson at their corners touched with menace. Lu Mingfei hopped back, nearly blurting, Let's talk this out! I didn't mean to make trouble; gentlemen use words, not fists! Her fierce aura always made him feel she might draw an Arabian scimitar from beneath her robe at any moment.

"A fine display of nerve with that final bid. I liked the blades too, but I don't have Mr. Lu's resources, so I had to let them go." The girl actually smiled.

She leaned forward slightly and did something wonderful beyond Lu Mingfei's imagining: she kissed him lightly on the cheek! A girl's warm body heat and faint floral fragrance enveloped him.

Huh? Was this the first time a girl had kissed him? What unscrupulous person had stolen his first kiss like that? Did she have no conscience or morals? If she was going to kiss him, why not on the mouth? Why not warn him so he could prepare? If possible, he'd really hoped to make the first move himself... Countless voices echoed in his head. The whole world blurred before his eyes. Were shining red hearts rising above his head?

"You're handsome, young man... Hear the applause? They're applauding you. Perhaps one day... the whole world will applaud you." The girl brushed past the motionless Lu Mingfei.

Applause poured from the opera-house hall like a surging tide.

A Bordeaux-red Cadillac DTS waited at the opera house's rear entrance, a Japanese flag mounted on its side. The veiled girl went straight to it and sped away.

"Wait, madam! Please wait!" The auctioneer's assistant rushed out of the opera house, only to see the DTS disappearing into the distance.

"Why didn't you stop her? Didn't I call you?" The assistant turned on the silent attendant, furious.

"It's a Japanese embassy car. Under diplomatic custom, even an embassy car flies the flag only when the ambassador or consul is aboard or when on official business," the attendant said quietly. "She has powerful backing. It wouldn't be easy to stop her."

The assistant paused and nodded slightly. "She's a new face. Did you check who sponsored her?"

"The Mint Club. We couldn't find anything more."

"More and more new faces, and they're playing more and more extravagantly." The assistant murmured, "It's unsettling..."

A partition separated the DTS's front and rear seats, and black privacy glass shut out outside eyes. On the broad sofa seat, the veiled girl curled into a ball and wriggled out of the spacious robe like a rabbit. All her bones seemed soft, every joint able to turn like a universal coupling. Only a rigorously trained yoga practitioner, contortionist, or... Japanese ninja could do that. She stretched her figure with pride. Hiding something so good beneath an Arabian robe was depressing.

The clothes she liked had been prepared: black leather top and pants, a wine-red short jacket, and red lace-up sandals with three-inch heels. Even with help, such an extremely fashionable outfit would take several minutes to put on, but for a ninja it was as easy as a hermit crab slipping into a shell. Mai Sakatoku removed the golden veil, revealing a breathtakingly beautiful face, the bright blush lending her a touch of ferocity.

A woman who always carried two ninja swords in her bag could never look harmless, however she wore her makeup. Her striking figure was even more conspicuous than her face, so she had to wrap herself from head to toe in a robe.

"As you said, a hundred million." Reclining in the seat, she crossed her long legs and connected the car phone.

"Beautifully done. I can already see a hundred million dollars added to the account. Subtracting the salvage expenses, our net profit is ninety-eight point six million. Cassell College is rich; they only need a few dozen seconds to move that much cash." Chips could be heard crunching on the other end.

"Their Board of Trustees is richer. Those people control trusts and syndicates; even a billion is no problem. Aren't you worried about getting fat, eating chips all the time?"

"I don't have your figure, so I won't be so demanding. As long as Levi's doesn't suggest the loose fit when I try on jeans, I'm happy." Chips Girl was as carefree as ever.

"A woman worth that much still wears Levi's... Why pretend to be the girl next door?" Mai Sakatoku muttered. She frequented luxury boutiques, happily dividing her time off between shopping, parties, and ninja training that involved hanging from a roof by two fingers...

"Miss High-and-Mighty, without all my hard work, how would you lot live so well?"

"Tell me, wasn't a hundred million too cheap for the Seven Deadly Sins? A treasure forged by the King of Bronze and Fire himself, deadly blades capable of killing the other Dragon Kings. There'll never be another set in the world."

"Can't be helped. The strongest weapons need the strongest wielder; they're no use to us. Would you risk being consumed by them? When their 'Crime and Punishment' domain expands to its limit, people of our bloodline can't even touch the hilts, can we? Actually, as long as they return to Lu Mingfei's hands, I'd gladly give them away, never mind paying the one-point-four-million salvage fee ourselves! But a gift would make Anjou suspicious, so we charged him a hundred million to help with household expenses... The economy's bad lately..." Chips Girl began rambling.

"You sound like a bookkeeper! No, a maid who keeps the accounts."

"What do you think my role is? I'm an accounting maid!" Chips Girl sounded aggrieved. "Besides me, who among you can be relied on? Managing this whole operation isn't easy. Thousands of mouths

to feed! You and that cold-faced girl know nothing about saving. Every mission you're like vandals, sweeping through and wrecking everything. The compensation bills afterward are terrifying..."

"Shut up, shut up!" Mai dreaded this routine more than anything. "Has the boss contacted you lately?"

"Once."

"What about?" Mai grew serious.

Her boss was elusive. Usually the woman who always had chips in her mouth managed the organization's affairs single-handedly; only on matters of exceptional importance did the boss give orders personally, and every time the move was fierce, overwhelming, and violent.

"Do you know a company called Square Enix?"

"Obviously. Square, Japan's most famous game-software company, known for Final Fantasy. It's practically the national company of Japanese gaming obsessives, and I'm Japanese." Mai was a loyal Square player herself, fond of the Valkyrie Profile series, and had completed every installment with every item.

"They recently released their newest title, Final Fantasy XIV, but the reviews were terrible. Longtime players reacted strongly. One posted passionately on the official forum: 'Final Fantasy XIV no longer appeals to me at all. The people making games have lost their way, so there's no reason for me to keep my eighty-five million dollars in Square Enix stock. I've decided to sell.' Just as everyone was laughing and assuming it was a joke, news came that the share price had instantly fallen 0.15 percent," Chips Girl said lazily.

"Hey, your train of thought has wandered way too far. Is this what you Chinese call a 'god-tier plot twist'?"

"I posted it using the boss's ID, then sold all eighty-five million dollars of his Square Enix shares on the Tokyo Stock Exchange within fifteen seconds." The other woman hung up.

Mai stared at the receiver's busy signal... It sounded like something out of a fantasy, but it was certainly the boss's style—that supremely powerful, supremely violent... gaming nerd.

Act Eight

A Sigh on the River Cam

Sigh on the River Cam

"But I still cannot allow the dragons to destroy all this. If they destroy Cambridge, I will have nowhere left to remember. If they destroy Cassell College, I will have betrayed the trust of my friends in the Lionheart Society. If they destroy the graves of the girls I loved in secret, I will fight them with my life. Because these last things that give my life meaning... elusive as reflections shimmering in the light... are all I have left!"

Hands in his pockets, Anjou hummed an aria as he walked through the VIP passage of the municipal opera house. Paintings lined both sides of the narrow corridor, from Van Gogh and Monet to Rubens. Sunlight fell on the scarlet ceiling, walls, and floor, making their magnificent color flow somewhere between blood and roses.

"Congratulations on winning what you wanted." The mild greeting sounded as if it came from an old friend.

Anjou stopped. The shadow of a small figure fell on the floor, back hunched, leaning on a cane. He looked down at it in silence for a long time. At the end of the passage, Lu Mingfei waited for him. Two security guards stood behind the boy with a cart; in its black hard case lay the set of alchemical blades worth a hundred million dollars.

Anjou smiled and waved to Lu Mingfei. "An old friend wants a word. I'll see you outside in a little while."

Lu Mingfei left. Anjou took a deep breath but did not turn around.

"I thought you were willing to talk. Why not come in and sit down?" the man behind him asked.

"In 1899, in Texas, you shot me the instant I turned around. Ever since, I've hated hearing you call me from behind. Henkel, do you still carry that pair of alchemical revolvers?"

"It's been a hundred years. Surely you aren't still holding a grudge?" The man behind him chuckled kindly. "Back then you could only slow time for four seconds. Now it's more than ten, isn't it? You can slow a bullet in flight. What have you to worry about? Besides, I'm old too. I'm not 'Quick-Hand Henkel' anymore."

"Your Holy Judgment is a nuisance, though. I'm still not sure I could escape your judgment."

"We're living in modern society. We don't settle things with Yanling and alchemical revolvers anymore. Come in for a drink. Everyone's here."

Anjou turned slowly. A crimson door hidden in the wall at the side of the corridor stood open. A gaunt old man in round glasses and a rolled-brim leather hat nodded to him. He looked like a retired Texas Ranger; a worn badge still adorned his hat.

Inside stood thirteen high-backed leather chairs, each occupied by a handsome young man. They greeted Anjou in the same way, raising their right fists to show silver rings on their index fingers: heavy, plain rings with different totems on their enormous faces. Each was a family crest.

"No introductions necessary, I suppose? Hilbert Jean Anjou, a well-known patron in our circles, a major customer, and principal of Cassell College." Henkel sat down at the table and invited Anjou to take any seat. "How many years has it been since we spoke, Anjou?"

"The last time was December seventh, 1941, at Pearl Harbor. We were halfway through negotiations when the air-raid sirens interrupted us. The damned Japanese chose that day to bomb the place." Anjou took an empty chair and lit a cigar.

"Yes, I remember. World War II, America declaring war, our negotiations for an alliance suspended." Henkel nodded wistfully. "And that suspension lasted more than half a century."

"Are these your generation's family representatives?" Anjou surveyed the well-dressed young men.

Henkel nodded. "The finest young people from each family. Some of the old fellows of our generation are dead. Others lie in hospital beds with oxygen tubes down their throats. Their bloodlines are a tragedy: they don't die suddenly of disease, only suffer slow organ failure... Their genes are imperfect, after all. They're only half dragon." Henkel sighed. "I'm old too. I envy you, still as vigorous as a young man. If you went to a bar, young girls would still fall for such a handsome old gentleman, wouldn't they? I rather like the Maserati you drove here."

"Don't circle around it." Anjou puffed smoke. "We see one another at auctions, but we haven't struck up a conversation in over half a century. Why make an exception today?"

"To celebrate your winning what you wanted." Henkel took champagne from an ice bucket, poured a glass, and handed it to Anjou.

"Thank you for withdrawing and letting us have it." Anjou raised his glass.

"To tell the truth, we rather regret it. You wanted it so badly you brought people to disrupt the sale. It must have exceptional value. But we lost our judgment at the time. Your Mr. Lu was too clever by half, bidding like a madman. By the time we realized he was a plant you'd brought along, the auction was over."

"A plant? He's one of our outstanding S-rank students." Anjou smiled.

"Oh, S-rank? You have another S-rank student after all these years? You must have recruited many young people with first-rate bloodlines." Henkel paused. "I hear you even killed Bronze and Fire, one of the Four Monarchs."

"You've always been well informed." Anjou studied the stemmed glass in his hand, where the wine rippled pale gold.

"But we don't know whether you obtained the dragon bones." Henkel raised an eyebrow.

"No." Anjou shrugged. "We could have, but something went wrong. A student acted in an emergency and struck him head-on with a Shkval torpedo. We searched the entire area afterward and found no remains."

The young men exchanged surprised glances. They had remained wary of Anjou, resolved to listen more than they spoke. The principal of Cassell College, one of the earliest members of the Lionheart Society, the man who organized the slaughter of Dragon Kings from behind the scenes... Such an old man should have been a sharp blade; anyone reaching for its edge had to be prepared to bleed. Dragon

bones were a sensitive subject, taboo even among hybrids, usually discussed under a name like the Holy Grail. When Henkel asked, the room grew tense and the young men fixed their eyes on Anjou. They would not have been surprised if the improper question made the old man turn hostile. Yet Anjou looked utterly accommodating, chatting freely about Cassell College's highest secret.

"But you confirmed that he died," one young man said.

"No. Even one of the Four Monarchs is still a living creature, though. A direct hit from a Shkval would punch through a cruiser; his chances of survival are slim," Anjou said mildly. "We did, however, kill Constantine and obtain his remains."

"Congratulations." Henkel raised his glass. "For the first time in history, we have truly killed one of the Four Monarchs. For thousands of years, the Dragon Kings' ability to form cocoons has been a nightmare for us, and you've solved that technical problem. In the foreseeable future, I believe the Dragon Kings will fall one by one. The day all Four Monarchs are buried will be the most important day in human history. Gentlemen, a toast to our compatriots."

The young men rose together, raising their champagne. "To a new history!"

"No. What matters isn't a new history... but the end of one part of the old." Anjou raised his glass too.

Everyone drained their glasses.

"Then, at such an important moment, might we resume negotiations for an alliance?" A young man stood. He wore a small, artistic mustache and smiled warmly.

"The door to negotiation is always open. If the terms are good enough, we'll climb the wall even if there isn't a door." Anjou smiled.

"I admire your openness, Mr. Anjou. Had Frost Gattuso come today instead, we might not be able to sit together like friends, have a drink, and talk things over." The young man looked into Anjou's eyes. "I think you know why."

"The Gattuso family is the strongest among us, and Frost is its representative. He's always been hard-line. If he were here, he wouldn't give you a chance to ask questions." Anjou spread his hands. "I'm a moderate. Everyone likes moderates."

"Exactly. That's why we can talk. Among our compatriots, the Secret Party are the most radical, like a flock of fighting rams, and Frost is the one most fond of jumping about. We don't want to talk to him; that would be unwise." The young man was condescending yet coaxing. A Harvard Business School graduate, he was the best negotiator among them. Speaking gently, he circled Anjou to convey his goodwill, while standing forced Anjou to look up at him. Negotiating psychology taught him that looking up at an opponent naturally placed one at a disadvantage.

"We're all hybrids. We ought to be good friends. We merely disagree on how to deal with dragons, and that difference can be bridged. We're delighted that you now have the power to kill a first-generation dragon. Dragons are our enemies too, after all. We look forward to your bringing their history to an end, and we would be glad to help." The young man smiled.

"So generous?" Anjou raised an eyebrow.

"We're willing to give generously to our common cause, but we expect a reasonable return. When the dragons' history ends, the new age will belong to all hybrids. No single group should become the absolute leader. We should share power." The young man rested a hand on the back of Anjou's chair,

so familiar that his breath brushed Anjou's face. "If Cassell is willing to discuss sharing power, we certainly won't be stingy about helping our friends."

Anjou shrugged. "Are we talking about dividing territory?"

"No, not dividing it. Sharing it. We're far superior to humans and ought to rule, but for all these years we've concealed our identities so carefully because the shadow of the dragons remained, haven't we? They could return at any moment and kept us in constant fear. We didn't want dragons and humans to see us as enemies at once. But now we've finally found a way to kill Dragon Kings. We're about to escape that shadow. Nothing will constrain us anymore; our influence will spread across the world! This will be our most glorious age!" The young man sounded like a Wall Street junk-bond broker, persuasive and lyrical. "Let us build that glorious age together!"

"That sounds rather good... but it's still only an ideal. Do you have a concrete plan?" Anjou asked.

"Of course." The junk-bond broker had found a prospective client; his face lit up. "First, and most important, the Holy Grail... I mean the dragon bones... you can't keep them all to yourselves."

"No monopoly? How about making a specimen of them and sending it on a world tour?" Anjou smiled.

"You know what I mean, Principal. Dragon bones are valuable as more than specimens for studying dragons. They contain a Dragon King's power. Dragons have only two ways to pass on power: producing offspring or devouring their own kind!" The young man circled Anjou slowly. "African cannibals believe eating a brave enemy gives them his courage. For dragons, devouring their own kind truly means inheriting an enemy's power!"

"Then split them in two, half for you and half for us. Charcoal-grilled dragon bones?" Anjou nodded and smiled. "I recommend a full-bodied California red with this reptile dish!"

"Leaving aside that unfunny joke, you're right." The young man was losing patience. "Our condition is that you get half the dragon bones and we get half."

"Could our half be a little bigger? We did more work, and we have a lot of students. Grilling won't stretch far enough; perhaps we'll have to make soup, one spoonful each."

"We're expressing a sincere desire to cooperate, not haggling!" The young man was plainly angry.

"We are haggling," Anjou said mildly. "We may all be hybrids, but for centuries we alone have fought the dragons. Our companions who emigrated to the Americas built a school, made weapons, gathered intelligence, and searched for ruins. That is how Cassell College came into being. Meanwhile, you carried gold stolen from Native Americans back to Europe, made it into jewelry for whores, danced and flirted with them, and bought property for your families. Your businesses grew larger and larger. For this war, we have lost enough companions to fill Santa Monica Beach with white crosses. After paying so much, of course we must haggle."

Henkel coughed softly, breaking the deadlock.

"All right, all right." The young man took a deep breath, suppressed his displeasure, and put his gentle smile back on. "We're happy to acknowledge the Secret Party's great sacrifices and will pay a reasonable price for them."

"How reasonable?" Anjou seemed interested.

The young man sensed hope; his smile grew warmer and more enticing. "The entire hybrid community will welcome you. Trade routes across the world will be open to you. Our families will

intermarry to strengthen our bloodlines and produce superior descendants. Most importantly, we will give your dragon-slaying plan our unreserved support. With the Secret Party alone, every encounter with a Dragon King is a life-or-death challenge. With us joining you, I wouldn't say victory is assured, but wouldn't your chances increase enormously?" He paused. "And for you personally... We know that although you're principal of Cassell College, you aren't the most powerful member of its Board of Trustees. Some people are dissatisfied with you, but they're only jealous because you're so outstanding. If you advance our proposal on the board and secure its approval, we'll send representatives with a substantial donation to join the board and support you wholeheartedly. At Cassell College, you unquestionably deserve to hold all the power."

The young man studied Anjou's face. Anjou showed no expression.

Determined to strike the strongest note of the negotiation, he patted the back of Anjou's chair. "Look forward, Principal! We honor our dead friends, but we shouldn't set too high a price on the dead. History is a wheel of steel. Some people are bound to be crushed beneath it; that's their personal tragedy, but history makes it inevitable! We can't remain submerged in grief. The greatest tribute we can pay them is to enjoy the peaceful life they brought us. When the future is about to begin, why keep dwelling on the disagreements of the past? Once dragons are extinct, hybrids will stand at the top of the evolutionary tree. Humans cannot compare with us." The young man drew a deep breath. "We will become... the new dragons!"

"New... dragons?" Anjou nodded slightly.

He lowered his head, closed his eyes, and began humming a song as if lost in thought. The young men waiting for his answer were taken aback, but recognized the aria 'The Magic of the Rhinegold' from Wagner's The Ring of the Nibelung. The dwarf Alberich admired the magically powerful gold at the bottom of the Rhine, but the three maidens guarding it mocked his ugliness and ambition without mercy. Enraged, he stole the gold and forged a ring symbolizing power, condemning himself to lose happiness as well.

The next instant, something unbelievable happened to the young man. His black suit and white shirt burst into hundreds of strips that scattered in every direction. His muscular body was entirely exposed, save for a stiffly starched collar.

Those watching Anjou saw something stranger still. Anjou, who had been sitting calmly, vanished. The champagne glass he had raised remained suspended in the air for an instant, then fell and shattered, splashing golden wine across the floor.

In the next instant, the naked young man sat in the high-backed chair, looking around in bewilderment, like someone waiting for a barber to shave him.

His barber stood behind the chair. Anjou spun a folding knife about twenty centimeters long in his hand, its edge flashing beneath the young man's jaw. Wild, beautiful patterns, characteristic of Damascus steel, covered the blade. He was still humming 'The Magic of the Rhinegold.'

The young man dared not move. Their positions had been exchanged, reversing the advantage of height. The pressure weighed like a mountain, pinning him to the chair; he lacked the strength to move a finger. His neatly trimmed mustache drifted down in the breeze. At the same time he heard his skin split with terrifying clarity. The cut grew longer, crossing his face, and a line of blood slowly appeared.

"I've wanted to trim your mustache ever since you started talking." Anjou smiled. "But I drew blood by accident, so I won't charge you."

"Now, Anjou, don't be angry with the child," Henkel said mildly.

Anjou drew on his cigar. "Someone must teach him. You know I'm an educator. Young man, don't you realize you're a dwarf in the eyes of pure-blooded dragons? You carry their blood, but not all of it. You talk big and feel inferior inside. New dragons? Don't make me laugh. You only mean to steal the gold." He blew smoke in the young man's face. "Your speech about history was splendid. Yes, great men don't care when certain people die, because their vision is broader. When I studied at Trinity College, my teacher also said those who hold power must view history from a higher place, like watching a battle from a mountain. People trample one another to death like ants, but you feel no pain because they're too far away. You're so elegant, not a spot of blood on your sleeves. How handsome! But I can't do it. I'm not on the mountaintop; I'm on that battlefield. Every second people die around me. Their pain surrounds me. I see their faces, their blood, their broken bodies, and every face is familiar. They're my companions. Henkel, I've never been a calm man, have I?"

"No," Henkel said mildly. "You're just cool."

"Then I'm already mad with killing. Can you lecture a man like that about the wheel of history?"

"No," Henkel agreed.

"Henkel, I suggest you teach your children some plain truths about life. Tell them the Wall Street approach doesn't work on a desperate man mad with killing. If you want to name a price to me, first understand who I am. Don't tell me not to set too high a price on the dead, as if I were a ghoul trading in corpses. And don't talk to me about 'new dragons.' All dragons, born or self-proclaimed, are my enemies!" Anjou flicked the ash from his cigar. "Anyone who has been my enemy has come to a bad end."

"Still, I agree with your assessment of Frost. He is a fighting ram who likes to jump about. You've learned your rhetoric well." He patted the young man's handsome, wooden face and went out the door.

The room fell deathly silent. Only the ticking of the wall clock could be heard.

The young men all came from distinguished hybrid families, the elite of a new generation and spokesmen for their houses. Their sight and hearing were far keener than humans'. Some were natural marksmen, able to hit a target over a kilometer away with an ordinary military rifle and no optical sight. Yet none had seen what had just happened. A piece of time seemed to have been cut out of Anjou's movements: one instant he sat calmly, the next his folding knife spun in his hand. During that missing interval, one of them had lost the artistic little mustache he had cultivated for years.

Given nothing but a folding knife, how long would it take to shave off a mustache? Half a minute at least. Then... Anjou had stolen half a minute from them. How many times could a man thrust a knife in half a minute? Thirteen would be no problem, enough to kill them all!

A piercing chill lingered at the throat of the man who had lost his mustache. He clutched his neck and gasped. Everyone's shirt was soaked in cold sweat. They sat frozen, struggling to recall the instant time had been severed and the scorching majesty that had burst from Anjou, a spontaneous domain born as his bloodline burned. Ancient legends said a dragon slayer must not look a dragon in the eye: meeting such a creature's gaze would shatter the mind of anyone whose will was weak, even destroy their soul.

Dragon's majesty!

Henkel dipped a handkerchief in the ice bucket and handed it to the wounded young man. "Wipe your face. It's all right. I didn't expect you to reach an agreement with him. I only wanted to sound him out. You did well."

"Oh. Oh." The young man took the handkerchief in alarm and pressed it to his face. Icy water and blood ran down together, staining his shirt cuff red.

"It seems we were rash to propose cooperation so abruptly. The Secret Party is strongly opposed," another young man said.

"Not necessarily. Cassell College does need our help. With their strength alone, they have too little chance against the Four Monarchs. But remember this lesson: with Hilbert Jean Anjou, you may negotiate and joke, but don't try to cross his bottom line." Henkel turned to the wounded man.

"His bottom line?"

"Don't offend his dead companions." Leaning on his cane, Henkel got laboriously to his feet. "Anjou is over a hundred and thirty, isn't he? A man that age should have his coffin ready and be listening peacefully to his grandchildren's stories. Yet when he sat calmly before me drinking champagne, I felt his body was taut, ready to spring at any moment, like a crocodile about to hunt." He opened a drawer and took out two old-fashioned golden revolvers. He removed a round and laid it on the table: a .5-inch Magnum pistol cartridge. Even unmodified, it could knock down a hippopotamus with one shot, and this bullet's tip bore the mysterious patterns of an alchemical weapon.

The alchemical revolvers: Texas Dawn.

The young men exchanged looks, realizing they had treated Anjou far too casually. Henkel had not taken out this pair of alchemical revolvers, which had once written hybrid history, in many years. He was now a family leader of exceptional standing among hybrids; using force had long since ceased to be his job. Yet when he met Anjou, he remained armed at all times.

"I can't help being cautious face-to-face with him. We're about the same age, but I'm so old I'm nearly dead, while he's full of life like a young man. Why? Science tells us a person's age depends on the desires in his heart. A movie star in his fifties looks dashing and acts impulsively like a young man, while an office worker of the same age grows a bigger belly by the day and prepares to retire. Movie stars have greater desires. Desire keeps people young." Henkel paused. "Anjou's desire... is revenge. That desire is more vigorous than any other, like a poisonous seed that takes root in the heart and grows into a tree until its shadow covers the whole heart."

"How I envy his youth," Henkel murmured, turning the alchemical revolvers in his hands, "and that desire... like a wildfire."

"So we're just... letting it go?" a young man broke the silence.

"We'll watch and wait for now. We still have a basis for negotiating with Anjou. He's different from Frost Gattuso. Frost takes pride in the noble Gattuso bloodline and looks down on all the other families. Naturally he won't lower himself to negotiate with us. But Anjou... he only wants revenge on the dragons for his dead companions. For a hatred that has lasted a hundred years, he might agree to any terms." Henkel smiled. "Besides, Frost is pressing him from behind. I hope Frost pushes him out even harder; then he'll drive Anjou over to our side."

Henkel went to the wall and knocked. "Anjou has gone. Come out."

A small red door concealed in the wall opened, and someone stepped out without a sound. A silver-gray suit, gleaming leather shoes, a rose-gold watch: the luxury suited his muscular build perfectly. The young men all looked at his feet. His steps were firm but light, with a powerful sense of rhythm. What a confident entrance! It perfectly expressed the image of a successful, elegant man; he could have replaced Sean Connery as the face of Louis Vuitton travel bags.

He sat opposite Henkel without greeting anyone. He entered this gathering of hybrid family leaders as though no one else were there.

Henkel looked up at him. "Next time, could you appear before me looking respectable?"

"A custom Prada suit, Hermès shoes, a Zenith watch." The guest shrugged. "That should do it, shouldn't it?"

"What is that over your head?"

"You've never seen a KFC paper bag? Come on..." The man pushed a ketchup-covered fry into his mouth.

A KFC takeout bag covered his head, with two eyeholes and a mouth hole cut into it. That was why the young men could only look at his feet.

"This time you're Colonel Sanders? Last time we met at a bank and you had a black stocking over your face... The time before that was Halloween, and you wore a Darth Vader mask." Henkel pressed a hand to his forehead. "How much do you love playing games? Can't you be professional?"

"A more professional disguise? Do you like Count Dracula? I'm in touch with several prominent vampire fan clubs in London."

Henkel was silent for a long time. He poured a glass of strong tequila and handed it to the guest. "Actually, I prefer Cleopatra. If you don't mind, next time come naked and covered in gold powder."

"I never imagined a man your age had such exotic tastes!" The guest chuckled. "All right, I was eating KFC takeout and borrowed the bag. It isn't time to show my face yet, is it? It wouldn't benefit either of us."

"Everyone allowed into this room can be trusted."

"When in history has an intelligence leak come from anyone but someone trusted?"

Henkel paused. "You have a point. You heard what Anjou said. Should we believe him, especially about the dragon bones?"

"It sounds as though he concealed nothing. He has one set of dragon bones. There should have been two, but the other sank in the Three Gorges Reservoir and couldn't be recovered. The Board of Trustees has asked for the bones, but Anjou hasn't handed them over."

"So many people are interested in dragon bones." Henkel smiled. "But apart from using them to make the Philosopher's Stone, nobody knows their true value, do they? They supposedly contain a Dragon King's power, but how does one open that treasure house?"

"If no one has the key, all you can do is dig up the whole treasure house and bury it in your own backyard, so you'll be first when the day comes that it can be opened."

"Where is their next target?"

The man shook his head. "No definite news. But the Executive Department has clearly been very active lately. The latest word is that a top-secret document has just arrived at the college from China,

only to be sent straight on to the Board of Trustees. The next target is probably in China too. They've consistently promoted Chinese-language education and trained a team fluent in Chinese. That can't have been just for the Three Gorges operation."

"China? Keep watching, then." Henkel nodded. "I'm also very interested in Lu Mingfei."

"An utterly ordinary freshman, now a sophomore, in the throes of a troublesome adolescence. His luck has always been good, and what he needs most at present is a girlfriend."

"Does he have a special background? Something incredible happened at the auction. Before he entered, his account held only two million in collateral. Yet he boldly bid up to twenty million. We had to suspend the auction and check his ability to pay. The first check still showed only two million. When he requested a second... in ten seconds his balance shot up to a hundred and two million dollars. He immediately raised the price to a hundred million and bought the alchemical blades. After the hammer fell, Cassell College transferred a hundred million to us. Remember, the payment did not come from Lu Mingfei's account. But when we checked his account then, it held only two million again." Henkel was silent for a moment. "As if someone had advanced him a hundred million in collateral exactly when he needed it!"

"Was the bank's computer system hacked? Or Anjou advanced the hundred million. Anjou can still command that much money."

Henkel shook his head. "Neither. The computer system was entirely normal, and Cassell College didn't back Lu Mingfei. The people who supported him were an enormous crowd: individual stock investors. In those ten seconds, twenty-five million retail investors in markets from the Americas to Europe and Asia each transferred four dollars from their accounts to Lu Mingfei, totaling a hundred million. After the auction, the money automatically went back. In other words, when he needed money, the whole world donated to him, twenty-five million streams of cash converging on him; when he didn't need it, the money returned automatically. Its withdrawal caused the indices of the world's major stock markets, from the Dow Jones Industrial Average to London's Financial Times index, to fall 0.000001 percent simultaneously, in exchange for Lu Mingfei's instant fortune."

The man thought for a long time, then shook his head. "It sounds more like a hacker, but breaking into twenty-five million retail accounts worldwide would require enormous server resources. I don't think any hacker group in the world has that technology."

"No, it wasn't like a hacker. It was like... the hand of God... shifting the balance of wealth." Henkel spoke softly. "Make monitoring Lu Mingfei a priority from now on."

"Understood. If there's nothing else, I'll be going." The man played with his glass of tequila. A curled butterfly larva floated in the brown liquor. "Henkel, you must have been one incredibly cool cowboy back then. Even your choice of liquor is so Western."

"From the town of Tequila, made from genuine blue agave. Top quality." Henkel pushed a silver dish of fine salt and lemon slices toward him. "Try it."

"If I'd known there'd be drinking, I'd have dressed as Zorro," the man said regretfully. "Colonel Sanders is rather inconvenient."

He carefully tore the mouth hole in the bag wider, deftly sprinkled salt on the web between his left thumb and forefinger, picked up a slice of lemon, and raised the glass in his right hand. Gazing at the curled larva in the brown liquor, he took a deep breath. "A real man's drink!"

He sucked the lemon, licked the salt clean, and threw back his head. The entire glass of tequila went down, after which he spat the worm into the silver dish with a loud, forceful sound.

"Ah!" He wriggled with pleasure. "Like a fireball rolling into my stomach!"

"You do love performing. Now turn into a ball and roll out of here, and don't forget to close the door," Henkel said mildly. "And a reminder: you'd better find something else to cover your face. Your bag is about to tear."

"How could that defeat me?" The guest turned the bag, moving the tear to the back of his head and bringing the intact rear side over his face.

"See you next time, Sheriff Henkel." He rose, gave an awkward imitation of a Texas Ranger's salute, and turned to leave.

With a bang, he walked into the doorpost.

"Forgot to cut eyeholes... damn it!" he muttered, feeling his way out.

Henkel stared silently out the window and began to wonder whether entrusting the future of hybrids to an idiot like that was courage or insanity.

The Maserati raced down the highway with its hardtop open. An old man and a young one wore sunglasses as sunshine and wind poured over their faces.

"Give this to the Academic Affairs Committee. They'll excuse you from the makeup exam." Anjou handed Lu Mingfei a hastily scribbled note.

"That's enough?" Lu Mingfei took the paper on which his GPA depended. It was just a note, without even a personal seal.

"This is special authorization from the principal." Anjou glanced at him. "I rarely exercise this privilege, so the board won't question my fairness as an educator."

"Principal, you look awfully serious..." Lu Mingfei cautiously studied Anjou, then glanced at the back seat, where the heavy black hard case held alchemical weapons worth a hundred million dollars.

They were like two great thieves who had stolen the Dragon-Slaying Saber, the weapon that commanded the world, from the Lion-Slaying Assembly at Shaolin Temple and were fleeing on swift horses. Shouldn't they be laughing triumphantly? Yet after an old friend called the originally excited principal away for a drink, his face had remained expressionless.

"Those people who call themselves old friends will soon become our enemies." Anjou understood what Lu Mingfei was thinking. "If we can kill all Four Monarchs... I mean if. The day the last Dragon King falls in a pool of blood... will be the day hybrids go to war with one another."

"War? But we're all brothers and sisters..."

"Dragons aren't very sentimental about their own kind. Though Constantine and Norton seemed to have strong brotherly affection, more dragons kill one another. Dragon blood is the strongest genetic inheritance in the history of evolution. Its nature is a struggle to the death. Only the dragons with the finest bloodlines survive, improving their genetic advantage step by step. We inherited that nature too; you just haven't noticed it yet."

"Then I'd rather not notice. As a coward, discovering that my genes say the winner takes all would be a tragedy!"

"Can't you have a little self-respect? You're our only S-rank!" Anjou smiled helplessly. "We've already put you forward. This auction was your first step onto the hybrid social stage, and you've made a deep impression. Soon hybrid families all over the world will know that an exceptional new descendant has appeared. His name is Lu Mingfei."

Lu Mingfei froze for a second, then bristled. "Hey! I was just a plant this time, right? A plant doesn't need everyone he tricks to remember his name, does he?"

He understood the old man's sinister intentions. This was no opportunity to make a name for himself; it was a pit of fire through and through.

Soon every reptile in the world would know Lu Mingfei was Cassell College's new ace. What did being an ace mean? Take Guan Yunchang of the Three Kingdoms, Brother Guan: famous everywhere, Liu Bei's most capable subordinate, one of the most dangerous outlaws of his day. Every outlaw in the land wanted to kill him but didn't dare. Even Cao Cao gave him a thumbs-up. He was unbelievably cool. But after decades of glory, he died, ambushed by some nobody. He had survived so long because he truly had ability. If Jiang Gan had been the ace... he wouldn't even have reached Maicheng; he'd have died crossing the five passes and slaying six generals!

Compared with Brother Guan, Lu Mingfei didn't mind admitting he was more like Jiang Gan. Jiang Gan had it good: Zhou Yu didn't kill him when he came as a persuader, and Cao Cao didn't kill him when he stole false intelligence.

No wonder the invitation carried his real name. It wasn't that the college couldn't be bothered inventing an alias. They had planned all along to use this opportunity to make the name Ricardo M. Lu known.

"Like dragons, hybrids take pride in superior bloodlines. Every family introduces its finest descendants to everyone. The more exceptional heirs it has, the more respect it receives. We finally discovered an S-rank in you, so naturally we had to put you forward," Anjou said. "Like presenting the family's most beautiful young lady to society."

Lu Mingfei wanted to smash his head into the airbag in front of him and make it deploy around his face.

"Principal, assigning me S-rank really wasn't just messing with me?" Lu Mingfei looked miserable.

"Of course not. I wouldn't joke about that." Anjou gave him a meaningful look. "Your S-rank was determined from the purity of your parents' bloodlines."

"Mom and Dad?" Something trembled quietly inside Lu Mingfei. He hadn't seen them for years. He said he expected nothing of the two unreliable people, but deep down he missed them. Whenever they came up, he couldn't keep playing the fool.

The speeding Maserati suddenly slowed. Anjou pulled into a highway rest area, lit a fresh cigar, drew deeply, and blew smoke toward the clear blue sky.

"You don't remember much about your parents, do you?" Anjou gazed into the distance.

"Not much. I was about twelve when they left home and never came back." Lu Mingfei seemed lost in thought. "They worked at a geological institute then and traveled a lot, always for a long time, leaving me home alone. When I was little, I ate at a hundred families' tables."

"A hundred families' tables?"

"A meal at one house, then a meal at another."

Anjou nodded. "Did you resent them?"

"Not really. When I was little, I thought my parents traveled all over the world for work and were a hundred times cooler than anyone else's. To me they were Indiana Jones; roaming the world was what they were supposed to do... Later I realized pride doesn't put food on the table. No matter how impressive your parents are, it means nothing if they can't pick you up from school." Lu Mingfei scratched his head.

"Indiana Jones?" Anjou smiled silently. "No. They were far more than Indiana Jones. Lu Lincheng and Qiao Weini had the purest bloodlines we had discovered before Chu Zihang... Both were S-rank."

"No way! Didn't you say there hadn't been an S-rank student in years?" Lu Mingfei was bewildered. Three S-ranks in one family sounded like a party that could sweep any dungeon!

"Your parents only took advanced studies at Cassell College. They weren't technically students, only alumni. And their records have always been confidential; very few people know. You know that once the proportion of dragon genes exceeds human genes, a hybrid visibly undergoes dragon transformation, becoming more dragon than human. In other words, once bloodline purity passes a certain threshold, the critical blood threshold, a powerful friend can instantly become a powerful enemy. When we first discovered your parents, they resonated extremely strongly with Draconic. We were all worried their bloodline purity exceeded the critical blood threshold. You hadn't been born then, but you were already in your mother's womb. We had to decide whether to let you be born..."

"Hey! Principal, isn't that going too far? I was their first child. Even family planning wouldn't have had anything to say about me!" Lu Mingfei protested at once. He had obviously made it safely through that dangerous embryonic period, but the thought that someone had once voted on whether he should be born still frightened him. What kind of cold-blooded killers had cast those votes?

"It was a very serious vote. Before you were born, even our most experienced bloodline professors didn't know whether you would be a dragon."

"You said... a dragon?" Lu Mingfei wondered if he'd heard wrong.

"Yes. Not a true pure-blooded dragon, but a hybrid with such a high proportion of dragon blood that they display a dragon's appearance. We also call them dragons. Usually hybrids don't have very pure dragon blood, and when they have children together, those children are human in form. But in extremely rare cases, when two hybrids with exceptionally pure dragon blood have a child, a 'purification effect' can occur. It's like the pharaohs of ancient Egypt often marrying their sisters: both possessed noble royal blood, and their offspring were believed to be more divine. Although modern genetics considers it dangerous, it is indeed possible to produce a child whose bloodline purity exceeds the critical blood threshold. In that case you would very likely show dragon characteristics..."

"I've got horns on my head... and a tail behind me?" Trembling, Lu Mingfei reached back to feel his backside.

Anjou stared. "What are you doing?"

"I remember my tailbone has stuck out a bit ever since I was little... I don't know if it's a tail that never grew in or something..."

"Can you stop talking nonsense on a serious occasion?"

"Sometimes being nervous just makes me talk more..."

Anjou shook his head. "In any case, statistically, because of your parents' highly pure bloodlines, you really might have been a dragon. Although morally it would have been cruel to destroy an unknown life, you know the Secret Party has never been particularly reasonable... The point was that we dared not risk allowing a dragon to be born, and the votes for and against were evenly divided. Finally your mother stood up. Her words, as a woman, were supremely sacred. When she spoke, her beauty as a woman astonished everyone there. She said, 'This child is the treasure of my life. If I lose him, I don't know how I can face the rest of it. I am willing to give birth alone in a sealed glass chamber, without a nurse or doctor's help. You may watch from outside. If I give birth to a dragon, you have the right to destroy both mother and child.'"

Lu Mingfei stared blankly up at the sky, imagining the woman's incomparable beauty at that moment, so beautiful that even hard-hearted men lowered their heads and dared not look directly at her.

"At the time, it seemed the least risky method. Some dragons are highly mobile before they leave the womb and can even use Yanling. Once born, they might escape before anyone could stop them, and the midwives would be their first targets. A young dragon could kill them the instant it opened its eyes," Anjou said. "Her strength and beauty had almost persuaded us. Then a man stood up and said, 'No!'"

"Who was so inconsiderate?" Lu Mingfei felt indignant.

Anjou smiled. "Your father. He said, 'I will deliver my wife's baby. I'll start practicing the technique right now. My wife must not give birth alone!' He also said, 'I want an opaque empty chamber as the delivery room. You can strap bombs to the outside and hold the detonator at a distance. If she gives birth to a dragon, I'll sound the alarm immediately; please detonate the bombs. I can die... but I cannot allow other men to watch my wife give birth!'"

"That's my dad, all right! What a man!" Lu Mingfei was so moved he nearly cried.

Anjou patted his shoulder. "Your parents staked their lives on their insistence, and so you were finally born into this world like any other child. If you once blamed them for not taking good care of you, perhaps now you can forgive them. They were willing to do anything for you, from changing your diapers to dying for you."

Lu Mingfei reclined in the racing seat, gazing up at the sky. After a long silence, he said, "They never told me any of that."

"Often that's how it is. You do a great deal for the person you love most, and they don't know, because you think it's only right and forget to tell them." Anjou breathed out smoke and sighed. "But we still couldn't rest easy. From birth you were a little white mouse under observation. We watched you for eighteen years and dispatched our finest observers."

Lu Mingfei's eyes widened. Observers? Had such people really appeared in his life? Had mysterious agents in black suits and sunglasses followed him from childhood?

"They all had disguises. Some seemed to be teachers at your school, some people selling newspaper subscriptions door to door, some from the electric company..."

"I knew that meter reader looked shifty! He looked everywhere as soon as he came in. So he really was up to no good!" Lu Mingfei suddenly understood.

"You are our hope. Others may think I protect you in a peculiar way. But to me you're a young man worth believing in, just like exceptional descendants such as Caesar and Chu Zihang," Anjou said.

"I've watched you for eighteen years, like... Have you seen a Chinese cartoon called Calabash Brothers?"

Lu Mingfei covered his face. "Something strange has slipped into our serious conversation... Okay, I get it. You're the old man who grows the gourds. Now, crack, the gourd splits and I jump out, with the powers of acting like an idiot and playing StarCraft, and you send me off to fight monsters? But Principal, are you really sure two exceptional hybrids produce an exceptional hybrid?"

"Hmm." Anjou considered. "It is possible the result could be a defective product, for example if you inherited all your parents' junk genes."

"Hey... even if it's true, could you not use 'defective product'? It's bad for my self-esteem."

"But you're not defective. Your bloodline test results were beyond first-rate. Your blood could even make the living spirit guarding the Bronze City retreat. You're the one we've been waiting for!" Anjou said. "With great power comes great responsibility."

"Suddenly we've switched from Calabash Brothers to Spider-Man... But Principal, I really don't think I'm suited to the great work of saving the world. The bloodline test, the Bronze City and all that... were just good luck." Lu Mingfei thought, One burst of power costs me a quarter of my life. Do you think I'm a nine-lived cat? Could this be my Yanling? Like a strange character in a game party: everyone else spends mana, but this guy's ultimate move consumes his health bar. When it's empty, he drops dead and the boss is blasted down too. The ending shows everyone laying white flowers at his gravestone while lovers confess their feelings to each other.

"Mingfei, have you ever thought about your reason for living in this world?" Anjou drew deeply on his cigar.

Lu Mingfei hesitated, then said cautiously, "If I said it was for the games I haven't played, the serials I haven't finished... and the girlfriend I haven't picked up yet... would you kick me out of the car?"

"Does the girlfriend you haven't picked up mean Chen Motong, the girl who always likes to wear red?"

"Hey! Principal! Could you not bring up the one thing I don't want to talk about? Let's go back to your deep philosophical subject! Continue with why we live in this world!" Lu Mingfei blushed and tried to stand his ground.

"Oh." Anjou nodded, eyes distant, as if his thoughts had flown to the far end of time. "When I was at Cambridge, people's tastes were different. Girls wore long white silk dresses and Oxford-style high heels with white soles. I'd stand by the Bridge of Sighs holding a book of poetry, pretending to read while I watched the girls walk past and waited for the wind to lift their white silk skirts." The old man blew out a thread of smoke, a look of longing on his face. "And reveal their lovely calves. Oh, heavens! Wonderful! At the time, I thought I lived for that sight!"

"Hey! What's philosophical or deep about that? You're just as bad as me!"

"But now they're all dead. Sometimes I bring a bouquet of white roses to visit their graves," the old man said wistfully.

"Hey! How did all that tender feeling mix so naturally with the leering from a moment ago?"

The old man ignored him and went on. "I still often return to Cambridge, but there's no one on campus I know anymore, and time has erased all evidence that I once studied there. I can't exactly take

out my old diploma and tell people I graduated from Cambridge Divinity School in 1897. They'd think I was mad, or a monster. When I speak with people, I say I'm only a tourist who dreamed of Cambridge when I was young. I walk alone through campus, watching students pass in T-shirts and sneakers with all kinds of handheld electronic devices. They no longer discuss poetry, religion, and art, but devote themselves to finding jobs in the City of London. And what of the things I cherished? The girls I admired? Their lovely white silk dresses and Oxford-style heels with white soles? The linden tree beneath whose shade we discussed Shelley's poems? They're all history in old photographs. I pass the young people like a lonely ghost who has traveled a hundred years."

Anjou paused. "How do you understand blood sorrow?"

Lu Mingfei stared. Blood sorrow? He had never understood it. Guderian said hybrids lived in the human world as sadly as lost lambs, but Lu Mingfei had always thought that was nonsense. Sad about what? That ordinary people couldn't use Yanling and you could? Hilarious! If he had Caesar's Kamaitachi, he only had to prick up his ears and listen to a girl's heart rate when she spoke to him to know if she liked him. Chu Zihang's Sovereign Flame would do too: a portable gas burner. At a picnic he could hold a pan in one hand and make fried rice while using the other to heat water for tea.

What sorrow? Why be sad because you have more than other people? People are only sad when others have something they don't, aren't they? Like when someone picks everyone else up in a car on a rainy day while you pull off your clothes to cover your head and run home; or when a father and mother sit behind everyone else at a parent-teacher meeting like a pair of door gods while you have an empty white wall behind you; or when someone's whole family sees them off abroad, holding hands and gazing tearfully at one another at security, passionately embracing a girlfriend and promising to meet again in summer, while you drag a huge suitcase through the long security line alone...

Come to think of it... his life really was miserable.

He used to read The Legend of the Condor Heroes in class. When the great master Huang Yaoshi saw his disobedient daughter insist on remaining with the foolish Guo Jing, he remembered his dead wife, waved a hand and killed two fine horses, then, overcome by sorrow, chanted a famous line from the Western Han scholar Jia Yi's 'Ode to the Owl': "Heaven and earth are the furnace, creation the smith; yin and yang are the charcoal, all things the bronze." Han Baoju, a mediocre swordsman with a considerable reputation, didn't understand and asked his brother Zhu Cong what the old fellow was on about. Zhu Cong had some education and explained that the old man meant life was an ordeal, like being roasted in a great furnace, and he was very sad. Han Baoju was contemptuous. Damn it! The old man was so powerful; what could he possibly have to be unhappy about?

Nine people out of ten would probably think Han Baoju uncultured. Only Lu Mingfei thought he was right. Old hero Huang Yaoshi was so literary and so easily saddened; would he trade places with Han Baoju if he had the chance? Han Baoju was thick-skinned and cheerful, loyal to his good brothers until he died, merely a little lacking in martial skill. If old hero Huang wouldn't trade, that meant his sadness was hypocritical.

What was this about the strongest being the loneliest? Lonely people were all putting on airs. If you always struck a lonely pose, it was because you hadn't suffered enough loneliness yet and still thought the pose looked cool.

Truly lonely people never think about it. If you're already terribly lonely and can't save yourself, all you can do is not think. But Lu Mingfei didn't yet understand that then... Late at night he sat on the

rooftop, looking toward the distant lights, imagining the day he would become amazing, and grinned foolishly in silence.

Anjou lapsed into a long reverie until the cigar butt burned his hand.

"Whenever I fly over London, I look down for the River Cam, then follow it to the Bridge of Sighs... Do you know how the bridge got its name? A hundred years ago, Cambridge had a rule that students who broke college rules were punished by being made to think beside the bridge. We always sighed while we thought." Anjou ran his tongue over his teeth, then suddenly smiled with unusual delight. "Do you think I'm contradicting myself? I lament that Cambridge is no longer what it was, yet say I'm still attached to it."

"I didn't understand, in any case," Lu Mingfei admitted honestly.

"Today's Cambridge is only a ghost of the Cambridge of a hundred years ago, but I still find myself returning again and again. Standing there, I still feel warm. I can faintly sense the air of a hundred years ago, and the white silk dresses and Oxford-style heels with white soles in my memory become vivid again." Anjou spoke softly. "I have no family. My best friends are all dead. Even among hybrids I've lived to a sadly great age. There isn't much left in this world for me to cherish. What if I kill all the Dragon Kings? Will my Cambridge reappear? Will my friends come back to life? Will the girls I admired jump from their graves, divorce their husbands, who have also become bones, and come running into my arms? Wearing my favorite long white silk dresses and Oxford-style heels? Even I feel the meaning of my life has ebbed away with time. My reason for living in this world is too fragile."

The old man drew fiercely on his cigar, sharp lines appearing at the corners of his eyes. "But I still cannot allow the dragons to destroy all this. If they destroy Cambridge, I will have nowhere left to remember. If they destroy Cassell College, I will have betrayed the trust of my friends in the Lionheart Society. If they destroy the graves of the girls I loved in secret, I will fight them with my life. Because these last things that give my life meaning... elusive as reflections shimmering in the light... are all I have left!" He forcefully spat the cigar butt out of the car. "If anyone dares touch my last piece of cream cake, how could I not fight them with my life?"

Lu Mingfei was stunned.

Damn! He'd never imagined... the old man was such a fiercely lonely man! He drove luxury cars, wore custom suits, and carried beautiful young women on his arm, attracting attention like an absurdly elderly playboy. Yet when that ferocity emerged, he was as intimidating as the folding knife he never put down.

"Mingfei, what about your reason? What fragile reason has kept you from suddenly deciding to jump off the rooftop one day while enjoying the cool air?" Anjou raised an eyebrow.

"What do you mean? Jump off?"

"Everyone has a reason to go on living. That's why we don't get high and jump off a building or something."

"Isn't the girlfriend I haven't picked up enough?"

"Not enough!"

"Then what about Dynasty Warriors 6 and StarCraft II, which haven't come out yet?"

"Still not enough!"

"All right, I'll be serious. I really do want to see my parents again, even though they've been pretty lousy to me and haven't come back to see me for years..."

"Still not enough!" Anjou smiled mysteriously. "The meaning of life... is those things that flash through your mind when you're about to die..."

He suddenly started the engine and floored the accelerator. The Maserati reared like a shark leaping from the water, its rear tires pouring smoke against the road. Lu Mingfei and his scream were both pressed into the racing seat by the mad acceleration. This was the car at full power: in half a minute it approached four hundred kilometers per hour, a speed Caesar's Bugatti could reach. Driving at that speed on an ordinary highway was like firing an aircraft cannon shell from an old hunting rifle! The highway, previously sparsely traveled, suddenly became crowded. At that speed, passing one car meant quickly encountering the next. The Maserati swept past one vehicle after another in uncanny arcs. The terrified drivers honked behind them, their horns stretched out by the speed and rapidly left behind. To a Ferrari traveling at two hundred kilometers an hour, the Maserati passing it was like that Ferrari passing a stationary pedestrian: the relative speed was two hundred kilometers an hour!

The maniacs in the Equipment Department had tuned it! No doubt about it!

Lu Mingfei should have thought of it. Anjou's Yanling was Time Zero, which extended the effect of time. Once he activated it, this speed would be nowhere near enough, about like a bicycle.

How could a mad old man who loved driving fast and possessed that Yanling have anything but a beast that ran on the edge of losing control for a car?

But at this moment Lu Mingfei had lost the ability to reason. He couldn't count how often he thought they were about to hit the car ahead, or how often he thought a rapid lane change would throw him out. Light and shadows swirled before his eyes; his brain was starved of blood.

That old man Anjou... put on sunglasses and loudly sang some old song into the sunshine!

Wasn't this the old man's life? More than a hundred and thirty years spent always rushing generously toward death, always charging ahead at high speed without knowing when he would hit a wall and be smashed to pieces. Once accustomed to it, he could sing loudly without fear.

"Do you feel the past rushing at you, Mingfei? See that slow old Beetle ahead? We're about to hit it! Think quickly!" The old man laughed.

Damn it! He really was trying, but nothing came. His mind was blank... What moment in this trashy life was he most reluctant to leave behind?

The rooftop at Aunt's house? He had sat there in the quiet of the night, staring at a sea of lights and imagining someone would take him to see a whole new world one day. But could he still go back?

Those sunny afternoons, Chen Wenwen reading on a bench in her almost transparent white cotton dress? But what did any of that have to do with Lu Mingfei?

Nono stepping out of her diving suit beneath the Three Gorges. Oh! In a bikini, enough to give a man a nosebleed! But the girl, her magnificent figure, and even her swimsuit all belonged to the boss on the ship above!

Was there really nothing else to think about? Was his life made up of these fragments? Nothing worth clinging to. Everything he longed for or thought about was either a daydream or somebody else's girlfriend. In that case... getting drunk and jumping off a building wasn't entirely out of the question...

Suddenly a fresh, exuberant green rushed toward him like a boundless forest. Sunlight filtered through the leaves, illuminating Lu Mingfei's eyes. His pupils widened and his whole body trembled as if an electric current passed through him. Once again he saw the old house where he'd lived as a child, new tendrils of ivy covering the window, sunlight filtered green before it was allowed into the room. He was a little boy waiting for his parents to come home from work. Another little boy stood beside him, holding his head...

"Brother, you have to live," the child said softly. "We all have to live. Life is the only... everything we have!"

Lu Mingze!

Damn it! What was going on? That was his childhood! When had this little devil invaded even that? And delivered such a corny, ridiculous, tragic line, while the two boys embraced? Damn! It made him want to puke!

But suddenly his tears began to fall, and he didn't know why.

Suddenly he was so very sad.

"Our fire... will set the whole world... alight!" Lu Mingze whispered.

The Maserati slowed gently and pulled over. The old man glanced at Lu Mingfei, handed him two tissues, and took out a fresh cigar. "Looks like you felt something! But you don't have to tell me. Everyone has a reason to live. Once you've understood it, just remember it. We fight the dragons for these fragile reasons. Fragile, yes, but they're all we have."

Lu Mingfei wiped his face and nodded. "Damn! That was embarrassing."

Thinking about it, it really wasn't fair. Plenty of people in the world had ten or a hundred times more than he did: houses, cars, girlfriends, wonderful lives lived to the fullest every day, not to mention bright futures. Yet a guy with nothing like him had to save the world. Shouldn't those with money give money and those with strength give strength? While he risked his life, Zhao Menghua was somewhere holding Liu Miaomiao around her slender waist. Why should he make such an effort?

But suddenly he was so, so unwilling to accept it! Our fire... will set the whole world... alight?

Act Nine

The Fall of Midgard

Roller Coaster Falling Down

Above their heads, iron-black rails rose steeply into the air, as high as a fifty-story building, twisting like the body of an enormous snake before plunging back down. A train of roller-coaster cars climbed to the summit amid its passengers' screams, slowing almost to a stop. Ahead lay a sheer drop like the edge of a cliff. The riders held their breath, too frightened to scream as the precipice crept nearer, like people on the guillotine waiting for the blade to fall.

"That's the Midgard Serpent, the world's most thrilling high-speed roller coaster. One hundred fifty meters high, with a top speed of two hundred fifty kilometers an hour," Anjou said.

Chu Zihang gazed out over the sunlit amusement park: Six Flags. In a park devoted to thrills and excitement, roller coasters were everywhere. Train after steel train raced across tracks that crisscrossed the sky, while screams rose and fell. He, meanwhile, sat on what was probably the least thrilling attraction in the place: the Ferris wheel. The leisurely contraption had taken fifteen minutes to lift their two-person gondola to the top. From here the mountains curved as gracefully as a young woman's figure, a pleasure to look at.

"Now it's time for your entrance orientation." Chu Zihang looked away from the view, his expression solemn.

"But, senior... we're on a Ferris wheel!" Xia Mi's eyes widened in surprise, like an Ultraman on patrol suddenly encountering a little monster. A slender, soft lock of hair bobbed before her bright eyes.

"Yes. I chose the Ferris wheel deliberately. Our entrance orientation has to take place away from crowds. This gondola seats two, we're fifty meters above the ground, and we'll remain here for ten minutes. That's enough time for me to finish."

Xia Mi covered her face. "And here I thought my beauty had finally opened your eyes... Hey! Do you know what taking a girl on a Ferris wheel means?"

Chu Zihang's cold face twitched slightly. It was not inner turmoil but alarm: he realized there might indeed be gaps in his knowledge.

"Is a Ferris wheel... different from the other rides?" he asked cautiously.

"Do you know the three sacred places for a date?" Xia Mi sighed.

Chu Zihang shook his head. He had studied books on female psychology and knew something about women's hormone secretion during romance. But the "three sacred places"...

"The movies, the aquarium, and the Ferris wheel." Xia Mi counted them off on her fingers.

Chu Zihang's expression grew even worse as memories came back to him. In high school, to thank the cheerleading captain for cheering them on at a basketball game against another school, he had taken her to a movie. Naturally, once he had repaid the favor, he had not contacted her again. Afterward, the girl who always wore a short skirt and a high ponytail seemed to look at him with

reproach in her eyes, though he could not quite understand why. He had also taken the head of Shilan High's dance troupe to an aquarium and explained how male seahorses raise their young in brood pouches. She had giggled the whole way, looking almost delirious. Chu Zihang had taken her because they were working together on an extracurricular paper about marine animals. Once it was finished, he had not contacted her again...

"A movie theater is dark, so a girl naturally feels she can depend on the boy. And during a horror movie he has the perfect excuse to hold her hand! Taking her to an aquarium makes you look refined and fond of animals. Girls like caring boys, and in a blue underwater tunnel, there's a mysterious feeling that the two of you are alone together in another world. A Ferris wheel is the best place to confess your feelings. Nobody can interrupt you, and the girl can't run away. When you reach the top, pull out the rose you've prepared, get down on one knee, and confess! You have a whole ten minutes. For a boy who knows how to talk, ten minutes is enough to move a sea turtle to tears!" Teacher Xia Mi instructed him earnestly.

"Why would you want to move a sea turtle?" A little sweat appeared at Chu Zihang's temple.

"That's not the point!" Xia Mi looked embarrassed. "The point is, a Ferris wheel is romantic! You can't bring up unpleasant subjects in a romantic place."

"Does... entrance orientation count as an unpleasant subject?"

"Depends what you compare it with." Xia Mi shrugged.

Chu Zihang relaxed slightly. Apparently, it was not the most unpleasant subject, at least.

"Compared with taking out a dead spider, throwing it at a girl, and laughing your head off, entrance orientation isn't all that unpleasant," Xia Mi went on.

Chu Zihang looked as though he had just eaten the dead spider.

"Come to think of it, this is my first time coming to an amusement park with someone!" Xia Mi looked into the distance. Amid the screams, the dragonlike coaster thundered upward in a spiral, as if trying to escape gravity.

Chu Zihang was surprised. He was a regular at amusement parks. In "Dad's" view, nothing showed family affection better than a park festooned with colorful flags. Television commercials always showed some goofy kid wearing a clown's red nose, with a "successful, loving dad" on one side and a "gentle, virtuous mom" on the other. The three would grin foolishly at the camera, and click, a photograph would capture them against a backdrop of bright rides. "Dad" loved that feeling, just as he liked printing photographs of himself with his bosses and hanging them on the wall. So Chu Zihang had been made to pose for countless close-ups at amusement parks.

The other man's way of spending time with his son was to take him to a public bathhouse, drink Coke while soaking in cloudy water, and ask Chu Zihang to scrub his back.

"I've always wanted to come to an amusement park. I used to sneak here by myself, but it wasn't any fun." Xia Mi gripped the rail by the window, its shadow falling across her soft face. Her eyes were deep, hidden in the shade.

"Really?" Xia Mi did not strike Chu Zihang as a girl from a poor family, and a trip to an amusement park did not cost much.

"I have an older brother. He has an intellectual disability." Xia Mi pouted like a child. "He can't come to an amusement park. He can't go on any rides, and the staff would chase him away. Every

weekend Mom and Dad stayed home with him. If I wanted to go, I had to go alone, and who wants to walk around an amusement park by herself?"

"I thought you were spoiled at home," Chu Zihang said casually.

"Why?" Xia Mi asked.

Chu Zihang did not know how to answer. There was no particular reason. She simply seemed like the little-princess type, a little like Liu Miaomiao. What parents would not dote on a daughter like that? She seemed born for parents to show off proudly to everyone else. Her smile looked as though it could radiate sunshine.

"We're twins. My brother was born six hours before me. I wouldn't come out, and the doctors and nurses were so worried about me that they forgot to look after him. He couldn't breathe and was deprived of oxygen for half an hour, so he ended up disabled," Xia Mi said. "Mom and Dad said he gave his chance to me. He could have been smart and outstanding too. So I was supposed to do better than everyone else, because half of my share belonged to him... No matter how hard I worked, nobody praised me..." Xia Mi stuck out her tongue. "Oh, a young master like you wouldn't understand. Did your mom and dad come to your parent-teacher meetings?"

Chu Zihang nodded. "Dad" regarded parent-teacher meetings as important occasions to display family harmony. He and Mom always arrived looking splendid, treating the teachers as solemnly as they would investors.

"But mine hardly ever came. I'd been top of my class since I was little, so they weren't impressed anymore. In my first year of high school, I won a gold medal in the Math Olympiad. I ran home excited to tell them, but the house was a mess. Furniture had been knocked over, clothes and quilts were everywhere, and every few steps I treaded on torn cloth and stuffing. Nobody was home. I couldn't reach them on their phones, so I sat in the middle of the mess and waited until I fell asleep. Mom and Dad didn't get back until morning. They said my brother had gotten upset somehow, banging his head against the wall and tearing things apart. They got a lot of people to help take him to the hospital, where he was given a sedative, and stayed with him all night." Xia Mi hugged her knees, lost in thought. "They were exhausted. They told me what had happened to him and went to bed. Nobody asked how I'd spent the night, and nobody cared that I'd won."

"You... don't like your brother?" Chu Zihang asked.

"No, I love him. Maybe because we spent ten months together in Mom's belly, he's very attached to me. When he can't calm down and Mom and Dad don't know what to do, all I have to do is talk to him and he settles down. That time he lost his temper because I was staying at school for extra lessons before the Olympiad, and he never saw me. He thought Mom and Dad had hidden me, so he got angry. It wasn't really an episode. Later, when I went to see him at the hospital, he was lying in bed staring hard at the ceiling, refusing to sleep. But the moment he saw me, his eyes changed. I gave him my hand to hold, and he sniffed it. Once he was sure I smelled and looked right, that I really was his little sister, he held my hand and fell asleep." Xia Mi smiled. "He's just like a puppy. Could you ever dislike your own puppy?"

"I can't have a dog. Mom is allergic to cat and dog hair." Chu Zihang apologetically explained that he had never had the chance to become attached to an animal.

"I hate it when people bully him. When we were little, I took him out shopping. Everyone looked at him with disgust, asking what sort of irresponsible parents would let a little girl take an idiot out by

herself. He may be slow, but he's very sensitive. He clutched my skirt and glared fiercely at them. Their stares made me uncomfortable, and suddenly I felt ashamed of him too. On the way home I wouldn't let him come near me. I told him to follow ten meters behind, and if he came closer, I wouldn't speak to him. He was afraid of that, so he followed me, keeping exactly ten meters away. I was upset and walked fast without looking back. After a while I turned around and couldn't find him. I was so frightened I ran back. I found him in an alley, pinned to the ground by a group of people who were beating him. Their leader was a boy from my school who I knew wanted to date me. When he saw me, he hurried to say he'd been passing by and noticed an idiot sneaking along behind me, staring at my legs with a nasty grin. So he'd called a few friends to pin him down, but the idiot was very strong and they'd had a hard time of it. They hadn't even had time to say hello to me." Xia Mi sighed. "I saw my brother in the middle of the crowd, his face covered in blood and dirt. When he saw me, he started grinning, even with a foot on his face. I felt so awful... I told him I wasn't angry with him, and he could hit them back."

"What did you mean?"

"He's very strong. All those people together couldn't beat him. But I'd forbidden him to hit people whenever he liked. If he hit someone, I wouldn't speak to him for a month..." Xia Mi said. "So he knocked all the boys flat, and I let him hold the hem of my skirt again and took him home. Those idiots never understood why he kept looking at my legs. He was really looking at my skirt, because he always followed me holding the hem."

"You're very good to your brother."

"But sometimes I wish he'd never been born," Xia Mi said softly. "Then he wouldn't have had to suffer so much."

"If he could come to an amusement park, I bet he'd be happy." Xia Mi fell into thought again.

Chu Zihang sat there blankly, unsure what to say. He did not know why Xia Mi had told him about her family, and in truth he did not particularly want to know.

Everyone had things they kept hidden in their hearts, didn't they? Like the "absolute territory" in EVA, an absolute domain of the soul where no one else was welcome. In his heart, for example, was a Maybach riddled with holes. When he woke suddenly from a dream, he often felt he was still sitting in that car, with rain pouring outside and that song playing over and over on the stereo. He never told anyone about it, because no one would understand. And if that was so, why tell them?

Some memories were unpleasant. You could bear the bitterness yourself; there was nothing worth sharing. Would anyone willingly sit with you in a broken car on a cold, bleak night and listen to the rain?

Really, Xia Mi need not have told him any of this either.

Of course, Chu Zihang had been moved a little. And, as Lu Mingfei said, sometimes he was a busybody who could not leave other people's affairs alone. If he had been in that alley years ago, he probably would not have stood by. Before the boys dragged Xia Mi's brother into the alley, he would have stepped in front of him, his face cold. If the boys wanted a fight, wonderful: Chu Zihang was a born killer. Then the thing that made Xia Mi unhappy would never have happened, and her brother could have followed her all the way home. Along the long lane, a girl in a white sundress edged with lace would walk, with her brother following behind, grinning foolishly.

But he had not been there. He had never shared his time with anyone, not even Susie. He had only sat alone in the Maybach on a rainy night, listening to an Irish folk song.

He felt he ought to break the awkward silence. He cleared his throat. "This is another form of blood sorrow. For people like us, coming together often stems from recognizing a shared bloodline and the loneliness of being unable to fit into society..."

"There you go again! We're still on the Ferris wheel! The weather's lovely and the view is great. Can't we talk about life and our dreams? I learned all that orientation stuff in prep school." Xia Mi glared at him.

"Dear passengers, you've talked quite enough about life and dreams. Your ten minutes are up. Welcome back to the ground." The gondola door suddenly opened, and a silver-haired old fellow outside bowed slightly like an attendant.

"P-Principal?" Chu Zihang and Xia Mi were both stunned.

Time seemed to have passed much faster than usual. The gondola had somehow returned to the ground, where Principal Anjou stood with Lu Mingfei, whose face was full of envy, jealousy, and resentment.

"I'm attending an event with Mingfei, and we had the afternoon free. Mingfei said he'd never been to Six Flags, and complained that we'd sent him to an event instead of letting him orient a pretty junior, so I brought him to have a look." Anjou patted Xia Mi's soft hand where it rested on his arm.

"I thought the principal would be some stuffy old man, but you actually eat mint ice cream? Mint is really trendy! They just introduced it." Xia Mi skipped along with her arm through Anjou's.

"Actually, I prefer lemon. But when you get old, you often regret how few new things remain in the life you have left, so you have to try whatever's newest." Anjou smiled happily. "Ah, walking with a pretty girl makes me feel much younger. I can feel passion flowing through my veins!"

"Cut the crap! That's the old man's long-dormant testosterone flowing, you bastard!" Lu Mingfei grumbled inwardly, following ten meters behind.

Anjou and Xia Mi walked arm in arm ahead, he eating a cup of mint ice-cream beads, she one with strawberry sauce. They looked inexplicably harmonious, like a grandfather and granddaughter. They had completely forgotten the two third wheels behind them, even neglecting to buy ice cream for Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang.

"Senior! He's stealing what you were supposed to guard!" Lu Mingfei nudged Chu Zihang with his shoulder. "I'm really not trying to stir things up, but if I were you, I couldn't stand that old guy stealing my girl right in front of me!"

He felt a little disappointed himself. Such a stunning junior was rare, and the expressionless senior had won her over with a hundred million dollars' worth of effort. Still, he had to admit that however you looked at it, Chu Zihang and Xia Mi were well matched: their looks, their bearing, and even their scholarly way of speaking.

"What's that got to do with me?" Chu Zihang kept a straight face.

A powerful wind swept past the backs of their heads with a thunderous vibration. The screams that followed nearly pierced their eardrums.

Above their heads, iron-black rails rose steeply into the air, as high as a fifty-story building, twisting like the body of an enormous snake before plunging back down. A train of roller-coaster cars

climbed to the summit amid its passengers' screams, slowing almost to a stop. Ahead lay a sheer drop like the edge of a cliff. The riders held their breath, too frightened to scream as the precipice crept nearer, like people on the guillotine waiting for the blade to fall.

"That's the Midgard Serpent, the world's most thrilling high-speed roller coaster. One hundred fifty meters high, with a top speed of two hundred fifty kilometers an hour," Anjou said.

The coaster entered the downward track, seemingly in free fall. Screams swept across the park again, startling a pigeon flying overhead so badly that its wings jerked and it nearly fell from the sky.

Lu Mingfei shuddered. He saw Xia Mi jump excitedly and point up at the sky.

"She can't be serious, can she? What kind of girl rides a roller coaster? You girls like things like Snow White's castle, right? You're happy just hugging Mickey Mouse for a photograph, right?" Lu Mingfei shouted inwardly, like a man reciting a spell.

"Let's ride that one!" Xia Mi said eagerly.

Lu Mingfei looked to Anjou for help. As an old fellow over 130, surely his heart wasn't up to it... Your life's ambition is to travel the world and kill every Dragon King, right? You don't want to die of a heart attack on a roller coaster before you achieve it, do you? Be brave and tell this crazy girl off! Tell her we should go see Snow White's castle instead!

"Ho! Now that's exciting!" Anjou rubbed his hands. "I can't wait!"

"Have you lost your mind? Aren't you afraid your heart will give out up there?" Lu Mingfei could barely catch his breath.

"Principal, you're amazing!" Xia Mi rested her head on Anjou's shoulder.

Lu Mingfei instinctively wanted to step back, but held himself in check. The roller coaster looked terrifying, but... losing your nerve in front of a pretty junior was a disgrace for life! Suddenly he noticed Chu Zihang had fallen a step behind. He turned and saw his expressionless senior staring at the enormous steel monster, his face twitching slightly.

"Could it be..." Lu Mingfei froze, and for some reason felt a little delighted.

Xia Mi turned around. "First Senior Brother, Second Senior Brother, come on!"

When had their titles changed to First and Second Senior Brother? Was this Journey to the West? Why did he suddenly feel like Zhu Bajie?

Xia Mi and Anjou had already rushed toward the end of the snaking line. Their excitement was apparently too great to contain; they hardly wanted to bother with the other two, and had invited them along only out of courtesy.

"Senior, I saw your face twitch," Lu Mingfei said under his breath.

"I get a little motion-sick," Chu Zihang said quietly.

"Come on. If you're scared, you're scared. Nothing to be ashamed of. Even if it is embarrassing, it won't kill you. Senior, just admit your favorite ride is really Snow White's castle, and we'll go there together... If you force yourself, neither of us will come out of it well!" Lu Mingfei coaxed him patiently, his face grave.

"My favorite attraction is actually Winnie the Pooh and His Friends."

"Hurry up!" Xia Mi waved at them from a distance.

"Yeah! Coming, coming!" Lu Mingfei smiled back instinctively. As soon as he had said it, he wanted to slap himself.

"Don't be silly. Neither Winnie the Pooh nor Snow White can save us now," Chu Zihang murmured.

Lu Mingfei fastened his safety restraint and glanced at Chu Zihang beside him. Chu Zihang gripped the handles over his shoulders, pale and staring straight ahead, as if a teacher had punished him for misbehaving by making him sit up straight. Anjou and Xia Mi had claimed the front row so they could enjoy the thrill of plunging headfirst toward the ground against the wind. Both had been eager and excited all along.

The launch tunnel was pitch-dark. Two rows of red lights flashed along the track, making the atmosphere inexplicably tenser. An attendant checked everyone's restraints. "Please keep your head firmly against the headrest to avoid straining your neck from the acceleration."

Damn it, couldn't they just say nothing? To mention neck injuries so casually... It was like an executioner gently telling you to relax your muscles before the blade fell, or your poop might fly out and make an ugly mess. A hundred Shaanxi waist-drum players were pounding away in Lu Mingfei's heart, and he knew there were a hundred in Chu Zihang's too. How he wished he had a Yanling like Star Platinum to cut out the next minute. In the blink of an eye the coaster would be at the end, and he could stand up calmly and say, "That was fun. I'd love to do it again, but the line takes too long. How about we go see Snow White's castle..."

The attendants withdrew into the darkness. An ominous alarm swept through the tunnel, and the red lights suddenly flashed ten times faster. Adrenaline surged.

Suddenly all the red lights went out! The alarm stopped! One suffocating second of dead silence.

Lu Mingfei felt as if he were riding a rocket, and the rocket had ignited! Acceleration pressed him hard into his seat. The wind pressure was so great his eyeballs seemed about to burst, even more extreme than Anjou's Maserati.

Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang could not help roaring. Everyone was screaming instinctively, unable to stop until every last breath had been forced from their lungs. Amid the screams came the laughter of Anjou and Xia Mi... which only made it more unbearable.

Light rushed at them as the coaster shot out of the launch tunnel at an astonishing 250 kilometers an hour. Ahead, the rising track was nearly vertical, like a ladder into the sky. Lu Mingfei felt certain they would smash into it and be pulverized. But the coaster began climbing and twisting vertically. White clouds in the blue sky spun rapidly across his vision, like a kaleidoscope.

It all felt unreal to Lu Mingfei: the shrieking wind, the spinning clouds, the sky rushing at him. Time seemed to race past him, the years slipping by, black hair turning white in an instant. It made him want to sigh softly.

Someone really did sigh softly.

"Brother, if you want to summon me, you have nine seconds. After that, there won't be anyone in the world who can save you."

Lu Mingfei froze, then lashed out viciously with his foot at the person beside him—not the deathly pale Chu Zihang, but Lu Mingze. The fellow wore casual clothes and sat with his legs crossed, perfectly at ease, holding a cup of ice-cream beads drizzled with yellow-peach sauce. A plastic spoon in his mouth, he looked up at the sky and sighed.

The idea of any normal person eating ice cream on a roller coaster traveling 250 kilometers an hour and twisting through 360 degrees was nonsense. The enormous centrifugal force would have plastered the ice cream and peach sauce across his face.

But Lu Mingze was clearly not normal. He had stopped the entire roller coaster!

The whole amusement park had suddenly turned gray, like a photograph frozen in an instant. Only Lu Mingfei and Lu Mingze were still in color, and only the people in color could move. Without warning, without the slightest sensation of slowing, their speed had dropped from 250 kilometers an hour to zero. Lu Mingfei looked around trembling. The coaster hung suspended in midair, far from both sky and ground, while the towering track resembled the bones of a giant dragon.

"Don't squirm. You really could fall," Lu Mingze warned. Yet he had not even fastened his own restraint, and sat there comfortably eating ice cream.

"Damn it! Can you make an appointment next time? Pick a better time? I don't want to entertain some devil salesman on a roller coaster!"

"The accident rate for roller coasters is about one in 250 million," Lu Mingze said. "Much safer than flying."

"I know. Can't I just join in and scream with everybody else to make the atmosphere more festive?"

"But it isn't zero," Lu Mingze said mildly.

Lu Mingfei froze.

"That probability means that for every 250 million roller-coaster rides in the world, there will be one accident. For the people caught in that accident, the death rate is a hundred percent."

A chill ran through Lu Mingfei. "Don't jinx it!"

Lu Mingze shrugged. "To a statistician, one in 250 million is a probability. But to the passengers on the coaster, everything seems like fate. They watch one group of visitors after another get on, scream, and return safely to the ground, so they believe they'll be fine too. Then they get on, and suddenly the ending changes." Lu Mingze pointed into the distance. "The last train went to heaven. This one is going to hell!"

Lu Mingfei followed his finger and saw cracks spreading across a section of track in the distance. The track was breaking apart! No, it was worse than that: it was twisting. Imagine someone gripping both ends of a snake's spine and turning them in opposite directions. At this rate the track would become one enormous twisted braid!

Talk about a jinx... No, this was a devil's curse! The train really was going to hell!

"H-help!" Lu Mingfei trembled.

"Sure! One quarter of your life, and I'll take care of it!" By the time he said it, Lu Mingze was no longer sitting beside Lu Mingfei. He had climbed to the front row and was leaning over Xia Mi, carefully smearing yellow-peach sauce on her face, like a painter wholly absorbed in his beloved work.

"Don't expect me to do it free this time. Do you know how much work it took to cultivate you as a client? When you chase girls, I send flowers. When you buy things, I pay. When you take up a sword to slay a dragon, I wait on you hand and foot. The only thing I haven't done is serve your tea." Lu Mingze smiled at him. His words were cutting, but his smile was still clear and innocent, rippling with warm sunlight.

A little less than half the rail had broken away. The greater part remained standing only because the main steel girder supported it. In the almost motionless flow of time, the severed section was falling slowly toward the ground with an apocalyptic beauty.

Anjou suddenly moved, as though trying to break free of a restraint. A savage expression flickered across Lu Mingze's face and vanished.

"People who interfere with someone else's business are the worst." His careless expression returned. "Then I'll leave the situation to him for now."

Lu Mingze vanished in an instant, as neatly as a pencil mark erased with a rubber. A hand seemingly appeared from nowhere and seized Lu Mingfei by the collar. "Xia Mi, Mingfei, Zihang!" Anjou's deep voice rang out.

The coaster continued to rise slowly, and the severed rail continued to fall slowly. Lu Mingze's disappearance had not returned time to normal. Otherwise, no matter how vigorous and brave Anjou was for his age, he would never have dared unfasten his restraint and reach back from the front row to grab them.

"It's Time Zero!" Chu Zihang realized. Anjou's Yanling happened to be the ability to stretch time.

"What's going on?" Xia Mi looked around in bewilderment.

Lu Mingfei's heart tightened. Above Xia Mi's lips, two strokes of yellow-peach sauce formed a little yellow mustache... Lu Mingze had never left traces in reality before, but whether it was the fried dough stick last time or the peach-sauce mustache now, he seemed to have gained the ability to bridge dreams and reality.

Anjou pointed into the distance. Chu Zihang and Xia Mi both changed color.

The sky was a deep blue, with white clouds drifting across it. A white pigeon hovered almost motionless with its wings spread, like a wax figure molded into the air. But a section of track was falling slowly.

"How much time do we have?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Only six seconds left. Within my domain, I can stretch time about fiftyfold, giving us three hundred seconds," Anjou said.

"The effect of Time Zero has always been secret, but I suspect it doesn't actually slow the flow of time. It changes the way the four of us perceive it," Chu Zihang said. "We're the ones who have become faster."

"Correct, but it doesn't work on humans. I can't speed them up as well," Anjou said.

"We need a rescue plan immediately, or everyone on this train will die." Anjou glanced at his wristwatch, but its hands seemed held fast by a magnet. "An ordinary timer is useless inside Time Zero's domain. I'd estimate we have 250 seconds left."

Chu Zihang and Xia Mi both nodded.

"Hey, I mean, isn't that impossible?" Lu Mingfei trembled. "Why don't we climb down now? At least we'd have a chance of surviving!"

After all, everyone here was among the absolute elite of the hybrids. In martial-arts novels, they would be towering figures of the martial world, and their lives were precious. For the great cause of

dragon slaying, shouldn't they encourage one another with "Make sure you survive" and "Our lives are vital to the future of the world," then jump off and escape?

All three looked up at Lu Mingfei at once. "We haven't reached the point where we have to give up," Chu Zihang said coolly.

Lu Mingfei shrank back, repelled by their simultaneous sense of justice. Silence fell. He looked left and right at three pairs of rapidly moving eyes, knowing that thoughts were flashing through their heads as busily as a pot of boiling porridge. His own mind was blank. A rescue plan? What nonsense. How much did a roller coaster weigh? At least a dozen tons, racing along a vertical track at 250 kilometers an hour, and only half the track was left. The only possibility was for a Super Stallion heavy-lift helicopter to happen by and hoist the whole train up. But under the blue sky and white clouds, the only thing that could fly was the waxlike bird. Among the four of them, Anjou's and Chu Zihang's Yanling had already been revealed, so all he could hope was that Xia Mi's ability was "Yanling: Transform into a Super Stallion"...

The coaster rose another few dozen meters. Slowed fiftyfold by the Yanling, it crawled like a snail climbing a grape arbor.

Chu Zihang suddenly looked up. "This coaster has fin-shaped magnetic brakes!"

Xia Mi blinked. "You mean we can brake?"

"Hey, if we brake now, won't we just stop in midair?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"We won't remain suspended." Chu Zihang said, "Fin-shaped magnetic brakes are special equipment on strata coasters. Only three roller coasters in the world have this system. The train itself has no engine. After electromagnetic acceleration gives it its initial speed, it climbs the track, converting kinetic energy into potential energy, and gradually slows."

Anjou's eyes lit up. "When it reaches the top, its speed is close to zero!"

Chu Zihang nodded. "The Midgard Serpent's track is like an arched bridge. The train has just enough kinetic energy to pass the highest point. Then it enters the descent, potential energy turns back into kinetic energy, and it speeds up again. Finally it enters the electromagnetic braking tunnel and returns to the ground."

"But we don't have a descending track anymore... After we pass the top... we'll turn into an iron dragon flying through... no, falling straight out of the sky!" Lu Mingfei said. Suddenly high-school physics was back in session.

"But we have fin brakes! They were originally designed as a joke on the passengers. As the train is about to pass the top, it's already moving very slowly. A little braking is enough to leave it without the kinetic energy to get over the crest. It rolls backward down the ascent and returns to the launch tunnel."

"Hey, how do you know all that? Isn't Winnie the Pooh and His Friends your favorite? You were trembling when you heard we were riding the coaster!" Lu Mingfei said.

"I wasn't confident, so I looked it up on my phone while we were in line..."

"What a tech geek! You've proved yourself again!"

"Yes," Anjou said. "It's a joke. When riders see the coaster going backward, they usually think something's broken and scream in terror. Before they've finished screaming, the train is safely back in the launch tunnel. Some have felt they came back from the dead, wept, and found religion afterward."

"The fin brakes are there to make us find religion?" Lu Mingfei's thoughts were a mess. "Religion can only save your soul... Have we already given up on saving our bodies?"

"No," Xia Mi said. "The fin brakes can send us back to the launch tunnel, so we won't need the descending track."

Lu Mingfei finally understood, and immediately felt a little inferior. Apparently everyone else had understood the moment Chu Zihang mentioned the fin brakes. The high-school physics lesson had been just for him.

"But the fin brakes can only stop the coaster when its speed is nearly zero," Anjou said. "We have to trigger them as we approach the highest point."

"That won't be a problem," Chu Zihang said. "In Time Zero's domain, time is stretched out. We can control the timing precisely."

"How do we activate the fin brakes?" Xia Mi asked loudly.

"The train has a transformer at the back. It steps up the low-voltage current from the track to high voltage to drive the fin brakes. But the control switch is undoubtedly in the control room below," Anjou said. "There isn't time to get down there now."

"Why do you all seem so familiar with roller coasters?" Lu Mingfei marveled.

"As a roller-coaster enthusiast, I've studied them." Anjou hesitated. "It isn't very convenient for me to come and ride one by myself, which is why I said I'd bring you to see it today... It's the same reason fathers often eat ice cream under the pretext of keeping their children company."

"If I open the rear housing, I should be able to pull out the live wire and spark it in midair to activate the fin brakes," Chu Zihang said. "My specialty is alchemical mechanics."

"Wow! Science guys are so handsome!" Stars shone in Xia Mi's eyes.

"Then hurry!" Lu Mingfei's eyes widened. "Swoon over him later!"

Chu Zihang drove Anjou's folding knife into the housing and sliced straight through the metal shell. With the transformer exposed, he easily stripped out two wires.

"The red one's live, the blue one's neutral. Touch them together and the fin brakes will start." He showed Lu Mingfei the wires. "Braking only takes three or four seconds. The key is timing."

"This half of the track is going to break too, isn't it?" Lu Mingfei looked around.

While they worked, the track around them was coming apart at a visibly increasing rate. It twisted farther and farther, cracks spreading rapidly. Screws that held the rails to the girder burst out one after another. Under Time Zero, they drifted past Lu Mingfei's ears, trailing long, tearing sounds. He thought it looked rather amusing and reached out to touch one, but Chu Zihang shouted at him to stop.

"They look slower to you, but their kinetic energy is still enormous." Chu Zihang pulled out an expired membership card and held it in front of a screw. The screw pierced it, leaving a jagged hole.

"In normal time, they're as fast as bullets!" Chu Zihang said.

Cold sweat covered Lu Mingfei. He had almost taken a bullet through his finger.

"Hurry! We don't have much time!" Xia Mi called from the front.

Anjou remained upright in the front row, staring ahead, his pupils brilliant gold. The deep-red rose in his suit's buttonhole swayed, broke apart, and scattered in the wind at a speed slowed dozens of

times. The old man was not deliberately striking a dramatic pose. Lu Mingfei climbed over and saw that the nosebleed spraying from Anjou's face was as shockingly red as the rose.

He was exerting all his strength to maintain Time Zero's domain. The domain of such a high-order Yanling drained Anjou's mental energy as if drawing water. At first he had only grown mentally tired, but now even his body could no longer bear it.

"Principal, you're gushing blood." Unable to keep his hands to himself, Lu Mingfei wiped it away.

"You can still be this clueless at a time like this? The principal's about to gush tears too..." Xia Mi looked thoroughly exasperated.

"Take a look behind you. I doubt you'll still be able to joke," Anjou said quietly.

Lu Mingfei turned and shuddered in silence. So many distorted faces together looked like a work of art depicting despair. The falling section of track was reflected in every pair of eyes. Mouths stretched to their limits emitted heart-rending cries, drawn out by Time Zero into notes as long as a violin's. The passengers had all realized they were racing toward death. Lu Mingfei had never imagined a person's face could twist so horribly with terror. Even the pretty girl he had glanced at a few extra times before boarding now looked like a fanged female ghost.

No... like souls suffering in hell.

Lu Mingfei swallowed, his scalp tingling.

"There's little time. Hurry! We have to activate the fin brakes about ten meters before the coaster reaches the top. Too early, and we'll be moving too fast; the brakes might lock. Too late, and if we pass the top, it's all over," Anjou said. "I can't help you. I may lose consciousness at any moment. Chu Zihang, this is an operation. You're the commissioner, and you have full command."

"Understood." Chu Zihang nodded.

At that moment the falling curved section of track struck the ground and plunged into a circus tent, throwing a curtain of dust into the sky.

"Xia Mi, look after the principal. Make sure his restraint is fastened. If he can't hold on, Time Zero's domain will end. Remember, you're still on a high-speed roller coaster. Lu Mingfei, observe from the front and signal me at ten meters. I'll ignite the circuit at the rear." With that, Chu Zihang climbed toward the back.

The dust rose swiftly and fragments of track flew, a heart-stopping sight. It looked like a documentary of humanity's final moments, played in slow motion. Lu Mingfei took a deep breath and looked back at Chu Zihang, who hung half out of the rear of the train, live wire in hand, looking toward the front.

Lu Mingfei chuckled. He was laughing at Chu Zihang. The wire in his hand must have carried direct current, charging his whole body until his hair stood on end, as if he had an enormous frizzy perm.

"I really have to hand it to you! You can still laugh now," Xia Mi said.

"I'm not the only one who laughs when he's nervous. I've always thought that if I were executed as a revolutionary martyr, I'd double over laughing on the ground and say, 'Ha ha ha ha, don't shoot! Ha ha ha ha, don't shoot! I'll confess, I'll confess, I'll confess everything, ha ha ha!' The enemy would think I was mocking them and pull the trigger." Lu Mingfei's voice shook.

"Mingfei, trust your judgment," Anjou said quietly. The gold in his eyes began to flicker like a dying candle, and even Lu Mingfei could feel the Yanling's domain wavering.

Lu Mingfei raised his hand. This was the signal they had agreed on: when he brought his arm down, the fin brakes would be activated.

The coaster crept forward like a snail.

Suddenly droplets spattered Lu Mingfei's face, and they were enveloped in a fine mist. He wiped his face in surprise. Rain? Surely not; the sky had been clear just moments ago. He looked down and understood. Beside the Midgard Serpent was a large high-pressure fountain that could shoot water 200 meters high. Its pipe ran beneath the circus tent. The rail had pierced the ground and broken the pipe; a high-pressure jet tore through the slowly rising dust and shot higher than the track.

A huge dark shape tumbled through the spray toward the coaster: a broken steel support beam!

"Damn it, don't shoot..." Lu Mingfei murmured.

His mind was still caught on the joke he had just made to Xia Mi. A moment ago he had held a chance of victory; now he was a condemned man about to face a firing squad. No, not a firing squad. With that several-ton beam crashing down on him, his death would be a hundred times uglier than a shooting.

Chu Zihang felt his blood run cold as he watched the deadly blow draw slowly closer. There were always moments that made a person feel small, because there was nothing he could do.

A cry stretched out dozens of times longer slowly tore through the air. He turned and saw a father, face contorted and streaming with tears and snot, lean out and slowly gather his howling son into his arms. He held the boy tight, curving his back like a bow, wrapping his own body around him. The slow motion let Chu Zihang see every detail clearly, including the man's eyes. He had plainly given up hope. In his own passage of time, he had less than a second left before death. At such a height and speed, with steel about to strike, an ordinary person could do nothing. So he did the most meaningless thing: he embraced his son. He wrapped his torso around the boy as the only shield he could provide... though when the impact crushed them, that shield would not last even 0.001 seconds.

"He's your son, isn't he?" Chu Zihang asked softly.

Of course, no one answered him. Chu Zihang stared at the father and son, and the moment stretched on endlessly.

The man stroked his son's hair and actually smiled. What an awful smile it was, full of grief and despair, yet he still smiled for the boy to see. To give him just a little courage.

"Dad, did you smile at me like that too...?" Chu Zihang suddenly leaped up and ran forward over the rows of seats.

"Lu Mingfei! Get to the back and trigger the brakes! I'll block it!" he roared.

"Huh?" Lu Mingfei was stunned.

You'll block it? Come on! Is that something you can block? Do you think you're Voltron, always saying, "I'll form the head"? Stop playing the hero. A hundred of you couldn't stop it! Maybe if you convert to Christianity and believe in God right now, you'll be saved!

Chu Zihang, of course, had no idea how wildly Lu Mingfei's thoughts were racing. They were nearing the highest point now, and the track was leveling out. He charged along the rails like an enraged rhinoceros.

Lu Mingfei scrambled to the rear, grabbed the live wire, and looked back. He drew a sharp breath. Chu Zihang stood at the end of the track, all his skin turned a strange blue-gray. Dense scales pierced through it, growing amid blood and tearing his clothes; his glowing eyes blazed like flames! Sovereign Flame's domain expanded rapidly. Lu Mingfei had never heard of anyone growing scales all over when releasing a Yanling. And the posture of those hands looked like the Buddha's Palm. Facing a beam that huge, shouldn't his senior at least use tai chi to deflect a thousand pounds with four ounces? Why was he using a Shaolin palm technique of utmost hardness and force?

"Trigger it!" Chu Zihang waved.

Lu Mingfei did not move. Chu Zihang's feet stood on the two rails. Activating the fin brakes meant applying high voltage, which would flow away through the rails. The moment he triggered it, the current would pierce Chu Zihang's heart.

"Don't be a fucking idiot! You'll die!" Lu Mingfei shouted back.

"I can only hold it for an instant." Chu Zihang's voice sank, filled with cold authority. "Trigger it!"

Lu Mingfei gripped the neutral and live wires, both hands shaking.

"Listen. Whether you trigger it or not, I can't get back anymore." Chu Zihang did not turn around. "Do what you have to. Trust me with the rest."

That was too brave, wasn't it? What a fine young hero, rushing to the rescue! Lu Mingfei almost wanted to give him a Young Pioneer salute... except he was brave enough to be a fucking idiot! Did he value his own life so little? Lu Mingfei did not salute. Tears welled up instead.

He hooked the neutral and live wires firmly together!

There was no dazzling light in Sovereign Flame's domain. As the temperature rose to its limit, the air currents instead took on a faint black tint. The beam hurtled straight at Chu Zihang; behind him was the coaster. Braking had begun, and high-voltage current made his whole body convulse.

Chu Zihang needed to buy them an instant. He could do it, because he had amplified his blood. Now... he was invincible!

The beam crashed into Sovereign Flame's domain, and the surging power of the Yanling melted it in an instant. Golden molten steel streamed past both sides of Chu Zihang's body. He threw his arms wide, and the superheated air exploded, forcibly scattering the flow of metal!

His vision went blank. He lost his balance and fell into the raging blaze he had ignited.

At last the coaster's speed fell to zero. After an instant's pause, all its steel wheels reversed, carrying it back down the ascent.

At that moment Anjou lost consciousness. The gold faded from his eyes.

Time Zero ended. Lu Mingfei was almost flung away. He had no time to climb back into the train and could only cling to the rail at the rear, dangling outside.

He stared blankly at the figure swallowed by fire... Hey, don't do this. If I'd known, I'd have made a deal with Lu Mingze. At most I'd have lost a quarter of my life, as thanks for helping me save face in front of Chen Wenwen... Just don't die like this... so damn foolishly brave.

A white figure leaped from the roller coaster. It was Xia Mi! She ran along the rails toward the dazzling fire and disappeared into it.

Act Ten

The Night Watcher

Night Watch

What a splendid civilization it had been! They had enslaved humanity and built magnificent cities. The ancient records said that the King of Bronze and Fire had lived on the northern ice fields, where he cast a bronze palace as towering as a mountain. There, too, stood the famous bronze pillar that held up the sky, on which the Black King had nailed the White King to death; the enormous column recorded the Black King's long history of war. He had also ordered the construction of a divine road across the ocean, calculated to have been four hundred meters wide—an undertaking greater than any highway today. But when the Black King died, those great monuments vanished, like Atlantis sinking beneath the ocean overnight.

An enormous oak conference table stood amid ranks of bookshelves, surrounded by aged faces. Most of those faces had never appeared on the Cassell College campus. Each was as pale as if it had just been dug out of an ancient tomb. Everyone wore an old-fashioned black tailcoat and an antique-silver ring on the little finger of the left hand.

The younger professors could attend only as standing observers. More than a hundred of them crowded the ground floor of the principal's office. The room formed an atrium open all the way to the roof, where sunlight spilled through the skylight and illuminated Principal Anjou's face at the end of the table.

"Younger professors" meant people like Guderian. Squeezed into a corner, he was trembling with excitement, pinching his bare little finger. Every "young professor" longed for an antique-silver ring, the mark of a tenured lifetime professorship at Cassell. The title generally required more than half a century of teaching at the college. Had these elderly scientists been ordinary humans, they would have developed dementia long ago.

"My God! That's Doug Jones! A landmark figure in the history of nuclear physics! America couldn't have built the atomic bomb without him! The whole world thinks he's dead!" Guderian's voice shook. "And Jean Grus! He's the reason America beat the Soviets to the moon! And he turned down a Nobel Prize! The Americans thought he'd converted to Tibetan Buddhism and retired to Tibet thirty years ago!"

"Aaaah! That's Blair Bittner, the Solomon of mathematics! An Einstein of his field!" Guderian jabbed Manstein with his elbow.

"Stop swooning! I can see pink hearts in your eyes," Manstein hissed.

"Aren't you excited? You're at a meeting with the milestones of modern science—and they should all be gravestones by now. If the media found out they were alive, the great masters of every discipline would rush here to pay their respects to their teachers' teachers' teachers..." Guderian rubbed his hands. "I hope there's a chance to get their autographs afterward."

"Wouldn't a photograph be better?"

"My old friend, you're absolutely right! Will you take it for me? Do you think putting my arm around their shoulders would seem too forward?" Guderian punched his palm.

"A souvenir photograph with lunatics? What's the point?" Manstein said coldly.

"Lunatics?" Guderian blinked.

Manstein sighed. "Those so-called milestones in the history of science are sacrifices humanity has offered to the monster called science. Look at them: their skin is pale and withered, but their eyes burn like torches. Some haven't left their laboratories in fifty years. They devote every moment to research, hoping to get a few steps closer to the realm of truth before they die. Their bodies keep declining; only their brains grow stronger. They probably wouldn't mind their limbs withering away until nothing remained but a brain to think with, because thinking is the only meaning in their lives. They're fanatical dreamers of science, lunatics honored with the name of genius. Would you want a life like that?"

"No, not really..." Guderian scratched his head.

Manstein nodded, pleased that his old friend retained a little reason.

"How could I ever deserve to be like them?" Guderian said shyly, like a girl overcome at the sight of her idol. "I'd be content to serve tea and water to those madmen racing toward the truth..."

Manstein silently covered his face, unable to describe his sense of helplessness.

"Quiet," Anjou said softly.

The two took the hint and shut up. In fact, they had been the only ones whispering since entering the room. The other "young professors" wore expressions as solemn as if their parents had died, while the "lifetime professors," occasionally let out of their academic sanctuaries for air, showed no expression at all—like the dead parents themselves.

"Everyone is here. Let's begin. Blair, my old friend, it's been half a century. It's a pleasure to see you alive in person." Anjou glanced at the "Solomon." "And to my other old friends, our distinguished department heads, it's a pleasure to see you face to face. I'm sorry to interrupt your research, but we had compelling reasons. The report has been sent to you all; I trust you've read it."

Everyone with a seat at the table was a department head at Cassell College. Most students knew only which department they belonged to; they had no idea the heads even existed.

"From the standpoint of physics, humans cannot yet do it," said Doug Jones, head of physics, in a low voice. His back was hunched, his aging spine bent almost into a circle, and he coughed as he spoke. He looked as if a missed breath would suffocate him.

He operated the touchpad on the table, projecting two black-and-white photographs in midair: the ruins of South Railway Station and of the Midgard Serpent. The twisted aluminum girders and rails had a grotesque beauty, like the bones of snakes stripped of flesh and wrenched out of shape.

"Both structures collapsed because of stresses within them—ghostlike stresses that, once unleashed, easily destroyed metal structures built to withstand a magnitude-nine earthquake." Doug Jones shook his head. "If humans knew how to trigger such stress, a poke of a finger could destroy the entire Hoover Dam."

"Ghostlike stress?" The "young professors" exchanged looks. Even coming from a scholar at the pinnacle of his field, the claim was extraordinary.

"We examined the Midgard Serpent's blueprints. It is one of only three roller coasters of its class in the world. Because no one had designed a coaster that demanding before, every place that called for one-inch steel was enlarged to five inches for safety. Even an F-22 fighter crashing head-on into it might not bring it down," said Jean Grus, head of precision mechanics. "Yet stress destroyed it. That silent stress was more astonishing than the kinetic energy of an F-22 cruising at supersonic speed. That's why we call it ghostlike."

Blair Bittner frowned. "Grus, the young people are weak on mechanics. Explain the basic concept of stress first!" The Solomon of mathematics certainly lived up to his reputation. Both hands resting on an ivory-trimmed black cane, he sat bolt upright in a hardwood chair, his hair a lion's raging mane. He looked rather like a Japanese samurai preparing to disembowel himself, his face radiating regal authority.

The "young professors," whose average age was fifty, all looked ashamed.

"Simply put, when a force acts on an entire metal structure, the resisting force within that structure is stress. If the force is torsion, the resisting force is shear stress. Shear stress forms a flow: enormous forces move through the metal like water, with a particularly high concentration at weak and narrow points. Once that concentration passes a threshold, the structure begins to fail," Jean Grus said.

"Then shear stress should be the enemy of every building. Why was it so destructive in these two?" someone asked.

"Good question. As we said, shear stress flows through metal parts like water, but not evenly; it resembles chaotic turbulence. Small flows cancel one another out and never grow unmanageable. There are exceptions, however." The Solomon glanced at Grus. "Mechanic, this is your field."

Grus nodded. "Yes. We call that exception stress concentration. In an instant, flows of shear stress happen to converge on a vulnerable joint, producing an enormous resultant force that destroys it. But to guide that concentration, or awaken the ghostlike stress, one must analyze the complete structure of the building. The computation is terrifying; even Norma can't do it. That's why we say it lies beyond human ability." He looked around. "Does anyone know the ancient martial arts of the East?"

The room fell silent.

Grus nodded. "Lately I've been studying a Chinese martial art called the Vajra One-Finger Zen."

The room remained silent. The minds of academic geniuses were truly like dragons whose heads appeared while their tails remained hidden. Everyone else was lost in a fog, unsure what he meant. Only the Solomon nodded slightly, apparently a fellow lover of martial arts.

Grus raised a thick, short finger, his eyes shining. "Vajra One-Finger Zen is a Shaolin art. It is said that a master can shatter a stone tablet with one finger. That fascinated me. A finger bone consists of water, protein, and a little calcium; it is actually fragile, easily broken with a light twist. How could it act like a high-hardness alloy drill bit? Yet there is evidence that people really mastered this ancient art. After six months of research with my colleagues, thousands of repeated experiments, and several colleagues breaking their index fingers, we finally found the secret. It lies in where and how you strike. The most exquisite force must hit the most vulnerable point. The Chinese call it the 'eye' or an 'acupoint.' Rock has its eye, and steel has its eye. Pour force through that eye like running water and guide the ghostlike stress. The resulting concentration fractures the entire target, even reducing it to powder in an instant."

"So," Anjou said, "the enemy who ambushed us at South Railway Station and Six Flags is a mysterious old martial artist whose control of force has reached perfection. If he wished, he could destroy the Capitol or the Pentagon with a single blow?"

"So it was an old martial artist," Guderian said thoughtfully.

"An old martial artist might break a stone tablet, but the Midgard Serpent was built from high-strength steel," Manstein said quietly. "Their 'old martial artist' is something else..."

"One of the Four Monarchs... the King of Earth and Mountain!" the Solomon said softly.

Dead silence settled over the room. The ancient title had stunned everyone. Though they had long known of this Dragon King from old books, and though he now appeared in their minds in the comical guise of an elderly Eastern martial artist, no one could laugh. It was as if a vast black shadow had fallen over them, heavy as a mountain.

"He is the master of the earth, and the element he commands is earth. No dragon in the world is more skilled at controlling force. The records say, 'The waves of stone herald his stretching before he wakes. The day he stretches to his full extent, mountains become abysses.' He can even break through the earth's crust," Anjou said softly.

"If he's awake, why hasn't he appeared before us directly? With his control of force, none of us could resist. We would be at his mercy," someone asked.

"I don't know." Anjou shook his head. "Perhaps something still gives him pause. Perhaps the one awakened this time is not the Dragon King himself but one of his descendants, a noble second-generation dragon. Whatever the case, a new dragon must have awakened behind these two incidents. Every dragon is our enemy. Given the chance, he will grind every one of us into dust! Rather than wait helplessly, we must sharpen our blades. This time we face an awakened dragon whose father may be the great Black King Nidhogg himself. This is a meeting to prepare for war. When it ends, the highest-level dragon-threat alert will go out across the world. A new war is about to begin."

The lifetime professors rose one after another. With the "young professors," they placed hands over their hearts and spoke solemnly: "Good shall triumph over evil. Wherever light reaches, darkness has nowhere to hide."

After seeing the lifetime professors off, Anjou returned to his desk on the third floor. A bone-china teapot and two cups stood on it; the Darjeeling inside was still warm. A listless young man sat beside the desk. The lifetime professors who had met downstairs had never imagined a student was listening in, much less that he had a seat and tea and refreshments, when even Manstein, head of the Discipline Committee, had to stand.

"Mingfei, won't you try a scone? They're hazelnut." Anjou sat opposite him, lit a cigar, and picked up his tea.

"I'm not in the mood..." Lu Mingfei sighed. "Principal, is it okay for me to listen in on a meeting like that? You know I have a big mouth sometimes. What if I let something slip?"

"The meeting happened to fall during the principal's afternoon tea, and you're the student I invited today. I'm sorry it interrupted our pleasant tea break; I merely asked you to wait here." Anjou shrugged.

"But everything you talked about was classified."

"I have something even more confidential. Would you like to hear it?"

Lu Mingfei covered his ears. "Forget it. Even if I can keep my mouth shut, what if I talk in my sleep? Anyway, it has nothing to do with me... Principal, if a Dragon King really is awake, I won't be on the dragon-slaying strike team again, will I? I already risked my life going to a Dragon King's house. That kind of thing uses up your luck... I think I need at least a hundred years to build it up before I go again!"

"I'm afraid there's no help for it. It's time to reveal some secrets to you. As our only S-rank student, there are things you'll have to learn sooner or later." Anjou set down his cup and gently pressed a red button hidden in the drawer.

Lu Mingfei felt his chair and the entire floor tremble. Then he, Anjou, the huge nanmu desk, and the steaming tea on it all sank into boundless darkness together.

"Ah! Is it an earthquake? An earthquake?" Lu Mingfei shouted.

"No. We're descending." Anjou's cigar tip glowed and dimmed in the dark.

"Descending?" Lu Mingfei blinked. "Where to?"

"The other half of Cassell College."

The floor and desk jolted again, gradually slowed, and stopped sinking. Light suddenly appeared on every side. Lu Mingfei looked up and saw a shark! And not just the enormous hammerhead: a languid sea turtle floated to his left, a bluefin tuna over two meters long swam to his right, and great schools of mackerel raced around him. Everywhere he looked, rippling water cast shifting light and shadows.

"This is our aquarium," Anjou explained. "We're in the underwater passage beneath it."

"An... aquarium?" Lu Mingfei was bewildered. "How did we get into an aquarium?"

"Strictly speaking, we're in an elevator. A VIP elevator reserved for the principal."

"An elevator?" Lu Mingfei was even more confused.

"The floor is the size of this platform, with transparent glass walls around it. That's my elevator," Anjou said. "It just sank into the underwater passage."

"What kind of VIP elevator has room for a whole desk? Isn't that a little extravagant?" Lu Mingfei murmured. Anjou's desk alone was larger than an ordinary elevator car—and when they descended, his liquor cabinet had come down too!

"Would a man who harbors the great dream of saving the world care about spending such a trifling sum?" the old man protested weakly.

The "elevator" suddenly moved, not up or down but sideways. It slid through the encircling school of mackerel. The hammerhead and sea turtle paid the moving glass room little attention; presumably they were used to it.

"The aquarium houses all kinds of marine life. It's the college's genetic repository. Research on dragons requires a large number of genetic samples for comparison," Anjou explained. "The aquarium is only part of this underground space, of course. We're going to see the rest. For the next little while, you'll be visiting the most highly classified area of Cassell College. It's also known as the Ice Cellar."

"The Ice Cellar?" Lu Mingfei wondered if he had heard wrong. Few students were allowed in. Legend said Cassell kept alchemical equipment and dangerous weapons there, and those who had been inside never spoke of it.

"You all think the Ice Cellar is merely a storeroom or a display room? That's only one part of it. Ice Cellar is the collective name for the college's underground buildings, which are far larger than the campus aboveground. You've never seen those department heads, have you? At an ordinary college it would be unthinkable for department heads never to appear on campus, but at Cassell their real work is research, and all their laboratories are underground. Norma's mainframe is here too, as well as heavy research equipment and even a subway train leading outside!" Anjou said proudly. "This underground space combines electronic, mechanical, and alchemical technology. No human can break in."

"So... a dragon could?"

Anjou paused, a little embarrassed. "No dragon has broken in either, but we have found mice down here... We don't know how they got in."

"That's not secure at all!"

"Ahead is our botanical garden," Anjou said.

A lush green expanse appeared beneath Lu Mingfei's feet, but it was no lawn or flower garden. It was a forest! Two elevated rails swept over the treetops, and their "elevator" was crossing a subtropical forest. There was even sunlight overhead!

"Artificial sunlight, providing energy for photosynthesis. This is a huge fissure in the earth. The space isn't really that large, but it holds more than 120,000 species of plants," Anjou said. "There's a zoo next door with more than 8,000 species, from pigs to pandas, but it has never been open to visitors."

The elevator entered the heart of the "mountain" through a cleft in the rock, then soon emerged again.

"What's that? It looks like a pyramid!" Lu Mingfei cried, pointing ahead.

"Oh, it is a pyramid." The old man answered casually. "We pulled it out of a South American jungle, transported it here, and reconstructed it. Quite an undertaking. We chartered a seventy-thousand-ton container ship and marked every stone so we wouldn't put it back together incorrectly."

The principal's elevator stopped in front of the pyramid, and they followed a metal stairway onto the enormous concrete base supporting it.

"Notice anything different about it?" Anjou led Lu Mingfei around the pyramid. It was built entirely of black stone blocks without any binding agent, like a construction of toy blocks. Its stability depended on its own weight and precise cutting. Though somewhat worn, the surface carvings remained clear. Its builders had carved patterns into the hard black stone and filled the deep grooves with molten copper.

"It seems... to have an extra face?" Lu Mingfei said.

"Correct. Unlike every other pyramid, it has five sides, each with 133 stone steps. Every step is covered in ancient Mayan characters—numbers, to be precise. The entire pyramid is a Mayan calendar, the whole history of the world as the Maya saw it." Anjou stroked the black stone. "But what the Maya called history was not only the past... it was also the future."

Lu Mingfei stared.

"It is a book of the past, the present, and the future. It is a history book and a book of prophecy."

"That's too deep." Lu Mingfei scratched his head.

"Have you seen 2012?"

"Yes." Lu Mingfei nodded. "The story where a science-fiction writer saves his ex-wife when the world ends."

"The director borrowed the date 2012 from the Mayan calendar. It is the most important date in that calendar: the year the Fifth Sun ends."

Lu Mingfei nodded, only half understanding.

"The Maya were remarkable. They were the most precise astronomical observers of antiquity, even able to observe the far side of the moon, which never faces Earth. They created the solar calendar: a calendar, a history, and a book of prophecy. They wrote the future into history because they believed it was already determined. The history of this world is finite; it need not extend forever. There are five Suns. Advanced civilizations existed in the first four, but each ended in destruction: Matlactli was destroyed by flood, Ehecatl by wind serpents, Quiahuitl by a rain of fire, and Tzontlilic by upheavals of the earth. Fortunately, each previous catastrophe spared an ancient civilization, and that civilization began a new Sun. But there will be no sixth. After the Fifth Sun, there is nothing: zero, emptiness, the destruction of all things." Anjou said, "Neither dragons nor humans will survive that end."

Lu Mingfei suddenly remembered something and shivered involuntarily. "Wait, wait. Those four earlier destructions... flood, wind serpents, fire rain... upheaval of the earth..."

"Yes. Earth, water, wind, and fire. They are represented by the Four Monarchs on the dragon thrones. Each of the first four destructions was caused by one monarch. No one knows about the fifth."

"The Black King?" Lu Mingfei felt cold sweat breaking out.

"The Maya didn't say. Perhaps the Black King, perhaps the White King, perhaps all Four Monarchs together. You enrolled in 2009. If we can't deal with this catastrophe, I don't think you'll get your diploma." Anjou shrugged.

"Hey, that's heresy, isn't it? Why should we believe the Maya?" Lu Mingfei came to his senses. "They were just primitive people, right? If they were so amazing, how did they get wiped out? Who did it? Spaniards with guns and cannons?"

"Ancient Mayan civilization declined in the eighth century. As their states broke apart, their priests lost their traditions. Before the Spaniards arrived, they had already lost the ancient calendar and all their mystical knowledge." Anjou spread his hands. "But that doesn't mean their prophecies are unreliable. One could say that none of history's books of prophecy were written by humans... Humans merely passed them on."

"Dragons?"

Anjou nodded. "This is something the dragons left behind."

"Wait. Principal, you said neither humans nor dragons can survive the Fifth Sun, and the dragons made the Mayan calendar. Doesn't that mean... the dragons predicted their own extinction?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"Yes. Dragon prophecies are prophecies of destruction, because in their view, destruction is the world's inevitable end. Norse mythology was most deeply influenced by dragon culture. The poets who recorded it did not describe enticing futures like reincarnation or heaven; they described death directly. Ragnarok is the destined day of destruction, when giants and the dead will attack the realm of the gods. Therefore Odin built Valhalla and ordered the Valkyries to bring the souls of brave warriors there. Day after day they practice fighting, drink, battle one another, die, and rise again, preparing to

take the field at the end. Even so, the outcome cannot be changed. The myths record clearly how the gods will end, who will kill whom, with no exception even for Odin. Norse mythology moves in one direction, with no cycle and no branching paths, like the thread spun on the loom of the three goddesses of fate: straight ahead, all the way to... death! That is also the dragons' view of the world. Every Dragon King has foreseen his end, yet they keep cocooning themselves and awakening, trying to resist."

"That sounds so sad," Lu Mingfei said softly.

"It's our view of the world too."

"Then it's not just sad; it's downright miserable..." Lu Mingfei pulled a face.

"Destruction is a recurring theme in myths around the world. Some put it more gently than the Norse did, that's all," Anjou said. "Have you read Journey to the West?"

"Even a cheerful book like that has something to do with doomsday?" Lu Mingfei's eyes widened.

"In Journey to the West, Patriarch Subhuti tells Sun Wukong that practitioners of the Way fear the 'three terrible calamities': three fated trials, which are in fact the three disasters of Buddhist mythology. The Shurangama Sutra describes them. First comes fire: seven suns appear in the sky at once and burn the world, destroying everything from Avici Hell to the first dhyana heaven of the form realm. Then comes water, flooding everything from Avici Hell to the second dhyana heaven. The third is wind, scattering all matter from Avici Hell to the third dhyana heaven." Anjou glanced at Lu Mingfei. "You see the connection?"

"It's a lot like the Mayan myths," Lu Mingfei said. "Earth, water, wind, fire."

"Yes. There's also the great flood mentioned in many mythologies. People living tens of thousands of miles apart in the East and West all believed a flood once destroyed the world. The Chinese tell of Yu the Great controlling the waters; the Bible says God told Noah to build an ark of gopher wood to escape the flood. The earliest record is a Sumerian clay tablet from 3500 BC. Scholars still debate it, but a great deal of evidence shows that a flood once covered most of the earth and cut a break through human history," Anjou said. "Dragon prophecies of destruction have been confirmed again and again. But none of us knows what will happen in 2012. We've been waiting, wondering what might happen... and then it really did. The long-silent Dragon Kings are awakening one after another, a collective awakening unprecedented in history. Mingfei, do you know what you should do now?"

"No! You've scared me half to death, Principal! Have you built a big ship in the Himalayas? Are tickets on sale?" Lu Mingfei's face was blank. He truly didn't know what expression suited a conversation like this. His life had scarcely begun to be good, and it seemed it was already about to end.

"Cassell College is a Valhalla. A hundred years ago we began assembling an army of the finest dragon-blooded descendants. We don't know what we'll face, but this army must be strong enough to adapt to any battlefield." Anjou patted Lu Mingfei's shoulder. "And you're one of its finest."

"I'm one of its finest? I have to say, Principal, your plan for the end of the world sounds shaky! Say aliens invade Earth, and the president makes a stirring speech, then appoints Nobita Nobi commander in chief of the entire army—Nobita without Doraemon! What if we fail? What if the world is destroyed? Building a big ship sounds more reliable!"

"This is the big ship." Anjou gestured around them. "There are five underground spaces like this in the world, some deep in mines, others beneath glaciers. Each natural space has been excavated and stocked with vast numbers of plants and animals, as well as embryos, pollen, and seeds. All of human civilization has been preserved, along with knowledge of alchemy and Yanling. There are complete sets of machinery, and of course food and drinking water. Deep in the Ice Cellar is a miniature reactor with enough energy to run this place for five hundred years. If you fail, I'll retire here."

"That sounds like a Nationalist commander frightened by the Communist charge, firing a few shots into the air and hiding straight in a shelter..." Lu Mingfei covered his face.

"Some people must go to battle, and some must live on." Anjou leaned against the railing beside the concrete base, the wind lifting his white hair. "I might be the one who dies, and you the one who retires."

"Now that sounds a little more loyal!"

"Remember my friend Meinhard?" Anjou said softly. "When we first founded the Lionheart Society together, he often drank with me and said that if we faced a Dragon King one day, the last man standing should run as quickly as he could. 'Someone has to carry on the soul of our Lionheart Society, doesn't he?' he always said. 'So who should survive? Well, I'd quite like to live myself, but I think Anjou would be better. Women like him, and genetically speaking, men women like have better genes. He's got the potential to be a playboy, have countless children with countless beautiful women, and train them all as new members of the Lionheart Society. Ha ha ha ha!'" Anjou imitated the man's laughter, gazing up at the sky lit by artificial light. "In the end, he really did die, and I survived."

"When I first went to Cambridge, I was on a scholarship and had very little money. Whenever I had any, I had nice clothes made to catch the girls' attention, and often went hungry. Meinhard was my senior then, and he always invited me to eat at his place. He was good at cooking foie gras and often made it himself. I'd drink red wine and watch him bustle around. I'd say, 'Meinhard, you're wonderful,' and he'd say, 'You don't need to thank me. Someday you can cook for your junior. If your junior cooks for his junior too, that would really be wonderful... Ha ha ha ha.'" Anjou smiled. "You have no idea how much he loved to laugh."

"I was joking just now." He turned to Lu Mingfei. "I won't retire here. I've already lived alone as the last man once. That was enough."

Lu Mingfei was silent for a long time. Looking up, he saw a black iron case being carried along the suspended track into the depths. "Do we really have a chance?"

"I don't know." Anjou shrugged. "Remember what I told you in Chicago? That is all I have, and for it I'll pay any price."

He glanced at the black iron case overhead. "The remains of the Dragon King Constantine, the only dragonbone cross in the world we can currently confirm. It was in the alchemy laboratory for analysis, but we had to move it to the deepest level and bury it. Too many people are interested in it."

Chu Zihang slowly opened his eyes. Everything before him was pure white and blurred. He believed in neither God nor heaven, but the face bending over him was unadorned and flawless, suffused with warm light, like an angel lowering her head to kiss a sinner's forehead.

For an instant he was dazed. He tried to lean closer to see her face clearly. He smelled the angel's warm, moist scent, carrying the fragrance of leaves after rain.

"Senior, are you getting fresh with me the moment you wake up?" she said leisurely, just as he was about to bring his whole face close.

"Xia Mi?" Chu Zihang's vision gradually cleared. He lay in an intensive care ward, sunlight passing through white curtains. Tubes and wires ran all over his body, and doctors and nurses came and went.

"That's right! Not an angel, just your junior, because you aren't dead." Xia Mi seemed to read his mind.

"Not dead?" Chu Zihang tried to move his limbs. Aside from an ache everywhere, every bone was intact. It was incredible. When he lost consciousness and fell, he'd been at the highest point of the track, with no air cushion below. However much he strengthened his bloodline, the body was still supported by human bones made chiefly of calcium carbonate. He couldn't fall two hundred meters and emerge unscathed.

"Does your body hurt? High-voltage current went through you and made your muscles spasm and go numb. Rest and you'll recover. You were lucky: if the current had passed through your heart, an angel really would be welcoming you now." Xia Mi rested her chin in her hand and tilted her head. "This is the college's intensive care ward. You've been unconscious for ten days, kept alive on intravenous nutrients."

"So... I didn't die," Chu Zihang said softly.

"You sound disappointed." Xia Mi rolled her eyes. "Come on, Senior, you escaped death! Could you stop being so expressionless and look happy?"

Chu Zihang stared for a moment, then pulled up the corners of his mouth in a silent smile.

"Not sincere at all!" Xia Mi pouted. "You should say thank you! You survived because your junior was incredibly brave and rushed up to catch you!"

Chu Zihang pressed a hand to his forehead. His memories were confused, but in the long, long dream before he woke he had dimly felt someone holding him, a faint scent of plants at his nose, letting him sleep on in peace.

"I used my Yanling, Wind King's Eye," Xia Mi said.

Chu Zihang nodded. "So your Yanling is Wind King's Eye. No wonder you weren't afraid on the roller coaster."

Yanling: Wind King's Eye, sequence number seventy-four. Within its domain, centered on the user, it manipulates airflow to form a vortex. With sufficient control, the user can hover in the air and even move through it briefly.

"Nothing of the sort. I was scared to death; I was just too embarrassed to say so. Do you think Wind King's Eye works like wings? Changing the path of a fall by manipulating air is easy enough, but landing safely depends on luck. We fell into the deep water on the rapids ride." Xia Mi huffed. "You make it sound so easy, but I took a huge risk! If I could really fly, why wouldn't I fly to America instead of paying for a plane ticket?"

Chu Zihang couldn't be bothered to argue with her nonsense. He was tired, his eyelids heavy, so he closed his eyes.

"Saving you gives me no sense of accomplishment." Xia Mi sounded a little angry.

"Why?"

"I've never seen anyone who values his own life so little! If you think your life is worthless, why should I risk mine to save you?" Xia Mi said indignantly.

"I don't want to die." Chu Zihang kept his eyes closed. "I just couldn't think of another way."

"Do you like cosplaying a hero that much?"

"No. Once before, someone died behind me, and I did nothing. I just kept driving forward... By the time I realized I was a coward and wanted desperately to go back for him, I couldn't find him anymore." Chu Zihang spoke softly. "Do you understand that feeling? If you still have a life to risk, don't wait until you regret it before risking it."

"What feeling?"

"The feeling of 'I'm a coward.'" Chu Zihang opened his eyes and looked at the ceiling.

"You say 'I'm a coward,' but deep down you still think you're amazing. You think if there's something you couldn't do, you must have made a mistake. Because you're so amazing, it's natural for other people to fail, but you can't tolerate failing yourself, and risking your life is a piece of cake?" Xia Mi sounded contemptuous. "You're still trying to be tough! Just how arrogant are you?"

"Yes. Anything I can't do is my fault," Chu Zihang said softly, his mouth a cold, hard line.

Xia Mi was silent a long time. She sighed, her voice softening. "If you always push yourself like that, one day you'll die."

"Don't worry about things that don't concern you." Chu Zihang closed his eyes again. He didn't want to talk to this nagging junior anymore. Xia Mi had saved him, and he would certainly buy her a meal or give her a gift in thanks, but he wasn't good at idle chatter. Weariness rose in waves. He hoped she would be quiet for a while, so he could have some peace too.

"Who says it doesn't concern me? Flowers for your grave cost money!" Xia Mi glared ferociously. "Tell me, what flowers do you want on your grave?"

Chu Zihang thought. "Lilies... or chrysanthemums. Yellow ones."

"Hmm... carnations would be better. Carnations are pretty..."

"In the language of flowers, carnations mean love for one's mother. They aren't grave flowers," Chu Zihang had to remind her.

"Carnations are cheap..."

Could this conversation get any more absurd? Chu Zihang felt inexplicably irritable. If Xia Mi would only say she had something to do and he should sleep, he could go to sleep without feeling rude. But she wouldn't stop talking. How did this junior have so much to say?

"You're the one who likes carnations, aren't you?" Chu Zihang said. He kept forcing himself to talk only because he felt it would be impolite to fall asleep like this.

The ward was quiet except for the monitor's beep... beep... This time Xia Mi actually made no reply.

The sudden silence pleasantly surprised Chu Zihang. Had his talkative junior finally understood what he meant by closing his eyes again and again? Would she let him sleep properly? He opened his eyes to check, and froze.

Hugging her knees, Xia Mi was curled like a kitten on the hardwood chair beside his bed, which could not possibly be comfortable. Her long eyelashes lay lowered, thick as a curtain in the morning light.

She had fallen asleep.

"She hasn't slept in forty-eight hours, has she? Waiting for you to wake up." A nurse checking his oxygen tube draped a blanket over Xia Mi's shoulders and spoke as if in passing.

Rome, Italy.

Frost Gattuso sat upright in sunlight behind his desk. As the Gattuso family's effective head, he sat here almost every day, managing hundreds of thousands of employees around the world without leaving his office.

Two black-and-white photographs now lay side by side on this "desk of power": the ruins of South Railway Station and the Midgard Serpent. Their striking resemblance was unforgettable.

"Buy Six Flags. I need to analyze those ruins." After a long pause, Frost raised a finger and gave the order.

"Negotiations are already underway. At the price we're offering, they'll find it hard to refuse." Parsi bowed slightly, pale-gold bangs falling across half his face.

"A Dragon King awakened? That's a startling conclusion. How certain are we?"

"Jean Grus and Blair Bittner are among the lifetime professors: a leading expert in mechanics and the Solomon of mathematics. Both believe such precise control of stress cannot come from a human. It can only be a Yanling, and a high-level one that only a monarch of the Four could wield," Parsi said. "The monarch who commands pure force is the King of Earth and Mountain."

"Interesting," Frost said coldly. "Actually, I'm more interested in the South Railway Station incident."

"You mean?"

"Suppose it really is a Dragon King. For so noble and tyrannical a creature to launch two assassination-style attacks instead of a direct assault suggests his strength has not fully returned. Anjou drew an important conclusion from the King of Bronze and Fire: after awakening from their burial places, Dragon Kings need time to recover completely. During that period they are like fragile newborns—though compared with humans they are already overwhelmingly powerful monarchs. So why is our newborn Dragon King so eager to strike? Where would he put his limited strength first?" Frost asked languidly.

Parsi considered. "An opponent he has no choice but to eliminate first."

"Exactly. He has no choice. So it's no surprise that he attacked Anjou at Six Flags. Anjou is an opponent every Dragon King would be wary of. But why strike South Railway Station?" Frost wrote two lists of names on a sheet of paper and handed it to Parsi. "Anjou wasn't the Dragon King's real target. His real target is someone who appears on both lists."

Parsi glanced down. The first list read "Raymond, Chu Zihang, Lu Mingfei"; the second, "Anjou, Chu Zihang, Lu Mingfei, Xia Mi."

"Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei?" Parsi said.

"Cross out Lu Mingfei too. His target is Chu Zihang," Frost said.

"Understood." Parsi was accustomed to Frost's decisive style; he often hit the mark on intuition alone.

"There are things about Chu Zihang that cannot be explained. We need to bring him under our control. From the information from China, he has had mysterious experiences involving dragons. I'd very much like to know what they were."

"Understood!" The secretary paused. "One more thing: the hunter named Tang Wei. Are we just going to leave him alone? He seems to have booked a flight to Vietnam."

"He's only a pawn, an insignificant pawn, who knows nothing of what happened behind the scenes. The person who hired him hid their identity through the Hunter Market. We are interested in the Hunter Market, but its technology is unusual. It doesn't even have a fixed server. You could say it is constantly flowing through the world's internet... like a ghost. Until we have the resources to deal with it, let's observe for now." Frost rubbed his temples. "I'm a little tired. I think we need a new principal."

Parsi was startled. "You mean?"

Frost slowly raised his eyes. "Anjou thinks we have no one to replace him. Yes, finding someone to replace Anjou anywhere in the Dragon Blood Secret Party would be impossible. But that doesn't mean he can't be removed. If an executive is good enough, you can allow him a little disobedience. But when he becomes so disobedient that he's nearly beyond our control, he loses his value. It's time Cassell College became an institution managed by the Board of Trustees. Chu Zihang's unstable bloodline will be the best evidence for impeaching Anjou. We can win the support of the great majority of trustees."

"Understood," Parsi said softly. "I'll begin making arrangements at once."

"Go." Frost waved him away.

Parsi retreated to the door. Frost suddenly frowned. "Wait. You haven't looked up at me once today. Why?"

Parsi hesitated for an instant, then silently lifted his golden, silk-like bangs. His eyes were exposed: one ice blue, the other dark gold. However beautiful either color might be alone, seeing both in one face was shocking, like looking at a demon.

Frost averted his gaze. "Have you taken your medicine?"

"The medicine doesn't help. It only makes me a little more comfortable."

"Take some anyway. Someone who doesn't have long to live should be especially good to himself." Frost's voice grew much gentler, with the concern of an elder.

"Thank you." Parsi turned and left.

Chu Zihang opened his eyes. On the silver tray before him was a whole pear. An old, thin hand lifted it by the stem, and strips of peel fell in graceful loops. The peeled pear was handed to him.

"Principal?" Chu Zihang was startled.

The ward was silent; the doctors and nurses who came and went every day had vanished. Anjou sat by the bed, slowly wiping pear juice from a folding knife with a handkerchief. He closed it and slipped it into a leather sheath inside his shirt sleeve.

"How long have you known this technique?" Anjou asked quietly, looking into Chu Zihang's eyes. "Don't try to hide it. I was a member when the Lionheart Society was founded. I know the technique you used. On the roller-coaster track you showed signs of becoming dragonlike. An ordinary hybrid could never do that: purifying your bloodline by your own will, multiplying the power of your Yanling, expanding your domain to an extreme, even displaying dragon traits on the surface of your body!"

"Two years," Chu Zihang said.

"So not long after you became president of the Lionheart Society, you mastered it." Anjou nodded and rose to pace the ward. "You deduced the technique from the society's original records, didn't you?"

"Yes."

"Astonishing." Anjou sighed. "The society's secret materials were accumulated from its founding, before there was even a library. Some cannot be found in the library. But those records were incomplete too. As a founding member, I removed the most important part, the part about blood amplification. Yet you recreated this forbidden technique from the faintest clues. Remarkable, I must admit. But do you understand why I removed those materials?"

"Blood amplification makes a person extremely aggressive: a will to kill."

"Yes. That so-called will to kill is a mental force unique to dragons. Biologically, it's like a beast becoming excited by the smell of blood: it is determined by genes, called the bloodthirst gene. When dragons are enraged, they have the impulse to attack every target. After blood amplification, a hybrid's will to kill also increases; a gentle person may become as cruel as a beast. But that isn't why the technique became forbidden."

Chu Zihang nodded. "I'm listening."

Anjou was silent for a long time. "The college curriculum deliberately overlooks the origin of hybrids. Some things are too filthy for us to wish to tell; others lie so close to forbidden territory that we dare not disclose them. But perhaps I can tell you. You've already stepped into that territory." He sighed. "There should never have been hybrids in this world. Dragons disdain mixing their blood with humans, just as humans have no hybrids with other primates. No one would willingly try to have offspring with a gorilla; even cultivating an embryo in a test tube would cross a moral boundary. Yet hybrids did appear. We were forcibly created... out of human greed."

"Because of an extraordinary event, humans killed the Black King and took the world from the dragons. They should have buried the dragons completely to prevent revenge. But some could not bear to destroy them. Dragons were creatures too powerful and beautiful, possessing the arts of alchemy and Yanling. Humans coveted those powers and continued studying the surviving dragons. Under the pretext of offering tribute to gods, they made human women bear dragon hybrids, thus creating the so-called hybrids. It was a cruel and barbaric ritual," Anjou said softly. "The women offered to dragons seldom survived until the children were born. Their bodies were too fragile, and the children they carried too powerful. In cages of iron bars, in dark dungeons, or bound to carved stone altars, they struggled in agony, covered in blood, unable to give birth. In the end the offspring broke out through the mother who served as its vessel. Docile offspring were raised; dangerous ones were killed with spears thrust through the cages. Then they continued interbreeding generation after generation until the bloodline stabilized. That is the filthy history of hybrids."

Chu Zihang closed his eyes slightly, as if he could see darker blood splashed on dark stone walls, lamplight flickering, women's cries and monsters' roars echoing deep in a cellar while primeval priests chanted hymns.

That history really was filthy enough to make one sick.

"You all know the definition of a hybrid: the proportion of human blood must exceed the proportion of dragon blood; otherwise the person is an aberration. Usually, the higher the proportion of

dragon blood, the greater the bloodline advantage. But once it passes a certain limit, the critical blood threshold, everything changes. Dragon genes are powerful enough to alter those of another species. In a hybrid who passes that threshold, human genes will be forcibly rewritten as dragon genes. He will complete an evolution," Anjou said.

"Evolution?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Evolution into a dragon, a higher form of life."

"Can a hybrid evolve into a complete dragon?"

Anjou shook his head. "No. They can approach a dragon infinitely closely... but never reach the end."

"Why?"

"Because the human genes fight back." Anjou picked a dry, hardened bread crumb from the tray and slowly ground it between two fingers. Fragments drifted onto the tray. "Before dragon genes, human genes are too weak to mention. Dragon genes overwhelm them as easily as a powerful steamroller crushes gravel into dust. But imagine what happens after the steamroller crushes the gravel..." He turned his hand over to show Chu Zihang his fingertips. Tiny crumbs still remained. Anjou ground them again, using several times as much force, and turned his hand over. The crumbs were still there.

"Once it's dust, grinding it again does no good. You can't erase it entirely, reduce it to zero," Anjou said softly.

Chu Zihang started. "Human genes can't be rewritten completely!"

"At the very end, human genes show astonishing tenacity. They fight back. The powerful dragon genes cannot eliminate that last trace of impurity. What dragons consider impure remains like dregs. So hybrids never truly evolve into pure-blooded dragons. They become things called death servitors. At the final moment of evolution they die, losing themselves like walking corpses. Dragons don't regard them as their own kind, and humans see them as enemies. If the dragons' world is heaven and the human world hell, they are lost souls between heaven and hell, accepted by no one. The call of their blood makes them obey dragons, who use them as cannon fodder in war against humans. Their deaths don't matter, because new ones are always being born."

"I understand." After a long silence, Chu Zihang nodded.

"Blood amplification is forbidden because it briefly activates the dragon bloodline. The side effect is that it can push you past the critical blood threshold. Once you cross it, you're like a roller coaster on a downward track: nothing can pull you back. This technique is a devil. The pleasure of instantly purifying your bloodline will immerse you in the illusion that you can do anything. If you're too greedy for power, the devil will quietly lead you across the boundary and push you into the abyss. You will end as a death servitor. Then I can only kill you; for the person you would be, death would be the best ending." Anjou stared into Chu Zihang's eyes.

"Are you going to expel me?" Chu Zihang asked quietly.

Anjou rose, his back to Chu Zihang. "I can pretend I don't know about your blood amplification. But if the Board of Trustees learns of it, you can imagine how they'll deal with you. As an educator, I never break the rules I set myself. This may be the only exception I ever make. Your courage left a deep impression on me. Don't abuse forbidden arts. Everyone wants to live a little longer."

"Remember to eat the pear." He pushed open the door and left. Chu Zihang sat alone on the bed as rain began to fall outside.

Driving rain beat against the chapel's bell tower, and the bell boomed in the wind. The door opened. A figure dressed in black entered with a black umbrella.

"Doesn't living here bother you? Listening to that bell all the time is like attending a funeral." The figure sat in the armchair in the corner. "Get me a drink, anything."

"You get used to it. That way, on the day of my funeral, I'll hear the bell outside my coffin and think I'm lying in my own bed." The middle-aged man hunched over the computer screen spoke lazily. "Anjou, on a gloomy rainy day like this, could you please not come listen to the bell dressed like an undertaker?"

"Black suit. What's wrong with it? Haven't I dressed this way all the years you've known me?" Anjou loosened his tie and unbuttoned the collar of his white shirt.

"Because all these years you've been preparing for a funeral." The Night Watcher casually picked up a bottle of single-malt whisky and a suspicious-looking glass, poured a little under half a glass, and handed it to Anjou.

Anjou curled up in the armchair and drank a mouthful at a time. Neither man spoke for a long while. It was a truly untidy attic. The sunny side was all glass windows, covered with huge posters of low-cut women. The room held only an unmade bed, a single armchair, a computer desk and swivel chair, and a large bookcase packed with Western DVDs. There were also empty liquor bottles all over the floor and adult magazines scattered everywhere. The Night Watcher, a hidden figure at the college, had lived here for decades, in the style of a frustrated adolescent boy.

The attic's style clashed violently with Anjou's taste, but when he came in he naturally took the most comfortable place. He knew the room well; he had to, because it was the only place to find the Night Watcher.

Everyone has a few disreputable friends who always arrange to meet somewhere of dubious cleanliness, over cheap beer and messy seafood. Yet you still put on your custom Armani suit and go, trading spit as you hurl insults at each other, and never tire of it.

Then he's probably a true friend.

"Let me use your speakers." Anjou tossed the Night Watcher a voice recorder.

After a rustle of static came two low male voices, both sounding as if they were talking in their sleep. The first was Anjou's own. The Night Watcher started slightly when he heard the second.

"You didn't see any cars on that elevated road, correct?"

"No cars at all... Quiet, very quiet. Only wind and rain."

"Do you remember how fast you were going?"

"The speed seemed... to disappear."

"Tell me about the shadows. Who were they?"

"They were hungry... they were thirsty... they wanted fresh meat, but they couldn't get it... they... were dead."

"Do you remember the number of the entrance to the elevated road?"

"The sign... was hidden by a willow."

"But you looked at the sign, didn't you? That's why you remember the willow covering it."

"I looked... couldn't see... the willow... swaying in front of the sign..."

"Think more carefully. You looked at that sign... a road sign, a green sign. The willow hid it, but the wind made the willow sway and exposed some words, didn't it? Some words were exposed. Do you remember anything?"

The breathing suddenly grew unusually heavy, shaking the entire attic through the high-fidelity speakers. The whole space seemed like a monster's enormous lung, contracting and expanding, contracting and expanding. The rain outside grew clearer, as though that night without a visible sky had returned. That night was a devil, and wind and rain were its messengers. The Night Watcher frowned and ran his tongue over his teeth. It was like watching a horror film at its climax: you knew the bloodsucking villain was bound to leap out at you, but no longer wanted to look away. You simply waited, eagerly waiting to see from which direction it would spring.

"000... number 000!" The breathing stopped, as though the narrator had been cut down with a single stroke.

Anjou switched off the recorder. "When I visited Chu Zihang this afternoon, I hypnotized him. He doesn't know it himself. I meant to hear about blood amplification, but I didn't expect to record this."

"Sounds like a nightmare," the Night Watcher said softly.

"I checked the map. The entrances to that elevated road start at 001."

The Night Watcher nodded. "So the entrance Chu Zihang took didn't exist. Did they find the Maybach afterward?"

"They found it in a wasteland outside the city. The body was badly damaged, as if hundreds of sharks had bitten it. The site was fifteen kilometers from the nearest elevated road. There were no tow-truck tracks nearby; it drove there under its own power." Anjou handed him a black-and-white photograph: a Maybach riddled with holes, sunk in mud. "The only fingerprints on the steering wheel belonged to Chu Zihang and his father. One of the two must have driven it there."

"So it was in that wasteland that Chu Zihang encountered Odin, leader of the Aesir in Norse myth, while believing he was on the elevated road." The Night Watcher slowly chewed a piece of ice. "A hallucination?"

"Chu Zihang was young then, but his father's Yanling, like mine, was Time Zero, which requires an exceptionally pure bloodline. If even he couldn't detect that he was experiencing an illusion, then whoever created it must have been at Dragon King level."

"In the myths, Odin is the black dragon's mortal enemy. He's righteous. He ought to appear with beautiful Valkyries, not death servitors."

"Yes, but the black shadows Chu Zihang described sound far too much like death servitors."

"What a mess. Could Chu Zihang have been delirious?" The Night Watcher scratched his head hard.

Anjou stared into his eyes. "There's another possibility. You've already guessed it, but you're hesitating to say it, aren't you?"

"Then he saw a ghost..." The Night Watcher's expression was strange, his cheek muscles jumping and the corners of his eyes twitching. It was impossible to tell whether he was frightened or making a face.

"Yes," Anjou said softly. "He may really have seen a ghost."

"Don't talk nonsense!" The Night Watcher sprang out of his swivel chair. "Nibelungen, the land of the dead? It's like a holy temple! For thousands of years alchemists have racked their brains trying to find it, and a child just happened to wander in?"

"It's rare to see you uneasy. All these years, whatever I've told you, you've curled up on the sofa like a lazy snake, and even grown a beer belly." Anjou pointed at the paunch his plaid shirt couldn't conceal.

The Night Watcher looked down. The eight-pack he had once proudly displayed to bar girls whenever he was drunk had become a single bulging lump. The handsome, free-spirited Western young man of those days was long gone; now he was merely a sleazy middle-aged man who liked cowboy clothes. Nothing had excited him in decades, because nothing had seemed worth excitement. The days numbed by hard liquor, Westerns, and pictures of sexy women had been pleasant enough. But if the exit leading to that holy temple had truly reopened, his comfortable days were nearly over.

"Tell me about Nibelungen in detail. You know far more than I do about alchemy and the secrets of dragons," Anjou said.

The Night Watcher pondered for a long time. "Nibelungen, the land of the dead, may be only a legend. It may not exist at all. Even if it does, it's been closed for many years. The last witch who claimed she'd been there was burned on a cross. That was back in the Middle Ages. It's the holy land every alchemist wants to visit. Though it's called the land of the dead, it isn't the underworld or hell. It's full of treasure."

"Treasure?" Anjou frowned.

"If you summed up alchemy in one sentence, it would be to 'kill' matter, then make it 'live again.' During rebirth, impurities are removed and matter acquires new properties. But killing matter isn't as simple as killing a person. To kill metal, generations of alchemists have pursued ever higher flame temperatures and miraculous formulas."

"Death is the prerequisite for life." Anjou nodded.

"Yes. Dead matter makes the best material. To refine gold, first kill silver; to forge a sharp sword, first kill steel. And in Nibelungen, the land of the dead, dead matter is everywhere. An alchemist once described that realm... There is no day or night. A half-dark, half-bright light always floats in the sky. The ground and mountains are bronze-colored, made of dead earth and metal; the sky is gray, made of dead air; flames are a cold blue, made of dead fire; and water cannot float anything, because the water too is dead. There are cities built of the bones of dead living things. The fifth element, spirit, is concentrated in them, and can be refined into the legendary Philosopher's Stone. So you can understand why alchemists long for it. Even Nibelungen's dust is worth a fortune to them. In Wagner's opera The Ring of the Nibelung, a dwarf steals the gold of the Nibelungen and forges a ring with the magic to rule the world. It's very like what the alchemists say."

"All of this comes from Norse mythology, doesn't it?" Anjou thought for a moment. "The black dragon Nidhogg guards the branch of the World Tree that leads to the land of the dead; he is the gatekeeper. At Ragnarok the sea is split open, and a great ship made of dead men's nails rises from it, crowded with the dead. That is the army of the land of the dead going to war against the living."

"I spent half my life pursuing the legend of the land of the dead, traveling as far as Antarctica, but I never found that mysterious realm," the Night Watcher said. "That doesn't mean it doesn't exist."

"Did you find evidence that it exists?"

The Night Watcher shook his head. "Not evidence, only speculation. Anjou, have you noticed that our research on dragons is missing an important link? We rarely find ruins of places where dragons lived together, especially from the time when the Black King Nidhogg ruled the world in the name of a god. Even Egyptian pharaohs left a pile of pyramids."

Anjou nodded. "Yes. Not one ruin from before the Black King Nidhogg was killed has been excavated."

"What a splendid civilization it had been! They had enslaved humanity and built magnificent cities. The ancient records said that the King of Bronze and Fire had lived on the northern ice fields, where he cast a bronze palace as towering as a mountain. There, too, stood the famous bronze pillar that held up the sky, on which the Black King had nailed the White King to death; the enormous column recorded the Black King's long history of war. He had also ordered the construction of a divine road across the ocean, calculated to have been four hundred meters wide—an undertaking greater than any highway today. But when the Black King died, those great monuments vanished, like Atlantis sinking beneath the ocean overnight."

"Many peoples of the world have legends of ancient civilizations that suddenly disappeared," Anjou said. "Do they refer to the sudden fall of the dragons' civilization?"

"Very likely. If our ancestors all said an ancient civilization vanished suddenly, perhaps they really had once been awed by its splendor. Even today people use Google Maps to search the world for lost Atlantis, but they find only ancient human settlements submerged by the sea. The real ancient civilization may be hidden in another dimension, and reaching it requires a mysterious entrance."

Anjou slowly tilted his head toward the black ceiling and exhaled a breath heavy with alcohol, savoring the mysterious aura rising like magic from the Night Watcher's words. "A parallel space?"

The Night Watcher spread his hands. "I'm an alchemist. I have no common academic language with scientists like you. We do better talking about wine and women. The land of the dead belongs to the occult; don't try to explain it with relativity. Legends of it aren't confined to Norse myth. In Tibet, China, some believe that after death a person wanders a mysterious realm for forty-nine days. The soul is then called zhongyin, transcribed as 'Antrabhara.' No eminent monk has said where that realm is. It may be a real space, or only consciousness lingering after death."

"All right, mystic." Anjou spread his hands. "Do any records say how to open the land of the dead?"

"Die..."

"Obviously! I mean go there alive!" Anjou pressed his forehead.

"I told you: master alchemists of every age wanted to go alive, and none succeeded. They've all gone now, though, because they're all dead."

"But Chu Zihang went in."

"He doesn't seem to know what happened either. He just wandered in by mistake."

"But he's our only clue so far."

The Night Watcher was silent for a moment. "Yes. Someone who's been there may still be able to find the old road. Like a medium, at the boundary between day and night, able to communicate with different worlds. Those who can enter Nibelungen are chosen by dragons."

The rain grew heavier, dense drops striking the glass. Anjou turned toward the window. The Night Watcher watched his companion of many years: seated on the sofa before the floor-to-ceiling window, back straight, his silhouette lean and hard. Though he wore only a suit, he had the imposing dignity of a warrior in iron armor. Whenever he displayed such an aura, it came from an intense desire for conquest.

"If you really found an entrance to Nibelungen, what would you do?"

"Tie the dragons up in their temples, put a nuclear bomb in each temple, and detonate them all at once. I'd sit on the bronze pillar where the White King was nailed to death and watch the world of those reptiles fall, fire raining from the sky." Anjou spoke mildly. "The thought is beautiful."

"That's performance art!" the Night Watcher exclaimed. "But it's your style."

"You know me best. That's why I came to you with the recording and had a drink to celebrate." Anjou raised his glass. "But I have a little problem. To make sure I can hold out until we find Nibelungen, I need a favor."

"Come to think of it, dinner must have been too greasy. For some reason I suddenly have a stomachache..." The Night Watcher clutched his belly.

"Could you come up with a more professional excuse?"

The Night Watcher pulled a face. "You'll think I'm making excuses whenever I say no anyway... Go on, what is it? Whenever you ask me for help, it's a matter of life and death."

"I've just heard that an investigative delegation from the Board of Trustees will arrive at the college next week. They probably intend to fire me as principal," Anjou said mildly.

"Wait, wait, wait! Fire you?" The Night Watcher was startled.

"Mm. I've been accused of three major errors and forty-eight minor ones. The board is seriously dissatisfied with my report and doubts that I'm still capable of remaining principal."

"Come on. If they fire you, who could take over? Frost Gattuso? You must be joking... He's already bald, and not half as handsome as you."

"Don't change the subject," Anjou said. "It looks sudden, but we argued at the board's annual meeting a few weeks ago. At the time I was as confident as you are: they couldn't find anyone to replace me. Now they seem unable to wait."

"What set it off?"

"The Six Flags incident. Chu Zihang unleashed Sovereign Flame in public and melted steel in an instant. That went far beyond an ordinary Yanling. The board suspects his bloodline is dangerous, and bringing a dangerous bloodline into the college is a major dereliction of duty. Prove that and they can fire me. In addition, Chu Zihang was under investigation in the Nibelungen Project. The information the board obtained from China mentioned his accidental entry into the land of the dead. It's deeply suspicious: anyone can see it must be connected to dragons, and no ordinary dragons at that. Chu Zihang was involved and came back alive. That too will make them question his bloodline."

"The board knows about Nibelungen?" The Night Watcher frowned.

"No. They probably haven't made that connection yet. But if they take Chu Zihang away, they can hypnotize him as I did and pry the story out of him."

"That wouldn't necessarily be bad. If the board knew how to enter Nibelungen, perhaps they'd fund a few nuclear bombs for you to take in and blow it up. Preferably they'd blow you up with it. I can imagine how much they dislike you." The Night Watcher said, "Then your wish as a revenge maniac would be fulfilled, the board would regain power, and everyone would be happy."

"Would you be happy too?" Anjou carried his glass to the window and looked toward the rain-washed sculptures atop Valhalla.

"As an old friend, I'd attend your funeral and promise not to make a scene." The Night Watcher puffed out his chest.

"The people on the board can't stand against dragons. You know it and I know it; only they don't. They have no idea how cruel war is, yet they're already confident that after the dragons are completely buried, they'll hold power over the world," Anjou said. "And the war has only just begun."

The Night Watcher shrugged. "They're politicians. Politicians always think about building a new world before the war is over, like the United States and the former Soviet Union deciding how to divide Europe into spheres of influence before they'd taken Berlin."

"But I'm a soldier. I only need to live until the war ends." Anjou looked at the Night Watcher. "Friend, I still need your support until then."

The Night Watcher sighed. "Friend, you're so old you're nearly dead. Why do you keep going?"

"You know. Why ask again?"

The Night Watcher nodded. "You're an undertaker, so you always wear black and carry a folding knife in your sleeve. For a hundred years, every moment you've thought of killing—no, slaying dragons. You're the sort who holds a grudge. Anyone who makes an enemy of you has only death waiting, unless they kill you first. I just wonder why you're so stubborn."

"And what are you thinking? Why have you stayed at Cassell all these years? Don't tell me you're here drinking beer in retirement." Anjou turned to look at him.

The Night Watcher scratched his head. "I'm not telling you... I don't want to make up a lie."

Anjou laughed. "You, honest? You used to sweet-talk women all the time."

"But you aren't a woman, so I can't lie to you."

"You're like a man who'd die if he couldn't make a bad joke." Anjou picked up the umbrella he'd brought and headed for the door. He had achieved his purpose in coming.

"Hey, Anjou," the Night Watcher said behind him.

Anjou stopped, neither speaking nor turning around.

"I don't like the tycoons and politicians on the board. For their interests they can sacrifice anyone. Politicians have no morals or limits to begin with. But they still want to build: to create a new age of hybrids and hold power in it. You only want to bury the dragons... I believe you. Given the chance, you'll end them with the mushroom clouds of nuclear bombs. When fire rains from the sky, you'll light a cigar and pour a glass of champagne to honor your old friends. Your life is spent waiting for that moment of performance art," the Night Watcher said quietly. "But Anjou, think carefully. All you

want is destruction. You care about nothing else. You've reached a dead end. Who do you think you are? The goddess of vengeance?"

Anjou stood in the doorway beneath his umbrella, rain falling from its edge. He gazed at the iron-gray sky, apparently thinking, his back blurred and distant.

"You're wrong," Anjou said gravely. "The god of vengeance."

Act Eleven

The Engagement

Engagement

Nono would always be the fierce little red-haired witch driving a Ferrari, ruthless and full of mischief. Marriage would still be a distant future for her; she had yet to learn to cook, stubbornly preferred ice cream close to the color of her hair, and raced with him down dark mountain roads...

But things would change. Everyone would leave, and he would be left where he was.

The CC1000 branch express raced across the fields of early autumn. Beneath a blue sky washed clean, the vegetation shifted from deep green to gold to reddish brown, changing like a rainbow.

Andrew Gattuso, head of the investigation team, admired the magnificent view with a calm, dignified expression, though emotions surged within him.

He was the Gattuso family's chief legal counsel, a Yale Law School graduate who had attended the same university as several American presidents. He was also a hybrid. Unfortunately, his talent for Yanling was limited, so he had spent the first half of his life in charge of the consortium's legal affairs, never directly involving himself in the family's largest investment, the College. But he understood its importance. It consumed money, yet it mattered more than all the family's profitable institutions. The College brought together the finest hybrids in every field. A hybrid who had never set foot there, never sat down to speak with its tenured professors and won their approval, was second-rate in the eyes of other hybrids, no matter how successful he was in the world of ordinary humans.

Today he had finally won his chance. He was not making a pilgrimage to the College; he had received the Board of Trustees' highest authorization to impeach the tyrannical principal who had been running amok there.

He would display his talent before the greatest hybrid elites. His powers of analysis, his logical mind, his profoundly moving eloquence: all seemed to have been prepared for this day.

Andrew Gattuso: that name would go down in history as a legal genius among hybrids! And the code of law he wielded was the sacred Abraham Bloodline Covenant!

"We'll arrive at the terminal in five minutes. The train has begun to slow." The young secretary entered the VIP car and bowed slightly.

Andrew nodded, reasonably pleased with the secretary's efficiency. The young man, Parsi, had been assigned to the delegation by Mr. Frost Gattuso, who considered him worth cultivating. Andrew thought that although he was nowhere near as spirited as Andrew himself had been at his age, he was at least obedient. Andrew did not much like Parsi's taste in hairstyles, however. The secretary always combed his beautiful blond hair into long bangs that covered his eyes, and Andrew could never see them clearly. Andrew thought it very bad not to look one's superior honestly in the eye.

"Has the College been informed of our arrival time?" Andrew adjusted his collar.

"Yes. They said they would meet us at the station."

"Good. You're very thorough." Andrew generously offered the young man encouragement. "Are they still calm?" He imagined the old fellow who had occupied the principal's seat for nearly a century hearing that the Board was openly investigating him. Surely it would feel like a thunderbolt from the blue.

"I couldn't tell over the phone."

Andrew remembered something and put on a stern face. "Remember, we're here on behalf of the Board. Everything must be strictly official. Don't have too much contact with them outside work, or they may influence you."

"Understood!" Parsi hesitated. "But impeaching the principal requires more than the Board. All the tenured professors have to vote. Until Principal Anjou has been found negligent, could we take a gentler approach?"

"Gentler?" Andrew said coldly. "We already have more than enough evidence regarding Anjou, and that student Chu Zihang!"

"One is president of the Lionheart Society, a student leader, and the other is the principal. If we handle this badly," Parsi said softly, "I'm afraid the students' emotions could get out of control."

Andrew sneered, not bothering to comment on Parsi's childish worry. What if the students lost control? Would they defy the Board? Riot? They should not forget that the Board—or rather, the Secret Party's council of elders—was itself the most powerful institution of force!

"Arrange my schedule. I want to visit every department head and every tenured professor. If Anjou cooperates with our investigation, I can have a friendly conversation with him. If he chooses to resist, there's no need for me to see him!" Andrew's tone was uncompromising.

"Understood."

At the sound of the whistle as the train entered the station, Andrew sprang to his feet, face stern and chest out, like a warrior going to battle. "Cassell College was founded as a military academy against the dragons. Now it is time to put it back on the right track!"

"Welcome, welcome! A warm welcome!"

"Welcome to the Board's investigation team! We look forward to your guidance."

"Professor Andrew, you've had a long journey!"

Andrew had barely stepped out of the car when cheers like these washed over him.

What was going on? Something seemed wrong. Had they stopped at the wrong station? Was he hearing things? Shouldn't the principal be waiting nervously beside a black sedan, looking grief-stricken as he awaited this imperial envoy? Andrew had prepared himself. If Anjou tried to curry favor before the investigation by inviting him to afternoon tea, he would refuse on principle: "I'm here to work, not drink tea."

But why was there a parade float? With banners streaming and colorful flags waving... And what were all those boys and girls on the platform doing with bouquets in their hands? Good Lord! A middle-aged fellow appeared beside him, wearing a bright-red Hawaiian shirt and plastic-framed sunglasses, and rushed up to embrace him!

He must have entered some wrong dimension and seen a bizarre scene. Surely if he stepped back into the train, closed the door, and opened it again, everything would return to normal!

Andrew had no time to close the door. The scruffy man swept him into a deep embrace and pounded his back as though trying to stop him coughing. The heavy smell of alcohol made Andrew dizzy. A pretty girl appeared beside them and slipped a Hawaiian-style lei around his neck. Surrounded by the crowd, he stumbled onto the float decked in red and green.

"Is this... a kidnapping?" Andrew was utterly bewildered.

Parsi hurried after him and leaned close to his ear. "This should be the procession the College sent to welcome you. This gentleman is probably... the vice principal!"

"The vice principal?" Andrew's mind went blank. He had read the College's documents. Did the place actually have a vice principal? He had never seen a vice principal's signature on any document.

"He's the Night Watcher," Parsi whispered. "Vice principal is an honorary title. He doesn't handle any specific duties."

The words "Night Watcher" startled Andrew. He looked the figure up and down, somewhere between a scruffy middle-aged man and a scruffy old grandfather, and could not possibly connect him with the person in the photograph. The College's number two, the Night Watcher, was an important figure hidden in the shadows. Andrew had researched him before coming and even obtained a photograph, though it had been taken in Bolivia in 1934... But however swiftly the years passed, surely he could not have changed this much? Where was the sculpted, handsome face? The high Greek nose? The long, slender curls somewhere between a rake's and a young rocker's? The eyes, both seductive and innocent, that could enchant women from young wives to grandmothers?

Time had made the old fellow into a complete tragedy!

The vice principal apparently had no idea what Andrew was thinking. He leaned in, nodding repeatedly and radiating enthusiasm. "We've been waiting for you! I've thought for ages it was time someone dealt with him. He lives as long as a tortoise! He's kept me vice principal all these years!"

Hundreds of students held bouquets aloft around the float as it rolled slowly along. The crowd roared, balloons and ribbons flew through the air, and the faint sound of champagne corks popping could be heard. They all seemed delighted by the investigation team's visit, ready to turn it into a grand College festival.

The vice principal put an arm around Andrew's shoulders, his face full of pride. "The students are in good spirits, aren't they?" He gave a vigorous thumbs-up. "I knew the investigation team would be pleased!"

Without giving Andrew a chance to answer, he raised an arm high. "Hello, students! Thank you for all your hard work!"

The students responded loudly, "Hello, sir! You're the one who works hardest..."

Andrew had no idea this "wrong welcome" was only the beginning of a succession of mistakes... Starting with the banquet, the mistake plunged into an utterly irreversible abyss!

Principal Hilbert Jean Anjou did not appear at all, much less invite him to afternoon tea. Reportedly, he was suffering from a severe throat infection. The hospitable vice principal took over all reception duties on behalf of the College's management. "You've come to investigate him, so he's upset!" he told Andrew privately.

"Never mind him. It wasn't easy getting here, so you should eat well. No need to stand on ceremony; just call me Old Mei." The vice principal kept Andrew's arm tightly linked in his all the way.

The banquet was authentic Chinese cuisine. The appetizer was Indian aster and shredded tofu salad, the main course roast duck from an open oven, and the soup hot-and-sour soup with dough pieces... The sommelier filled everyone's glass with a potent spirit called erguotou. Before Andrew could object, the vice principal embraced him and steered him to his seat. "If you won't drink with me, I won't help you deal with Anjou! You've got to give me face!" His heartfelt loyalty to the Board could have been witnessed by sun and moon. Accustomed to red wine, Andrew had never imagined such a clear, pure liquid could burn so fiercely. When the vice principal raised his glass, said "Let's knock one back," and drained it, Andrew assumed it was some kind of custom and drained his too.

"You can really hold your liquor!" the vice principal exclaimed. What followed was the opening of one bottle of erguotou after another, with the exuberance of champagne being opened at a grand wedding.

Andrew could hardly refuse such kindness. The vice principal had not only declared his loyalty to the Board, but had brought in department heads and tenured professors to join them. These were precisely the people Andrew had planned to divide and win over before coming. So he had no choice but to summon his courage and imitate the vice principal, carrying a little glass liquor pot around the round table and drinking with each of them in turn.

"Mr. Vice Principal, aren't you... French?" Andrew, swaying on his feet, finally realized this reception was exactly like a Chinese township welcoming officials on an inspection visit. He had once represented the consortium on a trip to China to study its investment climate.

"Yes, born and raised in Paris." The vice principal widened his eyes. "You think I have a bit of Chinese style, don't you? During World War II I helped Chennault set up the Flying Tigers in China and lived there for more than ten years. I can even sing Chinese folk songs..."

In high spirits, the vice principal threw back his head and sang several songs. The only words Andrew could remember were: "When friends come, there's good wine; if jackals come, hunting rifles will welcome them..."

The next day, Andrew was still hungover when the enthusiastic vice principal woke him by phone to visit one of the College's special programs: radio calisthenics. Supposedly the vice principal had learned this advanced practice while fighting the Japanese in China, and the College's Chinese-language instruction over the past decade had also been proposed by him.

The third day's program was a visit to the College's award ceremony for "Three-Good Students," naturally another Chinese educational tradition. It was solemn yet lively, but only at the end did Andrew discover that this year's recipient was Chu Zihang, the subject of his investigation...

The fourth day's program was an examination for the female students' deep-water certification. Andrew had no choice but to accept the vice principal's kindly arrangements, change into swim trunks, and sit with him on lounge chairs beside the pool, drinking erguotou over ice while watching girls in white bikinis dive gracefully into the water, their lotus-root-like arms rising and falling as they broke the clear surface.

"Nice view, isn't it?" The vice principal beamed and lowered his voice. "I've always thought the girls at our College have great figures!"

Over those days Andrew's entire worldview came close to collapse. He did not know what sort of people the family's years of investment had been supporting at the College. Weren't they supposed to be landmark figures in science, towering authorities in the occult, Executive Department

commissioners with wills of steel? This was supposed to be a sacred hall of learning admired by all hybrids, yet besides its flamboyant, domineering principal, it had an even more flamboyant and sleazy vice principal!

On the evening of the fourth day, filled with grief and indignation, he phoned Frost Gattuso in Rome.

Late at night, a light was still burning in the Night Watcher's little attic in the bell tower.

"A record full of misconduct! Absolutely full of it!" The vice principal slapped the papers in his hand, distraught. "My old friend, no wonder they're investigating you. Your actions during your time as principal can only be described as lawless, all right?"

"As vice principal, you collect your salary every month without fail, but a sleazy fellow who just hides in the attic drinking and reading adult magazines isn't qualified to say that, is he?" Anjou's brows drooped. He looked a little dispirited. The papers in the Night Watcher's hands were the Board's formal impeachment documents, clearly organized and supported by solid evidence. This investigation team seemed serious. After the fourth day, Andrew had abruptly become tough, coldly refusing all the vice principal's planned activities and then releasing the documents publicly.

"The rest is easy enough. I already explained things like 'giving extra attention to young, pretty girls' for you... But this business with Chu Zihang..." The Night Watcher scratched his head.

"Hey, how did you explain it?" Anjou felt inexplicably nervous.

"I said you're old and have little pleasure left in life, so spending time with young girls is good for your cardiovascular health and does no harm. And you're very attentive to little boys like Lu Mingfei too, so there's no sign you have improper intentions..."

"Hey! Are you the one the Board sent to smear me?"

"Let's set that aside and talk about Chu Zihang. He's your weak point now, and you've decided to protect him. Don't underestimate this team. Andrew may be useless, but Frost must be directing him from behind the scenes. After a brief period of confusion, they've regrouped and launched an attack, concentrating all their fire on Chu Zihang in front of every department head. The department heads are the College's core strength. If they decide you aren't fit to remain principal, that's when you'll really be thrown out. They won't care if your private life is disreputable..."

"Hey! My private life isn't disreputable!" Anjou protested.

"I said those were small matters! Set them aside!" The vice principal sounded very broad-minded. "But the department heads will care that you brought a dangerous bloodline onto campus. That's your fatal weakness. They've already decided to hold a hearing. In name it's a hearing, but in reality it's a court to try you, with Chu Zihang standing trial in your place. The two of you are tied together now. If he goes down, you go down with him. All the tenured professors are the jury, and King Solomon, the leader of the professors, is the judge."

"Can we assign Chu Zihang a lawyer?"

"You have me! Your reliable old friend! I'll represent the College's management and tear into the investigation team. Just watch my magnificent performance!"

Anjou glanced at him. "You look suspicious..."

"In any case, I'm the only lawyer you can send out now... or enforcer. Want some professional advice from your lawyer?" The vice principal crossed his legs like a seasoned shyster and blew clouds of smoke.

"All right." Anjou shrugged. "What should we do to prepare to win this trial?"

The vice principal held his hand like a blade and chopped downward. "Naturally, destroy the evidence!"

"You have absolutely no sense of morality... but I like it. All right, let's talk about how to destroy the evidence." Anjou nodded.

"We have someone even more professional at destroying evidence!" The vice principal clapped and called, "Come in!"

The door opened. Anjou drew a sharp breath, staring in shock at the face wearing a thoroughly loserish grin. "Fingel? Haven't you graduated? Weren't you sent away as an Executive Department commissioner? Why are you here?"

"At your service, Principal!" Fingel bobbed and bowed.

"The College's finest news expert, though his grades are a little poor." The vice principal clapped Fingel's shoulder vigorously. "He already has a preliminary plan for winning this trial."

"He's a student! Involving him will let him learn too much that he shouldn't know!" Anjou's tone was icy. "Those who know too much aren't usually the longest-lived among us!"

"You have to trust our young people!" The vice principal put an arm around Fingel's neck. "Just as you chose Lu Mingfei, Fingel is the one I chose. Don't look so surprised. Think of the name of the campus forum."

Anjou remembered. The forum was called... the Night Watcher forum.

Everything was easy to explain now. The name was not merely an expression of the students' respect for the vice principal. He was the mastermind behind it. Between drinking and reading magazines of beautiful women in his attic, he had also spared no effort cultivating his own power among the students. He controlled the News Department, that shameless band of paparazzi who dared post Anjou's official travel bills and photographs of department heads' first girlfriends online. In the end, almost nobody on campus dared offend the News Department lightly.

Anjou restrained the urge to throw tables and chairs at the pair. "All right, Fingel. Can you keep a secret? What are your conditions?"

"Please let me graduate." Fingel stood at attention.

"You're... from the class of 2001, aren't you? You still haven't graduated?" Anjou was startled. In a corner he had never paid attention to, a loser like this was still hanging on.

"Principal, you've touched a sore spot..."

"All right. It's a deal. If Chu Zihang can remain enrolled after the hearing, you'll graduate at the end of the academic year." Anjou sighed. "How could this happen? You were an A-rank we placed great hopes in!"

"I'm G-rank now..." For once, even Fingel looked embarrassed.

"There's... a rank that low?" Anjou was shocked again.

"They created it for me... because I got demoted again."

Anjou shook his head. "All right. I suppose the vice principal has told you everything. I know we have plenty of evidence we can't conceal. Tell me your plan."

Fingel opened a folder, his voice low and manner professional. "Chu Zihang, third-year, A-rank student, a key cultivation target for the College. He has thirteen missions behind him. Contrary to his mild outward appearance, his methods are forceful and reckless. Take this mission in China: his nearly uncontrolled actions sent fifty-three people to the hospital. The fact that nobody died was only luck. The records show thirteen missions and thirteen disciplinary citations. If Professor Schneider of the Executive Department weren't his adviser, he'd have been expelled long ago. Add his golden eyes that can't be extinguished and his dangerous Yanling, and his continued enrollment really is a failure of our management."

"It's that serious?" Anjou found his head aching too.

"His misdeeds are notorious, his crimes unforgivable!" Fingel declared firmly.

"Can we still clean up his image?"

"About as difficult as washing a lump of coal white."

Anjou pressed a hand to his forehead.

"Worst of all, because his style is so outrageous, many of the troubles he caused were reported by local news media. Though the newspapers and TV programs didn't name him, tens of millions of papers around the world indirectly documented his 'outstanding operational effectiveness.' The investigation team will present all of them to the jury as evidence," Fingel said.

"Could you give me some good news?" Anjou sighed. He was beginning to suspect that as an educator he really was as unqualified as the Board claimed.

"That's why we need Fingel. Know who spreads your little secrets all over the world?" the vice principal said. "Not WikiLeaks. The paparazzi. They're the most dedicated journalists in the world, with an unrivaled nose for gossip. They're skeptics who doubt everything, get in everywhere, and possess all the virtues of journalists. They'll search a female star's trash for the packaging from her new underwear to deduce whether she's had plastic surgery." The vice principal raised an eyebrow and spoke with pride. "But the people best at finding secrets are also the best at hiding them!"

"We specialize in washing coal white!" Fingel puffed out his chest.

"All right, go on." Anjou waved helplessly.

"Norma and Chu Zihang himself are also evidence. Norma keeps all the College's data, but we can't alter it anymore. The Board must already have examined all Norma's records and archived them," Fingel said. "More troublesome than Norma is Chu Zihang."

"Oh?" Anjou frowned.

"His blood sample," the vice principal said slowly. "Blood amplification was a technique your Lionheart Society originally invented. You should remember its side effects. It's forbidden because every time the user amplifies their blood, their genes are altered to become more dragonlike. Once the Board gets his blood sample, it'll be irrefutable proof."

"How do we deal with that evidence?"

"Kill the witness! Destroy the body! Let's rush to the ward now! Slaughter Chu Zihang! Burn him to ashes!" Fingel's eyes flashed viciously.

Anjou could not be bothered with this clown. He covered his face and thought for a moment. "Leave it to me. I have a way."

"Then there's only one thing left: witnesses. Some students have seen Chu Zihang on the verge of losing control, and there are plenty of rumors about him. The good news is that the Lionheart Society is one of the largest student organizations, and they'll undoubtedly stand behind their president. The bad news is that the Student Council is his sworn enemy, and Caesar will undoubtedly undermine him," Fingel said.

"That's something we can't resolve." Anjou pondered for a long time. "Then what are our chances at the hearing, my dear lawyer?"

"Fifty-fifty. If Frost weren't directing things, I could absolutely drink that good-for-nothing Andrew under the table... I mean, beat him in debate. But with Frost behind the scenes, I only have an even chance." The vice principal sighed.

"We must win the tenured professors' support, and quickly. This is a critical moment. They have another purpose in launching this impeachment against me." Anjou drained the strong liquor in his glass. "Hybrids all over the world know a dragon of exalted status has awakened, perhaps even a Dragon King. The Board families, and those under Henkel, are searching for him all over the world. Killing a Dragon King has been proven possible. They all want to kill that dragon before anyone else and claim his remains. And the Board has tied us up here with this strange lawsuit."

"The hearing will be held in three days, in the great conference hall of Valhalla," Fingel said.

"Then the battle between us and the Board has to begin tonight. They'll be staying up late preparing material to bring us down too." The vice principal tossed Fingel a ring of keys. "From now on you have authority to use the Central Control Room. Take your team in. Suspend the Executive Department's operations around the world! We'll take on the Board first!"

At midnight, Parsi, secretary to the investigation team, sat in darkness and breathed deeply. Once he was certain he had reached his optimal state, he opened the laptop before him. Its faint light illuminated his face, and his nonprescription lenses reflected lines of rapidly flashing dark-green characters.

From a hard aluminum-alloy combination case, he took a black envelope and tipped out a silvery metal card. It was solid metal, with no exposed chip and no magnetic stripe. Parsi ran his fingers across its surface, feeling a faint pattern.

A special card slot was already connected to the laptop's USB port. Parsi slipped the metal card in. A few seconds later, the interface refreshed. It was extremely crude: simple blocks of color and rough-edged lettering, without any graphic decoration, pure old-fashioned engineering style. Cassell College's network backend was rough not because its level was low, but because so few people used it.

Those who could use this page did not care about aesthetics. What mattered to them was access.

The highest access.

"Mr. Gattuso, I've connected to Norma." Parsi called and put the phone on speaker. "Awaiting your orders."

"Good." Frost Gattuso's voice was severe. "You now have Norma's highest authorization, granted by the white card. You can access every corner of Norma, but no one else can see a record of your visits. Use that power carefully. I shouldn't have entrusted the white card to you, but they were

shameless enough to cut off the network, so I had no choice but to have you log in from inside the College."

"Yes, sir."

That afternoon, Frost had been unable to connect to Norma from Europe as usual. More precisely, internet communication between the entire North American continent and Europe had been disrupted. Reuters reported that a transatlantic undersea cable might have been bitten through by a sperm whale. Only Frost understood the full sequence: a few hours before the cable was cut, the investigation team had announced its major decision to hold a hearing. And when the cable broke, the distinguished tug Moniach, which had carried out Operation Bronze at the Three Gorges, had happened to pass through those waters... Frost had not expected the two old men to be this shameless.

"Some of the data in Norma's core storage has always been impossible for us to decrypt. We back it up every month. They must be hiding something in those encrypted files. Once Anjou is removed as principal, we'll take over Norma. They'll certainly delete the data first. They have the principal's and vice principal's two black cards. But you hold the white card and have supreme authorization! First set the data to read-only, then begin the backup."

"Understood." Parsi's fingers danced over the keyboard like a peerless dancer on a red-hot iron plate.

Meanwhile, in the Central Control Room.

Every entrance had been locked. Unauthorized people, even members of the Executive Department, were forbidden to approach. A top-secret team had moved in before midnight.

Cassell College, News Department.

Alchemical cipher machines printed at high speed with a crisp clatter. Vast quantities of news photographs were downloaded by way of the College's secret server cluster in Asia; videos appeared as 3D projections in the center of the hall... If the data streams were represented as dark-green strings of numbers like those in The Matrix, digital torrents from around the world would now be surging toward the man in the center, overwhelming as ten thousand rivers flowing to the sea.

That man had his feet on an expensive walnut desk and drank Coke by the mouthful, tossing aside each document after reading it. Printed pages covered the floor, another mountain of files stood on the desk, and there were enough empty Coke cans to line up like dominoes.

"This is a post on the Tianya forum titled 'Holy crap! What are superpowers? This is what superpowers are!' The author must have seen Chu Zihang unleash Sovereign Flame. It has 76,239 views and 8,734 replies, and made the front page!" The head of the News Department's First Section hurried over and handed him a printout of the page.

"Do you have to bother me with something this small? Have the guys flood it with another two thousand replies, and get an administrator to change the posting time. The replies should say things like 'Don't be stupid, are you crazy?' or 'Ha ha ha, that's my cousin who's a magician. He fooled you!' or 'The original poster always writes alarmist stuff like this. Stop chasing rumors and be realistic.' You know what to do! Go!" Fingel waved a hand grandly.

"Our contact at the Associated Press says he'll take that report off their website for a thousand dollars!" someone called.

"Give him two thousand and tell him to clear the comments too!" Fingel waved again.

"The chief is amazing!" marveled the junior massaging his shoulders from behind.

"Of course. You want to know what efficiency is? This is efficiency!" Fingel grunted.

"Once you graduate this time, you can pay us back, right?" the junior asked cautiously.

"No problem!" Fingel gave him a sidelong glance. "The principal said if I do this well, he'll not only let me graduate, he'll clear my credit-card balance and help pay off my debts!"

The junior was almost moved to tears. "Then we'll make absolutely sure our boss graduates! From this moment on, Chu Zihang is a flawless perfect man in our eyes! Anyone who dares tell us he's bad will have us to answer to!"

"We'll make them answer for it!" The paparazzi, busy at their laptops, all raised their hands and shouted together. They were Fingel's juniors and underlings, but also his creditors. Soon after joining the News Department, while they were still finding their feet, Fingel had worn them down and borrowed varying amounts of money. Their loyalty to the department all these years... was also a way to keep a close eye on the man who owed them money.

"Boss, there's something here that's hard to deal with... It's a video," someone said.

"Project it onto the central screen!" Fingel tossed an empty Coke can.

It appeared to be black-and-white footage from a surveillance camera, thick with static and extremely poor in quality. It looked up at an old building at night, black windows packed together and searchlight beams rising from below. The time flashed in the lower right corner. The silence made one's skin crawl.

"Why does it look like a horror movie?" someone whispered.

Suddenly a dark figure appeared on screen, leaping out after smashing through a window. Another figure followed, a sword in one hand and a nylon fire hose in the other. The two fell together. The second figure kicked hard against the wall and, finding a point of leverage in that instant, hurled his long sword. It pierced the first man's chest. His heart must have ruptured, for blood sprayed from the wound in his back, splashing a wet red streak across the facade as if from a giant spray can. Finally the blood-soaked figure slammed into the ground. The second man landed safely holding the hose, looked coldly around, walked over to the body and pulled out his sword. He wiped the blood on his shoe sole and was about to leave when he noticed the camera, approached, and kicked it. Only static remained on screen.

They could not see his face, but his blazing eyes left the paparazzi in no doubt about his identity.

"So cold... so vicious!" someone said in a trembling voice.

"What is this?" Fingel asked.

"Front-page headline in The New York Times, April 2009: the baby-cutting case solved, the killer dead. It was actually one of Chu Zihang's missions. A hybrid had been operating at a hospital in Brooklyn, New York, cutting unborn babies from pregnant women, probably for some alchemical experiment of a black-magic nature. Chu Zihang disguised himself as a pregnant woman and went undercover at the hospital. He finally found the target and killed him by throwing his sword. This is the hospital's surveillance footage. Chu Zihang was disciplined because the scene was too horrifying: half the hospital wall was blood-red. It triggered extensive media coverage and threatened the College's secrecy," someone said.

"If that video is used as evidence, it'll be very bad for us," someone sighed.

"An affront to public morals!" Fingel sighed.

"Boss, wrong phrase. It's cruel and violent," the head of the Second Section corrected.

"Oh, I mean Chu Zihang actually stayed in the hospital with pregnant women for eleven days, sneaking looks at the naked expectant mothers..."

The juniors exchanged glances and fell silent for a long time. "Boss... there's a problem. Time is short, and this guy's record is practically a story high! And besides that, there's something even more troublesome. He blew up a building during an operation in Cape Town! It would have been one thing if it had been an ordinary building, but he blew up the Cape Town baseball center. That night the local professional teams were playing the final, and tens of thousands of spectators waiting outside to get in saw the whole thing..."

"If we explain it as a mass hallucination involving tens of thousands... probably no one would believe it, would they?" Fingel mused.

"In April 2010, Stockholm's 'Night Wanderer' serial murder case. The killer was contaminated by dragon blood from an unknown source and turned into a death servitor. Chu Zihang encountered him before dawn and hanged him with a noose in front of City Hall, a landmark all tourists pass... The scene had a very religious feel. Locals believed it was God's punishment for the killer, and the Pope even came in person to hold a grand Mass for the victims!"

"December 2009, Chicago, the Hancock Building. The west wall from the thirteenth to fifteenth floors was instantly destroyed by a shock wave because Chu Zihang used a weapon the Equipment Department claimed was still 'in the experimental stage': 'Dragon's Breath of Light and Dust.' It was originally considered reliable, portable individual combat equipment, like a handgun... but for some reason the final effect was a high-intensity shock wave. The weapon was melted down and reforged after the operation... and hasn't been put back into service to this day."

"He's really gone too far!" Fingel thrust all ten fingers into his disheveled hair.

The mood was heavy. Though they considered themselves experts at washing coal white, even the paparazzi were disheartened by this mountain of incidents. Once something had reached the news media, it was hard to contain. Public media had too much influence; they could neither recall and destroy millions of newspapers nor brainwash the entire world.

"Let's just deny it to the bitter end! What do the perverted killer who was hanged or the collapsed Cape Town baseball stadium have to do with Chu Zihang?" One paparazzo stood and slammed the table, with the ruthlessness of a man going all in. "Chu Zihang just happened to be there on a mission. Coincidence! It was all coincidence! The CIA has done this before. They send agents to a small Latin American country to turn the military against its government, then come back and say the coup had nothing to do with them. They just happened to be traveling there, and even brought back cigars."

"Naive!" Fingel rebuked him solemnly. "We can deny it, but we don't control the hearing. The final say belongs to the lifetime professors. If those old science geeks and old religious cranks think Chu Zihang was involved, it won't matter whether we admit it."

"The best way to show Chu Zihang didn't do these things is to show someone else did." One paparazzo evidently had a sound grasp of law. "The best way to prove a suspect innocent is to find the real culprit."

"You mean frame someone?" another asked.

"You could put it that way, though that's rather coarse, not very refined." The legal-minded paparazzo looked embarrassed.

"Refined, my ass! Who cares? As long as we win, that's what matters. It's a debate, just a matter of talking," Fingel said. "Still, you have a point."

"The problem is that ordinary people couldn't have done these things. They're clearly connected to hybrids or dragons." A junior frowned. "If a lunatic like Chu Zihang didn't do them, some other lunatic must have. There aren't many people we could pin them on."

"I know a group! They're perfect!" Fingel slapped his thigh, eyes blazing.

The download bar on the screen had passed ninety-five percent. Soon all the hidden files in Norma's storage would be backed up on Parsi's hard-drive array. No one could stop the backup, because no one had higher access than a white card. Inside Norma's network, a white-card holder flew like a god; the other users were ants crawling about, unaware that a god looked down on them.

Traffic in and out of the central control room suddenly began to rise again. The paparazzi seemed to have regrouped and thrown themselves enthusiastically back into work, unaware that Parsi was monitoring every stream of data.

Parsi tried switching to their interface to see what they were doing.

"Hi there. I don't know who you are, but unfortunately your access has to end. I'm sorry, but there's nothing I can do; someone with higher clearance has given the order." Suddenly a high-resolution simulated 3D figure appeared on the screen: a girl in a white nightdress, seemingly floating in the air, her long hair waving, her smile bright. The contrast with the crude interface was striking, like a full-HD beautiful girl from a PS3 suddenly appearing on an old Nintendo console. Parsi leaned back for an instant, as if trying to escape the force of her beauty.

He pressed Esc instinctively, the emergency command to terminate remote control.

He thought he'd been hacked, but immediately realized that was impossible. He was a god-level being now. Who could invade a god's temple?

Esc failed. As the beautiful girl bowed, the whole page went black, leaving only the dark-red download bar at ninety-eight percent. But instead of advancing, it rapidly retreated. Parsi reached for the cable connecting the hard-drive array, but it was too late. The bar dropped to zero. Everything downloaded had been remotely wiped. The white card popped out of its slot.

He had been denied.

He felt a shadow falling over him. Before coming, they had thoroughly researched the college and gathered vast amounts of information. Moreover, they reported directly to the Board of Trustees and thought they knew the campus well enough. But from the moment he entered and met the legendary vice principal, unknown things hidden in the dark had begun to emerge. He was surrounded and had to break out.

Parsi sat in the dark thinking for several minutes, then picked up the white card and rushed out.

Chu Zihang slowly opened his eyes. A figure stood in the darkness before his hospital bed.

He watched silently, not particularly surprised. He had sensed the person's approach; the visitor hadn't tried to sneak. Only those with special permission could enter this intensive-care room, but this person clearly had none. He was like a thief who politely knocked before coming in.

"Hello. Sorry to disturb your rest. May I turn on the light?" the figure asked.

Chu Zihang nodded.

The figure switched on the bedside lamp, and Chu Zihang finally saw his face. It was beautiful and gentle, but those strangely captivating eyes made most people overlook its shape. One eye was sea-blue, the other pale gold, like a fine Persian cat's. Meeting his gaze, Chu Zihang felt he was looking at a Persian cat: quiet, docile, even friendly, yet extraordinarily perceptive.

Cats were difficult to read, and Chu Zihang couldn't decipher the man's gaze either.

"My name is Parsi. I'm the investigation team's secretary. I've come to investigate you," the man introduced himself.

"Hello," Chu Zihang said.

"I need a blood sample. It will help us study you." Parsi took a vacuum syringe sealed in a plastic bag and inserted it into the back of Chu Zihang's hand. The vacuum drew one milliliter of fresh blood into the syringe. Parsi withdrew it. Throughout, he was like a conscientious doctor: professional, calm, possessing unquestionable authority, and acting entirely for your own good.

"Your performance at Six Flags was unforgettable. I hope to see something even more spectacular," Parsi said with a smile. "Although some people want to strike you from the college rolls, those trying to protect you are powerful too. Neither side will win for the moment, so until a winner is decided, release yourself one hundred percent." He bowed slightly. "We'll meet again. We can talk privately when there's a chance."

Chu Zihang couldn't stop him, though he knew perfectly well his blood sample must not leave the room. The intensive-care room was monitored as closely as a prison, with steel layers in all four walls and bulletproof glass. If possible, Norma would mount an aircraft cannon improved by the Equipment Department's maniacs at the door and pour bullets weighing dozens of kilograms at anyone without permission. Yet the young man named Parsi had walked in as casually as that, encountering no obstacle. Chu Zihang could hardly grab Parsi, pin him to the hospital bed, and shout for the guards.

Strangely, he felt no resistance to Parsi, not only because the young man was as gentle as a cat, but because he vaguely gave off an air of 'we're the same kind of person.'

Stranger still, at first glance you felt it was Caesar standing there, though they looked nothing alike.

When the first sunlight entered the central control room, every member of the News Department looked as gray as a beaten dog, but their eyes shone like stars.

They would be legends in the history of paparazzi. Under their great leader Fingel, they had smashed through every lower limit. WikiLeaks, the paparazzi car chase involving Diana: beside their magnificent achievements tonight, all would be trivial rubbish! The News Department working at full capacity reached far beyond the college. They had close ties with major media outlets, and under the vice principal's personal guidance and earnest instruction, the team firmly believed news could change the world. They had long since accumulated vast media resources; tonight, years of preparation had been unleashed.

They were confident they could give the investigators a great surprise... or perhaps make them furious... or even reduce them to sobs...

Fingel swept out an arm. "We're done! Take everything we brought! But not a scrap of paper or any storage device leaves this room! Not one word about tonight gets out!"

"Understood!"

Fingel looked down and suddenly froze. A file had been pulled up by accident from a confidential college folder: 'Bloodline Records.'

He looked furtively around, humming a tune as he quietly pressed Print. Then, eyes turned heavenward and hands tucked into his back pockets, he sauntered to the printer and discreetly rolled the printed document into his pocket.

"Damn it! How could that secretary enter intensive care without us knowing? Who gave him access?" Abandoning his usual composure, the vice principal paced furiously like a bear robbed of its honey.

That morning word had come from intensive care: a nurse had met the investigation team's secretary at the door and had a friendly chat with him. He said he had come to take a blood sample and asked her to inform the vice principal.

"How should I know? My college clearance is exactly the same as yours. I can even find out what sleazy websites you've visited, but I couldn't find any record of the secretary entering intensive care either. That room is sealed with electronic locks, and Norma controls every one." Anjou poured himself gin, added ice and lemon, and made a simple dry martini.

"You're normally the one who flies into a rage, yet you're this calm. I take it the blood sample the secretary took can't threaten us." The vice principal looked surprised.

Anjou sat in the sofa and drank deeply from his martini. "I told you I'd handle the blood sample. We arranged an operation to exchange Chu Zihang's blood; his whole supply was washed several times. For the next few months his marrow won't produce enough new blood of sufficient purity. No matter how they test the sample, they won't find a problem, because it isn't his blood at all."

"So you did get something done while your 'sore throat' was acting up. One of life's greatest blessings is having an ally who isn't a pig." The vice principal breathed a sigh of relief.

"The real sample of Chu Zihang's blood." Anjou handed him a sealed quartz-glass tube. "As an ardent enthusiast of alchemy, I thought you'd be interested."

"This is blood? Are you sure you didn't mix it up with Coke?" The vice principal held it to the light. No one would believe it was blood. It was pale black, with tiny bubbles forming, joining, and bursting inside, just like Coke in a glass bottle.

"It was bright red when first drawn. It changed to this within minutes. A trace of human blood remained in the sample container and reacted with Chu Zihang's blood," Anjou said. "The reaction was quite violent; it took some new Equipment Department devices to suppress it. This blood is too active. It's stable only inside Chu Zihang's body. In other words, he's its only vessel."

"We certainly can't let the Board of Trustees get this. It wouldn't even need to go to a laboratory. Mix in a little ordinary human blood and the problem would be obvious." The vice principal held the sample up in admiration. "A miracle of alchemy! A hybrid used his own body as a vessel for a highly advanced alchemical experiment, refining his blood to bring it closer to dragon blood! I'm almost moved by such reckless devotion to research!"

"You're right about reckless. We can't tell when his blood will cross the critical blood threshold. Blood amplification has already seriously harmed his body." Anjou frowned.

The vice principal nodded. "Lend me your folding knife."

Anjou drew it from his sleeve and handed it over. The vice principal promptly seized his wrist, flicked the knife open, and cut his finger!

"Now I'll borrow a little blood." The vice principal withdrew the knife with a drop on it.

Anjou pressed the cut to stop the bleeding. "Couldn't you use your own blood?"

"Obviously not. It hurts," the vice principal said frankly. He squeezed a drop of the Coke-like black blood from the quartz tube onto the blade as well.

The two drops rolled on the blade like fighters driven into an arena, slowly approaching, touching, and springing apart. The vice principal flicked his wrist, sending them along the edge to collide at the tip. They merged and left the blade.

Blood-red suddenly burst in the air, like an ethereal, seductive, coldly beautiful flower blooming and withering in an instant. The red flower turned black as ink and fell on the carpet, burning a mark the size of a coffee cup and saucer. The little room smelled of scorched wool.

"The carpet's wool. Damn it, this stuff corrodes anything that was once alive and still contains genetic material." The vice principal was startled. "It's practically aqua regia!"

"No. It's refining nitroglycerin in your own veins!" Anjou said quietly.

"We must stop him from continuing to use that skill, or the damage will be irreversible." The vice principal wiped the remaining blood from the blade with a tissue and returned it to Anjou.

In the Lionheart Society's clubroom, all the officers gathered under Vice President Lancelot. This was the greatest challenge in the society's history: its president would be sent before the college's internal court. The society quickly agreed to support him wholeheartedly. That wasn't difficult. Under pressure from Caesar's Student Council, the college's oldest fraternity risked slipping into second place. The reason it could still sit securely at the top was Chu Zihang. Without its super-A-rank president, the Lionheart Society had no chance against a Student Council with A-rank Caesar and Chen Motong as well as S-rank Lu Mingfei.

Though that S-rank was now sitting among them, looking as indignant as the rest.

But the killers under Chu Zihang plainly had no experience with hearings. If the same thing had happened to Caesar, the Student Council's girls in lacy white dresses and its scheming followers would all have mobilized to build support across campus. Lancelot could only lead the officers in waiting for news.

The door opened. Fingel came in, sat on the sofa, and let out a long breath. "Done! No problem at all!"

After a moment's silence, the killers applauded in relief.

Lancelot handed Fingel an envelope containing a promissory note drawn on the Lionheart Society's emergency funds. Fingel accepted it without hesitation, taking money from the principal on one side and the society on the other. The vice principal would have done the same.

"Leave the hearing to me. If I take your money, I'll solve your troubles." Fingel was full of confidence. "If you have time, why not visit Chu Zihang instead of sitting here looking miserable?"

Lancelot sprang up. Only now did the Frenchman remember they still hadn't visited Chu Zihang. While Chu Zihang was unconscious, no visitors had been allowed in intensive care, although the freshman Xia Mi had received special access from the principal. Today was the first day visits were

permitted. All the Lionheart Society officers followed Lancelot out, discussing in the corridor what sort of bouquet to prepare.

Lu Mingfei tried to follow, but Fingel patted his shoulder from behind. "I have bad news. Want to hear it?" His eyebrows drooped.

"Damn it, better to die sooner and be reborn sooner. Tell me!" Lu Mingfei didn't take it seriously. When had his useless senior ever had good news?

Fingel handed him a tissue. "Get ready, junior. You can start wiping your tears when you've heard."

"Bah! This looks like a decent tissue. I'll save it to wipe my mouth at dinner." Lu Mingfei folded it and tucked it into his pocket.

Fingel gave him a thumbs-up and bared his teeth. "Junior, your spirit knows no bounds. If you can still think of dinner no matter how hard you've been hit, your fighting spirit is intact! Listen carefully..." He licked his lips. "Caesar proposed to Nono!"

Lu Mingfei stared for a moment, then smiled.

Everything around his ears seemed blank. He felt nothing, not the least bit sad. He must have heard wrong, he thought.

He must have heard wrong. Don't believe rumors. In a minute the mistake would be corrected and everything would return to its former course. Caesar and Nono were still boyfriend and girlfriend, but things between them were a little complicated. They hadn't even graduated; why get married? A campus tyrant like Principal Anjou would scold them and tell them studies came first! What marriage? Wait until graduation! That would give him a few more years to moon over her. Damn it, wasn't college about mooning over the prettiest girl in school or class until the flower fell, the water cooled, the dust settled, and the beauty married a rich heir, at which point you grew up? It was a process! Did those two understand the beauty of the process? Couldn't they stop rushing it? If you rushed it... some people who hadn't had time to grow up would be very sad...

Even knowing he couldn't change the ending, couldn't he be allowed a tiny, disreputable crush before the dust settled?

Lu Mingfei stared at Fingel. He didn't know how much time passed before Fingel nodded vigorously and raised three fingers to the sky, swearing a curse on himself if he'd made it up.

At last Lu Mingfei felt sad: utter powerlessness, his heart too lazy even to beat, an awful sensation between exhaustion and pain spreading through his body. He wanted to sink slowly into a crouch, or simply lie on the floor and stop moving.

He forced himself to hold on and stared at Fingel. "Damn. How would you know?"

"Anyone at the college who wants to marry has to apply and undergo bloodline analysis, so they don't produce descendants with unstable bloodlines." Fingel pulled out a crumpled printout. "From the college's bloodline records. I happened across it in the Central Control Room. I thought, damn, isn't that hard on my brother? So I secretly printed a copy and brought it out. I'm a good friend, right?"

Lu Mingfei unfolded the paper: 'Application to Marry A-Rank Student Chen Motong (Student No. A09003),' applicant Caesar Gattuso. It was an old-fashioned document, probably copied from some template Caesar had found. It chiefly contained his and Nono's résumés, when they met, the state of their relationship, and their laudable wish to combine excellent bloodlines and raise exceptional offspring. Attached was a report from the college's genetic science department stating that, based on

blood samples, Caesar and Chen Motong's children were very unlikely to have unstable genes. The paperwork looked complete. If the investigation team hadn't suddenly targeted the principal and suspended all college procedures, the application might already have been approved.

It was like needing an organization's approval to marry in 1950s China. Lu Mingfei found the document both funny and frightening.

"The tissue... still saving it to wipe your mouth?" Fingel asked cautiously.

Lu Mingfei looked down at the tissue in his pocket, instinctively wiped his mouth with it, and tossed it on the floor. Who did Fingel think he was? The hero of a tragedy, lifting his face forty-five degrees to shed tears into the wind? He was just an extra. An extra didn't need a tearful profile. The whole affair had nothing to do with him anyway.

"I'm fine. I'm going to take a leak," Lu Mingfei said.

He turned and walked out, taking one step after another under Fingel's gaze. His back was slightly bent, his shoulders heavy, his arms hanging limply and growing heavier. He thought he had to walk faster or his arms would drag on the ground before he reached the end of the corridor. Then in Fingel's eyes he'd look either like Imperial Uncle Liu... or a monkey robbed of its bananas...

At last he made it to the end of the corridor. He turned the corner and ran, bursting into an empty restroom.

He leaned against the door and slowly sat down on the floor, remembering everything between him and Nono. So many messy little things: Nono ordering him to run errands for the Student Council's sailing practice, ordering him to buy a blueberry egg tart for a late-night snack, ordering him to remember how she took her coffee, 'a latte with one sugar.' Trivial, meaningless episodes. If he picked out the essence, there was very little...

"Now that's our Ricardo M. Lu." In the small cinema auditorium, before dozens of Literature Club members, Nono patted his face with a smile he couldn't tell was tender or teasing.

"It's beautiful... whoever sent it." Nono stood beside him, watching the fireworks slowly fade in the night sky.

"Don't die!" He shouted in the bitterly cold waters of the Three Gorges, holding a girl who didn't belong to him. Nono's dark-red hair drifted like thick seaweed, and she wore a bikini that set his blood racing. Yet at the time he had felt his blood was about to freeze. His whole body was cold, and he was only afraid she would die... If she died, he would be lonely again...

Lu Mingze said he was lonely, but he really didn't think so. By day he could moon over a pretty senior; at night he could eat late-night snacks and shoot the breeze with his useless senior. What was lonely about that?

If the world could stay that way forever, it wouldn't be bad.

Perhaps it was a little greedy to want everyone to remain as they had been when he first met them... Chen Wenwen should be on a sunny bench reading Marguerite Duras's The Lover, melancholy over a sad story that had nothing to do with her; his useless senior should never graduate, so they could share a room, eat late-night snacks every evening, and say whatever was in their hearts, good or ridiculous; Nono would always be that imperious little red-haired witch driving a Ferrari, fiercely mischievous and full of wicked ideas, marriage still in her distant future. She wouldn't have learned to cook yet,

would stubbornly love ice cream nearly the color of her hair, and would race with him along a dark mountain road...

But things would change. Everyone would leave, and he would remain where he was.

He raised his head and rubbed his dejected face in the mirror.

Act Twelve

The Dragonbone Cross

The Cross-Shaped Bones

They were the dry bones of a boy, a heavy bronze color, like a work of art cast in pure copper. Crystallized eyeballs were set in the skull's sockets, like a pair of golden glass beads. Though the skeleton looked human, a closer inspection revealed enormous differences. Nearly a thousand slender bones made up the body; some had fused together, while others formed organs found in no textbook. Two clusters of fine bones spread like fans from his back: his wings. His arms were outstretched, gripping the wing bones behind him, and his skull hung low, like Jesus nailed to the cross.

The dragonbone cross.

Chu Zihang lay surrounded by yellow and white flowers. If he pulled the sheet over his head and someone hung a funeral couplet above the bed, the scene would be complete.

The Lionheart Society officers had been unable to agree on what flowers to bring, so they had decided to buy out the college flower shop. Its flowers were not shipped in from outside; they came from the genetics department's greenhouse. That day, an entire greenhouse of yellow and white tulips had been picked, and the Lionheart Society had generously bought the lot. Tulips, in the language of flowers, meant "universal love, consideration, elegance, and wealth," which Lancelot, being French, thought appropriate enough. The effect of all those flowers in the hospital room, however, was rather awkward, so he thoughtfully sent someone to buy red roses to place at the head of the bed.

"That looks better." Lancelot was slightly more satisfied with the final result.

Chu Zihang could only smile and nod. He now felt as if he were lying on a white cream cake covered in lemon sauce, with the red roses arranged into a message such as HAPPY BIRTHDAY.

It was the first day visitors were allowed into intensive care. Besides the Lionheart Society, several important figures from the college appeared in the room, including the Executive Department, led by Professor Schneider. Campus clubs also sent visiting parties one after another. With the investigative team here to examine Chu Zihang's bloodline, the scale of the visits suggested that someone was secretly directing them. Andrew flew into a rage when he saw the campus news. Once again, the college, supported by his family's money, was resisting the Board of Trustees' interference. As far as Andrew was concerned, Chu Zihang should have been tied up and sent straight to Rome long ago.

At last the visitors all left. Afternoon sunlight filled the room, and someone leaned against the wall opposite the bed, staring absently out the window.

Lu Mingfei.

Chu Zihang watched him silently. Lu Mingfei had slipped in while the Lionheart Society's visitors crowded around the bed. There had always been too many people for him to get a chance to speak, so he had stayed against the wall, lost in thought. Whenever Chu Zihang looked through the stream of people coming and going, he saw him leaning or sitting there, his eyes vacant, reflecting the changing

sunlight through the day. Sometimes he went out to buy a bottle of water, then returned to drink it and stare into space again.

He was like a child left in a park on a midsummer afternoon. He did not know where to go, yet he was not afraid; he simply wandered back and forth within the small space between a tree and the lake.

Lu Mingfei suddenly realized the visitors were gone. He straightened up quickly and scratched his head. He wanted to say something to his expressionless senior, but all he could think of were stock phrases like "How are you feeling?" He could also say "It's good you're still alive," but they did not seem close enough for that; they had only been on one mission together in China. He nodded to Chu Zihang and turned to leave.

"Hey, can I ask you something?" Chu Zihang said suddenly.

"Hm?" Lu Mingfei turned back.

Chu Zihang hesitated. "What's it like... to like someone?"

"Pretty damn miserable!" Lu Mingfei said offhand.

His head immediately drooped. Liking someone was not necessarily miserable; it was miserable when he liked someone. And most miserable of all was having blurted that out.

It was like admitting defeat. Ask a gambler who always loses what kind of game cards are, and he answers without thinking, "A way to lose money."

"What are you asking, senior?" He eyed Chu Zihang warily, wondering if he knew something.

"You've liked Chen Wenwen and Nono, haven't you?" Chu Zihang continued, his face impassive.

"Actually, I like Lin Zhiling too, but I think the age gap might be a problem." Lu Mingfei could not resist a stupid joke. Chu Zihang sounded like he was checking his household registration.

Irritation suddenly rose in him. If you have something to say, just say it! Why beat around the bush about things we've already discussed? You just want to call me an idiot, right? Doesn't the whole college know that already? Are you making fun of the stupid kid, Mr. Poker Face?

"If you've got something to say, spit it out. If you've got a fart... let it out already. Stop hemming and hawing." Lu Mingfei scowled, but halfway through he softened his words; Chu Zihang was in a hospital bed, after all.

"What I mean is, what reasons might make you like someone?" Chu Zihang was very serious.

"They're good-looking, obviously."

"Could you be more specific?"

"A slim waist, long legs, and long hair."

"I don't mean that." Chu Zihang frowned. "Apart from looks, are there other reasons?"

"Do you need a reason to like someone? Do you? Don't you? Do you? Don't you?" Lu Mingfei was getting worked up again. "Who the hell knows? You're happy and carefree, eating hot pot, riding a train, singing as you leave town... and suddenly someone knocks the train over into the water. You climb out, open your eyes, and see a woman bandit with a slim waist, long legs, and long hair. She's got one foot on your face and looks magnificent. She says, 'I opened this mountain and planted this tree. If you want to pass, pay the toll! Refuse, and I'll kill you without even burying you!' Something stirs in your heart, and you can hardly wait to stay and become a bandit with her... That's the moment you fall for her."

He remembered the night in the dark little movie theater when Nono had stormed into his world, fierce and overbearing. A pang of sadness rose in him.

Chu Zihang plainly could not follow this development. "Could you be more specific? For example, was the girl very good to you?"

"Come off it!" Lu Mingfei was tired. He plopped down on Chu Zihang's bed. "Usually they're the ones who order you around and don't take you seriously."

Damn! He had exposed his loser nature again. Really, it was only the girls he liked who sent him running everywhere, wasn't it? Chen Wenwen was meek as a little wife when she was with Zhao Menghua.

"Can you call it affection when she orders you around and doesn't take you seriously?" Chu Zihang asked coldly.

"Damn it!" Lu Mingfei was genuinely angry now. "You don't get to decide what counts as affection, okay, senior? You've never tried it, so you don't know a thing! What gives you the right to draw conclusions? Is this something you can study?"

He was certain now that Chu Zihang knew the whole story. Whether the conversation was meant to comfort him or mock him no longer mattered. That cold academic tone made him want to flip the table!

"You have a point. So things like star signs aren't reliable either, right?" Chu Zihang nodded.

"Right about what?" Lu Mingfei asked absentmindedly.

"Aquarius and Gemini," Chu Zihang blurted out.

Lu Mingfei froze and turned to stare hard at his face. Chu Zihang met his gaze coldly for several seconds, then looked away. Huh? What? Could it be... Oh, that angle as he turned his head! Oh, that hesitant expression, as if he wanted to speak but couldn't! Oh, the meaning hidden beneath those words... He had completely misunderstood his poker-faced senior. Chu Zihang wasn't trying to comfort or mock him at all; he was asking for relationship advice! He had finally woken up to love!

Lu Mingfei knew Chu Zihang was a thoroughgoing Gemini, but who was the Aquarius girl?

His eyes lit up. "Not a great match. They're both air signs, but Gemini is too awkward and has trouble expressing feelings. An Aquarius girl is really subtle about who she likes and only cares for you quietly. The astrology books say an Aquarius girl is always somewhere around you, but you never know if she really likes you."

"Oh, not very good?" Chu Zihang nodded, showing no sign of disappointment.

"But astrology is just a game for little girls. You believe that stuff? Has your brain short-circuited?" Lu Mingfei hurried to add. His poker-faced senior fell in love once in twenty years; he could not let a load of nonsense crush it. As the saying went, block a man's road to riches and you deserved death. Blocking his pursuit of a girl had to send you to hell too, right?

"Under what circumstances would you be sure you liked a girl?" Chu Zihang looked Lu Mingfei in the eye, deadly serious. If there had been a notebook nearby, he would surely have picked it up and started taking notes.

Lu Mingfei tilted his head back and thought for a long time. He twisted his mouth. "If there's someone whose name you're thinking of now, while you're asking me these questions, then you like her."

He looked into Chu Zihang's eyes, his nose stinging a little. As he spoke, a name had come to his own mind too, and he knew he liked that girl. He would rather not have remembered; then he would not have felt so sad. He was a good friend, he thought, making himself miserable just to give Chu Zihang a hint. His little bit of sadness wasn't worth much anyway. If Chu Zihang understood and won the girl, whether she was Susie or Xia Mi, Lu Mingfei could count it as a good deed. Though life was hard for him, he wanted Chu Zihang to be a little happier. For all his impressive abilities, Chu Zihang did not seem truly happy.

Chu Zihang was silent a long time. Then he nodded slightly. "I understand."

Lu Mingfei felt his good deed was complete. He patted his backside and got up. "If there's nothing else, I'll go."

As he headed for the door, Chu Zihang asked behind him, "Are you all right?"

"I'm okay," Lu Mingfei said without turning. "Just depressed. I didn't even get a chance to compete. It was doomed to be a stupid mess from the start."

"Nobody wants their feelings for someone to be such a stupid mess, right?" he said softly. "Not even a chance..."

"Good afternoon, Senior Lu."

Lu Mingfei met Xia Mi in the corridor. She had changed into Cassell College's dark-green uniform, her hair in a high ponytail. She carried a notebook under her arm and an insulated food container in her hand.

"What smells so good?" Lu Mingfei sniffed toward the container like a dog.

"Snow fungus soup! Snow fungus soup! It's for the patient. What's so special about that? I can make pork-rib soup too. Just wait." Xia Mi grinned, showing two little canine teeth.

"Looking forward to it!" Lu Mingfei rubbed his hands. "By the way, junior, what's your star sign?"

"Aquarius! Aquarius people are great cooks!" Xia Mi narrowed her eyes in a smile and brushed past him into the room.

Lu Mingfei turned to watch her go, bouncing along, her ponytail bobbing.

"Damn, you can get snow fungus soup in America? This is way beyond a couple being sweet on each other. They're practically burning with illicit passion!" he muttered. Then he suddenly smiled and said softly to the empty corridor, "Senior, she's a good one. Don't miss your chance..."

"You're a little late today," Chu Zihang said.

"Come on! I had class this afternoon! I'm not your nanny. I made you soup because I respect you as a hero, and you're really taking me for granted!" Xia Mi sat by the bed, grumbling, her eyes shining like two pools of clear water.

"Snow fungus soup! Snow fungus soup! It's hard enough finding snow fungus in this godforsaken place. I even had to order it on eBay!" Xia Mi opened the container with an air of pride.

Chu Zihang ate the soup spoonful by spoonful, expressionless.

"Is it good? Is it good?" Xia Mi narrowed her eyes eagerly.

"It could use a little sweetened osmanthus." Chu Zihang delivered his calm assessment with professional precision.

"Wow! Young master, you have high standards!" Xia Mi almost shouted. Then she propped her cheek in her hand and asked earnestly, "What's sweetened osmanthus?"

Chu Zihang paused. "Dry fresh osmanthus flowers in the sun. Take a hundred grams, add two spoonfuls of maltose, steam for ten minutes, then let it cool and refrigerate it in a jar."

"That sounds like a lot of trouble, just the kind of thing a troublesome person like you would like. All right, remember to add it next time. I bought plenty of snow fungus, enough for lots of soup." Xia Mi spoke lazily.

"I'm finished." Chu Zihang handed the container back, indicating he had completed his assignment.

"Hey! Would it kill you to say thank you?" Xia Mi glared.

"Thank you." Chu Zihang readily obliged.

"You're enough to wear down anyone's temper." Xia Mi pouted. "Haven't you heard? The campus news site is going crazy today. Senior Nono and Senior Caesar are getting engaged! Caesar went to Van Cleef & Arpels to order a diamond ring, and apparently there's only one of it in the whole world. Wow! What a sight that would be!"

Chu Zihang froze and was silent for a long time. "No wonder..." he said softly.

"Brother, drowning your sorrows in drink isn't the way of a hero! Look how many bottles you've had." Fingel slapped the table and sighed.

Lu Mingfei struggled to lift his head. He counted the empty bottles on the table three or four times without getting a clear answer. There were roughly four or five empty wine bottles, and another dozen empty beer bottles on the floor.

"Can't count them." Lu Mingfei dropped heavily onto the table. "Drowning your sorrows is an attitude toward life. You don't understand. When Chinese heroes lose in love, they all drown their sorrows. Have you ever read martial-arts novels? Do you know Li Xunhuan? And Duan Yu and Xuzhu? Drowning your sorrows is what heroes do!"

"I'm mainly concerned with whose drink you're drowning them in... If you bought the wine yourself and wanted your senior to get drunk with you until the end of the world, I'd smile and say just one thing: 'Double order of pork knuckles!'" Fingel grimaced. "But come on, you're poorer than I am now. You've skipped class for days, Norma warned you, and your credit card's suspended... I'm paying for all the booze. You know I'm a man of feeling too, but it hurts to part with money. That's only human."

"You're so annoying. I'll pay you back when I have money!" Lu Mingfei couldn't be bothered to raise his head; it felt as heavy as a shot put. "If I don't borrow from you, who am I supposed to ask? Go to the boss and say, 'Boss, I hear you're marrying senior sister, and I'm sad. Could you lend me a little money to drink?'"

"Caesar's an understanding man. If you had the guts to say that, he'd give you several cases of aged Bordeaux!"

"I know the boss is understanding, but..." Lu Mingfei sighed. "I'm not."

He really did want to become an understanding man. Girls came and went; what was the big deal? As the poet Xu Zhimo said in "Taking Leave of Cambridge Again": "I wave my sleeve, and carry away not a single cloud!"

In his second year of high school, Lu Mingfei had written his extracurricular reading notes on Selected Poems of Xu Zhimo; Chen Wenwen had even praised his taste. But all right, even someone as

brilliant and carefree as Master Xu had fallen for the famously artistic and beautiful Lin Huiyin on the River Cam. After a few boating trips, he had pursued her for the rest of his life without success. Even when his plane crashed into a mountain and he became the brightest firework in the night sky, he had still been thinking of her. That seemed a little like Lu Mingfei's own situation.

Damn it! Whenever he was sad, he discovered that everything happening today seemed to have been foretold by the past. If only he had written his notes on Selected Poems of Li Bai instead! Master Li was easygoing and loved a drink. Once thoroughly drunk, he'd raise his cup and declare, "The waters of the Yellow River come down from heaven." That would ensure he never found himself moved to sorrow by the scene before him!

"Of course you're not understanding. You're an idiot," Fingel said. "Idiots aren't understanding."

"Damn it, you only just realized I'm an idiot? We've shared a room for a year. We could even swap underwear!"

Fingel scratched his shaggy head. "Look on the bright side. Let's review the past and look ahead. Nono never really had anything to do with you, did she? When you met her she was already Caesar's girlfriend. Caesar's surrounded by pretty girls in the Student Council, but he's faithful to Nono. They're well matched, a couple made in heaven. A year later they're ready to get engaged. It all makes perfect sense. As Caesar's junior, you should be happy for them from the bottom of your heart. When they get married, you can be the flower boy, holding up Nono's train with a big smile..." Fingel gave him an emphatic thumbs-up. "Wouldn't that be wonderful?"

"Pah! Flower boys are children!" Lu Mingfei said.

"And you think you're not a child?" Fingel grinned.

Lu Mingfei was stunned. After all these years, was he actually a child? But when he thought about it, that was what children were like, wasn't it? They adored something with all their hearts, longed every day to watch a particular cartoon, put posters on the wall and swooned over the heroine, listened to someone's CD over and over and called themselves a fan. They waited to grow up, hiding posters, figurines, and CDs in a cardboard box like treasures they would cherish all their lives, imagining that once they were grown they could meet the man or woman of their dreams.

But before they could grow up, the cartoon stopped airing, the poster wore to shreds, and the once-handsome singer grew a scruffy beard and turned into an awkward middle-aged man who wasn't cool anymore.

As you grow up, someone is leaving you too.

Nono was that person. She was only a dream: the beautiful heroine on an animation poster, or a vibrant young beauty singing and dancing under the lights. While some child was infatuated with her, she might already be secretly married, going home every evening to kiss some man who had appeared out of nowhere, make him dinner, watch television with him, and go to bed together. While they slept in each other's arms, the child lay in bed looking at the stars and dreaming, slowly, slowly growing up.

"So I'm a child... damn it!" Lu Mingfei slowly closed his eyes and fell asleep.

Chu Zihang opened his eyes and glanced at Xia Mi, who had fallen asleep leaning against the side of his bed. It was late at night.

Xia Mi wore a simple white blouse and a fitted uniform skirt. In the darkness her slender figure was pale and luminous as moonlight. There was a faint scent about her, both warm as sunshine and moist

as dew. Chu Zihang suddenly felt he knew it. A familiar scent had returned after being forgotten for a long time, bringing surprise and pleasure, like finding an old photograph in the corner of a battered hard drive. It was blurred by overexposure; all that remained were thin green blades of grass, a girl's slender calves, and the hem of a white skirt.

He was puzzled too. He could not remember where he had smelled it before.

Xia Mi lifted her head sleepily, her watch having left a mark on her face. "I actually fell asleep... Advanced calculus is driving me insane. Seriously, Cassell's calculus class is twisted." She had fallen asleep while talking to Chu Zihang and struggling through her textbook. These days she often hung around his room as though it were her study. Chu Zihang had gradually grown used to it. When he was sleepy, he simply went to sleep as if she weren't there. Sometimes she was still there when he woke; sometimes she had gone.

Xia Mi patted her rolled-up calculus textbook flat and stuffed it into her bag. She glanced at Chu Zihang. "What are you staring at, senior? Something on your mind? Don't worry. Everyone's on your side; the investigation team can't do anything to you."

"I'm thinking about a friend," Chu Zihang said.

"What could trouble you, young master?" Xia Mi cupped her cheeks in both hands, her face an open plea for gossip.

There was little Chu Zihang could do with her. Xia Mi was the sort who seized on any opening. You had better not give her a topic; once she had a starting point, she'd dig to the bottom and talk with you for hours.

He hesitated. "Someone proposed to the girl my friend likes."

Xia Mi rolled her eyes and scoffed. "That's all? I thought Obama had fallen for the Queen of England, for the great president to spend the whole night thinking about it. Isn't it perfectly normal for someone to propose? When I was in high school, a boy declared he was going to marry me. He wrote it on the blackboard at night, and the next day the whole school knew."

"What kind of person was he?" For once, Chu Zihang was interested in Xia Mi's subject.

"Who knows? If he'd dared show himself, would he have sneaked in at night to write it?" Xia Mi pouted. "If he'd had the nerve, I wouldn't have minded giving him a chance. But the principal photographed the blackboard and posted it at the school gate with a public reprimand. After that, all the boys who liked me kept their distance."

"If that boy really had come forward, you would have considered..." Chu Zihang suddenly couldn't find the right words. "Trying it?"

"Please! Could you be any more old-fashioned? In Japanese dramas they call it going out. In Hong Kong they call it dating. A little more old-fashioned is 'being together,' and even more old-fashioned is 'falling in love.' What kind of expression is 'trying it,' senior?"

"All right." Chu Zihang nodded. "Being together."

"Ridiculous! Why should I?" Xia Mi tilted her head back and sniffed. "I've got the figure and the face, and I tell terrible jokes. I'm good with both books and fighting. Plenty of people want to be with me. Should I 'try it' with every one of them? Do you think I'm running a charity soup kitchen?"

Chu Zihang nodded thoughtfully. "So a girl wouldn't accept feelings that appeared out of nowhere, would she? In other words, if you don't like someone, no matter how hard he tries, it's no use."

"Not necessarily. If you don't try, how do you know whether a girl likes you? Some people have known each other for ages without being close. Others feel close the moment they meet." Xia Mi leaned against the window, her hands behind her head, moonlight falling at her feet. "You have to approach this emotionally. You know what that means?"

"But you also said you wouldn't give people a chance easily."

"Lots of people like me. I can't give them all a chance."

"Lots of people like that girl too."

"Who's proposing to her?"

"Her boyfriend."

"Is her boyfriend a good person?"

"I think so. Lots of girls like him too." Caesar's pale-gold hair and the group of girls in white lace dresses surrounding him came to Chu Zihang's mind.

"Handsome?"

"Yes."

"Rich?"

"Though a little extravagant with money."

"A flirt?"

"No."

"Then what the hell is there to discuss?" Xia Mi shrugged. "A girl has a boyfriend who's handsome, rich, and faithful, and they've reached the point of a proposal. That's the best thing in the world. Your friend is just a light bulb. Senior, do you know what 'light bulb' means?"

"Someone who comes between a couple and gives off a discordant light."

"How academic!" Xia Mi gave him a thumbs-up. "But accurate. Has the girl ever shown she likes the light bulb? Or does only the light bulb like her?"

"Only the light bulb likes the girl."

In the Zone One dormitory, the unconscious Lu Mingfei suddenly let out a huge sneeze and shuddered violently, as though someone had stabbed him in a dream.

Chu Zihang always cut straight to the bone when he spoke.

Xia Mi looked thoroughly disappointed. "Senior, could there be any more boring gossip? It's just an unrequited crush! Who hasn't had one? You forget that sort of thing when you grow up. There's nothing to discuss."

Chu Zihang fell silent and turned to look at the fir tree outside, its shadow black as ink in the night. He was organizing his words. Whenever he wanted to explain something important, he prepared the sentences in his mind first and rehearsed them, just as he had when giving speeches as a student representative in high school. That was how rigid he was. Once he had prepared a speech in his head, he would recite it word for word, like an arrow released from the bow, unable to change direction.

"I suppose everyone meets someone in their life and falls for her. Some meet at the right time, like encountering flowers in bloom in spring. Then everything goes well: they fall in love, get engaged, marry, and live together. Others meet at the wrong time, like seeing a fish rise for air beneath the ice in

winter. Once it has breathed, it sinks out of sight, and nothing comes of it. But can we say it's right to meet flowers in spring and wrong to meet a fish in winter? If you meet at the wrong time, can you stop yourself from liking that person? Wouldn't you still do everything you could to get closer, find every way to hide yourself, even pretend to be another fish?" Chu Zihang said softly.

He trembled slightly. He suddenly realized he was not talking about Lu Mingfei; he was thinking of that man meeting his mother.

A dragon hybrid meeting a pure human, and one of them hiding what he was, pretending to be a useless man. Again he remembered the sunlight outside the little house, the beautiful woman grimy-faced at the stove with its steaming kettle, the child riding on the man's shoulders as the man crawled around the floor. And that damned glass of milk, with a sugar cube in it, sending up white steam in the depths of his memory.

What kind of love was right? What kind was wrong? Should seeds of hope that had never flowered be buried in the soil, without even a spring in which to sprout?

"How much courage did that boy who liked you need to sneak into the classroom late at night? What was he feeling when he wrote on the blackboard that he wanted to marry you?" He looked at Xia Mi. "Of course you wouldn't accept. But for all three years of high school he still watched you silently from a corner of the classroom. Like a mole. Moles can't bear the light; a few hours in the sun will kill them. A mole can't come out of the dark. It can only watch you in secret. Is that wrong?"

A cool silence settled over them. Their eyes met and held. An old wall clock ticked softly as time slipped away.

Chu Zihang suddenly regretted it and wanted to slap himself. The atmosphere was far too strange! All those speeches in school had given him this bad habit: he became lyrical without meaning to, imagining he was on a podium. And he was slow to react. By the end, seeing Xia Mi staring blankly without interrupting, he had realized he'd gone off course, but he couldn't stop... How was he supposed to end this?

A burst of applause.

"Beautifully said! If you'd debuted five years earlier, today's romance writers would all be out of work!" Xia Mi clapped as if she'd just heard an impassioned public address.

Chu Zihang looked into her sparkling eyes, a little stunned.

"If you like someone, you should hurry and tell her," Xia Mi said with a serious nod. "Otherwise she'll run away."

"Some things only count once you've said them. If you don't, you just keep guessing. Guess long enough and it all comes to nothing." Xia Mi grinned. "Still, that's so quietly passionate. No wonder you're such a hopeless Cancer, senior."

"Gemini. I was born June first," Chu Zihang corrected her.

Xia Mi bared her teeth in a grin. "But your rising sign is Cancer, and four planets in your chart are in Cancer. You're a fake Gemini and a real Cancer. Aren't Cancers just like you? Soft and tender, always full of things on their minds, sensitive, their hearts ten thousand times faster than their mouths. You wait for them to speak, fall asleep waiting, and they're still preparing. They're hopelessly concerned with saving face; if they think their pride's been hurt even a little, they'll swallow the words on the tip of their tongue and bottle them up instead. That's what people call a hopeless Cancer."

"How do you know my birth chart?" Chu Zihang stared.

"Don't you think... I know you awfully well?" Xia Mi made a face, then sighed softly. "You're just forgetful, aren't you? We used to be classmates! Classmates at Shilan High School! We went to the same middle school! I transferred away later!"

Chu Zihang was stunned. He did not remember ever meeting Xia Mi. Shilan had many pretty girls, but he always walked with his head down and rarely looked at anyone. Had there been a junior watching him from a distance, about to transfer away, while boys played basketball on the busy school grounds and girls gathered over fashion magazines and watched them? The name Xia Mi felt utterly unfamiliar, yet that scent seemed branded into his mind.

"If you see a fish rise for air beneath the ice, and you're still waiting there the next winter, you'll see it come up again. The next time you meet, you can bring an ice pick, smash the ice, fish it out, and take it home to make fish soup! That's what happens next." Xia Mi smiled with narrowed eyes. "Hey!"

She put on her bag and skipped to the door with her hands behind her back. At the doorway she turned. "The friend you were talking about is Senior Lu, right? Honestly, senior, you can't hide a thing. You sold him out completely."

She ran off, giggling.

"Can you veto Caesar's application? Find some reason. You're good at making reasons up anyway." Fifty meters below the Cassell College library, among dark servers and cables, a man reclined in a computer chair with his hands behind his head.

Soft light illuminated his stubbled face. It shone vertically down from above, projecting the translucent figure of a girl. She wore a dark-green uniform, and her plain white lace scarf was almost indistinguishable from her pale face.

"I can offer a recommendation, but I can't veto it directly. The principal and vice principal will give their opinions too. Even if all three of us object, the Board of Trustees can force it through." EVA shook her head. "On this matter, the Gattuso family can sway the entire board. In other words, if his family agrees to the marriage, no one can stop it."

"That's a bit of a headache..."

"Still, since you asked, I'll add a note opposing it to the report."

"Beautiful! I can always count on my girl!" The man snapped his fingers.

"Last time you asked me to change his grades. Now you want me to annotate his report. You're becoming his nanny. You've never liked interfering in other people's affairs... Why are you putting so much thought into him?" EVA tilted her head toward the man, half her hair falling all the way to her feet. She smiled mischievously, yet her smile was pure as frost and snow.

The man shrugged. "I want to delay the marriage and give Lu Mingfei a chance... At least he'll have time to try."

"You pity him?" EVA shook her head. "What good will that do? That child can't grow up under your protection forever. Even if you give him a chance, he has to be able to seize it himself. He's too timid. Ever since he heard the news, all he's done is drink and sleep every day, as if his soul had gone."

"How do you know?"

"There are very few things in this college beyond my surveillance. I can tell from his late-night food receipts." EVA said. "A weak child is ultimately of no use."

"Yes, he's a weak child. But those who must grow up will grow up, and what must awaken can't be stopped. Those are things for the future; they have nothing to do with me." The man shook a can of iced Coke. "I just want to give the little guy a little hope. A loser like him has so few things, and so few things he cares about. Just a handful of things fill his heart. Chen Motong isn't anything in particular to him, but she takes up a big space there. If she disappears, she'll leave a hole nothing can fill." The man touched the left side of his chest. "That's why he keeps drinking. There's a thirst only wine can soothe, and that thirst is loneliness."

After a long silence, EVA stretched out her insubstantial hand and stroked his hair. "You're getting old. You didn't talk like that before. You were proud as a beast."

"After I lost you..." The man reached out and took her hand, or perhaps only light and air, and spoke softly. "I was lonely too."

"Someone's breaking in." EVA suddenly looked up.

"Your design makes it impossible to hack you!" The man was shocked.

EVA sighed. "It's because of you. You were the only person who could truly break into me. But you were worried the Board of Trustees would copy the hidden files in my memory core, so you used a supercommand to disable some of my functions, even barring access to white-card holders. That left my defensive barrier incomplete."

"Damn! That supercommand is that powerful?" The man pressed a hand to his forehead.

"You should have read the manual I gave you carefully. Supercommands operate at the system's lowest level. Every one is extremely powerful. There's even one that can make me self-destruct. Would you like to write it down?" EVA smiled and reached out to stroke his face, like a mother dealing with a spoiled child who had made a mistake.

"No thanks. Where's the intruder now?"

"They came in through the circulating-water system. The target is moving deeper into the Ice Cellar's lowest level."

"The Well of Oblivion? Understood." The man sprang to his feet, shaking off the coat draped over his shoulders. Knotted muscles rolled beneath his skin as though about to burst free. His fists gave a faint crack as he turned and left.

"Be very careful when you use your Yanling. Excessive muscular strength puts enormous pressure on your bones," EVA warned.

"I know, I know. Sometimes I really wonder if I fell for you because of some strange mother complex. You're just like my mom." The man waved helplessly. "I'm not old enough for osteoporosis yet, and I've taken calcium tablets every day like you asked!" He grinned broadly.

A dark, fishlike shadow swam through a stainless-steel pipe. The pipes, two meters in diameter, carried fresh water and seawater to Anjou's enormous garden and fish tanks. Sturdy alloy screens stood every few hundred meters, but they had all been torn apart with ease. The alarms inside the pipe walls no longer flashed red. More than half of the Ice Cellar's defenses had been disabled.

The shadow rolled over and pressed the suckers on both knees against the smooth inner wall. Its domain unfolded, sending transparent ripples outward. The water stopped instantly, solidified and sealed by the domain. The figure clenched a fist and struck the pipe, shattering the water, the pipe wall,

and the rock outside together, like an old boxing master performing some legendary stone-splitting technique. The water flowed again, and the enormous pressure squeezed the shadow out.

He swam gently onward, the sound echoing through a vast, dark space.

The Well of Oblivion, the lowest level of the Ice Cellar. Legend said the three goddesses of fate spun, stretched, and cut the threads of life here. This was the place where all things were erased. It was as silent as an ancient cavern, save for the omnipresent sound of water.

The shadow took out two flares, lit them, and tossed one into the air. It crossed the darkness like a blazing meteor, yet could not penetrate the heavy blackness overhead. This was an immense underground cavern, carved by running water over tens of millions of years. The flare fell into the water ahead and went out.

The figure held the remaining flare high, illuminating his surroundings. The floor was bronze. Deep grooves, entwined like snakes, had been etched into it, and greenish-blue water flowed through them. Together they formed a flourishing vine that branched, branched again, then endlessly divided and rejoined before emptying into the silent lake ahead. Viewed from above, the shadow stood at the vine's root. Countless symbols appeared and disappeared among its tangled branches, forming a perfect circular totem around the little lake.

Here, in a place where no sky could be seen overhead and metal served as the earth beneath, time seemed frozen, everything sealed away and cut off. No wonder there were no elaborate defenses: the metal vine beneath his feet was the strongest defense of all.

An extraordinarily powerful domain filled the entire space, generated by the metal pattern underfoot. The vine was an unparalleled Yanling array. It was a miracle of alchemy: symbols and elements alone had created a domain, flowing and circulating without end. No living being was needed to sustain it. This was a privilege of the gods, beyond the reach of any religious code.

"So humans can take the art of alchemy to such extremes too," the shadow murmured.

Where the lines on the floor tangled most densely, small domains formed strange circles full of power, suppressing the restless forces within. Each held a different exhibit: unfamiliar machinery, stone caskets covered in incantations, even the dried upper half of a mummy, its arms locked by bone shackles to a section of iron pillar. Mummy and pillar were immersed in formalin in an ultracold quartz-glass container. A metal plaque said it had been unearthed in 1836 in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, part of a pharaoh's burial goods.

"A junk heap." The shadow glanced over the collection, any item in it capable of shaking the world.

He cut his wrist, and thick blood dripped into the grooves. Heavier than the greenish-blue water, it sank to the bottom and spread with the current. A new color stained the vine: the dark red of blood. Gradually the blood beneath the water began to glow in shifting colors, and bubbles rose to the surface as if from a violent chemical reaction. Soon the water boiled, bubbles and droplets dancing together. The Yanling array had been activated. Blood-red light flashed on and off in a steady rhythm, like a heartbeat.

The shadow's deep chant filled the entire space. Beneath that ancient, magnificent Yanling, the bloody light grew stronger, until the metal vine glowed like red-hot iron.

The light abruptly went out. Dark-red steam rose from every groove at once as the greenish-blue water evaporated; the dry channels looked as though strong acid had eaten through them.

The alchemical domain had been destroyed. The sealed space was free again, and everything felt light and fresh. Then... it was as if a host of demons had begun to dance!

The exhibits came alive, each in its own way. A bronze mask opened and closed its lips soundlessly, as if singing an ancient priest's hymn. The mummy writhed on its iron pillar, seemingly trying to break its shackles. The fine gold sand in a dark-gold hourglass had long since fallen to the lower chamber, but now an unknown force drew it back up. A mottled music box began to play again. Tiny new projections appeared on the silver cylinder that recorded its sounds: this was an entirely new tune.

A place meant to erase everything, a place like a coffin, had suddenly grown as lively as a temple fair.

"Shut up!" the shadow snapped.

His reprimand swept through the cavern like a military order. Wherever it reached, the exhibits trembled and fell silent again. Living spirits dwelled within them, and scarcely awakened from sleep, they felt a pressure more terrifying than eternal slumber: the pressure emanating from the shadow.

"You, keep playing." He pointed to the music box. "Give us something grand. This should be a great reunion."

The music box made several odd noises, perhaps tuning itself. Then a magnificent march rang through the space, solemn as the booming of an ancient bell.

The shadow walked slowly forward into the pool, where the greenish-blue water and the blood fought their final battle. He waded through calmly; the boiling liquid could not harm him. He looked straight ahead like a pilgrim approaching a shrine.

A circular metal altar stood in the center of the pool. He climbed onto it and looked at what lay before him. "We meet again. I still remember our covenant sealed in blood, and the oath to fight beside you until our blood ran dry. Yet when I see you again, you have withered away."

They were the bare bones of a boy, dark bronze in color, like a work of art cast in solid copper. Crystallized eyes sat in the skull's sockets like a pair of golden glass marbles. The skeleton resembled a human's, but closer inspection revealed enormous differences. Its body contained nearly a thousand slender bones, some fused together, others forming structures found in no textbook. Two fans of delicate bones spread from its back: his wings. His outstretched arms gripped the wing bones behind him, and his skull hung low, like Jesus nailed to the cross.

A dragonbone cross.

The shadow stroked the skeleton. "You can't have died just like that, can you? This is no death for a Dragon King... Let me undo your last bonds."

With one stroke he opened every artery in his wrist, and thick, fishy blood poured into the pool. For an alchemical domain, the greenish-blue water was like the electrolyte in a battery. Its circulation supplied an endless flow of power, mimicking the cycles of the world: sun and moon crossing the heavens, rivers running over the earth. The last alchemical domain contracted around the altar. Blood and greenish-blue water fought desperately, and the pool boiled furiously, but the evaporating water consumed the blood too. The two forces were evenly matched.

"To bring you back, I have to pay a greater price," the shadow murmured.

His ventricles and atria contracted with all their strength. He controlled his own heart, squeezing blood from his body in a way no human could. The blood slowly settled to the bottom of the pool.

With a deafening blast, all the water shot skyward, forming a circular wall dozens of meters high! It was a green-blue downpour flying in reverse. The final alchemical domain collapsed; the immense force shrouding the altar suddenly dispersed. The last bond had been broken!

At that instant the mighty march reached its climax, as though Beethoven's spirit had possessed the box and the heaven of the "Ode to Joy" had descended.

"Get up, Constantine!" The shadow clapped and roared.

No one answered. The dragonbone cross remained still, showing no trace of life. Green-blue spray fell on the skeleton like a sudden drizzle.

The shadow gazed silently at the skeleton. At last he stepped forward and gently gathered it into his arms, as a mother holds an infant. "Constantine... so you really are dead."

"Play us a lament." The shadow pressed his cheek against the skull.

The grand march stopped dead. Music of the deepest sorrow and chill poured from the music box's curved brass tubes, like Tchaikovsky's Pathétique mingled with the religious gravity of a Bach Mass. A soprano aria rose, piercing and beautiful, singing in a language not of this world of time turning like autumn leaves, of meetings often brief and farewells often eternal, of grief beyond human endurance being the world's eternal law.

"Perhaps because they know no dreams, the displaced pursue illusions," someone sang softly and desolately, as though playing a dust-covered xylophone.

The shadow turned. Another figure stood in the darkness nearby, with an exquisite, curvaceous figure and splendid long legs.

"Oh, I didn't mean to interrupt. Just trying to match the mood," the newcomer said with a soft laugh. Clearly a girl, she had a clear, ringing voice with a hint of insolence.

The first shadow fell silent for a moment and understood his situation. He had not heard the other approach; with his bloodline advantage, he could not possibly have failed to notice. There was only one explanation: she had been waiting there all along. She already knew what he was doing. "Mai Sakatoku?" He released the Dragon King's bones and rose slowly.

"Hi! Am I really that famous?" She snapped her fingers, and a light shone down from above. Mai Sakatoku stood lazily in its beam, arms folded, dressed in a black bodysuit, two straight swords strapped along her thighs, her long hair tied in a high ponytail.

"I came to pay my respects to a friend. What are you doing here?" The shadow kept his head down. Mai Sakatoku was clearly a dangerous opponent, but he showed no sign of caution.

"Stealing, of course. Who wouldn't want a look inside the Well of Oblivion, where the dragonbone cross is kept? Its defenses were too tight, though; blundering in would get you caught. But somehow part of the barrier suddenly failed. Like the lock falling off a granary door: naturally, we mice all rushed in. Paying respects to a friend? You're just another mouse here to steal. I'm the first, you're the second..." Mai Sakatoku suddenly turned toward the darkness to one side. "And he's the third."

As if in answer, a third person's breathing sounded in the dark.

"How interesting. One more person and we'd have a full mahjong table," the shadow said.

"Oh, we have enough for mahjong," a voice said behind him, a hand raised high.

"Nice to meet you all." Mai clapped, and a spotlight fell on each of the other three shadows.

The moment had come for everyone to show their true faces. Murderous intent hung taut as a drawn string, ready to snap at a touch! All three figures tensed in attacking stances... except the last, who wore a KFC paper bag over his head. Though his upright bearing and powerful muscles made a striking impression, the bag was a little out of place.

"Could you be a little more professional?" Mai burst out laughing.

"Do I have to dress formally?" Mr. KFC pointed to the third person. "Like him?"

The third person wore a light-gray suit, a white Florentine shirt, and, remarkably, a silver-gray neckerchief. He looked as though he had just come from a reception. He swept his bangs aside, revealing striking two-colored eyes, gold and sea blue.

"Let me introduce him," Mr. KFC said. "This is Mr. Parsi Gattuso, secretary to the investigation team."

"Just call me Parsi," he said mildly.

"I must say, you're awfully polite for a thief. If I'd known someone like you would be here, I'd have worn an evening gown," Mai said with a smile.

"No. Of the people here, I alone am not a thief. Everything in this college belongs to the Board of Trustees, including the dragonbone cross. The Board has authorized me to oversee its property. Naturally, I have no need to sneak around while inspecting what is mine to supervise," Parsi said mildly.

"How wonderfully righteous," Mai said with a grin. "But judging by the mud on your shoes, you don't seem to have come through the visitors' entrance. Did you cross the so-called 'garden'?"

Parsi looked down at his exquisite Italian leather shoes, now thoroughly coated in organic sludge. "Yes. It was difficult going."

"And it looks as if you swam in? Didn't the sharks get in your way?" Mai turned to the shadow beside the dragon's bones.

The figure was a woman, dressed in a pure-black combat suit whose elastic fabric outlined her graceful curves. She stood straight as a crane.

"They're all asleep," the woman said.

"Now that everyone's here, shall we begin?" Mai asked. "Does everyone at the table know how to play mahjong?"

"Sure, sure. Take from the player on your left, watch the one on your right, and keep a sharp eye on the one opposite," Mr. KFC said confidently.

As he spoke, he slowly backed away, muscles swelling all over his body, blue veins slithering along his arms like little snakes. Generally, the greater a Yanling's power, the smaller its domain. With a high-risk Yanling like Sovereign Flame, the domain was only five meters across unless it exploded. Before the mahjong match had even begun, Mr. KFC had retreated to a comparatively safe position. He was clearly a crafty fellow.

An unsettling disturbance in the air came from Parsi. No one had heard him chant, but his domain had already been activated.

This would be no easy game of mahjong. All their banter could not conceal the murderous intent. Anyone who dared break in here was desperate enough to risk death; they could not take apart the Dragon King's bones and divide them up, and there was no possibility of cooperation.

Mai remained languid, arms folded, not even touching the hilts of her swords.

"I'd say you're in the worst position. In mahjong, everyone should sit around the table; that's only fair. But you're sitting right in the middle," Mai said to the shadow beside the bones. "You're closest to taking them, but we'll all attack you first. Would you like to step back a little too?"

"Right, she's trying to be the dealer!" Mr. KFC said.

But the shadow could not even be bothered to look at them. Head lowered, she gently stroked the dragon bones. "Mahjong is a fair game. Killing is not. It isn't a game, and it isn't fun. Before someone who holds authority and power, there is no such thing as an evenly matched fight. Weaklings like you can only die like insects!"

"My, my, are you going to finish all three of us in an instant?" Mai spoke lightly, but a shiver ran through her unnoticed.

"You sing beautifully. I liked it very much. 'Perhaps because they know no dreams, the displaced pursue illusions.'" The shadow spoke softly. "You poor creatures, chasing illusions."

When she finished speaking, funeral bells pealed in unison!

Among the exhibits, a pipe organ two stories high suddenly began to play, a masterpiece with an alchemical mechanism at its heart. It played a Mass and a summons to the dead: the roar of ten million death gods gathered together! Everyone felt the impact from the shadow, not wind pressure or intense heat, but majesty! It was like a mountain slowly toppling toward you, about to crush you beneath it. A transparent domain visible to the naked eye spread outward from the shadow in every direction. The air curtain covered the Dragon King's bones gently and warmly; they did not so much as tremble. But the metal floor began to crack. Countless metal fragments rose slowly within the domain, accompanied by intense magnetization. The fragments clung to one another and revolved around the shadow like scythe-bearing death gods flying around a divine throne.

Five meters, ten, fifteen, twenty... The domain expanded rapidly. No one knew what the Yanling did, but death was surely the only possible end for anyone caught inside it.

But how could a Yanling so devastating also have such an enormous domain? It almost overturned the established rules of Yanling studies!

Twenty-five meters, thirty, thirty-five... It continued to expand. Flickering electric currents pierced the air within it, heating the suspended metal fragments red-hot.

Mr. KFC leaped backward over the circular pool beside the altar. It was not an escape, but the prelude to an attack. He began a low chant. His already imposing body swelled further, and his T-shirt slowly split. He raised an exhibit: a granite sarcophagus, an unidentified relic from the Maya era containing the remains of some unknown person of importance. An invaluable A-rank exhibit, it weighed three tons. A world champion weightlifter could lift only a little over two hundred kilograms; the visual effect was as astonishing as a worker ant raising fifty times its own weight.

Yanling: Bronze Throne.

The man's bones crackled softly, and a bronze sheen appeared on his skin. He hurled the sarcophagus high into the air!

It pierced the air curtain without slowing. A three-ton cannonball, it seemed certain to smash the slender shadow into a bloody pulp. But it suddenly stopped in front of her, as though an invisible hand held it aloft. The shadow struck its front with her fist, and a small crack appeared. Within seconds it spread to every corner of the sarcophagus. The coffin held its shape a few seconds longer, then the currents spinning within the air curtain blew it apart! Along with the important person's remains, it became a shower of drifting ash.

Everyone's expression changed. They all understood their mistake. This was not mahjong, but a slaughter. The shadow had initially been cautious only because the powerful alchemical domain was still active and restricting her. Now she had destroyed those shackles. Parsi drew an old flintlock pistol from inside his clothes, along with a brass box containing a bullet tipped with a carved dark-red crystal. The domain was not far away now, but he did not retreat; he loaded quickly. Retreat would have meant nothing. The shadow was playing cat and mouse with them, and she was perfectly capable of stopping the mice from escaping.

If the three mice wanted to live, they had no choice but to join forces and kill the cat!

A bullet tipped with the Philosopher's Stone: the supreme achievement of alchemy, pure spiritual element, transcending the four elements. The dragon monarchs and their descendants, who commanded the laws of the four elements, could issue no orders to an element beyond those laws. It was therefore invincible, able to pierce anything.

Parsi raised the pistol and fired. The dark-red bullet passed through the air curtain without resistance and struck the shadow.

The enormous impact drove her back a step, but she straightened again. Something like metal covered her body; the metal fragments had gathered over her. Dark-red crystal powder trickled down.

The bullet had shattered against her body!

"Didn't the person who gave you that bullet teach you how to use it?" the shadow said softly. "Once the spiritual element is refined into a crystal, it has a physical form. Its freedom from limitation applies only to Yanling. As a physical object, it will still shatter if it strikes something as tough as metal. You should have ambushed me, fired it into my body, and hit the core. That is how you could have killed me."

The air curtain was only a few meters from Mai. Awed by its enormous majesty, she trembled faintly. Her Yanling was Dark Illumination; if she wanted to flee in a dark place like this, no one could detect her. But fleeing would do no good now. The Yanling unleashed by the shadow was like Death itself. Nothing could survive within its domain, and in the end that domain would cover the entire space!

Molten metal fragments gathered before her into a grotesque weapon bristling with branches, ten meters long and covered in radiating iron crystals. It was Death's great scythe! Mai had only her two ninja swords, each with a blade less than about two feet long.

The enormous scythe whistled through the air curtain. Mai was as fragile before it as a fledgling, about to have her heart pierced and be impaled on its metal barbs.

A hand reached out of the shadow behind Mai and grasped the scythe's edge!

It belonged to another shadow concealed behind her, a fifth person in the cavern. He held the red-hot metal as easily as if he were holding a cup of tea. The air curtain stopped advancing, its transparent edge of death thirty centimeters from his face.

He was an utterly ordinary-looking shadow, his face indistinct, his build unremarkable. He even seemed to be wearing pajamas.

"Authority and power? Do you believe in authority and power too?" The man in pajamas looked at the shadow. "Good. You understand the rules better than they do. But those who believe in these rules must also pay their price."

"Mai, get up. Stand in front of me. You need not be afraid, and certainly need not panic," he ordered coldly. "Here, one person has Bronze Throne as his shield and knows no fear; another has the Philosopher's Stone as his shield and knows no fear. You have neither, but you have me behind you."

Mai rose and walked in front of him, her back to the man, standing between him and the boundary of death. If it advanced even a little farther, she would be crushed to powder like the sarcophagus. But she was no longer afraid, for the man had stepped out of the shadows.

"I understand. You are my shield," Mai said.

"No. I am not your shield. You are my weapon. The sharpest weapon needs no shield; its edge is its shield. There is no need to defend. You need only cut down the enemy." The man placed a hand on the back of Mai's head. "I grant you blood, to refine your soul in blood. What cannot be reached shall remain beyond reach, yet wherever you go, brilliance shall radiate! I grant you swords: slay all who defy you. Ame-no-Habakiri and Futsu-no-Mitama!"

A calm domain unfolded, like a tiny stone dropped into water. But that stone raised a towering wave!

Mai closed her eyes. When she opened them again, golden flames blazed in both pupils.

In an instant she had been transformed. A domain like the shadow's own, like Death itself, surged from her body and drove back the boundary of death pressing against her.

She drew both swords: Ame-no-Habakiri in her left hand, Futsu-no-Mitama in her right!

Mr. KFC and Parsi could no longer tell whether what they were seeing was real or an illusion. These were two of the three spirit swords from Japan's so-called Age of the Gods. Futsu-no-Mitama was the sword of the thunder god Takemikazuchi, while Ame-no-Habakiri was the divine blade with which the Japanese god Susanoo slew the ancient eight-headed serpent Yamata-no-Orochi. In other words, they should not exist as real weapons at all; they held a place like the Chinese Golden-Hooped Rod.

Yet Mai really had drawn two long swords flowing with crimson and molten gold. Ame-no-Habakiri, true to its other name, the Ten-Grasp Sword, was a long curved blade ten fists in length. Futsu-no-Mitama was an enormous straight sword two meters long, exactly as in the legends.

"Only three people in all of history could rewrite a bloodline. Who are you? Who are you? Who are you?" the shadow asked hoarsely.

She had watched the man ever since he stepped out of the darkness. She had remained silent because she could not speak. More keenly than the other three, she sensed how terrifying he was—or rather, that he should not exist at all! His presence here was a greater paradox than Futsu-no-Mitama

and Ame-no-Habakiri! At last she could not help asking, and the repetition betrayed the trembling deep in her soul.

"You're as beautiful as ever," the man said with a soft laugh. He vanished like a trace of ink washed away by water.

Death's scythe shuddered and gave a dying wail. It was breaking apart, metal splinters shooting at Mai like blades, yet they could not cut her skin. They only severed the red cord binding her hair. Her black hair spilled loose like a waterfall and streamed out against the domain of death. She swung Ame-no-Habakiri with an effortless motion. It was the simplest of cuts, without any technique, like slicing an onion with a kitchen knife, yet Death's scythe disintegrated, fragments shooting back the way they had come. It was unparalleled strength, like the shadow destroying the sarcophagus.

Mai swung again. Futsu-no-Mitama traced a perfect arc around her, and within that arc a domain arose of its own accord. Dazzling violet electricity streamed over it with a thunderous roar.

Carrying a long sword in each hand, Mai advanced slowly into the shadow's domain. Across the surface of the newborn violet domain, two different currents crossed, sparks flaring and dying.

"An alchemical domain!" Parsi hissed.

Like the domain in the Well of Oblivion, the one Futsu-no-Mitama had activated was alchemical. It required no living host, only an alchemical object, and could circulate without end. Once, this had been a miracle imagined by alchemists, not an actual technique. A domain was created by a Yanling, and only living things could use Yanling. However carefully alchemy refined the elements, whether turning silver to gold or refining sulfur from volcanic ash, the result was lifeless matter. An alchemical domain was different. To achieve it, an alchemist had to reorganize the four basic elements into something possessing the essence of life, something alive and capable of releasing a domain.

But this was an act of stealing divine authority, a technique for imitating life from dust.

A forbidden art!

Apparently, every dogma existed only to be challenged and rewritten.

The two drew closer. The shadow's combat suit split, and blue-gray scales covered her beautiful body. It swelled abruptly, the scales rising like a field of steel thorns! Bone spikes pierced her skin: her black bones were growing toward the surface and becoming sharp blades. Molten metal fragments adhered to them and cooled, forming metallic crystals over the bone blades. The same transformation was taking place in Mai.

"Draconic transformation," Mr. KFC said, licking his lips.

Ame-no-Habakiri roared, exultant. Another twisted metal weapon formed in the shadow's hand. They charged head-on like colliding meteors.

Endless light and heat, thunder and fire burst in every direction. The ground shook. Fragments of concrete crashed down around them; their first impact destroyed the exit from the Well of Oblivion.

Parsi raced into the black passage, the thunder behind him pursuing him like the death knell of the world! He had begun retreating before the two collided. Only a madman would stay; to watch a battle between gods, one had to be at least a demigod. This was an emergency passage leading to the enormous botanical garden through which he had infiltrated. Suddenly a jet of flame lit up his eyes, and a violent current hurled him away. Two figures flashed through the fire, weapons clashing, demolishing the concrete passage!

Like savage dragons locked in combat—was this their true strength when their dragon blood erupted?

Parsi turned and ran back toward the Well of Oblivion. He had studied its map before infiltrating and considered every escape route, but now only one remained usable.

Mr. KFC was hopping up and down, frantically pressing the elevator's up button. He stared when he saw Parsi racing toward him. "Waiting for the elevator too?" This was an emergency elevator, activated by card only when the Well of Oblivion was on the brink of destruction. Parsi clutched the white card in his hand. Mr. KFC, on the other hand, held nothing. He was simply hammering the up button like an office worker afraid of being late. Yet the elevator really was descending.

Was it... facial recognition?

Parsi hesitated. "Hello."

The tremors grew more violent. Flame and lightning shot through the air; wind and broken stone flew everywhere. The two men waited for the elevator side by side.

"Didn't expect this the first time we met. We really ought to have had a proper chat," Mr. KFC said.

Parsi had no idea where the man's peculiar sense of humor came from. He could only nod. "At a moment like this, seeing a monster like you makes me feel I've found my own kind."

"Exactly. Makes you want to exchange business cards."

At last the elevator doors opened, and the two men who had been chatting a moment ago scrambled inside like wild dogs.

But a strange, chilling sound came from overhead: the reinforced concrete structure was splitting apart! An enormous precast concrete slab slowly dropped along a clean cut. Mr. KFC's muscles surged as he thrust it aside with both arms. The elevator doors were about to close. Parsi hesitated for an instant, then a black sheathed hunting knife slid from his sleeve, bracing the doors open. It gave Mr. KFC a few seconds to vault over the knife into the elevator like an agile gorilla.

Parsi withdrew the knife, and the doors closed at once. The sudden upward acceleration threw both men onto the floor. Another tremendous shock came from below, so violent that the elevator shook like a birdcage in an earthquake. Half its floor collapsed, exposing the steel framework. They looked down into the black shaft. Seconds later, flames filled the long, deep darkness. Trapped superheated air rose with the fire like an enraged fire dragon, the blast of heat cutting their faces like a knife.

Parsi grabbed Mr. KFC's shoulder. His domain expanded to cover them both.

Yanling: Dustless Realm.

Everything without permission was excluded from the domain, even heat. Flames shot upward through the elevator, burning everything combustible until only its blackened metal frame remained, still carrying them upward.

The torrent of fire finally burst through the concrete at the top and twisted into the shape of a dragon in the night sky before vanishing in a flash.

The elevator reached the top. Red light rolled everywhere across campus. The alarm bells shrieked like a great flock of flamingos crying out in their final moments. The earth shook, buried water pipes burst, high-pressure jets spouted like fountains, granite facing peeled from buildings, and the rooster statue atop Valhalla crashed down.

It was like the apocalypse written in prophecy, and before it every person was as small as dust.

After breaking through the ground, the flames erupted from the well in front of Valhalla, the college's foundation well. In the days before running water, students and teachers had drilled the first spring there. Swept by searchlights, two shadows sprang out of the well and fled in different directions like mice, without time to say goodbye.

As Cassell College tottered in the sudden upheaval, ten time zones away in Beijing, China, the earthquake bureau announced a low-intensity earthquake measuring 2.1.

Earthquakes of such low intensity were commonplace. Only people working on the upper floors of tall buildings in the central business district would feel a little dizzy, so the news was quickly overlooked.

Naturally, no one connected the earthquake with the incident ten time zones away.

The subway lights went out. A few startled cries sounded, and after several seconds the lights came back on. The drowsy Zhao Menghua opened his eyes.

The train rumbled onward. An announcement said it was only an unexpected power outage, everything was normal, and passengers should not panic. Zhao Menghua glanced at the route display above the door. Zhongguancun was the next stop, and his destination. He had drunk too much with a buddy the night before and slept in his dorm; now he was headed back to Peking University. If it weren't rush hour, he would never have squeezed into the subway with a crowd. Even without a driver to pick him up in Beijing, he could have taken a taxi.

He could stop and have his phone repaired on the way. He couldn't open his contact list; the memory card was probably damaged.

He suddenly froze, his gaze caught. The person in front of him wore a black backpack bearing a circular emblem: the half-decayed World Tree.

Zhao Menghua had first seen that emblem at the Cassell College interview, and a second time on Lu Mingfei's credit card. It was the college crest. The young man and woman standing side by side ahead of him must have come from that mysterious college. Zhao Menghua had searched online for information about Cassell, but found nothing. On the surface it appeared to be a private school for the wealthy, but whenever he tried to learn more, he found it wrapped in an invisible shell that kept him from looking closely.

The more he encountered that barrier, the more curious he became. More importantly, from Lu Mingfei to Nono to Chu Zihang, every person who had humiliated him had come from that college. They were his sworn enemies.

"Boqian, have you found any targets?" the boy asked in a lowered voice.

The girl shook her head. "A few people with the bloodline, but probably a very low proportion. I haven't sensed anyone releasing a domain. Is this really going to work?"

Zhao Menghua felt his ears stand up like a rabbit's, but he couldn't really understand what the two were talking about.

"Searching for a first-generation dragon on the subway? I have no idea who came up with this plan. Would a first-generation dragon ride the subway?" the girl complained under her breath.

"They can take all kinds of forms. Didn't one in human form appear on campus?" the boy said reassuringly. "The subway has the densest flow of people, and you're sensitive to bloodlines and domains."

"But going through every subway station every day is so boring," the girl sighed.

"We haven't been to every station," the boy said, apparently trying to cheer her up. "There are at least two hidden ones you haven't visited."

"Hidden?"

"Mm. Not every station is open to the public. Every time you get off at the terminus, doesn't the train keep going? There are stations farther on; they just don't appear on the map. Those are the hidden stations..." the boy said.

"Next stop, Zhongguancun," the announcement said.

"Come on," the girl said. "Let's transfer to Line 4 and keep searching."

A thought struck Zhao Menghua, and he quietly followed them. They were acting suspiciously, and he wanted to know what they were doing. There were few people in the transfer passage. He jogged after the pair, shivering for no apparent reason.

The escalator descended slowly, the fluorescent tubes overhead flickering on and off.

Zhao Menghua glanced at the framed advertisements on the wall and was surprised to find they had all been removed, leaving empty spaces. Scraps of newspaper littered the floor, as if it hadn't been cleaned in years. The young man and woman walked and talked, their voices growing more distant. Zhao Menghua hurried forward, but could no longer see them, only faintly hear their conversation. He rarely rode the subway, so he looked up at a sign. He had a vague feeling something was wrong with it, but paid it no attention. The underground passage twisted and turned, and the farther he went, the more scraps of paper lay on the floor, as though a vehicle loaded with old newspapers had just passed through.

Ticket gates appeared ahead, though Zhao Menghua remembered that he had not left the station; a transfer shouldn't require another ticket. But there was only this way, and the pair must have gone through. He felt in his pocket: nothing but hundred-yuan bills, not even two coins for a ticket. The floor trembled faintly. A train must be coming in.

He looked around, saw no one, and steeled himself to crawl under the gate. No one challenged him, and secretly pleased, he ran to the platform just as the incoming train stopped. With a sharp clacking, rusted bearings turned and the doors opened.

Zhao Menghua looked up at the train, a chill coursed through his whole body, and he stopped dead.

Its lights were off. He couldn't see whether the darkness inside was crowded with people or completely empty, but suddenly he realized he was alone on the platform. At some point the voices of the young man and woman had vanished. All along he had thought there were a few other people scattered through the station; only now did he see it was utterly empty. It was as though everything before had been an illusion.

He had been the only person in this station from beginning to end!

The station itself was wrong too... Zhao Menghua slowly raised his head. Fluorescent tubes flickered. Massive columns supported a high vaulted ceiling above a terrazzo floor, and green-painted iron railings bordered the stairs. Everything looked both familiar and strange.

He suddenly looked down and saw "LINE 1" painted in red on the train's battered exterior.

Line 1? Zhao Menghua shuddered. How could a Line 1 train be here? Zhongguancun was on Line 4, where the trains were all new imports!

But the train wasn't the only thing wrong. The station looked like Line 1 too: Beijing's oldest subway, with its vast, empty Russian-style interior, cold wind blowing across the platform, fluorescent lights washing every face deathly pale.

Zhao Menghua held his head and slowly crouched down, his mind blank. He remembered the empty advertising frames, the scraps of newspaper, and the peeling paint on the signs. All the anomalies he'd ignored came back to him. As he went deeper into the station, traces of the modern world had been gradually erased. He had entered a Line 4 station in 2010 and emerged into a Line 1 station from the 1970s. The transition had been seamless, time drawn back little by little along the long corridor.

The subway train still waited, its open doors seemingly inviting its only passenger aboard.

Zhao Menghua backed away step by step. How could he get on that strange train? Who knew where it would take him? Heaven or hell? Heaven, my ass! He turned and bolted up the stairs.

The station was utterly empty. Zhao Menghua could not remember the way in, so he searched everywhere for signs. The normally crowded station now looked like an enormous maze. He understood why some claustrophobic people never rode the subway: however it was decorated with light and color, a station was an enclosed space isolating you underground. In this vast space were countless signs, every one pointing to the platform he had just left. Whenever he tried to go the other way, he saw only their backs, painted with huge red crosses and the words "NO ENTRY."

There was no way out, as if anyone who came here would never leave...

Icy wind poured into the station from the stairway leading to the platform, like the greenish vapor that often bursts out when an ancient coffin is opened. He could think of nothing else and ran, thick dust dancing behind him. He dared not look back and did not see the changes there. White walls gradually peeled and yellowed; aluminum ceiling panels became old-fashioned plaster; LED lights hidden in recesses were replaced by pallid fluorescent tubes; the escalator turned into hard, cold marble steps after he passed. Greenish mist was infecting the entire station like a virus of time.

"NO ENTRY."

"NO ENTRY."

"NO ENTRY."

The repeated red crosses and "NO ENTRY" signs flashed before Zhao Menghua's eyes. It was like taking a wrong turn while driving and hearing a GPS repeat in a stiff female voice: "You are on the wrong route. Please make a U-turn ahead... Make a U-turn... Make a U-turn..."

Like hell he would turn around now. Zhao Menghua kept his head down and ran. Perhaps it was his imagination, but the station seemed suddenly to have grown dozens of times larger. Its passages were as complicated as a spiderweb; each turn led to another long corridor. Legends crowded into his mind: in a tomb filled with accumulated resentment, for example, there were always paths that never ended. Grave robbers thought they were running for their lives, but to someone unaffected by the enchantment they were merely marching in place with exaggerated movements...

At last there was light ahead. A white sign painted in red read "PROCEED THIS WAY."

Joy surged through Zhao Menghua. It was the only different sign he had seen along the way. He leaped up four or five steps and stood beneath the sign pointing toward the light...

A silent subway platform waited ahead, as though dust and time had sealed it away for decades. Scraps of newspaper covered the floor. On the walls, old ceramic-tile pictures promoted "Five Stresses, Four Beauties, Three Loves." Aging fluorescent tubes flickered and popped. He felt ice crystals forming in his blood. He was back on the very platform he had struggled to escape.

He sank down beside the stairs and sat stunned for a long, long time. Then he gathered up scraps of newspaper and pieced them together strip by strip until he had an almost complete paper. The publication date was January 30, 1992.

Eighteen years ago!

Act Thirteen

The Bloodline Covenant

Blood Contract

Each of you has a human side and a dragon side. In your veins flow many contradictions at once: white and black, good and evil, love and hate, peace and slaughter. We are neither wholly good nor wholly evil. We possess the power to kill, but must not desire to kill. Remember that we stand with humanity. Only those whose human goodness overcomes the evil of dragons are our companions. Anyone who cannot restrain that evil, who lets a hunger for power consume their soul, becomes our enemy.

Lu Mingfei opened his eyes a crack. Warm sunlight fell over him.

He woke with a hangover, reeking of alcohol and naked beneath a sheet. After a few breaths of fresh air, his head cleared a little. He patted the edge of the bed. "Senior, what time is it? You forgot to close the curtains again, didn't you?"

"With the sun that bright, it must be about noon. Get up and have lunch!" Fingel called from the upper bunk.

The wooden bunk bed began to creak and sway. Apparently Fingel was getting up and preparing to climb down.

"Aaaaaaah!" Fingel suddenly shrieked.

"What are you crowing for? Think you're a rooster? Even if you were, it's not morning anymore." Lu Mingfei pushed himself upright and stretched. "Aaaaaaah!"

"You sound like a hen yourself, and you're criticizing me..." Fingel muttered. Lu Mingfei, however, could no longer speak.

Their bunk bed stood amid a pile of ruins. One leg had broken off, and a chunk of concrete had taken its place, somehow keeping the bed balanced.

A great Red Cross flag stood in the middle of the rubble, with dozens of white tents pitched beside it. Inside, doctors examined injured students. Occasionally a blood-pressure cuff burst: some hybrids had blood pressure far above that of ordinary humans. Otherwise, all was calm. At the edge of the ruins, cooks had lined up food carts and begun serving breakfast. The smell of Munich white sausages and scallion bread drifted on the breeze. Long lines stretched in front of both the medical station and the breakfast stand, with their bed caught squarely between them.

"Good morning." Someone from one of the lines came over and shook Lu Mingfei's hand: Kiran, president of the previous freshmen's association.

"Hey! Awake?" Lancelot, vice president of the Lionheart Society, waved from a distance.

"We all thought you'd sleep till noon!" Xia Mi stood in front of the bed, smiling, with a cup of milk and cereal in her hands.

"You drink table wine like this? Don't you find it astringent?" Caesar picked up the bottle by the bed, glanced at its label, and shook his head with disdain.

"Can you really remain so calm in the face of a disaster? I'd like to invite you to take some neurological tests..." Psychology instructor Masashi Toyama looked serious.

Lu Mingfei and Fingel could only pull the sheets tighter around themselves and wave expressionlessly, conveying such complicated sentiments as "I'm fine," "Don't worry about us," and "Please get lost."

The two brothers had merely shared a drink, discussed life, and talked about their dreams. They hadn't done anything shameful! How had the world turned upside down while they slept? What was there to stare at? Hadn't anyone seen a naked man before? Sleeping soundly was a good thing. They were just jealous, weren't they?

"There was an incident in the Ice Cellar last night. The cause hasn't been determined. The college announcement said it might have been an earthquake." Chu Zihang approached the bed. "Several people were injured. No one died."

Lu Mingfei and Fingel scratched their heads, wearing expressions that said, "Oh, so that's what happened. What a relief."

Chu Zihang turned to leave.

"Hey, wait..." Lu Mingfei and Fingel called together.

"What do you need?" Chu Zihang looked back.

"Could... you find me some clothes?" Lu Mingfei asked awkwardly.

"Could... you get me some orange juice and grilled white sausage?" Fingel asked sheepishly. "I'm not wearing anything, so I can't really get out of bed..."

After several seconds of silence, Lu Mingfei grabbed the wine bottle by the bed and threw it at the upper bunk. "Hey! Have some dignity! Eating is not the priority!"

"There's no such thing as dignity when you're hungry!" Fingel declared.

Chu Zihang couldn't be bothered listening to the pair argue. He looked toward Valhalla. The enormous rooster statue had crashed down and destroyed the mouth of the Foundation Well. Around it, a violent explosion had scorched a black circle dozens of meters across. If that could be explained as an earthquake, Cassell College's supposed elites had learned nothing. Whoever issued the announcement was obviously lying through their teeth. But with the principal on sick leave and the vice principal in charge, honest college announcements were rare.

The principal's elevator sank into the sea. The water was not its familiar blue, but a murky red. Dead hammerhead sharks, sea turtles, and bluefin tuna floated beyond the glass, all severed cleanly in two, as though a single sweep of an immensely long blade had cut through them. Their organs spilled from their bodies, digestive tracts drifting through the water like alien sea snakes. It was a vision of hell.

"My fish tank!" Anjou rasped, the corner of his eye twitching.

"I told you, you must stay calm and take things as they come. Suppose someone burned your house down. What good would it do to wander through the ruins screaming, 'My television!' or 'My paintings!'? You'd only make yourself miserable. Look for things you can still use. Those are the

surprises. Perhaps you'd find seashells you collected as a child with the little girl next door. Then you'd smile with delight..." The vice principal patted his old friend's shoulder.

"Don't drag my intelligence down to your level! Lunatics make everyone else insane and then defeat them with experience in their own field," Anjou growled.

"Easy, easy. There's worse..." the vice principal said gently.

The elevator followed its cable into a vast cavern.

"My garden..." Anjou nearly moaned.

Precious trees lay toppled in swaths; those still standing burned fiercely. The shrubs and velvety grass had fared even worse, churned completely to pieces. Black marks crisscrossed the ground, cutting deep into the soil, each broad and nearly a hundred meters long, as though a blazing giant plow had torn through it.

"Think of it as clearing land by fire," the vice principal said. "You're lucky you came now. When I arrived this morning, the smoke was so thick I needed a gas mask."

"My pyramid!" Anjou's bloodshot eyes nearly bulged from their sockets.

The pyramid of black conglomerate had stood for thousands of years in the American jungle; rain had worn only its surface and corners, proof of its strength. Now an enormous crack split its upper level, exposing the sandstone core. Whatever had struck it was difficult to imagine, but the force had brought down nearly half the structure. Black stones lay scattered around it, and putting them back together would be difficult.

The elevator entered a long, dark tunnel. Beyond it lay the Well of Oblivion. Anjou sat upright, fists clenched so tightly his knuckles cracked. He dared not imagine the devastation there. The intruders' target had surely been the Well, where every artifact represented vast expense and effort, including the dragonbone over which he had openly clashed with the Board of Trustees.

Everything was ruined. He had merely gone to sleep and woken up.

The elevator doors opened, and a tide of noise poured in. Anjou stared. Someone who knew would say they had come to inspect ruins; anyone else might have thought they were entering an avant-garde band's recording studio.

The vice principal switched on the lights. There was no band, but a raucous party. Alchemical music boxes played with enthusiasm; Persian-style brass boxes periodically spat flames; a silver-plated skull gaped at Anjou in laughter, its intact teeth clacking together. Without the alchemical domain, these objects containing living spirits had come to life, like little demons escaped from the depths of hell.

In the foulest of moods, Anjou kicked the silver-plated skull away. The kick showed the benefit of more than a decade's practice: at Cambridge he had been one of the soccer team's principal defenders.

The vice principal cried out and dived after it. Despite his belly, he caught the skull in midair with the difficult maneuver of a rugby player.

"Don't take it out on the collection." The vice principal carefully set the skull aside. "Come and see. There's a surprise."

He led Anjou onto the central metal altar, the most severely damaged area. The hard bronze surface had cracked all over; slag that had melted and cooled again littered the floor. A weapon, probably the

same one that had sliced the sharks and split the pyramid, had scored countless cuts across it. The altar felt as though it might crumble to powder at any moment.

The vice principal whisked away a black cover like a magician, beaming. "Well? Happy? Surprised? Your fish are dead, your flowers are dead, and half your pyramid has collapsed... but your precious dragonbone is still here!"

The bronze-colored dragonbone stood quietly, intact. The cross-shaped skeleton had the sacred air of a martyr—except that someone had stuck a yellow note in the middle of its forehead.

Anjou was stunned. Before coming down, he had prepared himself to find the dragonbone stolen. Hybrids around the world coveted this relic. A religious thief who slipped into a cathedral and found the Spear of Longinus, the weapon that pierced Jesus, would have no reason not to take it, even if it had not been the original target. Besides, who would risk so much and go to such trouble to enter the Well of Oblivion for anything else? Had the intruder suddenly repented on the verge of success?

The vice principal peeled off the note and handed it to Anjou. "Someone left us a message."

In lazy, untidy handwriting, it read: "I suggest your college improve its security. Next time someone sneaks in to steal it, I might not happen to be around." It was unsigned.

"Someone helped you save your collection," the vice principal said, patting Anjou's shoulder. "That's good news and bad news."

"What do you mean?"

The vice principal pointed to the pool surrounding the altar, now completely dry. "This was the world's second-largest alchemical domain powered by a mercury solution. I put at least twelve hundred tons of it in there, but some tremendous heat seems to have vaporized it all."

Anjou stared. "I thought ours was the largest."

"The largest has yet to be excavated: the tomb of Qin Shi Huang, China's first emperor. Historical accounts say he had a map of all China carved in his burial chamber, with mercury flowing through it as water—even mercury rain. In ancient Chinese alchemy, that represents perpetual circulation. Historians think it exaggerated, but anyone who studies alchemical domains knows it was an enormous one, powered by mercury. It was so powerful that opponents of his tyranny never dug it up." The vice principal sighed. "To destroy my domain in an instant would take power approaching that of a first-generation dragon. One of the intruders was undoubtedly a first-generation dragon, yet someone stopped him. That means there was another being of comparable power... though perhaps 'person' is hardly the word." He raised his eyebrows. "Few hybrids can approach a first-generation dragon. Given the damage to the Ice Cellar, two dragons may have fought here last night."

"Dragons have awakened—more than one—and their power approaches that of first-generation dragons. Even the one who helped us may be an enemy rather than a friend. Is that right?" Anjou's voice was low.

"Wrong. By your reasoning, all dragons are our enemies."

Anjou nodded slowly.

"Don't dwell on it. I'll move the dragonbone to a new storage facility. Our immediate problem is still the investigation team. They announced this morning that, despite the incident, the hearing will proceed as scheduled. They really can't wait to bring you down, old friend," the vice principal said.

Zhao Menghua sat in the darkness, dazed, as the subway train rumbled onward.

In the end, he had boarded the rust-streaked train because he had nowhere else to go. He had sobbed and screamed on the platform, hidden trembling behind a pillar—done everything a desperate person might do. No one paid him any attention. Not even a monster came out to frighten him. Finally, lying breathless on the platform, he remembered some philosopher saying that death was terrible not because of pain but because of eternal loneliness.

The train was empty too, but its rumbling movement felt better than the platform. Remarkably, it passed stations where lights shone and passengers waited. Yet the train sped through without slowing, and the passengers remained calm, as if they could not see it. Zhao Menghua pressed against the window and shouted, but outside, people kept reading, listening to music, or staring into space. One little brat even struck an Ultraman pose at him—though he was probably admiring his reflection in the glass doors.

The child belonged to 2010, and Zhao Menghua belonged to 1992. A chasm of time separated them.

Feeling cold, Zhao Menghua curled up and shoved his hands into his pockets. His fingertips touched something.

His phone!

Only then did he remember he had brought it. He had been on his way to Zhongguancun to get it repaired!

He pulled it out and looked. Darkness swam before his eyes. He had forgotten to charge it the night before; the battery had run flat and the phone had shut itself off. A large-screen smartphone lasted only a day and needed charging every night.

Zhao Menghua slumped in his seat. A figure in white crossed his mind—not a ghost, but Chen Wenwen. He had stopped charging his phone every night because they had broken up. When they were together, he charged it nightly because Chen Wenwen was sensitive and wanted him to keep it on at all times so she could always reach him. Every night before bed she sent a message: "Good night. Remember to charge your phone."

When you break up with someone, you say goodbye to everything connected with her. You stop eating at her favorite restaurant and close the blog you shared. A scene in a movie once made her cry for no apparent reason and rub against your shoulder; afterward, whenever you see it, you instinctively turn away and draw in your shoulder.

And of course you no longer wait for her little anxious messages: "Where are you?" "I had a dream." "Is it the start of winter today? It's getting dark so early... What are you doing?"

None of that is much, really. Prettier girls will take you to better restaurants. You move on to Weibo and meet selfie experts who post low-cut glamour shots every day. There will always be new midnight movies for every kind of sentimental girl to wash your shirt with tears. Your life will still be full.

But when you are trapped in an enclosed space with only a phone to call for help, you discover that, like an idiot, you also said goodbye to charging it every night!

It had taken her so long to teach you that habit...

Maybe there was still a little charge? Zhao Menghua thought. After a phone shut down, the battery always recovered a little. Turn it on again, and it might last a few minutes.

A few minutes would be enough! With trembling hands, he pressed the power button. The screen lit up. The smartphone took so long to start that his heart pounded. He stared at it, terrified the battery would suddenly die. If a pedal-powered generator had appeared before him, he would gladly have traded his expensive Rolex for it!

It started! But there was no signal...

Zhao Menghua was frantic. He remembered now: Beijing's subway tunnels had no mobile transmitters. There was a signal only at stations. He pressed his face to the window and stared ahead. Finally, a glow appeared. The next station was coming up. Two bars suddenly appeared on his phone!

There really was a signal! But the train would pass without slowing, leaving him barely a dozen seconds. He had to dial quickly. The battery would last only this one station.

But his phone was broken: he couldn't open his contacts. Zhao Menghua froze, his mind blank. He didn't remember his parents' numbers, his roommates' numbers, or Liu Miaomiao's. Young Master Zhao never bothered with such details. The only number he remembered was 114, directory assistance. But if he called and said, Hello, I'm trapped on a pitch-black subway train, I'm so scared, can you rescue me? the operator would probably reply politely, Certainly. I'll put you through to a psychiatric hospital.

He had only seconds. He had to call someone who would believe him—believe him unconditionally!

There was another number, though its owner no longer appeared in his contacts. He had deleted her. He remembered her number because she had once made him recite it over and over. Until he learned it, he was not allowed to keep strolling beneath the streetlights with his arm around her waist. That way, she said, whether he lost his phone or found himself trekking through wilderness with no signal, he could always find her with that number.

She had said sentimental, literary things like, "Look, eleven digits are all it takes to find someone. You can find me for the rest of your life, because I won't change my number or switch my phone off." And she had used the promise of more strolling with his arm around her waist to make him memorize those jumbled digits.

Alone in the empty darkness, Zhao Menghua murmured, "138..." The patternless numbers tumbled from his lips one by one, as if his lips and tongue remembered them rather than his brain.

The lips and tongue that had once kissed a girl.

The call connected. No one spoke. There was only faint breathing.

"Wenwen, save me..." Tears streamed down Zhao Menghua's face. His breath was like the feeble white mist of someone freezing to death in the depths of a winter night.

Valhalla conference hall.

Outside, the rooster statue still stood upside down in the Foundation Well, its rear pointing skyward like a roast chicken on a platter. The rubble had not yet been cleared, but the hearing began on schedule. It was the biggest event at the college: for the first time in a century, the principal faced impeachment. Chu Zihang was on trial, but everyone knew he was Anjou's proxy.

Chu Zihang stood inside the square wooden railing at the center of the hall, expressionless, nodding to the jury. Department heads and tenured professors, all dressed in black, were taking their seats at the front. They looked old enough to have been dug out of graves. Their faces were solemn, but their

manners varied: some smoked pipes, some chewed chunks of celery, and one blew bubble-gum bubbles with brightly shining eyes.

"They look like a bunch of idiots," Fingel whispered behind the vice principal. "Not half as dashing as you and the principal, boss!"

"But they are the college's foundations. The Executive, Information, and Equipment Departments all depend on their research. Without them, there would be no Cassell College." The vice principal sighed. "The Board of Trustees is ruthless, dragging these old researchers out to rule on college affairs. They're so easy to fool."

"If the other side can fool them, so can we."

"That's my student! How did Guderian ever become your adviser? You should be studying the highest art of shamelessness with me!" the vice principal said admiringly.

Opposite them sat the entire investigation team, Andrew at its head and Parsi immediately beside him. Andrew glared at his enemies, eyes blazing. He had sworn to avenge their humiliation of him; his plump, pale face twitched.

"Andrew, my boy, are you all right? Your face is twitching," the vice principal called across the room. "Not ill, are you?"

The old bastard had made a fool of Andrew again. Unable to think of a reply, he turned his head sharply away.

"Trying to play with me," the vice principal snorted. "Youngsters."

"How old are you, Vice Principal?" Fingel asked.

"Twenty-five."

Fingel blinked. He vaguely knew the vice principal belonged to the same generation as Anjou, who was at least a hundred and thirty.

"The golden age that will never leave me. Forever twenty-five!" Looking perfectly serious, the vice principal waved to Manstein in the audience. "Hello, son!"

Like Andrew, Manstein turned his head away. He did not want to acknowledge his idiot father in public.

The selected student representatives were taking their seats. The Lionheart Society had secured half the places. All its members wore crimson uniforms with white neck scarves, as orderly as an army. The Student Council held the other half. Never willing to match the Lionheart Society, they had chosen black uniforms. Caesar's prized troupe of girls in white lace now appeared in long black lace dresses, apparently ready to bury their rivals. The two sides occupied the left and right halves of the hall.

Student Council president Caesar Gattuso had plainly come to enjoy the spectacle. Wearing headphones, he listened happily to music. The campus paparazzi, meanwhile, noticed that neither society leader's woman had appeared: Nono and Susie were both absent.

There was still someone whose beauty commanded the room. Xia Mi, the strongest candidate for campus beauty among the freshmen, led a group of lovestruck boys from the freshmen's association to the Lionheart side. She held a bouquet of unopened fragrant lilies; anyone could guess its intended recipient with their eyes closed. Of course, if things turned ugly, no one could guarantee she wouldn't beat Andrew with it...

The last heavyweight to arrive was Lu Mingfei, the college's only S-rank student. Head lowered, he sat in a corner on the Lionheart side. His discretion was understandable: photographs of him and News Department head Fingel eating grilled sausages wrapped in white sheets had recently reached alumni inboxes around the world. He seemed to have some loyalty, choosing not to sit with the Student Council even though Caesar was his boss. Everyone knew, however, how much Chu Zihang had looked after him on their mission in China.

"Caesar's girls are formidable opponents!" The vice principal frowned.

"How so?" Fingel asked.

"A hearing is like a soccer match. We're playing against the investigation team. It isn't just about footwork; the cheerleading lineups matter too. I think their side has more beautiful girls!" The vice principal looked troubled.

Fingel nodded. "But we have Xia Mi. She's worth ten of theirs!"

"Yes, she's the only girl who gives me comfort... I'm really looking forward to watching her swimming test." The vice principal nodded slightly.

King Solomon tapped his gavel. The hall fell silent.

"I declare this hearing open," King Solomon said solemnly. "The Board of Trustees' investigation team and the college administration disagree over the bloodline of A-rank student Chu Zihang. We must therefore hold this hearing to allow an open discussion. In the documents submitted beforehand, the investigation team strongly condemned the administration's negligence. The administration described that condemnation as..." He lowered his eyes to read. "'Nonsense like a frog looking up at the sky from a well!' I quote the vice principal verbatim. Unfortunately, I do not fully understand the sentence."

"A frog at the bottom of a well," the vice principal corrected. "A Chinese idiom. A frog, toad, or similar creature sits at the bottom of a well, looks up, and says, Ah, the sky is only that big? It's smaller than my well! By extension, it describes certain narrow-minded, conceited people holding forth about things they know nothing about."

"A wonderfully vivid rhetorical device," King Solomon observed. He adored rhetoric.

Andrew's fury could have blown the roof off Valhalla. Snickers rose from the Lionheart side of the audience.

"Now, let both parties present their evidence. You may argue, but the final judgment rests with us." King Solomon brought down the gavel again.

Like a boxer at the opening bell, Andrew sprang up. "The Board of Trustees has ample evidence to support its concerns about the administration! Over the past decade, laxity has spread throughout the campus. The committees have failed to supervise and guide students effectively. The academic workload is too light; the Freedom Day event is irresponsible; bloodline rankings are assigned arbitrarily. Worse still, the Executive Department has become an organization of violence!" He slammed a stack of papers onto the table.

"It hasn't become anything. The Board simply doesn't understand our history. The Executive Department has always been an organization of violence!" its head retorted from the audience, his voice hoarse and cold.

The Executive Department's elites applauded thunderously. Schneider was telling the truth. They were not ashamed of being violent; their only regret was that they were less violent than the Equipment Department.

"Order!" King Solomon tapped his gavel. "Presenting the documents matters more than quarreling!"

"Very well!" Andrew said loudly. "The first document the Board wishes to disclose is Chu Zihang's Executive Department file!" Another document hit the table.

"Being loud doesn't make you right," the vice principal said calmly. "Chu Zihang? A fine boy, excellent in both character and scholarship! Outstanding grades, named an all-around model student two years running—no, I mean awarded the Principal's Scholarship. And unusually kindhearted. All our students know he often helps old ladies across the street."

Laughter swept the audience.

"Really? Then explain the collapse of the Cape Town baseball stadium! Sovereign Flame, a high-risk Yanling, used in front of tens of thousands! Yet none of it was mentioned in the mission report. What are you hiding?" Andrew demanded.

"It was mentioned in the report." The vice principal snapped his fingers. "Read it!"

Fingel unfolded a document. "Note: a minor disturbance occurred during the operation, resulting in several minor injuries and fires. The Cape Town fire service promptly extinguished the flames, which did not spread. Chu Zihang received a demerit and forfeited one month's scholarship."

"See? Very strict! We supervise our students very strictly! It's all clearly stated!" the vice principal declared.

"A minor disturbance? Tens of thousands watched the Cape Town baseball stadium collapse! Hundreds suffered burns!" Andrew shouted. "Cape Town television broadcast this to millions. The footage has been submitted to the jury. How do you explain that?"

"Speaking of which... I happened to watch a Cape Town television special yesterday, precisely about that incident." The vice principal snapped his fingers again. "Play the video!"

A television program appeared on the large screen, the station's logo in the upper right. A reporter was interviewing an elderly Black man with an earnest expression, who showed the reporter a burn scar on his arm.

"What can you recall about the stadium incident, which has yet to receive a satisfactory explanation?" the reporter asked.

"I saw the man responsible!" The elderly man nodded firmly.

"Can you describe his appearance?"

"Red and blue clothes. A tight suit and a cape. He looked like a lunatic. Fire came out of his eyes, and the clothes burned right off any woman he looked at!" The elderly man's expression said he had seen it clearly, beyond any doubt.

The shot changed to a young man in hip-hop clothes. "Definitely an American. Square face."

"A tight suit, lots of muscles. Very handsome," said a shy girl.

"I saw him lift a Hummer and throw it. I don't know who he was fighting," said a security guard who had been there.

The camera returned to the reporter. "After months of investigating the stadium's collapse, we have unexpectedly discovered that eyewitness descriptions all point to a familiar figure..."

The image froze. A full-screen portrait of a certain famous alien appeared: blue tights, red underwear on the outside, a red cape, and that coquettish little curl on his forehead...

Andrew's eyes nearly popped from their sockets. "You mean... Superman did it?"

The vice principal shrugged. "I didn't say anything. Cape Town television did."

Andrew hammered both fists on the table. "Enough! I've put up with you long enough! Don't treat me like a fool! If you're going to deceive me, at least invent something believable!"

"We aren't deceiving you." The vice principal shook his head helplessly. "I'm merely showing you television. The world is so lovely, yet you're so irritable."

"What about Stockholm? Chu Zihang hanged a criminal from the city hall!"

"A serial killer—and a death servitor. Hanging him was perfectly normal. A fitting end." The vice principal looked unconcerned.

"But during the operation Chu Zihang was clearly on the verge of losing control! He showed dangerous homicidal tendencies, caused by his bloodline! That was erased from the report!" Andrew sneered. "How do you explain it?"

"Oh, about that. Let's look at some witnesses the police recently found," the vice principal said.

The screen changed. "Definitely Spider-Man. Look at the way the man was strung up. That's his handiwork. I recognize it," a freckled boy in a backward baseball cap said confidently.

"A figure climbed the city hall very quickly, using both hands and feet, straight up the wall. Whoosh, whoosh." The witness spoke fluent Mandarin; the subtitles identified him as a Chinese tourist.

"I know you also want to ask about Chicago's Hancock building." The vice principal pressed the remote.

"I saw him. He winked at me. Very handsome. Sexy." A drunken woman sprawled on a barstool with her legs apart, a pose both seductive and indecent. She narrowed her eyes as though flirting with the cameraman. "He drove away in an Audi TT. That's right, Iron Man. It was him. Everyone knows that face. I think he'd have stayed for a drink if he hadn't been in a hurry."

"Repulsor Rays in both hands, a Uni-Beam in his chest. He fired like this and blasted through three floors of walls at once! Believe me, he's the strongest, because Iron Man can keep upgrading himself! Those superheroes who depend on genes can't compare. He did it. I saw it myself." A café employee posed with both hands firing beams. "Afterward? Don't listen to that stupid woman. Of course he flew away! Do you know anything about Iron Man? He can fly! Why would he need an Audi?"

The vice principal turned gracefully, spread his hands, and smiled. "After watching these reports, my dear colleagues, our great scientists and wise theologians, can we believe Superman, Iron Man, or Spider-Man did these things?" He slammed the table. "Obviously not! Can the public media be admitted as evidence? They're a pack of paparazzi! They'll fabricate anything for a sensational story!" He looked deeply grieved. "Why distrust Executive Department reports while believing the media? As vice principal, I have diligently insisted for years that the Executive Department seek truth, conduct itself honorably, and work conscientiously. That is the spirit of our century-old school motto... Oh, sorry. We have no motto." He cleared his throat. "Friends! Keep your eyes open! We shall never let a villain escape, nor falsely accuse an innocent!"

The investigation team looked as though lightning had struck them. They had guessed these people's standards were low; they hadn't guessed they had none at all. Cassell College's most shameless paparazzi were smearing the entire world's media as paparazzi to discredit its evidence.

After a brief silence, Fingel led every Lionheart representative to their feet in applause. Schneider led the attending professors in another standing ovation. Only Caesar and the Student Council representatives remained seated. The jurors exchanged glances. Many of these elderly scientists and theologians had not left campus for years and knew little of developments outside. Some had read Superman or Spider-Man comics, and some were fans. But comic-book heroes obviously could not appear in reality. It followed, just as the vice principal had said, that the media had degenerated over recent decades and could no longer be trusted. The investigation team's evidence would therefore have difficulty passing muster.

The tenured professors all nodded.

The heavy conference-hall doors creaked open, admitting a shaft of sunlight into the gloom.

Sitting beside the door, Lu Mingfei turned and saw a crimson uniform skirt, dark-red hair tied with a white silk ribbon, high-heeled crimson suede boots, and silver four-leaf-clover earrings gleaming beside her face.

For a moment he was back more than a year earlier, when his small world had extended no farther than a city in southern China. This little red-haired witch had opened a door in exactly the same way. Light had poured in, and she had stood within it, beautiful brows and eyes full of disdain. An angel descending, sword in hand. She had brutally torn an opening in his world; otherwise he would never have been here at a meeting with reptilian hybrids.

He smiled dazedly.

"Move over. Make room." Nono kicked him.

A stir ran through the audience. The Student Council president's girlfriend had arrived late, wearing the Lionheart Society's crimson uniform—and sat down on the Lionheart side! Caesar seemed not to notice her arrival. He did not turn, continuing to listen intently through his noise-canceling headphones.

"What are you doing here?" Lu Mingfei murmured.

After that long, hot summer, he and Nono had lost contact like a kite with a broken string. She hadn't even sent him a birthday message, though she had promised not to forget. Then he learned Caesar had applied for permission to become engaged to her. Was the engagement why? The bride-to-be was busy preparing her dress and everything else; he scarcely saw her on campus anymore.

He didn't really want to see her either. He admitted he was envious, jealous, resentful, and a little angry with her. She had been inexplicably loyal to him, always offering a glimmer of hope, yet could vanish in an instant because she had never promised anything. Why give him hope at all? Hadn't the Little Match Girl died because she had too much hope? Light one match: wow, a turkey! Another: wow, a cake! Another: wow, Mom! None of those hopes could come true, so the girl died.

If the Little Match Girl had spent her time finding somewhere warm to hide instead of hoping, she might have survived that freezing winter night.

Hope that you must eventually lose was poison.

He had decided to avoid Nono until he could firmly establish "Caesar's fiancée" as her identity in his mind. Then he would see her and wish them a long, happy marriage.

But he had failed to avoid her. Seeing her, his heart trembled, and all he could manage was that disconnected question.

"What are you doing here... Didn't you already leave?"

"Why can't I come?" Nono raised an eyebrow.

"There are sides here. Caesar's over there," Lu Mingfei said quietly.

"I know." Nono pointed to the Student Council delegation, all dressed in black. "I prefer red."

Lu Mingfei froze. He knew she liked red—so much that she chose strawberry sauce on her ice cream because it matched her hair. But could hair color determine which side you took?

"Victory is ours!" The vice principal beamed. "Now our beauties surpass theirs in both quantity and quality!"

"But we can't be sure those old men judge the result by the cheerleaders," Fingel said.

"What the old men think hardly matters. They've lost their eye for beautiful women. The point is to undermine Andrew's morale! Wouldn't a creepy middle-aged man hate seeing a more magnificent cheerleading squad on the other side?" The vice principal twisted his hips, made faces at Andrew across the room, and performed Michael Jackson's signature crotch grab. Even Fingel thought the old man's provocation vulgar.

"Order! Ladies and gentlemen, please curtail unnecessary disputes. This hearing concerns whether the administration made a serious error in bloodline assessment and admitted a dangerous bloodline to campus," King Solomon said sternly. "This is among our greatest taboos. In ancient times, we established ironclad rules under the Abraham Bloodline Covenant to purge impure bloodlines from our midst. Those rules remain in force. On the day you enrolled, you signed your agreement to obey them. We are all therefore bound by them..."

Only now did Lu Mingfei understand the draconian agreement he had signed on enrollment.

"Each of you has a human side and a dragon side. In your veins flow many contradictions at once: white and black, good and evil, love and hate, peace and slaughter. We are neither wholly good nor wholly evil. We possess the power to kill, but must not desire to kill. Remember that we stand with humanity. Only those whose human goodness overcomes the evil of dragons are our companions. Anyone who cannot restrain that evil, who lets a hunger for power consume their soul, becomes our enemy." King Solomon closed the heavy code, the Abraham Bloodline Covenant. "At that moment our covenant ends, and our blades will turn upon the one who has fallen into the abyss."

Everyone placed a hand over the left side of their chest in respect for the sacred code.

"Bold of you, Ricardo. A Student Council member sitting on Chu Zihang's side? Aren't you afraid Caesar will beat you up?" Nono whispered.

"Who isn't afraid of getting beaten up by the boss? But you have to be loyal. Chu Zihang's been good to me." Lu Mingfei ducked his head. "And this could cost him his life."

"Nonsense! That can't be your reason. Your reason should be that you take the same side as your big sis!" Nono glared. "Remember, you're my little brother, not Caesar's!"

Lu Mingfei stared at her, searching her beautiful, imperious face for a hint of something. There was nothing. She was simply beautiful and imperious, her brows lively. Her faint fragrance reached him, and he suddenly realized he was sitting right beside her. God alone knew why she had felt so far away until then.

"Brother, wake up to the situation!" a little voice clamored in his head. "Nono's on your side. Caesar's on the other side. Right now she's closer to you than to Caesar!"

"Honorable investigators, the debate thus far suggests the media are not a reliable source. Questioning the bloodline of one of our own is a serious matter. We require stronger examples." King Solomon turned to Andrew.

"Then I request permission to question some of those involved." Andrew stood and approached the audience.

He stopped beside Lu Mingfei. "Lu Mingfei, you and Chu Zihang carried out a mission together in China. What is your opinion of him?"

Lu Mingfei froze. He had not expected this. Only when Nono dug her heel into his foot did he leap up as though his backside were spring-loaded.

"Very... very loyal," he stammered.

The utterly irrelevant answer deflated half of Andrew's aggression, just as his forceful arrival at Cassell College had been met with the vice principal's absurd banquet. He had thought a surprise attack on this student might work. But the boy was evidently worthy of his S-rank and had absorbed the college's boundless shamelessness. He could not be underestimated.

Andrew decided on a frontal assault and placed a document before Lu Mingfei. "This is the mission report you signed. According to it, everything went smoothly and ended perfectly. In fact, Chu Zihang departed entirely from the plan and acted alone, didn't he? You have no idea what he did without a third person present, do you?"

"Absolutely not! We're honest people! We stand by our word! Chu Zihang followed orders and observed discipline!" Lu Mingfei committed himself. He had little choice: Nono had stealthily pinched his calf. It was an open threat.

"Really? Are you qualified to say that?" Sneering, Andrew placed another document before him. "While dozens were injured and the entire twenty-first floor of the Runde Building was destroyed, you were dining with a girl at the luxurious Aspasia restaurant! You took no part in the operation, did you? Here is your dinner receipt—paid, remarkably, by our Gattuso family. I can't help admiring your influence, Mr. Lu. Then, having wiped your mouth after dinner, you wrote this utterly irresponsible report saying everything went smoothly?"

"What's wrong with eating with a classmate? She'd had a breakup and needed comfort..." Lu Mingfei stammered.

Sweat broke out on his forehead. He did not know how to handle this. Chu Zihang had indeed written the report for him; he had signed without reading it and been dragged into the mess. Worse, he didn't even know what had happened at the Runde Building that night. He had no way to defend Chu Zihang.

"Ladies and gentlemen, the vice principal said media evidence is unreliable. Should we now also question our own internal reports? These apparently straightforward documents are tools used to conceal the truth: Chu Zihang's lack of control, dangerous personal style, and extreme methods on every operation. Above all, they conceal the bloodline problem behind it..." Andrew's voice rose abruptly, commanding the hall.

"All right, all right, I admit it." Lu Mingfei's voice was louder still.

The hall fell silent. Everyone looked at Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingfei cleared his throat. "All right. I formally admit I tampered with the report. I altered the operational plan, and what happened differed from the report. The truth is, I had dinner plans with a classmate that evening, so I sent Chu Zihang to retrieve the documents alone. I revised the plan in a hurry, which led to the destruction of the Runde Building's twenty-first floor. But I was on the phone with Chu Zihang throughout and confirmed everything was under control. I admit I falsified the report, but that has nothing to do with Chu Zihang."

"Absurd! You have no field experience. How could you devise a new plan? You couldn't possibly control Chu Zihang!" Andrew raged.

"But I was the commissioner." Lu Mingfei scratched his temple. "A higher rank carries weight."

He rolled his eyes and stared at Andrew. Consider it repayment to Chu Zihang. Besides... Nono was still twisting his calf! They were on the same side now. He could be a coward another time, but not now.

He turned to Nono to see whether his words had landed. She looked at him too, baring her teeth in a silent grin. Such a wicked grin, yet it made him feel as though he were floating. Suddenly he understood why that idiot King You of Zhou had lit the warning beacons to toy with his lords. Damn it, if it made the girl you liked smile, even overthrowing the Board of Trustees wasn't beyond Lu Mingfei.

He was the sort of person who could go mad for some peculiar reason!

"You mean the discrepancies in the report were entirely your responsibility?" King Solomon asked.

"Absolutely! I led that operation. Naturally I'm responsible."

"Understand that your record is currently clean. If you maintain this position, you will receive a serious demerit."

"Will my rank go down?"

"That requires discussion, but it is possible. You are our only S-rank student. You could lose that distinction."

"Oh, it's only my rank? I thought you were stealing my eggs." Lu Mingfei settled firmly into his seat.

After several seconds of silence, thunderous applause erupted. The Lionheart students' excitement peaked. Most did not understand the Chinese joke, but the vice principal was doubled over the table, pounding it, so it must be some devastating satire. They collectively pretended to understand and applauded. Andrew was engulfed by the noise. He hadn't understood either, but apparently everyone else had and was mocking him through their applause. He had no idea how to respond. Fury and humiliation made him stare so hard his eyes felt ready to split.

(Author's note: This is a bawdy joke. A village woman takes a basket of eggs to market. Several thugs find her attractive and try to seize and rape her, but she fights bravely with a rolling pin and leaves them battered and bleeding. Astonished, they say they never expected such a fiercely chaste woman: someone like her must not be touched. Only then does she understand. "Oh, is that all? I thought you were stealing my eggs!")

Nono was pounding the table with laughter too. Lu Mingfei stole a sideways glance at her. Such an arrogant laugh, but he longed to see it. When she laughed, the distance between them seemed smaller.

He was happy. A joke had set the whole room roaring, but all he had wanted was to amuse this girl.

"I will tolerate no more insults." Andrew strode back to the investigators' table. "Next I shall present evidence that cannot possibly be dismissed!" He surveyed the room. "Chu Zihang's blood sample!"

The vice principal froze.

"Haven't they noticed his blood was replaced?" Fingel whispered.

"I know they lack intelligence, but this degree of stupidity actually worries me..." The vice principal leaned closer. "No samples got out, did they?"

"All destroyed. Not a drop left."

Carrying a medical freezer box, Parsi walked to the center of the hall and placed a piece of quartz glass on a small table. He opened the box. A transparent evacuated tube stood in dry ice; the blood inside was black as petroleum.

"Our next evidence is an experiment. It is somewhat dangerous, so please keep your distance. As everyone knows, dragon blood strongly attacks human blood. Sometimes it strengthens the human body, as in myths of heroes bathing in dragon blood and becoming invulnerable. Usually, however, dragon blood is deadly poison to humans. The blood of hybrids with high-risk bloodlines has similar properties: uncontrollable, burning blood of evil that reacts violently with human blood."

The head of Genetic Biology was the first department chair to nod. This was textbook knowledge, though few people obtained fresh dragon blood and human blood for experiments.

Parsi raised the evacuated tube. "I drew this sample directly from Chu Zihang, immediately sealed it, and kept it refrigerated. It has not been opened since. Is that correct, Chu Zihang?"

"Yes," Chu Zihang said.

"This other sample is pure human blood from a blood bank." Parsi raised another quartz tube. "Its provenance can be verified. We will now take one drop from each sample and bring them into contact."

Using a pipette, he placed a drop of each blood sample on the quartz glass. An arched groove in its center guided the drops slowly together. They met but did not mix, like oil and water, merely adhering slightly. Suddenly Parsi darted backward. Brilliant red burst from the glass like flung ink, a flower opening in midair, or a crimson fountain. The reaction was as violent as sodium dropped into water. Fine threads of liquid splashed out, leaving black marks across the tabletop.

Everyone rose in astonishment.

"Damn it! How?" The vice principal stared. That reaction was unique to Chu Zihang's blood. He and Anjou had performed the experiment themselves.

Central Control Room. Even during the hearing, an Executive Department team remained on duty here, monitoring information worldwide.

A young Executive Department member kept refreshing the Hunter Market website. The college always monitored it, and surveillance had intensified after the previous incident.

Everything looked normal today. The posted jobs seemed unremarkable: mostly illicit trafficking in antiquities, with some requests for exorcisms and ghost hunting, and an invitation to dive in search of Atlantis. Hunters needed strong nerves. Otherwise, spending their days among illegal, irrational, inexplicable things occurring quite calmly on this forum might make them doubt they were still on Earth.

A bold title rose to the top of the forum. It had been posted only minutes earlier, yet already had an astonishing seventy replies—a number reached only by exceptionally hot threads here.

The young man glanced at it and began to tremble. He lacked even the courage to open it. Instinctively he pressed F5. In barely a dozen seconds, the replies passed a hundred.

The website suddenly slowed. Clearly the information was racing through fiber-optic cables around the world. Countless users were opening the thread, overwhelming the server with simultaneous requests.

This terrifying post would be a nuclear explosion throughout the hybrid world.

Parsi returned silently to the table, leaving the experimental bench almost scorched by the blood. Words were no longer needed to establish the sample's danger. The experiment had been horrifying.

The vice principal's expression darkened. As an alchemy expert, he knew this experiment could not be faked. That was blood refined by blood amplification, exceptionally unstable. But how had the sample escaped?

The tenured professors gathered and whispered. The experiment had shaken them too. They had to consider the danger: perhaps the silent student Chu Zihang carried blood like aqua regia throughout his body and might turn into a death servitor at any moment.

The students exchanged glances. Inside the wooden railing, Chu Zihang remained expressionless.

"Who can guarantee it came from Chu Zihang?" Xia Mi suddenly stood. "No one saw you draw it, did they? Maybe you just added concentrated nitric acid. Why not draw blood here?"

"Because his blood has been replaced! The body needs a month to regenerate all its blood. Wash it out as you would treat a critically ill patient, and all evidence disappears!" Andrew said loudly.

"If all his blood was like that, wouldn't contact with normal blood during the transfusion cause an explosion? How could he be sitting here?" Nono stood too.

Moments later, the Lionheart students rallied, applauding thunderously. A combined attack by beautiful girls really was a trump card. If Chu Zihang's blood reacted violently with fresh blood, how could a transfusion be performed?

The vice principal bared his teeth slightly. He knew the answer. Anjou's ruthlessness bordered on madness: he had indeed drained every drop of Chu Zihang's blood before introducing new blood. His body, strengthened by blood amplification, had sustained him through half an hour of life-threatening total blood loss.

"We don't yet know how they replaced it. But wait! There is more evidence!" Andrew sprang up, slapping the table. "Witness testimony! Ask Chu Zihang's classmates whether he really is the obedient, disciplined student the administration describes—or a potential tyrannosaur!" He pointed to Caesar. "I ask the tenured professors to hear the testimony of Student Council president Caesar Gattuso, an outstanding A-rank student!"

Silence returned. Everyone knew Caesar would oppose Chu Zihang: they were sworn rivals, the kind who delighted in each other's misfortune. Besides, eliminating the Lionheart Society would leave the Student Council as the college's largest organization. Its leader might become the future leader of the Dragon Blood Secret Party.

Caesar removed his noise-canceling headphones, adjusted his collar, and slowly stood. He bowed slightly to the tenured professors, then nodded to both sides like a performer about to sing. "Ladies and

gentlemen, I, Caesar Gattuso, swear upon my family name that everything I say here is true. Chu Zihang is our college's finest student and a good classmate to us all. We are all deeply drawn to his personal charm. He is refined, gentle, learned, and helpful: the graceful embodiment of every virtue..."

As that beautiful baritone flowed, Andrew felt his world collapse. What was happening? Hadn't he sworn on his family name? How could he still tell such shameless lies? The graceful embodiment of every virtue? Was that Chu Zihang, or Shakyamuni after attaining Buddhahood?

"Caesar cares little for his surname, just as he cares little for the family," Parsi whispered into his ear.

Once everyone realized Caesar was neither being sarcastic nor preparing a reversal, applause threatened to lift the roof. Caesar began an emotional account of working on a paper with Chu Zihang: helping each other, draping his coat over a classmate asleep at a library desk late at night, sailing across the great lake together and discussing their ambitions to slay dragons... Did they need to sound so devoted? The students went wild. Caesar Gattuso had never shown such a sense of humor. Lionheart and Student Council members stood and exchanged seats, mingling black and crimson.

They were no longer opponents. Before the investigation team, they had become friends.

Lu Mingfei suddenly understood. This was the greatest mockery of the investigators. Everyone in the audience had reached an unspoken agreement long ago. The boundary between black and crimson was merely a trick. The whole college stood united against the Board. Only he hadn't known. For days he had sat drinking cheap red wine and staring into space. For days he had never left his room. For days everyone had left him behind.

Nono was no longer beside him. Laughing at Caesar's deadpan jokes, she jumped up and rushed to embrace him. Black and crimson clustered around them.

Lu Mingfei applauded with everyone else. What else could he do? He ought to be happy. Now everyone was on his side. Together they had given the investigators a thorough drubbing. Even the tenured professors would have to consider the entire student body's opinion, wouldn't they? His expressionless senior would escape disaster.

Only he was a fool. They had planned it all; only he had been left out. Just like the time, years ago, when he had played a lowercase i... But the person who had rescued him then was now embracing her boyfriend. She too had become one of "them."

The pressure of the crowd forced him backward, step by step, until he reached a corner and seemed flattened against the wall. No one noticed him. Everyone was celebrating. Only one gaze crossed the crowd and rested silently upon him, unnoticed by Lu Mingfei.

It was Chu Zihang. He had suddenly lifted his bowed head.

The conference-hall doors flew open. The young man from the Executive Department rushed inside.

"No interruptions during the hearing!" King Solomon said loudly.

"Hunter Market... a new bounty!" The young man panted. "A dragon called Fenrisulfr... awakened in Beijing, China... recruiting hunters to kill him... the reward is a hundred million... a hundred million dollars!"

Dead silence. King Solomon stared for a long time, then sank into his chair. This truly was a nuclear bomb—an information bomb. Someone had posted this on a public site like Hunter Market.

The secret of dragons, guarded by hybrids for thousands of years, was about to leak. Hybrids were far from the only people on that website.

Chu Zihang suddenly raised his hand, his voice carrying through the hall. "Professors, if the hearing cannot reach a conclusion, I wish to prove myself through action. Under these circumstances, we are bound to send commissioners to China. Lu Mingfei and I have carried out a mission there together before. I request permission to go with him again. My actions will prove my bloodline."

Act Fourteen

Crime and Punishment

Crime & Punishment

It had come alive. Hearts seemed to be beating inside the case—not one heart but seven. All seven blades awoke together, their different heartbeats mingling, some like great bells, others like urgent drums. This was an orchestra of violence, fit to accompany a story like the Tang tale of Liu Yi.

Late at night, on the top floor of the principal's office.

One desk lamp, seven bone-china cups. Seven figures surrounded the enormous desk, sitting in the darkness beyond the lamplight. Wind rolled fallen leaves across the roof, sounding like countless ninjas stealing overhead. No one had spoken for a long time. The atmosphere shifted mysteriously, like the white steam spilling from the tea.

Anjou raised his cup to the others. "A rare pleasure indeed, inviting three students to our evening tea at once. Welcome, all of you, and your hardworking advisers..."

"Goddammit! Why do I have to go on a mission with a lunatic? Have I given up on my life of repeating grades? I'm not going! Absolutely not!" Someone plainly had no intention of playing along with the principal's gracious manner. He squirmed in his chair and shouted.

Cassell College's one and only G-rank student, Fingel von Frings. The reason he could only squirm instead of getting up and fleeing was that someone had tied his hands behind the chair with a belt.

Beside him, the vice principal held up his pants and grinned viciously.

"I haven't even mentioned sending you to China to slay a dragon yet. Could you save your outburst for a little later?" Anjou scratched his head.

"Don't think I can't guess what you're up to! Evening tea, my ass! This is a pep rally, right? You're tying me and Chu Zihang to the same sinking ship, right? I've already done my job, Principal. You can't go back on your word! Next year I graduate in a blaze of glory, become an Executive Department agent, and fly around the world on missions with sexy younger girls from school! Speeding down Cuban highways smoking cigars, lying on Hawaiian beaches while someone rubs sunscreen on me, rowing down the Mekong with some Asian girl I just happened to meet... My good times are almost here! Come on, I've spent nine years slogging toward graduation! I don't want to die just before dawn!" Fingel was outraged and grief-stricken.

"You're describing James Bond's life, not an Executive Department agent's," Schneider, head of the department, rasped. "If anyone in my department lives that way, it can only mean I've failed to maintain discipline!"

"Can't you leave a little room for imagination?" Fingel sighed.

"As the one and only G-rank, you think graduating will be that easy? Even if the principal and I let you slide, do you think the Board of Trustees won't take its revenge? We're creating an opportunity for you. Imagine how impressive your internship report will look if you finish this mission. The trustees won't have a single excuse to stop you graduating! Otherwise, you may very well become the

first tenth-year student in history!" The vice principal clapped Fingel hard on the shoulder, applying both carrot and stick to this stubborn mule.

"Better chewing pork knuckles in my tenth year than getting killed by this maniac's indiscriminate Sovereign Flame!" Fingel glared at Chu Zihang beside him, though he had clearly lost some of his bluster.

Chu Zihang sat expressionlessly, drinking tea and eating chocolate cake.

"Violence is the only thing that works on this sort," the vice principal told Guderian beside him.

Guderian nodded repeatedly, keenly aware of how much he still had to learn from the vice principal as an educator.

Anjou coughed. "May I continue? Inviting our finest students to drink black tea, discuss the college's history, and look toward the future has been a tradition of ours for many years. The three students here tonight are the true elite of this institution. It is my great honor to inform you that you will be dispatched to China as trainee agents to investigate the recently exposed incident of a Dragon King's awakening."

"Your great honor can kiss my ass..." Fingel looked miserable.

"It won't be just the three of us, will it?" Lu Mingfei felt uneasy too.

He had always heard that the Executive Department was packed with formidable fighters. Even among the professors who looked too frail to truss a chicken, plenty were terrifying monsters with offensive Yanling. Yet somehow two dragon-slaying missions in a row had landed on him, an underclassman. At least last time Manstein had led the team. This time the college seemed intent on making a team out of three students.

"The college is sending many teams. Yours will have only three members," Anjou said. "Don't think you lack experience. You are A-rank and S-rank—even Fingel was once A-rank. Your bloodlines give you an advantage over most Executive Department agents. The more exalted the ancient dragon you face, the more important your bloodline becomes."

"The public disclosure of a Dragon King's awakening is the greatest crisis in the college's history. In fact, every elite agent the Executive Department can mobilize has been divided among teams and sent out," Schneider said. "We're also sending two student teams. The other consists of Caesar Gattuso, Chen Motong, and Xia Mi."

Oh, so I finally don't have to be the third wheel this time? Lu Mingfei thought. Maybe the college had kept them apart on purpose. Otherwise it would have been awkward for everyone.

The indignant Fingel froze. His eyes darted around, then he craned his neck and made faces at Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang. "You two really are tragic! Both your crushes are on Caesar's team! Maybe I should have a crush on Caesar. Then all three people we're secretly in love with would be on the same team, and our tragedy squad would reach peak tragedy!" He turned and shouted at Anjou again. "Principal, isn't this division of manpower a little uneven? They've got three A-ranks, two of them upperclassmen, every one of them able to handle things alone. We get one violent thug dragging two deadweights?"

"You mustn't look at it that way. Their team has a first-year, a third-year, and a fourth-year. Yours has a second-year, a third-year, and you, a ninth-year. Yours is the senior team," Anjou said mildly.

"Hey! You can't count it like that!" Fingel protested. "That makes me worth all three of them put together!"

Without a word, the vice principal tightened the belt around Fingel's wrists.

"Joking aside, sending Caesar was not my decision. It was the board's," Anjou said. "Chu Zihang's bloodline remains 'in question,' and the board insisted on an additional team. Caesar chose Chen Motong and Xia Mi himself."

"That's blatant girlfriend poaching, isn't it?" Fingel stared into Chu Zihang's eyes and said earnestly, "I'm not one to stir things up, but let me tell you straight, junior: if someone tried stealing my girl, I'd fight him to the death, no matter what!"

Chu Zihang did not answer. He gazed at the light as though his mind had been wandering the whole time.

"All right, all right. Look who I'm stuck with: a wimp and a guy with facial paralysis." Deciding that no one would respond however much he fussed, Fingel heaved a long sigh. "So do we at least get some kick-ass equipment? Like how Q always gives 007 some top-of-the-line stuff before a mission? An Aston Martin with an alchemical autocannon, a submarine that can drive down Chang'an Avenue—the more the better! Principal, unleash that evil Equipment Department of yours! Your good students are about to risk life and limb. If you've got any treasures stashed away, now's not the time to hold out on us!"

"Unfortunately, the Equipment Department is one of the most difficult departments to deal with. Like the Executive Department, it answers both to me and to the board. And because of the board's impeachment proceedings against me, I cannot intervene for the moment." Anjou shrugged. "So you will not have the Equipment Department's full support, as you did during Operation Bronze."

"Are you kidding? At least then we had the Moniach and a Shkval torpedo with an alchemical warhead. This time you're sending us in naked? Wow! Fingernails and teeth? Bite the Dragon King to death?" Fingel was dumbfounded. All evening he had been in a state of hysteria, falling apart again and again.

"Although my authority has been temporarily suspended, there are still some things I can call upon." Anjou nodded to the vice principal.

The vice principal hauled a heavy black case from beneath the desk and set it on top. It was an aluminum-alloy case 180 centimeters long, with a black outer covering and steel-reinforced corners. A metal plate at one corner bore the inscription S20100144. An item from the Ice Cellar—one of the highest grade, its designation beginning with S. The numbers meant it was the 144th item added to the Ice Cellar's collection in 2010.

Lu Mingfei immediately knew what it was. He could almost feel that dangerous thing's long, slow breathing through the aluminum alloy.

The principal and vice principal each took out a bronze-colored key, inserted them simultaneously into locks on opposite sides of the case, and turned them together. Gears whispered inside. Interlocking metal teeth slowly withdrew. A narrow gap sprang open, and black-gold light spilled along it. For a moment even the desk lamp seemed to dim.

The principal lifted the lid. "The alchemical blades: Seven Deadly Sins."

Apart from the principal, the vice principal, and Lu Mingfei, no one present had seen the set before. They all craned their necks at once.

"What's this thing?" Fingel reached out and tapped the exquisitely ornamented blade case.

The vice principal flipped up a concealed latch. With a clear, ringing note, the inner mechanism slid out, bringing with it seven blades of completely different designs. In the lamplight, their black-gold edges revealed patterns like threads of ice, pine needles, drifting clouds, and flames. The vice principal drew a blade: a two-handed, long-handled weapon a full meter and a half long, its edge gracefully curved, its thickness about that of a finger.

"The design resembles a Chinese horse-chopping saber of the Song dynasty. It was named for its ability, wielded with both hands at full force, to take off a horse's head."

With a shhk, he drove the enormous blade into the desk.

"Hey! That desk is an antique, hand-carved by nineteenth-century Venetian craftsmen!" Anjou shouted.

"Oh. Got carried away." The vice principal smiled apologetically. "Have someone replace the top for you."

He drew another blade, a curved sword almost 1.2 meters long, its body slender, its cutting tip shaped like the prow of a longship. "Similar to a Japanese tachi of the Heian period. This design evolved from the Chinese Tang sword. A small point, narrow toward the tip and broad toward the base. A fine, classical shape."

Another shhk. This sword, too, sank half a foot into the desktop.

"A yataghan, a type of Damascus blade, historically forged by Turkish swordsmiths. The authentic craft has now been lost. Its distinguishing feature is the reverse curve of its edge, while the tip straightens out, combining the advantages of saber and sword. Wielded with one hand."

Shhk.

"A Han sword design, a straight blade with an octagonal cross section, also called a Han eight-faceted sword. An elegant thrusting weapon."

Shhk.

...

Anjou covered his eyes and listened to seven successive sounds of metal piercing wood. Each meant another drop in the value of his precious antique.

The desk now bristled with blades. Within minutes, this scholarly private library had become a forbidding museum of edged weapons, gathering the killing instruments of many ages under one roof. Circling the desk, the vice principal flicked the horse-chopping saber with a bent finger. Its humming filled the room. The other six weapons resonated in response, forming a perfect scale.

"Ye Sheng and Aki Sakatoku first found this set in the City of Bronze. Lu Mingfei and Chen Motong found it a second time on Ye Sheng's remains. It was lost again, then turned up at an invitation-only auction, where the college paid a great deal to buy it back. Each blade bears a different Draconic inscription. We cannot decipher the Draconic, but fortunately there is also ancient Hebrew, very likely the names of the seven weapons: Pride, Envy, Wrath, Sloth, Greed, Gluttony, and Lust."

"The Seven Deadly Sins of Christianity," Guderian said. "In Latin, superbia, invidia, ira, accidia, avaritia, gula, and luxuria. Together they form a medieval Latin word: saligia."

"All the blades are forged from regenerated metal. The material looks identical, yet each has a different rigidity and toughness. This is alchemy at its highest level: creating new metals according to one's will. Every master alchemist can only look up to such skill. It belongs solely to the supreme master of alchemy among the Four Monarchs, the King of Bronze and Fire," Anjou said.

"The Four Monarchs command different powers. The King of Earth and Mountain, for example, is believed to possess the greatest might. The King of Bronze and Fire, meanwhile, is called the Throne of Alchemy, because only he commands flames hot enough to reach alchemy's ultimate limits," the vice principal said. "The craftsmanship of these seven weapons is astonishing. You could say they possess every virtue of every edged weapon in history. Combined, those virtues produce unparalleled killing power. Using them to kill humans would be like shooting flies with antiaircraft guns. So why would a Dragon King go to such trouble to forge them?"

"To kill his own kind," Lu Mingfei said silently, looking at the row of cutting edges.

Lu Mingze had told him that, and he had never doubted it. The instant he saw these blades, he had dimly sensed the bloody destiny they carried. When Nono had taken them off Ye Sheng's bones without a moment's hesitation, a faint voice in Lu Mingfei's heart had said, No... no... no...

Something that must never be touched. A gate of slaughter that must never be opened. A demonic seal that must never be removed... He thought Ye Sheng had died in that bronze city precisely because he had taken these blades away.

"We believe they were forged to kill the other first-generation dragons," Anjou said softly. "Seven weapons, each corresponding to a weakness of one of the seven kings. Pride, Envy, Wrath, Sloth, Greed, Gluttony, Lust. With his supreme achievement in alchemy, Norton would pass judgment on his seven brothers. The ancient Hebrew on the outside of the case translates as: 'All royal blood shall end by the sword!'"

"Come on. None of the Dragon Kings sounds particularly horny. Was Lust specially forged for you, Principal?" Fingel said. "And why would he kill the other Dragon Kings? Shouldn't they team up and wipe us out first?"

"Dragons are a race that believes absolutely in power. Their familial affection is nothing beside their reverence for strength. If they believe a brother is too weak to deserve existence, they will start a war without hesitation, destroy him, and devour him. Both the rise and fall of the dragons stem from this savage tradition. Dragons are forever royalty. A king's destiny is to be killed by a new king. That is how they pass on their power," Anjou said.

"So when he forged these weapons, he had already begun counting down his younger brother's life?" Chu Zihang asked.

Anjou nodded.

"And yet he was enraged when we killed his brother?"

"That is how strange the dragons are. They savagely devour their own kind, yet feel an anguish carved into their bones when one of their kind dies. Legend says that after the Black King devoured the White King, he roared in agony and flew to the highest point of the heavens, then plunged into the deepest ocean, smashing through the hard ice of winter. He repeated this seven times," Anjou said.

"Sounds like a seriously messed-up artsy kid," Fingel muttered. "But can these things really kill a Dragon King? Especially this little one... Can it even pierce dragon scales?"

"Not yet. Because what you're seeing is not the true Seven Deadly Sins." The vice principal pulled the blades out one by one and fitted them back into the case.

He bit open his finger, holding it upright so everyone could see the drop of blood, then slowly smeared it across the case. The blood quickly filled its engraved inscriptions.

"Stand back a little. It's waking up." The vice principal motioned everyone away.

They were already backing away without being told. Everyone could feel the change. It had come alive. Hearts seemed to be beating inside the case—not one heart but seven. All seven blades awoke together, their different heartbeats mingling, some like great bells, others like urgent drums. This was an orchestra of violence, fit to accompany a story like the Tang tale of Liu Yi: amid song and graceful dancing in Dongting Lake, the red dragon named Qiantang swept three thousand li through the sky, killed six hundred thousand people, destroyed eight hundred mu of crops, and devoured the young dragon who had treated his wife so heartlessly. Then, back in the blink of an eye, he donned his lofty hat and broad sash once more and greeted his guests with a smile.

Dark red, vine-like patterns emerged on the surface of the case, like blood vessels. Its beating hearts were pumping frenzied blood through its entire body.

Cold sweat covered Lu Mingfei's forehead. He remembered the scene beneath the waters of the Three Gorges. This was exactly how the blades had been then. Holding them was like holding a dragon's body! This was their true form. They had to be awakened with blood.

"Now try drawing the blades again. Mingfei first," the vice principal said.

Lu Mingfei was deeply reluctant to go near the thing. No normal person would want to approach a vicious weapon poised between living and dead. Fortunately, though... this would not be his first time drawing these weapons. He was the one who had actually used them, but he could not say so. Obediently, he went to the desk, opened the hidden latch, drew a deep breath, and gripped the smallest blade, Lust, shaped like a Japanese wakizashi. Another force inside the case held the short sword in a death grip. Lu Mingfei's face reddened as he strained with every ounce of strength he possessed. Suddenly he lost his balance and tumbled to the floor, clutching the freed blade.

"First stage passed. Keep going. Try the others," the vice principal said. "Once awakened, this set develops an extremely powerful magnetic force holding the blades inside the case. The larger they are, the harder they are to draw."

"I really can't." Lu Mingfei shook his head. "That nearly killed me already."

"Try again." The vice principal's tone allowed no refusal. "The second blade. Gluttony!"

Lu Mingfei gripped the yataghan's hilt. This time the force inside the case was easily ten times what it had been for Lust. The blade slowly emerged, but after drawing it only an inch, Lu Mingfei ran out of strength and sat on the floor panting.

"Keep going. Greed," the vice principal said mildly.

"Hey, I couldn't even get the second-smallest one out!" Lu Mingfei's eyebrows drooped.

"Give it a try. Trying won't kill you. At worst you'll sprain an arm or something. No slacking! Slacking costs grade points!" the vice principal threatened viciously.

Greed barely cleared its sheath before being sucked back inside. Sloth lived up to its name and stayed thoroughly idle in the case, giving only a slight tremor amid Lu Mingfei's shouts of exertion. The Han eight-faceted sword called Pride, the tachi called Envy, and the mighty horse-chopping saber called Wrath remained completely motionless. By the end Lu Mingfei had even jumped onto the desk and planted his feet on the case to pull, perfectly illustrating the saying about an ant trying to shake a great tree.

"That's enough. Next, Fingel." The vice principal clapped his hands.

Freed from his bonds, Fingel smugly rolled up his sleeves and showed Lu Mingfei biceps like lumps of iron. He really did have a strong pair of arms. He managed to draw every blade up through Greed, brandishing the Scottish broadsword with a look of immense satisfaction. Beyond that, however, he ran into the same wall as Lu Mingfei.

"Last, Chu Zihang," the vice principal said. "Treat it as an exam. Give it everything you have."

"Yes." Chu Zihang went to the desk and breathed slowly. His arms were not as powerful as Fingel's, but his specialized physical training was in tai chi. The explosive power born of suppleness could be several times greater than brute force alone.

He drew Lust as casually as pulling chopsticks from a sleeve. For Gluttony he sank into a horse stance, focused on his lower abdomen, and succeeded on his first attempt. Fingel no longer looked so smug. He had spent quite a while grunting and straining earlier. Chu Zihang adjusted his grip on Greed's hilt and concentrated his mind. His long, steady breath seemed to flow all the way to his fingertips. He pulled!

Blood dripped onto the desk. Chu Zihang stood beside it, silently studying his palm. Both Lu Mingfei and Fingel were stunned. They had assumed he could draw at least as far as Wrath. Judging from his performance with the first two blades, he still had strength to spare. But the Scottish broadsword had not moved an inch inside its case. The dense metal scales on its hilt had opened and pierced his palm. Only when he took his hand away did the scales slowly close.

Greed had rejected him.

"Exam over. Dismissed!" The vice principal snapped his fingers. "Schneider, Guderian, Mingfei, Fingel—come with me. The principal needs a word with the student who failed."

The door closed. Chu Zihang was still looking at his palm. He was proud. A-rank. Some believed he had surpassed A-rank and was approaching S. Yet these weapons had rejected him. Mercilessly.

Anjou tossed him his pocket square. "It was a bloodline test."

Chu Zihang wrapped the cloth around his hand and nodded. "I understand."

"Fingel drew the third blade, but you were rejected. Why?"

"Because my bloodline isn't as pure as people think," Chu Zihang said softly. "My blood was cleansed. For a month, it won't return to its original purity."

Anjou nodded. "Yes. Most people at this college think you're beyond A-rank. They think your bloodline is purer than Caesar's, that you deserve the distinction of S-rank far more than Mingfei. But you know the truth. Your bloodline's purity doesn't even reach A-rank. A careful study of your parents makes that clear. Your father may have been a very rare sort of hybrid, but your mother is entirely human. Their child would be unlikely to be an even more exceptional hybrid. Mingfei's parents, on the other hand, are both hybrids. You have those golden eyes that never go out because you

mastered blood amplification. You forcibly raised your bloodline's purity. Being unable to control your golden eyes is a sign that your bloodline is nearing the point of going out of control. I don't know how far you are from your final degeneration, but if you restrain yourself, you can prolong your life."

Chu Zihang nodded.

"You know you probably don't have very long to live, don't you?" Anjou sighed.

"By the time I discovered the problem, it was too late," Chu Zihang said quietly. "You were right, Principal. Blood amplification is an abyss of a technique. From the first day I used it, I was already sliding down."

"So you never disclosed the technique to anyone."

"That's right."

Anjou tossed a file in front of Chu Zihang. "We know about the incident involving your father on July 3, 2007. It remains a mystery to this day. But if you want to find out what happened, first you have to stay alive."

"I understand." Chu Zihang gave a soundless smile. "Everyone wants to live."

"Do you know about the Nibelungen Project?"

Chu Zihang shook his head.

"You didn't obtain all the information on blood amplification."

Chu Zihang froze, then snapped his head up.

"There is indeed a way to increase the purity of a hybrid's dragon blood. It is an alchemical technique whose safeguards prevent the higher proportion of dragon blood from rewriting the hybrid's genes. But it is enormously costly and can be used on only one person. The Nibelungen Project screens unsafe bloodlines out of the college while also selecting a candidate whom it will help complete an 'evolution,'" Anjou said slowly. "I believe you understand how much such a gift would mean to you. It is the only way to safely cross the critical blood threshold and realize the full potential of dragon blood. It is also your only way to survive."

"Such a technique exists?" Chu Zihang's eyes widened.

"It does. And you are on the list of candidates." Anjou waved a hand. "Go. You need an achievement to compete with Caesar for that place. He has killed a Dragon King. You should make an equal contribution."

"Understood!" Chu Zihang hesitated, looking at Anjou as he sat quietly drinking tea beneath the lamp. "Thank you."

"No need." Anjou smiled and raised his cup.

"One last thing." Chu Zihang stopped at the door. "If Fingel really doesn't want to go, I don't think we should force him."

"Do you really think that man is deadweight? You're wrong. Fingel von Frings was once an A-rank student here. He took part in many missions and is the most experienced agent among the students. There is only one reason he stopped taking assignments: he was badly injured on a mission, badly enough to affect his mind. What you see now is not his true self... Granted, he was always rather outrageous... but not like this. Ten years ago, I saw him much as I see you now." Anjou drew from his

sleeve the folding knife he always carried and tossed it down from the upper level. Chu Zihang caught it.

"I'm lending it to you. It can wound first-generation dragons. When the yataghan handed down through my friend Meinhard's family broke, we forged this from a fragment of its tip. It's a precious memento." Anjou gave a convincing military salute. "Remember to return it when you're done."

"Yes, General." Chu Zihang imitated him and returned the salute.

The door closed, and someone emerged through a side door. The vice principal had come back. He drew up a chair and sat beside the desk. "Now we can finally prove that Lu Mingfei's bloodline fully deserves its S-rank."

"Yes. In fact, he could have drawn all the way through Sloth. Fingel and Chu Zihang failed because the blades rejected them. In Lu Mingfei's case..." Anjou did not know whether to laugh or cry. "He simply wasn't strong enough."

The vice principal sighed. "The blades had clearly accepted him. They were moving inside the case, yet that magnetic pull kept them from coming out. Even weapons inhabited by living spirits must find that depressing."

"At least he is the most suitable wielder of the Seven Deadly Sins we have found so far," Anjou said. "We just need to add a few physical-training classes to his schedule."

"But drawing only four isn't enough, is it? The last three are the real killing weapons." The vice principal frowned.

"Perhaps we should let Caesar try next time?" Anjou smiled.

"Why don't you try yourself?"

Anjou gently stroked the case. "I'm a little afraid. Afraid to learn my limits. Afraid to discover there are things I cannot do... I must believe I am a man capable of anything. The man who will lay the dragons to rest cannot be a man with limits!"

Meanwhile, the hall of Amber Hall blazed with light. Caesar had rented the campus villa as both the Student Council's headquarters and his own residence. After renovations, it looked more like a royal retreat. Black cases covered a table in the center of the dance floor. Their lids opened one after another, displaying all manner of equipment. No normal person could ever guess what any of it did merely by looking... Even with manuals, using it would be dangerous, because none of these things had been developed by normal people...

Cassell College's Equipment Department had made its grand entrance.

Researchers crowded around the table adjusting the equipment, while Caesar inspected it with his new teammate Xia Mi, like an emperor arriving at his summer palace with his favorite consort for a holiday.

When Caesar received Norma's notification about the China mission, these researchers with their black cases were already waiting outside Amber Hall.

"What's this?" Caesar noticed a researcher polishing an exquisite brass blowtorch.

The researcher gave him a contemptuous glance, turned the blowtorch sideways, and pressed a hidden button. A blazing jet of fire a full twenty meters long flashed out and vanished. Searing wind struck their faces. It was hard to imagine such a flame coming from a pipe only two centimeters across. The other researchers carried on with their work. Playing with fire in a crowd was hardly outrageous

for an Equipment Department known as the "Happy Camp for Lunatics." Anyone who lacked that kind of composure would never survive there.

"We call it dragon's breath. Right now it's loaded only with chemical fuel, but you can also fill it with nitroglycerin and mercury. Its flames can inflict fatal damage on third-generation dragons. If you encounter a first-generation dragon..." The researcher paused. "It can also serve as a flashlight."

"Impressive." Caesar smiled and nodded.

"A combat helmet with a metal faceplate. Besides providing strong protection, it can amplify your biting force when you chew."

"A lightly modified Vertu phone. Nothing particularly special, but you can throw it as a bomb."

"Your passport. Chemically treated. Customs will never notice anything unusual, but in an emergency, add a fuse the size of a cigarette butt and it can serve as a bomb too."

Caesar hesitated for a long time over this creation. "But if I burn my passport, how do I leave the country?"

"If you want to keep the passport, you can use the phone bomb instead. Or any of the other bombs." The researcher was very impatient with the question. "There are about forty-five in the complete kit. We'll give you a bomb inventory."

"The lighter's a bomb too, right?" Xia Mi had found a silver lighter, very much to Caesar's taste: a heavy S. T. Dupont with a ringing metal lid.

"Anyone could guess that a lighter might be turned into a bomb. If we did that, we wouldn't be the Equipment Department." The researcher gave a smug, chilly smile. "We only added an MP3 player! With a built-in speaker!"

Using a fingernail, the researcher turned a screw in the base and set the lighter on the table. The little silver thing began playing an aria from Puccini's Madama Butterfly. It was a fresh and oddly delicate sensation: a silver lighter vibrating faintly as it sang "One Fine Day" at the top of its voice, expressing all the tenderness of a Japanese woman waiting for her husband. The sound was bright, joyous, and superbly clear.

Pink hearts lit up in Xia Mi's eyes. She snatched up the lighter. "Can I keep this?"

Caesar shrugged. "Of course. Would you like that shoulder-fired sniper cannon too?"

"I'll pass." Xia Mi happily played with the lighter. A thin, sharp tongue of fire shot out, a full seventy centimeters long. No other lighter in the world burned so fiercely. It was practically a lightsaber!

Watching her rabbit-like figure and bouncing long hair, Caesar thought that this girl was either astonishingly oblivious or exactly the sort of lunatic who belonged in the Equipment Department.

He came up behind Xia Mi. Much taller than she was, he had to bend halfway down to speak by her ear, as if teasing a little girl. "Helping Chu Zihang once doesn't mean I'm his friend. A rival is always a rival. Doesn't it worry you, accepting gifts from the enemy?"

"I'm here as an undercover agent." Xia Mi put the lighter away, picked up a plate, and buried her face in cake, getting strawberry jam even on the corners of her mouth. "Don't you know I'm Chu Zihang's rumored girlfriend?"

"I know, I know." Caesar could only nod.

"Besides this equipment, there is one special item. The Board of Trustees specifically instructed us to place it in your hands." A man in a black uniform, quite unlike the other researchers, had come up behind Caesar. He too carried a black case, but had not put it on the table and opened it with the rest.

Caesar glanced at him, then smiled at Xia Mi. "Want to see something interesting?"

The study door closed, and the last black case was opened. Inside lay an exquisite crossbow with a single bolt. Its enormous, decidedly un-aerodynamic head was a prism of crystal glass.

"Ordinary crystal glass, not some magic gemstone. But hold it up to the light," the researcher in black suggested.

A dark red, blood-like thread extended through the synthetic quartz crystal, its surface shimmering with a crystalline gleam.

"A Philosopher's Stone?" Caesar frowned.

"Not an ordinary Philosopher's Stone. This one was refined from the remains of the Dragon King Constantine. One of only a few currently in existence," the researcher said.

"In alchemical terms, a Philosopher's Stone is pure spirit element. What difference does it make whether it comes from a Dragon King's bones or somewhere else? Gold from an Egyptian pharaoh and gold freshly dug from an Ethiopian mine are no different once you refine them into pure gold bars."

"There is a difference. This one is less pure," the researcher said.

"Less pure?" Caesar blinked.

"There are some peculiar impurities we cannot remove, no matter what we try. But those impurities are precisely what makes it so different from an ordinary Philosopher's Stone. For instance... it must not come into contact with oxygen. If it does, everything around it will burn with explosive speed. That's why we sealed it inside the crystal."

"Those impurities are..." Caesar looked straight into the researcher's eyes.

"Fire element. Pure fire element. Alchemists have never devoted themselves to purifying fire element, because spirit element is more useful. It is the elixir of immortality and the stone that turns things to gold. They didn't think fire element was particularly useful. It exists in every kind of flame, but cannot be captured and is constantly dispersing. This time, however, we captured fire element and sealed it with a Philosopher's Stone. Only a Dragon King's remains can produce a crystal like this. It is impure, but it holds a mixture of powers beyond human imagination." The researcher paused. "It is a concept."

"A concept?"

"Its concept is combustion. It releases something like a domain. As long as there is combustible matter within that domain, it will command that matter to burn as fast as possible. The result is an explosion. In theory, this combustion does not burn the substance itself, so it is not consumed. That makes the combustion endless! The principle is the same as a Yanling. Whoever releases a Yanling issues commands within its domain, and those commands can even alter the laws of physics. This substance approaches the fundamental nature of the world, or... the realm of God, if you like. Nothing we have, whether science or alchemy, can fully explain it. Perhaps the monarch of flame himself could have explained it. But he is dead."

"Sounds like the spark that could destroy the world." Caesar gently returned the bolt to its case.

"Don't worry. This is specially made quartz glass. It absolutely won't shatter if you drop it." The researcher smiled. "This is the family's greatest contribution to your mission. This kind of power can kill a first-generation dragon."

Caesar raised an eyebrow. "Sounds like Prometheus, the thief of fire. Steal a thread of the King of Bronze and Fire's power to kill the King of Earth and Mountain. Are you one of the family's people?"

The researcher gave a cold smile. "Gattuso may be the most influential name on the Board of Trustees, but thinking you can claim the Equipment Department's deputy director as one of your people is probably taking your self-confidence a little too far."

"The Equipment Department's deputy director? You?" Caesar's pupils contracted sharply. He turned to stare at the thin, pale man. The Equipment Department had always stayed hidden underground; no one seemed to know who ran it. Whenever the college needed equipment support, these tech geeks in white lab coats and thick glasses emerged from their underground laboratories with cases, handed over the goods, and hastily offered a few words of explanation. Sometimes they did not even provide a manual, let alone training. Yet this time the department, usually too lazy to deal with outsiders, had sent someone as senior as its deputy director to make a delivery.

The deputy director could not be bothered to answer. He snapped the case shut and pushed it toward Caesar. "In the pentagram representing the five elements, earth is at the lower left and fire at the lower right. Draw the pentagram and you will find that no line connects those two elements. There is therefore no circuit of transformation between them. In the terminology of Chinese alchemy, neither generates nor overcomes the other. If the powers of fire and earth collide, it will be a collision of pure force, like two bullets fired at each other along the same trajectory. The consequences could be unimaginable. Use it cautiously." He gave another cold smile. "But if you really face the King of Earth and Mountain, I suggest you not hesitate. He won't give you much time for hesitation."

The deputy director turned to leave, not even bothering to say goodbye.

"If you're not one of the family's people, why bring S-rank equipment like this here?" Caesar asked.

"As researchers, we don't care whether the board or the principal runs this college. Our job is to extract the strongest power from anything we can, seal it with the best technology available, and watch the resulting weapon perform on the grandest stage." The deputy director did not turn around. "Actually, I very much look forward to seeing you use that bolt in a crowded Chinese city center. Especially against an exalted Dragon King. A collision of pure forces. It ought to be beautiful, wouldn't you say?"

"A crazy dad means one crazy kid. A crazy mom means a whole litter," Xia Mi whispered to Caesar.

The deputy director heard her, but took no offense. He cackled like a crow spotting carrion and pushed the door open. He brushed past a girl standing outside with her hand raised to knock. He did not even look at her, as though she were nothing but air. Caesar's expression, however, changed slightly when he saw her.

"Could you let us talk alone?" he asked Xia Mi with a smile, his tone indulgent, as though coaxing a child. "If you want cake, help yourself from the refrigerator."

"Mm, how generous... No problem!" Xia Mi slipped past the girl. They exchanged a glance and polite little nods.

The girl sat on the sofa. She held a heavy envelope.

"You kept your word." Caesar studied her appraisingly. "Would you like a drink?"

"No need. I just have to give you this." The girl tossed the envelope to Caesar. "These are the materials I photocopied for Chu Zihang. They're all parchment manuscripts kept by the Lionheart Society. Some are badly damaged."

Caesar looked inside the envelope. Everything was handwritten in Old English, ancient Hebrew, or ancient Latin, accompanied by crude, puzzling illustrations like images on very old tarot cards: a hanging man, a burning tower, a pontiff with a skull-like face.

"Parchment manuscripts." Caesar stroked the pages admiringly. "Wonderful things. In the Middle Ages, one parchment manuscript could buy a manor. A famous private collector of the time owned seven and took great pride in them. Together those books were worth a fortune. Scribes wrote on precious parchment, and when they were finished, the bones of their fingers were cut off and used to decorate the cover, signifying that there would never be a second copy. Texts accorded such treatment usually concerned witchcraft, alchemy, and black magic, so they were also books of the dead and books of demons. They say the Library of Alexandria held thirty thousand parchment scrolls before the Christian era, only for an Arab army to burn them all. Who knows how much occult knowledge of the dragons turned to ash that day? It pains me to think of it." He looked straight at the girl. "What I want is in here?"

"Everything about blood amplification is in there. I can't understand it, but you should be able to. You consider yourself his equal. He worked it out from these damaged records."

Caesar nodded. "You really did keep your word. But Chu Zihang let you handle these because he trusted you. Does this count as betraying him?"

"That's none of your business. Our bargain was that you would support Chu Zihang at the hearing and I would give you these photocopies." The girl did not flinch from Caesar's cold gaze. "Our transaction is complete. If there's nothing else, I'll go. I still have a paper to finish." She rose and headed for the door.

"When he discovers he's no longer the only person in the world who understands blood amplification, will he hate you?" Caesar admired her slender figure from behind. "It's his treasure. You used it without asking him."

"He's just a messed-up kid who doesn't know how to manage his own life," the girl said impatiently.

"A messed-up kid?" Caesar stared. "The person I've always considered my rival is just a messed-up kid?"

The girl turned back, her dark eyes serious. "Yes. A messed-up kid. They aren't all the same. When they feel helpless, some bawl their eyes out. Others stiffen their necks, lower their heads, and stubbornly keep going their own way. He's the stubborn kind. But whichever kind they are, they all need someone to help them."

"Aren't you giving up a little too much for him?" Caesar leaned beside the window and looked out at the brightly lit work site in the ruins of the Foundation Well. The Equipment Department was working through the night, seemingly determined to send every cubic centimeter of soil to the lab for

analysis. "I'm sorry. If I'd known you were coming now, I would have had Xia Mi wait in another room."

"It's all right. My liking him... and his liking me are two unrelated things." The girl lowered her eyes.

"I'll bring him back safely from China. With me there, he won't even get to face the Dragon King. But whether he chooses Xia Mi or you afterward is none of my business. Some things... if I were you, I'd fight for them." Caesar raised his glass. "Good night, Susie."

"Take good care of Nono. She was very happy the night she received your proposal by text. But if you really mean to propose, you should bring a ring." Susie closed the door behind her.

Rome, Italy.

Frost tossed the report he had finished reading onto his desk and sighed. "I never really expected to remove Anjou as principal this time. But if we could have found a problem with Chu Zihang, we could at least have shaken Anjou's position. Yet Caesar... That child never seems to understand how much his family loves him."

"It was my failure." Parsi stood respectfully before the desk.

"It had nothing to do with you. You did everything you could, and you did well," Frost reassured him gently. "Who posted the dragon-slaying bounty on Hunter Market? Any leads?"

"No. The account belongs to a veteran hunter, but reliable intelligence says he encountered sharks while vacationing in Tahiti several months ago. The sharks tore him apart and ate him. Since no remains were recovered, the police still list him as missing. For the same reason, Hunter Market did not immediately deactivate his account."

"Such an unusual way to die. And then he rises like a ghost on Hunter Market to announce a dragon-slaying job to the entire world?" Frost smiled. "Our opponent is very bold."

"Yes," Parsi said. "It challenges the rule all hybrids follow: never reveal the dragons' secret to humanity. But sir, is the information credible?"

"If only it were a rumor." Frost was silent for a moment. "Unfortunately, it isn't."

"We've detected the awakening of the King of Earth and Mountain?" Parsi was startled.

"Yes. By monitoring the frequency of earthquakes." Frost took out a map and spread it on the desk. It was a map of China, covered in densely packed markings.

"The awakening of one of the Four Monarchs is actually easier to detect than that of an ordinary dragon. Their power is so immense that each awakening brings something resembling a natural disaster. Our failure to detect the King of Bronze and Fire was an exception. The bronze city had sunk into the Three Gorges Reservoir, and the immense volume of water absorbed the heat of his awakening. When the tenured professors deduced that the one awakening this time was the King of Earth and Mountain, we began collecting seismic data from around the world. The ground is constantly moving. Small earthquakes happen every day. But if the frequency and intensity rise sharply in a particular region, then something unusual must be happening in the crust. All these marks are records of seismic activity. After running the calculations, we finally focused on this city." Frost tapped the red five-pointed star in the middle of the map. "Beijing. A place the Chinese say is blessed with concentrated dragon energy. After passing through the Great Wall, China's last dynasty, the Qing, inherited that capital from its enemies. It stands beside the Yan Mountains, believed to be the bones of an ancient

dragon, extending east through Shanhai Pass. Beyond the pass lay the Manchus' homeland. The Manchus followed the dragon through the pass and finally saw dense dragon energy above Beijing. These ideas are dismissed as absurd geomancy. But history always becomes legend. Now every clue is converging on that city. Something connected to the dragons may indeed be hidden there. Perhaps even... a real ancient dragon."

"Have we begun operations in Beijing?" Parsi asked.

"We haven't had time. What finally convinced us something was there was an incident a few days ago. We lost contact with two agents in Beijing. The family has always cultivated trusted people within the Executive Department. These agents have satellite tracking devices implanted in their molars. Even if they died, those devices should keep working."

"The signals disappeared?"

"Not entirely. Roughly every two and a half minutes, both signals reappear. We don't know why. The cause remains unclear. But something has undoubtedly happened to them. Before we lost contact, they called to give a warning. The call was forcibly cut off. We haven't been able to reach them since."

Parsi thought for a moment. "If the signals appear every two and a half minutes in a repeating cycle, they may be on something moving in a loop. Though we can't be certain they're still alive."

"We'll leave that for Caesar to find out. We're sending Caesar's team, and Anjou is sending Chu Zihang's. This is direct competition over the choice of candidate for the Nibelungen Project. But the ultimate honor must belong to Caesar. Fenrisulfr, the King of Earth and Mountain, will be the second dragon to die by Caesar's hand. And we must obtain his remains!"

"Understood. But our intelligence is very limited this time. The situation is nowhere near as clear as it was for the Three Gorges operation. I'm afraid Caesar won't know where to begin," Parsi said.

"That is why we equipped him with a Philosopher's Stone refined from a Dragon King's bones." Frost smiled. "It is a weapon, and it is bait. It is the blood of a Dragon King. Every dragon will smell its powerful scent. They will come to Caesar. The King of Earth and Mountain will be no exception."

Parsi's expression changed. "But Caesar doesn't know..."

"There is no need to worry about him. Caesar is the one the family has awaited for centuries," Frost said softly. "He merely needs tempering. We will never let him die young. He is the one we have chosen to usher in a new age!"

The family had produced descendants with far purer bloodlines than Caesar's. The many high-risk Yanling they displayed were recorded, but they were not raised as heirs. Instead, their names were quietly removed from the family tree, and they were secretly sent overseas like freaks. Decades of waiting had brought only disappointment after disappointment, until the family elders received that silent infant from a nurse's bloodstained hands. The baby did not cry. From the moment he left the womb, his ice-blue eyes were open, observing the world.

"His name shall be Caesar, the name of a great ruler in Italy's history." The elders stroked the infant as though he were a priceless treasure. "He is the one we have waited a thousand years for."

Caesar Gattuso. A bloodline chosen from a thousand, from ten thousand, from a hundred thousand. Even with his pride, Caesar could scarcely imagine his own future. It was too vast, too magnificent, reaching far beyond the age in which he lived.

The pity was that he would not obey!

Disobedient children were the most infuriating. Sometimes, looking at that stubborn face, you really wanted to slap it. But what good would a slap do? Even if you split his cheek and sent threads of blood into his eyes, those ice-blue pupils would not so much as blink. They would regard you with contempt. That was true stubbornness: stubbornness unto death.

"They all have their rebellious phase." Frost sighed.

Midnight, Chicago International Airport. A Boeing 747-400 airliner waited for its transoceanic flight. Only red-eyes were flying at this hour. The apron was silent as a shuttle bus delivered the passengers beneath the wing.

"Is this some kind of mistake? Why make us take a shuttle to the middle of nowhere to board?" Fingel complained loudly. "Aren't we traveling on official business? Why economy? If we can't have first class, we should at least get business! We're going off to die for humanity!"

"Apparently the other flights were sold out, so this is an overnight charter. Even these tickets weren't easy to get. The last three seats in economy," Chu Zihang said mildly.

"And they didn't give priority to Caesar's team?" Fingel sounded a little pleased. "Looks like they really value us this time!"

"I heard Caesar requisitioned one of his family's Gulfstream business jets. They took off an hour ago."

"Huh? Shouldn't you be saying that through gritted teeth? You look like a rich kid too. Aren't you ashamed that you're a poor rich kid while Caesar's a rich rich kid? You don't even feel the slightest urge to fight him to the death!" Fingel delivered his verdict gravely. "Without that fighting spirit, I think our team is going to lose."

"My dad was just someone's driver." Expressionlessly, Chu Zihang handed over his boarding pass.

The flight attendant smiled like a flower, took the pass, tore it, and returned half to Chu Zihang. "Welcome. A new face."

Chu Zihang met her eyes through his sunglasses. After a few seconds of silence, he nodded. "I see. Hello."

The Boeing 747-400's enormous cabin was packed. It looked like a charter for a tour group. The passengers all seemed to know one another. Some chatted, some entertained children in neighboring seats, and others leafed through newspapers and magazines.

"These seats are tiny," Fingel muttered, stealing glances at a beautiful woman nearby with her hair in a high bun.

Lu Mingfei was a little surprised. He had never thought of Fingel as particularly burly. The man always wore a loose, oversized shirt and walked hunched over, giving the impression of someone rather sickly. But squeezed into an economy seat, he turned out to be a very substantial lump indeed, filling every inch of it.

"It's a direct flight. We'll take the Bering Strait route, along the Arctic Circle. About fourteen hours." Chu Zihang handed them two little packets, each containing an eye mask and earplugs. "Best to get some sleep. We start working as soon as we land."

"Oh, wow. Such motherly care!" Fingel was delighted.

Lu Mingfei took the packet absently and quickly put on the mask and earplugs. He had been listless for days, yet his head kept flashing with all sorts of muddled thoughts he should not be thinking. Sleep

would mean thinking less. The mask and earplugs seemed to seal him inside a private darkness. Dimly, he heard Fingel shout, "Hey, miss, when are you serving food? Do you have beer? Can I get two meals?"

Suddenly he remembered lying in darkness behind an eye mask like this at the end of summer, three months earlier. Rain had pattered against the plane's skin. He had felt the phone in his pocket, wondering whether, in another half hour, someone might send him a birthday message.

The engagement and all that had probably already happened quietly by then, hadn't it? He simply hadn't known. So he had thought there was still a little hope, and on the plane he had even had that pathetic little dream.

"Hell! This seat's going to snap my spine." Muttering, Fingel pulled off his eye mask and stood to roll his shoulders.

The plane had climbed above the clouds. Outside lay heavy darkness, and the cabin lights were dim. Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei slept side by side like corpses.

After a double helping of beer, the need to pee was inevitable. Fingel lurched upright and swayed toward the restroom, humming off-key rap. He stepped inside with a satisfied air, looked up, and opened his eyes so wide they nearly burst out of their sockets!

On the way to the restroom, his back had been to the passengers. Now he faced them. In the dim light he could clearly see faint golden pupils, like pairs of fireflies flying side by side. Even the sleeping brat had a pale golden glow seeping between his eyelids. An old man reading a newspaper noticed Fingel staring and lifted his head to give him a cold glance. In that instant the gold in his eyes blazed like blades!

"I must have a fever..." Fingel felt his forehead.

"Having trouble finding your seat, sir? Please go back and sit down. We're in a high-speed air current." The flight attendant's gentle voice sounded behind him.

"You have no idea what kind of passengers you're taking to China, do you, innocent little bunny?" Fingel muttered as he turned. He saw that the pretty flight attendant he had eyed several times had eyes... as richly golden as champagne beneath a gas lamp!

The attendant patted Fingel's cheek and squeezed his slack jaw, smiling. "Handsome, don't you know what kind of plane you're on? People without the bloodline can't board this flight."

This was a flying... dragon's nest!

Caesar woke in bed. Beyond the window lay utter darkness. This Gulfstream business jet happened to have three full-sized beds, enough for all three of them to rest. He checked his watch. Four hours until they reached China. They were over the Arctic Circle.

Caesar liked this jet very much. The firmness of the beds had been adjusted to his specifications. But he had not slept well. There had been an unease in his dreams, as if something were approaching.

He looked out the window for a long time. The blinking red light on the wing illuminated the clouds below, laying a wash of red across them like spilled blood.

He doubted he could get back to sleep. Opening the case he had brought aboard, he glanced at the crossbow and bolt. A thread of light flickered inside the synthetic crystal of the arrowhead. He took his laptop from the case, connected to the internet, and opened one of his frequently visited sites from his bookmarks: Hunter Market.

Very few people knew Caesar Gattuso's other identity: he was a hunter. He had been one before entering Cassell College, registering an account on Hunter Market at fifteen. Of course, he had no need to work for bounties. Even the most generous would barely cover his private jet's fuel and the tips he scattered so casually. He simply enjoyed a little adventure, and plenty of hunters were interesting people. His username was Governor of Gaul. The historical dictator Caesar had conquered Gaul.

The bounty on the Dragon King had been pinned to the top, with thousands of replies. Apparently many hybrids had accounts here. Formerly lurkers, they were all surfacing now. Some expressed surprise, some declared themselves unruffled by rumors, some speculated about how many people would rush to Beijing for the enormous reward, and some mingled with the crowd posting nonsense. It was as lively as a variety show. Apparently hybrids had at least inherited humanity's appetite for gossip. Caesar scrolled down, skipping the junk and reading the replies that had value. This was not like Cassell College's campus news site, where every account could be traced to a person. Some perfectly ordinary username might well conceal the leader of a family.

Caesar had no leads on the Dragon King either. He was pinning his hopes on this motley gathering of a website.

Suddenly he stopped. A post no one had replied to yet: "Information on the Dragon King for sale. US$200,000, payment up front."

There were plenty of posts like this. Someone on Hunter Market was always trying to sell information, and almost all of it was false. They were like the advertising spam that regularly appeared on ordinary websites. Regulars naturally ignored them, their eyes passing over without so much as a flicker of brain activity. Yet for some reason, when Caesar saw this reply, his temple gave a faint throb. Something was off about it as an advertisement. He could not say what.

He reread it several times, weighing every word, but still could not find the strange point that troubled him. Deciding he was probably being a little oversensitive, he prepared to scroll on.

Then he saw the poster's username: phoenix. The phoenix.

At last he understood what was wrong. He had never seen this username on the hunter site, yet a common name like phoenix should have been registered long ago. This was an old account that had been lurking for years. Had it surfaced merely to sell false information?

Caesar opened phoenix's profile. Most profiles on the hunter site were blank, but phoenix had retained certain details. Its registration date, for example. It had registered twenty-three years earlier, when the global internet was still in its infancy and Hunter Market was probably some sort of test version. The account already existed then. It was the seventh account ever registered on the site.

Caesar considered for a moment, then sent phoenix a private message.

His attention was entirely on the screen, and he had not activated Kamaitachi. So he did not notice the dense, sea-like clouds beneath the fuselage beginning to boil. A black shadow rose, parting the vapor, and silently followed the Gulfstream. Farther below, on an enormous Arctic ice floe, the ice cracked and similar shadows emerged. The heavy blows of their takeoff shattered the floe. Groups of dark shapes followed beneath the business jet like fighter planes in formation.

Like a swarm of bloodthirsty bats.

Act Fifteen

The Man Behind the Scenes

The Inside Man

"He's actually very lucky. Plenty of people help him. But there's something strange about it... It isn't happiness. None of that help ever makes him happy. It only keeps him precariously balanced on the edge of loneliness, as if he were the world's own child and no one dared let him truly despair. Whenever he's about to fall into the abyss of sorrow, someone always gives him a little comfort, like a handout, just enough to keep him going. I have a strange feeling... that on the day he truly despairs, he'll become..." Mai Sakatoku said softly, "something like a devil!"

Early morning, Beijing International Airport. The first flight of the day from North America to China had arrived, carrying an entire tour group. Customs hurriedly opened another entry lane, but a long line formed anyway. There was nothing these smartly dressed Americans could do but wait their turn. They all seemed well bred, except for a few noisy characters among them.

"Hey, Mingfei! Great to see you!" Someone from the tour group enthusiastically came forward to shake hands with Lu Mingfei, who had dark circles under both eyes.

"Townsend?" Lu Mingfei's eyes widened. The fellow had slept all night, completely unaware of what sort of company he was keeping.

"Wow, junior! You really do know everyone!" Fingel said.

"Are you here to slay a dragon too?" Townsend shook Fingel's hand as well.

"What do you mean... 'too'?" Fingel suddenly realized that this was far more than a matter of a few hundred hybrids taking a group flight to China.

"That's right." Townsend smiled and lowered his voice. "This is a special charter flight. We checked every passenger's identity in advance. They're all hybrids, without exception. We're all going to China to slay a dragon."

"Isn't that a bit of an army?" Lu Mingfei and Fingel exclaimed together.

"We're all friends here. No need to hide it. Isn't that why you're here too? The news has spread like wildfire lately. I imagine every hybrid in the world knows a Dragon King may be waking in Beijing, unless they happen to be somewhere cut off from the news, like central Africa or the South American rain forest."

"Come on, man! Who do you think you are? What qualifies you to go dragon-slaying in China? Do you think it's like visiting the World Expo? Buy a ticket, stand in line, and you're in?" Fingel gaped at him. "In that adorable little outfit?"

Instead of the formal suit he had worn at the auction, Townsend was dressed in a long-sleeved shirt under an army-green vest bristling with pockets, loose jeans, sneakers, and a New York Yankees baseball cap. Best of all, the shirt had bold Chinese calligraphy splashed across its chest: NO TRUE HERO UNTIL YOU REACH THE GREAT WALL.

"Oh." Townsend gave a tolerant smile. "I'm not quite that unaware of my limitations. With my Yanling, never mind a Dragon King—even a second- or third-generation dragon would completely outclass me. I just thought it would be a shame not to witness such a momentous event... And you do have a point about the World Expo. It isn't over yet. My friends and I thought we could take a vacation in China and visit the Expo while we were here. Two birds with one stone, right? Look, some people have brought their whole families."

"Hey, hey... What kind of fantastically laid-back middle-aged mindset lets you treat this as 'I'll try my luck, and if it doesn't work out, it's a vacation'?"

"A hybrid born in 1977 is thirty-three this year. What's so strange about having a middle-aged mindset?"

At the same time, a Bombardier Global Express XRS touched down lightly at Capital Airport. It was a private aircraft arriving from Hong Kong, and unlike most private planes, it was painted solid black. Its door opened as soon as it stopped. Facing the wind and the rising sun, its distinguished passenger jumped straight out without waiting for the mobile stairs approaching the plane. Even on a midsize business jet, the door was more than two meters above the ground. What shocked the ground crew even more was that the passenger was wearing three-inch heels and carrying a large LV travel bag...

Mai Sakatoku lifted her face in the dawn light and pulled out her hair clip. Black hair spilled down like a waterfall. She stretched luxuriously, shaking off the fatigue of the journey. Every man watching instinctively touched his nose to see whether it was bleeding. Even seen only in silhouette against the dawn, every stretching curve of her body called to mind a flower opening into full bloom.

Chu Zihang was bent over his laptop. Lu Mingfei and Fingel were nodding off, their heads drooping. Only Townsend saw that unforgettable figure from behind. The girl in black leather ran past them and flashed through the deserted diplomatic lane like a streak of black light. He could not help whistling. Lu Mingfei raised his head in a daze. For an instant, he had caught a familiar scent: a delicate fragrance edged with the murderous chill of weapons.

A stretch Hummer waited outside the VIP exit. The driver, who doubled as a bodyguard and was dressed entirely in black, respectfully opened the door. Mai Sakatoku leaped into the cabin like a black swift taking flight. The door shut at once, and the Hummer sped away.

The rear cabin was a private space, completely partitioned off from the driver's seat, furnished in cherrywood and burgundy lambskin. Crystal glasses in the climate-controlled bar clinked as the vehicle swayed. A broad kangaroo-leather sofa faced a forty-two-inch LCD screen showing movements on the New York stock market. A girl curled on the enormous sofa wore black plastic-framed glasses; her long, chestnut-dyed hair hung over half her face. With one hand she rapidly scribbled on a sheet of paper, while the other held the car phone. Her voice was stern. "Raise the bid by 1.5 percent and buy all you can of the wind-energy companies we've selected! Your authorized limit is five hundred million dollars." She grabbed a potato chip and stuffed it into her mouth. "Don't question my decision! Five minutes ago a two-hundred-thousand-ton tanker struck a reef and sank in the Gulf of Mexico. The spill will bring fierce environmentalist criticism of the oil economy. Alternative-energy companies will have enormous upside over the next three months!"

"Hey, Chips Girl! Looks like Beijing's treating you pretty well!" Mai Sakatoku dropped her travel bag and reached out to pinch the other girl's cheek.

"Hey! Hands to yourself!" Chips Girl hurriedly covered her face.

Too late. As a ninja, when Mai Sakatoku reached for someone's cheek, it was like drawing a blade to slit an enemy's throat: her hands always moved faster than words. Before Chips Girl could raise her hands, Mai had finished her pinch to her satisfaction and settled comfortably back on the sofa, taking off her sunglasses and crossing her legs.

"Letting a girl touch you won't kill you. You really have been looking after yourself. Your cheeks are so soft and smooth." Mai looked her up and down. "Your clothes are still as frumpy as ever, though."

"I put on a face mask while I was waiting for you..." Chips Girl looked down at her loose white shirt, faded blue jeans, and flat thong sandals. "I may not be in your league when it comes to fashion, but this isn't frumpy, okay? It's just a little casual."

"Fuck! I've been hauling two swords all over the place in three-inch heels until my legs are ready to snap off, and you and the three-nothings girl have the nerve to live it up? Face masks? Casual? What kind of sweet little homebody buys five hundred million dollars' worth of wind-energy companies over the phone?" Mai rolled her eyes. "When you called, I didn't even put on makeup. I jumped into the car and raced to Kai Tak Airport. God knows how many red lights I ran or tickets I picked up. Meanwhile you're taking it easy."

"Okay, okay, I know 'babysitting' is hard work. Once this job's over, you can take a long vacation." Chips Girl hurried to soothe her. "Have you read the material I sent?"

"The bounty page on the Hunter Market? Yes. Whoever posted it knows how to play the game. They've played every hybrid in the world."

"This plane arrived almost at the same time as yours. Three charter flights like it are flying from America to China within a week." Chips Girl handed her a charter contract.

"Three Boeing 747-400s? North American hybrids certainly know how to spend." Mai tossed the document back. "So more than a thousand hybrids have already entered China. Do they think dragon-slaying is some high-difficulty raid you can beat by throwing enough people at it? With some of their bloodlines, the instant they enter the domain of a dragon's majesty, they'll die of heart failure!"

"No, not a thousand. More than three thousand. Even more are coming to Beijing from Europe."

Mai remembered something. "There were a few hundred people lined up inside when I left the airport. That must have been the group? If customs knew what kind of tour group they'd let into China, they'd probably be too horrified even to cry."

"Three of them are named Fingel von Frings, Chu Zihang, and Lu Mingfei," Chips Girl said.

Mai's expression grew grave. "Lu Mingfei's here? Then the boss has given us new orders?"

"I got an email from the boss three hours ago and called you right away," Chips Girl said quietly. "The order is that, out of those three thousand people, Lu Mingfei must be the one to kill the Dragon King with his own hands!"

Mai put a hand to her forehead. "Here we go again! Is the boss a flake or a genius? Sometimes I really can't tell! Is that loser worth spending so much time on? What kind of ridiculous luck does he have? All these people playing nanny to him—it's like getting a wild card straight into the World Cup final! Characters this broken make you want to go over and kick them a couple of times!"

"We can't do anything about the boss's logic. Those are the orders." Chips Girl's voice was utterly firm. "The Dragon King must die at Lu Mingfei's hands! Everyone else who sees the Dragon King will go to its grave with it!"

"Those really are charter flights to death." Mai shrugged. "Fine. Let them be buried with it. Poor bastards. They can blame their luck for running into a freak like the boss. The problem is that Lu Mingfei really is useless. Otherwise, at the Three Gorges, he could have drawn Wrath and killed Norton instead of needing me to finish the job with that shot. How do we make sure he kills the Dragon King 'with his own hands'?"

"We can still manage that. The six people from Cassell College have split into two teams, and Lu Mingfei's team has that set of alchemical blades. They're paradoxical weapons capable of slaughtering any Dragon King. All he needs is the will to draw them. There's another part of the order that's even harder." Chips Girl sighed. "The fact that Lu Mingfei killed the Dragon King has to be made public."

"Made public?" Mai froze. "What do you mean, made public? How can you make dragon-slaying public? Has the boss's brain short-circuited again?"

"'I want the whole world... to watch his grand performance as a hero!'" Chips Girl enunciated each word. "That's the last sentence in the boss's letter."

"Holy shit... Are we supposed to arrange a live broadcast on China Central Television?" Mai abruptly sat up straight, put both hands on her knees, and assumed a solemn, dignified expression. "Good evening, viewers. This is the Central People's Television evening news. Tonight's special report: 'Requiem for a Dragon King in New China.' We will now bring you live footage of Cassell College's S-rank loser, Lu Mingfei, battling the Dragon King. Over to our correspondent at the scene..."

"You really can turn it on at the drop of a hat. Could you stop clowning around, O People's Artist?" Chips Girl said helplessly.

"The whole world would go insane!" Mai was losing her mind.

"Anyway, you know the boss's style. His orders can't be disobeyed. However illogical they are, we have to let the whole world know that Lu Mingfei killed the Dragon King. The story has to appear in all the major media, even the national evening news." Chips Girl patted Mai's shoulder comfortingly. "Now you see why I summoned you to Beijing in such a hurry. If we had time, I'd gladly sit here and cry with you. First we have to think of a way to handle this. You have the best media connections of any of us. What could I expect the three-nothings girl to come up with? She'd just faithfully carry out the boss's orders, shoot Lu Mingfei killing the dragon with a handheld camcorder, and upload it to YouTube or Tudou..."

"I can believe she'd do that..." Mai covered her face.

"Basically, we need to get a headline like 'Lu Mingfei Successfully Kills Dragon King' into the public media, without causing chaos..."

"Successfully kills... successfully kills... kills..." Mai's eyes lit up. She repeated the words several times, tasting the feel of the headline, then clapped her hands. "I've got it!"

"Let me guess. Not some lousy trick like buying the entire New York Times, printing a few million copies without putting them on sale, then destroying them?" Chips Girl stressed the point. "That won't fool the boss. It has to be released to the public."

"Buying the entire New York Times would be a little expensive, wouldn't it? But I'll still need a budget of twelve million dollars... Actually, get me twenty million, just in case!" Mai bent down to fish her phone from her travel bag. "Two cashier's checks for ten million each."

"Hey! Could you be a little less carefree and generous with the money? Every cent you people spend is something this poor bookkeeper worked her fingers to the bone to earn!" Chips Girl wailed as she took out the checks and began writing zeros. At the same time, her face broke into a delighted smile. "Still, that's a lot cheaper than I expected!"

Fourteen hours later. Blizzard headquarters, Irvine, California, USA.

Heber Hegarty, the head of marketing, pushed open the conference-room door. His unannounced visitor was already seated across the table, with the sunlight at his back. He was a young, handsome Chinese man who looked no older than thirty-five, impeccably dressed in a gray suit and matching tie, thoroughly proper and polite. Beside him sat a female secretary in a black skirt suit. He looked like a lawyer.

"Allow me to introduce myself. I'm an attorney practicing in Los Angeles. Our firm handles legal work relating to corporate mergers, breakups, refinancing, and public listings." The Chinese man stood and offered a business card with a smile.

It was a celebrated law firm—or a notorious one. These wolfish attorneys pursued cash-strapped companies around the Bay Area, sinking their teeth into them and profiting by tearing them apart and selling the pieces on the market. Behind them stood massive institutions with enormous sums at their disposal.

"How do you do? May I ask the purpose of your visit...?" Heber smiled cautiously. Representatives of financial institutions like these were not people to offend lightly.

The lawyer took an envelope from his assistant, laid it on the table, and pushed it toward Heber. "This is a cashier's check for ten million dollars. One of our clients is very interested in your online game World of Warcraft..."

Heber stared. "I'm sorry, but World of Warcraft is our core source of profits. Ten million dollars would be nowhere near enough either to buy the game or to acquire a stake in Blizzard." Inwardly, he scoffed at the lawyer's ignorance. Did he think he could mount an attack on Blizzard armed with a ten-million-dollar check?

The lawyer smiled. "You may have misunderstood. We're not here about a merger or a breakup this time. We're representing a client who wishes to commission a new 'dungeon' for World of Warcraft, to be developed within seven days. Its story must follow a script supplied by our client. Development must be completed and the update installed on servers worldwide within seven days. Beyond that, we seek no rights to the dungeon."

Heber was stunned. The piece of paper worth ten million dollars seemed to burn his hands through the envelope. The offer was far too generous. Ten million was enough to develop a major online game, and all they wanted was a single dungeon. He could not tell whether this was a trap.

Seeing his hesitation, the lawyer smiled with a sigh. "Yes, it sounds absurd. But as a law firm, we can hardly refuse a major client's requests. I received a late-night call from a client in Asia. She said she was a devoted World of Warcraft player and very much wanted a custom-designed, high-difficulty

dungeon, along with the honor of the 'first kill.'" He shrugged. "I don't play games. I only learned on the drive over, after searching online, that a 'first kill' counts as an honor."

"Yes. When certain difficult dungeons are released, guilds on the server compete to see who can kill the boss first. Once they've achieved the first kill, they usually post a screenshot of the victory online to announce their accomplishment. The server also immediately sends the news to every player. Players all over the world pay attention."

"Sounds like the honor the guys competed for when I was at Yale... being the first to date the prettiest girl in the law school," the lawyer said. "Ten million dollars for an honor. I'd say that's quite a good deal for you."

Heber hesitated. "But sir, developing a new dungeon is simply not something that can be done in seven days..."

"Then I'll add another check for ten million." Plainly unwilling to waste words, the lawyer cut him off and held out his right hand. His assistant handed him another envelope without a change of expression.

"Twenty million dollars for an honor." The lawyer was as cold as a tyrant.

The silence lasted half a minute.

"All right. You win. But before we sign, I'd like to know what your script is." Heber nodded. Twenty million dollars could buy a luxury yacht to cross the Atlantic. Naturally, it could also buy seven days of overtime from Blizzard's entire staff.

"I've brought the fax. The client wrote the script personally." The lawyer cleared his throat. "Fenrisulfr is a giant dragon inhabiting the wilds of the East. Usually it does nothing but sleep. When it wakes, it flies to a castle and carries off the princess... There's a note here: 'Any castle will do, but please don't have it carry off a troll princess or anything. That would look too ridiculous.'"

"Is your client really a devoted World of Warcraft player?" Heber gaped. "That's completely incompatible with Warcraft lore! What alternate universe is this?"

"Please let me finish... After taking the princess, Fenrisulfr discovers that this beautiful girl belongs to a different species and cannot become its wife, so it eats her..."

Heber rubbed his face hard and took a deep breath, urging himself to keep listening for the sake of the twenty million dollars.

"The king is heartbroken and posts a proclamation seeking brave warriors to avenge his daughter. Many young men therefore set out on the quest... Here, Fenrisulfr has an extremely bad temper. Whenever anyone tries to disturb its sleep, it flies into a rage and destroys everything around it. That makes it very hard to kill. The heroes must obtain a sacred item called the Seven Deadly Sins. This is a weapon for punishing every form of evil, a set of seven pieces, each bearing a different inscription. Together they form an ancient incantation." The lawyer took off his glasses and slowly recited, "'All royal blood shall end by the sword!'"

Heber thought for a moment. "All right. The script is a little different in style, but it's doable. I must stress one thing, though. We can develop the dungeon for you, but we can't guarantee that your client will get the 'first kill.' Once the dungeon is released, the dragon's lair will be open to every player on the server."

"You only need to develop it according to the contract. Slaying the dragon is our business," the lawyer said mildly.

"All right. I'll have the contract prepared now." Heber stood, hesitating slightly. "But I have to be honest. Your client may have a gaming addiction. It's an illness... it needs treatment."

The lawyer sighed softly. "Actually, I don't know the client personally either. The person who contacted us is only a subordinate. I hear he's a shut-in gamer with a terrible temper. Once, because he was unhappy with the leveling system in Final Fantasy XIV, he dumped a huge quantity of Square stock... You have no idea how hard it is to cater to these rich people. Sometimes they're positively neurotic."

Thirty minutes later, the lawyer drove off in his Porsche sports car with his pretty assistant, having gotten exactly what he wanted. Lying across the backseat was a friendly gift from Heber: a full-size replica of the greatsword Frostmourne.

Beijing, China.

Old Luo quietly wiped his sweaty hands on his pants and stared at the tabletop. The open case on it held neat stacks of cash with the bank bands still intact. Going out late at night with so much cash was astonishing enough. More astonishing was that they had arranged to meet in a Chengdu Snacks restaurant. Most astonishing of all, of course, was the girl sitting across the table. She simply did not belong in a cheap little eatery like this. Her fitted black leather clothes flaunted every curve. Through the open neckline, a tiny bandeau top and slim, straight collarbones were visible. Her jet-black hair shone like a mirror, tied with a red cord into the high coiffure of a lady from an ancient painting. An expensive fragrance enveloped her.

A touch of crimson shaded the corners of her eyes. Clear black pupils gazed deep into Old Luo's. Her rose-red lips parted and closed as though murmuring the most intimate secrets between lovers... In fact, she was gnawing on a skewer of grilled kidney.

Everyone in the little restaurant was watching the girl eat kidney. When she ordered, she had set a case full of cash on the table, pulled out a bill, and handed it to the waiter. "Double the chili."

"I only have seven days. I need a max-level character with the best gear and skills, and the best team behind him. I mean he needs to be the leader of a major guild. Top-tier priests, warriors who can tank, druids who can double as healers—give him two sets of everything. His ID is 'Lu Mingfei Ricardo.'" Mai set down her bamboo skewer and began leisurely filing her nails. "Can you do it? Everyone says you're the best in the business." She mischievously narrowed one eye at Old Luo. "Hey, hero, stop staring at the money. It'll all be yours. Look up at me."

Old Luo led one of the top guilds on World of Warcraft's Chinese servers. In the virtual world, he was a blood elf paladin with the ID "White North," a conqueror who stormed cities and seized territory, a mighty lord who threw money around by the handful. Join his guild and he would buy you a horse and give you a dragon. Under his rule, the guild had become an empire. He was the kind of character who led a raid to slaughter the Lich King while posting long poems in guild chat. As the Lich King crashed to the ground, Old Luo would unhurriedly fill the channel with Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes.": "This was the mine of souls, obscure and remote. Silently they passed through the dark, like hidden veins of silver. Blood welled between the roots of stone and flowed toward the world of men; in the endless night, it lay heavy as rock. Beyond it, nothing red remained." Girls worshipped his style. They imagined a cold young man driving an eight-horse chariot down a long street, cracking a whip

that tore the clothes of girls who hid from him yet stole glances at him, leaving scarlet marks on their lovely skin as he threw back his head and laughed.

Everyone who knew Old Luo called him "boss," though he looked more like the owner of an internet café. His supposedly devil-may-care jacket had gone unwashed for two weeks; his hair was full of dandruff and stuck straight up like a bird's nest. But he was the sort of man who became an emperor the moment he sat before a screen and touched a keyboard. Whenever he entered an internet café, dropped twenty yuan on the counter, and murmured, "All night. A Nutri-Express and a pack of Zhongnanhai," the Warcraft players around him would raise their heads to look at this star-bright veteran. For the rest of the night they could admire his dashing form curled on a sofa with a strange little smile, his left hand playing the keyboard like Beethoven, his right hand holding a cigarette as he wielded the mouse like a master of wild cursive calligraphy.

"No problem! What race and class?" Old Luo's expression was resolute.

"Human. Male. Black hair. A sad little kid's face. Useless-looking. Definitely not too handsome." Mai handed him a black-and-white photograph. "Make him look like this. As for class... a rogue, I guess. He's always been a petty thief."

"Not much personality for a hero," Old Luo tutted.

Mai clapped her hands. The black-clad driver came in carrying a paper guillotine. Before anyone could react, she stood up with a skewer of grilled tendon between her teeth, picked up a stack of cash, and chopped it in half.

After a moment's silence, a happily drunk fellow clapped. "Attagirl!"

Amid whistles and cheers, Mai's long hair swayed as she cut another stack in two, and another, and another. Each downward stroke of the blade had a graceful rhythm. Half banknotes fluttered into the travel bag the driver had set down.

"A five-hundred-thousand-yuan advance." Mai zipped up the bag and pushed it toward Old Luo. "I'm giving you all the right halves. You won't be able to exchange them for whole bills at the bank. If you want the left halves, bring me the character. Work hard, sweetheart. You're adorable... But remember to wash your hair properly before you see me again! I can feel a fermented smell drifting over from your side!"

She blew a flirtatious glance at everyone present, took five thousand yuan from her wallet, and laid it on the table. "Tonight's drinks are on me. In seven days, go online and watch a man named Lu Mingfei kill a giant dragon."

To cheers, she swayed gracefully toward the stretch Hummer outside. Before getting in and leaving, she turned and waved, exactly like a movie star bidding the press farewell after her own awards gala. Yet no one thought it odd that this was happening outside a Chengdu Snacks restaurant. Everyone sensed that something big was about to happen, something thrilling to look forward to. They raised their beer bottles to see off this thoroughly amazing girl.

"Over the next seven days," Old Luo told his deputy guild leader on the phone, "we're going to build a gleaming, golden Lu Mingfei at number one on the rankings! Yes... he's going to kill that dragon!"

"Hey, Legs. Will this really work?" Chips Girl leaned against the window, looking out.

It was sunrise. Fiery clouds burned along the horizon, and the sun slowly floated up like a cooked egg yolk. Traffic was thickening on the ring road below. A new day had begun. In this top-floor conference room in the heart of the central business district, she and Mai had gone twenty-four hours without sleep. All other business had stopped. The New York stockbroker had not received a call from Chips Girl in a whole day. He was wondering whether his client had been kidnapped, and whether he ought to call the police.

"It should, provided every stage connects smoothly. Blizzard has canceled all employee vacations. For the next seven days, they'll work in two shifts, developing around the clock. The announcement of the new dungeon will go up on Blizzard's official website in a few hours. Launch is set for seven days from now." Mai glanced at her watch. "No, six days and four hours. It'll be the first time in Blizzard's history that a release hasn't been delayed. That Old Luo fellow is doing well too. 'Lu Mingfei Ricardo' has already reached level fifty-seven. Two teams are taking turns leveling him, with two more providing support. By noon today he'll be at max level. Over the next few days, he'll cover the entire map collecting skill points, reputation, and top-tier items. When the dungeon goes live, one of the top-ranked heroes will be standing at its entrance."

Three thirty-six-inch HD screens stood directly before Mai and to either side. Linked together, they provided a nearly 180-degree view. An endless swamp stretched across them, with crocodiles dimly visible here and there. A little rogue was riding through the mud on horseback, the words "Lu Mingfei Ricardo" floating over his head. In fact, he was far from alone. Zoom out a little and you would discover behind him... a surging cavalry corps. Max-level tanks and powerful healers thronged around him. Guild chat raced past: "Hurry, tell Old Bai to go farm that dagger for Brother Lu!" "Who's meeting Brother Lu in Stormwind? Fly over there. Our main force is almost there." "We need a hundred and twenty wool cloth. Get it for Brother Lu!" "Hey, boss. They asked for a max-level character. Should we max out Brother Lu's cooking too?"

"This looks so lively I'm tempted to make an account myself." Mai nudged the wireless mouse.

"What about the media?" Chips Girl asked.

"I held a press conference at the Kempinski last night and invited every media outlet in the industry. I handed out five hundred red envelopes with two hundred dollars in each. The instant we get the first kill, the reporters who took our envelopes will post the story on every major gaming website. The headline is settled: 'Lu Mingfei's Team Scores First Kill of Dragon King.' A few hours later, the city papers will race to reprint it. A few hours after that, it'll be on the television news. I even contacted a publisher who'll put out a nonfiction novel."

"All that's missing is a movie with the same title..." Chips Girl raised her eyebrows. "Mobilizing all those resources just to make one big boy happy? Tell me, Mai, do you think the boss really cares how Lu Mingfei feels?"

Mai thought for a moment and shook her head. "I don't think he cares how anyone feels."

"That's what I think too. You've spent time with Lu Mingfei. What kind of person is he, really?"

"It's hard to say. On the surface he seems like a coward. He has no confidence in himself and no expectations, so he doesn't try very hard at anything." Mai put her feet on the conference table and held a mug of hot chocolate, gazing absently at the ceiling. "But sometimes he turns into someone else... lonely and vicious, with so much refusal to give in hidden in his eyes. It's like... he's caught fire."

"Wildfires start burning deep in the heart, don't they?" Chips Girl said softly.

Mai took a sip of hot chocolate. "He's actually very lucky. Plenty of people help him. But there's something strange about it... It isn't happiness. None of that help ever makes him happy. It only keeps him precariously balanced on the edge of loneliness, as if he were the world's own child and no one dared let him truly despair. Whenever he's about to fall into the abyss of sorrow, someone always gives him a little comfort, like a handout, just enough to keep him going. I have a strange feeling... that on the day he truly despairs, he'll become..." Mai Sakatoku said softly, "something like a devil!"

The fluorescent tubes were shrouded in choking smoke. People cheered or cursed from time to time, while others, headsets on, poured out tender feelings to girls at the other end. A hundred-odd computers stood in rows. On every broken-down sofa sat a red-eyed fellow who had paid for the night, a cigarette in his left hand and a mouse in his right. Hard-driving rock leaked from cheap headphones. As usual, the girl at the cash register was fast asleep. All the noise and all the faces of joy and sorrow in the world seemed gathered here, in an underground internet café in Chaoyang District.

The man who was supposedly going to burn the world with the fire in his heart, Lu Mingfei, was directing his army of Dragoons onto the high ground. Zealots bearing psi blades formed ranks behind them. Golden Reavers crawled slowly forward, while High Templars cloaked in blue lightning hovered in the air.

The enemy's main base sat on the high ground: a typical Terran fortress. Its buildings were packed tightly into an orderly layout. Rows of Supply Depots stood at the front, followed by Bunkers full of Marines and, farther back, masses of tanks deployed in Siege Mode. Squadrons of Valkyries patrolled around the base. Missile Turret radar covered every area to keep Lu Mingfei's Dark Templars from slipping through in the confusion.

This was the final battle. The enemy had raised an iron wall before Lu Mingfei's army.

This was the fifteenth challenger to take him on tonight. The previous fourteen had all been beaten so badly they were crying for mercy. Some had hurled their keyboards down and cursed; others muttered to themselves as though they had attained enlightenment.

The StarCraft crowd in the café was stunned. Where had this brat come from, drinking Coke with his eyebrows drooping as he routed them all? Worst of all, sometimes he would switch the mouse to his left hand so he could scratch an itch. To the StarCraft experts, this was sheer humiliation. It was like Ximen Chuixue meeting Ye Gucheng to duel atop the Forbidden City, except Ximen Chuixue had brought a rake instead of a sword and still beaten Ye Gucheng to a pulp. There would be no way for Ye to save face short of cutting his own throat.

Was he here to challenge the whole establishment? They had no choice but to call Brother Dog. Brother Dog was the undisputed grandmaster here, so far above the rest of the world that he had no worthy opponent. In his own words, he was "so lonely at the top, all I can do is go home and put the kid to bed."

Brother Dog was astonished. It was the happiness of Dugu Qiubai, the Seeker of Defeat, suddenly discovering that he lived in the same age as Dongfang Bubai, the Invincible East. He hurriedly knelt on a washboard for a while to persuade his wife to watch their child that night, then rushed over in his slippers.

The moment he entered, he was knocked senseless by a club. Then came six more blows in rapid succession. Brother Dog lost seven straight games without the slightest ability to fight back.

Only then did he understand that he was not living in the same age as Dongfang Bubai at all... He was living in the age of the Transformers. Your black-iron greatsword might embody the supreme elegance of simplicity, but when it hit the enemy, all it produced was a few clangs before the other fellow flattened you with one foot.

For this game, Brother Dog had thrown everything into mounting an unprecedented defensive stand at his own base. Whatever trickery Lu Mingfei tried, he was confident he had two answers ready. A brute-force Carrier assault, an airborne drop in the confusion, a flood of Zealots—Brother Dog was prepared to make any of them bleed rivers! He felt his adrenaline surge to the limit. The hand gripping his mouse trembled slightly. He was a general on horseback with his blade held crosswise, aching to roar at the formidable enemy across from him: "Come on!"

But across from him was only a brat with drooping eyebrows and a listless expression. Lu Mingfei drank the last of his Coke, made a few casual inputs, and got up to go to the restroom.

Brother Dog was dumbfounded. What was this? Surrender? If he was surrendering, he could at least type "GG"!

"Nuclear launch detected." The cold warning sounded in his headphones.

Brother Dog froze. What was going on? Nuclear missiles were Terran weapons, but Lu Mingfei was playing Protoss! Of course, Protoss could use a Dark Archon to capture a Protoss worker and thereby reproduce a Terran army, but did anyone actually play that way? Hardly anyone even built top-tier units like Dark Archons, did they? And even after capturing a worker, wouldn't it take ages to reproduce the entire Terran building tree? What kind of lunatic played like this? Wasn't this a strategy that existed only in theory?

"Nuclear launch detected." Another warning. It was not a repeat. Another nuclear missile had been launched.

"Nuclear launch detected."

"Nuclear launch detected."

"Nuclear launch detected."

"Nuclear launch detected."

Six warnings in succession. Almost simultaneously, Lu Mingfei had launched six nuclear missiles! Brother Dog dragged his mouse around, frantically searching the screen for the red targeting dots. Too late. The six nukes slammed down one after another. His disciplined formations and ironclad defenses vanished. The base he had so painstakingly built was reduced to ruins. The few remaining buildings had red health bars and blazed with fire. Meanwhile, Lu Mingfei's great army... was simply drawn up outside, doing nothing, in the shape of an enormous V.

So Lu Mingfei had built an entire screenful of troops just to make a V!

When Lu Mingfei came back from the restroom, he saw "GG" on the screen. A few seconds later, Brother Dog quit.

"Master... how about one more? I'd like to learn." Brother Dog walked over and spoke sincerely. "Boss, two Nutri-Expresses."

The owner set the drinks in front of him. Brother Dog glared. "Just one for me. The other's for the master over there. Beating us up is thirsty work."

"Thanks, thanks. Sure, sure," Lu Mingfei said.

"Mind if we watch from behind you, man?" Someone edged over.

"Sure, sure," Lu Mingfei said.

And so another game began, this time as a lesson. A crowd gathered behind Lu Mingfei. A rather pretty girl in a little black dress sat beside him, her eyes wide with curiosity. At this moment, Lu Mingfei was the star of the place. Embarrassed, he shifted his butt to avoid brushing against her thigh. But inwardly, he was a little thrilled...

Was this what people called feeling that you mattered?

Some people felt they mattered beside champagne-soaked swimming pools, amid streams of luxury cars and clouds of beautiful women. That was Caesar. Some felt it on dragon-slaying battlefields where blood ran in rivers. That was Chu Zihang. Some felt it ringing a bell and showing off to the Board of Trustees. That was Anjou. Some found it in erguotou liquor and lingerie magazines. That was the vice principal... And he found it in internet cafés like this one, filthy and shabby, thick with smoke and dimly lit, with the occasional girl showing her legs. Everyone would glance back as if by accident... Yet only here did he feel that someone might care what he was.

"This is the story of a man who has yet to realize his destiny—" Sound leaked from the headphones of the guy beside him, who was watching anime. The hot-blooded hero on screen—it was the Taiwanese dub, with something of the grandiose delivery of Pili puppet theater—pointed at the sky and shouted.

"Let's head for the surface, Simon!"

"Kamina..."

"What do you mean, Kamina? Call me big bro!"

"But I... don't have any brothers..."

"That's not what I mean! I mean a brother of the soul, a soul brother! Don't mind what those ugly girls say. This thing suits you. Your drill is your soul!"

That was Gurren Lagann, wasn't it? The idiot big brother, bursting with fighting spirit, who would take on giant robots with a Japanese sword, was lecturing his useless little brother. Watching it before had made his blood boil with excitement. Hearing it now... what kind of lines were those? Your drill is your soul? So the mouse was Lu Mingfei's soul, and a red-wine bottle was Fingel's? Souls sure differed from person to person... It must be late outside now. Nono and Caesar... what were they doing?

His fingers danced over the keyboard. His army took shape once more. Zealots gathered into a torrent of steel, psi blades flickering. Dragoons danced. Carriers massed together. The screen's glow lit his blank face.

The executive suite was a wreck. Papers littered the floor, several laptops were running, and a map of Beijing was projected on the wall. Brightly colored fast-food wrappers lay everywhere too, with two half-eaten family buckets on the table.

Chu Zihang sat upright at the table, typing with a chocolate bar between his teeth. He had worked without stopping since checking into the hotel, subsisting on chocolate bars, cookies, and soda.

Fingel sprawled amid the papers covering the bed, a bottle of red wine in one hand and a fried chicken drumstick in the other, as contented as a toad lying belly-up in the sun.

"Lu Mingfei's been out all day. Do you know where he went?" Chu Zihang asked suddenly.

"Said he was going to an internet café. Gaming here would disturb your work. Junior, we're counting on you. The other team is all elite, and you're stuck dragging us two stepchildren around."

"I think you've misunderstood that expression. In Chinese, it means the child a divorced woman had with her former husband," Chu Zihang corrected him. "For example, I'm one."

Chu Zihang pressed Enter, loading the data into the mathematical model he had just finished. Countless ripples spread across the projected map on the wall in an instant, as though it were a still lake and he had just scattered a handful of fine sand onto it.

"What are you tinkering with?" Fingel could not make sense of it. "Didn't we come here to slay a dragon? Yet all three of us are shut-ins in our own way. Our useless junior's a gaming nerd, you're a science nerd, and I'm a... I'm a glutton. Shouldn't we be hauling equipment all over Beijing looking for a dragon?"

"If by equipment you mean DSLR cameras, Townsend and his friends are doing exactly that. They visited the Forbidden City yesterday. Today's destination is the Summer Palace," Chu Zihang said evenly. "The reason they've turned into a tour group through and through is that they've discovered dragon traces everywhere in this city. There are dragon veins in the landscape, auspicious dragons and phoenixes on imperial stone carvings, dragons' descendants crouched on every corner of the halls. Even the tortoises carrying stone steles are dragon offspring. There's nowhere to begin. China uses the dragon as its totem, so it ought to preserve the most information about dragons. But all that jumbled information hides the essential information we're looking for." He pointed his pencil at the patches of ripples on the map. "The jumbled information I have now is this year's ground-motion data for Beijing and the surrounding area."

"Ground-motion data?"

"The seismological bureau has installed a lot of small monitoring devices throughout the city. Beijing lies on the Yanshan seismic belt in North China. There are hundreds of small earthquakes every year, but their magnitude and intensity are so low that we can't even feel them. The instruments faithfully record every movement, though. It might be a shift in the earth's crust, or it might be something hiding inside it. This year, the frequency of ground movements in Beijing suddenly increased tenfold. I've built a simple mathematical model and fed the data into it. Using various calculations and filters, we may be able to locate the source: the King of Earth and Mountain."

Fingel listened blankly for a long while, then nodded. "That's amazing!"

"It's natural that you don't understand. My courses lean toward science, yours toward dragon genealogy," Chu Zihang said mildly. "In other words, I'm a science major and you're a humanities major."

"Fuck, nine years in college before I find out I'm a humanities major!" Fingel took a swig of wine. "So this bad-tempered Dragon King keeps firing off his powers from one spot? What if he's moving while he does it?"

"Why would a Dragon King move? Does he have a job to go to?"

"True. He should be hiding somewhere building up his strength, so he can knock us all flat once he's fully recovered." Fingel nodded. "So this data will put us ahead of Caesar's team?"

"Hard to say. Too many things cause ground vibrations in a city: heavy trucks, subway trains, construction machinery, even fireworks during festivals. Those all get recorded too. In other words, the

ground-motion data is mixed with hundreds of times as much irrelevant data. There's no telling how long it will take to filter it out, and our time is limited." Chu Zihang stared at the projection. "Senior, have you ever had a girlfriend?"

"Hey... what kind of conversational hairpin turn is that? Don't you need some connection between one thing and the next? You science guys really are a bunch of blockheads!" Fingel jumped.

"Sorry. It just occurred to me. If you'd rather not answer, that's fine."

"Why wouldn't I answer? It's my glorious military history! An immortal monument on the battlefield of love!" Fingel sat bolt upright. "I used to be an A-rank everyone adored! In my first few years at college, I was a hero like you, wandering among the flowers and conquering wherever I went! Girls who admired me lined up to give me chocolates on Valentine's Day. There were so many I had to melt them down into chocolate spread. Enough for a whole year's breakfast toast!"

"So you did have a girlfriend? And then you broke up?" Chu Zihang looked at him seriously.

"You've hit a sore spot!" Fingel clutched his chest.

"Sorry. I just wanted some advice... If you liked a girl and had never told her, and now she was about to marry someone, would you tell her?"

"You're worried about that loser's mental health?" Fingel understood. "I suppose I wouldn't tell her..."

"Then you'd make the same choice as Lu Mingfei." Thoughtfully, Chu Zihang opened a can of Coke.

"Why would I tell her?" Fingel glared. "I'd choose to take out the groom first!"

Chu Zihang considered this for a few seconds. "If he doesn't say anything, those hidden feelings are worth nothing. One day he'll die with them, and no one will even know. So why not tell her?"

Fingel flopped backward onto the bed again. "Feelings are funny things. Some people's are worth a fortune, and some people's are garbage. Our useless junior's, for instance, aren't worth a cent. He can't give Nono anything Caesar can. Love is a sacred word, but it isn't hard currency. You can't exchange it for food. Don't think your feelings are precious just because you like someone, my friend. The sooner he forgets that useless love of his, the better."

"But you just said you'd take out the groom."

"Everyone's different. Take a lunatic like you. If you fell for a girl, it would shake heaven and earth. If she was marrying someone else, even if the wedding car had already left, you'd blast the axle apart and steal her away," Fingel said. "But our useless junior's a wimp. Even if Caesar invited him to be best man, he wouldn't know how to refuse. He'd stand behind Nono in a crisp suit and watch her marry into the Gattuso family, then come back, down two bottles of red wine, and sleep like a dead pig. The fiercest he gets is charging into hordes of zombies with a shotgun in Resident Evil, drooling as he blasts them."

"Love has no value unless it drives you mad?"

"You could put it that way." Fingel shook his head and sighed. "A coward who can only burn in secret and never dares do anything—his love is cheap! No, not cheap. He's a complete fucking idiot!"

"A complete fucking idiot?" Chu Zihang weighed the phrase. "What sort of person qualifies as a complete fucking idiot? I know it's an insult, but it seems you can call anyone that. Does it have a specific meaning?" He was fastidious about language. Almost anything he said could be printed

unabridged in a middle-school textbook—a science textbook, at that. He stated facts in a wholly level tone, without the slightest inflection.

"Well..." Fingel scratched his tangled hair. "A Chinese guy asking a German to explain 'a complete fucking idiot' is already pretty fucking... Anyway, the phrase basically covers any irritating loser you look down on. In our junior's case, I guess it means... someone who knows something's impossible but insists on hanging on to hope. He's a coward all the time, then sometimes this thing gets his blood up and he acts like a lunatic, but when the moment comes for him to be brave, he chickens out again... Just a clueless little brat, stubborn as fuck and spineless too. Jesus! He's got every flaw in the book. Doesn't that make him a complete fucking idiot?"

Chu Zihang was silent for a long time, then nodded slightly. "I understand. He is a complete fucking idiot. So, senior, how did you break up with your girlfriend?"

"Fuck! Another hairpin turn! It's like asking a specialist about cosmetic surgery and having him suddenly ask whether you still have your appendix!" Fingel grumbled. "All right. It was because I was a complete fucking idiot back then too..."

"Everyone's a complete fucking idiot sometimes, aren't they?" Chu Zihang said quietly.

A knock sounded at the door, followed by a pinched voice. "Mole, Mole, this is Sweet Potato!"

Chu Zihang got up to open the door. Xia Mi poked her head inside, laden with bags, and gestured to Fingel. "Wow, what a mess! Is this the legendary boys' dorm room? The kind where you keep cockroaches as pets? May I come in? Could you ask your pets to move aside first? I'm afraid I'll step on the cute little creatures..."

She wore a long, Bohemian-style plaid skirt, straight-shaft deerskin boots, and a cropped burgundy sheepskin jacket, with a long purple scarf wound around her neck. No one could pin down her style. Every time they saw her, she looked striking in a different way. Presumably she had a whole walk-in closet full of clothes to compare and mix and match.

"Our junior's so pretty! Come let your senior see whether your waist has grown..." Fingel spread his arms wide.

Xia Mi smashed a piece of cheesecake into his face. "I brought you food so you wouldn't starve to death! Huh? Where's Lu Mingfei?"

"Your senior Lu has gone off to train in the outside world. He won't be back for a while. We'll meet again in the Sabaody Archipelago in two years. Just split his food between us. Is it Beijing street food?" Fingel's eyes shone.

"Yep, yep." Xia Mi sat down and rummaged through the bags. "I'm from Beijing, you know. I'm going home to see Mom and Dad today, so I went shopping and picked up some food for you while I was at it. There are two Chinese guys on your team, but somehow you look like the one who's best at taking care of himself, Fingel."

"You flatter me. Just the survival instinct to find food wherever I go. Born with it." Fingel looked pleased with himself.

"Daoxiangcun pastries, candied fruit, Eighteenth Street fried dough twists... those are from Tianjin... and Tianfuhao pork knuckle." Xia Mi took them out one by one. "Enough to feed you for a few days."

Fingel pressed a hand to his chest. "Ah! This overwhelming happiness! You really are our team's undercover agent, aren't you? I knew your heart was still on our side."

"Because you're the handsomest senior, Fingel." Xia Mi grinned, baring her teeth.

Fingel turned to Chu Zihang and thumped his chest. "See, junior? You still need your senior's looks to rescue you from the misery of eating junk food all day!"

Chu Zihang could not be bothered with these two clowns. After nodding a greeting to Xia Mi, he had kept his eyes on the map of Beijing, lost in thought.

"Beijing's ground-motion data?" Xia Mi came to stand beside him. Her major leaned toward science, and she understood at a glance.

Chu Zihang nodded. "But there's too much junk data. Too much interference. It's like wind rippling a lake: with waves everywhere, we can't find the bubbles from that one fish." He tapped the map. "That fish is hiding under the surface. On the day it fully wakes, it'll suddenly burst out of the water in dragon form. By then it'll be too late."

"He's still in human form at present. To wake completely, he should be in the process of transforming into a dragon's body," Xia Mi said.

"Yes. Otherwise he couldn't have caused the incidents at South Railway Station and Six Flags. He could hardly have flown to America in dragon form," Chu Zihang said. "But a dragon in human form has limited power. The Dragon King Norton already proved that."

Xia Mi studied the map. "Transforming completely into a dragon takes time. It's like going through incubation again. I told Mom and Dad how well you've looked after me, and they said they'd like to invite you home for a meal."

Chu Zihang froze. Before he could answer, Fingel's booming voice broke in. "Another science-major conversational hairpin turn? Hey, hey, is this the legendary 'meeting the parents'?" He covered his face. "This is shamefully adorable!"

"Adorable, my ass!" Xia Mi whipped around and snarled. "It's just an invitation to dinner!"

"Then why aren't I invited?" Fingel jumped up to demand.

Xia Mi froze.

"Obviously I'm not! You clearly never meant to invite me! Guilty conscience! You're blushing! Damn it! I knew you little girls thought of your senior as a middle-aged man! All that 'you're the handsomest' stuff was a lie!" Fingel was furious.

"I don't know you..." Xia Mi covered her face and turned away.

Chu Zihang coughed and hesitated for a few seconds. "As you can see, we're swamped here. I probably won't have time to visit. Please thank your parents for their kindness."

"It's only a meal. Surely you can spare a few hours. My brother really wanted to meet you when he heard about you." Xia Mi covered her ears. "On the phone he kept yelling, 'Sis, Sis, I want big brother to come play with me!' So noisy, so noisy, so noisy! I had no choice but to come invite you!" She leaned her face close to Chu Zihang's. "Do me the honor? Please? Please?" Her head bobbed and her eyes rolled about.

"I..." Chu Zihang was at a loss. "I'm not very good at playing with people..."

"Isn't he your older brother? Why does he call you big sister? And didn't you say before that he was your little brother?" Fingel was curious.

"It's 'big sister' as in the mature-woman type!" Xia Mi stuck out her tongue. "He's been a little slow to develop since birth, so mentally he's like a child. That's why he always thinks I'm his big sister."

"Come to think of it, helping minors is a time-honored virtue at Cassell College!" Fingel puffed out his chest. "It's my bounden duty! And yours too, Chu Zihang!"

Chu Zihang had no choice. "When?"

"Lunch, three days from now? How about we make dumplings?"

"All right." Chu Zihang nodded.

"Oh dear! But I already have plans for lunch that day," Fingel suddenly said. "Much as I'd love to go with you, the timing's unfortunate. You'll have to go to our junior's house for the meal yourself."

Chu Zihang stared. "What... plans?"

Fingel shook out his fluffy long hair to give it a touch of artistic individuality, straightened his clothes, and raised his chin. "A visit to Beijing's 798 Art District."

"You're screwing with me, aren't you?" Chu Zihang thought.

"Oh, you're going to 798? There are a few good galleries there. I'll draw you a map..." Xia Mi was already sitting on the bed, sketching a map for Fingel on a sheet of white paper. No one paid Chu Zihang any further attention, as though everything were settled, perfectly natural and reasonable. At noon three days from now, duty-bound Chu Zihang would represent Cassell College, that aristocratic institution with its fine tradition of moral virtues, at lunch in Xia Mi's home, and play with her older brother.

Chu Zihang suddenly understood why people kept typing "table flip" online. It was that feeling of wanting to smash a keyboard into these two people's faces! It had been a con from the beginning! Since when did Cassell College have a tradition of helping minors? When had that bunch of killing machines ever given a damn about minors?

"Hey, undercover junior, what's Caesar up to?" Fingel suddenly asked.

"Since yesterday, I think he's mostly been drinking tea, taking Finnish saunas, getting spa treatments, that sort of thing. Today I think he went browsing in Liulichang."